THE BEGINNING AFTER THE END
by TurtleMe
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322
ECHOES AND ACCUSATIONS

THE VISION of Ellie vanishing in a wave of destruction played over in my mind, again and again. My sister...dressed like an Alacryan soldier...caught up in an asuran attack on the elven homeland…where Nico and Tessia fought side by side, like old friends...

It didn't seem real when I thought about it like that. Each piece was more absurd than the next. *Maybe it was just a vision*, I told myself, though I knew it wasn't true. Whether it was some aspect of the relic's magic or my own intuition, I knew that what I'd seen was real, that it had just happened.

Ellie's alive.

She had to be. I couldn't accept a world where she wasn't.

"How are you feeling?" Caera asked, her brows knit with concern.

Letting out a deep breath—as if that would somehow ease the weight of what I had just witnessed in Dicathen—I nodded at the Alacryan noble. "I'll be fine."

"What happened? The stone in your hand was glowing, and then, suddenly, your eyes were glazed over and you froze like a statue." Caera was holding onto my arm, her upturned gaze searching for answers on my face.

Regis waited expectantly, almost awkwardly, and I could sense his desire for answers as well.

Answers I wasn't quite ready to give.

Although I had made up my mind that Ellie had to be okay—as if my own force of will could make it so, if I only believed in it hard

enough—I hadn't even begun to come to terms with what this meant for Dicathen, for the war...for the world.

It was all too much.

Prying Caera's warm fingers from my arm, I took a step forward dazedly toward the portal back to the second level of the Relictombs. The toe of my boot struck the relic, which rolled across the white tiles to the edge of the pool of water at the center of the room.

I resisted the urge to kick it into the bath and leave it there, instead scooping up the multifaceted stone and examining it. The clean, shiny surface was again opaque and dull. Not quite the same plain-stone texture it had been when I first won it, but it felt dead and lifeless in my hand.

Looking more closely, I noticed a faint crack along one side, but my mind was too heavy to ponder the relic's mysteries, and so I tucked it away in my dimensional storage rune.

Caera was standing anxiously between me and the shimmering gate, her body tense and gaze flickering back as she blocked my way. Her horns had disappeared again, hidden by the relic she was wearing, which was no longer being suppressed by the snowy wasteland of the last zone. "Grey, wait."

I was angry, anxious, tired, and scared, and a part of me just wanted to crawl in a hole and deny everything the relic had shown me. But there was work to be done. I needed to go back and meet with Alaric. I needed resources, a plan, and I needed to get back to the Relictombs.

Because of what I'd seen in the relic, I was now sure of one thing. The Vritras weren't the only clan of asuras that were a threat to Dicathen.

I could hear the dull echoes of my footfalls ring in my ears, drowning out Caera's words as I staggered through the portal.

I was greeted by a mass of Alacryan soldiers positioned around me in a crescent formation.

To my left, knights in blackened steel armor held their weapons forward, ready for battle, each individual figure thrumming with magic. On my right, knights wearing armor of glimmering white silver formed the other edge of the crescent, but, unlike their darker counterparts, their stance wasn't aggressive.

Directly ahead of me, filling in the center of the semi-circle, were several individuals garbed in robes of varying colors, tensed and quiet.

Caera stepped out from the portal beside me. "Damn it, Grey, why didn't you wait—"

The sharp ring of steel on stone cut her off as the knights in white silver stamped their spears against the ground and took a knee in unison.

'Quite the welcoming committee,' Regis mused. *'Think this is all for the demon lady here, or…'*

"Lady Caera!" A woman with bright orange hair tied atop her head in a loose bun rushed through the line of soldiers in white, practically sliding to a halt before my companion. "Are you hurt? Distressed? In pain?" she rambled, her wide eyes scanning every inch of Caera's body.

Despite her weariness, Caera mustered a smile. “I’m fine, Nessa, really.”

The orange-haired woman frowned as she slapped the Alacryan noble in the arm. “How could you sneak out on another ascent! And without your guardians! Do you know how much trouble I have been in with the highlord and lady? My goodness, and, as if that’s not enough, to think you got mixed up with—”

The woman named Nessa let out a frightened squeal, as if only now noticing my existence. She pulled Caera a few steps away and hid behind her.

“Y-you! You’re the murderer!” she stammered, pointing a shaky finger at me.

“Are you finished, *aide*?”

The resonant voice echoed through the terrace, and all eyes turned toward the source. I locked eyes with an elderly Alacryan who stepped forward from the rest of his robed peers.

That’s when I noticed the crown emblazoned on the chest of his dark robe. In fact, now that I was paying closer attention, I realized all the dark-armored soldiers had a golden crown etched into their breastplates, too.

Memories of the Granbehl siblings came flooding through my mind, their deaths replaying as clearly as the moment it had happened.

Damn it.

‘Looks like Caera was right,’ Regis mused. *‘Should have just killed the girl.’*

That’s not what Haedrig—not what Caera said, and it’s also not helpful, Regis.

Reaching a pale, boney hand into his robes, the golden-haired elder pulled out and unrolled a scroll before proceeding to read it. “Grey, blood unnamed. You are hereby charged with the murder of Kalon and Ezra of Blood Granbehl, and Riah of Blood Faline.”

Caera stepped forward, her arm raised in front of me. “Grey wasn’t the one that killed them.”

The elder looked up, his clenched fists betraying the forced respect in his voice. “We have a statement from a key eyewitness that says otherwise, Lady Denoir.”

“I, myself, am an eyewitness, just as Lady Ada of Blood Granbehl is,” she countered.

The golden-haired elder’s eyes narrowed. “Your testimony and involvement in this matter has been revoked, Lady Denoir. Please step aside.”

Anger seeped from Caera as she took a threatening step forward. “By whose right?”

“By Highlord Denoir, my lady,” the elder replied immediately. “At his request, with acknowledgement from Blood Faline and Blood Granbehl, the Ascenders Association has sanctioned this so that you will not be questioned and sent to trial as well.”

Caera continued to argue, but it was clear she was losing the battle.

My tired mind tried to examine the options available to me. It was pretty obvious I wasn’t likely to get a fair trial considering they were willing to forgo Caera as a witness, and I had no desire to undergo any kind of questioning from Alacryan officials that might lead them to realize I wasn’t who I claimed to be.

Despite the number of battle-ready mages surrounding us, I knew it wouldn't be too hard to escape now that we were back to the second floor of the Relictombs. But fighting my way out, becoming a wanted fugitive with my appearance revealed, would make any future ascents difficult, and would certainly draw attention. Maybe even enough attention to get a Scythe involved.

'You're not actually thinking of just going along with all of this bullshit, right?' Regis asked, his irritation growing. *'Just let me out, and I'll clear a path.'*

For now, playing along seems like the best option. A thought occurred to me. *Who knows, maybe we can even turn it to our benefit somehow. At the very least, we know that none of their mana-suppression artifacts will work on me, and we can escape later if we have to.*

A bright, silvery voice cut across my thoughts. "Caera, enough." The voice silenced all others in the vicinity, drawing my attention toward a lavishly-gowned woman with gleaming white hair. "We are leaving, dear. Leave this to the administrators."

"But Mother—"

"Now, Caera." The authority in the woman's voice was absolute, and Caera crumpled under the weight of it.

I couldn't recall seeing the Vritra-blooded Alacryan mage look so miserable before, even when I was on the verge of killing her myself when she first revealed her true identity.

She turned, her scarlet eyes meeting mine.

"It's all right," I said. "Just go. I'll be fine."

"Grey, I'm—"

“Caera!” the white-haired woman said again, her voicing ringing across the terrace like a bell.

Caera flinched and rushed to follow her adoptive mother, who led the white-armored knights away from the portal. She shot a furtive glance back at me, and I was struck by how much different she looked and acted in her blood’s presence.

‘Families are weird,’ Regis said. *‘I mean, look at all the crazy shit you’ve gotten me into.’*

I realized the golden-haired elder was speaking again. “…and so it is that the suspect, Grey, is to be taken to the Granbehl manor for questioning before a trial is held. This trial is currently set for”—he checked the scroll again—“three weeks from day.”

I scoffed. “Is it standard procedure that the accused is imprisoned by the accusers? Hardly seems fair and unbiased, does it?”

The speaker cleared his throat and scowled. “Blood Granbehl has every right to ensure that you stand trial for your crimes. Were you a member of a named blood or highblood, you might be released to your blood’s custody to await trial, but—”

I waved away his explanations, knowing it was nothing but words. The truth was that the powerful always played by different rules than everyone else. “Let’s just get this over with, shall we?”

I held the man’s gaze until he flinched and looked away. “Put this man in shackles and get him in the cart,” he said, a hint of bitterness and wariness in his tone.

Three knights stepped forward. One pulled my arms in front of me while another fitted my wrists with a pair of mana-suppression cuffs. The third kept his spear pressed against my back.

When that was done, I was led to a small, beast-pulled cart that had been left at the edge of the terrace and wordlessly deposited inside. It was small, with only enough room for me and one other Granbehl soldier who was already sitting inside.

The guard's features were hidden behind a full-face helmet. A shortsword rested across his lap, carefully set into the crook of his arm so that, if needed, a short thrust would pierce my core.

A moment later, the cart rocked as the goatlike beast pulling it surged forward at the command of our driver. I rested my head against the back of the cart and closed my eyes. My thoughts were jumbled, an indecipherable mush of memories, fears, and plans for what was to come.

I was deep enough in my own mind that I didn't notice the guard take off his helmet, and was surprised when a familiar voice interrupted my tired contemplation.

"Well, this is a hell of a scrape you've gotten yourself into, eh pretty boy?"

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IMPRISONED

MY EYES SNAPPED open and I twisted to look at the "guard." Sitting next to me was a red-faced old man, his graying hair matted and sticking out at odd angles. He let out a belch, filling the small carriage with the stench of his alcoholic breath.

"Alaric, how…" I trailed off, waving the fumes away from my face.

'The gentleman sure knows how to make an entrance,' Regis joked, chuckling inside my head.

Alaric gave me a half-cocked smirk. "You didn't think I was just going to let you get arrested without paying what you owe me now, did you?"

I shook my head in wonder. "You can't fool me, old man. You wouldn't risk squeezing into that armor just for a few pieces of treasure—"

"But you did get some accolades in there, right?" he asked, his bloodshot eyes widening. "Not to put too fine a point on it, but you're in deep shit, pretty boy—and a little gold would go a long way to turning the right ears. Or a lot of gold, if you've got it."

I rolled my eyes, but felt in my dimensional storage rune for one of the items Caera and I had taken from the Spear Beaks' hoard of treasures. It was a sheath for a shortsword, made of deep red leather and inset with gemstones, a couple of which were missing.

Barely looking at the "accolade," as the Alacryans called the treasures unearthed from the Relictombs, I tossed it into Alaric's lap. "Consider it a down payment, but you don't get the rest until I get out of this mess."

The old man ran his fingers appraisingly along the leather, pausing greedily at the gemstones. “Well then, this will do nicely.” Alaric shot me a covert look from the corner of his eye. “And you’ve got more like this?”

I held back an amused laugh, not wanting the driver to overhear. “Enough to keep you drunk until your dying day.”

Alaric’s eyes closed and he leaned back, a serene peacefulness falling across his face. “Just what I’ve always wanted to hear…”

At least he’s easy to please.

‘But what can this drunk really do to help us out here?’ Regis wondered.

“Now,” I said soberly, “what do you know about this trial? There has to be more to this than what they’re saying.”

Alaric’s face fell and he shot me a dirty look, like I’d just woken him from a pleasant dream. “The Granbehls are about tops for a named blood. They don’t swing as big a stick as the highbloods, but they’ve been pushing for highblood status for years—sponsoring ascenders, buying up property in the first two levels, currying favor with the Sovereigns, that kind of thing.

“This Kalon boy was the rising star of Blood Granbehl, from what I’ve heard. Good-looking, talented, good instincts both in and out of the Relictombs...you get the picture.”

I was nodding along with what Alaric was saying. “Likely to be the future head of the house?”

Alaric nodded in return as he stored the sheath in his dimension ring and rested his shortsword against the side of the carriage so he

could get more comfortable. “A shoo in, yes. His death is a hard blow for Blood Granbehl.”

“But ascenders die in the Relictombs all the time,” I said, half to myself. “I’ve seen it first hand in the convergence zone. Most of the mages who entered that place didn’t leave.”

“Aye, but an experienced ascender who doesn’t want to take on too much risk can make some good will and a name for himself by leading preliminary ascents for noble brats,” Alaric said sagely.

For a moment I was reminded why I had agreed to work with the old drunk in the first place. Despite his lack of grace, Alaric was very perceptive. Then he belched loudly, and I wondered, not for the first time, if it wasn’t all just blind luck and alcohol-inspired overconfidence.

“Damned armor’s too bloody tight,” he grumbled, tugging at the edges of the blackened steel chestplate.

“So they’re angry about losing their heir apparent, but how does pinning his murder on me help?” I asked, frowning across the carriage at Alaric.

“Not sure yet, to be honest, but this”—he tapped his dimension ring, indicating the jeweled sheath—“will help make tongues wag. You’re right, though. It doesn’t make sense on the face of it. Proving murder in the Relictombs…well, it’s damned tricky, especially with only one eyewitness.”

“Two,” I said, my frustration bleeding into my tone, “but they’re refusing to let Caera act as a witness on my behalf.”

“*Caera*, is it?” Alaric waggled his thick eyebrows up and down, an expression that reminded me of Regis for some reason. “Spent some

quality time with the highblood beauty in the Relictombs, aye? Shared a few romantic evenings slaughtering beasts, then cuddled by the fire, still crusty with blood from the day's fighting…" He trailed off under the weight of my withering glare. "All right, don't pop your cork, boy. All I'm saying is I know how it gets when you're facing death every day. No one would blame you—"

"Alaric," I said, my voice low and calm but humming with an obvious threat even he couldn't miss. "Get to the point."

"Let's think this through then, shall we?" he said quickly. "Highblood Denoir is more powerful than Blood Granbehl, but the latter's hungry and punching above their weight. What would the Denoirs gain by allowing their precious princess to be entangled in this whole trial fiasco?"

He paused, looking at me with unfocused eyes. "What was the question?" He scratched at his messy hair. "Oh, right. Nothing, that's what. They don't want it getting around that the adoptive daughter of the noble Highblood Denoir snuck off into the Relictombs with some bloodless rookie. It looks bad. All they have to do is let the Granbehls eat you alive and, for them at least, the whole situation goes away."

"But what do the—"

The carriage swerved and our driver exchanged shouted insults with someone. Alaric grinned.

"—Granbehls have to gain by putting me on trial?" I finished.

"We're going around in circles now," he said. "Perhaps they've hedged that there's more to you than you told the three Granbehl siblings. You're freaky powerful, enough to alter the difficulty of any

level you walk into. Depending on what young Ada's said, they may be hoping you're secretly some disguised highblood that they can recoup losses from by forcing the issue in front of a panel of judges."
That made sense. *It would be a chance to get* something *back from Kalon's death*, I mused.
'But they still have to prove it was murder, right?' Regis pointed out. *'Which they can't do, because, y'know, it wasn't.'*
I echoed this thought to Alaric.
"That's what's got me worried," he grumbled. "And why I'll be doing some digging. Blood Granbehl must have something up their silk sleeves if they're going to all this trouble."
We sat in silence for a minute, listening to the wooden wheels of the carriage crunch over the stone streets. "So," Alaric said, "how many zones did you make it through?"
"Three," I said, a little bitterly. *I should have just kept going.*
'And get yourself killed because you were distracted by the genocide of your girlfriend's entire race?' Regis asked. *'Cooling your heels in a jail cell is probably not a bad thing for you right now.'*
You were telling me to fight our way out not ten minutes ago, I thought incredulously.
'Hey, I'm nothing if not inconsistent,' he replied, letting out a barking laugh.
Alaric whistled in response to my answer. "You were in there for a few days longer than I'd expected, even after word got around about the Granbehls. Must have been weeks for you."

I only nodded. The Granbehls would be forcing me to recount every painful detail of the ascent soon enough, and I wasn't eager to go through it with Alaric too.

The carriage slowed to a halt, and I heard heavy iron gates rattle open outside. "Must be there," Alaric said as he lifted his helmet off his lap and set it carefully over his head.

"You never told me how you arranged this," I said, waving my hand at his black armor and the carriage around us."

I couldn't see his face, but I could tell he was grinning beneath the helmet. "Friends in low places, pup. Don't worry, old Alaric is going to get you out of this. I'm not letting you avoid paying me the rest of my forty percent…"

The carriage surged forward, but stopped again only a few seconds later. I steeled myself for whatever was to come, but a thought occurred to me as someone began unlocking the carriage door from the outside.

"Alaric, take the dimension ring," I said, holding my shackled hands up with my fingers splayed out. "It'll raise suspicion if they check it and see nothing stored in there."

He plucked it off my finger and slipped it into the bracer of his armor. "Good thinking."

A second later, the door on my side of the carriage opened and one of the black-armored knights grabbed my arm and pulled me roughly out into a broad courtyard fronting a large manor house. It was an imposing residence made mostly of dark stone with steeply pitched roofs, with sharply pointed arches over the windows and doors.

At least twenty of the Granbehl knights stood in the courtyard, flanking the carriage. A man and woman waited beneath the mansion's veranda, which had some kind of blue-leafed ivy growing in thick vines across it.

I could tell immediately that they were Lord and Lady Granbehl. Both were fair-haired and wearing fine dark clothes with silver trim. Lord Granbehl had the same broad-shouldered build as his sons, while Lady Granbehl was like an older, more beautiful version of Ada.

The knight grabbed me by the shackles and dragged me toward the lord and lady. Three other knights fell into position beside and behind me, their weapons held at the ready.

'This might be your last chance,' Regis suggested. *'Think of how badass it would look if you just snapped those shackles in half and drove all these mages to their knees with your "angry eyes" before just* vanishing *with God Step.'*

You mean my aetheric intent? I struggled to keep my eyes from rolling as I stood face to face with Lord and Lady Granbehl. Her eyes were red, and I could see dark rings under them through the makeup she'd used to paint her face.

Lord Granbehl's jaw tightened as he looked down at me from the edge of the veranda. I saw the blow coming long before he threw it, but didn't flinch when his heavy fist swung down, landing a solid punch against my temple.

"Take this murderous dog to the cells," he ordered, his voice booming across the courtyard. The knights behind me all stamped their spears against the ground twice as my guard hauled me by the shackles into the house, along a finely appointed hallway, and down

a set of stone steps that led first into a cellar and then into a sort of dungeon.

There were four cells, all of them empty. Runes were etched along the floor and bars of the cell doors. I couldn't read them, but I was sure they were meant to keep people from using mana within, perhaps a backup to the mana-suppression cuffs.

The guard shoved me through the barred door into one of the cells and forced me up against the wall. He began to pat me down, feeling my pockets, along my sides, and up and down my legs.

Next, he pulled up my cloak and shirt to examine the false-spellform runes on my back.

When he was finished, he turned me roughly around and stared at my hands before giving me a furrowed look, which—along with his massive build—reminded me of Caera's bodyguard, Taegen.

"Where's all your stuff?" he asked.

"It was all in my dimension ring," I lied, "which I lost in the last zone we went through."

The big guard gave a shrug before stepping out of the cell and slamming the door. "Lord Granbehl will be down in a minute. I trust you won't get lost in here." The guard laughed stupidly at his own joke as he stomped away.

I was too tired and mentally drained to bother offering the man any sort of reaction, instead turning my attention to the accommodations.

The cell was solid stone with no windows. A cot—little more than a thin piece of fabric stretched across a wood frame—was pushed up

against one wall. There was a drain in the corner instead of a chamberpot. That was it.

Well, we've slept in worse places, I told Regis as I sat down on the cot.

'What now, effeminate one?' Regis asked, deepening his voice to mimic Taegen.

I let out a scoff while rummaging through my dimension rune. *First I need to make sure Ellie is okay.*

I pulled out the cracked relic, but it was still dull, and it didn't react when I probed it lightly with aether.

'Is it broken?' Regis asked, and I could sense him attempting to be consoling. Although I wasn't in the mood for pity, I couldn't prevent his emotions from seeping into me, and it helped to ease my mind.

Maybe…

I reached for the godrune that channeled Aroa's Requiem. Swirling violet motes of aether danced along my skin and over the relic, concentrating into the small crack before fading away. The crack was still there, and the stone still dull and lifeless.

My hopes fell for a moment, but I steeled myself against the disappointment. Focusing on the aether in the air—which was much less than in the deeper zones—I examined the relic carefully. The aether was drifting slowly closer to the relic, where it congregated around the crack and, I saw with surprise, was eventually drawn inside it.

It's recharging, I realized. Though I had hoped to look for Ellie immediately and prove to myself that she was alive, knowing that the relic was still functional was a relief.

I stored the device away and pulled a different stone from the extradimensional storage rune: the rainbow-colored egg where Sylvie still slumbered.

It was heavy and warm, and there was a hunger emanating from it. How long had it been since I had tried to fill the reservoir within with aether? *Too long*…but doing so was draining, and would leave me defenseless—and if I didn't have enough aether, it wouldn't release Sylvie anyway.

I turned the iridescent stone over in my hands as I considered what would come next. It would be three weeks until the trial, and I was sure to be questioned, possibly even tortured. That didn't really matter though.

The sight of Elenoir being destroyed flashed in my mind.

The reality of it was beginning to settle onto my shoulders like a heavy weight. I'd always known I was going to have to fight Agrona and the Vritra Clan…but would I also have to defend Dicathen from the rest of the asuras, too?

All the more reason for me to return to the Relictombs as soon as possible. With three weeks to rest and plan, I should be more than prepared for my next ascent…though there was a small doubt nagging at the back of my mind.

'It's not exactly productive for us to just throw ourselves headlong into the Relictombs over and over again looking for these other "ruins,"' Regis said, giving voice to my own doubts.

We just have to let the Relictombs guide us, like it did when we reached the first one. Sylvia's message said she imprinted the locations

into my mind. Maybe that acts as a kind of… key when we're moving from zone to zone.

Regis was silent. The dangerous truth was that we didn't know. There were too many questions and no answers at all. Despite two increasingly difficult ascents, I was no closer to learning how to wield Fate… or even really what this "higher edict" truly was.

My shoulders sank from the weight of my thoughts and role in all of this. And with the scale of things so much grander than even when I was a king, I couldn't help but feel alone… now more than ever.

I held Sylvie's egg close to my chest, trying to feel some semblance of life within. Eventually, my thoughts drifted and my world darkened.

I curled up around Sylvie's egg and held it close to my chest.

324
BLOOD TIES

CAERA DENOIR

"Blood Granbehl has gone too far." I seethed with malice, and mana leaked out of me, making my adoptive mother flinch. We were approaching the exterior gate of Highblood Denoir's pristine white stone and marble compound within the second level of the Relictombs. "Surely you won't let this insult stand," I said, my voice growing lower and more threatening. "Right?"

"It would be wise to hold your tongue until we are inside and away from curious ears, Caera," she replied before studying me with a curious gaze. "It is unlike you to become so emotional over someone else."

I let out a breath as I stared deadpan back at my adoptive mother. *Lady Lenora of Highblood Denoir, always so concerned about appearances. Vritra forbid anyone ever see us at less than our best…*

Our procession made its way through the gates of the outer wall, which were etched with runic wards that came with a variety of functions, powered by several tons of mana crystals. Several people were waiting in the meticulously manicured courtyard, including both Taegen and Arian. My personal guards' eyes were downcast, their faces drawn and a little pale.

While I cared little for my adoptive parents' emotional turmoil, I did feel guilty for these people. Though I was used to keeping secrets, even from Taegen and Arian, disappearing to the Relictombs without them could only be taken as an insult, and I knew my adoptive mother and father would have made things difficult for them over

the last few weeks—though I suppose it had been less long for them.

The truth was that each man had fought fearlessly and loyally at my side several times, and even though I could not tell them the truth about my Vritra blood's manifestation, I trusted them with everything else, and even thought of them as my friends—something I had few enough of. Aside from Nessa, they were the only members of Highblood Denoir that I could trust at all.

There will be time to mend that relationship after I figure out how to help Grey.

Lenora and Nessa escorted me into the mansion while the procession of guards dispersed in the courtyard. Highlord Corbett, my adoptive father and guardian, stood tall in a white and navy suit that highlighted his athletic build next to his eldest son, Lauden Denoir. Unfortunately, unlike Sevren—my late brother, fallen in the Relictombs—Lauden had taken after his father, making him an arrogant bigot who preferred to step on others to elevate himself and the precious Denoir bloodline.

"Nessa, you are dismissed," Father said coolly before gesturing toward a chair. "Caera, take a seat."

"Corbett, I—"

"*Father*, Caera," he said firmly, gesturing to the chair again.

I crossed the room in silence and sat down. Corbett glared down at me. He was an imposing man: a textbook image of the perfect nobleman with olive hair trimmed fashionably to frame his severe and arguably handsome face.

Lauden, a younger, more muscular clone of the highlord, crossed the room to pour himself a drink from a crystal decanter. Behind Corbett's back, he lifted the glass and gave me a sarcastic salute.

Finally, Corbett spoke. "Your mother and I are deeply disappointed in your callous disregard for your own well-being and the well-being of this blood. No," he said as I opened my mouth to respond, "I'm still speaking".

"You know as well as I what would happen to Highblood Denoir if you were harmed in the Relictombs, especially traveling by yourself, without any kind of guard. We've humored your improper desires to test yourself on these ascents for the sake of perhaps manifesting your Vritra blood, but this was a direct betrayal of our trust."

Lenora slipped her arm through Corbett's and let her look of matronly disappointment wash over me like cold moonlight. *Perfected through many long hours of standing mutely at the highlord's side…*

I let my gaze flick back and forth between them. Corbett was building himself up to tell me something, but I could already guess what it was. "I understand that I betrayed your trust, and I'm willing to accept any punishment you see fit, even should you choose to ban me from the Relictombs," I said in a businesslike tone. "However, it is essential that I continue to challenge myself if I am going to fully manifest my Vritra ancestry, something you want just as much as I do, if not more."

Several conflicting emotions warred across Corbett's face: frustration, anger, wariness, and acknowledgement. I knew there was no straighter line to his greed than mention of my Vritra blood.

The Denoirs still held out some hope that it could manifest fully within me, completely ignorant of the fact that it already had.

Lenora answered instead, her head tilted slightly and a sickly-sweet smile plastered onto her face. "Caera… Dearest Caera. We only have your own safety and well-being in mind. Although you don't share our blood, you are still a member of our Blood, and we care for you and have always treated you as our very own daughter. If your… Vritra lineage does manifest, well then of course we'll be excited—for you. But we simply cannot allow you to get yourself killed in your eagerness for adventure."

"The man I was travelling with, the man who you have just allowed to be arrested for a murder he didn't commit, has some understanding of these things." Corbett's heavy brows furrowed as he regarded me suspiciously.

Perhaps that does seem a little too convenient, I realized, but too late.

"If you truly care for my safety and well-being"—I paused, the next words catching in my throat—"please help him."

Lenora's eyes widened in surprise and she exchanged a look with Corbett. Behind them, Lauden looked at his glass as if shocked and mouthed the word, 'please?' as if he couldn't believe what he'd heard.

"We won't have you drawn into this business with Blood Granbehl," Corbett answered after a moment. "The best thing for Highblood Denoir—and that includes you, too, Caera—is to let this play out. You have to see that it would look quite bad if—"

"Vritra's sake, is that all you think about?" I snapped, mana leaking out despite my firm grip on it. This earned me a scowl from Corbett,

but there was also a hint of wariness, even fear. Lenora let out a disapproving *tut*. "How does it look if the *Highblood* Denoir rolls over and lets a mere named blood falsely accuse and imprison the man who saved my life?"

"Not as bad as it would look to have our foster child dragged before a panel of judges in a petty squabble between lesser houses," Corbett countered, his deep voice a growl. "In addition to—"

Someone cleared their throat delicately from the door to the drawing room, and all four of us spun to see who could be impertinent enough to interrupt a family conversation.

A strong sense of relief washed over me.

Standing in the doorway was my mentor. Her pearl-colored hair was pulled elegantly up between her sweeping obsidian horns, and she was wearing flowing black battle robes and an imperious expression.

Corbett, Lenora, and Lauden all bowed deeply and held, waiting for her to speak. She met my eyes with one brow raised slightly. I stood and bowed as well, though perhaps not quite as deeply as the others.

"Rise," she said simply. "Lauden, pour me a drink before you go."

Lauden rushed to do as she commanded. Lenora took a few tentative steps forward to welcome her into the drawing room, but stopped when Corbett began to speak.

"Scythe Seris Vritra, we weren't expecting you," he said, his voice a couple steps higher-pitched than normal.

I always enjoyed watching Corbett struggle to maintain his regal bearing while addressing the Scythe, especially when others were

watching. Even the Highlord and Lady Denoir couldn't help but bend under the weight of her presence.

"I am aware I'm interrupting," the Scythe said smoothly. "However, I wish to speak to Caera. Alone."

Corbett's glance flicked to me before resting back on Scythe Seris. "Perhaps it could wait until after—"

"*Highlord* Denoir," she said coolly, cutting him off so that his mouth closed with an audible *snap*. "I will send Caera to your study once she and I are finished."

"As you wish…Scythe Seris Vritra." Corbett gave her a deep bow and fled the room, dragging Lenora behind him.

Scythe Seris turned her heavy gaze on Lauden who was still standing by the liquor cabinet with a full glass in his hand. He flinched back as he realized he should already be gone, then hurriedly delivered her glass before practically teleporting out of the room in his eagerness to get away.

My mentor must have been waiting for me to return and would have been informed at once when I stepped out of the portal from the Relictombs. I gave her a warm smile, something I reserved for very few.

"Don't look so happy to see me, girl," she said, but her relaxed demeanor was enough to tell me she wasn't here to scold her pupil. "Sit down. I expect we have a lot to talk about."

I sat, resting lightly on the chair with my back straight and my eyes on the Scythe. She sipped at her drink, gave the glass an approving look, then took the seat nearest me.

“So,” she began, “you found the unusual ascender again—and spent weeks inside the Relictombs adventuring at his side?”

I nodded, eager to tell her all about it, but understanding that there was a rhythm to our conversations. It would be highly inappropriate to begin my tale before allowing her to guide the conversation there, which I knew she would do in her own time.

“Grey, was it?” she asked, swirling her drink around thoughtfully. “Did you discover his blood?”

I shook my head.

“Tell me about him.”

I opened my mouth to blurt out the first thing in my head, but stopped myself and took a moment to collect my thoughts into some kind of sensible order.

“He’s intense, almost like a force of nature…and even more strange and powerful than I told you. It was obvious that, despite his displays of strength in the convergence zone where we first met, he was holding back. Except, he was holding back much more than I could have guessed.”

I paused, considering his unusual abilities—and his lack of mana. Would it somehow be a betrayal to tell my mentor this? To which of them did I owe my loyalty, really?

She noticed my hesitation. “Go on.”

“His bladesmanship is impeccable, flawless, just…brilliant. And paired with his unique magic, I’m half certain he would be able to stand his ground against even you, Scythe Seris.”

My mentor wasn’t angry or even surprised at my bold statement. If anything, she was even more intrigued.

“What is so unique about his magic?” she asked.

“He…doesn’t use mana to control it,” I said haltingly. “And he can do things that hardly make sense. I’ve seen him teleport and regenerate limbs—even turn back time, in a way.”

Scythe Seris leaned forward, her finger steepled in front of her lips. “Fascinating. So how does he do it if not with mana?”

“Aether,” I said, feeling a jolt of guilt now. He had told me these things in confidence, but…I couldn’t lie to Scythe Seris. Not about anything.

My mentor’s eyes flashed and she leaned back in her chair and took a sip from her glass. “Only the asuras of the Indrath Clan can wield aether like a weapon. But a dragon could not enter the Relictombs.”

“Perhaps he could be…something like me?” It was a strange, thrilling thought. Although there were other Vritra-blooded Alacryans, I’d met them rarely and certainly never felt any kind of kinship with them. “An Indrath-blooded human?”

“No,” she said, waving the idea away without a second’s thought. “The dragons would never let that happen. They’re much too *pure* to cross their bloodline with mere *lessers.*” She leaned forward again, her dark eyes burrowing into me. “Tell me about your ascent. Leave nothing out.”

Scythe Seris listened for half an hour, occasionally asking for confirmation of some detail, or for me to be more specific, but otherwise just listening as I told her of my time with Grey, from disguising myself as Haedrig to our deadly encounter with the trapped Vritra-blood in the hall of mirrors, all the way until we were stepping out of the sanctuary room and back to the second level.

She was particularly interested in our conversations, and probed to make sure I had remembered every word. “And he seemed ignorant of Alacryan culture?” she asked.

“Yes, even about the simplest things. As I’ve already mentioned, when we first met he asked all sorts of strange questions, but made it sound almost as if he were testing *us*. We talked a lot on our journey, and I was continually surprised by what he didn’t know.”

“And when he found out about your identity? When he learned how you had tracked him?”

“I thought he was going to kill me at first, but…well, he didn’t obviously. He seemed terrified that someone could track him…but then the fear faded just as quickly once he understood that only I could use it.”

Seris looked thoughtful, swirling her drink around in her glass absently. “So, our mystery ascender is incredibly powerful, ignorant of our customs, and fearful of being found out. He wields aether like an ancient mage, but is incapable of channeling mana.” She drained her glass and set it down with a delicate *clink*. “Describe the man. In as much detail as you are able.”

I felt myself go red in the cheeks as I pictured Grey’s handsome, severe face, and hoped Scythe Seris hadn’t noticed. “He is tall and lean, with an…athletic physique. He has sharp features and skin as white as milk. His pale wheat-blond hair tumbles ramshackle around his face, and he has these piercing golden eyes that seem to see right through me. He came off as really cold and distant, but after spending time with him, it’s easy to tell that he’s quite caring…” I trailed off after seeing Scythe Seris’s lips twitch into a smile.

“I was merely curious about his physical appearance, but if you wish to divulge your feelings for him, I will listen.”
I let out a startled laugh. “M-my feelings? I just thought you’d be interested to know what kind of person he is.”
My mentor remained silent, a smile still tugging at the corner of her lips.
I furrowed my brows, pouting. “I don’t know what I did to deserve such teasing, Scythe Seris.”
The pearl-haired Vritra let out a melodic laugh, a sound very few had the honor of hearing, before she raised a hand in a placating manner. “Regardless of your feelings for this ascender, he seems likely to be walking a path of hardship and tragedy.”
I wanted to argue, but her words rang true. Grey was clearly adept at getting himself, and those around him, into trouble, at the very least. “Yet, at the same time, you will find few who can match either your mind or your magical abilities, Caera. Perhaps we may be able to help your mysterious love.”
“He is not my love,” I stammered, but my heart thrummed in my chest. If anyone could help Grey escape Blood Granbehl, it was Scythe Seris. She could end this farce of a trial with a snap of her fingers.
“But this mysterious ascender…why does this ‘Grey’ sound more and more like—” My mentor’s piercing eyes suddenly went wide, and a knowing smile bloomed on her flawless face. “So you really have not fallen…”

325
PAINLESS

LORD GRANBEHL'S large fist struck my side. His guards stood around me, holding me up by the arms with my hands still shackled. The next blow was to my face, then a series of punches to my ribs again.

The broad-shouldered noble was sweating, and some of his hair had pulled free of the ponytail that ran down his back, giving him a slightly disheveled look. After a few more swings, he stepped back and straightened his dark suit.

A young man hurried to mop the sweat from Lord Granbehl's face. The boy had the same fair hair as all the other Granbehls I'd met, but he lacked Kalon and Ezra's build.

Someone cleared their throat from outside my cell. "Lord Titus?"

My *host* turned and stepped out into the dingy stone hallway without even a second glance in my direction.

It had been three days since I'd walked out of the portal and right into this political mess. Every day, Kalon's father had visited me to ask one question: did I kill his sons? And every day, when I told him I hadn't, he spent a few minutes beating on me before leaving. The rest of my time was spent alone with Regis and my thoughts.

It wasn't bad, not at all. My new asuran body was more than capable of absorbing a few punches, and so far there hadn't been any lengthy interrogations either. The worst part was the anticipation…not of the trial, but about Ellie.

The relic still hadn't recharged. I'd been checking it every few minutes, but sometime during the second day Regis pointed out that

I looked like a crazy person, so I had been holding myself back to only once an hour.

The old man that had led my arrest, who I'd learned as Lord Granbehl's steward, appeared in the doorway just long enough to wave for the guards to release me, and in moments I was alone again.

'As entertaining as it is to watch you pretend to be a punching bag, I'm bored,' Regis thought the moment the guards closed the door. *'We really going to do this for three whole weeks?'*

Go take a nap then, I snapped.

'Rude,' he grumbled back.

After glancing out the barred door to make sure the guard at the end of the hall couldn't see into my cell, I laid down on the cot and withdrew the hard fruit-toy from my dimension rune. The noise of the seed rattling around inside it immediately took me back to the snowy mountaintop village where I had trained with Three Steps.

Picturing the climbing peaks and plunging valleys, and letting myself slip into the meditative state I'd used while training with the Shadow Claws, I released a small amount of aether from my core and pushed it toward the tip of my index finger.

The purple energy hummed softly as it formed into a thin, slightly curved extension of my finger. I slid the aetheric "claw" into the slot and fished around for the pea-sized seed. Although I could get the seed to the hole, when I tried to pull it through, the aether lost its shape and dissipated.

Taking a deep breath, I conjured the claw a second time and tried again with similar results. I kept at the seed for another hour or two before Regis interrupted my practice.

'You've been doing this for hours,' Regis grumbled. *'Don't you get tired of it?'*

Not really. It gives me something to focus on…to occupy my mind, I guess.

'Oh. So sort of like knitting?'

I rolled my eyes. *Yes, Regis. Manipulating aether into a solid, deadly weapon is* exactly *like knitting*. I intended to return to my practice, but footsteps on the stairs told me someone was coming.

Quickly storing the seed, I stood, walked to the cell door, and rested my hand on the bars. A jolt of mana jumped into my hand, running up my arm like a bolt of lightning. I grunted and pulled away, flexing my tingling fingers.

The steward appeared once again. He gave me a snide smirk when he noticed my obvious discomfort. "Oh, I'm sorry, Ascender Grey, did they forget to mention the door? The bars are heavily enchanted against physical contact—to ensure our guests don't attempt to force their way free, of course.

"Now, if you would please step back to the wall…"

I did as he asked. The elder waved a hand and the wall behind me began to move. Restraints appeared, growing out of the stone and around my legs and arms, pinning me to the wall.

"Don't bother struggling," he said confidently. "These manacles were designed by the finest Instillers in Central Dominion. The chains and their moorings are unbreakable."

I tested their strength, flexing my arms and shoulder until the stone began to quake.

Oops, I thought. *Almost broke them.*

The golden-haired elder was still smirking, apparently not having noticed. I returned the look with a deadpan, almost bored gaze. "Neat," I said flatly.

His smirk flickered. "I realize, Ascender Grey, that your time in the Relictombs has likely inoculated you against base fear, and you've already shown yourself to be adept at holding out through pain. I'll admit, Lord Titus has been most frustrated with your lack of expressiveness. He would like to see you squirm, to use his word."

The elder stood aside so another man could open the door and enter the cell. This man was tall and gangly. He wore dark leather armor with gold studs that smelled strongly of oil, which matched his greasy black hair and the gold ring in his ear.

"Where should I start, Master Matheson?" he asked in a high, simpering voice as his black eyes trailed over my body.

The old man wrinkled his nose at the torturer. "Oh, I wouldn't presume to tell you how to do your job. Just make him talk." Matheson met my eyes from behind the torturer. "I'll be back in, say, twenty minutes for the questioning."

The torturer grinned, revealing black and rotting teeth. "Yes, Master Matheson." To me, he said, "Grey, is it? I'm Petras. I'd say it's a pleasure, but"—his grin widened—"I promise it won't be."

'Ugh, that was so cringey it made my nonexistent toes curl,' Regis groaned.

I didn't say anything, but kept my expression level and uninterested.

My lack of a response didn't seem to bother Petras at all. He produced a wicked-looking dagger with a flourish and, in the same motion, drew the blade across my upper arm. It was so sharp I hardly felt it.

The wound let out a trickle of blood before healing over.

Petras's grin faded. He regarded me warily before cutting in the same spot, slower and deeper this time. I realized that my extreme healing was going to draw unwanted attention and attempted to close off the trickle of aether from my core. It was only partially successful.

Regis, go to my left foot.

'If this is about my toes comment earlier, I was just being—'

I need to limit my healing factor. Just do it.

My companion drifted through my body into my foot, and the slow trickle of aether redirected, pulled toward him by whatever gravitational force he had on it.

The second cut was slower to heal. Petras didn't make a third right away, instead watching with interest as the remaining aether knit my flesh back together. For me, the healing was sluggish, but compared to a normal person, it was still incredibly quick.

He ran a rough finger over where the cut had vanished without even a scar.

He checked my mana-suppression cuffs to make sure they were tightly fastened, then took a step away from me. "How are you doing that?"

"Doing what?" I replied, my face perfectly blank.

Frowning, the torturer held the flat of his blade to the back of my hand. The dagger began to glow red hot, my skin sizzling and popping and filling the cell with the stench of burning flesh.

I let my mind slip away from the pain, meditating on my core and the aether swirling around inside it, which I held onto as tightly as I could. A small stream was leaking out, half pulled toward Regis, but some traveling along my aether channels toward my hand.

When Petras lifted his glowing dagger, the scorch mark it had left behind was a deep scar in my pristine flesh. Instead of hurting, though, I only felt a kind of tingling as aether started repairing the damage, but it was working even more slowly now on the larger wound.

The torturer stuck his thumb into the raw burn and pressed hard, his black eyes absorbing every twitch, every flicker of movement from me, but the pain was nothing. His slack face curved down into an exaggerated frown.

"Minor healing abilities, even with mana choked off," he muttered to himself. "High pain tolerance, likely due to the same ability. Yes, time to try something else."

He tossed the dagger, its blade still glowing, into the corner, and cracked his knuckles.

"Usually I save this for later, but…" He gave me a devious smirk. "I can tell you require… special treatment."

'Ooh Arthur, special *treatment. I think he likes you,'* Regis teased.

A hint of a smile crossed my face. Petras scowled furiously in response.

“Think this is funny, Ascender Grey?” he asked, his voice going even higher. “To the pain, then!”

His bony fingers clamped tightly around my own, and a savage kind of glee came over him. I could tell from the concentration on his face that he was casting a spell, but nothing happened, even as sweat started pouring down his face and each breath became a desperate gasp.

The burn on the back of my hand was still healing, and Petras kept glancing at it, his expression turning more frustrated by the second.

He held my hands like that for another minute before throwing them down in disgust. “That’s not possible!” he shouted, storming back and forth across the small cell. “Entirely impossible!” He rounded on me, glaring fiercely. “What the hell are you?”

“Innocent,” I said flatly. “And a bit hungry.”

Hissing, Petras snatched his dagger from the floor, took two quick steps toward me, and drove the weapon into my side, just below my ribs. Though no longer glowing, it was still scorching hot, and I could feel it burning inside me.

I’d had worse.

His beetle-black eyes searched mine for any hint of pain or fear he could console himself with, but I gave him nothing.

He ripped the dagger out and stared at the wound. I let the aether flow freely. Half still filtered downward toward Regis, but the rest went to the deep cut in my side. It slowly began to heal over. Finally, Petras slumped to my cot and fell into it. He stayed like that for a couple of minutes, silently glaring up at the low ceiling.

“I’ve never seen anyone heal as quickly as you, and yet your mana doesn’t react to my crest. My touch should turn every nerve in your body to fire if you have any mana in you at all. I don’t understand it.”
He turned his head so he was staring at me. His fury had faded to wary curiosity. “Is it an emblem? A…a regalia? I was told your runes were vague, but nothing unusual.”
I shrugged awkwardly, pinned to the wall like I was.
“A man of mystery…” Petras said under his breath, looking back at the ceiling. “Nothing for it then but to see just how strong this ability is.”
The torturer rolled out of the cot and flourished his dagger with a nasty smile.

By the time the golden-haired elder returned, my clothes were in tatters and stained red with my blood. Petras had taken his time, inflicting wound after wound with slow, deliberate focus. My injuries were closing slightly slower now, so I recalled Regis from my foot, but I hadn’t rewarded the torturer’s efforts with even the flicker of an eyelid.
The old man, Matheson, seemed surprised by my state. He glared at Petras, but the lanky Alacryan only shrugged apologetically. “You can leave us now. Wait in the hall.”
Petras’s shoulders slumped and he sulked out of the cell. Matheson waited until he was gone to begin asking questions.

“Ascender Grey,” he began, “I would like for you to explain to me why you murdered Lord Kalon of Blood Granbehl, Lord Ezra of Blood Granbehl, and Lady Riah of Blood Faline. Please, spare no detail.”

Speaking as calmly and plainly as I could muster, I said, “I didn’t murder anyone. The Relictombs proved much more difficult than Kalon had anticipated, and they fell to the monsters inside.”

Matheson’s brows came together in a small frown. “You must understand, Ascender Grey, that we have an eyewitness to these acts. We know what happened. My Lord and Lady Granbehl now wish to understand why.”

He took a step closer to me. “Was this attack political in nature? Are you an assassin sent by a rival blood?”

“If I was, I did a pretty lousy job seeing that I left an eyewitness.”

Things didn’t get better from there. Matheson pressed me to explain the details of our ascent, from how I found the Granbehls, to the forms the beasts within the Relictombs took, all the way down to small details like what we all ate while trapped in the mirror room, and what the figures in the mirrors looked like.

I told as much of the truth as I comfortably could, but took careful note of any omissions I made for when they inevitably asked me to repeat everything I’d said.

Finally, Matheson turned to leave the cell, but stopped in the doorway. “Oh, yes. One more thing, Ascender Grey. Where did you hide your dimension ring?”

“I lost it,” I answered with a tone of regret, “along with all my belongings. But I already told the guard that.”

"I see. Very well then." Matheson left without another word, shutting the cell door with a heavy *clang* behind him.

Regis, who had been uncharacteristically quiet throughout the torture and following interview, fluttered awake inside of me. *'You okay?'*

Fine, I replied, easing onto the cot. I'd put myself through so much worse when forging my aether channels and training in the Relictombs.

Habit caused me to withdraw the multi-faceted relic from my dimension rune to check, and I felt a jolt of adrenaline and sat back up quickly when I realized the stone was warm to the touch and humming softly with a faint aetheric energy.

It's recharged!

'About time. So what first then?'

There was no question. Clenching the relic in my fist, I thought Ellie's name. White fog swirled across the surface of the stone, and I wasn't immediately drawn in as I had been before. Closing my eyes, I focused harder, picturing her face and chanting her name in my mind: *Eleanor Leywin, Eleanor Leywin… Ellie…*

'Arthur,' Regis thought consolingly, *'I'm sorry—'*

Even though my eyes were closed, I felt my perception shift suddenly. Regis's presence was gone, as was the feel of cold stone beneath my feet.

Slowly, I opened my eyes.

The first thing I saw was Ellie. My sister, alive and safe.

326
BACKLASH

ELEANOR LEYWIN

I clenched my teeth, trying to stay focused through the throbbing pain that covered every inch of my body, as Commander Virion addressed everyone present. Mom had been pretty stubborn in her efforts to keep me at home in bed, but I *couldn't* miss the council meeting. They had been waiting for me to get better so I could tell them what happened after everyone else teleported back to the sanctuary from Elenoir… and why Tessia had never returned.

But now that I was sitting in the City Hall's main conference room—the same one where Tessia had first brought me to a council meeting—with every important figure in Dicathen staring holes right through me, I kind of wished I had listened to my mom.

I'd already told Virion and Bairon about most of it anyway, but I'd been sort of in and out of consciousness for the last couple days so I didn't think I'd been very helpful.

"—leanor?"

I suddenly realized how long I had stayed quiet. "Sorry, what?"

Virion cleared his throat. He looked… old. Old and tired. "Would you like to tell the council about your mission in Elenoir?"

I stood slowly, regretted it quickly, and then fell back into my chair. "Um, well, you see, I… uh…"

There was a faint *pop* from just behind me and a chorus of shouts filled the room. Kathyln, who was sitting right beside me, sucked in a surprised breath. Her brother had his sword half out of its sheath before he realized what was happening.

Lord Bairon was crackling with thunderous energy, but backed down when I turned and rested my hand on the furry creature that had manifested behind me.

"Boo, I said to wait outside. You can't just *poof* to me every time I get a little nervous," I scolded him, but it was half hearted. His presence gave me strength.

He grunted in a way that told me he wasn't sorry, then laid down in front of the arched doorway.

"Sorry," I mumbled, glancing at Virion. If the old elf was annoyed, he didn't show it.

"Not to worry, Ellie. Go on, if you're ready."

I took a deep, shuddering breath before words started to spill from me. I explained my part in our plan to free the elven prisoners from the little town of Eidelholm, going over my fight against the retainer's brother. I told them how I gave my medallion to Albold so that the elves that were left could escape, and how Tessia had finally killed Bilal.

The hardest part was describing Elijah's arrival, but no one interrupted as I stammered my way through it. Kathyln gave me a shocked look when I got to the part where I pretended to be an Alacryan student-soldier, and even Bairon let out a low whistle, which I thought meant he was impressed.

Finally, I told them how Tessia had reappeared at Elijah's side, and about the attack, and how I'd tried to save the elven slaves… but…

It was too much, and I let the story end with the explosion that ripped me away from Elenoir, then leaned forward to rest my forehead on the cool table.

Helen Shard walked around the table to set her hand on my shoulder. “No one could have done more, Eleanor. What you accomplished… frankly it’s incredible.”

Kathyln squeezed my hand. The normally composed princess had tears sparkling in the corners of her eyes. Behind her, Curtis was downcast and pale.

“How in the world did you escape?” the old soldier, Madam Astera, asked.

Sitting up straight, I pulled the phoenix wyrm pendant out from underneath my shirt. It was milky white and cracked all the way through, empty of mana. “This.”

I could still clearly imagine how the elven servants had looked at me as I tried and failed to activate Tessia’s medallion and take them all with me. They knew that I couldn’t do it. They knew they were going to die. Then the wall of light washed over me and everything went pink.

For a few seconds, I could see the world being ripped apart around me through the tiled pink shell of energy conjured by the phoenix wyrm pendant. The Alacryans, the elves, the bleachers, the little stage, the mansion… it all vanished in the blink of an eye. And then so did I.

I had woken up screaming, my legs dangling in the little stream that ran through the underground sanctuary. Boo was there, smoke rising from his singed fur, somehow alive. The last thing I heard was his deep roar filling the cavern before I passed out from backlash.

“Do we know—how big was the explosion?” a trembling voice asked. It was one of the elves we’d rescued, the man who knew Tessia and Kathyln: Feyrith.

Virion and Bairon exchanged a dark look. “As soon as Eleanor returned, General Bairon flew straight to the Beast Glades and up toward Elenoir,” Virion said, nodding to the human Lance.

“Elenoir is gone,” the Lance said gruffly.

“What do you mean ‘gone’? A country can’t just d-disappear!” Feyrith argued.

“Well it has.” The Lance turned a sharp eye to the elf. “Nothing remains between the Beast Glades and the northern coast but a scorched and twisted wasteland.”

Kathyln’s breath shuddered as her hands covered her mouth.

The young elf had gone ghostly pale, but seemed frozen, his mouth half-open, his knuckles white from gripping the edge of the table. An elven woman, whose name I couldn’t remember even though she’d been at the sanctuary since the beginning, began to sob.

Behind me, Helen squeezed my shoulder again in a gesture of support.

“But the asuras—” Curtis started to say, his voice low and full of crackling energy.

“Were and still are our allies,” Virion said firmly. “Despite appearances, we do not believe that the greater part of the destruction was caused by the asuras’ attack, which was only intended to destroy the Alacryans gathered at Eidelholm.”

From the doorway behind me, a soft voice said, “How could you possibly know that?”

Little waves of pain rippled through my entire body as I twisted in my seat to look at the speaker. Albold, the elven guard, was standing framed in the arched entrance on the other side of Boo's hulking form.

He held himself awkwardly, leaning to his right side. He'd been badly hurt during the fight against the retainer; I was kind of surprised to see him on duty already.

Albold continued, not waiting for an answer to his question. "Ellie saw the asura known as Aldir initiate the attack with her own eyes."

I couldn't see Virion's face, but I could hear the low growl of anger in his voice. "This is a closed council meeting, Albold. Return to your post. We will discuss this later."

Albold scowled, but turned and marched out of sight.

I reached down to scratch Boo before slowly twisting back around to face the others.

It's not just Albold. The others aren't exactly thrilled with Virion's explanation, either. Curtis Glayder was frowning deeply, his gaze leveled at the table instead of Virion. The elven woman was continuing to cry quietly.

Feyrith stood. His legs were a little shaky, and he had to support himself with a hand on the table. "Commander Virion, if General Bairon is correct, then *our* homeland…the vast majority of the elven people…" He paused and took a deep breath. "Someone has to answer for this atrocity. We know the Alacryans are our enemy, but what proof do we have that the asuras are still our allies?"

The anger that had suddenly overtaken Virion at Albold's intrusion went away just as quickly. He waved for Feyrith to sit down. "They

have been since the beginning, Feyrith. Do not forget that they saved us from the betrayal of King and Queen Greysunders. They guided the war effort in the early days, before we knew what we were up against. They tried to end the war before it began."

"That's a strange way of saying they betrayed us when they attacked the Vritra behind the Council's back, an act that forced them into an agreement to stop helping us entirely and resulted in Dicathen's fall," Curtis said. Although he kept his voice calm, the prince's cheeks had turned red, and he was staring hard at Virion.

Virion waved Curtis's argument aside. "An act that, had it succeeded, would have saved Dicathen. Leaders make decisions, Curtis, you know that as well as I, and not all those decisions end the way we hope."

Madam Astera leaned forward, her fake leg splayed out unnaturally to one side of her chair. "But how did the Alacryans do it, then? If you're telling me our enemy has the power to wipe out entire countries, then why haven't they done it before? And what hope do we have in defeating them?"

Virion nodded. "That is a better question. To the first, we don't yet know, but I think we can guess the reason for not doing it before. After all, they wanted to take over Dicathen, not burn it to the ground."

"Then what changed?" she shot back.

"What indeed?" Virion said, and I couldn't help but notice he hadn't even tried to answer the question.

"We're talking about the complete destruction of our home!" Feyrith shouted, his wide, furious eyes jumping from Virion to Madam Astera

and back. “Nothing you’re saying makes any sense! It’s like you don’t even care—”

Virion’s fist slammed down on the table, making everyone jump. Boo sat up and glared over my shoulder at the commander.

“Do not speak to me as if I’m some bystander, boy. I, too, am an elf! One that has just lost the very country that he grew up in, that he fought *two* wars for!

“Listen to yourselves!” Virion’s face became wild and desperate as his calm facade cracked. “As if having one asura as an enemy hasn’t proven bad enough, you want to go to war with all of Epheotus? No, if the asuras were truly our enemies, then we have no chance of winning this war.”

Virion’s outburst was met with shocked silence. I wasn’t sure what to say, or even what to think. It sounded more like he was just hoping that the asuras hadn’t destroyed Elenoir than that he had discovered any kind of proof…

But what *had* happened? I’d seen the asura, towering high above the town and radiating a pressure so strong it paralyzed everyone, fire a blast of mana that ripped Eidelholm apart…but could it really have been strong enough to destroy the entire country?

I shook my head, even though no one was looking at me. *I was* there, *and even I don’t know what happened.*

Despite his hard words, when Virion’s gaze traveled around the room, meeting everyone’s eyes in turn, his expression wasn’t hard or angry, just weary. “But we have to lay blame where it is due, not engage in some witch hunt against our allies. It was the Alacryans that attacked us and drove us from our homes. It was the Alacryans

that murdered our kings and queens of the Council and put our people in chains. It was the Alacryans that stole our land and burned our forest.

"The asuras are now our only hope to reclaim Dicathen. They took a great risk to attack the Alacryans in Elenoir, an act that would have broken Agrona's hold on our homeland, but the Vritra knew that. Instead of allowing Elenoir to be retaken, the Vritra destroyed it utterly."

The rest of the council stared warily at Virion. Albold and Feyrith's question was still stuck in my head. *But how do you know?*

As if reading my thoughts, he said, "Elder Rinia came to me with a vision." Virion's voice was sharp and resolute, as if those words explained everything. "She told me that the asuras of Epheotus would come to our aid, but that the Vritra Clan were expecting their agreement to be broken, and would turn the attack back on us. She said they would try to make it look like the asuras were our enemies, but they are not."

Even Bairon seemed surprised to hear this news. Curtis and Kathyln exchanged a glance, while the elves leaned against each other for support.

Madam Astera snorted, her old face wrinkling up into a sneer. "The old soothsayer who claims to have seen all this coming, and yet did nothing to prevent it? How convenient that there is always some vision we only learn about after it's too late to do anything."

That's not fair, I wanted to say. Without the seer, Tessia, my mother, and I would have been captured by the Alacryans a long time ago.

But I bit my lip and held back because Madam Astera wasn't the only one who felt like that.

It was part of the reason why Elder Rinia had chosen to seclude herself so deeply in the caverns. Because when people found out what Elder Rinia had known—and what she could've done—they never looked at her the same again.

I thought—hoped—that Virion might get upset with Madam Astera, but he only shook his head and looked even more tired. "It isn't her fault, Astera, though I know it may be hard to trust her. Rinia has sacrificed much to help us however she can, and it has taken a terrible toll on her."

I realized with a jolt of guilt that I'd entirely forgotten that aspect of Elder Rinia's magical abilities; she traded her own lifeforce to see our possible futures. "Is she okay?" I asked, my voice sounding very small.

Virion held my gaze for several seconds before replying. "She is near the end of her power, I'm afraid."

Madam Astera looked as if she couldn't have cared less about Elder Rinia's failing health, but had the good grace not to share whatever she was thinking.

I picked at the loose end of my nail as I thought back to when I had visited Elder Rinia.

She seemed pretty healthy to me. I didn't doubt Virion's words, but, at the same time, I had trouble picturing the elderly elf's health failing so quickly.

And what was she looking for when she had this vision? When I asked her about our mission, she'd given me a vague warning about the

cost being more than Virion wanted to pay. I'd thought that she'd been talking about Tessia…but had she already seen the asuran attack on Elenoir, and meant losing the whole country instead? But if that was the case, why hadn't she told me more at the time? Did she just see it later?

I hate this visions-of-the-future junk, I thought miserably. It never made any sense.

I decided to go see her again and turned my attention back to the meeting, but the meeting seemed to have ended. Everyone else looked as caught off guard by the sudden dismissal as I felt.

Feyrith was already helping the elf woman out of the room, nervously skirting around Boo, who took up most of the doorway. Virion was having a whispered conversation with Bairon, while Curtis and Kathyln waited for a private word with the Commander.

Helen helped me to my feet and guided me toward the door.

"Thanks," I said gratefully.

We made our way down the hall and through the heavy leather flap that served as a door. Albold wasn't at his post when we left, but the other guard, Lenna, gave me a firm nod as we went past.

Boo's sides scraped against the walls of the hallway behind us, and he had to squash himself through the door. My bond gave me a grumpy, mewling grunt when he finally made it out onto the steps.

"Don't look at me. I told you to wait outside," I said, waiting for him to catch up. When he did, I twined my fingers into his dense fur and let him support me as we walked.

"I know you don't feel this way, Ellie, but…you did good," Helen said when we caught back up.

"Yeah…" *You're right, I really don't feel that way…*

"One thing I don't really understand," Helen said, her tone conversational. "How did Boo escape? Did the pendant Arthur gave you bring you both back?"

I didn't answer right away. The truth was, everything after Aldir and Windsom showed up in Elenoir was sort of a blur. Boo had been hiding in the forest around Eidelholm, and should have been killed, but… when I came to in the sanctuary, he was right beside me.

"Or have you been keeping these powerful and mysterious abilities a secret from your teacher?" she asked, giving me a look of mock surprise.

I shook my head, allowing a faint smile. "I don't think it was the phoenix wyrm amulet, and this definitely wasn't something I was keeping a secret from everyone. To be honest, I've never really figured out what kind of mana beast he is, so we're not sure what his powers are."

He moaned from behind us. "Yes, we're talking about you. Ever since we came back, anytime I get… stressed out or a bit scared, he just *poofs* right next to me. So that must be how he escaped. It draws off my own mana, though, and nearly killed me from the backlash…"

Helen's eyes widened until her brows rose up out of sight behind the line of her hair. "Either way, I think you're more like that brother of yours than anyone's given you credit for."

Ever since Elenoir, I'd felt like there was this sort of crack that ran all the way through inside me, and it got a little bigger with every nice thing someone said to me. I didn't feel like Arthur. I wasn't heroic, or

brave, or talented, or powerful…if I was, then I could have done something. I could have rescued Tessia, or saved those elves or…

Could Arthur have stopped them from destroying Elenoir? I wondered.

"Hey, look at me." Helen took my chin firmly in her hand and tugged my head up so our eyes met. "Don't blame yourself for everything that went wrong, and don't refuse to accept where you helped things go right. Your mission—you, Ellie—saved a lot of people."

"I know," I said, but the words came out half choked as my throat tightened and my eyes began to overflow with tears. "I just—I…"

Words failed me. Helen's arms were around me, and I let myself sink into her. Every wracking sob sent a hot bolt of pain through me. Boo's heavy warmth pressed against my back as he joined in our hug.

"Why don't I take you to meet some of those people you saved?" Helen said softly. "Remind you what all this was for."

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ENOUGH FOR NOW

ARTHUR LEYWIN

I forced my hand to relax around the relic, afraid of it shattering within my clenched fist, and withdrew my consciousness. My eyes opened to reveal the small cell in the Granbehls' mansion as a broad grin spread across my face.

Ellie was alive!

I clamped a hand over my mouth out of fear that I might just burst into laughter, interrupted by a loud sigh from inside my head.

What?

'Nothing,' Regis said with a shrug. *'I just feel sorry for the poor sod that tries to actually marry your little sister in the future.'*

I stifled another laugh, actually finding Regis's sense of humor amusing for once, which took even my companion by surprise.

"Thank you," I whispered to the relic as I held it up against my forehead. I repeated it again and again as relief continued to wash over me like a soothing balm.

The tension and fear that gripped my chest like an iron claw loosened and I was able to breathe fully and deeply again now that I knew my sister was okay.

It was still frustrating trying to piece together the conversation I'd witnessed in my head, but what was important was that Ellie was safe.

That was enough for now.

They were still hidden in the underground sanctuary, that much at least was clear from the architecture of the building as Ellie

recounted what happened to her in Elenoir. The relic didn't allow me to hear the conversation, but I followed along by reading her lips as best as I could.

A mixture of emotions bubbled up as I realized that my little sister had fought off a fully trained Alacryan mage all by herself. I was angry at her, scared and worried for her—and yet, proud of the warrior she'd become.

My brows furrowed as I considered Ellie's description of her time at the Alacryan camp.

How could she be so reckless as to pretend to be a race of people she knows nothing about and infiltrate their base of operations? I thought with a sigh.

'Are you being deliberate here or are you just blind to the hypocrisy?' Regis asked.

Shut it, I snapped, ignoring the almost tangible sensation of Regis rolling his eyes within me.

It was bad enough that Elijah's name had appeared from Ellie's lips. The memory of that last battle with my reincarnated friend and the Scythe, Cadell, was muddled, but his animosity bordering on hatred toward me was clear, and it made me sick knowing that he had been so close in proximity to my sister.

But it wasn't until Virion had started to speak that things got confusing. Even though I hadn't been able to make out every word he said, his account of the attack was clearly different from what I had witnessed.

'Huh. Well I guess you can't blame a guy for wanting to deny that it isn't just one asuran clan that wants you all dead,' Regis chimed in.

I don't think it was as simple as being in denial. He seemed so sure for some reason.

'Then maybe he knows and just wants his soldiers' attention on an enemy that he can actually fight,' my companion offered. *'A temporary, but maybe necessary, tactic.'*

Maybe, I replied, but I wasn't convinced. I rolled up into a sitting position and rested my elbows on my knees. *He could have misunderstood Rinia's warning, or maybe he's just wrong. I'm not sure I'd have believed it either, if I hadn't watched Aldir do it.*

Ellie's safety and health was a huge weight off of my shoulders, but it also felt bittersweet. An entire country, one that I'd visited multiple times, had been destroyed completely.

How many had died in the asuras' attack? How many elves weren't able to be evacuated during the Alacryans' initial assault?

And what about Tessia?

Standing, I began to pace back and forth across the tiny cell.

Tess's battle against Lord Aldir and Windsom, side by side with Nico, replayed in my mind. I pictured the way she'd fought, how she'd moved so awkwardly, like she was having trouble controlling her own body, and how Nico had defended her, putting himself between her and Windsom's attacks.

And that look they shared, at the end…

I sat back down and rolled the relic around absently between my fingers.

'While I would normally encourage these sorts of sentimental moments to a tin can such as yourself, I don't think Nico making moves on your girl should be—'

It's not that simple, I cut in, jaw clenched.

The last moments before Sylvie sacrificed herself for me, the memory I'd been so desperately burying, resurfaced:

"You said taking Tess isn't going to bring Cecilia back, right? Well, what if it will?" Nico had asked me.

Tess was the vessel for Cecilia. They wanted to reincarnate Cecilia *into* Tessia's body. Nico had told me as much.

I narrowed my eyes, focusing on a specific crack on the ceiling. Taking a steady breath, I forced myself to calm down. I needed to make a mental step back so I could think clearly.

I knew that my own reincarnation had somehow been the catalyst for Agrona figuring out how to bring Nico into this world. Nico had loved Cecilia and dedicated his entire life to her… and I had killed her right in front of him.

Watching that happen, living with that anger and fear and guilt as I went on to become king and cut myself off from my old life… I couldn't bring myself to blame Nico's resentment.

Or did Agrona do something to him to make him like this?

Blaming Agrona for Nico's current state was easy, but that was also me trying to shift the blame. Most likely, the Vritra could only manipulate him because of our ties in our previous life.

Now, Nico wanted Cecilia back… but there had to be more to all this reincarnation stuff than just that. Agrona was calculative and manipulative—I couldn't see him not doing anything that wasn't a benefit to himself or his goal. He wouldn't have promised to reincarnate Cecilia just to make Nico happy.

Of course, he intends to use her. Just like how Vera used me. All Cecilia had wanted was peace, which is why she had…

I shook my head, pulling away from thoughts of my past life and forcing myself to focus on the present.

Elder Rinia had said that we had to keep Tess away from Agrona, that everything depended on it. This isn't about Nico at all. It's about Cecilia. Maybe it always had been.

How strong would Cecilia—this so-called "legacy"—be in this world?

'Well, given that a quadra-elemental white core mage and a darkness-spewing Vritra are needed to even summon her…' Regis started, *'I'd say pretty damn strong.'*

Not helping.

My thoughts were scattered, jumping from one thread to the next before I could settle on any one idea.

I sat up again and rubbed at my face.

But none of this answers the question, why would Indrath choose to attack now? Unless—I swallowed past a hard lump in my throat—*Agrona was successful.*

"Damn it!" I threw a punch, stopping just shy of the closest wall. The last thing I needed was to accidentally break out of this cell and make things worse.

Even if Tess was now… Cecilia, it didn't change the fact that I needed to play this trial out in order to move about freely in Alacrya. I couldn't afford to risk facing Agrona and the Vritra and Scythes before I was ready.

What do you think, Regis? I asked, eager to hear any thoughts but my own.

'That the answer I'll give isn't the answer you want to hear,' he responded gruffly.

Have you ever given me an answer I wanted to hear? I let out a breath. *You have my memories and a part of my personality, along with some of Sylvie's and Uto's. Just be honest.*

'Well, there's a good chance your lady love has been erased and replaced with the super-powerful chick you murdered in a previous life. Sound about right?'

I bit back my immediate annoyed response. *Yes, Regis, as you've so eloquently put it, but what can I do about it?*

'A passing gnort donkey can tell you that there isn't a damned thing you can do about that right now,' my companion cut in. *'You're trying to solve a puzzle with half the pieces. At this rate, you're going to either get the wrong answer or have a mental breakdown trying.'*

I ran my fingers through my hair, once again reminded of how far I had come—how much had changed—since I first came to this world. *Then what happens if Agrona can solve the puzzle before I can even gather all of the pieces?*

'Then you lose,' he said flatly. *'But remember what the djinn said, Agrona doesn't have insight into aether like you do, which is why you even have a chance at beating him. Why give that up to try and do exactly what Agrona has been doing for centuries to try to win?'*

I pondered over Regis's words for a moment before responding. *You're right.*

Anger flashed from my companion *'No, no, you're not listening to me. You—wait, did you just say that I'm right?'*

I nodded.

'Thanks… no, I mean of course I'm right,' Regis continued. *'Also, while you're actually listening to me for a change, I don't think that relic is going to be good for your mental health, if you know what I mean. Don't get addicted to spying on your sister.'*

I let out a humorless chuckle. *Thanks, Regis.*

The relic was still resting in my hand, smooth and sharp-edged. Looking at it gave me a sudden idea.

I only hoped that the relic had enough power left for a second use.

Holding it gingerly between my index finger and thumb, I pushed aether into it and thought, *Tessia*.

Mist swirled across the surface of the stone, but nothing else happened.

Cecilia.

The clouds grew dark and the relic began to emit a soft purple light as it absorbed my aether, but I didn't receive a vision.

'Dead again?'

No, it's drawing on my aether, but it's not showing me Tessia or Cecilia.

'Well… try someone else, maybe? To make sure it's still working.'

Feeling calmer now, I took a moment to consider my options, but there was only one other person I could think of that I wanted to see, so I thought her name.

White fog rolled around me, and suddenly I was back in the underground sanctuary beneath the desert in Darv. The massive cavern opened up all around me, and there was a small stream at my feet.

Across the stream, my mother sat on a gray log with her feet kicking in the water. Her rich auburn hair—a trait I no longer shared—had

hints of gray throughout, and new wrinkles formed creases under her eyes and over her brows.

I didn't know what I had expected—what I hoped—as I watched my mother, but I silently waited.

It was an odd moment of realization when I thought to myself that Alice wasn't really my mother—not in a conventional way at least. I was an adult long before I was born into this world, with previous memories and experiences that should've deterred me from seeing this woman as a mother-like figure.

Yet, it grew harder and harder to watch her like this, small and alone. Memories of her smile, her laughter, her tears as I navigated my way through this world resurfaced, reminding me that I had never been alone—at least, not in this world.

Suddenly, my mother looked up and let out a sigh. Her lips moved, and even without sound, I could clearly hear what she said.

"How are you doing up there with our son, Rey?"

I felt a cold lump in my throat, and just as I tried to pull away from the vision, a sparkling fish the size of a large trout swam up and nibbled at my mother's toes.

In that moment, I wanted nothing more than to tell her that I was still alive, and that I would keep fighting.

A brief smile flashed across her face, just a tiny upward curve of her lips before the fish zipped away downstream.

But it was enough for me.

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FACE TO FACE

PETRAS LEANED OVER ME, his rancid breath a form of torture in and of itself.

"Poke, poke, poke," he chanted, following each word with a swift thrust of his knife into a different part of my body.

It had been a week since Caera and I had left the Relictombs, and every day had been almost exactly the same.

"This is becoming tedious, Ascender Grey," Matheson said from behind the torturer. "Surely you can see the writing on the wall. Save yourself from two more weeks of pain, and admit to the murders of Lords Kalon and Ezra."

Though the Granbehls' steward kept his face passive, he repeatedly fumbled with the cuffs of his sleeves. Over the last week, I had decided that this was Matheson's tell for when he was becoming frustrated.

"Or," I returned calmly, batting my lashes while gazing doe-eyed at the old man, "you could be a dear and let me go."

Inside me, Regis let out a chortle.

Matheson returned my gaze with a glare of his own, adjusting his sleeves yet again before turning to Petras. "Spend some more time with him. Lord Granbehl has been most…*disappointed* with your service as of late. He expects *results*."

He turned and strode out of the cell, leaving me shackled to the wall. Petras, who was so close he was practically leaning against me, stared after the steward for a long time.

“Well,” he said eventually, his high-pitched voice lower and gloomier than usual, “you heard Master Matheson. We get to spend some extra time together today.”

After another hour of burns, cuts, and the stench of Petras’s breath, the lanky Alacryan seemed to give up. He left without a word or even a backward glance, his arms hanging down at his sides and his steps slow and plodding.

‘I’m actually starting to feel bad for him,’ Regis said, after the torturer was gone. *‘Throw him a bone…give him a grunt or a wince, at least.’*

I stretched out my arms and legs as the wounds quickly healed over. By spending a few hours every day focusing on absorbing aether from the atmosphere, I was able to keep up with the cost of healing the many wounds left by the Granbehls’ torturer.

‘So, another stimulating day spent staring at that toy of yours?’ Regis asked as I reclined on my cot and pulled out the dried-fruit toy. *‘I’m dying to get out and stretch my legs.’*

You know we can’t do that right now, I told him for the tenth time.

A violet claw grew from my finger, and I slid it into the slot at the base of the dried fruit. After rattling the seed around inside until it rested over the hole left by the fruit’s stem, I pulled with the claw.

The aether held for a moment before bending and losing its shape like wet clay.

I sighed before reforming the claw and trying again.

When I’d learned how to use God Step with Three Steps’ help, she had been able to show me how to change my focus and see the

world differently. I was sure that there must also be some kind of mental "trick" to using aether to form a physical shape but I felt stuck in the same pattern, doing the same thing over and over.

Still, it calmed my mind to focus entirely on summoning the aether claw. I spent hours trying to claw out the seed, and even though every attempt was met with failure, I wasn't frustrated by it. It felt *right* somehow, like this was what Three Steps had intended.

Eventually, though, I had to admit when I'd done enough for one day, and stored the toy back into the dimension rune.

Thoughts of Tessia began to drift in the moment I stopped focusing. I had no intention to confront these thoughts right now, and searched for something else to keep me busy.

Habit caused me to withdraw the seeing relic. It was dull and lifeless; I'd used it again only a day ago to check on my sister and mother. First, I tried to find Tessia again, but it failed, just like before. After that, I watched Ellie train with Helen until the stone's power faded.

'There's that goofy grin again. You're thinking about your sister again, huh?' Regis asked, invading my thoughts.

Yeah. She's growing to be a really talented mage, you know? And brave…

'Yet you still worry about her dating life,' Regis grunted.

I groaned. *Enough with the whole overprotective brother label. I would be… glad if she finds a good guy that makes her happy.*

'Tell that to the cot rail you just bent with your bare hand.'

I looked down to see that the metal pipe used to support the cot was dented.

That says nothing, I retorted, straightening out the dense rail.

'Just promise not to force your sister's would-be suitors to beat you in a duel or some crap like that…'

That's actually not a bad—

Halting footsteps on the stairs interrupted our conversation, and I quickly stored the relic and stood, facing the gloomy hallway.

The person standing on the other side was familiar, but she'd changed a lot since I'd seen her last. Enough to feel a pang of guilt.

"Hello, Ada," I said, keeping my tone and expression flat and calm.

The youngest Granbehl sibling had cut her long blonde hair so it was shorter than mine. She'd lost weight, too, making her girlish features sharper and more mature, but also gaunt and sort of… haunted, in a way.

The fact that she'd come to see me wasn't all that surprising; I'd been expecting it. The death of her siblings and her best friend in the Relictombs had been awful, but—although she'd blamed me at the time—she *knew* I didn't kill Kalon, Ezra, or Riah.

The Alacryan girl didn't reply, just watched me with her bright, cold eyes.

'Is she just going to, like, stare at you, or what?' Regis asked. *'It's kind of creepy.'*

I took a slow step toward the door, trying to look as non-threatening as possible. Ada flinched back anyway.

"Ada, listen—"

"No," she said, her voice raw. "I don't want to hear anything you have to say."

"Then why are you here?" I asked simply. If I could get through to Ada, then her blood would have to drop their accusations.

"It's *your* fault…"

I replied with a gentle shake of my head. "I didn't kill them—any of them. You know that, Ada."

"But you did!" Her voice cracked, and I couldn't help but wonder if she hadn't used it much since returning from the Relictombs. "You took us to that place. Y-you knew it would get us all killed!"

Ada's thin face twisted into a grimace as she suppressed the tears building up in her eyes. "You knew…" she repeated, her voice barely a whisper.

I took a deep breath. The truth was, I *had* known that my presence made the Relictombs more dangerous for regular ascenders. And perhaps I hadn't really cared what that meant at the time. These Alacryans were—*are*, I reminded myself—my enemies. Did it really matter if a few died along the way because they couldn't keep up with me? My goal wasn't to make friends or babysit a bunch of mages who would immediately try to kill me if they found out who I really was.

I thought of Kalon's friendly grin and Ezra's protective stance and suspicious glare. Their family—their blood—were the type of people who kept a torturer on staff and jail cells in their basement.

Kalon and Ezra would have likely been just as bad as their father, given time.

'Or maybe they would have turned things around for their blood, you know?' Regis chimed in cheekily. *'I mean… if they'd have survived.'*

Thanks for that, I shot back.

'What's the point of having a voice in your head if it won't give you some perspective?"

Ada, who had been watching me silently as I went back and forth with Regis, took a deep, shuddering breath. “And the w-worst part is, you don’t even *care*. My b-best friend, my brothers, died because of *you*, and you don’t *care*.”

I stared back, expression fixed. “Would you have cared for my death? A total stranger you met only a few days prior?”

“Shut up!” she snapped, her rough-edged voice catching in her throat. “You’re a monster…worse than those creatures in the R-Relictombs…”

“You may be right about that.”

“If you hadn’t been there, Kalon would have kept us all safe! A-and if I hadn’t touched that stupid mirror…” Ada fell silent, her small, pale hands balled up into fists and shoulders trembling.

I let out a sigh, only being able to see her as a wounded child and not as the horrific Alacryan that would’ve made this conversation so much easier.

“It’s not your fault,” I finally said, wondering if I was even entitled to give her comfort.

Ada’s head snapped up, her red-rimmed eyes glaring. “No one said—”

“No, but it’s why you came down here, right? Because at some point in all of this, you stopped believing in your own words.” My gaze fell as I remembered watching everything from within the keystone...stuck and unable to help.

Ada’s brows furrowed as she opened her mouth to reply, but the words stuck in her throat.

I leaned against the wall next to the door and slid down until I was seated on the hard stone. “Contrary to what you might believe after seeing me down at the Relictombs, I’ve managed to live this long and get this far only because of the sacrifices that others have made for me.”

I thought of Sylvia pushing me through the portal as a child, and Sylvie sacrificing her life in order to heal me.

“And every time someone I loved died just so that I could live, I would focus on nothing else but seeking out the ones responsible. Even if it meant chasing after shadows.”

Ada stomped her foot on the stone ground. “Why are you telling me any of this? What’s the point?”

I shrugged. “Because I hope that punishing me for your brothers’ deaths will at least help you feel less guilty for surviving.”

Ada gripped one hand tightly in the other. “I’m not doing this out of guilt! I’m doing this to get revenge for them. For what *you* did to them!”

I waited, letting her yell.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” Tears began to flow freely down her cheeks. “Why are you looking at me like that!”

“Because I've been where you're standing right now, and it's not something I’d wish for anyone to have to go through,” I said quietly.

I listened to her hurried steps as she ran down the hall up and up the stairs, and felt a sobering numbness settle over me.

Staying on the ground, I leaned back against the cold wall as her steps grew fainter. A part of me hoped she’d come back again, but another part found it actually easier to be tortured.

The last footfalls echoed through the halls before a lonely silence filled its place.

What, no snarky commentary, Regis?

'And cut short your well-deserved self-loathing?' Regis responded. *'Even I know when it's not an appropriate time to make an inappropriate remark.'*

I raised a brow. *Is there ever an appropriate time to make an inappropriate remark?*

'Sure, if you're as clever and funny as me.'

329
A PLEA FOR HELP

CAERA DENOIR

"So, I take it that your extended stay in the Denoir's Relictombs estate has been especially… disagreeable," Nessa said as she gently placed my head back.

"It's been… fine," I said calmly, letting my eyes close.

I heard a faint giggle. "Are you sure?"

"Of course I'm sure," I snapped, trying to focus on the suffocating scent of flowers and spices emanating from the plethora of "calming" candles in the bathing room.

"Then can you try telling that to your leg?" Nessa asked, holding in another laugh. "Because at how much you're squirming, I'm afraid you're going to wiggle yourself right out of the tub, Lady Caera."

I peeked an eye open, only now noticing the large puddle of water and fragrant bubbles that had pooled around my bathtub.

Letting out a sigh, I stilled my leg. "Time seems to be moving at a crawl these days, Nessa."

I closed my eyes once more, trying to relax by focusing on the combination of scalding hot water, sweat, and my dead skin topped prettily with aromatic froth.

Meanwhile, Nessa sat at the head of the bath, working scented soap into my hair and massaging my scalp between my horns, which were kept imperceivable by my relic, even if she happened to bump against one.

“Bathing is one of the most potent methods to ease nervousness and soothe muscle fatigue,” Nessa informed me as she continued to work down my hair.

“It feels more like stewing than bathing,” I grumbled back.

“M’hm,” she dismissed, continuing with her work.

Frustration bubbled the more I thought about it. “By the Vritra, I swear I’d leap out of that window and run naked through the streets for another chance to get into the Relictombs.”

“Well, that would certainly get the highlord and lady’s attention,” Nessa replied, and I could hear the smile in her voice.

“And it’s another whole week until the trial. Which, of course, I’m not even allowed to attend,” I continued, sinking a little more deeply into the tub so that the bubbles went up over my chin and mouth.

“We all must follow the highlord and lady’s wishes, after all,” Nessa said simply.

I opened my eyes and blew outward with my mouth, sending bubbles flying. “Perhaps we could—“

The heavy *clang* of our front doorbell interrupted me. Nessa stopped kneading my hair as we both listened.

The muffled sound of unfamiliar voices came from the main foyer.

“Go see who it is, Nessa.”

“Only if you promise not to jump out naked and make a run for the Relictombs, Lady Caera,” my personal attendant said with a grin.

I mustered a smile. “Just go.”

She stood briskly and whisked out of the bathing room, closing the door quietly behind her.

Once she was gone, I slid down under the surface of the water and forced myself to relax, letting my arms float naturally while my body rested lightly on the bottom of the excessively large marble bathtub. My mind floated too, drifting around in the muddle of conflicted thought I'd been trying to sort through for two weeks now.

Scythe Seris's words about Grey kept coming back to me. She seemed to know more than she was telling me, but I couldn't quite puzzle through it, and she'd been firm in denying me more information. My mentor wouldn't budge once she'd made up her mind about something, and I knew better than to push too hard. Everything would come clear in its proper time.

Grey…

I tried to picture his face, but it was the memory of his body pressing gently against mine as we shared his bedroll for warmth that came to my mind.

I shot upright, splashing even more sudsy water onto the marble floor and glaring down at myself. I was Caera Denoir. I did not *pine* for anyone.

Rising, I stepped carefully out of the bath and wrapped a heavy towel around myself just as a small knock came from the door.

Assuming it was my attendant, I said, "I'm not decent, Nessa. A moment."

"There are two men here to see you, Lady Caera," Nessa said softly through the door. "They want to speak to you. About… *him*. They're with your father in the receiving room."

My eyes widened at his mention and I hurried to dry and dress myself.

Someone who knows Grey. They must be here about helping him, I thought as I slid into embroidered white robes. The idea that Grey had friends was unexpected. He had seemed so distant and walled off...

Eager to find out more, I hurried out of the bathing room, but a frantic Nessa threw herself bodily in my way.

"Oh no you don't! You'll have to step over my dead body if you think I'm going to let you go in looking like you just got caught having an illicit affair, Lady Caera."

"You've been reading too many of those novels, Nessa," I scolded her.

She grinned as she fussed with my hair, combing through it with her fingers, then took a moment to straighten the hem of my robes.

Huffing, I waited impatiently for her to finish, then rushed past her to the receiving room, my bare feet padding silently across the thick red rug that ran down the center of the hallway.

I had the good grace to compose myself before stepping through the open doorway, however.

The receiving room was less comfortable than the drawing room, which was intended only for members of our blood, but was more opulent, carefully designed to instill a sense of wonder and awe on the highlord's guests.

Not that we ever had guests or visitors here.

Portraits of severe- looking men and women—previous highlords and ladies, mostly—glowered down from the walls, and several high-backed chairs surrounded an open fireplace that burned either blue or scarlet when it was lit.

Inside the room, I found my adoptive father facing off with the two men. The three were standing, and the fireplace was cold and empty. Although Corbett Denoir's cross-armed stance and haughty scowl were hardly unusual for the highlord, our visitors weren't what I expected.

The first man was older, and thickly built, perhaps once a soldier or even an ascender, but he had clearly let himself go. His gray hair and beard had been heavily oiled and gleamed in the warm receiving room light, and his fine clothes hung from him awkwardly. He watched the highlord restlessly as his companion spoke, and his hands kept patting something inside his jacket.

He was certainly not the type of man who usually called on Highlord Denoir.

His companion, on the other hand, was his opposite in almost every way. Despite Corbett's cold stare, the stranger seemed perfectly at ease. Tall and broad-shouldered, with the easy grace of a trained warrior, he had the air of nobility, but I couldn't recall ever seeing him before. His suit was finely tailored, a muted olive that highlighted his emerald-green eyes and showed off his athletic physique.

"—understand your stance, Highlord Denoir, absolutely," he was saying, "and my companion and I have no wish to put you or your daughter in a politically uncomfortable position, of course, but the life and livelihood of an innocent man hangs in the balance."

The man noticed me enter from the corner of his eye, and he took a step backwards and to the side, turning to greet me without putting

his back to Corbett, which would have been considered rude in noble circles.

My adoptive father glared at me, his sharp gray-green eyes lingering on my bare feet.

"My Lady Caera Denoir," the stranger said, bowing deeply before giving me a wide smile and holding my gaze.

The older man, who had been watching my adoptive father carefully and hadn't immediately sensed my arrival, grunted and spun around. His bow was belated and clumsy, which amused me all the more because of the irritation it caused Corbett.

"Lady Caera," he said, his voice a coarse growl. "I'm Alaric, the ascender Grey's…uh…uncle, and this is Darrin Ordin. We were hoping to speak to you—"

Corbett took a step forward, his arms unfolding and his chest swelling. "Which is something I had not yet agreed to allow." My adoptive father looked imperiously down his nose at me, almost as if he were challenging me to argue with him.

My thoughts, however, were on the old man's words. *Grey's uncle?* I stared at him, looking for any hint of a family resemblance, but there was none. Though he dressed well, Alaric wouldn't have looked out of place passed out in the corner of some seedy bar somewhere.

From Corbett's pinch-nosed expression of displeasure, I could tell he was thinking something similar.

I met the highlord's eye. "Just as well that I stumbled in then, Father, if I had guests." To Darrin, I said, "Why do I feel as though I've heard your name before?"

The man grinned and ran a hand through his fine blond hair. “I’m an ascender. Mostly retired, now, but I achieved a little fame—”

“Of course!” I said, interrupting him and earning myself another glare from my adoptive father, which I ignored. “You were the lead Striker for the Unblooded party, weren’t you?”

His brows shot up in surprise, but the grin Darrin gave me seemed genuinely pleased. “It’s an honor to be recognized by a member of Highblood Denoir, Lady Caera. I did not expect to—”

“These men,” Corbett’s voice boomed, cutting through our conversation, “have come to beg for your testimony regarding the events of your most recent ascent.”

Everyone fell silent as our attention turned to the highlord. “But, as I have already told them,” he continued, “it is our wish that you not be drawn into this trial.”

I opened my mouth to reply, but he quickly carried on, addressing Alaric. “While your…nephew’s position is unfortunate, sir, Highblood Denoir is not responsible for either his actions, or those of Blood Granbehl. Perhaps your time would be better spent speaking to them directly.”

“With all due respect, Highlord Denoir,” Darrin replied, “Lady Caera is, from what I’ve been led to believe, the only witness aside from Grey and the young Lady Ada Granbehl, whose testimony we believe to be suspect. Justice demands—”

Corbett’s brow rose and he gave the man a withering look. “Even justice may not make demands of me here, under my own roof. Our blood has already discussed this matter, and the decision has been made. You’ve wasted your time, and mine.”

I certainly did not agree to any such thing, I thought, my nails digging into my palms as I clenched my fists.

"Don't be so quick to dismiss our guests, *Father*," I said, forcing a smile. "Darrin Ordin is a famous ascender. He led a very successful group of ascenders from unnamed bloods. Surely we can afford a few moments to hear him out."

Corbett wrinkled his nose, as if I'd just told him Darrin was a wogart farmer. "Yes, well, be that as it may, I'm afraid we can't help with his current request."

"On the contrary, I think we could be most helpful," I countered, careful to keep my voice even. "Honestly, it's almost as if you're *afraid* of these Granbehls…but they're just a named blood, so I'm sure that's not true."

Corbett's jaw tightened, but otherwise he didn't display the anger I knew was building within him. "We have discussed this, Caera, and you know where I stand. Should you feel the need, we may continue with our *discussion* after our guests have left."

Darrin Ordin cleared his throat. "We apologize for the intrusion. We'll see ourselves out, Highlord Denoir."

"Much gratitude for your time," Alaric grumbled, already shuffling sideways toward the door.

The snapping of a panel on the far side of the receiving room made everyone turn suddenly, but it was only Lenora.

My adoptive mother was dressed comfortably in dark green robes embroidered with golden runes. The outfit wasn't actually magical, but the runes made it look powerful and authoritative anyway.

She smiled warmly at our guests. “Excuse me, I’m so sorry to intrude. You wouldn’t mind if I shared a brief word with my husband, of course?”

Darrin bowed deeply and flashed Lenora a charming smile. “Of course not, Lady Denoir, but I’m afraid we were just leaving—”

“That won’t be necessary, at least, not at this very instant. We’ll just be a moment.” With these last words, she shot Corbett a meaningful look and held out her arm to him.

The highlord moved stiffly, a muscle twitching in his jaw as he swept past Lenora and disappeared through the panel at the back of the room, which functioned much like a servants’ entrance.

She shot our guests a dazzling smile as she let her arm fall to her side before following her husband from the room.

Knowing I might only have a moment or two before they returned, I stepped closer to Darrin and Alaric. “Are you really Grey’s uncle?” I asked the old man, who was eyeing me warily.

“Isn’t it obvious by my sharp and chiseled features?” he asked, a smirk tugging at the edge of his dry lips.

Darrin rolled his eyes at this, dropping his formal demeanor. “It’s about as obvious as an infant shadow prowler hiding in the dark.”

I let out a chuckle at their banter. “Excuse me. I didn’t mean to be rude.”

“No, being rude is this old man’s forte,” Darrin replied. “But I digress. You should know, Lady Caera, that this man’s nephew wouldn’t—”

“No,” I agreed, “he wouldn’t. Grey can be… dispassionate, when he needs to be, but he’s no murderer. The others died fighting, through

no fault of Grey's at all. In fact, he saved Ada's life." *Which I told him was a bad idea*, I thought icily.

Grey's uncle pulled a flask from his breast pocket and unscrewed the cap with practiced ease before taking a drink. His bleary eyes darted to the open panel across the room before he took one more. "It certainly would've saved us from all of this trouble if my nephew hadn't, but he's a kind-hearted block of ice."

I nodded, a smile forming on my lips as I recounted all of Grey's bullish moments. "That he is." I paused for a moment, hesitant to ask the question that had been on the tip of my tongue for a while now. "Have you been close to Grey since he was young?"

What was he like when he was a child? I actually wanted to ask.

"He's been my responsibility since becoming an ascender," Alaric responded, taking another large sip from his flask. "It's just a shame that he's run into trouble with named bloods, especially leeches like the Granbehls, nobles who are willing to do anything and everything to climb higher, no matter who they step on. Which, I realize, describes most named and highbloods—"

Darrin Ordin elbowed the older man in his side sharply.

He scratched his beard. "No offense."

I had heard the accusation in his tone. "It just so happens that I agree with your assessment of the noble bloods. And I would like nothing more than to act as a witness on his behalf, but Highlord Denoir won't allow it," I shot back defensively.

Darrin Ordin rested a hand on the old man's shoulder. "We understand, Lady Caera, and wouldn't ask you to go against the wishes of your blood."

Alaric rolled his eyes, but didn't say anything else. There were so many things I wanted to know, questions I had hoped to ask, but at that moment Corbett strode back into the receiving room, with Lady Lenora at his side, her arm lightly tucked into his.

"After further consideration, Highblood Denoir has decided to offer our assistance in the matter of Ascender Grey's trial," he announced, the very picture of a magnanimous lord granting a boon.

I peered at my adoptive parents, trying to get some sense of why they'd suddenly changed their mind, and Lenora met my eyes with a strange, knowing smile that I didn't like.

"An agent will bring Caera's statement, and whatever other documentation we may discover that would be of benefit to your case, on the day of the trial," Corbett continued. "Until then, it would be best that you not draw further attention to Highblood Denoir by returning here again."

Alaric fidgeted, frowning slightly under his beard, but Darrin gave Corbett a deep, sweeping bow. "Thank you, Highlord Denoir. It is as much as we could ask for."

"As much and more," Corbett replied dismissively, already turning away. "Nessa!"

My attendant, who had been hovering just outside in the hall, hurried into the receiving room, her eyes on the cut-marble floor.

"See our guests out."

Darrin Ordin bowed yet again, followed clumsily by Alaric, and then both men followed Nessa out into the hall.

When we were alone, I faced my adoptive parents. "What was that?"

Corbett waved a hand so that the fire burst to life, burning a deep, bloody scarlet that reflected off the white walls and floor. Turning his back on me, he strode across the room and poured himself a glass of water from a crystal container.

Lenora walked to the doorway and peered down the hall, making sure our visitors had gone. When she turned back, she wore a gleeful smile. "It appears, dearest Caera, that your mentor and our patron, Scythe Seris Vritra, has expressed some interest in this ascender of yours."

Having spoken at length with Scythe Seris regarding Grey, this wasn't exactly news to me. But I didn't immediately catch on to my adoptive mother's meaning.

"It appears your relationship with this man could have some value to Highblood Denoir after all," Corbett proclaimed seriously.

I looked between them, their sudden change of mind starting to make sense. "You want him to be indebted to Highblood Denoir… for your assistance in freeing him," I said slowly.

Lenora moved to Corbett's side and slipped her arm through his. "If he is of value to Scythe Seris, then he may be worth the trouble, yes."

Of value to Scythe Seris…

"But when he was just of value to me?" I said coldly, my throat tightening around the words. "Then you were happy to let the Granbehls have him?"

"Oh, don't be that way, Caera," Lenora said, waving as if my words were a bad smell she could waft away. "You get what you want, in the end—and your blood benefits as well."

They didn't know the kind of fire they were playing with. I shivered as I remembered the ice-cold fury that had settled over me like a physical presence when Grey discovered my true identity. He could have killed me in a second, I knew that as clearly as I knew that there was Vritra blood running through my veins

We had grown comfortable together, but I was certain I hadn't yet fully gained his trust. If he thought I was somehow manipulating him…

"Smile, dear," Lenora said, displaying her own gleaming white teeth. "This could end up working out wonderfully for us."

I stared dead-pan at the woman.

"You should be more grateful to your mother," Corbett said, setting his glass down heavily so that water splashed over the rim. "While you've been moping around the house, she learned that House Granbehl seems to have some kind of back-channel dealings going on to ensure this ascender's guilty verdict."

He held up a hand to keep me silent. "I need you to understand your role in this, Caera. If Highblood Denoir is to expend time and capital, both financial and political, to assist this ascender, I must be assured that he will fully appreciate just where his aid came from.

"You will be allowed to contact him… *after* the trial, and invite him to our estate in Central Dominion. Then, we can discuss our blood's plans for the future, and where Grey fits into those plans."

Although I was seething on the inside, outwardly I smiled as Lenora had suggested. "As you wish, of course."

Their conversation turned to the Granbehls' schemes, and what Scythe Seris might want with Grey. I stayed and listened, not

wanting my adoptive parents to form any plans behind my back. I would need to know exactly what they were up to, if I wished to help Grey avoid exchanging one prison for another.

330
THE HIGH HALL

THE THREE WEEKS until my trial passed in a blur of repetition and monotony.

When the morning came, I was spared the usual session of torture with Petras and Matheson, and even allowed a cold shower to wipe away the blood and grime of my three week stay in the Granbehls' dungeon. I guess they didn't want it to be too obvious that I'd been deprived and tortured.

Ada, thankfully or not, hadn't come to visit me again, but I guessed I'd be seeing her soon enough at the trial.

I was sitting cross-legged on the floor, Three Steps' dried-fruit toy held firmly in one hand. The index finger of the other hand had sprouted a curved claw of violet aether, which was currently wrapped around the seed within the fruit, pulling desperately at it.

I'd held the claw's shape for ten seconds already, but the seed wasn't budging. Twenty seconds passed. Then thirty. My finger began to ache and tremble, and I could feel the claw losing its shape.

Finally, after nearly forty seconds, the aether claw dissipated with the seed still lodged firmly inside the dried fruit.

"What is *that*?"

My eyes snapped open to find Matheson staring through the bars at me. I'd been so focused on holding the aether claw's shape that I hadn't heard him arrive.

I flourished my hand, rolling the toy out of sight before storing it in my dimension rune, then cupped one hand over the other.

“Oh… you mean this?” I said innocently while slowly sticking up the middle finger of the hand I was hiding in my palm.
Regis barked out a laugh.
Matheson scowled and stepped aside so four Granbehl knights could open my cell door and march in to surround me. The tallest of the four pulled my arms behind my back and put manacles around my wrists.
“Search him,” Matheson ordered, and the same knight proceeded to give me a thorough patting down, but of course found nothing. He shrugged his armor-plated shoulders at the steward.
“I hope you’re enjoying yourself, Ascender Grey,” he said quietly. “I myself am very much looking forward to seeing that infuriating smirk slapped off your smug face.”
“Can we get going then?” I asked. “I sure wouldn’t want to be late for that.”
Matheson adjusted the cuffs of his sleeves and marched past, leading the way up the stairs and through the well-appointed halls of the mansion above. A few household servants peered at us from various rooms as we made our way out of the Granbehl estate, but the only familiar face I noticed was Petras, who was sitting on some barrels near the backdoor that I was led out of.
I gave him a cheery smile as I passed by. “We shed so much blood, sweat, and your tears together that I’m almost going to miss you.”
My words made the torturer practically fold in on himself in shame, while Matheson chortled in disgust.
‘Way to kick a man when he’s down,’ Regis said accusingly.

I rolled my eyes. *Forgive me for lacking sympathy to the guy that spent the last three weeks cutting me open.*

'Well, if we only judged by your reaction, I'd say poor Petras did nothing more than give you a rigorous massage,' Regis noted. *'But that's beside the point. You're awfully chipper for a guy on the way to his own murder trial.'*

I felt genuine curiosity radiating from the little ball of warmth that was my companion.

I'm just about ready to burn this damn place to the ground. We'll see how things play out with whatever Alaric is up to, but whatever happens, I don't plan on coming back here.

'I call dibs on Matty.'

Several more heavily armed and armored Granbehl guards met us outside the house, and I was escorted to another cart like the one in which I'd been brought here.

Lord Granbehl was standing beside the door, his hands clasped behind his back. He lifted his chin as I approached. "This will be your last opportunity to confess your crimes, Ascender Grey. Admit your guilt, and I will plead for leniency on your behalf. If you stand before a panel of judges and profess your innocence, it will be out of my hands."

I locked eyes with the Alacryan nobleman. "Thank you for your *wonderful* hospitality, Titus."

He ground his teeth as we matched glares, but eventually he waved a hand, and I was shoved bodily into the carriage.

This time there were two knights seated inside, each with a naked blade trained on me. Even if one of the guards turned out to be

Alaric, there was no way he could let me know without giving himself away, and so I stayed quiet. Mostly.

I let out a sigh, leaning back in my seat. "They could have at least given me a carriage with windows."

One of the guards shifted awkwardly on the narrow bench across from me, which was obviously meant for luggage, not a fully armored knight.

"I guess you fine gentlemen are still a better sight than my dingy cell and ever-attractive Petras," I continued with a shrug.

The other guard stifled a laugh while the first raised his blade so the point pressed into my throat. "Be quiet."

'Do you think everyone that works for the Granbehls is trained to be an ass, or do they need previous experience as an ass to qualify?' Regis asked.

This time, it was my turn to stifle a laugh.

"You think this is funny?" The guard holding his blade against my throat twisted the shortsword and lashed out with the pommel, driving it into the corner of my mouth. "Make another sound, and I'll give you the other end, scum."

'Yup. This guy definitely likes to kick puppies.'

I smiled as I ran my tongue across the cut that had already begun to heal, tasting blood.

"Vritra, he's as freaky as they've been saying," the second guard said. He sounded young, and more than a little nervous.

Neither are Alaric, then, I thought, regarding the knight coolly.

“You heard the rumors, Roffe? They say someone’s been stirring up all kinds of trouble around this ascender. Some of the guards think he’s secretly from a highblood house, and they’re—”

“Would you shut up?” the guard who’d hit me, Roffe, snarled. “We’re supposed to guard, not chit chat like a couple of academy girls.”

The second knight went silent.

So, someone is starting rumors? That has to be Alaric, I thought, frowning. *What’s that old drunk think he’s doing, going head to head with a named blood?*

‘Securing his investment, I’d imagine,’ Regis suggested.

Let’s just hope that he knows what he’s getting himself into, I thought, leaning slightly to the side and trying to get comfortable, which wasn’t easy considering my hands were still chained behind me.

The rest of the carriage ride went by quickly. Within a few minutes, we rolled to a stop and someone knocked three times on the outside of the door. Roffe knocked back twice, and the door opened.

Without waiting for them to push or pull me out, I hopped down to the ground on my own, causing the closest armored figures to step back and brandish their weapons.

Looking past them, I took in the building they were leading me to. Even without any cultural touchstone to compare it to, the massive structure was immediately recognizable as a courthouse.

The dark stone building was covered in ornate decoration: colored glass filled the arched windows, leering, horned gargoyles leaned out from the walls and glared at all who approached, and hundreds

of thin, black metal spires reached up toward the sunless blue sky above.

Matheson appeared from between two of the many armored guards standing around the carriage. “Beautiful, isn’t it?” he said, looking up at the courthouse. “Like the Sovereigns’ own justice carved in stone.”

I snorted, drawing an irritated look from the steward.

“Get this criminal inside,” he snapped.

I was pushed and prodded forward, under an arched entryway and into a grand hall. The inside of the courthouse was just as ornate as the outside: the floor was cut marble, the grand stairs that led up to a second floor landing was wrought of the same dark iron as the spires, and an enormous fresco covered the entire ceiling.

It showed a muscular, bare-chested man with grayish skin and sweeping horns that curved around his head like a crown standing amidst dozens of much smaller, less detailed people. Colorful motes of light were drifting down from him and being absorbed into the gathered crowd, whose faces were upturned gleefully. A ring of runes encircled the painting.

Agrona, giving magic to the Alacryans…

‘Do you think the part where Agrona tortured and experimented on the Alacryans for a bajillion years is drawn on the backside?’ Regis asked.

“‘Under the watchful gaze of the High Sovereign, all beings are judged,’” Matheson said, reading the curved runes.

I was about to say something flippant, but a jolt from Regis cut me short.

What is it?

'Remember, you're an Alacryan. It wouldn't be a good look for you to go demeaning Agrona in public, especially here, now.'

I thought for a moment. *Mm...Good catch.*

A hunched figure in thick, black robes with a golden symbol on the breast approached and exchanged a few words with Matheson. I couldn't see their face, which was hidden in shadow beneath the cowl of the robe, but I could sense probing eyes on me.

The symbol showed a sword with scales hanging from the crossguard, and must have labeled them as some kind of court official.

They waved for us to follow and led the procession of guards, Matheson, and myself, down a long, high-peaked corridor that ended in two solid stone doors, each at least ten feet tall and four feet wide.

As we approached, the doors opened by themselves, revealing a courtroom capable of seating a few hundred people, at least.

It was designed like an amphitheater: half-moon shaped, with a series of ebony benches ascending in steps around a platform along the flat side, where five high desks, each emblazoned with the same golden symbol as the official's robes, looked down on a single chair made of twisted black metal.

The dark-robed figure led us down an aisle between the benches, all of which were empty at the moment, and gestured to the chair. Two of the knights shoved me into it, and heavy black chains came to life and wrapped around my wrists, ankles, waist, and neck. The chains were blisteringly cold to the touch.

I flexed carefully, keeping the motion subtle so no one thought I was trying to break free. The chains constricted around me like a snake, their burning cold surface biting into my flesh and threatening to choke me.

The dark-robed official leaned forward so that we were face to face. Beneath the shadowed cowl, a young woman with dark eyes stared back at me. “The more you struggle, the stronger the chains grow, ascender. Be still, and let only truth pass your lips in this place. Only guilty men fear the High Hall’s justice.”

More out of curiosity than anything else, I relaxed to see if the chains would slacken. They did.

“Good,” she said, straightening. “The trial will begin shortly. The rest of you may find seats, or stand along the back wall.”

There was a lot of clanking and rattling as the heavily armored guards maneuvered to the back of the room. At least thirty of them had escorted my carriage, and Matheson had brought every one of them into the courthouse.

I turned my head slightly and caught sight of the Granbehls’ steward sitting on the closest bench to my left. He was inspecting me carefully, his eyes following the crisscrossing network of chains.

The babble of voices and low thunder of dozens of footsteps on marble drew his attention to the back of the room. He glowered, apparently not liking whatever he saw there.

I listened carefully, trying to pick up snippets of the many conversations happening behind me.

“—to prove murder in the Relictombs. What are the Granbehls—”

“—exciting, isn’t it? I’ve never been in the High Hall before—”

“—that him? Oh, wow, he’s so handsome, I—”
“—cousin heard from one of their guards that he never even blinked when Lord Granbehl beat him—”
I snapped around, looking warily to my right as heavy steps approached. A large, blond man in a gray suit was moving purposely toward me. His bright green eyes squinted into a smile when they met mine.
“Grey,” he said, his voice a rumbling baritone. He gave me a jaunty grin. “Comfortable?”
“Not really,” I admitted. Another man was behind him, dressed in an ill-fitting charcoal suit.
“Alaric,” I said in surprise. “Are you sure you should be here?”
The ex-ascender raised an eyebrow. “Who do you think’s going to get you out of this mess if not me, nephew?”
“Well, if I were to put my bets on just appearances, I’d go with the gentleman that doesn’t look like he was still nursing a hangover,” I said with a faint smirk.
“My dearest nephew indeed.” Alaric rolled his eyes before nodding his head toward his companion. “Grey, this is Darrin Ordin. Ex-ascender like me, and once a pupil of mine. He makes it a habit of helping out other, less fortunate ascenders.”
I gave the man a second look. His clothes were perfectly tailored and made of a fine wool that must have cost a fortune. He didn’t have the athlete-gone-to-pasture look like Alaric, and I couldn’t help but wonder how retired he really was.
Mostly, though, it was the way he carried himself that made his wealth obvious: confident, straight-backed but not stiff, and an

unconcerned air. Alaric, on the other hand, looked so out of place in the High Hall that it was almost comical.

Darrin was scanning the seats behind me, the hint of a frown on his face. “I’ve been fortunate, that’s true,” he said, turning his attention back to me. “I just try to make sure others who choose the life of an ascender—those who don’t have the backing of a high or named blood—have someone looking after them…but we can talk about me later,” he added, his attention turning to the tall desks that looked down on my chair.

Five robed figures had entered from a door I couldn’t see, and were each moving to stand behind a desk, elevated several feet above me. They wore matching black robes, similar to the woman who’d guided us to the courtroom, but their hoods were down, revealing five gaunt, humorless mages.

The man at the central desk hammered a gavel, causing the room to hush suddenly. I could hear the muffled noises of people hurrying to sit behind me, then the resounding crash of the huge double doors slamming shut.

“So begins of the trial of Ascender Grey, blood unnamed, on the charges of murder,” the judge announced in a rasping voice.

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THE TRIAL

"THIS TRIAL SHALL BE ADJUDICATED by High Judge Blackshorn, Judge Tenema, Judge Falhorn, Judge Harcrust, and Judge Frihl," the central judge, apparently High Judge Blackshorn, said as the five black-robed Alacryans took their seats.

"The purpose of this trial," he continued in his slow, clear voice, "is to determine the truth of whether Ascender Grey"—he gestured to me, chained in the black chair—"murdered Lord Kalon of Blood Granbehl, Lord Ezra of Blood Granbehl, and Lady Riah of Blood Faline."

"And," he added after a short pause, "to decide upon an appropriate punishment, should the ascender be found guilty."

Whispered conversations drifted down from the onlookers behind me, but my focus was on the judges as they began shuffling through documents laid out on their desks. High Judge Blackshorn was an older man, in his seventies at least. There were dark smudges under his deep-set eyes and mottled gray spots across his wrinkled scalp.

'He looks like he could drop dead any second now,' Regis said.

Knowing my luck, they'd probably blame me for that too, I replied.

Regis snorted, his incorporeal form radiating amusement.

Blackshorn cleared his throat. "Judge Tenema will provide a procedural briefing."

Tenema was even older than Blackshorn, with thin white hair that seemed to float around her head and thick glasses that magnified her eyes to cartoonish proportions.

She tried to speak, coughed, then tried again. “This panel will hear opening statements from both Blood Granbehl and Ascender Grey’s council, after which witnesses will be called.” Her voice cracked and faded as she spoke, the volume fluctuating. “If there is physical evidence of the crimes, it will then be provided, followed by closing statements and this panel’s deliberation.”

The old woman took a deep, rattling breath as she finished, as if the effort of saying those few sentences had exhausted her.

Judge Harcrust, the youngest of the judges, was staring at the old woman, his nose wrinkled in disgust. His blue-black hair and goatee reflected the cold light of the lighting artifacts and gave his face a severe, humorless look.

Blackshorn nodded to Tenema. “Now, the representative for Blood Granbehl may stand and provide their opening statement.”

Unsurprisingly, it was Matheson who stood and addressed the judges. “Thank you, High Judge.”

He stepped forward just within my peripheral view before continuing, his voice projected so the people behind us could hear him clearly. “As we all know, ascenders are the fists that swing the swords of our progress. Those who risk themselves to search for relics of our past—hidden within the Relictombs by the devious ancient mages—have always been treated with respect in Alacrya, even with love and adoration.

“Ascending through the Relictombs is a time-honored tradition of our people, a role that directly serves the will of our High Sovereign himself. When the Ascenders Association tests prospective mages,

they aren't just assuring their strength of body, but the power of their will and the pureness of their hearts, as well."

Matheson let his voice fall, giving the silent crowd a crestfallen glance over his shoulder.

"Which is why it is so rare that there is violence between ascenders in the Relictombs…and why it is so tragic to be standing here today, discussing the unfortunate loss of three young mages, all named bloods, pillars of the common folk. Their families rose up to nobility to give them bright futures," Matheson pointed a trembling finger at me. "Futures that were taken from them by this man!"

"Ascender Grey lied to the young Granbehls, assuring them that he was on his preliminary ascent in order to gain their trust and access to the Relictombs—but within, they found a hellish nightmare zone full of creatures far beyond their expectations for a mere preliminary ascent, which of course was *exactly* what Grey wanted."

Matheson gazed imploringly up at the five judges. "I have seen with my own eyes the callousness, the lack of empathy, shown by this man over the last three weeks. Despite my lord's pleading, Grey has refused to acknowledge his own crimes, or to show even a flicker of regret at the deaths he caused."

Regis let out a chortle. *'Huh...didn't know the words "torturing" and "pleading" were interchangeable.'*

"Whether by malice, hostility, or base cruelty, we can show this court with certainty that Ascender Grey led Kalon, Ezra, and Riah to their deaths, purposefully and with motive."

Matheson spun around toward the crowd, his robes swirling dramatically. "It is for this reason," he said, practically shouting,

“that Blood Granbehl asks for the harshest possible sentence for this terrible crime: public execution!”

A number of voices broke out in surprised muttering, but the courtroom was quickly silenced by the hammering of Blackshorn’s gavel.

“Silence!” the old man ordered to the already quieting room, the word ringing like an echo of the gavel. His droopy eyes scanned the courtroom before he spoke again, turning to the steward. “Thank you Master Matheson, you may be seated.”

My gaze followed the steward as he walked back to his seat. His facade faltered as our eyes locked, and he flinched before looking nervously away.

“Next, we will hear the opening statement from Ascender Grey, to be made by…” The high judge leaned toward a scroll he was reading from, his wrinkled brow creasing as he frowned down at it.

Blackshorn turned to Falhorn, sitting to his right. “Is this accurate?”

Judge Falhorn was a large man with graying auburn hair and a pockmarked face. He leaned forward and whispered something to Blackshorn, who peered down and to my right, his face twitching.

“We call Darrin Ordin to make Grey’s opening statements.” I could have been wrong, but there was something distinctly grumpy about the way the high judge said Alaric’s friend’s name.

The man stepped confidently forward, straightening his suit as he stood on my right side, and a burst of noise rippled through the people in the stands, prompting another hammer of Blackshorn’s gavel.

“This is a courtroom, not a combat arena,” he said, glowering around.

Darrin half turned and gave a little wave to the audience before addressing the judges. “My counterpart would have you believe that they have proof of some malicious intention on Ascender Grey’s behalf, that he set out to kill these three young ascenders. He has painted Grey as a cold-hearted murderer, bereft of any redeeming qualities.

“But do the Granbehls have any proof of their accusations?” he asked, his voice ringing through the courtroom. “Even after being allowed by *this court* to hold Ascender Grey in their own private dungeon, with no oversight from the High Hall and no access to his own council, during which time the Granbehls tortured him *every single day*, they don’t have even a speck of evidence to show for it.”

Darrin stepped closer and rested his hand on my shoulder. “If Grey intended the deaths of these young ascenders, why did he rescue Lady Ada? Surely if he were capable of murdering the famed Kalon Granbehl, then his younger sister wouldn’t have posed a challenge. And how would a first-time ascender know how the Relictombs would react to his presence, even if the Granbehls could prove that the supposed difficulty of these zones was directly influenced by Grey’s presence?”

The courtroom had gone deadly quiet as my council spoke, and I could tell the audience was soaking up every word. The judges, on the other hand, appeared anything but compelled.

Blackshorn’s natural grumpiness had sagged into a glower. Tenema, on the other hand, had a dreamy expression as her eyes travelled

slowly over the faces in the crowd. Beside her, Harcrust was twirling his goatee like a storybook evil wizard, his dark eyes locked on Darrin. Falhorn's fat face was bent low over a document, ignoring our opening statement entirely, but it was Judge Frihl that really caught my attention.

Frihl had been quiet so far, but now he seemed to be talking to himself in a quiet but furious diatribe. The other judges were ignoring him, and Darrin's voice easily carried over Frihl's, but it was slightly disturbing to watch.

"The sad truth is," Darrin continued, "the Relictombs are a dangerous place, even for those of us who have stepped through an ascension portal dozens of times before. All it takes is a moment's overconfidence, a single missed step… and sometimes not even that. Every ascender has a story about ending up in a zone they weren't prepared for. At least, those who make it out alive."

"There is no evidence that suggests this was anything but a tragedy. No foul play, no murder plot, just a preliminary ascent gone wrong. For Blood Granbehl to make baseless claims against Grey threatens the very institution on which ascents are based: the trust and faith in each other that every ascender must have."

Darrin returned to his seat while the judges exchanged looks that varied from exasperated to completely hostile.

'Did this Ordin guy piss on all their mothers' graves or something?'

There's clearly some kind of history there, I agreed, wondering if that would end up being a good or bad thing for me.

I assumed someone would ask for me to speak, or make a statement of my own, especially since I'd never even met the man now

defending me before the trial, but so far no one had addressed me directly at all.

Judge Tenema flinched at a small tap on her shoulder from Blackshorn. Her bleary, magnified eyes widened, and she shuffled quickly through the notes on her desk..

"Yes, yes, witnesses, of course." The ancient woman cleared her throat and she peered down at a scroll. "As the first witness, the panel calls—"

Darrin was on his feet again already. "With all due respect to the esteemed panel of judges, I believe written testimony is to be read before calling witnesses—"

The sound of the gavel cut Darrin off. "We do, in fact, know our own rules," Blackshorn said coldly. "However, there are no written statements to read, Ordin. Please, Judge Tenema, continue."

Darrin Ordin's jaw clenched, and I caught him shoot another quick look around the room before taking his seat.

"Where was I…" The old judge was quiet for a while before she let out a croaky "Aha!" and continued. "We call upon our first witness, Gytha of Blood Algere."

'Who the heck is that?'' Regis asked as I racked my brain to remember a Gytha.

I couldn't recall the name, but I recognized the thin, black-haired woman immediately when she stepped up in front of the judges.

The official who took our information before letting us into the Relictombs…

Falhorn leaned forward, looking down over the edge of his tall desk at her. "You are Gytha, of Blood Algere?"

“I am,” she answered. The woman was standing awkwardly, hands clasped together in front of her, wide eyes staring up at the judges.
“And you are familiar with the defendant, Grey?” Falhorn’s voice was croaky and wheezing at the same time, like a bullfrog that had just been stepped on.
“I’m a clerk, and I took the Granbehl party’s information before they entered the Relictombs, including Ascender Grey.” The woman’s eyes flicked to me as she said my alias. She looked absolutely terrified.
“And what was your impression of this ascender at the time?” Falhorn attempted a friendly smile, but it came across as aggressively hungry, just making him look more like an overgrown toad.
The Relictombs official glanced at me again, wringing her hands. “I thought it strange that someone with no blood would be traveling with such high company. The older brother, Kalon… well, he seemed comfortable enough, but the younger brother kept shooting what I thought were angry glances at Grey, and I got the distinct impression he didn’t really want him there.”
I couldn’t help but notice how both she and the judge entirely avoided mention of Haedrig, or Caera. *That can’t be a coincidence*, I thought.
“And what of Grey himself?” Falhorn probed.
“He was quiet, standoffish. Maybe even a little uncomfortable. Like… like he was hiding something.”
I closed my eyes and let out a sigh.
“I see. Thank you, Gytha. You may leave.”

Darrin jumped to his feet. “Judge Falhorn, I would like the opportunity to question the—”

“In the interest of time,” Blackshorn interrupted, “only the judges will be given the opportunity to ask questions of these witnesses.”

I caught my council’s look of confusion from the corner of my eye. Clearly, this wasn’t normally how an Alacryan trial would proceed.

The chains tightened around me, making me realize I’d been unconsciously flexing against them, and my aetheric intent was leaking out into the room so that the judges, Matheson, and even my own council eyed me warily.

“Check those bindings,” Harcrust snapped, and a black robed figure rushed over to examine the chair and chains. They nodded and returned to their post beside the row of high desks.

I forced myself to take a deep breath and released the arms of the chair, holding my hands loose and relaxed as I leaned back against the cold iron.

By the time I turned my attention back to the proceedings, Gytha had vanished, and Judge Tenema was calling a second witness. “Would Quinten, blood unnamed, please come forward?”

Another name I didn’t recognize, until I saw the man enter my line of sight as he made his way toward the judges. He had exchanged his dark leather armor for black pants and a loose tunic, and he limped slightly as he walked.

Quinten…

I scoffed aloud as I remembered my first moments in the second level of the Relictombs, when a friendly young ascender led me into an alley and tried to mug me.

'Why the hell would they be calling him as a witness?' Regis asked angrily.

Ignoring my companion, I watched the crook with both amusement and annoyance as he stepped up before the judges.

"You are Quinten, blood unnamed, and an ascender?" It was Harcrust who asked the questions this time. His nasally voice practically oozed self-importance.

"Retired ascender, Judge," Quinten said, his voice weak and tired. "But yes, I'm Quinten. No blood name, as I'm just a nobody from a little village in Vechor."

"And why, may I ask, has a young, strapping man such as yourself been forced to retire?" Harcrust continued.

Quinten rubbed at his leg and gave the judge a pained look. "A few weeks ago, I had a run in with another ascender—this man, Grey—right here on the second level. He tricked me into thinking he was a woga—a, uh, first timer, and needed some help finding his way around."

He took a deep breath and let it out as a sigh. "I believed him, of course, and showed him around a bit—not expecting anything in return, just being friendly—but when we were off the main road, he knocked me out, stripped me… naked… and tied me up."

Harcrust's scowl deepened as Quinten spoke. "Despicable. And what happened then?"

Quinten shot me a furtive glance, like he was afraid to be standing on the same platform, and swallowed theatrically. "He threatened me… tortured me. Shattered my leg, so I can't risk going back into the Relictombs…"

“And why did he torture you? What did Grey want?”

“He wanted to know about the Granbehls, Judge—”

The sound of shearing metal cut across the proceedings as I accidentally ripped one iron armrest free of the chair. The chains constricted around me, pinning my arms down even more tightly and burning my skin with their cold.

Quinten leapt away from me, no longer limping, and Harcrust paled as he took in the damage to the chair.

Turning, he scowled at the hooded official. “Are you *quite* sure the mana suppression is working properly?”

I couldn’t hear the official’s muffled words over the blood pounding in my head.

‘Boss…’ Regis’s anxious worry leaked out into me, pulling me back from the precipice of my own anger.

I scanned the judges’ startled, fearful faces before dropping the broken piece of chair. It thudded heavily against the floor, resounding through the chamber.

Finally, the chains slackened as I stopped pushing back against them, letting me breathe again.

Harcrust cleared his throat before asking, “And why do you think Grey wanted to know about the Granbehls?”

Quinten was gaping at the twisted piece of metal on the ground. Harcrust cleared his throat again, making the pale, sweaty ascender flinch. “I-I was too afraid to think properly at the time,” he blurted out, stumbling over his words, “but… it, um, became clear afterward that he had something bad planned for them. I wish I’d have come

forward earlier, but…he'd threatened to kill me if I told anyone about any of it."

Harcrust was nodding along, as if Quinten's story made perfect sense. "No one blames you, Ascender Quinten. But we do appreciate you being here today. Standing in front of your attacker and speaking the truth required great courage, but finding justice always does. You may leave now."

Quinten gave a stiff bow and turned to leave. For an instant, our eyes met, and there was a twinkling amusement there, and a twitching at the corners of his mouth that could have been a smirk, but it was erased by my cold glare. He forgot to limp again as he hurried away.

Darrin had stepped forward once again. "I'd like to call for a brief recess to speak to Grey, so that we might appropriately refute this witness's claims," he said, his voice constricted with forced calm.

High Judge Blackshorn scoffed. "You've had three weeks to arrange your refutations. In the interest of time, we will not be recessing until deliberation, and only then if necessary for the judges to pass their final decision."

Darrin clenched his fists and gave a shallow bow before returning to his seat. I could hear him and Alaric whispering back and forth, but couldn't make out what was being said. There was some conversation from the crowd, too, but it was silenced by a hard look from Blackshorn.

Tenema cleared her throat. "Would the final witness, Lady Ada Granbehl, please step forward."

Ada appeared from my left, but she wasn't alone. Both her mother and father walked beside her, Lord Granbehl's thick arm around her

shoulder, while Lady Granbehl held her around the waist, sandwiching the girl between them.

It was Blackshorn who addressed them. “Lord and Lady Granbehl, Ada, let me start by saying how sorry we all are for the loss of Kalon and Ezra, and thank you for attending this trial in person.”

Alaric snorted, then belatedly disguised it as a cough. Blackshorn threw him a warning look.

Lord Granbehl’s voice boomed through the courtroom when he spoke. “We are here to ensure that justice finds the monster who murdered our children, High Judge Blackshorn. Though the pain is still fresh, my daughter insisted on being here to look into Grey’s eyes and condemn him to his face.”

Ada did look into my eyes then, but I didn’t see condemnation, just confusion. I saw a girl, scared and alone without her siblings. Then Lady Granbehl pulled her tight, breaking our eye contact.

“Would Lady Ada please recount Ascender Grey’s actions in the Relictombs?” Blackshorn said.

Ada spoke haltingly as she began to tell the story about how we met and our journey into the bridge zone. I had been expecting an embellished version, or even outright lies like the bandit Quinten had told, but Ada stayed close to the truth.

There was genuine horror in her voice when she recounted how Riah was wounded, but when Blackshorn tried to guide her toward blaming me, she stumbled around the question awkwardly.

“And it was Grey who got us out of that zone…” she was saying, describing our escape through the face of a statue that looked like me.

By now Lady Granbehl's stoic smile seemed strained, and Lord Granbehl was shooting Ada frustrated looks. "It is clear," he said loudly, making Ada jump, "that the rogue Grey's intention was to lead my family deeper into the Relictombs before—"

"In the interest of time," Darrin Ordin said, even louder than Lord Granbehl, "and High Hall procedure, the witness should be allowed to give her statement without interruption. Unless, of course," he added with a wide smile, "the panel of judges is opening this witness up to questions, because I have quite a few."

Blackshorn glared down at him. After a tense standoff, the high judge turned back to Ada. "Please continue, young lady."

Ada didn't get far in her story before Harcrust and Falhorn began pressing her for details of how I got across the chasm. They made her walk through, in detail, everything I said or did, and kept circling around to whether I had activated a relic to do it.

Ada couldn't answer, of course, having no idea that I'd used a godrune, but they kept returning to this same line of questioning.

'If they think you have a relic, or relics, that'd be quite the payday for whoever gets the loot when you get beheaded,' Regis joked, but I could still sense the tension and worry emanating from him.

When it became clear Ada couldn't give them any other information, they let her proceed to the events within the mirror room. Here, her story diverged slightly from the truth. She skipped over her entrapment within the mirror and the aether phantom's possession of her body entirely, describing the scene as if she'd simply been sitting in a corner watching.

Lord Granbehl started to relax as Ada described the growing tension and frustration as the days stretched on within the zone, and food ran out. But when she reached the part where the Vritra-blooded ascender, Mythelias, was released from his mirror by Ezra, Lord Granbehl again spoke over her.

"I'm sorry, High Judge, my daughter is suffering from the stress of these events, and missed an important detail. Ezra actually released this ascender to—"

"Who exactly is the witness here, High Judge?" Darrin said, exasperated. "I wasn't aware that Titus Granbehl had first-hand knowledge of what happened on this expedition. If that's the case, why wasn't *he* called to be a witness?"

A susurrus of muttered agreement came from people in the stands, causing Blackshorn's gavel to fall yet again. I couldn't help but notice it didn't immediately quiet the crowd this time.

Blackshorn drew himself up so he towered over the courtroom from his high desk. "I will remind all those present," he said, practically shouting, "that procedure is decided by the high judge—in this case, *me*—and I will do what is necessary to provide timely justice for the murdered. It is not the place of council to question the High Hall's procedures, or my decisions."

Darrin turned his shoulder from the judge, his attention settling on Ada. "Ada, do you truly believe that Grey meant for your brothers to die? That he is guilty of murder?"

"How *dare* you address my daughter," Lord Granbehl boomed.

Blackshorn's gavel came down several times as he blustered wordlessly.

“Ada!” Darrin pushed. “This man’s life could depend on—”

“I demand you take a seat!” Blackshorn howled.

Falhorn and Harcrust were both nodding vigorously, while Tenema held her hands to her ears and glowered at the gavel that Blackshorn was continuing to hammer. Frihl had leaned back in his seat, arms crossed, and was glaring murderously down at Darrin Ordin.

The crowd grew louder. Their yells of indignation echoed off each other until their words blended into an unintelligible chorus.

“No!” Ada cried out, her pained voice cutting through the chaos like a siren.

Then, the room was deathly quiet, all eyes focused on the trembling figure of the Granbehl child. Her gaze fell, her blonde bangs covering most of her face as she spoke in a quiet whisper. “Grey didn’t kill my brothers.”

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BROKEN CHAINS

"GREY DIDN'T KILL THEM," Ada said, louder this time.

Titus Granbehl's hand reached up to cover his daughter's mouth. "Ada! What are you—"

Slipping from her parents' grasp, she stepped toward the judges. Words began to spill from her in rush as her face grew more and more red. "I was trapped in a mirror and Grey was trying to save me but Ezra wouldn't listen and freed the horned ascender from the magic mirror while Grey was working with this artifact thing, and the other ascender killed my brothers, and I would have been stuck there forever but Grey saved me."

The girl hid her face in her hands as her parents stood stiffly to either side of her.

Darrin gave me a victorious look before turning to Blackshorn. "Well, there you—"

"Lord Granbehl," Blackshorn said, speaking over my council, "it is clear that your daughter is incredibly distressed. While we appreciate your blood's bravery in attending this trial in person, it is the opinion of this panel that we cannot accept Ada's testimony at this time, and will instead use the written account of events we have already received."

Ada gaped up at the high judge as her father nodded, his cheek twitching as he suppressed a smirk.

"You may go, all of you," Blackshorn added.

The chains began tightening once more as I failed to suppress my growing annoyance. I pressed my hand into the sharp, twisted metal

where I'd torn the armrest free, letting the pain burn bright in my mind as it cut into my skin.

Someone behind me yelled out how this wasn't fair, wrapped neatly in a string of curses, and in seconds the entire courtroom had exploded into a chorus of shouts and insults being thrown at the judges.

"—got to be kidding—"

"—even listening what the girl said—"

"—a sham, a total fraud—"

"—better let Ascender Grey go or—"

All the judges were on their feet—except Tenema, whose wrinkled old face had scrunched up in displeasure—as Blackshorn hammered with his gavel over and over again, but the courtroom was in full revolt behind me. Hearing the eager crowd turn against the corrupt judges helped settle my nerves just enough for the chains to simply restrain me and not try to take my head off.

"Silence!" the high judge was howling. "Silence! Silence!"

Harcrust turned to an official who had been half hidden behind the desks. "Clear the room. Do it. Now!"

Suddenly, soldiers in black armor were pouring into the courtroom, but everything was happening behind me. I twisted in my seat to get a better look, but the chains bit down, cold and hard, keeping me pinned to the iron chair.

Regis let out a scoff. *'They're pushing everyone out.'*

A panicked scream resounded through the court.

'Damn, one of the soldiers just knocked someone out. And of course the Granbehl guards are helping them.'

In front of me, Darrin watched in horror as the High Hall's enforcers escorted the mob through the huge double doors and out into the long hallway. The judges wore looks of mingled disgust and satisfaction.

The doors slammed shut, and the shouts and heavy, stomping steps were dulled, then slowly disbursed, until the courtroom was left in a state of eerie silence.

Aside from the five judges and a handful of the black-armored High Hall guards, only Darrin, Alaric, Matheson, and I remained in the room.

"Is there any point in reminding the high judge that a trial before a panel of five should be open to the public?" Darrin asked, his voice a growl of suppressed fury.

"None at all," Blackshorn snarled, staring grim-faced down at the four of us. Darrin and Blackshorn locked eyes, but after a few seconds my council submitted to the judge, looking down at the floor of the platform.

Alaric had moved to stand at my other side, while Matheson kept his distance. Alaric leaned down a little and whispered, "I know this looks bad, kid, but don't go doing anything stupid. We still have a couple tricks up our sleeve...I hope," he added in a slightly hesitant undertone.

Blackshorn cleared his throat, a wet, rasping sound like a blade being sharpened. "It is clear to me that *someone* has worked to antagonize this rabble and disrupt these proceedings. Fortunately, we were forewarned this might be the case."

Frihl let out a sharp "Hah!" that silenced the high judge and caused the rest of the panel to turn toward him expectantly.

"When I heard someone was spreading stories, riling people up, I *knew* it must be 'man of the people,' Darrin Ordin, fouling this trial with his sense of low man's justice. Bah!"

Frihl's face melted into an exaggerated frown. "You've become predictable, Ordin. But your games won't work this time."

'I wonder how many horned asses he had to kiss to become a judge?' Regis asked in a tone of mingled wonder and horror.

"Thank you, Judge Frihl," Blackshorn said placatingly. "As I said, we were expecting such tactics, but won't allow this trial to become some kind of circus."

I laughed, cold and humorless. Darrin shot me a warning look and Alaric shook his head, but I was done.

"It seems like Ascender Grey is finally revealing his true nature," Blackshorn said, raising his brow. "His ability to laugh after such dire events have occurred speaks volumes."

"Honestly, I feel as though this has been a trial for my patience rather than the Granbehls' ridiculous allegations," I said matter-of-factly. "What's next? Perhaps the honored judges will reveal that the corpses of Kalon, Ezra, and Riah were magically recovered from the Relictombs, and their wounds prove beyond a shadow of a doubt—*somehow*—that I'm the killer?

"Or, better yet, perhaps you've found my secret diary that I conveniently misplaced in some public place somewhere, detailing my evil plan to kill all the Granbehls, except of course the one *I saved.*"

Frihl shot up from his seat, his gnarled finger pointed at me. “How dare you utter such blasphemy in front of—”

Blackshorn raised a hand, quieting his colleague before leaning back in his chair. Rather than being angry at my not-so-subtle sarcasm, he merely studied me, his fingers steepled before him.

Frihl’s face was crimson with seething rage, but he held his tongue, as did Falhorn and Harcrust. Tenema was the only one who appeared uninterested, seeming to find more interest in a loose thread on her robe than me.

“The absence of physical evidence is hardly an issue, considering the compelling witness statements we received,” Blackshorn answered with a slight shrug of his shoulders. “Which brings us to the deliberation portion of this trial, I believe.”

Tenema, frowning slightly, plucked the thread loose and let it drop on her desk. “Guilty, I’d say. I can see it clear as day.”

Darrin’s face fell as he glanced back at the main doors. Opposite him, Matheson let a self-satisfied grin creep across his face.

‘At this point, it’s hard to tell which ones are corrupt and which ones are just stupid,’ Regis said with a sigh.

“No deliberation necessary. Guilty,” Judge Harcrust spat, his finger again twirling his oily goatee.

Falhorn’s jowls jiggled and swayed as he shook his head. “A piteous display. Guilty.”

Frihl’s sharp gaze locked on Darrin as he hissed, “Guilty, three times over.”

A slight movement in the corner of my eye caught my attention: Lord Granbehl, standing in the shadows of an alcove at the far edge of the

chamber. Even in the gloom, his bright white teeth shone as he smiled victoriously.

Blackshorn leaned forward over his high desk. “Guilty,” he said slowly, savoring the word.

Alaric was shaking his head, as if he couldn’t believe what he was hearing. “They didn’t come, damn them,” he said in a hoarse whisper.

“As to the matter of punishment,” Blackshorn said, suddenly businesslike. “First, all material possessions and wealth of Ascender Grey are forfeit immediately, and will be transferred to Blood Granbehl in recompense for the loss suffered at Grey’s hands. Ascender Grey, you are to turn over all assets, including whatever items were brought back with you from the Relictombs, to this court immediately. The location of any wealth or possessions you may own, but are not carrying on you at this moment, must be divulged, including partial ownership of any blood holdings.”

“Don’t forget, High Judge,” Matheson simpered, “whatever illicit artifacts the ascender has been in possession of.”

“Of course,” Blackshorn added. “In the event, Ascender Grey, that you refuse to divulge the location of your possessions, then your mind will be peeled apart by our most powerful sentries before your execution.”

He paused, his eyes boring into me as he waited for my response.

I gave him a charming smile. “I can’t wait.”

“Guards,” Blackshorn said, his nose wrinkled up like he’d just stepped in something foul, “put this murderous thug in the deepest, smallest cell available.”

'Now are we going to kill all these clowns?' Regis pleaded. *'I call dibs on the jackass with the goatee.'*

No. Not here, I replied coolly.

The noise of shouting reached my ears from outside the courtroom; there was some kind of commotion in the hallway beyond the huge double doors.

"That could be our trump card," Alaric hissed. "We need to keep your ass in that chair, kid."

As I scanned the guards slowly surrounding us, an icy calmness spread through me. In a way, there was a cold sort of comfort knowing that their decision had been made and my trial was over.

Darrin and Alaric were forced back away from me and out of view. Even as the dozen black-armored guards advanced toward me, weapons at the ready, I remained seated, dispassionate and composed.

"I'd like to walk to the cell on my own two feet," I said, my voice even and smooth despite the number of sharp, mana-charged weapons pointed at me.

"Do you still think you're entitled to such a freedom?" Blackshorn retorted. "No. You will be stripped and bound until the moment you die."

I let a wave of aetheric intent surge out of me, swelling through the guards and rendering them immobile. Some of the weaker ones fell to their knees, eyes wide and gasping for breath.

The judges were all pale, their eyes scanning for some answer to explain exactly what was happening. I was a prisoner bound and

stripped of any access to mana, after all. Normally, something like this would never happen.

Normally.

"I d-demand to know what you are doing!" Frihl managed to shout.

"It must be a relic, your honor! I knew he was hiding it somehow." Matheson marshalled enough strength to crawl up from his knees, his expression strained as he turned toward me. "I demand that you hand the relic over at once!"

My gaze fell to the steward, making him recoil in surprise. "Why don't you come here and take it?"

Matheson, his thin brows lined with sweat, swallowed heavily.

Time stilled in the room, as none of the people present were able to muster the courage to take a step closer toward me.

It was only when the doors of the courtroom slammed open that I released the suffocating pressure I was holding in the room. Twisting against the tightening chains, I looked back over my shoulder to see a couple of familiar faces.

"It's about time," Alaric breathed.

'Our cavalry has arrived, Effeminate One,' Regis said with a grin.

The first man I noticed was the brawny, crimson-haired Striker named Taegen, and next to him was his trim companion, the swordsman Arian. The two ascenders flanked a muscular, olive-haired man that I didn't recognize, who in turn was following a furious woman with burning red hair and blazing ice-blue eyes. The four paused at the head of the stairs, glaring down on the standoff between the guards and me.

“Vritra’s grace…Blackshorn, why have I had a dozen different people hammering to get into my office for the last fifteen minutes? Explain yourself at once.”

The high judge shrank back from the authority booming within the woman’s voice, and his mouth began to open and close like a fish drowning on the shore.

“Oh good,” the olive-haired man said from behind the woman, gesturing to the courtroom with a stack of parchment held in one hand. “We appear to have arrived just in time to prevent a gross miscarriage of justice.”

Harcrust’s face had lit up when the doors opened, but fell again at the sight of the red-haired woman and her entourage. “High Justice! And…the Denoir heir, here, in person. Have you, um, brought us Lady Caera’s statement?” he asked, his air of lofty superiority fading. “You needn’t have bothered, of course, we’re nearly finished with this deranged criminal. High Justice, there was no need for you to—”

When the woman’s ice-blue eyes turned on Harcrust, it was like they froze him right through to his mana core. “Don’t presume to tell me what I *need* to do in my own hall, *Harcrust*.”

“The thing is,” the olive-haired man said, “we’re here on *behalf* of the deranged criminal.”

The Denoir heir…So Caera convinced her blood to help after all. I couldn’t help the flicker of a smile that crossed my face.

“Be quiet, Denoir,” the woman snapped.

Harcrust began to bluster, finally having regained a measure of his composure, but the woman snapped her fingers, silencing him.

“If even half of what I’ve been told is true, you’ve made a mockery of the High Hall’s justice, flouting every rule we hold sacred.” Her cutting gaze swept across the five judges. “Disallowing cross-examination? Forceful removal of public observers? *Stationing of third-party soldiers within these hallowed walls?*”

Based on the intensity of the woman’s glare, I was surprised that Blackshorn and the others didn’t burst into flames right then and there.

“High Justice, I mean no disrespect when I say this,” Blackshorn mustered, straightening his robe. “But in the interest of time, we could not strictly follow standard protocol. We only sought to keep our citizens safe from this murderer.”

“Is that right?” An amused grin stretched across the high justice’s face as she was handed a stack of parchment from the Denoir man. “So I suppose this extensive list of your many back-alley deals, unethical promises, and fraudulent actions leading up to this trial, was all in the name of keeping our citizens safe, Blackshorn?”

The old judge’s mottled skin paled. “T-that… High Justice, allow me to expla—”

“As high justice, principal arbiter of the Relictombs’ High Hall, I declare this trial null, and release Ascender Grey, effective immediately.”

“But—”

A fiery look from the high justice forced Blackshorn’s mouth shut.

I relaxed, letting the chains do the same, and scanned the dark alcoves around the courtroom looking for Titus Granbehl. He had taken a step back farther into the shadows at the arrival of the high

justice. Our eyes met briefly—his glaring furiously, mine squinting in amusement—before he turned and vanished.

"Guards, see to it that the judges of this panel don't go anywhere, and for Vritra's sake someone get those chains off that man," she snapped.

"No need," I said simply.

A sharp, metallic groan filled the courtroom as the chains restraining me burst apart. Shards of metal flew across the room as the guards' gazes widened in shock and awe and they stumbled back, half of them pointing their weapons at the judges, the other half at me.

Blackshorn and the other judges were staring disbelievingly at the chains, any semblance of poise they had left gone.

Rubbing my wrists, I turned to Blackshorn, whose jaw had gone slack.

"My apologies for ruining your artifact, but…" I flashed him a smile. "You know…in the interest of time."

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A SHAME

'*THAT WAS PRETTY BADASS,*' Regis said approvingly as we stepped outside.

Standing beneath the vibrant blue sky, I took a deep breath of fresh air, and couldn't help but smile. The High Hall's gargoyles and iron spikes seemed a lot less imposing now that my trial was over.

From the arched entry, the high justice cleared her throat to get our attention.

Lauden Denoir stepped forward and bowed deeply. "Thank you for your assistance today, High Justice. Highblood Denoir will not—"

"Presume to imagine that my actions were for your blood's benefit," the woman cut in with a slight toss of her fiery hair. "This is a place of truth and justice, not some gambling den where low-minded people can seek to cheat their way into a fortune."

Lauden Denoir's aristocratic smile faltered for just an instant, but it was plastered firmly across his face again when he took a step back.

"It would be best," the high justice continued in her sharp, authoritative voice, "that today's events, and the actions taken against you over the last three weeks, were left in the past, Ascender Grey. The High Hall has a…reputation to consider, after all, and the Sovereigns may become personally involved if the violence were to escalate between you and Blood Granbehl."

I raised a brow. "You have quite the way of asking for a favor, High Justice."

Tension crackled in the air as my gaze bore into her ice-blue eyes. I considered all of the laws that the Granbehls had broken that the high justice was asking me to just forgive and forget.

Finally, I let out a breath. "As long as the High Hall—and the Granbehls—stay out of my way, I won't make an effort to cause trouble."

The high justice gave me a single, sharp nod. "Then I would recommend you make yourself scarce, for a time at least."

I held her gaze for a moment longer before turning away, the momentary thrill of the trial's end stained by the woman's sharp reminder.

Several small groups of people were still lingering around the edges of the courtyard, but they didn't dare approach past the oppressive pressure radiating from Taegen and Arian, who were shooting warning glares around the open space.

I heard a few cheers and a couple shouts for my attention, but I ignored them, instead focusing on Lauden Denoir, whose well-practiced courtly smile seemed plastered on his face.

"Thank you for your unexpected assistance," I said, watching the highblood heir carefully. "Though I admit I'm a little surprised that Highblood Denoir went out of its way to help a lowly, unnamed ascender."

"For a friend of my dear sister? Honestly, any trouble is worth easing Caera's mind. She's been most concerned about you, in fact, but I'm sure she'll be *incredibly* relieved to hear of your acquittal." A genuine smirk slipped through the courtly mask he'd been wearing.

“I have heard Lady Caera muttering Effeminate One’s name under her breath more than once,” Taegen grunted.
“Sticking with that nickname, are we?” I asked, deadpan.
Arian, taking his sharp eyes away from the crowd for just a moment, flashed me a chagrined smile. “My abnormally large and dense companion finds it easier to just call them by their physical characteristics rather than bothering to remember their name.”
Taegen shot the thin swordsman a warning look. “I sense mockery underneath your embellished words, tiny sword.”
“Anyway,” Lauden cut in, that forced smile twitching again, “I’d love to extend an invitation for dinner this evening so you can see Caera. My parents have already returned to our estate in the central dominion, but I trust a man of your obvious talent can find the way? The Highlord and Lady Denoir are eager to meet you, especially after the *investment* they’ve just made in seeing you released.” His tone became more serious, almost pointed, as he said this. The implication was clear.
Before I could respond, Alaric wrapped an arm around my shoulder and said, “Many thanks to you and your highblood, but I’m afraid my nephew has been through a significant ordeal. He’s been tortured for three weeks straight, after all, and needs some rest. I’m sure Grey here would love to come around some other time, of course. We’ll send a note.”
Before the Denoir heir could refute, my “uncle” was already pulling me away. I glanced back to see Lauden, flanked by Arian and Taegen, with his arms crossed and brows creased into a frown.

I opened my mouth to ask Alaric whether it was wise to dismiss the Denoir heir so suddenly, when a shout interrupted me.

"Ascender Grey, I love you!"

Surprised, I scanned the crowd until I found the source of the voice, who turned out to be a young woman in vibrant orange leather armor.

'I love you too, you tanned, sculpted goddess,' Regis hollered, his voice echoing in my head.

My eyes lingered on her, curious, until Alaric thumped me on the arm.

"No time to mingle with the groupies," Alaric said, quickening our pace. "We need to get you somewhere with fewer eyeballs, regardless of how big and blue they might be."

"Why does it feel like we're trying to run away?" I asked, keeping a leisurely pace. "Lauden has a terrible poker face, but it wouldn't have hurt to visit his place and just say thanks—"

Alaric snorted humorlessly and hurried onward. Beside him, Darrin's head swiveled back and forth, like he expected us to be attacked at any moment.

"If you think a simple 'thank you' is all Highblood Denoir is doing this for, you might as well slip a collar around your neck and hand them the leash," Alaric said, turning onto a wide boulevard I recognized as leading toward the exit to the first level. "Don't be thick, boy. The only reason those self-absorbed nobles would get involved is because they want to make you their loyal little pup to fetch them accolades and relics from the Relictombs."

“That’s easy enough to tell,” I retorted back. “But unlike the Granbehls, Caera’s family doesn’t have anything to hold over my head besides me maybe owing them a favor.”

“A favor is often more valuable than a carriage of gold, especially if owed by an individual with as much potential as you,” Darrin replied as his eyes continued to scan our surroundings.

‘Not to cast doubts on your beloved horned paramour, but it is possible that Caera told them just how powerful you are in order to try and convince her family to help,’ Regis added.

It doesn’t matter, I said, as much to myself as Regis. *I doubt we’d have any reason to cross paths again.*

My companion clicked his tongue. *‘Alas, if only our alcoholic friend here was half as pretty as Caera.’*

I turned my attention to Alaric, realizing that, unknowingly, I’ve been relying on the old drunk. Without him, it would have been a lot harder to get back into the Relictombs…but at the same time, he was easy to understand.

Alaric saw me as his meal—or rather, alcohol—ticket, and he wasn’t interested in who I really was or where I came from. I didn’t have to worry about his motivations, and I appreciated that about the man.

It was hard to say the same about Darrin Ordin though. I wondered what Alaric might have told him, and what kind of promises had been made on my behalf for Darrin’s help.

‘Not that he was even that much help…’ Regis groused.

As my thoughts turned back to the trial, one in particular that had been nagging at the back of my mind stood out. “Alaric, why exactly do I have groupies? Who were all those people at the trial?”

Alaric and Darrin exchanged a look. “My idea, actually,” Alaric’s friend said over his shoulder, running a hand through his blond hair. “Though I let Alaric do most of the dirty work.”

We moved to the side of the road to avoid a huge carriage pulled by two blood-red oxen.

Alaric shrugged, but his beard twitched in a way that worried me. “I might have spread some rumors about you. Stirred up some interest, encouraged a few people to come watch your trial.”

“What kind of rumors…?” I asked, watching Alaric from the corner of my eye.

The old man cleared his throat. “Nothing to compromise your shroud of mystery and intrigue.”

I stopped walking suddenly and gave him a pointed look. “Alaric…”

“Just a tale of a young ascender being bullied by a named blood,” he said, scratching at his beard. “If I suggested that the ascender was so handsome and…*gifted*…that he’d drawn the attention of even a certain highblood lady—”

I resisted the urge to bury my face in my hand. “Please tell me you’re joking.”

‘That certainly explains the ratio of women to men in the crowd,’ Regis teased.

Alaric shrugged and started walking again, weaving through the swelling crowd of people as we neared the exit portal to the first level.

Darrin had watched this exchange with a tight-lipped smile. “That part wasn’t my idea,” he said apologetically before following Alaric.

I stared down sparkling tiles of the street, hoping that these rumors never reached Caera.

Jogged to catch up with the others, I fumbled around for something else to talk about. “So what’s the plan?” I asked finally. “I’ve wasted enough time out here—”

“Let’s get somewhere a little less crowded,” Darrin said, glancing around at the dozens of people passing by in both directions. Most of them weren’t paying attention to us, but a few did double takes when they saw Darrin, and more than a couple pairs of eyes followed me as well.

We bypassed the many inns and ascender bars lining both sides of the wide street as Alaric made a beeline for the portal to the first level. Once the portals were in sight—like two pieces of glass hovering over a pad of colorful mosaic tiles—we joined a queue of ascenders who were leaving the second level.

“Where are we going?” I asked.

“I think it’s best if we leave the Relictombs for the moment,” Darrin answered. “First, we’re going to my estate in the countryside of Sehz-Clar.”

“Sehz-Clar?” I wondered aloud, trying to remember what I’d read. “That’s sort of rural for a famous ascender, isn’t it?”

“I like it that way,” he said nonchalantly.

I considered the size of Alacrya and where we’d entered the Relictombs from in Aramoor, which was in the eastern dominion of Etril. Would we have to go back through Etril before heading to Sehz-Clar? It was a very long way to go just to have a conversation,

considering that we were surrounded by inns where a private room could be rented for a handful of gold.

Glancing back across the second level toward where I thought the massive portal into the deeper zones of the Relictombs was, I noticed a group of men—all dressed in dark leather and chain armor—look away at the same time, like they'd been staring at me only a second before.

I quickly scanned the rest of the line. The woman in the orange armor was standing several people behind us. Our eyes met, and her mouth fell open slightly before she lowered her head, letting her dark hair fall across her face. Besides them, no one else seemed to be paying attention to the three of us.

Questions arose but I kept them to myself, trusting that Alaric had his reasons for getting us away from the Relictombs, and not wanting to make Darrin suspicious by asking the wrong one.

It only took a couple minutes for us to reach the exit portal, where a uniformed clerk waved us through. It was like night and day traveling from the second level to the first. Where the second was bright and airy, the first was dank and heavy with the smell of iron and excrement.

A man dressed in the hide of some mana beast was shouting at one of the portal guards about his pass. The uniformed guard had his arms crossed, and a muscle in his wide jaw was twitching.

Behind him, a dozen ascenders were waiting in line to enter the second level, most of them grumbling about the wait.

I was watching the commotion from the corner of my eye when I noticed the woman in the bright orange armor step through the

portal. She scanned the area, and when her eyes found me she made a beeline toward us while withdrawing something from her dimension ring.

With heightened senses and reflexes, the seconds that it took for the tanned woman to catch up to me passed by in a crawl.

Just before she was in arm's reach, I spun on my heels and caught her by her wrist, crushing the chain bracer into her flesh.

The woman gasped, and whatever she was holding tumbled to the ground.

"Did you not think I'd notice?" I asked, my gaze piercing through hers as I twisted her wrist. "Why are you following me?"

"I'm s-so sorry!" she squealed, her mahogany eyes wide and her face pale. "I just wanted your a-autograph!"

I glanced at the ground where the item she had dropped pressed against my boot: a pyramid-shaped steel box, engraved with chains that wrapped around the edges. As I watched it, the woman's foot groped forward and tapped the pointed top.

Several things happened at once.

The artifact at my feet unfolded, letting out a glowing golden light.

There was a flash from the woman's free hand, and a sleek dark dagger appeared in her grasp.

All around the portal platform, the crowd of ascenders that had been either watching us warily or ignoring us in favor of grumbling about the unmoving line drew their weapons and turned as one toward me and my companions. Behind them, three nervous officials vanished through the portal back to the second level.

This whole thing had been a setup—and there was only one group that would go to this kind of trouble.

"Lord Granbehl sends his regards," the orange-armored ascender snarled, thrusting the blade at my abdomen.

Still holding her by the wrist, I jerked the tanned woman off her feet and threw her at a nearby cluster of armed ascenders. She let out a yelp before crashing into them, but my attention was back on the artifact, which had opened like a flower and was glowing more brightly by the instant.

Lifting one leg, I began to step down toward it, intending to crush it under my heel, but…I froze, unable to move. The golden light emanating from the open pyramid wrapped around me, shining over every inch of me like a second skin. I could just make out the ethereal shape of chains within the light, wrapping around me and my companions.

"Well I'll be damned, they actually got a force cage." Even with his voice muffled by the layer of energy the force cage had wrapped around him, Alaric was more amazed than shocked as he tried to wiggle his body. "And a pretty good one at that."

His words were met by a chorus of chuckles from the many ascenders now eyeing us dangerously.

"Shit," Darrin swore, sounding like he was speaking with his head under water. "This isn't good."

From the corner of my eye, I saw two men struggle to pull the orange-armored woman to her feet. By the way she was holding her arm, I knew I'd pulled it from the socket. That didn't stop her from beaming at me victoriously.

“Quite the handful, aren’t you?” she said while popping her arm back into place. The woman sauntered closer toward us. “A shame that I have to hand you over to the Granbehls. So many better uses for a pretty face like yours.”

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LAST MERCY

MY GAZE SHIFTED from the woman in the orange armor to the ring of ascenders around her closing in on us. Their hardened expressions, posture, gait—everything about them reinforced my impression that the Granbehls had made a significant investment to orchestrate this last ditch effort.

Stopping in front of Darrin, our female assailant placed a hand on the golden aura restraining him. "Sorry you got wrapped up in this, Ordin. I know I speak for all these men when I say that you've earned our respect over the years."

"Well, then you could let us go," Darrin ventured, the charm in his voice ruined by the muffling of the golden force field.

The woman shook her head, eyeing us seriously. "No, I'm afraid not."

I watched the mercenaries, their hands gripped firmly around their weapons despite their advantages. My eyes turned to where we had crossed over to this floor. A steady stream of ascenders should have been headed in both directions, but no one new came through the portal from the second level, and the street leading out into the first level was empty as well.

"Still scheming for a way out of this?" The woman asked with a raised brow. "I admire your composure, but it's no use."

"Scheming?" I echoed, raising a brow. "Is that what it looked like I was doing?"

"Superstar here thinks he's invincible after being let loose," one of the men standing nearest to her said with a chortle. His red hair had

been shaved down on the sides, and scars marked his face, the sides of his head, and the bare skin of his arms.

Apparently, even the most professional of mercenaries weren't immune to the disease of a swelled head because another man—this one a much rounder axe-wielder—leaned forward lazily against his weapon.

"That's a top tier force cage, moron," he said with a smirk. "The thing about these expensive ones is that, while they cost as much as a Relictombs estate, they drain your own mana to use against you, reinforcing the barrier."

"So by all means," the scarred redhead sneered, giving his shoulders a little shake, "struggle all you wish."

The orange-armored woman let out a snicker and the mercenaries behind her saw that as a signal to cackle in amusement.

So when the supposedly unbreakable golden barrier of mana shattered around me, their expressions couldn't have changed any faster.

'Puahaha! Look at their faces!' Regis guffawed, practically rolling on his back within me.

"Th-that's impossible…" the woman stammered, her tanned skin a shade paler.

"I've been told that a lot," I replied casually, dusting the golden shards of solidified mana off my shoulder.

Recovering quickly from her disbelief, the woman in orange let out a guttural roar as she flashed forward, twin sabers appearing in her hands, blazing in a golden red fire.

My form blurred as I used Burst Step to close the distance between us, catching her off guard. I kicked her knees and slammed her face-first into the ground with a quick strike to the back of her neck.

By the time the rest of the mercenaries snapped out of their shock and terror, their leader was already under my foot.

My gaze swept across the twenty some men and women in cold apathy. I had given the Granbehls enough chances.

Regis, kill the rest, I thought.

A shadowy wolf engulfed in violet flames burst forth, eliciting a storm of curses and yelps of surprise. Being the hardened mercenaries that they were, however, our opponents reacted with practiced efficiency, glowing mantles of all different elements erupting around them. Mana shields flickered to life as well, bathing the platform with colorful light.

I took a moment to glance back at Alaric and Darrin, whose dumbfounded expressions indicated that they were still processing what exactly was going on. While the idea of freeing them for additional help crossed my mind, it didn't seem necessary…and I wanted them to get a glimpse of just what sort of person they were actually helping.

Shrouding myself in a layer of aether, I focused on my opponents, ready to meet their barrage of spells.

Regis struck like a meteor, spraying blood wherever his dark claws and fangs went, but after killing a few of their comrades, our attackers were able to encircle him with mana shields while their Casters bombarded him with spells.

The scarred ascender with burning red hair was the first to approach me, rushing forward with a giant warhammer in hand, creating a depression on the ground with each mana-infused step.
"Screw taking you alive!" he roared. "Die!"
With bloodshot eyes filled with vengeance, the Striker swung his blackened steel hammer that seemed to pulsate.
I dug my heels into the ground, directing a burst of aether from my core through my arm and into my fist while keeping a steady flow throughout the rest of my body to keep myself stable.
My bare fist collided with the face of his metal hammer, creating a shockwave of force that ripped through the air.
The mercenaries nearby were blasted off their feet, slammed by the kinetic energy while the redhead's hammer shattered just like the force cage they tried to trap me in.
Before my wide-eyed opponent could recover, I followed up with an aether-clad punch to his chest that made sure he never would.
Meanwhile, Regis had his jaws trained on the round axe-wielder's head. His agonizing scream turned into a gut-wrenching crunch as my companion snapped his mouth shut before moving on to his next victim.
While protective panels of mana were able to deter the shadowy wolf for a moment, Regis's claws were infused with destruction, slowly disintegrating whatever the mercenaries could conjure.
All around me, the mercenaries scrambled chaotically, perhaps now realizing how outmatched they were.
A Striker came from my left, hefting a huge sword surrounded by a sharp torrent of wind, but I sidestepped the unwieldy weapon easily,

ignoring the scratches from its cutting aura. As the blade struck the ground, I snapped out a forward kick against the flat edge. There was a rending of metal as the serrated blade tore free from its handle and went skittering across the ground into the distance.

The Striker had just a moment to stare dumbfounded at his broken weapon before my second kick took him in the side, sending him crashing through the wall of one of the surrounding buildings.

Spinning, I dodged a crackling arc of electricity that left a trail of shattered earth in its path.

The robed caster let out a manic laugh as he moved his arm, controlling the stream of voltaic mana back at me.

With another series of aetheric bursts channeled through my body, I Burst Step past the caster, my bloodied arm ripping a hole through his stomach.

His laughter dissolved into a hysteric scream as he looked down at his fatal wound.

As the ascender slumped, blood leaking from his mouth, I held his body and spun, using it as a shield to catch a series of ice spikes that flew toward me. I felt that man's body shake as the spikes impacted, then he went still in my grip.

I let the corpse fall to the ground.

Flicking the blood off my arm, I scanned the battlefield; one of the mercenaries had made a break for the portal. A powerful gale of wind blurred his form, and he was just a single step away from escaping, one arm already inside the glowing window of the portal.

The world shifted as my perception stretched and the currents of aether appeared around me. Letting the threads of spatium feed

information to me, I was able to find the route that led me to the escapee.

Then I took a step.

Tendrils of violet lightning crackled around me as my vision shifted to just behind the wind mage. Grabbing him by the back of his armored collar, I jerked him toward me.

“Where do you think you’re going?” I asked.

Despite my gentle smile, the ascender’s face twisted into one of horror.

“H-how…” he croaked before his skull was slammed into the ground.

Feeling the absence of the rich aetheric atmosphere of the deeper Relictombs zones, I noted the drop in my reserves from that single God Step and knew I couldn’t be careless about wasting aether.

Turning back to the battle, I spotted Regis who had moved onto another victim, the huge shadow wolf ripping through armor and flesh alike with ease.

As I stepped back toward the remainder of the enemy combatants, a shadow moved through the air right in front of me. I brought my left arm up just in time to catch the hand holding a dagger, which shimmered as it moved, just like its wielder. My attacker, a short-haired girl, had somehow camouflaged herself and her weapons, making her almost invisible against the chaotic backdrop surrounding us.

“You should’ve escaped when you had the chance,” I said, snapping the wrist in my grasp.

“Screw you!” the camouflaged ascender screamed as she spun on her heel and swung the second dagger she held in her other hand.

The dagger never reached me. The tip of my finger, extended into a sharp claw, tore across her throat.

With a spray of blood and an unintelligible gurgle, she fell to her knees.

Behind her, I watched as Regis leapt on a spear-wielding Striker, catching the shaft of the spear between his jaws and snapping it in two before dragging the man down. Spinning disks of white light kept flashing past Regis’s shadow wolf form from behind the corner of a nearby building, where a couple of the mercenaries were retreating.

Movement brought my attention back to the dagger-wielding ascender, who—while clasping her torn throat with one hand—managed to muster the strength to drive one of her daggers into my leg.

I winced, more out of annoyance than out of pain, as I wrenched the dagger free.

The camouflaging ascender froze, unable to do anything but stare as the wound she had desperately inflicted began visibly healing in front of her, before succumbing to her fatal wound.

Finally, the enemy began to break as a couple of the men attempted to flee. Regis had already killed one of them, and was going after the second when one of the white disks caught him in the shoulder.

Anger flared from my companion as he ignored it in favor of killing the runaway first.

By the time I finished off a few of our remaining attackers, Regis had his attention back on the caster that had injured him with the glowing white disks. He was hiding behind a grizzled woman in armor of overlapping steel plates.

As the two stumbled back into an alleyway away from the shadowy wolf stalking them, the woman conjured a box of shimmering mana around her and the caster. A second and third box manifested around the first, and she took a deep breath, her hard eyes bearing down on Regis as the relieved caster behind her began summoning more searing white disks.

With each step my companion took toward the two remaining mercenaries, the brighter and more sinister his claws glowed until destruction flickered silently, melting effortlessly through each of the three conjured barriers. I could tell that my companion was relishing in his final two prey.

Leaving Regis to wrap up, I walked over to where Darrin and Alaric were both watching me with wide eyes beneath the golden aura restraining them.

The force cage artifact gleamed from the ground where it had been dropped, projecting ethereal golden chains that snaked around my companions. Without preamble, I stepped down hard on the unfolded pyramid, and it—along with the ground—crunched under my boot.

As the golden light faded, both men stumbled forward.

Massaging his knees, Alaric's gaze swept across the bloodied battlefield before taking in my form.

Clearing his throat uncomfortably, he shot a glance at Darrin before looking up at me. “You… uh… hurt?”
“It would’ve been faster if you two had joined,” I said with a shrug.
“You seemed to have things… under control, ” Darrin muttered, his emerald green eyes still soaking in the sight around us.
A figure stirred on the ground to the left of where we stood.
Alaric and Darrin looked to me but I shook my head. I let her recover as she peeled herself off the ground with a haggard groan. The once-orange armor was dyed in crimson, but most of the blood wasn’t hers. Aside from a raw scrape across her face, and what was likely to be a vicious headache, she wasn’t badly wounded.
I walked toward her and waited silently until she was finally able to take in the sight surrounding her.
“No… ” she whispered, eyes red and lined with tears.
The ascender turned her trembling body toward where I stood.
“Please… just let me live,” she croaked.
“I didn’t leave you alive just to show you this mess,” I answered, even-toned. “I have a job for you.”
She nodded fiercely. “A-anything you want.”
“Tell the man who hired you that this”—I swept my gaze through the portal platform now littered with corpses—“was my last act of mercy.”
The mercenary’s jaw clenched, but she nodded once more in understanding.
“If he chooses to disregard whatever semblance of sanity he has left and comes after me again, I’ll make sure that Ada is the only

Granbehl left to mourn for her blood," I said, giving her a mirthless smile. "After all…I know where they live."

With one last nod, she scrambled away, barely able to make it through the portal.

I made my way to Darrin and Alaric, who had watched my interaction with the woman in grim-faced silence.

"Do you disagree with how I handled this?" I asked.

"The outcome? No, not in the least," Darrin answered before he looked off in the distance. "The method, well…"

"The outcome would've been better if you could've broken us out of the force cage *without* breaking it," Alaric grumbled, holding the broken scraps of the artifact tenderly. "Do you have any idea how much this was worth?"

"If you sold it, it would just end up back in someone like Granbehl's hands," I replied, deadpan.

"Well, sure," he sputtered, "but I'd be significantly more wealthy in the meantime!"

I snorted, and Darrin gave me a helpless shrug.

Regis chose that moment to reappear out of the alley. He loped up beside me, his maw red with blood, and I couldn't help but notice the way Darrin eyed him uncomfortably.

Shaking himself, Regis sent a fine spray of warm red drops into the air, splattering Alaric, Darrin, and myself with little specks of blood. Darrin flinched back, covering his face with an arm, while Alaric stared off into the distance, unamused and face dotted red.

'I feel so much better,' he thought, his tongue lolling from the side of his mouth. *'Gonna take a nap now.'*

Darrin and Alaric watched, awestruck, as Regis faded away, drifting back into my body.

"Your magic and…summons…" Darrin paused, as if searching for the right words. He opened his mouth, hesitated, and closed it again. In the end, he only shook his head helplessly.

"I'm more curious how you broke out of the force cage, myself," Alaric admitted as he tried to force one of the triangular panels closed. "That should be impossible."

"Do you really want to know?" I asked, meeting Alaric's eye.

He looked down at the hard-packed dirt for a second before kicking away a loose stone. "Nope, I don't suppose I do."

Over his shoulder, Darrin said, "Well I certainly would like to know, and I hope one day you'll trust me enough to let me in on your secret, Grey."

'Which ones?' Regis snorted in amusement.

When I didn't immediately reply, Darrin's face twitched with a tentative smile, and he turned away, leading our party out of the Relictombs.

"Wow," I said, genuinely surprised by the sight in front of me.
Darrin's home in rural Sehz-Clar was twice the size of the Helstea's manor in Xyrus, and it was surrounded by rolling green and golden fields that stretched as far as I could see. A little town was tucked in between two hills a few miles away, and a handful of other, similar estates dotted the surrounding countryside.
The main structure was two stories, but flared out into low wings that opened to either side. The entire mansion was made of light red brick highlighted with white stone columns. The house was surrounded by a well-manicured yard of green grass and dense, flowering shrubs, and a path led away to the east, where I could see some kind of walled off area higher up on the hill.
The rural serenity of the estate had calmed everyone's nerves, still on edge from the assault in the Relictombs. Looking at the painting-like scene around us, I actually began to look forward to at least a small rest devoid of any torture or attempts on my life.
"The benefit of living rural," Darrin said, beaming. "Property costs a quarter of what you'd pay in the more densely populated dominions, and these hills have poor soil, so you don't have to fight the farmers for land rights, either."
"I'm a little surprised you don't live in the Relictombs, though," I said as I ran a finger along the edge of a bright purple flower. "Considering what you do."
Darrin began leading us across the wide lawn, which we had appeared in the middle of, toward the bright white double doors of

his home. “I couldn’t afford a property there, so the best I’d be able to do is rent a two-room suite in one of the nicer inns, and that would still cost a small fortune.” He paused, taking in the rolling hills and bright, wide sky. “No, I think I’d rather live here, and pay the teleportation fees.”

I followed his gaze, taking in the sight again. “I guess I can’t blame you. It’s quite the view.”

Darrin put a hand on Alaric’s shoulder. “Never would have managed it all without my mentor here. You’re in good hands, Grey, even if he does feign a rough exterior.”

Alaric huffed, his already ruddy cheeks darkening, and his gaze landing everywhere except on Darrin. “And a fat lot of good it did me, considering you only ended up owning a single estate in the middle of nowhere…”

Grinning, Darrin knocked softly on the door.

A moment later, it flew open and a young girl, no older than seven or eight, threw herself into his arms. “Uncle Darrin!” she yelled, squeezing her arms around his neck and grinning over his shoulder.

When she realized Alaric and I were there, her eyes, green as emeralds, went wide, and she squealed and wriggled free of Darrin’s hug so she could hide behind him and peek out at us.

Giving the girl what I hoped was a friendly smile, I waved. She immediately ducked behind Darrin, who laughed.

“Pen, these are my friends, Alaric and Grey,” Darrin said, gently maneuvering her back out into the open and ruffling her dark blonde hair. “It’s okay, they’re friendly. Well, Grey is.”

Alaric's face twisted into a menacing snarl and he growled low in his chest. "But I'm the mean one, and I bake little children into yummy pies!"

The girl giggled and looked up at Darrin. "Your friends are funny!"

"*They* think they are, anyway," Darrin replied, rolling his eyes at Alaric. He scooped the girl up and carried her across the threshold, waving for us to follow.

"Any word about your mom while I was gone?" he asked her as they led us into the entry hall, where two curved stairs led up to the upper floor.

She shook her head and pouted. "No."

Darrin pulled her into another hug and patted her back consolingly. "That's okay, I'm sure she'll be back soon." He set her down on the granite-tiled floor. "Why don't you go tell the others we have guests?"

Nodding seriously, the little girl vanished through a door to our right, which must have led into one of the other wings of the house.

"Yours?" I asked, watching her bounce away.

"Oh, no," Darrin said, running his hand through his hair. "Her mother is one of my teammates from back in the day. She's still active. Pen stays with me sometimes when her mom's on an ascent."

My eyes followed Pen out of the entrance hall, catching on a figure leaning against the wall in the corner. It was a young woman with bright orange hair that faded to sunny blonde where it ended just past her shoulders. She was wearing a white blouse with silver buttons and tight leather pants, and a long, slender sword hung from her belt.

But it was her hazel eyes that stood out, or rather, it was the way they traveled slowly across me, from the toes of my boots all the way up to my pale blond hair, before spinning in a dismissive eye roll. Before I could do more than meet her gaze, the young woman swept from the room, and my attention was again redirected.

"Mister Darrin!" a happy voice said from a room behind the stairs. A plump woman with mousy-brown hair appeared from it, wiping her hands with a towel. "I'm so sorry, I didn't hear the door."

Darrin gave her a warm smile, though the direction of his gaze lingered on the passage where the young woman had disappeared. "No problem, Sorrel. We have guests for the evening."

The woman curtsied, her tightly curled auburn hair bobbing around her round face. "A pleasure! Are the three of you hungry at all, Mister Darrin?"

Alaric's stomach rumbled audibly in response, which he patted appreciatively. "Never mind that, where are you hiding the good stuff?" Without waiting for a reply, the old man strode purposefully away.

Shaking his head at his friend, Darrin said, "Why don't you show Grey to the bathing room first?" Turning to me, he added, "I assume it's been a while since you had a warm bath?"

Darrin's housekeeper eagerly led me deeper into the mansion until I found myself standing in what, at first glance, appeared to be a cave. The walls of the bathing room were craggy stone, and the bath itself

was sunk into the smooth rock of the "cave" floor. After Sorrel left me, I took some time to examine the room.

Aside from the bath, there was a mirror inset into the wall, a series of racks and hooks where clothes could be hung up, and a person-sized niche that I didn't immediately understand, until I found a small copper button next to it.

The button clicked when I pressed it, and a wave of heat rolled out. I stuck my hand in; the air was dry and warm.

Clicking the button again turned the effect off.

'Ooh, fancy,' Regis said admiringly.

Turning my attention to the bath, I found a row of buttons along the edge. During my life as King Grey, I'd grown to enjoy warm baths in water heavy with salt. It had been a luxury that I hadn't enjoyed since being reborn in Dicathen. So when I saw the button labeled "Salt Bath," I knew I had to try that one first.

Pressing the button caused warm salt water to seep out of the sides of the rocky bath, and it was full before I finished peeling off the simple clothes I'd worn to the trial.

Sinking into the water, a chill ran down my spine despite the warmth. *When was the last time I enjoyed such a simple comfort?* I wondered, letting my head fall back so the salt water covered my ears, drowning out all noise except for my own thoughts.

And Regis's. *'Maerin Town wasn't so bad, but that was like a hundred years ago now, right?'*

I let out a laugh before splashing some of the water across my face. After wiping it away, I replied, *It does feel like that. Do you want to come out for a bit?*

Regis leapt from my body to stand outside the pool. He stretched, pushing his front paws forward and yawning widely. “You know, sometimes I forget how quiet it is when I don’t have your broody thoughts running through my head all the time.”

“I’m not broody,” I replied defensively, glaring up at my companion from under half-closed lids.

Regis snorted as he walked around in a slow circle before lying down. “Okay, princess.”

Kicking outward, I send a wave of warm saltwater cascading over the edge of the bath to soak my companion. He leapt up, sputtering with indignation. “I just got comfy!”

The shadowy flames that flickered around his mane flared, drying him instantly, and he found another spot to settle down. He let out a yawn and stretched his long limbs before asking, “So, what now?”

I let my eyes drift shut. “Right now? Let’s give ourselves a few minutes to relax, then we’ll figure out what Alaric and his friend have up their sleeves.”

I felt the heavy fog of sleep settling over me soon after. Although I didn’t really *need* to sleep, I relished the idea of drifting off for a while, and I didn’t fight the sensation.

The sound of a crowd chanting came from all around me, like the noise of waves crashing against a cliff face; It was distant and muffled, like I was hearing it from a very long way off.

Slowly opening my eyes, I looked around. I was standing on a square dueling platform, surrounded by stands filled with familiar faces: Claire Bladeheart and the rest of the Disciplinary Committee, the Lances, Jasmine and the Twin Horns, Virion, the kings and queens of

Dicathen's Council, the elders who trained me in the four elements, Lady Vera, Headmaster Wilbeck, Caera, Ellie, with Sylvie's little white fox form on her lap, my mother… my father.

Someone else was on the dueling platform too: Cecilia. She held out a hand, and a dual-bladed sword shimmered to life in her fist, a beam of hot white light that hummed with deadly energy.

I gave Cecilia a low bow, but she only glowered back at me before lunging across the platform, her weapon leaving a trail of light in the air. I lifted Dawn's Ballad to block the attack, but the teal blade shattered in my hand, and I felt white hot pain as Cecilia's weapon bit deep into my shoulder.

For a moment, we were face to face, her turquoise eyes blazing malevolently.

She yanked the blade from my shoulder and spun, driving the other end toward my stomach. I looked for the aetheric pathways to God Step out of the way, but there was nothing.

The blade sunk into my stomach and burst out my back.

Behind Cecilia, someone was running down a long tunnel toward us. Although he seemed miles away, I met Nico's eyes, blind with hatred, twisted by fear, and felt a thick layer of ice grow over my heart, and the cold detachment I'd learned as King Grey spread from it.

Cecilia jerked her blade free and twirled it around, a gold-green light emanating outward, staining the edges of my vision and shining off the frozen faces in the audience. A beam of pure light lifted her off the dueling platform, her blade pointed at my chest like a lance, then she streaked toward me.

The scene froze. Standing, I clenched my fist, holding in it Dawn's Ballad, the translucent teal blade, now whole again, refracting the light and sending green-blue beams dancing across the dueling platform. In the distance, Nico was still running toward us, the only thing moving besides me.

And history repeats…

Cecilia was moving again, crashing down on me like a comet. When our blades clashed, a shockwave rippled outward, obliterating the platform, the stands, the arena, and wiping away the audience—all those familiar faces from both my lives—in a cloud of dust.

My blade was blazing with violent amethyst light from where it had run through Cecilia's chest. But it was Tess, not Cecilia, who slumped forward, her body falling into me, her life's blood rushing out over my hands, quickly staining the dueling platform red.

My mouth fell open to gasp out…something—anything—but the words were stuck in my throat, as if a giant hand had wrapped around my neck and was choking me. All I could do was watch, paralyzed, as the light faded from her eyes.

Her fingertips brushed my face, running down my cheek and across my lips.

The icy fist gripping my chest burst, and my eyes snapped open.

Heaving a strained, half-choked breath, I pulled myself up out of the salt bath and rolled over to lay on the floor, panting.

"Hey!" Regis barked, as I'd sent a wave of bathwater splashing over the cave floor. "What'd I do this—whoa, you okay?"

"Fine," I muttered, rubbing hard at my face. "Just a bad dream."

"Want to talk about it?" he asked, resting his chin on his paws.

“Not really,” I said as I rolled up to my feet, the images of the dream already growing muddy and distorted in my mind, except for Tess’s blood staining my hands.
I’ll find you, Tess. I promise.

Sorrel met me in the hall outside the bathing room after I had put on a clean set of clothes from my dimension rune. One eyebrow rose as she looked me up and down, barely suppressing a smirk. “Don’t *you* clean up nicely…” she said. “Mister Darrin and the rest are sharing a drink on the back porch. I’ll show you the way.”
The housekeeper swept through the mansion until we reached a sunroom entirely surrounded by glass. It contained plants of a hundred different varieties, and was filled with the rich, sweet, earthy smells of flowers and herbs. I inspected the collection as we passed, but only recognized a handful of the plant species. A door led onto an open porch that overlooked the endless rolling green-and-gold hills.
Outside, I found not only Alaric and Darrin, but the girl Pen, the young woman with the orange-blonde hair, and three other children of various ages.
Pen was the first to notice me, and immediately ducked her face down into Darrin’s shoulder.
Alaric looked up and gave me a mock frown. “I was starting to worry you’d drowned in the bath, boy. Would have sent Sorrel to check on you, but Darrin told her not to do anything I asked.”

“Do you blame me, after what happened last time you were here?” Darrin asked, patting Pen’s back lightly.

Alaric’s cheeks, already ruddy from alcohol, turned a brighter shade of red. “You said we weren’t going to talk about that again.”

Darrin caught my eye and winked. “I did, and we won’t. Grey, come join us!”

I sat in an empty wooden chair and all eyes turned to me, even Pen’s, who was staring out from behind a curtain of her own hair.

“Hooligans, this is Ascender Grey, another student of Alaric’s,” Darrin said in introduction. “Grey, this is my ward, Adem.”

The indicated boy appeared to be in his early teens, around my sister’s age, maybe a little older. His dark blue eyes met mine without a hint of fear or intimidation. We matched gazes for a moment before he gave me a shallow nod.

“And these,” Darrin said, “are my trainees, Katla, Ketil, and Briar. The twins’ parents are farmers here in Sehz-Clar and are trying to get them into one of the ascender academies. Briar is the oldest daughter of Blood Nadir, and is here to train in preparation for her second year at Central Academy.”

The twins shared the same bright blonde hair, almost as light as my own but more vibrant, and were stocky and muscular, likely from growing up on a farm. Katla nodded, but kept her eyes to the ground. Ketil, on the other hand, adjusted his posture to stand taller as he interposed himself between her and the others protectively.

Briar of Blood Nadir was rolling what looked like a shiny silver arrowhead around in her hand, except it wasn’t *in* her hand, but

hovering about an inch over it. She didn't look up or acknowledge the introduction.

Looking at the children, I couldn't help but think about Headmaster Wilbeck, her face still fresh from my dream. I knew it was partially the sentimentality leftover from the strange nightmare, but I couldn't help but like Darrin Ordin. He reminded me of the Headmaster, and even a little of my father when Reynolds had been young…

Prying myself away from my thoughts, I gave them a faint smile. "It's a pleasure to meet you all."

Katla mumbled her greeting in return, although her brother was louder.

Adem stood and bowed stiffly. "Welcome to our home, Ascender Grey. We're honored to have you."

Darrin's lips twitched as he hid a smile at the boy's proper greeting, but it fell to a frown when Briar let out a derisive snort.

Adem glared at her as she returned to her seat, but didn't respond.

"So, Briar," Alaric said into the awkward silence that followed, "you survived a year at Central Academy, aye? Good for you, kid."

The young woman tossed her multi-colored hair as she leveled a defiant gaze at the old man. "Of course. Despite Central Academy being one of the best, and toughest, military and ascender training academies in Alacrya, I scored above average on *all* of the assessment criteria."

Alaric whistled in appreciation. To me, he said, "Most of the ascender-focused academies grade by the same metrics the Ascenders Association uses. Easier to track progress that way."

I nodded, saying only, “I see.”
“Do you?” Briar asked pointedly, her brow raised in obvious skepticism. “It’s doubtful, given that my teacher had to bail you out for getting your teammates killed in a measly prelim.”
“Don’t be mean!” Pen said, pouting at the older girl.
“Briar,” Darrin said firmly. The young woman stiffened, turning to him but focusing on a point over his shoulder instead of making eye-contact. “Rudeness toward my guests extends to rudeness toward me. If you can’t hold back your frustration, I’d encourage you to head down to the training rooms and sweat it out.”
I could see her jaw clench in frustration, but the young woman relented, dipping her head toward her teacher before marching back into the house.
“She didn’t even apologize,” Adem muttered under his breath.
Darrin let out a sigh as he ran a hand through his blonde hair. “I’ll apologize on her behalf. Briar is…prideful of both her upbringing and her personal accomplishments.”
“Quite the bucket of sunshine, that one,” Alaric said as he took a generous sip from his glass of wine.
“I’ve seen worse,” I said with a shrug, my gaze lingering behind where Briar had stomped off.
The retired ascender let out a chuckle as he lifted Pen from his lap. “Now then, the three of us have some things to discuss.”
The twins shared a relieved look as they scurried inside, but Pen had to be shooed away by the housekeeper. Adem lingered, looking at Darrin hopefully, his face falling when the ex-ascender waved him inside as well.

Darrin watched the boy sulk back into the house.
"He's your ward?" I asked, curious about why a wealthy ex-ascender seemed to be running his own halfway house for Alacryan youth.
Darrin nodded and sipped from a wooden mug. "His parents were both killed in the Relictombs. I didn't know them, but Pen's mother did. The boy didn't have anyone else, and he would have ended up in the slums somewhere, or given to some rat-hole academy that'd only half train him before sending him off to die in the war."
"So you adopted him instead?"
Darrin frowned at me in confusion. "Adopted? No, of course not. Only the named bloods or highbloods are allowed to formally adopt. Is it… different, where you're from?"
I quickly shook my head. "I didn't mean a formal adoption, no, just that you'd taken him on. That's… very kind."
Thanks for the heads up, I thought to Regis.
'Huh? What? I wasn't paying attention.'
Resisting the urge to roll my eyes, I focused back on Darrin. "And the girl? Briar?"
"You mean Miss Superiority?" Alaric snorted.
Darrin shot Alaric a meaningful look before turning back to me. "Briar has just been a bit upset that I've been preoccupied with your trial instead of being here, training her. Her parents have paid me good money to mentor her, but she is in the mindset that physical and magical prowess is all that's needed to survive the Relictombs."
"It definitely doesn't hurt to be stronger," I argued, my gaze lingering on the door that the kids had left through.

Darrin's gaze grew distant. "Yes, but coming out of the Relictombs alive is also a team effort."

'You hear that? Apparently we've been doing it wrong,' Regis chimed in with a chuckle.

"Anyway, while my life is definitely missing that glamor it once had, it's much safer for me to be training kids than ascending." He scratched his cheek, looking almost embarrassed. "While he's not my blood, I couldn't leave Adem alone and just go off on ascents when each one could be my last. If something happened to me…well, then he really wouldn't have anyone."

"Yep, Darrin here is a real softy. It's why I knew he'd help you," Alaric said with a lopsided grin before nudging his former student with an elbow. "Remember the time when—"

I watched silently as Darrin massaged the bridge of his nose, letting out a deep breath as Alaric reminisced about old times. Being around the likable young ascender—or ex-ascender—had become increasingly uncomfortable for me. Not because I was afraid of him finding out who I was, but because it was becoming increasingly difficult to see him as an enemy. His concern over Briar, his sympathy after adopting Adem, and even babysitting his former teammate's child…I just couldn't link him to the same people who I had gone to war against.

"I'm sorry, Grey. Alaric and I tend to get a bit sidetracked when we talk," Darrin said with a laugh. "Now, where were we…"

"Aside from you being 'a softy', as Alaric put it, I'm still not sure why you chose to help me," I answered, studying the retired ascender.

“I’m not sure what Alaric promised you, but I don’t have much wealth.”

Darrin stood and crossed the porch, leaning against the railing. “Most of the people I help don’t. No, I don’t need money. I still make a little on the side by visiting the academies and telling scary stories to the students to keep them in line, and of course for taking on private students like Briar, but I made my fortune in the Relictombs, and it’ll keep me comfortable until I’m an old man.

“I just… don’t like to see the little guy getting stepped on by the nobility. And I really don’t like it when ascenders get thrown away, just because they don’t have highblood backing.”

“That explains why those judges hated you so much,” I noted, remembering their open hostility.

Darrin laughed softly. “Yeah, it wasn’t the first time I’ve been at cross purposes with Blackshorn and Frihl.”

“So… you expect me to believe you helped me out of the goodness of your heart?” I leaned forward in my chair, watching the Alacryan closely.

He turned his back to the hills and rested against the rail, meeting my gaze with an intensity I hadn’t seen from him before, even at the trial. “Not exactly.”

I watched him carefully, unsure where he was going with this.

“I invest in people, Grey. People like Adem, Katla, and Ketil. People like a dozen other ascenders who were taken to trial, over accolades rights, or accidental death, or expired badges.”

“You expect a cut, like Alaric?” I said, unsurprised.

Alaric snorted. “That’s exactly what I told him to do, kid! But he doesn’t have my business acumen.”

Darrin gave him a deadpan look. To me, he said, “I expect you to remember that people can be kind, and when you see someone who is down on their luck, or who isn’t as fortunate as you are, or who needs help, that you’ll do what you can.”

I blinked, waiting for a punchline or an “and” to come after, but Darrin just sat silently.

“That’s it?” I finally said. “You just expect people to… pass it on?”

Darrin gave Alaric a quick glance before turning back to me, his eyes sparkling and a boyish grin reappearing on his face. “Okay, there may be one more thing…”

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PROTECTION

HOLLOW FOOTFALLS ECHOED against the fortified walls as Darrin led Alaric and me down a long winding stair that took us deep underground.

What greeted us at the end of the short journey was a thick, rune-inscribed door that opened into a large training area. My gaze swept the wide room as memories of the training grounds in the flying castle, where I had trained with Hester, Buhnd, Camus, and Kathyln after becoming a Lance, resurfaced.

With the nightmare about Tess and Cecilia still fresh in my mind, the past felt like it was floating closer to the surface than usual.

That seems like another lifetime ago, I thought with a sigh, halting in the doorway.

'That brings up a good question: exactly how many lives do you have, anyway?' Regis inquired, his incorporeal form radiating amusement and genuine curiosity. *'Nine, like a cat, or are you more like a river nix, just molting and remolting forever?'*

A river nix?

'It's this tube shaped little mana beast that lives in the rocks underwater. It sheds its crystalline exoskeleton every morning, coming out brand new, and if you cut one in two, both halves regenerate.'

Stepping into the training room, I considered what it would be like to sprout a clone of myself every time one of my limbs was lopped off.

Regis cursed in my head. *'Please forget I said anything. That image is horrifying.'*

Like the door, runes were inscribed into the floor, along the walls, and across the ceiling. I followed a line of the runes, trying to determine what they were for.

"Warding runes," Darrin confirmed. "To keep the house above safe. It means I can pretty much go all out down here without even waking Sorrel from her nap."

It was an impressive training room, though not quite as grandiose as the one in the flying castle.

"So after going against the high judges and a named blood for me, this is all you wanted?" I asked, still browsing the unembellished room. "A sparring session?"

Alaric picked lazily at his ear. "He's just weird like that."

"Really? I think it's normal for a fighter to want to always test himself," Darrin replied as he stretched on the ground.

"Excuse me, Mister Darrin!" Sorrel chimed in from the door. The children were clustered around her and peeking eagerly into the training room. "Sir, the children were hoping they could come watch?"

Darrin looked at me, and while I wasn't keen on showing my combat prowess to even more Alacryans, these were just children. "I don't mind."

The retired ascender beamed in delight as he waved them in. "It'll be a great experience for them!"

"I should've charged you for this," Alaric groused.

"The amount of alcohol you've already inhaled from my shelves should be enough to call us even for this favor," Darrin said with a wink.

As the children situated themselves into the far corner of the room, Briar walked in through the door. With a towel draped across her shoulders and sweat shining on her face, she took a seat with the rest of our audience.

While Adem and the other children were obviously eager for the show, Briar watched me even more critically than the judges of the High Hall.

"Do you need some time to warm up?" Darrin asked, getting back up to his feet.

I shook my head, throwing the outer robe that Sorrel had provided for me on the ground.

"A couple rules then," he went on, stretching one arm across his chest. "No killing or maiming, obviously." Darrin followed this statement up with a smile to make it clear he was joking. "Since we don't have Shields—"

"I can create a barrier around myself," I said, knowing he was about to find out anyway.

Most of the Alacryans I had fought in the war hadn't been able to protect themselves with mana, instead relying on their battle groups, specifically the mages known as Shields, to protect them. My experience with other ascenders in the Relictombs suggested not all Alacryan mages were so strictly limited, but I didn't want my ability to stand out too much.

"Good," he said. If he thought it was odd, he didn't give that away. "Specialization has become popular ever since the simulets allowed ascenders to climb the Relictombs together, but I'm a firm believer that versatility has much more merit when things go wrong."

“Stop preaching,” Alaric booed. “None of these whippersnappers want your outdated opinions.”

“You probably experienced it yourself, Grey,” Darrin continued, ignoring the old drunk’s comment and the children’s snickers. “The Relictombs require flexibility and creativity if you want to survive.”

I simply nodded as Regis’s voice rang in my head.

‘Yeah, show some more creativity than “imbue body with aether, punch things,” princess. Didn’t you used to be a quadra-elemental mage?’

True, but I couldn’t regrow an arm back then, I thought flippantly.

‘… Touche.’

“Any other rules before we get started?” I asked.

“I normally wouldn’t mention this, but I’d say, for you, avoid big attacks in the direction of the children,” Darrin added with a wry smile. “That barrier is sturdy, but after what I saw against those mercenaries, I’m not so confident in it.”

I allowed a small chuckle. “I’ll keep that in mind.”

From beyond the barrier, a chorus of supportive shouts rang out from Pen and Adem, encouraging Darrin. He gave them a gracious wave before settling back into a fighting stance, his fists raised like a boxer.

No shouts of support from my usually-mouthy companion? I asked Regis, poking him mentally.

‘Woo, go Arthur,’’ he replied drolly.

Gee, thanks…

Darrin nodded, indicating he was ready, and I returned the gesture.

Instantly, Darrin's form blurred as he lunged forward, his fist snapping out at my chin. Catching the attack mid-strike, I redirected the blow away while pivoting my forward foot behind me, reversing my stance.

He carefully avoided overbalancing or opening himself up for a counterattack, instead throwing another jab, feinting, and throwing a hook at my ribs instead. I stepped forward, inside the punch, and drove my elbow into his chest, sending him stumbling back a couple of steps.

The children's cheers went quiet as Darrin rubbed the spot where I'd hit him. "That was… fast," he said appreciatively.

"Get him Uncle Darrin!" Pen yelled.

Cracking his neck, Darrin fell back into his fighting stance before launching a flurry of punches and kicks. He struck with brutal efficiency, moving between attacks with fluid grace born of long practice. The athletic ex-ascender would have easily outclassed most people in hand-to-hand fighting, even without his magic.

But most people hadn't been trained by an asura.

I avoided my opponent's blows without counterattacking for a handful of exchanges, letting him maneuver me around the training floor as he attempted to pin my back to the wall, then, when he was fully in his rhythm, I reversed course, responding to every blow with one of my own.

In moments I had the Alacryan backpedaling, flailing to defend against attacks that were both stronger and faster than his. When he extended his back leg too far to keep his balance, I swept the front leg, sending him tumbling to the ground.

Groans and disbelieving yells came from our small audience. Ketil was on his feet, his face practically pressed against the inside of the mana shield, and even Briar's once critical gaze was nowhere to be seen.

Darrin's experience as an ascender shined as he immediately rolled backwards over his shoulder to come to his feet in a single motion, his face now a mask of determination. He nodded again, waiting for me to do the same.

This time, when he snapped out a jab, his fist fell well short of my body, but a slight change in air pressure prompted me to dodge anyway. Something hard and heavy brushed past my left cheek, clipping my ear.

The layer of aether clinging to my skin absorbed the attack, but I was certain the strike would have knocked an unshielded opponent out cold had it landed squarely.

"You even managed to dodge that, huh?" Darrin noted behind his tight guard. "That's a bit disheartening."

"You caught me off guard," I admitted, watching his eyes carefully for his next move.

"Maybe, but it seems like your monstrous speed and reflexes managed to make up for that," he replied before taking a few steps back, putting more distance between us.

Realizing what he intended, I rushed toward him, but was met by a barrage of attacks from every different direction. The direction of the attacks didn't seem to correlate with his physical movements at all, and he was good at masking his intentions by focusing anywhere except where the blows would come from.

Although I couldn't sense the wind-attribute mana's formation, there was a faint rush of air ahead of each attack. I ducked and wove, using my enhanced senses to track each extended punch by that subtle *woosh*, but the barrage was enough to keep me from closing in on Darrin to counterattack.

'Can't you just…I don't know, charge through?' Regis asked, bored. *'Or are you showing off your fancy dance moves?'*

A smile formed on the edge of my lips. *I can, but where's the fun in that?*

'Ah, we're going for fun. Got it.' Regis cleared his throat before shouting like an announcer at a prize-fight. *'Aaaand the retired ascender is keeping Arthur Leywin on the ropes! Can the Thrasher from Ashber come back from this one?'*

Fighting the urge to roll my eyes, I dashed forward, my feet carrying me forward in a zigzag path toward my opponent as I weaved between his bombardment.

Just as I reached him, the air in front of me lit up with crackling arcs of lightning, jumping around the edges of another—much larger—wind strike.

Shrouding my arms in aether, I pivoted on my lead foot. Whirling past Darrin's blast while using my aether-clad arms as a conduit to redirect the mana, I struck back with a lightning-charged attack of my own.

Darrin threw up his forearms in a tight crossguard to block my punch. While the retired ascender skidded back from the impact, the electricity surrounding my arms merely spread out like a web of flickering yellow light across his mana-clad body before dissipating.

One of the children shouted out in pure excitement, but Darrin's attention was on my hands, which had streaks of burnt skin that branched up my arms.

'That sure looks fun,' Regis deadpanned.

Darrin lowered his guard, concern in his eyes as he looked at my hands. "That looks pretty bad. Maybe we should get you—"

I held up an already healing hand, and his eyes went wide as the flesh returned to its naturally pale complexion. "No need."

Although he still wore a concerned frown, Darrin took a few steps back and indicated he was ready once more.

This time, I dove into the maelstrom of lightning-imbued wind punches eagerly, honing my focus until I saw nothing but the arcing lightning bolts and heard only the rush of wind. Darrin could throw two or three strikes per second, assuming he was going all out—which I wasn't sure if he was, yet—and I felt a real thrill of challenge as I spun, dipped, and dodged, avoiding blow after blow.

"Your speed is amazing," Darrin—who looked like a shadow boxer, kicking and punching at nothing—shouted from outside the storm. "But if you're trying to tire me out, you'll have to do better. I've fought for days without rest in the Relictombs before, I'll—"

Channeling aether into my muscles, nerves, and tendons, I timed Burst Step to the sliver of an opening within the cloud of strikes and appeared at arm's reach of Darrin.

He couldn't do anything more than stare, slack-jawed, as I swiped the blade of my hand across his chest. With aether condensed and molded into a single point over my straightened hand, my attack

pierced through the mana clinging to his skin and ripped a single clean line through his shirt without even touching his skin.

Much too late, Darrin brought his arms up to defend himself, then stumbled backwards away from me. This time, he didn't get up right away.

Collecting himself, Darrin inspected the ruins of his shirt. "Well, I think I've seen enough."

"What?" Adem yelled, rushing out from behind the barrier. "That attack didn't even hit! You can't quit now."

"Yeah," Pen said, stomping up behind the older boy, her arms crossed. "Uncle Darrin always wins." Sorrel scooped the little girl up from behind, causing her to squeal with surprise.

"Adem's just upset he lost his bet with Mister Alaric," Briar said, standing behind everyone else with her arms crossed.

"Briar!" Adem complained, turning red.

Alaric crossed the training floor toward us, a broad grin beneath his beard. "You really should teach your ward not to gamble, Darrin. Especially not against men four times his age and infinity more wise."

"Infinitely wiser," Adem shot back irritably.

"Are you okay, Uncle Darrin?" Pen asked in her small voice, staring at the ex-ascender with wide, watery eyes.

He let out a good-humored laugh. "Of course, it was just a friendly match." He stuck his fingers into the hole I'd ripped in his shirt and wiggled them at the girl. "See? Not a scratch. Never forget Pen, your uncle was the leader of the *Unblooded*."

Adem and Briar groaned simultaneously.

“That was the craziest thing I’ve *ever* seen!” the blond boy, Ketil, exclaimed. “How did you move so fast?”

“Is that how all ascenders fight?” his sister asked, her eyes glued to the floor.

“No,” Alaric said, pacing the length from where I’d Burst Stepped to where we stood now, his old face crinkled up thoughtfully.

Darrin was frowning down at my hands until he noticed my attention, his head snapping up. “Grey is both fast and strong, but don’t let that intimidate you,” he said to Katla and Ketil. “You don’t have to be able to do what Grey or I can do to be successful ascenders, but you *can* be just as good as we are, if you work hard.”

Katla and Ketil shared a skeptical look at this. Briar turned up her chin, glaring around fiercely as if to tell us that she *would* be just as good some day.

“Well, I’m famished,” Darrin announced. “Why don’t we all go get that meal?”

The housekeeper bobbed politely and wrapped one arm around Katla’s shoulders, holding Pen in the other. “Come on, children, you can help me set the table.”

Unlike before, on the balcony, the blonde twins seemed disheartened to be pulled away from the adults, their looks of awed excitement fading, as they muttered, “Yes, ma'am.”

“Can't I ask Grey some questions?” Adem asked, lingering as Sorrel maneuvered the younger children away. “That was so cool. I want to—”

“Adem,” Darrin said softly, and the boy's mouth snapped shut.

“Of course, sorry. I'll go help with dinner.”

Behind him, Briar hesitated for a long breath, but when Darrin cleared his throat, she spun and followed the others. I couldn't help but notice when Briar stopped at the door, giving me one last inquisitive glance before disappearing.

As the group was ushered from the training floor, Alaric plucked at the tattered part of Darrin's shirt. The blond man slapped his hand away playfully, but Alaric wore a serious frown.

"That attack could have killed you," he said softly.

"I know." Darrin cracked his neck and led the way out of the room. Over his shoulder, he said, "It was like my mana just melted away where the attack touched…"

Darrin guided us up the stairs and into a surprisingly small dining room with a table for four.

He pulled an ornate bottle of amber liquid from a shelf and set it down heavily, clapping Alaric on the back. "I've been saving this just for you."

The old Alacryan's eyes lit up like a child opening presents on his birthday, and he flung himself into a chair before ripping away the wax seal around the cork with his teeth.

I slid into the chair opposite Alaric and gazed around. Aside from a couple of cabinets and shelves, there was also a tall, narrow bookshelf in one corner, heavily laden with leather-bound books. Beside the shelf, a window took up most of the far wall, looking out over the hills.

"What was that move you used back there, Grey?" Darrin asked conversationally, turning his chair around so he could rest his forearms on the back. "You used something similar against those

mercenaries, right? It was pretty impressive then, but seeing it up close and personal like that was…well, it was something else entirely."

I forced out an awkward laugh and rubbed at the back of my neck. "There wouldn't be much of a point in keeping my runes hidden if I go bragging about them to everyone I meet, right?"

"True," he nodded. "I'm against showing off my runes as well—a few gawking looks and envious stares don't mean as much to me as they would for most mages."

"It's because your runes aren't much to look at in the first place," Alaric jabbed as he took a generous sip from his glass.

"Anyway," Darrin said, giving up on prying more about my runes, "I had the children eat with Sorrel in the main dining room. We have some more serious business to discuss."

The retired ascender exchanged a meaningful look with his drunk mentor before turning back to me. "Grey, what is your plan now?"

"Now that I've more or less finished my preliminary ascent, I plan on heading back to the Relictombs by myself," I answered. "At least in there, I only have to worry about the mana beasts trying to kill me."

Darrin rubbed his chin in thought. "Do you plan on just staying inside the deeper levels of the Relictombs indefinitely? Because the first and second floors of the Relictombs are under constant surveillance, making your whereabouts very obvious to people of high power."

"Like the Granbehls?" I asked in a challenging tone. "If they try to—"

Alaric held up a placating hand. "Look, I'm sure the Granbehls got your last message loud and bloody clear. I doubt even they'd be stupid enough to attempt another attack on you directly."

“But that doesn’t mean they won’t tell their close named-blooded friends and their mothers about you,” Darrin continued. “And that doesn’t even account for the much more wealthy and powerful Denoirs, who also expect to be compensated.”

“And they’ve got a rather curvaceous carrot to dangle in front of you once they find you,” Alaric added with a waggle of his brows.

‘Curvaceous indeed,’ Regis agreed.

“If you’re referring to Caera Denoir, I hope you don’t think that the two of us went on some romantic getaway together in the Relictombs,” I said, a tinge of real annoyance lacing my words. “She was the one that disguised herself and tracked me down to observe me.”

“Regardless,” Darrin cut in. “From what I’ve gathered between you and Alaric, it seems like you want the freedom to be able to move as you want.”

I thought about all of the resources available that could help in Alacrya, as well as even the possibility to go back to Dicathen to see my family. “Yes. That would be ideal.”

“Good. Then we’re on the same page,” Darrin said. There was a moment of silence as the two Alacryan ex-ascenders shared that look again before he continued. “Okay, this next part might sound outlandish at first, but the best thing for you right now would be having a patron or sponsor of sorts.”

I tilted my head. “I don’t follow.”

“Okay.” Alaric scooted forward. “What you need is protection. Political protection, not the fighting kind. We know you can take care of your pretty, little self. The problem is, there are only a few

institutions—much less people outside of Scythes and the Vritra themselves—that would offer you the kind of immunity that would keep even Highblood Denoir from meddling. And it just so happens that I know a guy in the admissions office at Central Academy—""

"Academy?" I blurted. "Where Briar goes to school? You don't expect me to—"

Alaric gave me a squinty-eyed frown and took another drink straight from the bottle. "This is going to take us a long time if you keep interrupting every seven words." He paused, pinning me with a pointed look, but I stayed silent. "Yes, the very same Central Academy."

"So, what, you expect me to…attend school?" I asked, disbelief dripping from every word.

"No, boy, I expect you to *teach*," Alaric announced, a twinkle of amusement in his eye.

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I JUST STARED at the old Alacryan, not entirely sure I'd heard him correctly.

"Academy faculty are outside the normal societal ranks," Darrin said, following quickly on the heels of Alaric's statement. "At least at the prestigious academies. Even a powerful highblood couldn't pull you away from a teaching post, and the Granbehls would be stripped of their name immediately if they were caught arranging an attack on Central Academy grounds."

I leaned back in my chair, arms crossed, unable to keep one eyebrow from raising. "You said they wouldn't attack again anyway."

Alaric snorted in amusement. "C'mon, kid. Don't change the subject."

"The post is for an initiate-level melee combat instructor," Darrin continued, drumming his fingers on the table. He was watching me intently.

"Easy street, don't even have to teach the little wogarts magic," Alaric added with a grin. "Just swinging swords and running drills, that kind of thing."

"You'll only actually have classes a couple days a week," Darrin continued, "so once you're settled, you'll have time to—"

A faint knock at the door brought him up short.

A moment later, the door opened and Sorrel came in with two heavily laden trays full of food. "All this back and forth is hungry work," she said, smiling sweetly as she slid the trays onto the table.

'I know what you're thinking, obviously,' Regis chimed in while we waited for Sorrel to arrange the table and lay out a few utensils, *'but you and I both know that, logically, this is a pretty solid plan.'*

What about this plan seems logical *to you, Regis?* I shot back, unable to suppress a flare of annoyance.

'For carte blanche to keep doing our thing without interference, teaching some rich Alacryan brats how to hit each other with sticks seems like a small price to pay, princess.' Regis's tone was smug, since he knew he was pulling thoughts right out of my head to argue back at me with.

You mean teach Alacryan kids how to kill Dicathian kids?

'Is that what you were doing when you helped little Belmun in Maerin Town get a crest? Or what about Mayla and her emblem?'

I didn't have anything to—I cut myself off, waving the thought away. The truth was, I suspected that the reason the two children received such powerful runes in Maerin had something to do with me. I didn't know what, but it was too big of a coincidence to ignore.

'Haven't we moved past treating every Alacryan we meet like a mortal enemy by now?' Regis asked, letting the sharp edge in his voice fade to something almost sympathetic. *'Hell, aside from you, I've* only *met Alacryans… and I'm not being sympathetic, I'm being* convincing.*'*

I focused on Sorrel laying out the last of our dinner as I considered Regis's argument. He was right, but I tried really hard to keep that thought from leaking out to him. She beamed at the three of us before whisking back out of the room.

As soon as the door clicked shut behind her, Alaric started up again. "Remember where I first found you, kid? That little library in

Aramoor City? You go to Central Academy, and you'll have access to one of the biggest libraries in Alacrya. And with information a little closer to the source, if you know what I mean. Not so… thoroughly curated as what you found in Aramoor."

I ignored the old drunk in favor of stabbing a slice of some ruby red fruit with a fork before taking a bite.

"Ascenders do well in academy circles," Darrin added, smothering sweet-smelling butter onto a thick chunk of steaming bread. "And Central Academy, in particular, is very prestigious. A professor can easily arrange to get to and from the main Relictombs ascension portal when they want… or make accommodations to gain access to a secondary portal, or even a private portal somewhere. A lot of professors still go on ascents, so you won't stand out."

I frowned as I chewed on the fruit, which had a rubbery, jerky-like texture. My most immediate concern was returning to the Relictombs. If pretending to be a professor at this academy wouldn't be a barrier to that…

"You'd be surrounded by experts in a dozen different fields," Alaric went on. "The kind of people who love to show everyone how smart and talented they are. Mages who know everything there is to know about how runes work, about the Relictombs, about relics from the ancient mages… "

Swallowing heavily, I leaned forward and took a wedge of hard cheese from one of the trays. "Do they study relics at this academy?" I asked, trying not to sound too interested. By the way Alaric's face lit up, I knew I hadn't been entirely successful.

“No, relics all go to the High Sovereign, who probably has some super secret lair where his instillers do their experiments”—I felt my face fall as Alaric’s words doused the brief excitement I’d felt—“but they do have quite a bit of dead relics on display there!” he finished in a rush.

Darrin was nodding enthusiastically. “That’s true. I was a guest speaker there about a year ago, and they showed off what they call their ‘reliquary,’ sort of like a little museum for dead relics they’ve attained over the decades.”

An entire room full of dead relics? I considered the possibilities. If I could get my hands on more relics like the—

What should we call this thing, anyway? I asked Regis, thinking about the multi-faceted stone that allowed me to see my sister and mother.

‘The Orb of Long-Range Stalking,’ Regis said, drawing the name out theatrically. *‘I’ve already been calling it that in my head for weeks.’*

Just…no, I responded. *But whatever we call them, having a few more relics at our disposal wouldn’t hurt.*

“Okay,” I said out loud, “let’s say, for the sake of argument, I go along with your plan. How’s this going to work?”

Alaric thumped the table and grinned, spitting a few crumbs of food into his beard, and Darrin launched into a more detailed explanation.

That evening found me sitting cross-legged on the floor in one of Darrin’s comfortably appointed guest rooms, considering my

situation, while Regis snoozed on my bed, his huge bulk sinking into the soft mattress.

As much as I didn't want to admit it, Alaric and Darrin's idea did have some merit. Director Goodsky had made me a professor when I was only twelve, and I'd trained my hand-to-hand combat skills for years inside of the soul realm with Kordri.

The academy would provide me political protection from both the Denoirs and Granbehls, and it sounded like I'd be able to delve back into the Relictombs almost immediately.

The Relictombs…

Somewhere, three more ancient ruins were waiting for me to find them. I couldn't be sure if the zones Caera and I had ascended together were the same ruin or a different one, but I felt instinctively that I hadn't been successful in my second ascent.

Although I'd made significant progress with God Step—thanks to Three Steps—I hadn't had a major breakthrough, or found anything that guided me toward insight into a new godrune, since the keystone containing insight into Aroa's Requiem had technically been from the first ruin.

I couldn't help the thought that, to master the aspect of Fate, I had to find more zones like the ruined room where I'd spoken to the talking magic crystal. Why else would the djinn have left a remnant of themselves there, just waiting to hand out the keystone to the first worthy "descendant" to come along?

I cleared my mind and reached for the locations of the four ancient ruins, as Sylvia had described them. The implanted memories flashed through my head, but I found no guidance there; none of the places I

could see were familiar, except for the one I'd already been to, and I had no way to guide myself to them within the Relictombs.

"We're just stumbling around here in Alacrya," I said softly. "What if Agrona gains insight into Fate first?"

Regis's head lifted from the bed, cocking slightly to the side. "Then…we lose, I guess. Your girlfriend leads his army into Epheotus, and Agrona uses Fate to—I don't know—turn all the other asuras into dandelions or something."

Shaking my head, I let myself lean back until I rested against the cool floor. "Whatever Agrona and Nico did to Tessia, whatever those tattoos or spellforms were…I have to save her, Regis."

"For a girl you've been dancing around for your entire life—second life, whatever—I'm sensing a lot of mixed feelings here." Regis paused to consider his words. "Are you saving her out of love or guilt?"

I let his words steep before eventually letting out a sigh. "I'm not sure, maybe both? It's complicated…"

The shadow wolf yawned and rested his chin on his paws. "Coming from the guy who figured out how to rewind time to bring objects back to life."

I let out an absent chuckle, my mind drifting through all the stages of my relationship with Tess. From rescuer to little sister to friend and classmate, to something more. There was always some form of love amidst it all, but not in the way Regis meant it. Guilt of being a man much older than his physical body had kept me from examining my feelings in depth, pushing them away. Even the couple of kisses we shared were tentative, testing…

And then I'd disappeared to Epheotus, and Tessia had gone to war. We'd hardly seen each other during the war, and romance had been so far from my mind…

Then, suddenly we found ourselves together again at the Wall. The Tess I met there was a beautiful and talented young woman who had once promised to wait for me…

That night, that moment on the cliffs overlooking the Wall…that was, perhaps, the first and only time our relationship approached the label of *love*. Not that I'd been very good at it. Even with two lives, there were still some things I wasn't good at…

Just like Tess had said…

"Should I have never gotten close to her?" I asked the room, my voice barely a whisper.

"Then how would your life here have been any different from the one before?" Regis asked, not bothering to lift his head.

I opened my mouth to speak, but I couldn't form a response. There were a lot of things I blamed myself for, but getting close to all of the people that I've come to love in this world wasn't one of them.

Seeing me so conflicted, my companion let out a sigh and slipped from the bed. Turning in a circle, he laid on the floor next to me, his back pressed against my left arm.

I patted his slowly rising and falling side, then pushed my fingers through his fur.

"You're weirdly soft," I said, mustering a weak laugh.

"I know," he said sleepily, his jaw cracking with a huge yawn.

"Thanks," I said, knowing he'd understand what I meant.

Regis was silent, but I felt him fluff up with contented warmth.

“If only I could use the relic to see her…maybe we could figure out what’s really going on. I would know if she was…still herself.” There was a part of me that was glad I couldn’t, though. I was afraid of what I might see if the stone worked.

When I imbued aether into the extradimensional storage rune, Regis perked up again. “Are you going to try anyway?”

I only shook my head, forcing my mind away from the deep well of guilt and fear I felt whenever I thought of Tessia. She wasn’t my only concern right now. There was another old friend who needed saving, too, and I missed her just as much—perhaps even more—as the elven princess.

Withdrawing the iridescent egg, I turned it over in my hand, feeling for Sylvie within it. Unlike Regis, I couldn’t slip my mind into the egg, couldn’t console myself by touching her sleeping consciousness.

I couldn’t do anything about Tessia right now, but maybe…

Regis lifted his head up off the floor and looked over his shoulder at me. “It’s been awhile since you’ve tried to do your thing…crack the egg or whatever.”

Too long, I thought, considering the increases in power I’d made since Maerin Town. I’d been tempted to try during the long, tiresome days spent imprisoned by the Granbehls, but…I had also been concerned about what might happen if I succeeded.

“Well?” Regis prodded, scratching behind his ear with a paw. “Are you going to try or what?”

“I guess we’re safe enough here…”

I gazed nervously down at the stone, which would drain me of every drop of aether if I started imbuing it. *And if Sylvie suddenly reappears*

in front of me? Would my bond come back as a fox, or a girl…or a fully grown dragon, demolishing Darrin Ordin's home?

I wondered, not for the first time, if she'd be the same Sylvie who had been by my side since I was a child. Would she be angry with me? Would she remember everything that had happened, everything that we had done together?

What if she reappears, and she doesn't even know who I am…?

"Only one way to find out, princess," Regis said, stretching as he stood up.

Mind made up, I hopped to my feet and took three quick steps across the room, pushing open the large glass window that looked out over rolling hills. Since I didn't know exactly what would happen, I wouldn't risk Darrin's home by imbuing aether into the egg here.

I turned to ask Regis if he was coming, but I could already sense the answer. This was something private, something I needed to do on my own.

I held his eyes, nodded, then turned and jumped out of the window, clearing a row of decorative bushes and a small fence before landing in tall grass. The hills were ghostly in the dark, the pale grass colorless in the starlight.

Imbuing aether throughout my body, I jogged off toward a tall hill about a mile from Darrin's home, the softly gleaming egg in my fist.

Despite my best efforts to keep myself calm, my heart thrummed in my chest as I sat cross-legged in the stiff grass. The last time I'd attempted to imbue aether into Sylvie's egg, it had felt like I was throwing buckets full of water into a quickly draining reservoir. But

that had been a lot better than my first attempt, shortly after I'd formed my aether core.

Based on my best guess—it was a lot harder for me to pinpoint the clarity of my aether core than it had been my mana core—my growth between Maerin Town and now was significantly higher than what I'd accomplished on that first ascent.

It hadn't taken much aether to make the short run to the hill, but I still decided to absorb all the aether I could from the atmosphere before starting. The process was significantly slower than in the Relictombs, where the atmosphere was rich with it, but I kept going until my core was completely full.

To make sure I was maximizing my chance of success, I then released some of the aether from my core, letting it move naturally throughout my body and exerting no conscious influence over it. Most of the aether moved toward my hands—or, more accurately, toward Sylvie's egg—and some of the excess was lost, but after thirty minutes or so of meditation, my core was overflowing and my body was swimming with free-floating particles of aether.

The sensation gave me a giddy feeling, like I'd had a few drinks and was just on the edge of being drunk.

"All right, Sylv," I whispered. "Let's see if this works."

Gripping the incandescent stone firmly, I closed my eyes and felt the warm radiance of my aether core within my sternum. Imagining the aether channels that ran all throughout my body connecting to my core like little highways, each with its own gate holding back the aether until I released it, I took hold of those gates in my mind.

It was important that the aether all flow into the egg, but it was also important that I channel the aether fast enough to fill the reservoir within it. Of course, if I just sent out an uncontrolled blast of aether, most of it would dissipate into the atmosphere instead of flowing into the egg.

All at once, I opened the gates and *pushed*. My body grew hot as the flood of aether rushed through my lava-forged channels. At first I was too focused on preventing aether from escaping or being absorbed into my physical body to fully appreciate what was happening with the egg, but as more and more of my aether was imbued into the stone, I realized with a shock that it was *working*.

More of the purified aether was being drawn into the stone, now, with only a trickle of impure energy rushing out again—a significant improvement.

The spiraling path within, where the aether was drawn into the heart of the egg, began to glow with vibrant amethyst light. Around me, the hilltop was bathed in purple light, splashed through with green, red, and blue shadows.

My core began to ache dully, like an overstretched muscle, as the very last of my aether was pulled into the egg.

The light faded as the vibrantly glowing stone went dim, then dark.

Then, from deep inside the little stone I'd carried since awakening in the Relictombs, there was a *crack*. It was something I *felt* rather than heard, like stepping on too-thin ice and feeling it shift beneath my feet.

I waited for something to happen. Would the stone burst open as the aether coalesced back into the form of my bond, just as she had

faded into nothing before my eyes? Or would she be reborn from the egg itself, crawling out the size of a newborn kitten?

A few seconds passed, and I started to grow nervous. After a minute had gone by, I knew something was wrong.

There was no longer any aether swirling down through the egg. It had devoured everything I had given it, but it hadn't been—

I froze. Something was different. I could *sense* it, even if I couldn't see it.

Although my core ached from being drained, I spent a few minutes gathering aether, just enough to send an experimental burst into the little stone. Sylvie's egg took it hungrily, but unlike before, the aether didn't spiral down into the egg's center.

The line of purple motes followed a sharp-angled geometric path as they were absorbed.

I let my head hang, the wheat-blond hair I'd inherited from Sylvie cascading over my face. "Another layer." The words fell like dead leaves, dry and paper thin.

If I took into account the complexity of the new pathway, I was certain this new layer of the reservoir would require even more aether than the first.

And it might not be the last.

My hands trembled as a bitter scoff escaped my lips. To have my excitement turn so abruptly to disappointment left me stunned, staring blankly at the egg until my vision blurred.

Letting out a shuddering breath, I recollected myself and wiped away my tears before pressing the iridescent stone against my forehead.

“Even if it takes all the aether in the Relictombs, I’ll get you out of there, Sylv.”

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A WEAPON AGAINST HIM

CAERA DENOIR

Night birds twittered softly from the treetops as I wandered through the orchard outside Corbett and Lenora's Central Dominion estate, having been released for a brief moment of leisure time after dinner—an awkward, tense affair due to Grey's failure to show up.

But then, I knew he wouldn't, which I'd tried to explain to the Highlord and Lady. Grey must have seen right through their tactless attempt to manipulate him. After all, they sent *Lauden* of all people to High Hall to put an end to the sham trial.

Kicking a large seed pod that had fallen from the branches above, I watched as it bounced down the path before tumbling into the thicker grass beneath the trees. Something small and quick moved in the twilight gloom, scurrying through the undergrowth to inspect the commotion.

Although I knew Grey wouldn't come, I still found myself disappointed, an emotion that frustrated me more than the cause itself. It had been three weeks, but I was still struggling to come to terms with how I felt about the man, or what I wanted from him.

Perhaps I should be asking myself: what does Grey want from me?

I released a deep sigh into the warm night air as I pondered the question.

Soft steps crunching in the gravel path warned me that someone was approaching. I conjured a layer of mana to cling tightly to my skin and peered through the gloom. It was unlikely that I'd be

attacked here of all places, but only the High Sovereign fears no treachery, as the saying goes.

Just as I finished that thought, the air shifted behind me, and a length of solid shadow coalesced from nothing, swinging toward my neck. I ducked under the attack, letting the motion carry me into a standing sideways flip as the shadow hissed past my ear.

My own scarlet sword was in my hand and burning with black soulfire in an instant, but I couldn't sense anyone else in the orchard, nor determine the source of the black edge that had nearly taken my head off.

Which meant it could only be one person.

Spinning, I brought my long blade around in a wide arc over my head, black flames spreading out from it in a destructive nova. There was a ripple in the flames just to my right, but by the time I snapped out with a short, sharp strike, she was gone, and a razor-thin shard of purest black mana was pressed against the side of my neck.

"Tsk, tsk," Scythe Seris said, appearing as if from her own shadow. "If I were an assassin you would be—"

Soulfire leapt from my flesh and raced along the edge of her blade. With an amused huff, she let the conjured weapon disappear, but the soulfire still hovering in the air between us condensed into a flickering arrow that launched toward her throat.

In the space of a heartbeat, a mist of dark energy was billowing around her. My attack dissipated as the aura hungrily devoured my mana.

“Your control over the soulfire is progressing nicely,” she said, her lips twitching up at the corners. “It appears the mysterious Grey has pushed you past your most recent plateau.”

I stowed my weapon, turning my eyes to the gravel at our feet. “You give me too much credit,” I replied evenly, ignoring the flushing of my cheeks at Scythe Seris’s teasing. “It is thanks to your training and mentorship that I have reached this level.”

She rolled her eyes pointedly and turned, her hair—normally pearl-colored, but now a deep amethyst in the low light—swirling after her. “You’ve never been a kiss-ass, Caera. It’s one of the things I like most about you. Don’t start now.”

Biting my lip to keep from smiling, I followed as my mentor walked deeper into the orchard. “I wasn’t expecting you this evening, Scythe Seris.”

“I’m going away for a little while. I wanted you to be aware.”

“To the other continent again?” I asked, clasping my hands together behind my back. “Are you ever going to—”

“Yes,” she said, her voice low and heavy with intent. “To both questions. But now is not the time, Caera.”

We walked on in silence for a minute or two as my thoughts turned to the war. The Denoirs were one of the few highbloods that hadn’t claimed land in the enchanted forest in Dicathen. Corbett and Lenora’s star has risen yet higher as so many other bloods suffered, some wiped out entirely by the unexpected devastation there.

My adoptive parents had sent a fair number of soldiers to the war, of course. It would have made them look weak to stay out of the fighting, even where it was an option. But when Corbett had seen

the named bloods, and more than a few highbloods, race to claim choice land and slaves in Dicathen, he had only met their excitement with a quiet smile, insisting "Alacrya already has everything the Denoirs need."

Time, it turned out, had proved him wise, as much as I hated to admit it. It would have broken my adoptive parents' hearts if Lauden had been busily establishing an estate for the Denoirs when the asuras attacked. Not that I'd have minded terribly…

"Apparently the trial of Ascender Grey was quite the spectacle," Scythe Seris said to break the silence.

"It should have been a straightforward issue to resolve," I said with an edge of bitterness. "It's an embarrassment, honestly, to know that our legal system can fail so dramatically."

Scythe Series responded with an elegant laugh. "The highbloods have spent generations bending the system to their benefit, so much so that most of you hardly notice anymore. Your surprise is evidence enough of this."

Hurrying my pace to walk beside her, I met my mentor's eye. "Why do the Sovereigns not intervene?"

"The better question is, why would they?" she asked, one eyebrow raised. "They have carefully crafted a system by which purity of blood is paramount, have they not? They let the highbloods get away with murder, so long as it doesn't interrupt their own machinations. No, the truth is, girl, that the Sovereigns care little about what the lessers do to each other, so long as it is done with the appropriate amount of reverence to each dominion's overlord."

Scythe Seris opened her mouth to keep speaking, then gave me a shrewd look. “Clever little half-blood. You got me to change the topic.”

I straightened, practically marching like I was in a military parade. “You’re just teasing me again. We both know you’re not going to tell me what you know about Grey, so I’m not going to ask.”

This elicited another delicate laugh from my mentor. “If you want him to trust you—really trust you—this is knowledge you’ll need to earn on your own, Caera. I won’t give you any shortcuts.”

“But you want me to stay close to him? You’ve hinted that much.” I kept my attention straight ahead, but I could feel her examining me. “Am I to be your spy, Scythe Seris?”

“You are,” she confirmed. “But don’t think that you’re betraying him. After all, the boy owes me quite a lot.”

I paused at the sound of heavy crunching steps moving quickly along the path behind us. If anything, my conversation with Scythe Seris had only made me more confused and conflicted regarding this situation, so that I was almost relieved by the interruption.

My mentor and I watched as the figure of my attendant, Nessa, appeared out of the gloom.

“Lady Caera, I—”

Nessa’s eyes widened comically when she noticed the horned Scythe beside me, and the poor girl threw herself into the gravel at our feet. “Please forgive me, Scythe Seris Vritra! I did not realize!”

My mentor looked imperiously down at the terrified attendant. “Be more attentive in the future.” Despite her tone, I could see that

same, barely-visible twitch at the corner of her lips. Then, without another word to me, she turned, and vanished into the night.

"You can get up now, Nessa," I said.

Shakily, my attendant crawled to her feet. "Lady Caera, again, I had no idea, I apologize for my—"

I waved her apology away. "No matter. I can only assume my adoptive parents sent you?"

Nessa's quick, labored breaths slowed, and she folded her hands in front of her and rearranged her facial features into a less terrified expression. Finally, after clearing her throat, Nessa spoke again. "Yes, Lady, you… you're to see your parents in the highlord's study immediately. It took me a few minutes to find you, so you'd best get going."

A loud hooting noise from nearby made Nessa jump, and she took a step closer to me. "We'd both better get going," she muttered, glaring out into the dark trees.

When I arrived at the door to Corbett's study, I found it slightly ajar. Lenora was speaking quickly, her voice low and rich with frustration. "The gall, Corbett, can you imagine? Ascenders would be lining up to fight in the streets just for the *chance* at a private dinner with us, and yet this man has the nerve to stand *us* up?"

"Indeed," Corbett said, the single word cold and sharp as broken glass. "One would think Ascender Grey has no sense of propriety or decorum at all."

“Perhaps Caera isn’t as important to him as we’d believed,” Lenora went on. “If only we knew what Scythe Seris Vritra *wanted* with the ascender…”

“And yet, once again, your information network has proven invaluable,” Corbett said, his tone softening somewhat. “The fault is not yours, my love, but his. By the Vritra, if only this ascender weren’t so valued by our patron, I’d have him thrown into Mount Nishant.”

Having heard enough, I knocked lightly on the door before letting myself in. Lenora, who had been pacing back and forth in front of Corbett’s ornate desk, stopped and straightened as I entered. Corbett was sitting behind the desk, one hand wrapped around an empty crystal glass. He was glaring into the far distance, as if still imagining Grey being hurtled into the caldera of an active volcano.

I glanced around the study. Shelves of books occupied almost every inch of wall space, wrapping around the entire room, with breaks only for the door, a large window behind his desk, and a brick fireplace. In many highblood households, this collection of knowledge would have been for show alone, but Corbett was a well-read man, for all his other faults.

Above me, a rail of black iron ran around a narrow walkway, where there was another set of bookshelves. Aside from books, the shelves displayed a wide assortment of tokens and treasures Corbett had collected over the years.

“Caera, dear,” Lenora said, flashing her dazzling smile at me. “We have some news about your friend, Grey.”

I stood stiffly, my hands clasped together in front of me. Using a trick shown to me by one of the many tutors I'd had over the years, I took two breaths before responding to keep myself from sounding too eager.

"Oh? Did he send his apologies for missing dinner?"

Lenora let out a tinkling laugh. "No, I'm afraid we haven't heard from Grey himself, but I received a letter from an old friend of mine—an administrator at Central Academy—with some strange news."

My brows turned down into a slight frown. "What does this have to do with Grey?"

"That's the news," Corbett announced through gritted teeth. Leaning back in his chair, he swirled the empty glass around in his hand. "Apparently, there has been a rather unusual hiring at the academy."

Lenora was nodding along with Corbett's words. "Three days ago, someone pushed through hiring an unnamed, untried ascender for an initiate level post. *Most* unusual, wouldn't you agree?"

"Yes," I answered slowly. Despite understanding the suggestion Lenora was making, her words didn't make sense. "Especially if that same ascender was on trial for murder…"

"It's quite clever, really," Lenora said, leaning back against the desk and resting a hand lightly on the polished surface. "A total image makeover, and protection from the Granbehls in the bargain. Though I confess myself surprised that he has the kind of connections it would have required."

I resisted the urge to pace back and forth across the study. Standing straighter, I held my hands behind my back to hide the nervous

fidgeting of my fingers. The truth was, I found myself just as surprised as Lenora. First, the famous ascender, Darrin Ordin, showed up to defend him, and now Grey had suddenly been hired at one of the most prestigious academies in the central dominion?

Who are you, really? I wondered, picturing Grey's golden eyes gazing out from behind a curtain of pale blond hair.

I stopped fidgeting as a thought struck me. If Grey was going to be at Central Academy, I could easily speak to him—and without tracking him by the medallion, which I had sworn to myself to use only in case of a dire emergency.

I just have to escape Corbett and Lenora first.

I considered my adoptive parents. They wanted him beholden to Highblood Denoir for no other reason than Scythe Seris was interested in him, even though they had no idea why. I knew I could use that.

"Lenora…*Mother*," I said, knowing my use of the term would delight her, "how do you plan to keep an eye on Grey if he's shrouded by the academy?"

If I could convince them to let me go to Grey…

As I had anticipated, Lenora beamed at me happily. "Why, that's where you come in."

Corbett cleared his throat and set his glass on a square of cork on his desk. "We've already arranged for you to take on your own role at Central Academy. You'll be the assistant to Professor Aphelion. I'm sure you remember him."

I blinked. "What?"

Lenora pushed away from the desk, walking up to me and resting her hands on my shoulders. "This is important, Caera. I know you didn't enjoy the academy while you attended as a student, but this is about *blood*."

I gave her a tight-lipped smile and took a step back, giving myself a little room to breathe. While I was thrilled to be leaving the Denoir estate to spend time at Central Academy with Grey—and without so much as an argument from my adoptive parents—I also knew what they expected of me.

"You will want a report on his activities, of course," I said, my smile unfaltering. "And for me to convince Grey to… do what, exactly?"

"It takes more than idle fancy to turn a Scythe's head," Corbett said, standing to walk around his desk and linger in front of the fireplace, despite it not being lit.

"Scythe Seris hasn't… said anything to you, has she?" Lenora asked tentatively. "About this ascender?"

"Of course not," I said, bristling. "You know everything I do." This was a lie, of course, but not a significant one. I hadn't told the highlord and lady about Grey's use of aether, but otherwise I had told them everything I knew about him.

Which, as it turns out, isn't very much, I thought, considering again his strange hiring at the academy.

"He *is* special," I went on, "but I have no idea what, if anything, Scythe Seris wants with him." This was the truth, although perhaps not all of it. Seris knew Grey, somehow, but she hadn't been willing to provide me any more information after our last conversation.

Lenora stepped closer to Corbett, sliding her arm through his, and my adoptive parents watched me silently for several *very* long seconds.

Finally, Corbett spoke. “We hope you’ll impress upon this ascender how much we’d like to meet him—perhaps even work with him in the future. If you remind him of the role we played in his release”—I felt a muscle in my temple twitch as I kept from rolling my eyes—“so much the better.”

“And of course,” Lenora added, resting her head on Corbett’s shoulder, “you should let us know if you learn anything…interesting while working with Grey.”

“Fine,” I said, meeting my adoptive mother’s eye. “I’ll do it.”

But I won’t let you use me against him, I added silently.

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THE CENTRAL DOMINION

ARTHUR LEYWIN

"Alright, you remember everything I told you?" Alaric asked me for the third time, despite already covering it twice that morning.

The old Alacryan was standing with his hands in the pockets of a royal purple robe—an outfit closer to the bath robes of my previous world than the battle robes commonly worn by mages in this one—that was stretched just a little too tight across his midsection.

"Yes, Uncle Al," I said sarcastically, tugging at the hem of my own simple traveling clothes.

Darrin had offered to let me borrow a few high-end outfits, which he said would fit in better in the central dominion, but he was significantly broader across the chest and shoulders, and there was no time to have anything altered.

"You know," he replied thoughtfully, "I don't know if I hate that or not."

"By the High Sovereign, are we going or what?"

Alaric, Darrin, and I turned to look at Briar, who was leaning against the wall of Darrin's warp chamber. She had clad herself in crisp white leather armor, and kept her hand on the pommel of her slender blade.

The intractable young woman met our gazes unflinchingly. "I'd like to get back to the academy before I'm as old as you three."

'Considering all the forces of evil arrayed against you,' Regis said solemnly, *'who'd have guessed you would be murdered by a sixteen year old school girl.'*

Alaric barked out a laugh and clapped Darrin hard on the back. "However much Blood Nadir is paying you, make them double it," he teased.

The girl only huffed, redirecting her line of sight to the tempus warp, which sat at the center of a raised stone platform. The roughly anvil-shaped artifact was crafted of a dull gray, pockmarked metal, and engraved with dozens of runes.

A quick glance at the lines of runes told me it was based on a similar premise to the teleportation gates in Dicathen, but these were much more compact and complex.

"How far can this reach?" I asked, feigning casual interest.

Darrin bent down over the artifact, brushing off nonexistent dust from its surface. "It's powerful enough to get to the west coast of Sehz-Clar, or just past the southern border of Truacia." Seeing me frown, Darrin added, "More than strong enough to reach Cargidan City in the central dominion."

So not nearly capable of sending me home to Dicathen, I thought, dousing my disappointment. It was a foolish thought, anyway. As much as I wanted to tell my sister and mother that I was alive, returning to Dicathen now might actually put them in more danger than they already were.

'Hey, you still have the Creeper's Stone,' Regis said in what he thought was a consoling tone.

Sorry, the what? I asked, my train of thought completely derailed.

'I decided "Orb of Long-term Stalking" was way too long. Creeper's Stone rolls right off the tongue—figuratively speaking.'

Forcefully shunting Regis's thoughts to the back of my mind, I returned my attention to Darrin, who was beginning to calibrate the tempus warp for travel.

"I'm going to send you to the Library of the Sovereigns," Darrin was saying. "Briar, can you show Grey to the—"

"Student Administration Office, yeah." When Darrin cocked a brow at the girl, she straightened and said, "I mean, yes, sir."

Smiling to himself, Darrin finished the calibrations and stood back. "All ready to go."

I offered my hand to the Alacryan, and he took it. "Thank you for your hospitality, and your help," I said sincerely.

Although I could have forced my way out of the Granbehls' jail cell or the High Hall at any point, it would likely have made everything else I needed to do much more difficult—even impossible, if it drew the attention of a Scythe or two. Thanks to Alaric and his friend—*and Caera*—I'd avoided that.

"What you faced was a terrible injustice," he replied. "I'm glad we were able to help."

"You owe me big, kid," Alaric said wryly as I offered my hand to him as well. "Darrin here is never going to let me hear the end of it, and that's not even including all the other favors I've had to call in."

"My hero," I replied, deadpan.

"So, before you go, we better settle up."

Thinking he was joking, I gave him an exaggerated roll of my eyes, but then he slipped my old, empty dimension ring from a pocket and held it out. "Forty percent, I believe?"

Briar scowled. "Forty percent is highway robbery."

Darrin gave the old man an embarrassed frown, but kept his opinion on our transaction to himself.

"Plus ten percent for my services as your legal counsel," he added with a wink.

I made a show of sliding the ring on my hand and "activating" it as I rifled through the collection of accolades I'd brought back from the Relictombs. Few of the items were of interest to me, as the weapons would degrade too quickly when imbued with aether, and I couldn't use anything designed to channel or utilize mana.

When I pulled out the first piece—a silver crown set with blood red jewels that swirled with so much fire mana it was visible to the naked eye—Alaric beamed with unsuppressed glee.

One by one, I began handing over half the treasure I'd collected.

Briar's bright eyes grew larger and larger with each piece that came out of my extradimensional storage rune, and even Darrin failed to hide his surprise at the size of the payment, made up of a wide variety of shiny, lightly magical artifacts.

"I thought you said you didn't have any wealth?" Darrin asked, cocking an eyebrow in my direction.

"I don't. I have a bunch of stuff. It's not really 'wealth' until I get the chance to sell it, technically," I said as I pulled another accolade from my dimension rune.

Alaric made a show of inspecting each piece before tucking them away in his own dimension ring, trying to keep up a cool facade, but by the end he was practically drooling, and his hands trembled with excitement.

“Do me a favor and don’t drink yourself to death with this,” I said, fixing him with a stern look.

The old ascender hefted the ring as if he could feel the physical weight of all the treasure it now contained. “When you get to Cargidan, the local Ascenders Association will buy whatever else you have and put it right on your runecard,” he said distractedly. “And they can print you an official badge, too, now that you’ve completed your prelim.”

“You got all that from your *preliminary ascent*?” Briar asked disbelievingly, her eyes jumping from me to the dimension ring and back.

Darrin was quick to reply. “Don’t get your hopes up, Briar. That definitely isn’t a normal haul for a single ascent—or even several ascents.”

I simply shrugged at the young woman. “My travelling companion and I got lucky.”

“I’ll say,” Darrin replied. “Anyway, you two better be on your way. Grey, Briar will help you find your way around.” He eyed his student and ran a hand through his blond hair. “And Briar, don’t forget that Grey is going to be a professor at the academy. You may not be in his class, but I can’t imagine he’ll take kindly to any more rudeness from you.”

Briar was slow to peel her eyes away from me before stepping onto the platform next to the tempus warp, standing with military precision as she waited for me to join her.

“See you around, Grey,” Darrin said as I joined the young woman on the platform.

“Hurry up and get settled so you can go back to making me money,” Alaric added gruffly, twirling the dimension ring around his calloused finger.

“Bye bye!” a tiny voice said from the doorway as Pen peaked around the corner, waving.

I waved back, then the mansion faded around me, and I found myself standing on a different platform, far away from rural Sehz-Clar.

The transition was seamless, without any jarring sickness or twisting of my insides. The platform under my feet had changed from bare stone to dark wood, while the room around me was simultaneously cavernous and claustrophobic.

Glancing quickly around the rows of bookshelves, each one laden with leather-bound tomes, I considered the enormous amount of information contained within this library. *Tens of thousands of books on every topic imaginable. Although, if it’s as carefully curated as the library in Aramoor, there probably isn’t anything very important or useful here*, I thought, tempering my expectations.

Still, I was eager for a few quiet moments to spend studying Alacrya, the Sovereigns, and the Relictombs. There was still too much I didn’t know, too many ways I could mess up without even realizing it. I hoped the library would contain some answers.

Pulling my gaze away from the bookshelves, I caught sight of Briar standing on a separate small platform a few feet to my left. She was watching me carefully, but her attention was pulled away as a man in black and gray battle robes approached.

“Identification?” he asked in a bored drawl, holding out a hand.

Briar had hers ready, but I had to draw mine out of the dimension rune, making a show of activating my useless ring. The guard's eyes darted across the face of her identification badge before handing it back wordlessly.

When he got to mine, though, he stared at it for several long moments, a deep frown forming on his face. His eyes darted to me, then back. Briar huffed again, but he ignored her.

Eventually, he turned his focus on me, inspecting me closely, his gaze lingering on my simple clothes. "I'm afraid I'll need you to come with me, Mister Grey, so we can verify the validity of this identification."

Although the guard's words were professional, his tone told me clearly enough what he thought about the "validity" of my presence in the central dominion.

Letting my gaze pass over him lazily, I said, "Very well, but I hope you're prepared to handle the consequences of harassing a Central Academy professor."

Somewhat amusingly, the guard turned his uncertain gaze on Briar, who jerked her thumb at me and said, "Don't look at me, bud. He's the big shot."

"A, um, professor?" he asked, suddenly nervous as he glanced down at the identification badge again. "So sorry, Ascen—*Professor* Grey, I didn't realize—"

Reaching out, I plucked my identification out of his hand. "Wise man," I said coolly, marching past the man.

He took a quick step back, halfheartedly saying, "Welcome to the Library of Sovereigns, Cargidan City, Central Dominion," as we passed.

Briar gave me an appraising look from the corner of her eye. “Maybe you’ll fit in at the academy after all.”

“Not bad for a country bumpkin, huh?” I said with a wink before letting my gaze wander around the building again. The floors and walls were bright white marble, which stood out in stark contrast to the dark wood of the platforms, railings, and shelves.

A dome of silvery-white glass above let cool morning light into the library to glint and shimmer off the marble, and every shadowy corner was lit by lighting artifacts, making the entire interior of the building seem to glow.

Compared to the dingy little library in Aramoor, this place was a palace. The people sitting in reading nooks or milling about between the shelves seemed to be of a different class as well. They wore their wealth and stood casually, without the pompousness I’d seen from the Granbehls, and seemed all the more wealthy and powerful because of it.

In my previous life, I had met many other nobles from all over Earth who went by a hundred different titles. It was those who were the most comfortable in the trappings of their power that I knew to be wary of, and the people around me in the library seemed *very* comfortable.

A wide bay of white glass doors led out onto a green lawn, beyond which a busy street bustled with people. Although there was some foot traffic here, it seemed more common for these highbloods to travel by carriage, several of which were rolling by as I watched, pulled by a variety of mana beasts. The blood red oxen I’d seen used

in the Relictombs were most common, but I also saw one pulled by a reptilian horse, and another by an enormous bird.

"Come on then, *Professor*," Briar said, already marching quickly across the library lawn.

I followed, staying close behind her, but most of my attention was on the city around me.

Dark gray stone tiles made up the roads, contrasting starkly against the white stone of most of the buildings, which arched, swept, and rose high into the air in spires, pillars, and towers, accented with reds, blues, and greens. All throughout, harsh, black metal was present, adding a cohesiveness throughout the myriad of shapes and colors.

Behind it all, visible occasionally through the gaps between buildings, rose a range of enormous mountains, stabbing into the sky like the fangs of some world-eating beast.

Briar moved purposefully, leading us away from the library at marching speed.

"The academy campus is about a mile from the library," she said over her shoulder as we turned away from the main street and into a series of alleys. "Longer if you follow Sovereign Avenue all the way to Central, the main street that bisects the city."

"You seem to know your way around pretty well," I noted, my gaze tracking over the buildings around us. The alleys were clean, clear of both garbage and lingering people, the only other pedestrians moving purposefully, like we were.

Over her shoulder, she said, "It's a requirement. Students who can't navigate quickly through the city are likely to miss deadlines or fail assignments."

"Is the curriculum that intense?" I asked with genuine interest.

Briar stopped and turned to meet my eye. "Central Academy is one of the most prestigious academies in Alacrya, but you should already know that, *Professor*. People don't become successful ascenders by living soft, easy lives."

'Yeah, princess!' Regis crowed. *'Stop with your soft, easy life and step up.'*

I apologize for living such an easy, trial free life, oh great and powerful weapon of the asuras, I thought, deadpan.

Out loud, I said, "Not everyone learns well under that kind of pressure."

Briar wrinkled her nose. "The students of Central Academy aren't *everyone*. We're the elite, even among named bloods and highbloods."

Without waiting for a response, she spun, sending her bright hair twirling, and began to march again.

We walked in silence for a few more minutes before stepping back out onto a major thoroughfare. The street was heavy with foot traffic and lined with businesses that likely catered to the academy students: restaurants and taverns, armories, high end clothing stores, and a couple of shops that claimed to buy and sell accolades.

"You don't want those," Briar said when I slowed down to read the sign outside *Andvile's Accolades.* "These shops are all shady, and most of the people who trade with them are, too. Great if you have a

stolen accolade to get rid of in a hurry, but not so much for keeping your reputation as a professor of Central Academy. If you're going to sell off the stuff Alaric didn't screw you out of, take it to the Ascenders Association. The building is right outside the entrance to campus anyway."

Almost as if to emphasize her point, the door opened and a shifty-eyed man in dirty gray battle robes came out. His attention was on a glassy stone in his hand so that he nearly ran into me. He flinched as I loomed into his peripheral vision, shot me a suspicious look, then pulled his hood up and shuffled into the crowd of passers by.

Briar gave me a look that said, "See? Told you so."

I started to turn away when I noticed a moving image playing across the surface of some kind of crystal bound to the side of the building with black brackets. When I stepped closer, I realized the image was panning across a blasted, wrecked landscape.

Briar smirked. "This really is your first time to one of the big cities, isn't it?"

"It's some kind of projection artifact?" I asked, taking a step closer. "Showing recorded images?" Once I was standing within a few feet of the artifact, a strong male voice filled my head.

"—truly horrifying images captured from Dicathen's easternmost country of Elenoir. The loss of life, both to the native Dicathians known as elves, and those brave Alacryans who had volunteered to relocate to the distant forests, is incalculable. High Sovereign Agrona insists on calm, and requires all Alacryans to understand this assault by the vile asuras of Epheotus will not go unanswered.

“Furthermore, we will all join together to offer thanks to the High Sovereign, for continuing to protect us all in his—”

I took a step back, and the voice cut out. “Proximity telepathy?” I looked at Briar for confirmation.

She nodded, stepping back out of range herself. “My parents thought they were being really clever, guessing that the war was ending and betting on ascents instead. I guess the war isn’t quite as over as they thought.”

“Doesn’t the idea of going to war with beings capable of obliterating an entire country scare you?” I ask, slightly surprised by her lack of either empathy or fear at the images still playing silently across the projection artifact.

Briar shrugged and began walking again. Over her shoulder, she said only, “The Vritra protect Alacrya.”

I made note of the other merchants lining Sovereign Avenue, but didn’t stop to linger again. Within a few minutes, we were standing between two towering complexes, and before us a black iron gate blocked entrance into what could only have been Central Academy.

Several groups of students were making their way toward the gates. A handful of girls paused suddenly as they noticed Briar and me, and gave a happy shout. Briar grinned and waved back.

“Even though this has been *so* much fun, this is where I leave you, Professor.” She was already moving away when she said, “I assume you can find the way from here?”

“I think I’ll manage,” I called after her.

Trying to put the Alacryan girl out of my mind, I turned to examine the Ascenders Association building—or rather, buildings. The

towering white buildings flanking the entrance to Central Academy were actually connected by several arched stone bridges at varying heights above me.

"Oh my Vritra, Briar. Who is that gorgeous man?"

Despite the distance to the group, the noise of the street, and my own distraction, my enhanced hearing was enough to pick up everything the group of girls was saying.

"Is that your *boyfriend*? You said you couldn't hang out because you were in *training,* Bee! But instead you've been off galivanting with—"

"He's *not*, and you can shut up right now, Valerie, before I show you exactly how hard I've been training," Briar said in a low growl that only made the other girls grin even wider.

I cast a discreet glance their way to find the three girls staring—much less discreetly—in my direction, while Briar was already making her way toward the academy gates. Unlike Briar, who was in her white armor, the other three had donned matching black and azure uniforms.

They lingered only a moment before following Darrin's student away, but not without sending a couple of curious glances back in my direction.

"You know, I'm kind of surprised they're so…normal," I said, watching the students queue up at the academy gates. A memory of Ellie playing with the other girls from the School for Ladies surfaced, bringing a smile to my lips.

'Honestly, I'm more surprised Briar has friends,' Regis commented.

Smirking, I returned my attention to the Ascenders Association buildings. Black metal signs indicated that the entrance to my right was for "Testing & Teleportation" while the entrance to the left led to "Administration & Facilities."

Choosing the left entrance, I followed the short path up to the double doors—wide enough an entire carriage could have driven through them—and pulled the black iron handle. The door didn't open, but a moment later a small panel around face height slid open, revealing a helmeted guard.

"Badge?" he said in a bored drawl.

I withdrew the badge I'd received in Aramoor and held it up to the narrow slit. The man plucked it out of my hand and the panel slid shut again, leaving Regis and I to wait. A minute or two passed, long enough for two other ascenders—both short, thin men in the style of battle robes favored by Casters—to line up behind me, muttering grumpily about the wait.

After another minute, the lock finally released with a heavy *thunk* and the door swung inward.

A man in silvery battle robes with ebony pauldrons, bracers, and boots that caught and bent the light in an unusual, liquid way stepped forward. He had short black hair and a well-trimmed beard, with a hint of gray at his temples and chin.

"Welcome to the Cargidan City Ascenders Association Hall, Ascender Grey. We've heard quite a lot about you already."

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BURDEN AND STAKES

TO EITHER SIDE of the well-dressed bearded man, the Ascenders Association guards were giving me curious stares, and the two Casters in line behind me muttered something about "the high mage."

Amusement—and something else, something hungry—glittered in the man's eyes as he bobbed his head respectfully and gestured into the building. Turning on his heel, he moved away with the light but confident strides of a warrior, leaving me in a small entry chamber flanked by guards.

Though the entrance was uninspiring, stepping out into the wide hall beyond was anything but. I had thought the Aramoor Ascenders Association building had been impressive, but this place had more in common with a temple or palace than a simple guild hall.

The walls, ceiling, and floor were white stone—brighter and cleaner than marble—and carved columns broke up the room every twenty feet or so. Golden runes were inset into the floor in the shape of pathways leading from one section of the hall to another, and I could see the shapes of beasts laid out in jade in several places as well.

The walls were hung with dozens of tapestries depicting ascenders within the Relictombs battling against aetheric beasts. One large tapestry caught my eye; it showed three men in golden armor surrounded by a swarm of carralions—the clawed, babyish creatures I'd fought in the convergence zone.

I followed the man through the hall in silence as we moved swiftly past the grand tapestries and decor. My gaze lingered on the

extravagant artworks, wondering if these depictions were common tales that any passing Alacryan would recognize.

After passing a series of desks and comfortable seating areas, we made our way up a narrow staircase tucked away in one corner of the main hall. This brought us to a balcony surrounded by black iron railings, and led into a large office that overlooked the hall below.

Despite the lack of conversation during our journey, it was clear he was comfortable with the silence, or perhaps his position. The way he slid into his seat behind a massive desk carved of ebony and inlaid with gold filigree, then kicked his heels up on the lavish piece of furniture, suggested the latter. He waved at a plush chair in front of the desk, and I took a seat, never taking my eyes off him.

"So, here you are." The man grinned, but I could see the snarling grizzly wolf behind his amiable mask.

"I've just completed my preliminary ascent," I said, businesslike. "I need my new badge."

"Oh, I've already seen to it. My assistant will be up with it any minute." His smile cut into something more sly. "And I bet you have a whole dimensional storage artifact full of accolades to turn in too, right?" His eyes went pointedly to the ring on my finger. "Clever of you, to keep it from the Granbehls."

I sat up straighter, my lip curling into a sneer. "That matter is resolved," I said coldly.

He raised his hands innocently. "Don't misread me, Ascender Grey. That whole affair was bad for business—our business." His grin took on that sly quality again. "That little named blood doesn't have any

power here in Central Dominion anyway. No, I was being quite serious: you've shown yourself to be quite clever.

"So, how did you manage it?"

I let the question hang in the air while I considered my answer. It didn't help that I couldn't be sure which "it" he was referring to.

Not wanting to give anything away about myself, I finally said, "I'm not sure what you mean."

He slid his feet from the desk and leaned over it, eyeing me hungrily. "How did you secure the posting at Central Academy? An unnamed ascender, fresh from his prelim… it's unheard of."

I let out a sigh. "Complications often arise from knowing too much."

It was the man's turn to let my words hang for a moment before he leaned back and laughed, an uncontained, mirthful guffaw.

"That may just be the most pleasant way someone has threatened me," he beamed, pointing his fingers at me. "I like you, Grey! Damned but I like you."

'You've managed to attract yet another weird one,' Regis chortled.

Ignoring my companion, I scanned his desk to see if the man in front of me had a nameplate somewhere. "I'm afraid I don't—"

"Vritra's name, where are my manners? My name is Sulla of Named Blood Drusus, but everyone around here calls me Sul. I'm the high mage of this little establishment." The mage gestured out over the hall below.

"Do you welcome all new ascenders like this, Sulla?" I asked doubtfully.

"No," he said, leaning back in his chair. "I certainly do not. But then, not many new ascenders are given a principal's badge after a single

ascent, or made a professor at the most prestigious academy in Alacrya"—I didn't think it was possible, but his grin grew sharper—"I wanted to see you for myself."

I ground my teeth. This was exactly the kind of attention I wanted to avoid.

'Maybe you shouldn't always make such a spectacle of yourself then,' Regis commented mockingly.

"I'd just like to get my badge, exchange my accolades, and be on my way," I said with finality, making it clear that I'd like to end this interaction. "I still need to check into the Student Administration Offices and get settled in. It's been a long journey here."

"Ah, of course," Sulla responded professionally, but the slouch in his shoulders and the way he leaned back suggested that he was slightly put out. "Once again, I've let my enthusiasm override my good sense. But promise you'll come back soon, *Professor* Grey. I'll make sure your trip won't be wasted."

After selling the majority of the treasure I'd taken from the Spear Beak tribe, I escaped the Ascenders Association building and the high mage's probing questions, then proceeded straight for the Central Academy campus, eager to meet with my contact and find my rooms, which I hoped were quiet and free of any more probing eyes.

The black iron gates had opened of their own accord when I approached. On the other side, the close confines of the city streets were left behind in favor of wide walkways bordered by short hedges.

A fifteen foot wall of white stone wrapped around the campus, encircling it and setting it off from the city. The gates opened into a semicircular plaza, from which three paths branched away toward clusters of school buildings.

Dozens of young men and women in the black and azure uniforms of Central Academy were milling around the plaza, some chatting animatedly while others sat quietly on benches or in the grassy lawns between the hedges. A few cast me curious glances, and I realized that Briar had been right: I stuck out in my plain traveling clothes, even more than if I'd come to the academy in full battle attire.

Directly across the plaza from the gates stood the Student Administration Offices, a castle-like complex with a dozen peaks and spires that seemed to loom over the campus entrance. The central path from the plaza went straight through this building, under an arched tunnel lit with bright globes that hung from the roof.

A woman in tight-fitting white battle robes was standing just outside this tunnel, her eyes casting around as if looking for someone.

As I approached, making my way toward the open entryway into the offices, her amber eyes stopped on me, traveling up and down my body several times. Blonde hair tumbled in waves over her shoulders, bouncing in a way that seemed to defy gravity when she hopped in place before taking a few quick steps toward me.

'Her hair isn't the only thing that defies gravity…' Regis said suggestively. *'If you die, can she be my new master?'*

Why wait? I answered, pushing with my aether as if I intended to expel the shadow wolf from my body.

'Hey!' Regis groused. *'No need to get pouty.'*

The woman dipped into a shallow bow as we approached. “Plain clothes, gorgeous eyes, too young by half…you could only be our new level one Melee Enhancement Tactics professor, right?” She beamed at me and bounced on the balls of her feet. “I’m Abby of Blood Redcliff. I teach a couple of higher level wind-specialization Caster courses.”

“Um, hello,” I said, caught off guard by her forwardness. “I wasn’t expecting—”

“A welcoming committee?” she said with a happy laugh. “Well, a shy guy like you might not want to hear this, but you’re pretty much a celebrity around here already.”

Damn you, Alaric, I thought grumpily.

“Anyway, I just *really* wanted to be the first one to meet you, after everything I’ve heard.” She gave me a winsome smile, twirling a lock of her golden hair around her finger. “Did you really break the containment chains at your trial?”

“I’m sorry, I’m late to meet my contact in administration,” I said stiffly, stepping around her and making my way toward the door.

A surprisingly strong hand caught my elbow. “It can be kind of overwhelming here at first. I’d be happy to show you the ropes, Grey. You just let me know, m’kay?”

With a wink, my fellow professor released me and turned away.

I was distracted as I made my way into the administration offices and announced myself to one of the young clerks at the front desk. He gave me directions to a fourth floor office where Alaric’s contact could be found, giving me a bemused smirk when I admitted I needed to hear the instructions again.

'You okay, chief? What's got you so rattled?'

First the head of the Ascenders Association, then this other professor… We're getting way too much attention, Regis.

'You're thinking of cutting and running.' It wasn't really a question since he could read my mind.

No… yes… I don't know, I admitted. *I don't like feeling trapped.*

Regis barked out a laugh in my mind. *'You just spent three weeks in jail.'*

Stone and bars weren't holding me. I chose to stay, let that play out. I was trying to avoid *drawing too much attention.*

'How'd that work out?'

Almost as well as that piece of acclorite Wren Kain gave me, I answered with a smirk, taking the stairs three at a time to the fourth floor.

'I feel personally attacked. You know what, I'm going to take a nap. Wake me up when you're feeling less venomous, all right, princess?'

Despite my conversation with Regis—or perhaps because of it—I felt better by the time I was knocking on the office door of a man named Edmon of Blood Scriven, a mid-tier clerk within the administration office.

A reedy, nervous voice invited me into an office that wouldn't have looked out of place in one of the old detective movies from my previous world. The lighting artifact suspended from the ceiling was flickering and gloomy, casting a gray haze over the small office, including a simple desk piled with parchment and scrolls with the man hunched behind it.

“Close the door,” he said impatiently, his watery eyes following me as I did so before sitting down in the worn chair across from him.

“Edmon, I’m—”

“I know bloody well who you are,” the thin, pale man snapped as he wiped at his nose with the sleeve of his brown robe. “What that son-of-a-lurk-worm thought he was doing, forcing you in here, I swear to the Vritra I have *no* idea…” the man grumbled under his breath, as if unaware that I could still hear him.

We glared at each other over the top of his desk for a moment before I let out a long sigh. “What do I need to know, Edmon?”

He sniffed and wiped his nose again as he shuffled through some of the scrolls on his desk. “Once you’ve signed your contract, you can have your schedule and curriculum, and be on your way. Once you’ve left this office, I sincerely hope not to see you again for the remainder of your tenure here.”

Based on the man’s open hostility, I could only assume that his agreement with Alaric hadn’t been entirely equitable.

Edmon shoved a stack of parchment out of the way and unrolled a document explaining the details of my employment with Central Academy in legal jargon. I was surprised to note the pay, which hadn’t even crossed my mind.

“In the event that you don’t understand some piece of your contract…” Edmon shrugged his hunched shoulders. “It’s not my job to explain it all to you.”

Taking the offered quill, I wrote my false name, my hand automatically tracing the same swooping letters I had used to sign official documents as a king. Edmon’s spiderish hand snapped the

contract away the instant I'd finished, and he replaced it with a single flat piece of parchment and two long scrolls bound with iron rings.

"This"—he indicated the parchment—"has your schedule on it, while these"—he waved at the scrolls—"are your curriculum for Melee Enhancement Tactics and a list of the academy's rules. Read them very, very thoroughly, because I swear by the Vritra, I will not go down for your criminal uncle…"

"Listen," I said, starting to lose my patience with the man's snide remarks, "I don't know what sort of deal you and—"

"Deal?" he hissed, his eyes wide. "That no good drunk bullies and coerces me into hiring his wogart of a nephew, and you call it a *deal?* Just because he thinks you're worth this risk, doesn't mean *I* do. Now get the hell out of my office, and don't come back, or I'll—"

The man's mouth snapped shut as my aetheric intent washed over him, crushing him back into his chair. His eyes bulged, insect-like, and his fingers clawed at the surface of his desk, disrupting several of the scrolls.

"I'm just as happy to pretend this conversation didn't happen as you are," I said, my voice quiet and emotionless. "But I won't be threatened." To emphasize my point, I strengthened the aura, watching as the pale man's breath was choked off by the pressure. "I don't know why you're afraid of Alaric, but it would be wise to extend those feelings toward me as well… at the very least."

Grabbing the papers from his desk, I released my aetheric intent and swept out of his office.

'What did I miss?' Regis asked, the mental projection of his voice drawn out as if he were yawning.

Just making more friends, I joked. *You know me*.

My companion snorted, and I felt his consciousness drift away again as he went to "sleep," which for him was more of a meditative mindset while he absorbed aether from my core.

Back down on the ground level, the front-desk clerk looked up when I stepped out into the entry hall. "All done here at administration? Can I arrange for someone to give you a tour of campus or introduce you to the other faculty?"

"No, I've had a long journey here and would just like to see my room," I answered, recycling the excuse I'd given to the high mage at the Ascenders Association. "Can someone show me the way?"

The young man smiled with understanding. "Sure thing, Professor Grey. Let's get you settled in. Adelaide?"

"Hm?" A distracted young woman looked up from where she had her nose in a scroll at another desk.

"Can you watch the front desk while I show Professor Grey to his rooms?"

"Hm," she said in affirmation as her eyes jumped back to her reading.

Shaking his head and giving me a chagrined look, the young man led the way out of the building and turned right. We passed between two hip-height hedge rows that separated large, grassy areas where students were lounging and talking, reading scrolls, and wrestling around.

"Classes haven't started yet, obviously, but students are expected to arrive early, and the administration keeps things more or less open

so everyone coming back from the recess can enjoy themselves for a moment before the work starts."

My guide continued to chatter away, apparently feeling the need to give me the tour despite my insistence that it wasn't necessary. He told me the names of the buildings, yards, and plazas, as well as the history of the families for which they'd been named.

Although I had questions, I wasn't comfortable asking them, and instead maintained an air of tired, slightly bored aloofness. No need to give the talkative young man any reason to be suspicious about me.

It wasn't until we were passing a dark building that seemed to loom ominously over the path, that I saw something that truly interested me.

"Is that a portal?" I asked, looking at the rune-carved stone arch. It looked exactly like the teleportation gates in Dicathen.

"Sure is!" my guide said enthusiastically. "As I was just about to say, the Chapel"—he pointed with his thumb at the brooding, black-stone building—"was a gift from the High Sovereign himself, and houses Central Academy's collection of relics and artifacts. It was placed here exactly because the High Sovereign wanted it to look down over and guard the Relictombs portal."

There was no shimmering portal of energy hanging in the air inside the frame at the moment, but I could see a familiar series of controls next to it. "Can this portal be programmed to go anywhere, or just to the Relictombs?" I asked, feigning mild curiosity as I thought of Dicathen and my family.

“Oh, that’s the really cool thing, actually,” my guide gushed. “Apparently, a really, *really* long time ago, these kinds of portals were everywhere, connecting all of Alacrya. But during some ancient war, most of them were disabled or destroyed. The whole Central Academy was built on this spot—which used to be well outside of Cargidan City—exactly because that portal still existed.”

I waited.

The young clerk grinned at me for a moment before jumping. “Oh, right. Whatever magic made the portal work in the past was broken, but the Sovereigns had it retrofitted into a tempus warp set to take you directly to the second level of the Relictombs. You have to have a token to activate it, but yours should be waiting in your rooms.”

Too bad, I thought. Even if the portal still operated normally, though, it might not have reached all the way to Dicathen, and connecting it back to my home would have been much too dangerous anyway.

‘Maybe you can use Aroa’s… thingy to fix it?’ Regis pointed out. *‘Like you did with the portal back in the Relictombs.’*

If we ever need to leave Alacrya and don’t plan on coming back, I’ll try, I replied. *But for now, I need access to the Relictombs to gain control over the aspect of Fate.*

“So the academy was built around that thing?” I asked as we moved away.

“That’s right. Central Academy used to be like a city to itself. It still operates separately from Cargidan, with the director answering straight to Taegrin Caelum,” he answered importantly. “I’m sure you already know this, but the Sovereigns place a very high value on the education and betterment of young soldiers and ascenders, which is

why schools like Central Academy have their own place in the politics outside of the standard governments and blood structure."

I relaxed as I realized this young man would tell me anything I wanted to know as he happily continued explaining what must have been basic, well-understood facts about the academy and its role in Alacryan society. Suppressing a smirk, I imagined how his constant stream of information would have been pretty irritating for an actual Alacryan professor.

For me, though, his thoughtless banter made him the perfect guide, and allowed me to probe without worrying about giving myself away.

Finally, nearly an hour later, I sagged into the deep-cushioned couch in my own private quarters in a building called Windcrest Hall. Apparently it had been named after some highblood family in thanks for their contributions to the academy, but I'd tuned out most of the impromptu history lesson I'd received from my chatty young guide.

The three-room suite was significantly nicer than I had expected. Apparently Central Academy treated even their new professors to the finest accommodations. It wasn't large, but the living area contained a private projection crystal, like the one I'd seen outside the accolades shop, as well as a small table designed specifically for the game Caera had taught me to play in the Relictombs.

There was an empty bookshelf and a small writing desk, as well as the couch I was sitting on, and a large bay window that looked out over campus. A comfortable bedroom and a luxury bath opened off the living area.

I had been surprised to see there was no kitchen or any other way to cook within the private room, but the guide had laughingly assured me that I could have food or any book from the academy library brought up to my room at any time by a runner.

"Not too shabby," Regis said from where he lay curled up on the floor. "Would have been nice if they'd given us a second bed for you, but I guess you'll be fine on the couch, right?"

I let out a tired snort. Despite the fact that it was only early afternoon, my journey from Sehz-Clar felt like it had taken days. I could fight for days, even weeks on end, but dealing with this subterfuge and drama exhausted me.

It was hard to believe I'd somehow found myself back at school, once again a teacher. But this time, the stakes were much higher.

341
ASH AND DUST

ALDIR

Ash and dust.

Everything—every tree, every beast, every lesser being—for hundreds of miles, had turned to ash and dust. *This* was the power of the asura. I scanned the barren landscape for anything, any sign of life or speck of mana, that might have escaped my attack.

But there was nothing.

My steps crunched through the broken surface of the ground with every step as I wandered the wasteland that had once been Elenoir. Even the ground was not stable, threatening to collapse beneath me at any moment.

I was a soldier, doing my duty and following the orders of my lord. The scorched forest should have instilled in me a sense of pride, knowing I had struck a terrible blow against our enemies. Pride, however, was not the emotion I felt at the sight of this grim image. Not nearly.

When I was sent to kill the Greysunders, I had done so without hesitation. There had been no pride—because one does not feel prideful at the swatting of a gnat—but neither was there pity or remorse. It had merely been a necessary moment in the war, the elimination of two important enemy agents.

When Lord Indrath explained what was to happen to Elenoir, however…

"I can no longer afford to sit idly by while Agrona expands his control over the lessers. Alacrya was a sacrifice I was willing to make, allowing

him to keep busy with his mutts and experiments, but his continued expansion into Dicathen will not be allowed, especially now that he has somehow succeeded in his efforts to create a weapon of untold power through reincarnation.

"Dicathen is but a stepping stone toward Epheotus, and I refuse to let that traitorous snake bring this war here. For generations, we have worked to make sure Dicathen could fight back against Agrona, but they have failed. We will not sacrifice ourselves to keep them alive.

"What we will *do is send a message that Agrona cannot ignore. He has so far used the lessers as a shield, holding their lives hostage to protect his own. No longer. If the choice is between giving him the power to move against us or tearing down the world, then I will see it all* burn*."*

Windsom was the first to step forward, bowing so low he could have kissed Lord Indrath's boots. "I volunteer for this honor, My Lord. I will strike the first blow."

Lord Indrath did not smile, but there was a victorious light in his eyes. "You will continue to serve in your role as guide and protector, Windsom, but you will not swing the axe that is to fall. No, there is only one among us who is capable of wielding the World Eater technique."

The secret technique of the Thyestes clan is Mirage Walk, an ability that made us unparalleled combatants, but long ago, when the asura often warred with one another, we had another technique, so powerful and devastating that it was forbidden to be used when the Great Eight formed, and was no longer taught, except for one student in each generation.

Which made me the only living member of the Thyestes clan with the knowledge Lord Indrath required.

The World Eater technique allowed the caster to channel an incredible amount of mana, compacting it until the individual particles began to burst, causing a chain reaction that would spread out to the atmospheric mana and continue until not a spark of the caster's own, purified mana was left, causing unparalleled devastation.

"This technique is forbidden, *Lord Indrath," one of the Thyestes clan leaders insisted angrily. "Knowledge of the World Eater is kept alive so that our clan will never forget the horrors of limitless power—"*

"This moment is exactly why *the technique has been taught to one talented young member of your clan since time immemorial, which I myself commanded as you may remember."*

Although there was grumbling from my clan, no one else challenged Lord Indrath as he summoned me to stand beside Windsom.

"General Aldir, I call on you now to prove your loyalty. You and Windsom will travel to Dicathen, to the forest land of Elenoir, and locate the Alacryan Scythe Nico and the elven princess Tessia Eralith—or her physical body—and activate the World Eater technique. Give my message to Agrona, and rob him of his new weapon in the process."

In that moment, I had felt something inside me crack, something I thought had been unshakable: the foundation on which my entire identity as a servant of the Indrath clan was built.

Kneeling, I ran my fingers through the dry, gray nothing that I had created when I followed my lord's command—a command I knew was wrong the moment it was uttered, but to refuse would have risked the future of my entire clan. Lord Indrath would not hesitate

to lift one of the other—more servile—pantheon clans into the Great Eight, and label the Thyestes clan as anathema…

Even so, our failure to destroy the reincarnates had drawn Indrath's ire. We had not expected that they had any method to teleport away so quickly, and Windsom had gotten carried away toying with the angry, black-haired child. And yet, still, the lord's wrath fell on me.

Do not mope, Aldir, I told myself. *It is unbecoming of a member of the Thyestes*.

My fingers continued to trace through the thick layer of gray nothing, and I found myself examining the bumps and folds in the landscape for some reminder of what this place had been: a fallen tree, the rubble of a collapsed house, even the charred bones of one of the millions of lives I had extinguished.

The World Eater technique left nothing, though, no sign that this place was once a beautiful forest inhabited by millions of elves. The combustion of mana destroyed absolutely.

No, there is still something here, I thought, peering into the hazy air as if hoping to see the amethyst particles of aether suspended in the clouds of smokey ash. Though I could not, I knew it was there, all around me, undisturbed even by the World Eater technique. The thought gave me a sliver of peace, which was disturbed again immediately.

Two figures were approaching from a distance, drawing me out of my spiraling thoughts. Even when they reached me, I didn't stand up, didn't turn to look at them. Instead, I scooped up a handful of ash and let it run through my fingers to blow away on the wind.

“Back again, Lord Aldir?” the cool, confident voice said. “You’ve been here often since… well, you know.” Although it irritated me to know I was being watched, I wasn’t surprised. My act had reset the balance of power in Dicathen, sending a tremor of terror through every Alacryan on the continent.

Of course someone has been tasked with watching the wasteland, but choose to show themselves now? I wondered, my back still to them.

“They say ten thousand Alacryans died here,” she continued, her tone unreadable. “But we both know that was just a fraction of the casualties.”

The two stood well back, just close enough to speak without shouting. Their mana stood out like an oasis in the desert, since the atmosphere here was still empty of it.

“Is it confidence or naivety that you dare reveal yourself to me here, Scythe?” My words contained no threat, merely an observation. They knew I could move through them with no more effort than brushing away a spider’s web; there was no need for threats.

“I know genocide makes you somewhat irritable, Lord Aldir, but *I* wasn’t the one who ordered the deaths of millions of innocent elves,” she replied, gently mocking, devoid of any fear. “Do you think he considered what the act would do to you, asura? Perhaps he did, but then, if a sword breaks, you simply forge another, you do not mourn the loss of steel.”

Then, I turned my eye to her. To her credit, she didn’t flinch away, although the same couldn’t be said for her retainer. “What do you want, Seris?”

“I merely wish to talk, Aldir. Share a few words, in the hope that you’ll hear them.” She smiled, but it wasn’t mocking or amused, only…sad? “If I am right, at this very moment Kezess is busily spinning his web of lies, convincing the Dicathians that it was the Vritra who did this”—she waved one hand at the desolation—“so that the poor fools don’t even know who is really killing them.”

Strategically that would be the correct move, although it risked breaking what little spirit the Dicathians had left. To counter this, Windsom would be working with their Commander Virion—one of the few lessers I thought had any real leadership ability—to make sure that didn’t happen.

“But who do you think has killed more Dicathians in this war?” Seris continued, cocking her head to the side and tapping her lips with a finger. “Agrona’s forces have killed, what? Twenty thousand? Fifty? But Kezess, well…”

“Deaths made necessary by Agrona’s continued treachery,” I said, repeating Windsom’s words when I had shared this same thought in confidence after the destruction of Elenoir. It was unnerving to have this Vritra mutt throw the same words at me now. “And that’s *Lord Indrath* to you.”

“You sound just like him,” Seris said quietly, digging the toe of her boot into the ash.

I raised my chin and stood, letting my form expand until I was half again as tall as she was. The retainer tried to step in front of his Scythe, but she stopped him with a hand on his shoulder. “I am proud to sound like the great Lord Indrath, and I will not be spoken down to by the likes of you, half-breed.”

She shook her head. “I didn’t mean Kezess. You sound like Agrona.”
Sneering, I summoned Silverlight, which appeared as a long, thin rapier glowing with moonlight, and pointed it at Seris’s heart. “You have exhausted my patience, Scythe. I can cut you both down right now, and there isn’t a soul in hundreds of miles to risk collateral damage.”
I regretted my choice of words immediately as Seris gave me a sardonic look.
“You already took care of that, didn’t you, Aldir?” she asked wryly. The retainer shot her a fearful glance, as if even he thought she was pushing their luck. “But is that all you are now, pantheon? An executioner? Assassin? Faithful automaton, devoid of empathy or the ability to think for yourself?”
Why doesn’t she fear you, Aldir? I asked myself.
Because she knows you are done with death, the answer resounded from the deep recesses of my mind.
I ground my teeth and released Silverlight. “If you expect me to abandon Lord Indrath for Agrona, you are—”
“Indrath, Agrona. Agrona, Indrath.” Seris ran a hand along the length of one curving horn. “You speak as if they are the only two beings in the world, as if there is no choice but to serve one or the other.”
I scoffed. So *this* was the mutt’s plan? To install herself as some kind of opposing queen to the Vritra lord? “This is a war of two sides. *Everyone* must choose a side, even you, Seris.”
“But is it, though?” A storm raged in the Scythe’s dark eyes as she held my gaze. “If the world is a coin, Agrona on one side, Kezess on

the other, then someone else has flipped that coin, and no matter how it lands—whichever face looks up from the ground—it will be that someone who is looking back down."

"Who is it you speak of so reverently?" I asked, somewhat unnerved by her demeanor. "Who do you believe could rival these two, who are considered great even among the asura?"

The Vritra half-breed smiled coyly. "Oh, you know him well, Aldir, perhaps even better than I do. A certain human mage with a penchant for biting off more than he can chew."

My eyes flew open—all three of them—as my mind went back to the moments before I finished casting World Eater, when I felt an alien presence *watching* me, almost as if some greater deity—a true god—had arrived to witness my lowest moment and judge me by it. I hadn't known who it could have been at the time, but now…

"Arthur Leywin…"

SERIS VRITRA

I was cautiously optimistic as I held the asura's strange, three-eyed gaze. Cylrit stood protectively at my side, wound more tightly than a spring, more than ready to lay down his own life for me were we to be attacked.

Although the conversation had gone *exactly* as I had hoped, I wasn't yet ready to turn my back on Aldir. Instead, we stood like that for some time, him glaring down at me with an expression I hoped was thoughtful, me gazing back as placidly as I could manage given his crippling aura.

I knew it was risky, coming to Elenoir without the High Sovereign's approval and revealing myself to the asura, and I even felt just a little

bit bad about giving Arthur's survival away to the asuras as well. But the boy needed a push. Agrona had his new pet, and it would only be a matter of time before he decided to use her. If Arthur took too long running around the Relictombs playing pat-a-cake with young Caera Denoir, or hiding under the guise of "Professor Grey" at Central Academy, the escalating conflict between the Vritra and Epheotus would ruin everything.

Finally, Aldir released a heavy breath—half irritated scoff, half world-weary sigh—and shrunk back to normal proportions. Wordlessly, he raised a hand, conjuring a black-opal portal, and vanished with a sudden rush of mana.

A sharp breath escaped my lungs as they deflated. I looked down at my trembling hand, then closed it into a tight fist in frustration. I refused to shake with fear, despite the gap in power between the asura and me.

"Will he tell Indrath about Leywin?" Cylrit asked as he reached out a hand to draw in the few lingering particles of mana from Aldir's spell.

"Not right away, no," I answered, considering my words just as I considered my knowledge of the asura. "He'll ponder what we've said, agonizing over why we've shared this information, afraid it may be a trick or a trap. Then, eventually, his sense of duty will overwhelm his concern, and he will tell Indrath. Exactly like we want him to."

A slow smile spread across my face as I considered our current situation. My plans were continuing to move forward, keeping just ahead of the war, but the reappearance of Arthur Leywin as the

mysterious Ascender Grey was a welcome wild card. And with my protegee so conveniently placed at his side, well…

"Agrona will kill us if he finds out about this meeting," Cylrit said quietly.

"Agrona cannot currently see beyond the walls of Taegrin Caelum, Cylrit," I answered smoothly, elbowing my retainer in the shoulder. "He has eyes only for *her* right now, at least until he decides if this whole reincarnation gambit was worth it."

"And if he does?" Cylrit's voice carried an edge of nervousness I wasn't used to from the stalwart retainer.

"I imagine he'll grow significantly less careful with his Scythes and their retainers," I answered.

There was a brief silence. Then, Cylrit cursed. "Sovereign's horns. It's eerie here, isn't it? No mana, no noise, no life at all… "

"This," I said, linking my arm through his, "is what our world will look like if Agrona and Kezess have their way. Agrona will happily take Epheotus in exchange for Alacrya and Dicathen, and Kezess is willing to rebuild life here from the ashes up if he has to."

A shiver ran through my retainer at my words as he gazed around the empty waste. "Agrona wouldn't really let this happen to Alacrya, would he?"

I snorted indelicately. "If, in exchange, he could rule over all the other asura clans—or destroy them and take Epheotus for the Vritra—then you know damned well he would. What is one mortal world in exchange for the land of deities themselves?"

"But there's one thing I've never really understood," Cylrit admitted, slowing slightly so that I had to release his arm. I turned to meet his

serious, steady gaze. “Why the human? He’s strong, yes, but he only lived long enough to grow into his strength because of you. What’s so important about him?”

I floated into the air and turned southwest toward Darv. “Even now, I can’t say what Arthur Leywin’s part in all this is going to be. He’s an anomaly, a force of change. I sensed that the moment I laid eyes on him. In a world where deities have the strength to wipe out entire countries, one human shouldn’t matter. Even you and I are a ripple in the sea of power next to beings like the asuras.

“It was the mana that told me, Cylrit. The way it seemed to be drawn to him, as if awaiting his command, like he was constantly reshaping reality without even trying. He didn’t just move through the world, the world moved to accommodate his passing.”

342
DUALITY

TESSIA ERALITH

It was cold. Really cold. But the sensation of frigid air biting at my skin—*my* skin, I had to remind myself—was exhilarating. It reminded me that…

I'm alive.

Resting my bare hands on the icy-cold railing that ran around my ten-foot-wide balcony, I stared out at the endless range of snowy mountains, miles and miles of jagged peaks that rose up from the earth like the teeth of an enormous dragon.

No, not the Earth, not anymore. Despite reminding myself of this startling fact at least a hundred times, I have yet to come to terms with it. Who could have known there were other worlds out there? And that you could be… *reborn* into one.

My gaze was drawn to the series of runes marking my bare arms, glowing faintly with warm light. These arms were more slender than those I'd had before…

Before what?

I closed my eyes hard against the fog in my head, squeezing until I saw stars before opening them again.

It had been worse—much worse—the first time I had seen the thin arms and the tattooed runes. Nico had been there, standing over me—although I hadn't recognized him, of course. His alien eyes had stared into mine from beneath his new, dark brows. I had immediately vomited all over his shirt before passing out…

In the distance, a winged creature the size of an airplane was wheeling around one of the peaks, hunting. What had Nico called the creature?

A mana beast.

As I watched, letting my attention move entirely away from my own body and the glowing runes that marked my now fair skin, the magnificent monstrosity suddenly tucked in its wings and dove, vanishing in the dips and valleys. I wished I could join it, flying through the mountains, nothing between me and the jagged rocks but the magic I'd inherited with this body.

Of all the amazing things I'd seen and learned, flying was definitely my favorite.

Flying, though, made me think of my first battle in this new world, of the impossible strength of our enemies, and a chill ran through me that had nothing to do with the cold, raising gooseflesh along my arms.

We hadn't expected an attack…I had barely known what was going on still, only that my new friend Agrona—the one who gave Nico and me another chance at life—needed my help. I simply repeated what they told me to, until…

I flew, I thought dizzily. *I'd never done that before.*

Turning suddenly, I whisked back into my room and shut the door against the cold and the alien landscape. A twisting sense of vertigo threatened to overwhelm me, so I threw myself into a chair in front of the blazing fireplace, rubbing the bridge of my nose forcefully, my entire body rigid against the nausea.

An unwanted memory surfaced. I was walking across the school campus on a day like any other, when my body began to ache and tremble, the swelling ki washing across me like waves over a stormy ocean, and when those waves of ki broke land…I was lying on the floor, my body jerking and twisting within a cocoon of dark, spear-tipped vines, the angry presence hidden within me lashing out, roaring with hatred and confusion…

Shaking my head violently, I recoiled from the images, tucking my legs up to my chest and wrapping my arms around them.

Breathe, just breathe, Cecilia.

This dizzying sensation of *wrongness* had been common at first. Nico said it was just my mind acclimating to my new physical form, but—

A knock at the door made me jump.

Unfolding from the chair, I stared at the back of the door. "Yes?" I asked after a few seconds.

"Cecilia, it's Nico. Can I come in?"

I turned back to the fire, dancing in shades of orange and yellow, and took a deep breath to push back the lingering dizziness. "Yes, of course."

The heavy wooden door swung smoothly inward, revealing a figure a head taller than me, with alabaster skin and jet-black hair. He stepped inside and let the door close softly before crossing the room to sit stiffly on my bed.

Nico looked so different, and not just his physical features. Whatever had happened to him in this new life had been hard on him. It had made *him* hard.

“How are you feeling?” he asked, his piercing eyes burning into me as if he were trying to see my soul, hidden beneath the skin I was wearing.

“Fine,” I replied, too quickly.

Liar.

“I had an attack of vertigo, just now,” I admitted. “But I’m okay.”

Nico was off the bed and kneeling beside me in an instant. When his hand came to rest on mine, I pulled away as something inside of me recoiled.

“Sorry,” I whispered, but I didn’t put my hand back.

“No, Cecilia, it’s okay. It’s fine, really.” The obvious hurt this caused him shone back at me from those unfamiliar eyes, but he took his hand off the arm of my chair. “I know this is all so confusing.”

Confusing doesn’t begin to cover it.

“Do the exercise,” Nico suggested.

Nodding, I closed my eyes and began to focus on the orange glow of the fire playing across the inside of my eyelids. Then, breathing deeply, my focus followed the breath in through my nose and down into my lungs, where I held it.

As I breathed out, my focus stayed on my lungs, on the way my sternum shifted as my chest rose and my stomach expanded, causing an intricate interplay of the muscle, bones, and internal organs. There, I searched for my mana core, trying to feel it, to be consciously aware of it.

It took a minute, but eventually I found it near my solar plexus. Once I had it in my mind, it felt impossible to miss: a ball of white hot

power, waiting for me to draw on the gusting hurricane of energy contained within. Sort of like my ki center, but… more.

But there was something else there, too.

Within the core, I could sense another will, separate from my own, just like in the memory. Angry green tentacles wriggled, making my stomach churn.

The elderwood guardian's beast will…

My eyes snapped open as I was shunted out of the meditation by the queasy feeling the beast will gave me. From the corner of my eye, I saw Nico watching me closely.

"Better?" he asked when I opened my eyes.

I only nodded in response.

"Anyway." Nico stood and took a hesitant step back. "Agrona would like us to join him for dinner in an hour, in his private rooms. Want me to wait for you to get dressed?"

I shook my head this time, then tucked a stray lock of gunmetal hair behind my ear. "No, I'll… see you there."

With a nod, Nico fumbled behind him for the door handle, then backed out into the hallway, not taking his eyes off me until the door had snapped shut.

Sighing deeply—something I couldn't remember doing often in my past life, but felt the need to do frequently now—I sank down into the chair and moved my feet closer to the fire, close enough to be uncomfortable.

Like the cold, the sensation of the too-warm flames licking at my bare toes made me feel…

Alive?

Remembering what Nico had said about dinner, I jumped up and dashed through a door on the other side of my bed that led into my own private dressing room. Inside, there was a desk with drawers full of perfumes and makeup, several mirrors, three dressers for different types of clothes, and a closet that ran the length of the room.

It was, I thought a little guiltily, my favorite place in Taegrin Caelum.

I'd never had my own *stuff* before, not really. Or at least, I didn't think so. So much of my previous life was still a blur, although Nico and Agrona assured me that it would all come back with time. But I remembered the orphanage, and Headmaster Wilbeck, and I remembered the testing…

Pulling away from the memories to avoid another fit, I began to sort through the clothes hanging inside the closet. It contained mostly dresses and strange robes of a hundred different colors and designs, and all just for me.

My fingertips brushed a simple, onyx-colored dress with black runes along the back that I thought would make my new hair stand out, but dismissed it for an ankle-length green dress with golden leaves embroidered up the side.

As I quickly changed, I prepared myself for a conversation with Agrona, ordering my thoughts and preparing answers to the bombardment of questions I knew I'd receive.

Once I was dressed, I started the long walk through the fortress to Agrona's private rooms without even glancing in the mirrors to check my appearance; looking at the stranger's rune-covered body

and unfamiliar face staring back at me would only give me vertigo again.

Taegrin Caelum's halls were always bustling with activity: hundreds of servants rushed about, tending to the needs of the many soldiers, aristocrats, and military leaders who frequented the mountain fortress. The castle was like a city unto itself, contained within the towering walls of dark stone.

Each hall was lined with paintings and portraits, or artifacts hung in rune-marked glass cases. Stuffed mana beasts were common, every one posed as if it were about to lunge and attack passersby. I was fascinated by the grotesque and alien forms, and had mapped out much of the fortress by learning the location of the many stuffed monsters, but there was no time to linger and examine them today.

Wherever I crossed paths with a servant who was polishing an artifact or scrubbing stains from the scarlet carpet that ran down the center of the hall, they would press their backs against the walls and bow deeply until after I'd passed.

Early on, I'd tried to talk to a few of these servants, but they wouldn't speak to me, except to answer direct questions, and they never made eye-contact. In fact, aside from Nico and Agrona, I had no one to talk to.

They want you to be isolated, to see only what they're showing you.

I shook my head, knowing this wasn't a fair observation. Too much stimulus overwhelmed me, especially after the attack…They had to introduce this new world slowly, and even then I found myself having a hard time retaining information.

Like where things were in the huge fortress.

It was when I passed the lunging form of a feline beast with two heads and three tails for the second time that I realized I'd turned myself around while lost in thought.

"Was it the second right after this cat-thing, or the third?" I muttered to myself, peeking down corridor after corridor.

Turning at the third corridor, I increased my pace, hurrying to the door at its end, which I thought opened into a narrow, spiraling staircase that would take me up several floors to the level on which Agrona maintained his private rooms.

Instead of a staircase, I found a large, dimly lit suite. Surprised, I froze in the doorway, my eyes tracking slowly across the chamber as I tried to figure out where I was.

"Who's there," a thin, tired voice said from deeper in the chamber. "Just leave whatever it is by the door and go away!"

"I'm sorry," I replied. "I'm a little lost. Do you—"

Something was scrabbling against the floor near the corner, and I could just make out a lithe silhouette unfolding from where it lay and stalking toward me into the ring of light from the open door.

I stepped back out into the hallway, my heart suddenly pounding in my chest, although I wasn't quite sure why.

The woman seemed to fill the doorway, despite her stick-thin stature. She rested her hands on the frame on either side of the opening and scowled out from behind thin, greenish-black bangs. I was taken aback by how ill and… inhuman she looked.

Her cheeks were sunken beneath dark, red-rimmed eyes, and when she sucked in a hissing breath through her thin, gray lips, I saw that

her teeth had been filed to sharp points. The black robes she wore exposed her arms and sides, which were skeletally thin.

"Are…" I trailed off, my voice failing as I struggled to overcome whatever instinct was urging me to flee from the woman. Swallowing heavily, I tried again. "Are you okay?"

"Am I…? Am I *okay*?" she hissed, staring at me as if I'd suddenly grown a third arm. "You speak to Bivrae, last of her blood…and ask if she is *okay*?"

"I'm sorry," I muttered, unsure why the woman repulsed me so completely.

She looks just like him.

This thought took me by surprise, but the moment I had it, I knew what it meant. I could picture the man, puffy and skeletal at the same time, with seaweed green hair and sunken pits for eyes…

Bilal. The retainer. Her…brother?

"I'm sorry for your loss," I choked out, overwhelmed by a strangling collision of emotions I couldn't explain. "Forgive my intrusion."

Bowing slightly, I fled back down the hall.

"Wait!" she screeched, but I didn't stop, rounding the corner and nearly colliding with a servant woman.

I dodged around her and was halfway to the next corridor before I heard her yelp of surprise, then increased my pace still more, practically flying through the halls, hammering through a door and shooting up a winding staircase.

Only after I'd burst through another door into a wide hallway with an elegantly curved roof covered by a long, detailed fresco did I skid to a stop, breathing hard.

“Cecilia?”

Jumping, I spun around only to realize that Nico had been standing near the stairway door, admiring a gold and silver shield hung on the wall.

His expression fell when he noticed my heaving breaths, and what I assumed was a wild, panicky stair. “What’s wrong? What happened?”

“N-nothing,” I stammered, working to collect myself. “Just…got turned around—didn’t want to be late.”

“You’re perfectly on time, actually,” a deep voice said from down the hallway, the rumble of it carrying through the stones and vibrating up into the soles of my feet. “No need to have gotten yourself worked up, Cecilia dear.”

Turning toward the voice, I bowed deeply, but the motion made my head swim as a wave of vertigo crashed around me, and I stumbled forward. A powerful, marble-gray arm caught me, and I felt myself being lifted like a child and set firmly back on my feet.

Standing in front of me, his hands on my shoulders, was Agrona, his vibrantly scarlet eyes staring right through me. The lord of the Vritra clan, and my new home of Alacrya, was handsome, with smooth skin and a sharp jaw that reminded me of an actor. His frame was lithe and graceful, and he moved with an easy confidence that drew your eyes to him.

Enormous horns sprouted from the sides of his black hair like an elk’s antlers, except shiny and black, each prong coming to a spear-sharp point. Several gold and silver rings wrapped around the many prongs, and bejeweled chains traced the lines of the horns. On

anyone else, it would have looked gaudy, but to Agrona, it only added to the sense of power that hung from him like a cloak.

Lost in the twisting vertigo, I couldn't help but stare as his presence overwhelmed me.

“Oh, those pesky memories,” he said softly. “Riling you up again, aren’t they? Let me help.”

No! Please don’t—

Then Agrona was in my head, in my mind, poking around like a potter molding clay. The confusion of memories and thoughts that weren’t mine began to recede, as did the cascading avalanche of emotions.

As his mental fingers kneaded my brain, I took a deep breath and let myself relax. First, he removed *her* memories, pushing them away and burying them down deep, then he began to sift through my own, giving a tug here or a prod there to help me remember things from my previous life.

A rush of images played in my mind’s eye, flashing by in quick succession:

Nico, just a boy, inviting me to play with him and his friend, even though I was too shy to even speak.

Nico dodging between blasts of ki energy, moving faster than his age should have allowed, to press a gloved hand to my stomach, saving me and everyone else in the orphanage from the surging unstable ki threatening to explode out of me.

Nico handing me a medallion that he’d made just for me, to keep me safe, his nervous smile speaking more than his words ever did.

Nico saving me from violent men in an alley, men who wanted to take me away, who were willing to kill to get me.

Nico, his arms wrapped around me in congratulations after we'd been accepted into the military training institute we attended together.

Nico, his arms wrapped around me in…

My eyes snapped open and I took a quick step back from the towering Vritra, who gave me a knowing smile before straightening.

"There, there, all better now, isn't it Cecilia."

"Yes, Lord Agrona," I replied calmly, the noise in my head finally settling. "Thank you for your assistance."

Next to me, Nico's fingers were fidgeting at his side, and I knew he wanted to reach out and take my hand, but he held back. I didn't make any effort to encourage him, appreciating the distance. For some reason, physical contact with Nico, no matter how innocent, always triggered the sickening sense of vertigo.

"Now, I've had an *exquisite* meal prepared for us," Agrona went on, turning and gesturing for us to follow. "Star fruit and moon oxen from Elenoir—bit of a rare delicacy now, all things considered—but that's not the reason I wanted to speak to you both.

"I know you want to get out and see the world, Cecilia dear. This all still seems very alien and otherworldly, and I don't want you to feel like a bird trapped in its cage. Which is why I am sending Nico—with you at his side, as it should be—to investigate some strange goings on at the High Hall within the Relictombs."

Smiling up at the Vritra lord, Nico and I followed him into his private dining chamber, eager for the opportunity to prove myself to the High Sovereign.

343
PROFESSOR PRINCESS

AFTER A QUICK SCAN of my quarters, I sank into one of the plush chairs facing a small table and let out a sigh. Holding a civil conversation with strangers had become increasingly more exhausting—more so because of how much I had to watch my tongue.

Pulling myself out of my daze, two items caught my half-lidded eye, both resting at the center of the small game board with a note.

"This must be the token that activates the ascension portal," I muttered, fiddling with the jade runestone while reading the note.

The second item was an open ring crafted of ebony, taking the shape of an intricate snake that adjusted its size around my finger to fit better.

My gaze settled on the pale ring wrapped around my middle finger, letting the fact that I had officially become a professor of the very continent I was at war against sink in.

Turning my attention back to the table in front of me, I read the small brass plaque that read:

Sovereigns Quarrel
Pieces in the red and gray of Named Blood Hercross
"It is often the sharper mind that wins the war, not the sharper blade."
A gift to Central Academy by Lord Leander

Unlike the crudely made "pieces" Caera and I had played with, positioned on the marbled hexagonal board were exquisitely carved representations of Strikers, Casters, and Shields in deep red stone on one side and thundercloud gray on the other.

"Fancy," Regis said, sniffing around the board and knocking several of the pieces over.

Pushing his head away, I reset the pieces and stood up from the table.

Next, I turned my attention to the projection device. The oval crystal, which was slightly rough, as if it had been hand carved from a larger piece, was mounted to the wall with metal brackets.

“On,” I commanded, unable to find any controls near the device.

No response.

“Activate,” I said hesitantly while waving my hand in front of the oval crystal to see if it reacted to physical gestures.

Regis let out a snicker, causing me to turn toward him, one eyebrow raised. “You just give it a little pulse of mana to turn on. It turns off again when the mana crystal embedded inside is either out of mana, or you draw all the mana back out.”

“Oh,” I said, realizing my mistake. It was such a stupid little thing, but if someone else watched me stumble around like this, it would be immediately obvious I wasn’t an Alacryan.

“You know,” Regis said with the air of someone about to state something very obvious, “the whole ‘no mana’ thing seems like a bigger deal now that we’re in civilization. You’re going to need to be more careful.”

“If only I had someone—a companion of some sort—who had more detailed knowledge of Alacryan technology and customs,” I said sarcastically. “Someone who could help me by pointing out potential missteps *before* I made them.”

Regis stopped sniffing around and gave me an affronted look. “What do I look like, a mind reader?”

“We can *literally* read each other’s minds, Regis,” I said, pushing past the huge shadow wolf before throwing myself onto the couch.

“Then you must know that I’m bored,” Regis said, taking a seat in front of the couch and staring at me with his dark eyes, his fiery tail thumping softly on the floor.

I let my eyes close. “We’ve only been here ten minutes.”

“Ten very long, very boring minutes,” the wolf countered, moving to rest his chin on the edge of the couch next to my head. “Let’s at least go look around, where there are cute girls I can gawk at.”

I groaned. “The girls here are all teenagers, Regis. Don’t be disgusting.”

“And I’m barely a few months old, and not even the same species. So what? Besides, there are probably some good-looking professors for you, old man.”

“Fine,” I sighed, giving into his relentless badgering and rolling to my feet. Fresh air could be good for me. “I should figure out where my office is anyway. My teaching supplies are supposed to be there.” I stopped at the door. “But you’ll have to sightsee from inside me.”

“But I—” my companion spluttered.

“Regis. You stand out even worse than I do. In.”

The shadow wolf huffed in annoyance, but did what I asked.

I shook my head as I felt his ethereal form meld into me, drifting around near my aether core. *Let me know if you sense I'm about to do something that will draw attention*, I told him.

'Aye aye, Professor Princess.'

It was a short walk across campus to the building where I would be teaching, a grand structure that reminded me of the universities of my previous life. The building was largely empty, since classes hadn't started yet, and I wandered the spacious halls in peace until I found the right room.

The single door opened into a half-circle shaped space, like a small arena with a dueling ring on the floor level. It was smaller than I'd expected, with seating for no more than thirty or so students.

As I took the first shallow step down the stairs, lighting artifacts along the outside wall and ceiling lit up automatically, filling the

space with cool light. Something caught my eye, and I stopped to bend down over one of the seats, which had a rune engraved into it.

"Am I reading that right?" I muttered.

'Yup, pretty sure you are,' Regis confirmed for me.

The rune, when activated, would send a jolt of pain up the spine of whoever happened to be sitting on it. "Barbaric."

'Welcome to the Alacryan school system,' my companion shot back.

Following the stairs down to the dueling ring, I walked around it to the far side where there was a metal panel with a series of knobs and levers on it. Curious, I flicked one, and a shimmering, transparent shield vibrated into place around the platform.

This was no different from the training rings at Xyrus, but the rest of the controls were more interesting. I discovered that, with the flip of a switch, I could activate a force-dampener that would dull all

impacts within the bounds of the combat platform, and there was a dial that let me control even the force of gravity, making it heavier or lighter to challenge the students.

Although I was no more eager to be teaching potential enemy combatants than when Alaric first explained his hairbrained scheme, I had to admit the Alacryans had some fancy toys.

Another door opened into the wall just behind the dueling ring. Using the jade runestone, I unlocked it and entered a small office with a desk, three chairs, a couple of shelves, and a large trunk with runes etched into the metal.

A stack of scrolls, parchment, and books was already waiting for me on the desk. Withdrawing the two scrolls I'd received from Alaric's contact, I set them on the desk, deciding to dig into the more detailed aspects of the class later.

The runestone also unlocked the trunk, which provided storage for more sensitive items. Currently, it was full of training gear for the class. I recognized vests that would allow detailed analysis of mana flow, physical force, acceleration, and probably a dozen other

metrics. It was similar to the training gear Emily had invented to test my abilities back in the castle, but obviously much more advanced.

If Gideon and Emily could get their hands on some of this Alacryan technology…

I closed the lid, which locked again automatically, and gazed around the small office, unable to keep the frown off my face.

'Boring room, check. Boring office, check. Can we puh-lease do something more interesting?' Regis begged, giving the mental equivalent of puppy-dog eyes.

I brushed my fingers past the cover of a book on my desk. *Sure.*

'This isn't exactly what I had in mind,' Regis said when we stepped into the Central Academy Library. A plaque next to the entryway offered thanks to Highblood Aphelion for donating this library building, which had been built several decades ago.

Did you think we'd be creating havoc with a scantily-clad girl on each arm or something? I retorted.

The short entry hall was decorated with paintings of previous academy directors and ended with a large portrait of a stern man with short grey hair and thunderous brows creased into a furrow. According to the brass plaque on the wall beneath it, this man—Augustine of Highblood Ramseyer—was the current director of the academy.

'*That guy looks like he'd be a blast to have at a party,*' Regis noted sarcastically as we moved past it.

Regardless of his personality, Director Ramseyer would be someone I would have to watch out for.

As we passed from the entry hall into the foyer, an older woman looked up from a stack of books and frowned. She tidied the stack momentarily before beelining toward us.

“I’m sorry, young man, the library isn’t yet open to students,” she announced in a voice that sounded much younger than her appearance.

“What about professors?” I asked levelly, holding up my hand to display the ebony ring.

“Oh! My apologies,” she said, looking me briefly up and down before waving me in. “You all get younger and younger every year, I swear.” Spinning around, she quickly made her way to a large round island in the center of the foyer. “Smart, young man, though, coming to the library first thing.

“What class will you be teaching?” she asked as she began fiddling with a strange device next to her desk.

“Melee Enhancement Tactics,” I answered, following the librarian to the circular desk that wrapped around her.

She winced and gave me a sympathetic look. This melted away into a teasing smile as she said, “Maybe I’ll have to take back what I said

about your intelligence? I'd assumed you were here to brush up on course material before classes started but…"

I leaned forward, resting my elbows on the desk, and watched her manipulate the device. "Is the class really that bad?"

"Oh, well…" she started hesitantly, "it's just that teaching highblood mages how to punch and kick things has never been exactly…a highly respected position among the students."

"I see. How long did the last professor last?" I asked, my employment at the academy suddenly making more sense.

"Two sessions," the librarian admitted, frowning back at me. "Then the class was cancelled for the rest of the season."

I couldn't help but laugh at that, earning a raised brow from the librarian. "To be honest, I was feeling a little nervous about this whole teaching thing, but you've put my mind at ease."

This caused her raised brow to crawl all the way up to hide behind her bangs. “The students scaring off the last teacher after two days made you feel better?” She blinked several times before adding under her breath, “I take it all back. You’re obviously mad.”

Grinning, I drummed my fingers across the desktop. “It just helps ease my mind, is all.” To Regis, I added, *Because it sounds like I won’t actually have to teach these kids anything.*

Shaking her head, the librarian turned back to her strange device, which was made up of a smaller version of the display crystal in my room set on top of an iron pedestal, and touched the screen. By the way it lit up, I assumed she had imbued mana into it.

“Melee Enhancement Tactics,” she said, apparently to the device. The projection crystal displayed a handful of books, including what appeared to be a location within the library.

“Impressive,” I muttered, scanning through the titles. “And that works for any topic?”

“Topic, author, or title,” she said proudly, patting the machine like it were an obedient pet. “Want to give it a go?”

Feeling my lips form a thoughtful frown as I looked at the screen, I said, “The ancient mages,” thinking that asking about relics might cause some suspicion.

The display shifted, the list changing to show a large number of books about the ancient mages, the Relictombs, and a number of other related topics. I memorized the locations of a couple at random.

“Is it okay if I look around?” I said.

“Of course, Professor…?”

“Grey,” I answered politely.

“Dehlia,” the librarian responded. “There are more of these consoles around. If the screen is off, just give it a poke with a little mana.”

“Thanks again, Dehlia,” I said with a nod before walking deeper into the library.

All around the foyer, shelf after shelf of books spread out to fill the huge building, which extended two additional levels above. Dozens of reading nooks were arrayed around the outer edge of the library, giving students a place to hide away to study.

‘Or other, less academic things,’ Regis pointed out.

The Central Academy Library wasn’t as large or grandiose as the city library, but it must have contained tens of thousands of books and scrolls. I read titles at random as I strolled between the high shelves, curious about what the Alacryans would consider important.

One row contained at least two hundred separate books about Alacryan runes, from marks to regalias. Another held Highblood biographies, each of which appeared to be competing against its neighbors to be the thickest or have the most ornate cover. I found

an entire section for poetry extolling the virtues of Agrona and the Sovereigns.

Eventually, I found the row I was looking for, and plucked a heavy, leather-bound volume that sounded interesting off the shelf. It claimed to be a thorough examination of Alacryan adaptation of the ancient mages' technology throughout the ages.

'Please tell me we're not going to skulk around this library reading *all day? At least take me back to the boring rooms so I can get out of you,'* Regis moaned.

Ignoring my companion, I opened the tome and began to flip through pages when a soft, nervous voice said, "You'd be better off with the response by Crenalman."

Turning, I saw a mousy young man staring at me from under his thick glasses. The boy's gaze fell to my hand as he scratched at his muddy-brown hair, his eyes widening after spotting my ring. "S-sorry, sir, I just…nevermind."

He spun on his heels and quickly marched away.

“Hold on,” I called out, causing the boy to nearly stumble before he turned back to me.

“Are you supposed to be here?” I asked, more out of surprise than any authoritarian desire to make sure he wasn’t trespassing in the library without permission.

“S-sorry, sir, I’ve been here f-for a couple of weeks, and have special—”

I waved him to silence. “It doesn’t matter. What were you saying about this?”

He glanced fearfully between me and the book before replying quietly, “It’s just that…well…there isn’t much information in that one. It’s all theoretical, and spends too much time thanking the Sovereigns for—”

The boy's mouth snapped shut as his eyes went wide. "There isn't anything wrong with… I just meant that… um… "

I tried to keep from smiling as I watched the boy flounder. When he finally trailed off into silence, I raised a hand. "It's okay. I know what you mean. So you suggest something better?"

Tentatively, like someone walking out onto thin ice, he said, "Yeah. There is a response piece by Crenalman that directly addresses the problems with that one. It should be"—he took a few steps into the row, scanning the shelves quickly—"here."

The boy slid a slightly thinner book from the shelf and handed it to me with a shy smile.

"You seem to know your way around this place. I'm new here, and honestly not very well read. Might I ask for some recommendations?" I paused, thinking for a moment. Did I dare reveal my primary interest to this young student? It seemed safer to enlist help from a nervous student than the librarian, so I decided to risk it. "My primary interest is in relics."

The boy's eyes lit up and his demeanor quickly transformed. He hastily shoved the book by Crenalman back, then did the same with the one in my hands. "I've read all about relics. Histories, catalogues, theoretical treatises—but this library has hundreds of books on them, most of which I'd never even heard of until I got to the academy!"

He waved for me to follow, then practically ran through the labyrinth of shelves, leading me up a stair tucked away near the back of the library, then winding through several more rows. Near the center of the second level, overlooking the foyer, there was a small section dedicated to relic related books.

He grabbed three and held them out to me. "Start with these," he said proudly, then quickly added, "if you haven't read them already."

Accepting the proffered collection, I looked at each in turn: a history of relic retrieval and the evolution of the laws surrounding it; an exploration of relic powers and how they were; and a catalogue of dead relics discovered over the last hundred years, including an entire section of the reliquary of Central Academy.

The boy watched my face carefully, and what he found in my expression must have prompted him to explain his choices. “I know relic law doesn’t sound interesting, but the author does a great job making the material accessible. It’s the best of its kind, I promise, and really helpful to understand the little ins and outs. There are all kinds of ways ascenders can get in trouble if they don’t understand the law.”

Holding the books under my arm, I gave the boy a thoughtful look. “Is learning more about the Relictombs why you want to be an ascender?”

Perhaps I said something too invasive, because his face, already pale, seemed to drain of color. “I…um…no…” He stopped and took a deep breath. “I don’t really want to be an ascender, sir. Or a soldier,” he added guiltily. “But I always wanted to be a mage, and my sister—”

He cut himself off, giving a little shake of his head. “I’m sorry, sir. I don’t mean to bore you with this. Just…thanks for asking for my help.”

“No problem. Thanks for the recommendations…” I paused, waiting for the boy to provide his name.

“S-Seth, sir,” he provided after a moment’s hesitation.

“Thanks for the recommendations, Seth.”

With an awkward smile and a wave, he turned and disappeared back into the sprawling library.

‘Seems like an all right sort of kid,’ Regis said.

I only shrugged as I rearranged the books in my arm and headed back to the front desk to check out.

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EYES LOCKED

THE AFTERNOON SUN warmed my back, its bright rays reflecting off the yellowed pages of the book I was reading. From my secluded corner of the campus cafe, which was located near the administration building, the din of students and faculty conversing over drinks and dessert made for a pleasant change of pace from my room.

And while this was a bit more socially active than I would have preferred, it still beat having to listen to Regis complain about being bored.

"Here you go, Professor." A young waitress in her mid-teens slid a small plate of food and a mug of tea onto my table.

"I didn't order the food," I said as I picked up the mug and blew steam across the surface of the hot tea.

"On the house," she said, bouncing on her toes as she vanished back into the kitchen.

From my head, Regis let out a groan. *'Your looks are wasted on you. If I were you, I'd—'*

I thought we agreed you wouldn't bother me if I came here, I replied as my gaze swept through the cafe.

The academy was already much busier than it had been only two days ago. Students were arriving regularly, some with their family and attendants, while more of the faculty began appearing throughout the halls.

Sipping the fermented nettle tea, I continued to flip through the pages of my book, passing over several sections until I found the one I was looking for, then began to scan through the information. I had

already glanced through the law book and the treatise on relic powers, but neither contained what I was looking for.

Fortunately, the third book I'd borrowed from the library was a bit more interesting: a catalog of relics brought back from the Relictombs. I'd already known that Agrona himself kept any relics that were functional, but I was surprised by how much the Alacryans knew about the dead relics they recovered.

Through a combination of interviews with the discovering ascenders and the work of dedicated Instillers who specialized in relics—all of whom operated out of Taegrin Caelum, Agrona's fortress—most dead relics were identified, including the powers they once contained. Not all dead relics were thoroughly understood, but with the Relictombs at their disposal, the Alacryans had made much more progress in their study of the ancient magical technology than the Dicathians or even the asuras of Epheotus.

Although the book contained details regarding well over a hundred dead relics, I was most concerned with a specific group: those housed within the Reliquary at Central Academy. Throughout the centuries, they had managed to procure eleven, and I read each one's description carefully.

Safe to say, however, I was mildly disappointed. It was my own fault. The knowledge that I—and only I, as far as I knew—could revive and use any djinn relic had encouraged all kinds of fantasies. Reading through the descriptions, though, I was reminded that the djinn were peaceful people.

Not that the relics were useless, necessarily, but I wasn't looking for tools and trinkets. I wanted a *weapon*.

'Thank you for acknowledging that I am neither a weapon nor your possession,' Regis commented with a snort. *'But this stuff isn't all bad, you know. What about these Binding Chains? Just think about someone, activate them, and* wham*! The chains wrap your target up and then follow you around? I can think of several uses for those.'*

According to the author, the relic labeled the Binding Chains had other functions as well, including mana and aether suppressing abilities, preventing speech, and even putting the affected person or creature into a paralyzed stupor if necessary.

While the idea of dragging Agrona across Alacrya—bound, gagged, and powerless—so his people could witness his end held a dark appeal, I had my doubts about how powerful any single dead relic might be.

I don't know how much I trust the author's deductions here, I pointed out. *Like right here. It says, 'While the Imbuers weren't able to confirm this theory, it is possible that the Binding Chains can search out a target anywhere on the continent.' It's just fluff.*

'What about this one then?' Regis sent, focusing on a drawing of a gladiator-style net.

Labeled the Mana Net, the relic could "catch" mana out of the air like a fishing net caught fish. The author theorized that it was a defensive device meant to absorb incoming spells.

It certainly seemed useful, especially since I could no longer use the spell cancellation ability I had developed utilizing Realmheart and my quadra-elemental abilities. But how effective would it be against Scythes or even asuras? If not, would it help me find the remaining ruins within the Relictombs?

'Maybe the real question is: why aren't we just going to take everything?'

I knew Regis was only asking because that was still a question in my mind as well. Since I could use Aroa's Requiem to reactivate all of the academy's dead relics, I could just take them and worry about how helpful they would be later. But I couldn't imagine a scenario that would allow me to steal the priceless collection and maintain my cover at the academy, or even stay in Alacrya.

Then of course, there was the other question that constantly nagged at me.

How long am I going to keep this up?

Closing the book, I absentmindedly popped a bright red berry into my mouth. The rich sweetness of it was a pleasant surprise. I'd gotten out of the habit of eating regular meals, since aether kept my body alive without it, but I realized that I missed the tastes and textures of food.

I ate a couple more berries, chewing slowly to relish the flavor.

There was something so…*normal* about sitting at the small cafe enjoying a meal in the fresh air. I couldn't remember the last time I'd taken a moment for myself like this.

Leaning back in my chair, I took a deep breath of the bittersweet herbal aroma from my tea and forced away my thoughts.

'Getting pretty comfortable, aren't we?' Regis asked teasingly. *'Hopefully, you don't get too used to this lifestyle.'*

You don't need to remind me why we're here or what's at stake, I pointed out, setting my cup down.

With the books under one arm, I stood and left the cafe patio. Reading about the dead relics was one thing, but it seemed like a good time to see them for myself.

The campus was bustling with activity, but the atmosphere had changed from when I first arrived. Instead of milling around and chatting, the students I saw were all focused on preparing for classes. Most were either sparring or exercising, but there were also quite a few students reading quietly in the fresh air.

Quick footsteps from behind made me spin around. The look on my face must have been hard, because the approaching young man stopped short, his jaw working silently as he struggled for something to say.

Forcing my expression into something more placid, I nodded to the young man. It was the clerk who had originally given me the tour of campus and showed me my rooms. I realized I'd never gotten his name.

"Professor Grey," he mumbled finally. "Sorry if I interrupted, I was just—"

"It's fine," I said, waving his apology away. "Resting professor face. What did you need?"

The small joke got a chuckle out of the clerk, and he settled in beside me as we began walking again. "Oh, nothing really! I'm off duty this morning, but I saw you wandering and thought I'd check in and see if you needed anything. I know the academy can be a little hard to navigate when you first get here."

“No thank you, I was just going to visit the Reliquary after I dropped these books off at the library,” I answered, dismissing the young man.

“The Chapel is such a fascinating building! And those dead relics… Did you know that Central Academy officially has the largest collection of any school in Alacrya? Director Ramseyer himself has overseen many of the acquisitions.” His eyes wandered enthusiastically until he caught sight of another professor being followed by a group of students.

“Oh, and that over there is Professor Graeme. He’s one of the academy’s top researchers,” he said in a nervous whisper.

My guide went silent as his face turned down into a thoughtful frown. Speaking quietly, he added, “He’s also a bit, well… *harsh*.”

My gaze followed the student’s to a man in silky black dress robes. Azure lines ran down the sleeves to the cuffs and from his neckline to trace the opening along his spine. He had six runic tattoos on his exposed back.

A group of students trailed along behind him, listening intently as he talked. A familiar head of orange hair that faded to yellow near the tips stood out among the others. The professor said something I couldn’t hear, causing Briar to laugh and toss her hair.

‘I didn’t think Briar was physically capable of laughing,’ Regis deadpanned. *‘Maybe she’s been possessed.’*

As if he sensed our attention, the professor stopped and turned. He had burnished brown hair that hung in loose curls down to his shoulders and a youthful, cleanly shaved face. Bright, intelligent jade eyes took me in at a glance and his lips quirked up into a half-smile.

“Students!” he announced, lifting both arms to gesture toward me. “It seems we have the good luck to be introduced to Central Academy’s newest faculty member. Will any of you be taking Melee Enhancement Tactics this season?”

The professor glanced around his group. A round of snickers went through the young men and women, most of whom were shaking their heads in denial. Briar was looking at her feet instead of me, and winced as another girl elbowed her and whispered something in her ear.

“No, I suppose you wouldn’t be, would you?” He flashed the group a knowing smile. “There are of course more important topics of study for such accomplished students than learning to punch each other like drunken unads.”

My guide fidgeted nervously beside me. “When I said *harsh…*”

‘What you meant was sandpaper asswipe harsh,’ Regis finished for the young clerk.

“I do hope that you’re a better fit for the duty of teaching than the last *professor* who taught that class.” He gave me a simpering smile. “It’s such an embarrassment to the academy when we employ such useless mages.”

Keeping my face blank, I said, “Pleasure to meet you,” and began to walk away, but the man moved swiftly to cut me off. I paused and met his eyes expectantly.

“There is a certain hierarchy among both faculty and students here,” he informed me. “It is best to figure it out quickly, or you’ll fare no better than your predecessor.”

“I’ll pretend to keep that in mind,” I said politely, eliciting a few bug-eyed looks from the students.

With a nod, I stepped around the stunned professor and walked away, ignoring his near-tangible gaze on my back.

‘At least you can’t be racist about his behavior,’ Regis thought.

I held back a smirk thinking back to the professor I beat on my first day of school in Xyrus. *Whether it’s here or Dicathen, or even Earth, there are always going to be those sorts of people.*

“Sorry about him, sir,” the clerk said, reminding me that he was still there.

“Did you personally transform him from a normal person into a mule’s ass?” I asked, not looking at the young man.

“Um… No?”

“Then why be sorry,” I said firmly. Stopping, I took another look at him. He was tall with dirty blonde hair and an easy smile. His uniform was a little wrinkled, and he had messy hair sticking out at odd angles from his head. “What was your name?”

“Oh, jeez, so rude of me… Tristan, sir. Of Blood Severin. We’re from Sehz-Clar, small blood, I’m only here because I got lucky enough to—”

“Tristan,” I interrupted before he could get lost in a self-deprecating spiel. The boy’s mouth snapped shut. “I appreciate your company but I can find the library on my own.”

Dipping into a bow, he flashed me a wide grin but said nothing else as he spun on his heel and walked quickly away.

‘A bit of a teacher’s pet, but he seems like a useful one to keep around,’ Regis commented as Tristan left.

Technically, you'd be the teacher's pet, I replied with just a flicker of a smile.
'If you're still thinking of a way to get all of those girls off of you, just keep telling jokes like that,' Regis retorted.

Dehlia, the old librarian, wasn't on duty when we arrived in the library, so I dropped the books unceremoniously at the front desk with one of her many assistants.
Before leaving for the Reliquary, there was one more topic of research I knew I couldn't keep running away from. Since I couldn't activate the catalogue system, I began to wander the library at random in search of the right section.
'Why do you need to read books when you have me?' Regis asked, understanding my intent.
No offense, but you haven't been particularly timely or reliable with your cultural knowledge, I thought as we walked through the "Epic Poetry" section.
'Offense taken,' Regis huffed.
I'd been lucky to find people eager to be helpful, like Mayla and Loreni in Maerin Town, and later Alaric and Darrin. At the academy, though, I was surrounded by Alacryans who would be paying closer attention to me, and it was suddenly much more important to have some basic knowledge of Alacryan terms and customs. To that end, I was searching for a book or two that might help give me context to the simple daily normalities of Alacryan life that I wasn't familiar with.

As I passed the "Folktales" section, I heard the heavy *thump* of a fist impacting flesh and a gasp of pain.

'Hey, that sounded pretty interesting,' Regis perked.

It also sounded like it wasn't our business, I countered indifferently.

Beyond the rows of Alacryan folktales, I found a section labeled "Customs and Traditions." The shelves were full of bound books detailing the differing customs of Alacrya's five dominions. Some looked at the topic from a more historical view, exploring how these traditions came to be, while others functioned more like guides for travelers or the nobility.

A low, threatening voice reverberated through the shelves from a nearby section, distracting me from my search.

"—stop pretending you're one of us. Just 'cause your family all got wiped out in the war doesn't make you a real highblood."

"I never said I—*oof!*"

I paused after hearing the familiar voice before he was cut off by another blow.

"Don't speak without permission in the presence of your betters."

Letting out a sigh, I moved slowly and rounded the corner.

Regis let out a snicker. *'What happened to minding our own business?'*

Shut up.

Moving along the lengthy bookshelf, I found a gap that opened into a secluded corner.

Four boys had crammed into the shrouded nook. They all wore the black and azure uniforms of Central Academy, but the disparity between them was clear.

Two of them had Seth, the scrawny kid who had helped me pick out my books, pinned up against the wall. One was very tall and on the thinner side, giving him a stretched appearance. Braided locks of red, black, and blonde hair hung from his head. The other was shorter, but with broad, bearish shoulders and a mop of wild red hair.

The last young man, whose skin was dark ebony and his hair a darker black, stood back a few feet, his arms crossed. He was more classically highborn in appearance than the others, and he wore his nobility openly, in the set of his shoulders, his stance, and the careful passivity of his face, his nose upturned slightly, lips parted in a practiced smile.

"A homeless orphan like you has no place here," grunted the heavy-set boy.

"Go home," wheezed the other, wrapping his hand around the back of Seth's neck.

"Oh wait." The broad boy twisted Seth's arm, causing him to let out a pitiful moan.

"You don't have a home, do you?" asked the thin student as he shoved Seth's head back into the wall.

Stepping into the aisle, I wordlessly passed the dark-haired student and approached the other three.

"Excuse me?" he asked incredulously as I stepped between him and his friends.

The thinner student looked me up and down, his hand still pinning Seth's head to the wall. "Need something?"

Stepping up next to him, I raised a hand. He flinched back, then scowled as I reached past him to pluck a book off the nearest shelf.

As I flipped it open to read the title, I made sure my spiraling ring was plainly visible.

Letting go of Seth's arm, the large boy stuck out his chest and took a step toward me.

I looked up from the book. And waited.

His attempt at a threatening glower twitched. His friend glanced past me to the third boy, grimacing. I let my brows crease into the smallest frown.

The large boy deflated, stepping back again.

"You must be the new combat professor," the black-haired boy said from behind me. "For the no-magic class." When I glanced at him over my shoulder, he nodded slightly in a bow that would have been considered disrespectful in any formal setting. "Professor Grey?" His thin lips turned up in an amused smile. "Show the professor some respect, gentlemen. We'll be seeing him often, after all."

"My bad," the large student grunted.

His companion flashed me a jovial smile as he straightened Seth's uniform for him, causing Seth to flinch back. "Sorry, professor."

Both boys skirted around me as best they could as they followed their ringleader out of the alcove.

"Thanks," Seth said as he unfolded out of his defensive posture.

I scanned the bookshelf absentmindedly, not actually taking notice of any of the book titles. "Liking to read is fine, but you should probably learn how to defend yourself if you plan on staying at this academy."

He was silent as I walked away, letting my words hang in the air.

With a couple new books in hand, I left the library several minutes later and headed for the Reliquary.

I was surprised to find a couple dozen students gathered around the Chapel—the building Tristan had gloated about earlier—watching a procession of mages march out of the portal. Two by two, the armed and armored mages formed a barrier leading from the portal arch to the dark stone steps of the Chapel.

When an unfamiliar horned figure stepped out of the portal, my blood turned to ice in my veins.

The Vritra-blooded man was colossal. He stood well over seven feet tall and had the physique of a titan. His horns jutted from the sides of his shaved head and curved to point forward like a bull's.

'Dragoth,' Regis whispered in my mind. *'A Scythe.'*

Throughout the entire war, I had thought that word with fear and anticipation. The entire Dicathian army trembled at the mention of the title, terrified of the day one would appear on the battlefield and show us what they could really do as elite Alacryan generals.

This fear had only been amplified when the Scythes had finally made an appearance. I had watched Seris Vritra tear the mana-infused horn from Uto's head as effortlessly as a child pulling the wings off a butterfly. I had witnessed the aftermath of Cadell's destruction at the castle, where he overpowered a Lance and the commander of Dicathen's armies without breaking a sweat.

Even at the peak of my strength, I had nearly killed myself to fight to a stalemate against Nico and Cadell—and I would have, had it not been for Sylvie.

These thoughts passed through my mind between one heartbeat and the next, and I realized something.

It wasn't fear that I was feeling.

It was anger.

As one, the body of students took a knee, and suddenly I was exposed to the Scythe.

Dragoth's wide head swiveled around until his blood-red eyes locked on mine. He frowned, halting for a moment, and I felt as if he was looking through my eyes and into my mind, seeing my hostility as plainly as if I'd pointed a sword at his heart.

'Art! Your intent, he can feel it!' Regis sounded panicked but distant, and I realized with a start that I had inadvertently suffused my entire body with aether.

Blinking, I withdrew my intent—which had only just leaked out and was still shrouded under the Scythe's own oppressive aura—and the crowd of students stood, once again obscuring me in the throng.

"Scythe Dragoth Vritra!" a deep voice announced from the doors of the gloomy Chapel. "It is with great honor that we receive you!"

The speaker looked just like his portrait: short grey hair that contrasted sharply against his ebony skin, and a permanently stern expression on his face that didn't break apart even in the face of a Scythe.

Relief mingled with regret as Dragoth turned away from me to face the director. "Augustine," he answered in a warm baritone. He ran a hand through his thick beard. "I've brought the relic as agreed. In person, as Cadell required."

Clenching my fists, I forced the anger down and took an iron grip on my intent. As I looked at the Scythe's black horns, though, the image of Cadell's demonic form standing over the dying Sylvia flashed in my mind. Then Alea, her eyes gone, her limbs nothing but blood stumps. Then Buhnd, on his back in the rubble, burning from the inside out.

Dragoth had said something to the crowd, but I missed it. The Scythe and the director were walking toward the entrance to the Chapel as his guards formed a line across the base of the stairs.

Chatter broke out amongst the crowd all around me, but I could only stare at the Scythe. He was right there. I could kill him now. I could deprive Agrona of one of his most powerful soldiers. I could—

'*—listening to me?'* Regis's voice was suddenly shouting in my head. *'We can't just—'*

I know, I thought, pushing back my emotions and turning away. *Now isn't the time.*

345
SOCIALITE

SETTING down the scroll detailing the lessons I was expected to teach, I sighed and leaned back in my chair. I was forcefully reminded of the military academy I had attended in my previous life, and not in a good way.

The warrior in me—the man who had been a master swordsman, a king, a Lance—looked at these drills, which focused on mastering repeated movements and perfecting the minutiae of stance and the placement of hands and feet, and saw the kind of iron-fisted control over training that defeated creativity in battle. This part of me knew I could do better than grinding students on form.

But then there was another part, too: the brother, friend, and son. I was a Dicathian, displaced and surrounded by enemies, being asked to train soldiers that may one day use these abilities against the people I loved most, just to keep myself safe. Although it had only been two days, it had grown increasingly difficult to focus as that part of me kept asking the same question.

What is the point? I asked myself for the tenth time since the Scythe, Dragoth, had appeared at Central Academy. That anger had clung to me since then, coloring every interaction, poisoning every thought.

I wanted to be doing something more than just going over papers behind a desk.

All of Alaric and Darrin's arguments felt so far away now that I was here, sitting in an office in Central Academy, preparing to *teach*. Had there really not been a better way for me to escape from the political

knot I'd been tied up in, trapped between the hostility of the Granbehls and the manipulation of the Denoirs?

Is all of this even worth it?

"Is all of what worth it?" Regis cut in from where he lay in the corner. "The political protection, the free, no-questions-asked access in and out of the Relictombs? Or maybe the trove of dead relics and textbooks we have access to?"

I closed my eyes. "You know what I mean."

"Just admit that you're scared you're going to see these Alacryans as real people instead of devils incarnate," he said with a smirk. "I imagine humanizing your enemies can't be easy on your already-messed-up moral compass."

Prying an eye open, I threw a scroll at the big roll of fur and fire. Just as it should have bounced off him, his body flared with purple flames, engulfing the projectile.

Regis's smirk merely widened as his tail wagged annoyingly. "I hope that wasn't anything you needed."

I opened my mouth to retort, but a soft knock at the door interrupted me.

'Do you want me to go back in?' Regis asked.

I shook my head. *At this point, it should be fine.*

"What is it?" I said aloud, the words coming out more bluntly than I intended.

The office door swung inward and a woman stepped in, her floating waves of blonde hair trailing after her slightly as if she were surrounded by a gentle breeze. "Grey! I hope you don't mind my stopping by."

I acknowledged her with a terse nod. “I’m sorry, I’m a little busy—”

“Oh, do you need help preparing for class? I’m sure you have so much on your plate.” She bounced across the room and leaned one hip against my desk to look down at the materials spread out in front of me. “This is the third season I’ve taught both my classes, so I’m all set, myself. I’d be happy to spend some time with you—helping you, I mean.”

Frowning, I considered how best to get rid of the woman without burning a bridge, but Regis shuffled, his flames flaring, and Abby squealed and retreated back across the small office.

“Wh-what is *that*?” she exclaimed, her amber eyes wide with fright.

“My summons,” I answered nonchalantly.

“Wow, a summons?” Abby asked breathlessly, her cheeks flushed from fright. “I’ve never seen one quite like this before.” Taking a few tentative steps away from Regis, who was having a difficult time maintaining a serious face, she hiked herself up onto my desk, one leg crossed over the other. “That’s really impressive. Do you mind if I ask, though”—her lips quirked up into a teasing smile—“having your summons out, do you feel in danger or something?”

Regis waggled his brows as he watched Abby lean in closer toward me, obviously enjoying my discomfort. I was tempted to call him back with the verbal cue that Regis and I had agreed on beforehand for cases like this, but my companion shook his head now that Abby wasn’t looking at him.

‘I like the view from here, if you don’t mind,’ he said with a satisfied smile. *‘And watching you squirm makes it even better.’*

I shook my head, locking my gaze with Abby's and returning a soft smile. "Perhaps I just wanted to impress a fellow colleague."
"O-oh," The blonde-haired professor's eyes widened, taken aback. Regis's eyes did the same.
After a brief pause, I gave her a wink. "I only jest, Miss Redcliff. Though, I'm sure you're well accustomed to shrugging off leering suitors."
"You're too much," she said with a giggle, her ears burning bright as she looked away. "And please, call me Abby."
"Very well." I stood up and walked around my desk, leaning against it next to her.
I held out my hand and waited for her to take it. Her fingers barely touched my own as she returned my gesture. "It's a pleasure to see you again, Abby."
"The pleasure is mine," she replied with a light squeeze of my hand.
Pulling away, I took a peek at my companion, whose jaw was slack, before turning my attention back to my guest. "I hope I'm not sitting too close. Talking to you from behind my desk makes it feel like I'm talking to my students."
"No, I prefer this as well, I mean—I'm not a student, after all," she said, shaking her head.
"Good, I'm glad," I chuckled happily before letting my grin fall. "Though we may have to keep our conversation short today."
Abby kept her expression impartial, but her shoulders slumped at my words. "Oh? I take it you've made plans for the rest of your day?"
"I plan to enjoy a lovely date with these piles of papers over here," I said with a tired smile.

“Like I said before, I’d be happy to help you prepare for your class, Grey,” she said.
“It’s not really about my class, per se.” I scratched my cheek while looking away, feigning shame. “Nevermind, it’s a bit embarrassing for me to say aloud.”
“What is it?” Abby’s amber eyes twinkled in curiosity as she leaned closer to me. “I promise I won’t tell.”
I let out a sigh. “Well, I’m from a rather detached area of Sehz-Clar so I’m terribly uninformed about much of what everyone here would consider common knowledge.”
Abby’s face brightened in realization. “Oh! You couldn’t have told anyone better!”
I raised a brow, shooting her a timid upward glance. “What do you mean?”
My colleague gave me a mischievous grin. “You see, I’ve known most of the other professors here long before I took a teaching post myself, and a lot of us like to talk.”
I leaned closer to Abby, just enough to let our shoulders touch. “Really now?”
She glanced at our shoulders before looking back up. “And a common gossip topic we all share is about the students here, especially which highbloods we have to watch out for.”
“I’m jealous.” I let out a meek chuckle. “I really want to make a home out of this place and fit in, but asking for you to share so much with me would only be a burden on you.”
“It wouldn’t be a burden at all!” She lit up like Xyrus during the Aurora Constellate. “Oh, where do I even begin?”

I let my hand rest gently on her arm for a moment as I gave Abby a wistful smile. “You’re a lifesaver, Abby. That was really helpful.”

Beaming, she slid from my desk and bent into a curtsy, holding her white battle robes out like the hem of a dress. “At your service, Professor Grey. Please”—those honey-tinted eyes held mine with fierce attentiveness—“don’t hesitate to call on me again, okay? Maybe for drinks next time?”

I walked after her, leading her toward my door with a light touch at the small of her back and a smile to accompany it. “Let me walk you out.”

“Quite the gentleman for someone so socially disinclined, or so you put it,” the Caster said with a shy smile before stepping out of my office.

As soon as I closed the door behind Abby and her hair, which billowed in a wind she was obviously conjuring around herself, my shoulders slumped and a breath escaped my lungs. The lingering anger had finally burned itself out, but I was left feeling cold and detached.

Turning around, I was faced with a dumbstruck Regis, his uncomprehending eyes staring at me.

“What?” I snapped.

“Who are you and what have you done with my antisocial, charming-as-a-grumpy-log owner?” he asked with a mixture of suspicion and admiration leaking into my head.

“Just because I choose to be reserved, doesn’t mean I can’t be charming when need be,” I argued, sinking back into my chair.

Regis followed me to my seat and put his muzzle on my desk. "Aren't you worried that Miss Loose Lip over there will tell other professors all about her conversation with you?"

"I'm counting on it," I answered wearily, leaning my head back. "My fake background will be a lot more believable if it comes from someone else's mouth."

"Should I be scared of your uncanny proficiency in the art of seduction?"

"You make it seem like I just sold myself to her or something," I scoffed.

"And the way you avoided her last question by putting your hand on her back… did you learn that from a textbook or something? Because I'd like to read that as well," he said, shaking his head.

I ignored my companion as I kicked one foot up on the desk, resting the heel of my boot in the middle of the stack of parchment.

"Shouldn't you be working on all that, anyway?" Regis pointed out.

"Yes, assuming I had any interest in actually teaching these kids." Standing up again, I left the office. "Come on, let's make some use out of this training facility before school starts."

Regis tottered after me. "Ooh, a battle for the gravity-defying hottie?"

"Get your head out of the gutter. She's not an object," I shot back. "And besides, I thought you had a thing for Caera."

"Why do I need to only like one?" Regis asked seriously.

I rolled my eyes as I made my way to the control panel. "Just go stretch or something so you don't blame losing to a pulled ethereal groin."

After fiddling with a few switches, the shielding barrier sprang to life with a low hum. Next, I turned the gravity within the ring up as high as the system would go, biting back a smirk.

"I'll show *you* an ethereal groin," Regis quipped, leaping up onto the platform and immediately stumbling under the weight of his own body. "Hey, wait a damned second!"

I chortled as I hopped up next to him. The force of the increased gravity was oppressive—maybe seven times normal—but nothing I couldn't handle with aether infusing my muscles and bones.

"What's wrong, pup?" I teased, beginning to bounce on the balls of my feet as I acclimated to the change in environment.

Regis let out a low growl and stalked back and forth across his end of the platform as he, too, attempted to adjust. "Oh ho. You are *so* lucky that I'd probably cease to exist if I blasted you with Destruction right now."

Holding back a grin, I began to throw tentative punches and kicks in the air, feeling out the extra weight of my blows, then shifted into a set series of motions I'd learned while studying under Kordri. The minute, careful movement required to implement most of the asuran martial skills was made significantly more difficult by the intense weight of my limbs.

Regis twisted his neck with a resounding *crack*, and his entire body quivered with anticipation—or maybe it was the effort of standing in the increased gravity. "You ready for this, princess?"

Focusing, I narrowed my attention on the shadow wolf, blocking out the subtle hum of the shield and the sound of students' voices that occasionally drifted in from the courtyard outside.

My companion's haunches tensed, and in the next instant he was hurtling through the air like a ballista bolt, but I had already stepped to the side, the flat of my hand coming up to deflect his snapping jaws.

As he flew past, my other hand snatched at one of his rear paws. The simple disturbance of his momentum, combined with the increased gravity, was enough to send him spinning so that he crashed heavily to the mat, landing on his back and tumbling painfully into the shielding.

"Couldn't have… turned on the impact dampening?" Regis huffed as he fought back to his feet.

"Finished already?" I asked in a tone of mock disappointment.

The flames around Regis's lupine body flared, painting the classroom with splashes of purple light. Once he was on his feet again, he squared up for another leap, apparently out of things to say for once.

The tensing of his body was even more pronounced on his second pounce, but rather than lunging directly at me, he feinted forward only a few feet, waiting for me to step aside, then redirected his attack.

I brought up my aether-clad hands, intending to catch Regis in midair, but his form shifted and became ethereal, and he vanished into my body. I spun, expecting what followed, but with my body weighted down I wasn't fast enough, and his jaws latched around my calf and pulled the leg out from under me, sending me crashing heavily to the ground.

The shadow wolf's fire-wreathed head smirked down at me. “One-one, *boss*.”

Raising myself up onto one elbow, I inspected my companion thoughtfully. “Utilizing your ethereal form to outmaneuver me like that was pretty clever.”

Regis puffed out his chest. “I’m a literal weapon designed by a *deity*, for Vritra’s sake. You think I—” Regis stopped, staring down at me with wide eyes.

I returned his gaze with a wry smile, one brow lifted. “For Vritra’s sake?”

“Ugh, sorry. Some of Uto slipping through.” He sat back and smirked mischievously. “That part really enjoyed putting you on your ass, by the way.”

I heaved myself to my feet. “Let’s see if you can do that again.”

We continued to train and spar until our legs shook with the effort and my core ached from the amount of aether it took to strengthen my body against the heightened gravity. Regis was circling me, biding his time before another attack. Although he was trying to shield his thoughts, I knew he was at the end of his physical strength for the moment.

Which is why I thought he’d be caught off guard when I Burst Step across the dueling ring onto his back, but before his legs could collapse from the added burden, the shadow wolf vanished, drifting safely into my body while I slammed to the ground hard enough to shake the entire platform.

'We've got company,' Regis's voice sounded from inside my head. *'You take care of this guy. I'm going to take a nice, long nap in your aether core.'*

Remind me to start locking that door while we're in here, I groused.

Kicking up off the mat, I scanned the room and saw that a man was making his way slowly down the stairs toward me, limping slightly on each step. He looked ten or so years older than me, but something—maybe the way he held himself, the slightly soft lines of his face, or the expression of youthful amusement he wore—told me he was younger than he looked.

Once he saw me look up, he gave a little wave, which I didn't immediately return. His hand went to his auburn hair, ruffling it so that it looked even more wind-blown and mussed than it already had, but my attention was on the other hand—or the lack of it, as it ended in a stump at his elbow.

"Hi there. Grey, right?"

"Yeah," I said breathlessly. "Can I help you?"

He tilted his head curiously before giving me a polite smile. "No, not particularly. My classroom is just down the hall, and I wanted to stop by and introduce myself. I'm Kayden of Blood Aphelion."

I gave him a single nod of my head, which sent a fresh wave of sweat rolling down my cheeks and nose. In my head, Regis said, *'Even Uto had heard of the Aphelions. Highbloods, military family.'*

A frown flitted across his face for less than a second, but was smoothed away just as quickly as he limped toward the dueling ring. "You're as laconic as the rumors say, which is a welcome change around these parts."

“Your tone suggests a dislike of gossip, but it seems like you’re rather well-inclined towards rumors yourself,” I replied with a raised brow.

“I choose to listen rather than partake, but I will admit to the minor hypocrisy,” he said with a chuckle, continuing to take careful steps down the stairs. “Anyway, I managed to catch your last movement and I have to say… your speed is almost as impressive as your mana control. Even now, I can’t sense even a drop of mana leaking from you.”

It wasn’t until he stepped over the boundary of the platform that I realized…

“Personally, I don’t spend as much time as I—oof!”

Like he’d stepped off the edge of a cliff, Kayden collapsed, his injured leg giving out immediately on contact with the platform as his weight increased seven-fold.

Ignoring Regis, who was roaring with laughter, I jumped down to the floor and hit the control to reset all settings. The mana shield crackled as it faded away, and the highblood Alacryan was able to push himself up into an awkward sitting position.

“Vritra’s horns, how were you even standing up here?” he asked, gaping at me. Then he let out a surprisingly genuine laugh. “Of course the man who broke his detention chains right in front of the panel of judges attempting to execute him would train like this.”

“Sorry,” I said, although in the back of my mind I was wondering just how many people here knew about the trial. “Are you all right?”

“No harm done,” he said with a grin. “I’ve had worse.”

“I…don’t doubt that,” I replied, looking down at his stump of an arm.

After a brief pause, Kayden stifled a laugh.

My brows furrowed. “Is something wrong?”

“No, it’s nothing.” He waved his hand, still smiling. “It’s just that, I’ve seen a lot of people look at what’s left of my left arm, but you’re the only one whose expression didn’t turn into pity.”

“Who am I to pity when that could be your medal of honor or token of sacrifice,” I said simply.

Kayden’s lightheartedness disappeared as he stared at me like I had just sprouted wings before catching himself and shaking his head while muttering, “I’m really glad I brought this.”

Using my shirt to mop up my sweaty face, I considered the man as he sat up and kicked his legs over the edge of the dueling platform. He withdrew a bright white bundle from his dimension artifact, which appeared to be a simple golden bracelet around his remaining wrist.

He held out the bundle with careful nonchalance. When I hesitated, he gave me a knowing smirk. “Don’t worry, I’m not in the habit of giving gifts that might harm the recipient.”

I pulled the gift from his loose grip. It was soft to the touch. I shook it so the bundle unfolded, revealing a brilliant white cloak with a white fur-lined hood. It was trimmed in subtly shining silver that felt metallic to the touch.

A closer look revealed nearly invisible runes embroidered across the hood. “Magic?” I asked suspiciously.

The man grinned. “I thought perhaps you might appreciate a little anonymity when you travel outside the academy grounds, considering.”

I rubbed my fingers over the white-on-white thread forming the runes. “Some kind of concealment spell?”

Kayden nodded, his brows twitching upward. “Specifically, the cloak will conceal you from the attention of others, causing their eyes to slip away from your face. Only when the hood is up, and only when they don’t look too closely.” He cleared his throat and shuffled slightly. “I hope I haven’t misread the situation…”

Frowning, I glanced at the man, who was watching me closely. I realized I’d been staring at the runes as I thought about what his gift—and his words—implied. “This is a costly present,” I said, folding the cloak back up. I held it out to him. “I can’t accept this.”

Kayden’s expression softened, but he didn’t move to take it back. “I understand why you’d think that, but it’s nothing, honestly. Whether you choose to use it or throw it away, do with it what you will.”

After a beat of hesitation, I nodded, accepting the magical cloak. “You have my thanks,” I said formally, giving the other professor a small bow.

Kayden waved away my gesture before making a somewhat clumsy dismount from the platform. “It was a pleasure meeting you, Grey.” He began to limp toward the stairs, then paused and looked back over his shoulder. “Everyone around here has their demons, Grey. Most people won’t be able to see yours past their own.”

Smiling to himself, the man made his delicate way up the stairs and out of my classroom.

'Weird dude,' Regis noted. *'But he brought presents, though, so I'll forgive him.'*

"Most people won't see yours past their own," I echoed, taking comfort in those words.

'Yeah, stop being so paranoid. That's basically what I've been telling you,' Regis chimed.

I looked down at the refined white cloak. "How many days until classes start?"

'Yes. Just yes,' Regis said, reading my thoughts.

"And you're *sure* you want to go in alone?" the woman asked me again. She was middle-aged, with a hint of gray in her brown hair. A burn scar covered the left side of her face. "There are plenty of groups looking for—"

"I'm sure," I said with a stale smile.

The clerk finally relented with a shrug as she marked something down on the scroll in front of her. "Professor Grey of Central Academy, solo ascent. Your identity has been verified. All relics and accolades must be logged on your exit. May your ascent be fruitful."

Stepping away from the booth, I pulled the fur-lined hood back up to hide my features and looked around.

A few dozen ascenders were gathered in front of the massive ascension portal, either lined up behind me or preparing to enter. I scanned the banners showing the sigils of the many high and named bloods hanging from the white walls and stifled a laugh when I saw that someone had defaced the Granbehl's banner.

A group of young men and women, no older than their late teens, was standing nearby, and one of them attempted to catch my eye. He was holding an artifact that looked like a simple black box with a mana crystal affixed to it.

“Hey, sorry to bother you,” he said, flashing a sheepish smile, “but would you mind taking our picture? It’s our first ascent without a principal—”

“No,” I said simply, walking past the surprised group and directly into the golden-white light of the portal.

346
A DIM SPARK

MY EYES TOOK a moment to adjust to the sudden dimness as I stepped out of the ascension portal.

I sucked in a lungful of aether-laden air, and it felt like the first real breath I'd taken in weeks. The tension faded from my muscles, and there was a hungry jolt from my core as it reacted to the dense atmospheric aether.

I was standing on a small floating island. The portal had faded, leaving behind only an empty frame overgrown with sharp purple crystals. Dozens of other floating islands hovered at the heart of what appeared to be…

Regis let out an appreciative whistle. *'Whoa.'*

A few strides were all it took to cross the island I was on. I gazed down into the gloom below before looking up at the roof high above; the curving walls, floor, and ceiling of this cavernous structure were made of enormous purple crystals. Similar growths dotted the many islands as well, some the size of small bushes, while others grew into huge, jagged boulders.

It was like standing at the heart of an enormous, glowing geode.

Regis's shadow wolf form coalesced next to me, looking down as he licked his lips. "Imagine how much aether is stored in all these crystals."

My eyes focused on a black spire that rose from an island in the center of the zone. Augmenting my vision with aether, I could just make out the carvings covering the entire three-story structure. It

was also the only thing in the zone that contained no aether. “What is that?”

My companion managed to pry his hungry gaze away from the aether crystals to take a glance at the black spire. “Beats me…but knowing the Relictombs, it’s probably going to try to kill us.”

“Reasonable assumption.” I nodded in agreement before turning to the archway shimmering with opalescent light on the far end of the geode. “At least the exit is within sight.”

“Seems too easy,” Regis said, sniffing around the edge of the platform. “We’re supposed to just play leapfrog from island to island until we reach the portal?” Regis sprang across the twenty-foot gap to the closest island, then back again to prove his point.

“Feel free to play leapfrog by yourself.” I began charting the aetheric paths all the way to the portal before shooting my companion a wink. “See you on the other side.”

Regis cursed as I started to God Step across the zone.

As I stepped onto the next island, however, the pathways began to shimmer before twisting and melting away in a fuzzy haze. The atmosphere trembled with a sickening vibration.

Suddenly dizzy, I stumbled to one knee.

“Wha—”

The howl of a rushing wind filled the entire zone. Clouds of purple motes flew from the thousands of glowing crystals, being drawn toward the obelisk at the heart of the geode. My instincts took hold and I forced the gates around my core shut, but it was no use; my reservoir was emptied, the aether I had collected since our training session forced out of me and drawn away on the receding tide.

A thin, strained voice cried out over the howling wind.

My eyes widened in horror at the sight of Regis, collapsed, his physical form rapidly dwindling as the aether that bound it together was forced away. The shadow wolf became a pup, then a will-o-wisp, before fading into a dim spark.

I reached out a trembling hand as the glowing strands of his black and violet form faded. My fist closed just as the final spark began to disperse, and his incorporeal form drifted into me, his mind dark and cold.

The wind faded, as did the horrible vibration, though the sensation lingered behind my eyes and deep in my aching core. Backlash sent spasms through my chest and stomach, but I resisted the urge to be sick, and instead forced myself back to my feet in order to figure out what the hell had just happened.

Every inch of my body ached as I moved. Dragons needed aether to survive; their bodies consumed themselves if they didn't have enough—and my physical form was mostly asuran now. I couldn't be sure how long I had, but it felt like even my blood had dried up into sand. And there wasn't a single particle of aether left in the atmosphere.

Regis was silent, his minuscule spark floating near my empty core.

The zone had gone dark except for the obelisk. Now containing every mote of aether within the geode—including my own—the obelisk glowed like a neon light, burning with impossible power. I was stunned.

Even as my tired, aching mind had trouble focusing, my eyes were locked onto the glowing spire like it was an oasis in the middle of a desert.

But the obelisk continued to grow even brighter.

I cursed, pulling my gaze away and scanning the other islands. Most of them had crystal protrusions, but mine didn't. If the growths had all been suffused with aether when we arrived, it made sense that—

I cursed again. The twenty feet to the nearest island felt a lot farther now that I couldn't strengthen my body with magic, but there was no other choice but to make the jump.

Backing up until my heel was pressed against the quiet portal frame, I gathered all my strength before bursting into an all-out run. I hit the edge of the island at full speed and kicked off, hurling myself through the air toward the neighboring landmass, but my backlash-weakened muscles resisted, and I knew the moment I jumped that it wasn't going to be enough.

My chest impacted the stony cliff with *crunch*. I scrambled for something to grab onto amongst the bare stone and loose dirt as I slid down the side, but failed. Just as my lower half swung out into the open air, my left hand closed around something hard and sharp: a knife-like shard of crystal growing out of the dirt.

I hung that way for the space of a single breath before the obelisk flashed. A sphere of aetheric fire burst out from it, quickly engulfing the closest islands. A pained yell ripped out from my throat as I heaved myself up—the crystal cutting deep into my palm—until I could kick one leg over the side of the island.

On pure instinct, I threw myself behind the large crystal growth and curled up in a ball, my back pressed against it just before the nova engulfed me.

Rather than burning my flesh, the aether was drawn into the crystal growth at my back. The explosion continued to expand past me, but the small area just behind the barrier was shielded.

I was able to watch from relative safety as the expanding sphere of light crashed against the distant walls, infusing them with aether and lighting up the entire zone again.

With no way of knowing how much time we had, I struggled back to my feet, each breath a pained gasp, and pressed my bleeding hand to the boulder-sized growth. My core hungrily devoured the aether stored within, and I was finally able to breathe. It wasn't much, but enough to heal my hand and fortify my body to stave off the backlash.

I fought the urge to check in on Regis and focused on getting out of the zone. My stomach twisted and churned as I searched for aetheric pathways.

There was no path to the exit portal. At least, there was no path I could follow. The branching, interconnected points—which usually made a kind of road map from one space to the next—were tangled in a convoluted knot.

To make matters worse, I could already feel the nausea-inducing vibration building up again, trembling through every particle of aether in the zone simultaneously.

With no other recourse, I threw myself back behind the crystal shield and hoped it would protect me again. When the obelisk activated, all

the aether in my core was ripped away for a second time. All I managed to maintain was a thin layer that I wrapped around Regis to keep him safe.

The pain was immeasurable. As my eyes rolled back in my head and my mouth opened in a silent scream, I focused every ounce of my remaining strength on staying conscious.

The second explosion rippled past me, a visible wave of dark purple fire that washed over the series of islands, lighting up clusters of aether crystals one by one until it hit the far walls. The cavern burst into light again.

I can't die like this. There has to be something I can do, I assured myself over the sound of my teeth grinding against each other. My sluggish mind struggled to sort everything I knew and what I could potentially use.

The obelisk on the central island absorbed all the aether from the zone, then utilized it in some kind of explosive attack. I didn't know what would happen if I was struck by the explosion, but with no aether to defend myself, I was sure it wouldn't be pretty. Aside from whatever destructive effect it had, the explosion also redistributed aether throughout the zone.

The time between the first wave and the second had been different by several seconds, so it seemed likely that there was some randomness involved. Unfortunately, this meant I couldn't rely entirely on timing to move through the zone.

But the crystal growths on the islands acted like shields due to their reabsorption of some of the aether. It was just too bad that they didn't also protect against the part when my core was drained over

and over again. If I couldn't find some way around that, the backlash would kill me before anything else got the chance.

When my brain cells and the blood in my veins began to shudder again, I clenched my teeth and prepared for the worst. It had come faster this time by at least fifteen seconds, and I hadn't even absorbed any of the aether from the protrusion I was sheltered behind to protect myself with.

This time, though, was different. The amethyst light playing within the clear crystals dimmed as the aether particles were drawn away, but I felt nothing. The tiny piece of aether I had held on to, wrapped protectively around Regis, had trembled with the vibration, but hadn't been pulled away from me.

The puzzle clicked into place.

Knowing I would have to move quickly, I rose up to one knee, making sure my body was still entirely blocked from the blast that came shortly after. I was already absorbing the aether from the crystal barrier before the rest of the explosion hit the outer walls. Once I had absorbed the entire reservoir, I strengthened my body and sprinted to the edge of the island, clearing the twenty-five-foot gap with room to spare.

I barely had time to lunge behind a large, curved growth of the clear crystals before the warning vibrations shivered through my core again. When the stones at my back dimmed, and the walls released streams of amethyst particles, my own aether gave a faint tug but stayed safely in my core.

A shuddering breath escaped my lips.

"That's it…" I gasped in relief.

By hiding behind stones still full of aether while the obelisk drew it in, then absorbing it for myself after the following explosion, I could jump from island to island while refilling my core and avoiding the djinn's trap. The only variable became timing.

Before maneuvering to the next floating island, I turned my attention to Regis. It took a quarter of my aether reserve, imbued directly into the tiny wisp, to bring back any signs of life. A sluggish confusion leaked from him before quickly sharpening into panic as he flew into my core, drawing on the rest of my reserves in a rush.

Don't take too much! I warned quickly. *I need as much as I can if we want to get out of here.*

Regis didn't respond. Instead, I felt a cold, numb fear… something I'd never felt from him before.

You all right now? I asked tentatively. He hadn't been this weak since he first formed from the acclorite given to me by Wren Kain.

'How'd that even…I almost…' Regis let out a resigned sigh. *'That fucking sucked.'*

We'll get through this, I assured him. *Just stay near my core and focus on recovering when I absorb more aether.*

Another explosion rolled by. This one had been forty seconds from the previous, and ten seconds since the absorption process.

And Regis?

'What?'

Glad you're not dead, I thought evenly, suppressing the fear and worry that had plagued me when he nearly disintegrated.

My companion let out a groan. *'Don't get all emotional on me now.'*

I was just worried that all of the aether I fed you would've gone to waste if you had died back there, I lied.

'Ah, there's my loveable master,' Regis said, his weak voice still oozing with sarcasm.

While I'd been checking on Regis, three more blasts had gone off. The shortest gap between the explosion and following absorption was seven seconds, which didn't leave a lot of time to maneuver around. The next time a blastwave emanated out from the obelisk, I quickly drained the crystal shield and leaped to the closest island. It was a barren little patch of stone with no protrusions, so I moved on immediately, sliding into cover a full ten seconds before all the aether was sucked in again.

I waited, catching my breath and allowing another phase to go by. The jet black spire blazed amethyst as the power built up before being released yet again. Wrapping my hand in a thick protective barrier, I reached up into the oncoming blast.

Now that I had a better grasp on my overall situation in this zone, I wanted to test the strength of the blast while simultaneously attempting to absorb aether directly from the explosion. The blazing wall of light burned away my protective aether, then my hand along with it, leaving behind nothing but a cauterized stump.

'*That turned out nicely,'* Regis noted.

"The sarcasm…I don't miss," I hissed breathlessly. "Hand. Now."

The wisp drifted down my arm to the scorched stump of my wrist, and I released nearly all of the aether from my core. It rushed through my aether channels, further condensed by Regis, and began

to rebuild my hand, knitting flesh, blood, and bone from the purple particles.

The destruction of my appendage made me realize that I had, at some point, stopped fearing the Relictombs. I'd come to think of it as a personal training ground, like the flying castle or Epheotus, and forgotten that it was designed to kill me; its difficulty would always grow to match my strength.

By the time I had restored my hand, nearly all of my meager aether reserves had been depleted.

'Have I ever told you that you're a masochist?'

"Once or twice." I mustered a weak grin as I leaned back against the cool glowing barrier.

When the vibration came again, signaling the start of another phase, I burst into motion.

Several islands passed by quickly, each in the same fashion, and by the time I was halfway to the exit portal I was feeling better. My core was rich with absorbed aether, and my body had healed. My companion wasn't as lucky.

'This is the worst,' he complained from within me. Even though I had absorbed more than enough aether to share, it was impossible for Regis to draw on it as quickly. After experiencing something akin to muscle atrophy, he would need to spend time rebuilding his strength.

"Just stay in there and absorb what you can," I said while also counting down the time since the obelisk had drawn in the zone's aether. It had been over a minute, but the black spire was still growing brighter, building up toward the inevitable explosion.

Finally, it burst with the sound of a thousand cannons. I waited for the ripple of aetheric fire to roll past, then quickly drew out the energy trapped inside my protective barrier and prepared to leap to the next island.

The obelisk exploded a second time.

My course took me in the direction of the oncoming nova, so for a moment I was suspended in the air, watching the blaze overtake one island after the next as it expanded toward me.

I hit the ground in a roll, slamming hard into a small cluster of crystals just barely big enough to cover my whole body. When the blast struck the crystals, already burning with purple light, they trembled and began to splinter with sharp cracking sounds.

Not bothering to absorb the aether from the crumbling protrusion, I threw myself at the next floating island just as the obelisk exploded for the third time.

The crystal shield on this island was the largest I had seen so far and curved inward to create a small cave. As I scrambled into the shallow depression, a noise like shattering glass filled the zone in short bursts.

The crystal barriers, I realized just as the wave of aetheric fire roared past my shelter. Pressing both hands against the glowing walls, I began to absorb the aether as fast I could, draining the crystals to prevent them from bursting apart.

All around me, clusters of violently glowing crystals shattered, sending shrapnel spraying across the other islands.

Looking around the edge of my shield, I saw that the only protective barrier to survive was the one I had hidden behind. I quickly charted

a path to the exit portal, but it was too far to reach before the next explosion.

Using most of my stored aether to activate Burst Step, I propelled myself across several islands.

'Uh, that's the wrong way!' Regis pointed out as we sprinted and leaped toward the central island and the obelisk.

Lacking the time or mental energy to put my plan into words, I tried to project the idea directly into Regis's mind.

'You… sure about this?' Regis asked.

"No," I grunted as we landed on the central island, the three-story spire rising high overhead. "But it can't be any worse than swimming in lava, right?"

The obelisk was dark and empty, but I didn't think I had long before the next wave began. Hurrying to it, I pressed my hands to the smooth sides. It had a glassy texture and was cold to the touch.

I waited. Thoughts ran in a jumble through my mind. If this failed, then I would probably die.

When the vibration started, my eyes snapped shut and my lungs seized in my chest. It was much more intense this close to the obelisk. I prepared for the backlash.

Having my core suddenly and forcibly drained for the third time in thirty minutes made my legs shake and my palms sweat. I heaved for breath, trying to force my lungs to work again, but it felt like a titan bear was sitting on my chest.

I started to absorb aether from the spire before it had even finished taking it from me. I needed to utilize every possible second before the next aetheric blast.

The offsetting flow of aether kept me on my feet despite the pain of backlash. I sucked at the aether building within the obelisk-like a half-drowned man gasping for air. My hands were already pressed against the quickly-warming stone, but I leaned forward and rested my forehead against it as well, absorbing the swelling energy as quickly as I could.

The aether was pure. Much more so than any source I'd encountered before. It was like breathing in pure oxygen; my head swam with the power of it, burning like a bonfire in my solar plexus.

My aether core couldn't even condense or refine it further. Instead, the purified aether was scraping the remaining impurities from my core, and my chest began to ache.

As my core filled to the brim, I continued to draw aether from the spire—I had no choice. If I stopped, it would explode and kill me—but it felt like I was trying to drink the ocean. My core was so full that it began to quake and tremble. A radiant bolt of pain shot out of it, and I tasted bile in the back of my throat.

The light from the obelisk grew brighter and brighter through my closed eyelids. I wasn't even sure how long it had been.

I tried to expel most of the aether from my core, just like I had when I first began to trace my aether passages, but when I opened the gates around my core, the streams still running in from all over my body overwhelmed my attempt to push outward, creating a backflow that caused an uncontrolled flood of purified aether that I couldn't stop.

'I'm drowning in here!' Regis shouted, his wisp form entirely inundated with aether.

Strobing flashes of light pierced my eyelids. I pushed my face away from the obelisk and opened my eyes; the spire flickered, struggling to release the intended expulsion of destructive energy but lacking the force to do so. I was acting like a release valve, giving the aether an outlet that kept the pressure from reaching the necessary level.

There was a resounding *crack* from my sternum.

Looking inward, I saw a dark fissure appear across the surface of my aether core.

My vision swam. Fireworks went off behind my eyes. A white hot blade of pain cut all the way through me.

No.

A second crack branched off the first, shivering like a slow-motion bolt of lightning around the circumference of my sphere, nearly breaking it in two.

No!

Taking a ragged breath, I bent every ounce of my formidable will on the task of molding the aether to my will. With somewhere else to go, it stopped overflowing into my weakening core, and I eased into a delicate balance between the obelisk's continued efforts to explode and my inescapable absorption and reformation of the purified aether.

Despite the precarious nature of my position, a grin formed on the corners of my bloody lips.

Regis hovered within my core, watching me work. *'No way.'*

"Yeah," I huffed, my smile stretching wider. "Definitely better than bathing in lava."

347
A STROLL WITH GODS

ALDIR

A sea of mist moved in the unconscious rhythm of earth and air, eddying around the base of the mountain and under the many-colored bridge that guarded Castle Indrath. Wide, white rivers streamed past further out, away from the tumultuous currents near the stone cliffs.

It was almost as if one could ride the wild river of clouds away from Castle Indrath and into the far reaches of Epheotus, where the politics and intrigue of war were a distant, meaningless shadow.

I'd carried the knowledge of Arthur Leywin's survival for several days now, but the understanding of what to do with it eluded me. As a soldier, I owed it to my lord to inform him at once, and yet…

My fingers traced the story carved into the wall where I'd stopped to think. It told the tale of an ancient Indrath prince, and how he challenged Geolus, the living mountain. Hundreds of miles had been torn apart by the ferocity of their battle, but in the end, Arkanus Indrath cleaved Geolus nearly in two, and the mountain fell still.

In ages after, Akranus's descendants built their home on the mountain's back. As a sign of respect, they forbid the use of mana when ascending or descending Geolus, a tradition that lived on to the present era.

A wisp of earth mana trickled from the runes and along my outstretched fingers, imparting me with the stolid essence of ancient bedrock. My mind quieted as my spirit settled. This tale was a

favorite of mine; it imparted the passiveness of rock and stone, allowing for more rational thought.

“I guessed that I might find you here, old friend,” Windsom's voice came from down the hall. “Is your mind still plagued with doubt?”

“No,” I answered, half turning to watch the dragon approach. He wore his uniform as always, which denoted his position as a servant of Lord Indrath. The midnight blue fabric was embroidered with gold thread at the cuffs, shoulders, and collar, and a rope of woven gold hung from his right shoulder to the middle button of his jacket. I had allowed myself more comfort, wearing a simple gray training robe bound with a silk cord.

His gaze settled on me with the weight of the night sky. “When we last spoke…”

He left the rest unsaid, but we both understood well enough. I had expressed concern that our actions had led to more Dicathian deaths than Agrona’s ever had or likely would, a moment of weakness I now regretted.

“I did not carry the burden of my actions lightly or well, but distance widens one’s perspective,” I answered.

Windsom glanced at the story wall. “Are these the words of Aldir, or of Geolus?”

“I am a warrior,” I answered simply. “My mind is full of tactics and battle, and at times requires calming.” Stepping back from the wall, I gestured down the hallway. “Walk with me? I am enjoying the castle this morning.”

Windsom nodded and fell into step beside me, his hands clasped behind his back, his eyes straight ahead. “I’m glad you’ve accepted

the necessity of what was done. At least your part is played, for the time being."

We stepped aside as two armored guards marched past. They stopped to bow deeply before continuing on their patrol. "Is that why you were so quick to volunteer to lead the attack? To end your long-suffered role as guide to the lessers?"

Windsom straightened his uniform. "I will do as Lord Indrath commands, now and always. But the truth is, you had it easy, old friend. The lessers have become more tedious by the day. At least the boy, Arthur, was interesting. The rest are just fireflies."

I couldn't be sure if the dragon spoke out of ignorance, or if he was testing me with his suggestion that my task had somehow been "easy." It was possible he was attempting to push me to anger so that I might reveal some hidden reservation. I let his words go by unanswered.

"Is the situation in Dicathen salvageable?" I asked.

"They have not accepted our version of events as readily as the asuras," he answered, his tone accusatory. "Lessers are suspicious by nature, and they yearn for hope above all else, even if it means abandoning logic."

I nodded solemnly as we turned a corner. On our right, a training room was open to the hallway, separated only by a series of columns carved into the shape of serpentine dragons. Four students practiced a coordinated series of movements and strikes, each in near-perfect unison with the others.

I stopped to watch for a moment. I'd witnessed a thousand—maybe even ten thousand—such displays in my life, but now I couldn't help

but see it as much more than the slow perfection of form, speed, and delivery that we taught our youth. With each practiced strike and block, they learned a blow intended to disarm or kill an opponent. If the asuras continued on their current path, these young warriors would have reason to use them soon.

"Taci looks strong," Windsom remarked, his eyes on a tall young pantheon.

The boy's head was cleanly shaved, as was the tradition among the fighting class of pantheons. His once nut-brown eyes—of which there were only two, a rarity among the pantheon—had darkened to beetle-black.

Taci, the only pantheon among them, was just into his teen years, but time spent training in the aether realm—a privilege, especially for those not of the Indrath Clan—had left him more intense and mature than his age would suggest.

It was clear watching him train that he was not in pursuit of physical or mental exercise. No, for Taci, this was about mastering the art of death. I could nearly see the image he held in his mind: an enemy breaking under each punch and kick, an army falling before him.

I understood what he felt, because I was very similar once, a long time ago.

The young warriors finished their form and stopped to give Windsom and me a deep bow. While the others began paring up to continue their training, Taci ran up to us and bowed again.

"Master Windsom. Master Aldir. Please accept my gratitude again for allowing me to train within Castle Indrath," he said in a crisp, serious tone.

“Kordri has seen great promise in you,” Windsom answered. “See that you live up to it, Taci.”

The fierce young Pantheon bowed yet again and ran back to his training partner.

“If he continues as he has been these last several years, he could be the next wielder of the World Eater technique,” Windsom commented.

“I was over two hundred years old before I was chosen,” I pointed out. “If he were chosen, it would not be for many years yet.”

Inside though, I couldn’t help but wonder: When the elders inevitably asked me to pass on the technique to another warrior, would I do it? Could I give this burden to another member of my clan, knowing they may one day be forced to use it?

Leaving Taci and the others behind, we continued on our slow circuit of the castle interior. We walked in comfortable silence for a minute before Windsom spoke again.

“Why do you think he chose to use it this time? Even with the”—Windsom glanced around the hall, making sure we were alone—“djinn, Lord Indrath never considered its use.”

“Your ears are closer to the mouth of our lord than mine,” I pointed out. “But I see no reason we would have needed it. The djinn were pacifists. They had no army and little combat magic. That was a culling, not a war.”

“It *was* a war,” he countered, watching me from the corner of his eye. “We simply struck preemptively.”

There were few, even among the asuras, who truly understood what had happened to the djinn. Most asuras never looked beyond

Epheotus, and cared nothing for the lessers. Those who did were told a very convincing lie. Those who saw through the lie and *cared* were dealt with.

"Our lord did what he thought needed to be done, both then and now," I hedged.

Windsom chuckled. "And you say you have no mind for politics. You're as careful with your words as any courtier."

"There is no need for caution when words are shared between old friends, is there?" I asked, stopping to ponder a tapestry that hung from floor to ceiling. "Take this image, for example."

The tapestry portrayed a young Kezzess Indrath at council with his best friend, Mordain, a member of the phoenix race. A golden plaque beneath it was engraved with the title: "Let Rest."

"Even after the formation of the Great Eight, the dragons and the phoenix race carried their ancient animosity openly, but Kezzess and Mordain spoke truly with one another, each opening the other's eyes to the atrocities of their endless warring."

Windsom had stopped beside me and was running his fingers along his chin thoughtfully. "And in this comparison, which am I?"

I frowned at the tapestry. "I did not mean to imply—"

"Because, of course," Windsom said casually, "Mordain was later at odds with our lord on the issue of the djinn, was he not? As prince of the Asclepius Clan, he threatened to reveal Lord Indrath's actions before disappearing from Epheotus."

Of those few who knew about the extermination of the djinn, even fewer knew that Mordain and Kezzess had fallen out. Their argument was kept secret so that no asura might ever grow

suspicious that Lord Indrath played a role in Mordain's disappearance. The rumor was later circulated that the Lost Prince, as people began to call him, left Epheotus to join Agrona.

It was a near-perfect parable, if I had wanted to communicate any such thing to Windsom. But I did not.

"It was happenstance alone that brought us to this tapestry, old friend, and my mind was not on the wider story between these two." I rested a hand on Windsom's shoulder. "I am not Mordain, and you are not Indrath."

"Of course not," Windsom said in answer, turning away to begin walking again. "You asked me about the situation in Dicathen, but my answer was flippant. The truth is that they have no great leaders or mages among them anymore. Unless I am wrong, it will come to war with the Vritra Clan and their mutts."

We turned down a short corridor and stepped out onto an open terrace overlooking the many-colored bridge. A steady breeze buffeted the castle walls. "That is my fear as well."

"It is a shame," Windsom continued. "So much work, wasted…but then, I always thought giving them those artifacts was a bad idea."

And yet. you delivered them and taught the lessers to wield their power, I thought, but kept this to myself.

"The Dicathians grew lazy," he went on, heedless. "With a white core mage soulbound to protect them, the royal families never needed to defend themselves, and their magical strength faltered. As for the mages who benefited from the artifacts…" Windsom scoffed irritably. "They never *learned* to be strong. They *became* strong. It is not the same."

A sky swimmer soared out of the clouds, its iridescent scales glittering in the sunlight. The long, fishlike body was supported by triangular wings that folded and unfolded to catch the updrafts. I watched as the mana beast glided along the top of the clouds for a moment before tucking the wings to its sides and plunging invisibly back into the depths.

Windsom's eyes stayed on me, careless of the wildlife.

"Would you visit Lord Indrath with me?" I asked, finally coming to a decision regarding the Leywin boy.

I could not be certain if it was unnerving or comforting that Windsom showed no surprise at my question, answering only, "Of course, Aldir."

We did not make for the throne room. Instead, we headed deeper into the castle. The carved, story-filled halls gave way to natural tunnels as we went down. Luminescent moss filled the crags and hung in patches from the roof, and in several places. natural springs sent rivulets of clear water trickling down the sides of the tunnels.

There were no carvings down here, no tapestries or paintings. These tunnels, the veins of the mountain, had been left untouched for a dozen generations of asura.

Earth mana was heavy in the air, and only grew heavier as we proceeded downward. It clung to us as we moved, like mud sticking to our boots. Weaker asura would find these passages uncomfortable to navigate as the mana weighed them down, and lessers would quickly crumble under the force of it.

We passed several guards in the form of conjured earth golems, but they did not bother us. Above, in a more comfortable guard

chamber, the dragons controlling them recognized us and let us pass.

The tunnel ended in a collapsed wall. Broken stone woven through with thick roots barred the way. Or appeared to, at least.

I stepped through the illusion first.

And I stepped out into a small cave. A thick carpet of moss-covered the floor, while jewels shone like stars in the ceiling, reflecting the light from the glowing pool that took up most of the cave.

Lord Indrath sat unmoving at the center of the pool, his hands resting palm up on his knees, his eyes closed. He had not changed during my entire life. His cream-colored hair clung wetly to his head, while his unintimidating form dripped with condensation from the pool.

Windsom and I stood to the side and waited.

Lord Indrath enjoyed expressing his displeasure in subtle ways. For example, he was well known for leaving his counselors out of meetings when he was displeased with them, or asking envoys from the other clans to wait for days–or even weeks–if he disagreed with the clan's lord.

After several hours, Lord Indrath finally stirred. The blue glow reflected off his purple eyes, giving them an unnatural indigo color. The simple change to his visage transformed his face, and I had to resist the urge to step back.

Standing, the Lord of Dragons stepped out of the pool and waved his hand, summoning a white robe.

"Windsom, Aldir. Thank you for waiting."

We each bowed, staying bent until Lord Indrath spoke again.

“You’ve had something on your mind, Aldir,” he said easily, shifting so that his hands were clasped behind his back. He smiled softly, but his eyes were hard and sharp as obsidian. “You’ve come to tell me what that is.”

“I have, my lord,” I answered, opening my lower two eyes to meet his, which was an expected sign of respect. “I have news that could affect our course in the war.”

I could feel Windsom’s gaze burning into the side of my head, but I kept my eyes on our lord. He was contemplative for a moment, then gave another wave of his hand.

The cave disappeared from around us. Instead, we were standing in a regally appointed solar: one of Lord Indrath’s private rooms. “Sit,” he commanded simply.

Sinking down into the thick cushion of a royal-purple armchair, I laid my arms awkwardly on the rests. Lord Indrath took the seat across from me, while Windsom was placed to the side, more a witness to than participant in the conversation.

So as not to stare, I let my gaze settle just over Lord Indrath’s shoulder, focusing on the wall of climbing gold and silver vines behind him. Purple flowers bloomed inconsistently over the vines. Very rarely, a tiny sapphire-blue fruit grew as well.

Lord Indrath nodded his head, indicating that I should begin.

“An envoy of the enemy came to me, seeking to take advantage of some perceived weakness and turn me against my lord,” I said clearly. “To this end, she brought me this piece of information, although the mere fact she thought it might sway my loyalty says more about her than it does of me, I believe.”

The two dragons waited for me to continue.

“According to the Alacryan Scythe, Seris Vritra, Arthur Leywin is still alive,” I announced formally. “He is currently in Alacrya, and he has developed some new power. I believe he witnessed my use of the World Eater technique against the elven homeland.”

There was no twitch of his eyelid or straightening of his back, no hitch in his breathing to tell me my lord was surprised. But there was a faint ripple in his aura, and that was enough: he had not known.

“Then Lady Sylvie may yet—”

Lord Indrath held up a hand to silence Windsom. “We must ascertain both the human’s strength and his attitude. He may still be a useful tool against Agrona and this… Legacy.”

“And if he is no longer willing to work alongside the asura, my lord?” I asked.

My lord’s gaze held true, his tone impassive. “Then he will die.”

348
MELEE ENHANCEMENT TACTICS

WHEN I STEPPED BACK into the second level of the Relictombs, my limbs practically dragging behind me, a bespectacled clerk rushed up as his eyes darted across my bedraggled form.

"Sir?" he asked tentatively. "Are you all right? Where is your party?"

I shook my head and took a step past him. "Fine. Solo ascent."

The man kept pace, his hands fidgeting with a scroll he was carrying carefully in front of him. "I see. Yes, solo ascending is notoriously difficult, sir. Name, so I can record your return? Any accolades to report?"

Still walking, I said, "Grey. Just Grey. And no."

The clerk winced, making his glasses slip to the end of his nose. "Sorry to hear that, Ascender Grey. Might I scan—"

I stopped suddenly, forcing the man to jerk to a halt and turn back around to face me. Leveling an irritated glare in his direction, I said, "I am exhausted and would like to be on my way. Whatever you need, just do it."

The clerk cleared his throat and fixed his glasses before pulling out some kind of wand. "If you're carrying a dimensional storage artifact, please present it," he said, somewhat stiffly.

I held out my hand, showing him the dimension ring. He waved the wand past it, then along the length of my body. He clicked his tongue. "No accolades, as you say." Next, he turned his attention to a scroll he was carrying. "Ascender Grey…Ascender…Oh, a professor!." He scribbled something, muttering under his breath. "My apologies. You're so young, I didn't realize…"

“Are we done?” I asked impatiently.
“Yes, sir, of course. Thank you for your patience.” He gave me a nod and started to turn away, then stopped.
Closing my eyes, I rubbed two fingers against my temple and down to my eye socket. “Yes?”
“Well,” he started tentatively, “I just thought you might want to know that classes at Central Academy began three days ago.” With an awkward smile, he returned to his post.
“Shit,” I grumbled, and began dragging my tired body across the second level toward the teleportation platforms.

From the hall outside my classroom, I could already hear the laughter and shouts of the unsupervised teenagers inside.
I caught snippets of conversation as I stepped through the door.
“—told me that the new professor isn’t even a named blood. Should be easy to—”
“—hear about the hot new assistant for Professor Aphelion?”
“—class is such a joke. I can’t believe Strikers have to waste our time with—”
“—kidding me? The rest of my classes are so freaking hard, I’m looking forward to doing nothing in here.”
I glanced quickly around as I descended the stairs. Two young women were sparring roughly in the dueling ring while another student goofed around with the controls. A couple others had pulled out sparring dummies and were punching them awkwardly. The rest of the students were lounging around doing nothing.

“The professor isn’t here again,” a bespectacled boy said without looking up from his book.
“He *is* the professor, Deacon,” another student said. It was the black-haired boy who had ordered the two bullies around in the library.
“You’re late,” his broad companion grumbled, crossing his thick arms over his chest.
“And you missed the first day,” their tall friend added, kicking his long legs up on the back of the chair in front of him.
“Very perceptive,” I said as I opened my office door and half stepped through it. “You all seem to have things under control for today. I’ll be in my office.” I closed the door before anyone could respond, cutting myself off from the prying eyes.
The classroom burst into chatter again the moment my door closed.
“Nice! Free day.”
“—be exactly like last season—”
“—stupid idea to train without mana anyway.”
Sighing, I tuned them out and sank into my office chair, leaning forward to rest my head against my forearms. Despite my exhaustion, though, I felt my face crack into a wide grin.
I had actually done it.
My mind buzzed as I considered the results of my experiment in the Relictombs. I wanted to talk through it, but Regis seemed to be hibernating like he had while I trained with Three Steps in the peaks above her secluded village. I hoped that meant he would restore himself more quickly.

Withdrawing the puzzle toy Three Steps had given me, I tapped it against the table, listening to the seed within rattle. I hadn't been able to replenish much aether on my journey through the second level of the Relictombs, and my core seemed to be strained to the edge of my endurance, but having something to occupy my hands would make it easier to think.

Turning my awareness inward, the first thing I noticed was my aether channels. The flood of pure aether from the obelisk had widened them and scoured the insides clean of imperfections.

There was a deep ache from my core as I manifested a claw and began to dig around inside the seedpod, but I focused on holding the shape. Although I didn't have much aether to pull from, I found that the aether itself was moving along my channels more quickly, meaning I could manifest it to a specific point of my body almost instantly.

It still took time to condense the aether into a thin claw off my index finger, though, and my tired mind struggled to focus on the shape. Instead, I focused on my core.

The core itself was larger and more transparent. The reddish tint was entirely gone, and the aether within had resolved into a deep, rich violet hue. Focusing closely, I could see the clear delineation between two separate layers of my core: the original shell supporting and holding the pieces of my mana core, and a second, thicker layer.

I had first forged my aether core by pure intent and sheer will. At my weakest and most desperate point, I had turned total loss into an

impossible victory, doing something perhaps no one in the history of this world had accomplished.

When my aether core began to crack, I realized that I had to move beyond my current limited perspective. I had followed the same path as a mana-wielding mage, expecting growth through use, meditation, and combat.

Mana cores lightened in color as they became purer. This was a purely biological mechanism, natural to its function. Although it required intentional meditation to make the most of it, even someone who never focused on refining their mana core would see it slowly progress through use, like the strengthening of a muscle.

But my aether core wasn't natural. There was no set biological progression.

Through significant effort, and the knowledge born of my time both as a white core mage and a ki user, I had been able to remove many of the impurities and imperfections within it. Although this had allowed me to more easily absorb aether, and in greater quantities, it had not brought about significant stages of progression like advancing through the orange, yellow, and silver stages.

I realized that I needed to be more intentional. If my aether core wouldn't evolve on its own, I had to find some way to force it.

Utilizing the vast reservoir of aether from the obelisk trap, I had formed a second layer around my core—very slowly, and very painfully.

Unfortunately, the process had required nearly all of the aether channeled into the obelisk, so that by the time I was done there was none left to absorb for myself, leaving my body weak and aching.

Now that I had done it, I couldn't help but wonder: Could I do it again? With enough aether, could I continue to add layers to my core, growing exponentially more powerful with each one?

It was possible. The biggest hurdle was finding a source of aether strong enough to forge the layer in a single sitting, almost the reverse of holding enough aether in my core to imbue into Sylvie's stone and break through a layer.

In my moment of necessity, when I had no choice but to do something drastic or risk crippling my aether core, it was exactly that thought that had given me inspiration. The way Sylvie's stone, or egg, utilized multiple layers to capture and hold aether had served as the foundation of my own attempt.

Thanks, Sylv, I thought. *Even asleep in your egg, you keep finding ways to keep me going.*

There was a knock at the door. I ignored it.

Another knock. "Professor Grey?"

I sighed and released the aether claw. "In."

The door opened, and a familiar face peered around the frame. Seth, the boy from the library, was pale and sweaty, and his uniform was sticking to his chest and arms. "Sir, are you going to be teaching the class today?"

My surprise at seeing the boy lasted for about a second before I waved him away. "Haven't you heard? This isn't a real class."

"But you told me to learn to defend myself," Seth said quietly. "I thought you meant—that you wanted me to…"

"You thought I was going to teach you?" I raised a brow. "You're a highblood, right? You'd be better off hiring a private tutor."

A chorus of laughter came from the classroom, and Seth, looking crestfallen, stared down at his feet as he slowly closed the office door, but I only activated the aether claw and tried again.

"Don't worry, we can help teach you a thing or two," someone jeered.

There was a thump and a pained grunt from just outside the door.

The aetheric claw on my finger faded in and out as I struggled to ignore the distraction. Without realizing it, I had pulled the seed into the round opening and held it there, balanced perfectly within the stem hole, for thirty seconds or more. I closed my eyes and refocused on the claw, pulling steadily while holding the aether's form.

"No, not like that, orphan. When you curl up, you lose sight of your opponent and"—there was another, sharper *thump*—"leave yourself open to blows to your head."

The edges of the hole buckled slightly and the claw slipped, but I was able to adjust my grip and maintain my hold on the seed. *So close*, I thought. *Just a bit more…*

A series of sharp, heavy knocks at the door broke my concentration, and I heard the seed clatter back to the bottom of the pod.

Standing, I quickly crossed the office and jerked the door open. "What?"

The uniformed man on the other side of the door wrinkled his nose and pinned me with a disapproving frown. "Professor Grey, yes?"

"That's me. Can I help you?" I asked with a slight tilt of my head.

"We haven't had an opportunity to meet yet. My name is Rafferty."

The man was middle-aged, with gray hair at his temples and wrinkles

starting to appear around his eyes. He was wearing a black and azure suit and a look that told me he wasn't exactly glad to meet me. "I, in case you did not know, am the head of your department."

He held out a scroll. "This is an updated class list, which you need because several students have already dropped this course."

I took the scroll and tossed it on my desk. "I see. Well, is there anything else I can do for you?"

The department head glowered. "Yes, as a matter of fact, you can. Looking at your qualifications and recommendations, I am not entirely certain how you came to be employed here at Central Academy, young man, but I will not accept anything less than maximum effort from the professors in this department. Please ensure that you attend classes on time in the future, and that you adhere to the academy-provided training regimen."

His tone should have bothered me, considering my situation, but I was too caught between exhaustion and excitement to worry about this thin Alacryan's threats.

Forcing a contrite frown, I bowed shallowly. "I apologize, there was a mix-up in the Relictombs. I don't plan on missing class again."

His frown smoothed somewhat. "See that you don't. We don't need any more trouble like that in the High Hall, Professor Grey."

Spinning on his heel, Rafferty swept out the open door. On the other side, my dozen students were all motionless, obviously having heard every word of my chastisement.

Wordlessly, I shut the door and returned to my mess of a desk. I hadn't bothered to look over the class roster I'd received in my

original paperwork, so I pulled the new scroll open and scanned the—much shorter—list.

I didn't recognize most of the names: *Brion of Named Blood Bloodworth, Deacon of Blood Favager, Enola of Highblood Frost… blah blah blah… Mayla of Blood Fairweather, Pascal of Blood Bancroft, Portrel of Highblood Gladwyn, Remy of Highblood Seabrook… blah blah… Seth of Highblood Milview…*

Milview, I thought, the name sounding familiar for some reason. I'd heard it before, but where? *Some soldier in the war? Not the man I'd tortured… Vale… so where—*

My eyes widened in realization.

There weren't many Alacryan soldiers important enough to have their names recorded in our reports, but that was exactly where I'd read the name before. The sentry who charted a path through Elshire Forest—the person responsible for the fall of Elenoir—had been named Milview.

A scoff escaped my lips as I set down the scroll. Was this coincidence or some sick twist of fate?

Standing up, I crossed my office, opened the door, and leaned against the frame to watch.

Seth was cowering between the same two students who'd cornered him in the library, trying awkwardly to protect his stomach and head. The wide, squat bully had his fists up lazily. He met his companion's eye, winked, then threw a knee up into Seth's unprotected face.

As Seth hit the ground, the rest of the class seemed to focus on me. The short-haired girl sparring on the training platform grimaced, obviously uncomfortable, and another young man was leaning

forward in his chair, frowning at the spectacle. Others were chuckling softly or simply waiting curiously to see what I'd do.

I strode forward toward the Milview boy, shouldering the other young men out of my way. I met the heavily-set student's eyes, looking down my nose at him. "Name?"

"Portrel," he said, his chin up and chest puffed. "Of Highblood Gladwyn."

"If you plan on fighting, do it in there," I said, nodding toward the training ring.

Portrel's squashed face twisted in confusion as I jerked Seth up from the ground by the back of his uniform and pushed him toward the ring. "Did I stutter?"

Letting out a chortle, Portrel strode purposefully to the dueling ring while Seth followed hesitantly, dabbing at a bloody nose with his sleeve.

The girl with the short golden hair, one of the two already training in the ring, scowled at them, actually baring her teeth. "We're using this."

"Not anymore," I said evenly. "Move."

She scoffed but leapt off the training platform. Her companion, a thin girl with brown eyes and dark hair that ran in twin braids down her back, winced as she stepped off the platform, her hand pressing against her ribs.

The two boys climbed up onto the platform and positioned themselves a few feet apart before stepping onto the platform myself.

I sensed the fear that struck Seth as he realized I had no intention of helping. However, he still got in a defensive stance as he faced the Gladwyn boy.

Crossing my arms, I stood between the two combatants, arms crossed, ignoring the rest of the class. "Continue."

They were as mismatched a pair as I could imagine. Portrel was twice Seth's weight, even if he wasn't any taller, and was probably a Striker. From how he settled comfortably into a fighting stance, both hands up and his right foot back slightly, I was sure he had trained in hand-to-hand combat.

Seth, on the other hand, was of average height but looked shorter because of the way he slouched. He was skinny to the point of looking sickly, an impression heightened by his pale skin, and had clearly never been taught to throw a punch.

Maybe if he didn't spend all of his time in the library, I thought, ignoring the memory of him helping me that was scratching at the back of my brain.

"Well? What are you waiting for?" I asked the bulky Striker. "Aren't you going to hit him?"

An even deeper confusion riddled their faces as they looked at me. Portrel recovered first, smirking as he lifted his fists. "Whatever you say, *Professor."*

His first punch was lazy, striking Seth on the inside of his shoulder, but the following uppercut landed squarely on Seth's chin, rocking the unprepared boy's head back and sending him sprawling to the ground.

“I know we’re not using mana, but I expect you to at least try to throw a decent strike,” I said, my voice level, almost bored. “You punch as if Milview here is going to lean into your fist.”

His cheeks reddened. “I’m one of the best fist fighters my age in Vechor!” he argued. “I have trained with—”

“Someone who was afraid to tell you how shit you really are,” I finished for him. “That’s the weakness born of too much power. Now, go again.”

There were some surprised snickers from the audience, including his colorful-haired buddy, which made Portrel blush even deeper. He scowled and squared up across from Seth, who was watching me instead of his opponent. Portrel didn’t hold back, unleashing a series of powerful punches that Seth couldn’t hope to defend against.

The skinny boy was on his back within seconds. Portrel kicked his defenseless opponent sharply in the ribs once, then pulled back for a second, but seemed to remember himself. He gave me a defiant glare, as if daring me to criticize him.

“Your feet were crossed, and at one point you had both fists extended,” I said flatly.

Seth’s lip had broken open, and he was slow to regain his feet. The next time Portrel struck him, he collapsed immediately.

“You pulled your punch and let your wrist go limp,” I pointed out.

The stocky highblood ground his teeth and glanced out of the ring at the darkhaired boy who seemed to be his ringleader. From the corner of my eye, I saw him shake his head.

Realizing I should have read through the entire list of students’ names, I thought about the different bloods Abby had mentioned

during our conversation, and which students she told me to be wary of. Although she had spoken about him very diplomatically, she had mentioned that the grandson of Director Ramseyer attended the academy. Looking at the dark-haired boy, I could see the resemblance.

It made sense, then, why he was ringleader even among the highbloods.

Turning back to the class, I pointed to the short-haired girl. "You. Are there training swords somewhere?"

She nodded slowly and pointed to an open door in the corner of the room.

"Well?" I asked, giving her an expectant look. "Can you go *get them*?"

Her expression fell into a disbelieving grimace, but she didn't move. Her training partner gave me an uncomfortable look and said, "I-I'll get it…" before hurrying across the classroom to retrieve the practice swords. When she returned with them, she gave me a squinty, apologetic smile.

The sparring swords were simple lengths of light, springy wood. I handed them to the combatants. Seth, who had finally dragged himself back to his feet, looked at the weapon as if it were a snake that was about to bite him, while Portrel twirled his with practiced comfort.

"Fighting stance," I ordered.

Portrel adopted a middle stance, his left foot back with the sword held in front of him in both hands, pointed at Seth's face.

I glanced at the Milview boy, who copied him awkwardly, looking like he'd never held a sword in his life, and felt a pang of annoyance. It grew from the fact that I felt more pity toward Seth than anger. He was the brother of the soldier responsible for not only the conquest of Elenoir but its destruction as well.

If the Alacryans hadn't taken over the country, the asuras would've never…

A shift in the room snapped me out of my thoughts. The students around us, most of whom were only half paying attention a second ago, were now gazing at the ring with tense excitement. Seth's eyes widened as he focused on the dull blade of his opponent's practice sword.

Seeing that Portrel had adjusted his posture suddenly and seemed much more focused, I knew, even without being able to sense magic, what he was up to.

"No mana," I said firmly.

He scoffed. "Such a stupid rule. What is the point of—"

"Are you afraid to spar without it?" I asked with a tilt of my head.

Portrel swelled. "I'm not afraid of anything! My blood has—"

"Begin," I barked, catching both boys off guard. Seth jerked his sparring blade down, catching Portrel on the bridge of the nose with a *crack*. Blood splattered the front of his uniform.

Snarling, Portrel lunged forward, swinging the sword like a club. Seth's eyes snapped shut, and he stumbled under the wild swing purely by accident. He let his sword sag so that it ended up between Portrel's off-balance legs, and the enraged highblood tripped and crashed to the ground at Seth's feet.

The tall boy with multi-colored hair let out a hoot of laughter. “Nice one, Port!”

I blinked dumbly. “Well that was fun. Did the two of you practice that little comedy skit or was it improvised?”

Seth looked away, embarrassed, as he scratched the back of his head. Portrel, on the other hand, was practically vibrating in anger.

“How dare you, you unnamed trash!” The bulky Striker got back on his feet and pointed his sparring sword at me. “I don’t know what you did, but my father will—”

“Portrel, you forget yourself,” a firm, authoritative voice said. I was surprised to see the Ramseyer boy on his feet. “Your actions bring disrespect to your blood.”

Portrel flinched, looking from his ringleader to me and back. “Sorry, Valen.”

The director’s grandson, Valen, flashed a diplomatic smile. “I apologize on the behalf of both Highblood Ramseyer and Highblood Gladwyn, Professor. Portrel is an excellent fighter, but he has a temper.” There was a glimmer in Valen’s eyes and a wry twist to his smile that was unsettling, but I couldn’t tell what he was up to.

“It’s a shame you chose to match him up against such an underwhelming opponent. Perhaps your lessons will be better imparted through a personal demonstration.” That glimmer brightened. “I’m sure Portrel would be honored to spar with you, Professor.”

“So very honored,” he echoed, trying and failing to keep a vindictive smirk off his face.

“Very well,” I said as I slowly twisted the spiral ring off of the middle finger of my right hand.

The ground beneath Portrel’s feet trembled as the Striker darted forward with a speed that wasn’t possible without magic.

I made the slightest step to the side to avoid the wooden sword aimed at my shoulder. And with a gentle snap of my wrist, I slapped the kid across the face with the back of my hand.

Portrel’s head jerked from the impact before he lost his footing and rolled right out of the unshielded dueling ring.

Silence clung to the room as the students watched Portrel dig himself out of the seats he had crashed into.

“You wouldn’t have rolled so hard if you hadn’t used mana,” I said matter-of-factly, securing the ebony ring back on my finger.

“Class is over,” I announced, focusing on Valen. “Get out of here.”

Laughter and excited chatter broke out from the rest of the class as they began collecting their bags and ascending the stairs out of the classroom.

“Help Portrel up, Remy,” Valen said dryly. While the tall boy helped his struggling companion disentangle himself from the seats, Valen’s gaze lingered on me, that wry smile never slipping from his face.

Portrel, on the other hand, glowered at his feet, careful to avoid looking in my direction, but his fists were clenched white as his friend teased him all the way up the stairs.

From behind me, barely a whisper, I heard, “Professor?”

Seth had stood frozen in the corner of the platform during my exchange with Portrel, and he was now staring at me with a hopeful expression that made my stomach squirm with discomfort. His lip

was badly swollen, and I could see the beginning of a dark bruise appearing around his left eye.

"Don't expect class to get any easier than this, Milview," I said dispassionately, the intent of my words more threat than warning. Being in Alacrya, pretending to be a teacher…that was one thing. But teaching the family member of the woman who let the Alacryan army overtake Elenoir?

I wasn't sure I could do that.

"Thank you for the advice, sir," he answered resolutely, even as his gaze was lowered. "I…I'll keep that in mind for your next class."

As Seth slumped past me, my attention was drawn to the exit, where students were starting to bottleneck. "I said class is over! What's the hold up?"

Reluctantly, the gawking boys stepped aside, revealing a blue-haired, scarlet-eyed woman.

"Long time no see, Grey."

349
HOPE AND LIES

ELEANOR LEYWIN

My mana arrow struck the clod of dirt dead center, causing it to burst apart in a dusty cloud. The arrow continued along its path to the golem that had just thrown it, clipping it in the right temple. Although part of the golem's head collapsed, it apparently wasn't enough to count as a kill, because the animated pile of dirt and rocks shuffled to the side, preparing another attack.

At the same time, a second golem appeared, growing up out of the ground like it was melting in reverse. It had a huge stone axe trained at my head. I let out a snort.

"Dirt clods and blunt axes? I've trained with a *Lance*, Hornfels," I said flippantly as I sidestepped a clumsy swing by the axe-wielding golem. The axe came up in a side-hand cut aimed at my hip, but I rolled backwards over my shoulder. Reinforcing my bow with mana, I swept the golem's leg out from under it, then had two arrows glowing against the string of my elven bow before I was on my feet again. Splitting the mana arrows with my finger, I sent them on slightly different trajectories so that one pierced the axe-wielding golem's chest, while the second took the clod-thrower in the throat.

"Nice shot, Ellie!" my new friend Camellia whooped.

I flashed the young elf a toothy grin, then yelped in surprise as the ground beneath me turned to muck. As I sank up to my knees, three more golems grew out of the ground and glowered down at me.

I threw myself flat in the muck to avoid a crushing blow from a stone fist. The ground hardened again, trapping me half in the rocky cavern floor. I spit out a mouthful of mud.

"Yuck," I moaned, trying to adjust my position but completely stuck.

"Don't forget, I've also trained with a Lance, you overconfident little twig," Hornfels said jovially.

Soft footsteps darted toward me. "Are you okay?" Camellia asked.

Hornfels let out a low chuckle, and the stone turned to sand, releasing me. "She'll be just fine. Don't fawn over her, girl. The lass has a big enough head as it is."

I drew myself out of the sand pit and brushed myself off. "I do not have a big head!"

Someone huffed sarcastically, and I turned to see two familiar figures walking toward us.

"Jasmine! Emily!" I shouted with excitement. "Come to see how awesome I've gotten?"

"No, not big-headed at all…" Camellia teased. I shoved playfully at her shoulder, and she poked me in the ribs, then jumped away before I could get her back.

"I just needed to make sure this one wasn't getting into trouble," Jasmine said, nodding to Camellia.

The serious adventurer hadn't changed much since I was a little kid. I liked all of the Twin Horns, but was secretly a little scared of Jasmine. When Helen, Durden, and Angela Rose had originally been brought to the sanctuary, Jasmine hadn't come with them. Camellia had told me all about how Jasmine saved her, though, so I was glad she'd come back.

“Actually, we were looking for Hornfels,” Emily piped in. “Helen suggested we get some training time in too.”

Unlike Jasmine, Emily had changed a lot in a pretty short amount of time. There was a hardened edge to her that she definitely hadn’t had before, and sometimes I’d notice her go sort of blank and cold. She’d chopped off her hair after it’d been burned in an explosion, but at least her eyebrows were growing back.

I’d been so happy when she arrived with the Twin Horns and Gideon. We weren’t best friends or anything, but Emily had always been nice to me, and she had even made a custom bow back then that took advantage of my pure mana techniques.

She was a total genius, though, so it wasn’t exactly surprising that she’d found a way to survive. She and Gideon had been captured by the Alacryans and forced to work for them, but the Twin Horns had helped to save them. Or they’d helped to save Jasmine? I was still a little fuzzy on the details.

She had been almost as bummed as I was to hear that my bow had been destroyed. Unfortunately, we didn’t have any of the tools or resources she needed to make another one in the sanctuary so I was stuck using a practice bow.

It was still really good to have them both back. And seeing more familiar faces had been good for Mom, too. She’d started to come back to life a little as she realized that a lot of our friends were still alive out there, just waiting for help.

“I’m about done with Princess Leywin anyway,” Hornfels jeered, making Camellia giggle.

“Hey!” I said indignantly.

“Another princess? Just what we need…” Jasmine said, and she seemed so serious that I couldn’t tell if she was joking or not.
“Don’t mind her,” Camellia said, wrinkling her nose. “She’s just not very good at expressing herself.”
Jasmine raised a brow at the elven girl. “Careful, *Skunk*.”
Camellia crossed her arms and stuck her tongue out at Jasmine.
“All right then,” Hornfels said, laughing loudly. “The Watsken girl I’m familiar with, but you’ll have to walk me through your abilities, Miss Flamesworth…”
My attention drifted away from the others as Jasmine and Hornfels began to discuss sparring.
We had chosen a flat ridge overlooking most of the cavern to be our training ground. It was far enough away that we weren’t likely to accidentally break something in the process. I also liked it because it looked down on the village, and I could see almost every house from up here, and most of the tunnels out of town.
Curtis and Kathyln Glayder were marching quickly toward the tunnel leading to the teleportation gate. After what happened in Elenoir, most of us never left the sanctuary anymore, but the Glayders, along with a few other strong mages, were still going on missions to look for more refugees.
The members of our expedition to Elenoir had stayed pretty close after we all got back from Elenoir. Kathyln described it as a “shared guilt.” Each of us thought we could have—should have—done more to make sure Tessia was safe.
The only one who didn’t seem interested in checking in with us at all was the elven guard, Albold. Apparently he’d wanted to return to

the forest almost immediately when Tessia and I didn't come back, but Virion wouldn't let him. Then, when Bairon confirmed that Elenoir was entirely gone, well…

I shook my head. I'd tried to consider how it would feel to know Sapin was just… gone, but…

"Ellie, you okay?" Camellia asked, nudging me with her elbow.

"Of course," I said as I slung my bow over my shoulder. "But I'm pretty tired. I'm going to call it a day, okay?"

Waving to the others, I turned and began the long descent into town, unsure what to do with myself. I *was* tired, but I was also…

I didn't even really know. I never knew how to feel anymore, and so I'd started just pushing it all into the background.

Was that how you dealt with it, Brother? I wondered.

Sighing, I kicked a stone down the size of the natural ramp I was walking down. It clattered away over the edge, eventually landing with a splash in the stream.

It didn't help that I was surrounded by people who had lost everything. I'd lost my dad and my brother—*and my childhood*—to the war, but then I thought of Camellia… her entire family had been killed during the invasion, her home was gone, most of the people she'd ever met were dead…

I wanted to understand it. I wanted to help Camellia and Virion and all the others, but I just couldn't wrap my head around what they'd experienced.

Albold was the only other elven member of our group. Maybe it was selfish of me, but it felt like he was my connection to what

happened. I wanted him to help me understand what he was feeling, but he'd pretty much gone into hiding.

There were other elves I could talk to, of course. Commander Virion was in meetings all the time, though, and, as much as I had wanted to speak to him, I hadn't been allowed in weeks.

Rinia said she was too weak for visitors, but she hadn't moved back into the sanctuary. I couldn't help feeling that something was going on between Virion and her. I just couldn't guess what. And since neither one was speaking with me, well…

Having Camellia was great, at least. There were a few other kids in the sanctuary, but no one who understood what I'd been through the way she did. Maybe it was because we were so much alike that we both struggled to really understand what had happened. Before Jasmine saved her, she had already lost her whole family, and seemed kind of numb when it came to the attack on her homeland.

There were others, too, but no one I felt like I could talk to. If Tessia were still here, she could—

Could she? I flashed back to that moment in the little elven town, with Tessia, looking beautiful, standing above her shocked and confused people…

Shaking my head, I turned away from that thought. Instead, my mind went back to Albold. I'd gone looking for him a few times over the last few weeks, but hadn't found him. Still, trying again wouldn't hurt, I told myself, and maybe he needed to talk to me as much as I needed to talk to him.

Although I was sure he wouldn't be there, I headed for the town hall first. Albold hadn't been at any of his regular guard shifts since I'd

given my report to the council, but I really wasn't sure where else to look.

As I'd expected, two unfamiliar guards flanked the door, while the elven woman named Lenna stood at the foot of the stairs. She was watching me approach.

I hadn't made it within thirty feet of her before she said, "Sorry, Miss Leywin, the Commander is not available."

"Actually," I started nervously, "I was looking for the guard, Albold. Do you—"

"Albold is still on his leave of absence, due to his injury," she interrupted me, speaking firmly.

I happened to know that my mother had personally tended to the elf's wounds moments after he teleported back to the sanctuary. Although there would have been some lingering discomfort for a bit, he had gone back to his duties almost immediately. Still, there was no point arguing with the head guard. I also knew what she'd say when I asked where he was now, but I tried anyway.

"As I said before, Albold has been given a private cave outside of the town, and has asked not to be disturbed. I'm sure he'll let you know when he is feeling better." The way she said this made it very clear just how likely she thought it was that Albold would seek me out for anything.

I wanted to be mad about her attitude, but then I just thought of Elenoir again, and my stomach folded into a knot. "Sorry to bother you. Thank you for your time and"—I scrambled for something to say, feeling myself grow more awkward with each word—"your service," I finished with a wince.

Turning at the edge of the town hall, I intended to weave into one of the alleys and just walk for a while, but a noise from inside the large building brought me up short.

As I listened closer, I realized there was a sound dampening spell in place, but someone had shouted loud enough for my sensitive ears to pick it out.

Looking around to make sure no one was watching, I moved closer to the side of the town hall where the large conference room was, but there was something there, like an electrical charge in the atmosphere, or a crushing pressure, enough to make my ears pop. Even though I wasn't sure what was causing it, I trusted my instincts enough not to get any closer.

There was a small communal garden right next to the town hall. It only grew roots and mushrooms and stuff, so I didn't usually spend much time there, but it was the perfect cover now.

Taking a seat in the middle of the garden, I pretended to be examining the plants. Instead, I activated the first phase of my beast will. Noises from all over the cavern grew loud in my ears as my senses sharpened dramatically so that I had to take a few seconds to carefully tune it all out. I focused on the town hall, listening for Virion's growling voice.

"—artifacts we were promised. This lie you've made me tell is only worth it if we—"

Another voice interrupted the commander. "The lie you've agreed to tell is best for all, Virion, as we've discussed at length. I understand you are eager to retake your continent, but the artifacts are not yet ready. Nor, for that matter, are the asuras."

Although I hadn't heard this second voice in many years, I knew immediately who it was. There was no way I could forget the man—or deity—who gave me Boo.

But what were they talking about? Lies? Artifacts? I didn't understand.

Virion's voice was a snarl when he replied, "Damned your games, Windsom. Don't think I've forgiven your crime against my people. I spread your lie only because I have no other choice. Knowing what the asuras did would shatter what little hope remains in Dicathen."

"You are correct," Windsom said, his voice cold and emotionless. "You have no choice, Commander Virion. If you wish to lead your people—elves, humans, and dwarves alike—through this war, then convincing everyone that the destruction of Elenoir was an act of the Vritra Clan is essential.

"The story has played well in Epheotus," Windsom continued. "Even the remaining basilisk clans have started coming around. Soon, Lord Indrath will have enough support to proceed with a full-scale war."

"But Dicathen will be protected?" Virion asked—somewhat nervously, I thought.

"You have my word," Windsom answered firmly. "Lord Indrath is fervent in his desire that Dicathen will be unharmed by this war. As for the Alacryan populace, well, it is unfortunate…"

"And my granddaughter?" Virion shot back. "Will she be more collateral damage for your war? You told me you'd find her, asura."

"I'm afraid I have nothing new to report on this matter," Windsom confirmed. "We know only that Tessia's vessel—her body—is currently in Alacrya, but the clans of Epheotus have no knowledge of

this reincarnation technique Agrona has used. In the event that it is not reversible, you must be prepared to—"

Reincarnation? My heart was beating so loud in my chest that it drowned out Windsom's words. *Like Brother?*

A faint *pop* made me jump, and suddenly all I could see was the big, hairy body of my bond. His head was swiveling around, looking for danger, and as he turned around his large rump knocked me over. My concentration on keeping my beast will active broke and the enhanced senses faded.

"Boo!" I grumbled as I tried to sit up, but couldn't because of the wall of fur hovering over me.

He let out a grumble that shook the ground.

"No, I'm not in danger! I was just—"

Another rumble, this time accompanied by a whine.

"Well I'm sorry I interrupted your hunt, but I didn't ask you to—"

The enormous, bearlike mana beast sat back with a *humph*, crushing a patch of glowing mushrooms.

"Hello, Eleanor," a voice said from nearby, causing me to let out a yelp. Boo was on his feet again in an instant, his bulk obscuring the speaker.

Grabbing a handful of my bond's fur, I pulled myself up and stepped around him. Windsom was standing just outside the garden, his hands held behind his back.

"Um, hello… sir?" I said nervously. Had he somehow realized I was eavesdropping on his conversation? What would he do to me if he knew that I'd overheard…?

To my surprise, the asura took a seat on a large rock just outside the garden and raised his hand toward Boo. My bond approached him warily, sniffing at the outstretched hand. Then my bond's demeanor seemed to change, and he gave the asura a lick.

I gawked as Windsom let out a small laugh. "Apparently he remembers me." He started scratching Boo's forehead between the white markings above his eyes, and my bond's rear paw began to thud against the ground in pleasure.

We sat in silence for a few seconds. My mind was blank with fear.

"You know, I had intended to return to you eventually," Windsom said, his gaze on Boo's wide head. "You need to know more about your bond, if you're to begin the assimilation phase of…"

His head turned to face me, and I could practically feel his eyes burrowing down into me, looking at my core. "Fascinating," he murmured. "You have completed the assimilation phase, and can utilize his beast will. And you accomplished this without aid?"

My tongue seemed to swell up to the size of Boo's in my mouth, and I couldn't respond. Was this some elaborate trick so I would reveal that I'd been spying on them?

"I'm making you nervous," Windsom observed. "I speak to so few of your kind. My apologies."

Boo turned back to me and nudged my arm with his broad head. When he touched me, warmth poured out of my core, pushing away the fear. I let out a shaky breath.

Windsom smiled, and I could see his eyes tracking the movement of the warm glow as it moved throughout my body. "You have indeed come a long way with your bond. Again, I apologize for not having

this conversation sooner. I had not guessed you would complete your assimilation without my assistance."

I looked at the backs of my hands and my arms, where the fine hairs were standing on end. "What…what kind of mana beast is Boo, anyway?"

"We call them only guardian beasts," Windsom answered, shifting on his seat so he was facing me directly. "They are bred—or perhaps created is a better term—by the Grandus Clan of the titan race. A guardian beast's entire purpose becomes the protection of its bond."

"What else can he do?" I asked breathlessly, my eyes locked on Boo's, my fear forgotten. I had known he wasn't a normal mana beast, but I'd never guessed he was some kind of super-Epheotus mana beast.

"Their powers manifest differently based on their form," Windsom went on, "but all guardian beasts are meant for protection, and so they can sense when their bond is in danger and teleport to them at great distance, if necessary. Eventually, this guardian bear will be able to protect you in other ways, too, such as absorbing physical damage to your body and taking the wounds himself."

"Oh," I said softly, running a hand along Boo's neck. "I'm not sure I like that very much."

Windsom gave me a curious look. "Such is the purpose of a guardian beast. A guardian bear can also inspire great courage in its bond, allowing you to push past your fear when necessary, as I believe you just experienced."

“When I channel Boo’s beast will, I can… um… ” I trailed off, realizing I didn’t really want to talk about my enhanced senses.

“It gives you insight into the beast’s own senses, yes,” Windsom said, picking up my train of thought. “It can be quite powerful. The second phase should then manifest some of your bond’s strength and fighting prowess, but it differs from asura to asura, and I honestly can’t tell you how a human will adapt to the second phase. It is possible—quite likely even—that you will never pass the integrate phase.”

I slowly nodded. Virion had said something similar when I asked him about my beast will. It was apparently pretty common for beast tamers to stop at the assimilate phase, and some couldn’t even assimilate properly.

“Why did you give me Boo?” I asked, unable to suppress the thought. Now that I knew the truth about what Boo was, it seemed pretty unlikely that a deity would decide to just hand me one of their special guardian beasts.

Windsom sat in silence for a while, pondering. A frown slowly creased his brow, and I felt his strangling aura leak out for an instant. Then he was on his feet. “I’m afraid I must return to Epheotus.”

He looked down at me, and rather than being drawn to his strange, cosmic eyes, I felt my body trying to pull itself away from him. It only took a second more to figure out why.

The night sky over Elenoir, that’s what his eyes looked like… *Before he and Aldir destroyed the entire country*, I reminded myself with a tremor of fear.

“Know that your brother is not forgotten among the asura, Eleanor. You were important to him, and so you are important to us. That is why I gave you a guardian beast.”

Before I could respond, the asura had vanished.

I sat in the garden for a long time after that, thinking. I still couldn’t be sure if Windsom had somehow realized I overheard him and Virion or not. *Was that why he decided to tell me about Boo now?* I wondered. *To distract me? Or maybe show me that he wasn’t a threat, that he still cared about us?*

I wanted to be mad, but if Commander Virion was willing to go along with this lie to save Dicathen, then what right did I have to question him?

Then I thought of Albold, who wanted to know the truth more than anything. *Doesn’t he, and the rest of the survivors, deserve to know the truth?* I asked myself.

Wrapping my forearms around my knees, I pulled myself into a ball and wished, not for the last time, that Arthur or Tessia were there with me.

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COLLEAGUES

CAERA DENOIR

I kept my face impassive, my tone leveled, and my posture straight as I strode into his class. After all, I was to be seen by others as merely a colleague, nothing more.

So why in the Vritra's grace did I blurt out his name, announcing the fact that we know each other already?

Around me, the students broke out into shocked whispers as they tried to determine the relationship between us. My mind was already whirling with what my next words should be to hopefully quench any potential rumors that might spread from this room. Grey wasn't a fan of attention, and I preferred not to start off on the wrong foot once again.

I attempted to make my way through the wave of pampered teens when a fierce young woman with short-cropped golden hair stepped into my path.

She gave me a practiced curtsy before speaking just loudly enough for her classmates to hear. "Lady Caera of Highblood Denoir, my mother and father asked that I pass along their well wishes to you and your blood should we meet in school."

"You must be the youngest of Highblood Frost," I affirmed.

"Enola," the blond said proudly. "I've been a fan of yours since your earlier ascensions were made public. I strive to one day become an ascender as distinguished as yourself, Lady Caera."

I gave her a nod. "Then you would do well taking notes in this class."

The Frost girl, along with the students around her, frowned in confusion and offense as I walked past. The girl to Enola's right, who stuck to her in a servile way that marked her as being of the Redcliff blood, gave me a quick bow before escorting her master out of the room.

The whispers grew louder as the students now tried to deduce what my last words meant, but my attention was on the golden-eyed professor standing with his arms crossed in the training ring.

Grey was silent, his face unreadable even as we locked eyes.

I feared that he already knew what had brought me to this school. But worse than that, I feared he didn't know but naturally assumed.

"I apologize for my classmates' rudeness," a voice rang, pulling me from my thoughts.

The speaker, a lean young man with ebony skin and piercing eyes, shouldered past a couple of the others and held out his hand. "I am Valen of Highblood Ramseyer. We've never had the pleasure, but—"

"I have business with your professor," I interrupted, ignoring his outstretched hand while sweeping a cold gaze through the crowd of students. "And as he mentioned… *class is over*."

The Ramseyer heir's jaw clenched as he recoiled his hand before strutting out. The whispers and murmurs only grew as the rest of the class followed suit. Only the last student to leave was wordless, his thin frame hunched forward as he struggled to climb the stairs, his gaze glued to his shoes.

I straightened my blouse as I began descending toward him. Now that it was only the two of us, my mind began racing, trying to come up with the next words to break this tension.

Letting out a sigh, I stopped halfway down the stairs and settled for the words, “It’s nice to see you again.”

Again, I was met with silence, the only change in his expression being a raised brow of suspicion.

I held up my hands in a placating gesture while also showing him my ring. “I merely came to say ‘hi’ and to catch up with a friend.”

“And here I was worried you were stalking me,” he answered, unwavering in his impassivity.

I nodded seriously. “Oh yes. Because I’ve yearned for your grumpy, vaguely threatening presence.”

The smallest twitch disturbed the corner of his lips. “I’m not grumpy.”

I let out a scoff as I sat down in the nearest seat. “Right…”

Turning his back on me, Grey began to fiddle with the controls of the training platform. Kayden’s classroom had something similar, so I should have guessed what was about to happen, but—

A sharp jolt of pain shot up through my rear end and into my back, causing me to yelp and jump out of the seat.

Grey stifled a laugh, finally dropping his cool demeanor as I glared down at him. “Too bad Regis is sleeping,” he said. “He’d have loved that.”

I rubbed at the spot where the pain-inducing rune had shocked me. “So childish…”

He had the good grace to look sheepish, rubbing the back of his neck—but still smiling like an idiot. “I was just wrapping up here. Want to go for a walk? We should talk about what happened.”

“No,” I snapped.

Then, I let out a sigh. “Yes, I suppose.”
After he locked up his office and haphazardly put away a few training implements, we left the building, walking slowly in the general direction of Windcrest Hall, where we were both staying.
“So…” I started after a minute of awkward silence. “Professor Grey, hm?”
“Yeah. It seemed…”
“Prudent?” I finished for him.
He gave me a stiff nod.
“It was a smart move,” I affirmed with a slight smile. “What you did to those mercenaries in the Relictombs…well, it’s an open secret that was you, but after your trial, the High Hall had no interest in pursuing you, and the Granbehls left their Relictombs estate and returned to Vechor, where they’ve been pretty quiet.”
Grey’s pace stuttered and his brows furrowed. “You’re awfully well informed.”
“Yes, well, I have my resources,” I said, watching a group of students jog past.
The constant activity and bustle of the campus had always been both exciting and, in a way, exhausting for me. I’d had private tutors growing up, and when Sevren, Lauden, and I were socialized, it was for the sake of formal dinner parties at our—or some other highblood’s—estate. It was only much later, when I was a teenager, that I was allowed to attend the academy, and even then only for two seasons. Although many of the students here were from highbloods, my Vritra blood had assured me I would always be treated as a crystalline statue rather than an actual person.

Even in the Relictombs, I had always been protected by the Haedrig disguise and the presence of my guards, Taegen and Arian. The academy was different, especially because my adoptive blood along with my own accomplishments brought a fair amount of undesired attention.

"Lady Caera," a crisp voice announced from behind us. Grey and I both stopped and turned, and I saw Grey's face flatten into an impassive mask from the corner of my eye.

The speaker was a mage with overly-styled hair and a showy robe. I didn't recognize him.

"Lady Caera," he repeated with a bow. His eyes stayed on mine, never so much as acknowledging Grey's presence. "An honor to finally meet you. I am Janusz of Blood Graeme, professor of—"

"Excuse me," I said in a polite tone that still managed to convey my dismissal. "I'm afraid you've interrupted my conversation with Professor Grey. Perhaps we can speak later, at a more appropriate time."

With a curt nod, I turned away from the man, who looked as if I had slapped him.

I turned toward Grey, curious to see his reaction, but the heartless ascender had already left me.

Jerk, I thought with a frown before catching up to him.

I found myself sneaking glances at Grey, taking in his sharp profile as we walked together in silence. "I apologize if any rumors spread because you were seen with me."

“I didn’t realize being in your mere presence would evoke so much attention,” Grey said, his tone carrying just a hint of teasing humor. “Forgive me for being unaware of how much of an honor it is.”

“You are forgiven,” I replied sagely before letting out a soft chuckle.

“Maybe having some drama between us will keep these highbloods distracted from me.” The corner of Grey’s lips curved up ever-so-slightly as he gazed idly ahead.

I scoffed. “You act as if the only thing we value is interesting gossip.”

“Isn’t it?” Grey returned.

I shook my head. “I’ll have to introduce you to Professor Aphelion. You two should be fast friends given your mutual loathing of the noble class.”

“We’ve already met,” Grey stated, before he turned his gaze to me. “But I’d like to know more about him.”

“Kayden of Highblood Aphelion was a distinguished mage,” I answered as we passed between the Chapel and the Relictomb portal. The portal frame was humming with energy, indicating someone had just used it. “A regalia on his third rune, foremost son of his house, and in line to be the next highlord before he was wounded in the war.”

“He was in the war?”

Grey had fallen back to concealing his emotions behind an expressionless face. He might as well have been wearing a mask.

“He was,” I said, uncertain why this would surprise him, or even if he *was* surprised. “The rumor is…” I caught myself and let the words trail off. “Actually, it’s not really my place to say. But it is common knowledge that he was captured and tortured by the Dicathians.”

Grey frowned and seemed to focus far into the distance. I couldn't help but wonder what memory had surfaced. Had he lost people in the war?

"Have I misspoken?" I asked.

"No. I'm just… thinking about the war," he said.

I stopped short, biting my lip as I thought about what Grey had said. Suddenly, everything made sense. His insistence on doing things alone and avoiding others, the way he seemed to step back from himself whenever Dicathen or the war was mentioned, how he never spoke about his life prior to the Relictombs…

"You were in the war, weren't you?"

Grey froze before turning in my direction, his usually-apathetic eyes now frigid and sharp. "What makes you think that?"

I hesitated. It seemed plain as day, now that I'd made the connection, but it was also my mentor's interest in him. But I wasn't sure if I could—or should—confirm that Scythe Seris was my mentor just yet.

"Never mind," he said with a single sharp shake of his head. "It doesn't matter. Yes, I was, but I'd prefer not to talk about it."

"I'm sorry. Of course," I said.

Grey wouldn't be the only soldier that had been scarred from this war. When he refused the Denoirs' invitation, I had attributed it to his frustrating individuality, but now I could see how he intensely avoided any of the political nets woven into Alacryan society. I didn't push the topic further, despite the fierce curiosity I had for this mysterious ascender and his past.

Still, I couldn't help but linger on thoughts of the war as we walked on in silence. The war itself was a regular topic of conversation among the named and highbloods, but I'd never imagined myself fighting against Dicathen much less thought about how that might have changed me.

I had never yearned for the kind of glory war brings. I had no interest in killing those who had never harmed me, regardless of where they were born or to who they swore allegiance.

And because of Scythe Seris's teachings, I knew that the High Sovereign's expansion to Dicathen was self-serving at best, and that it didn't benefit the people of Alacrya, nobility or otherwise. I couldn't imagine being forced to fight for a cause I didn't support.

If my life had been different, though, if Scythe Seris hadn't hidden the knowledge of my blood's manifestation, I very well could have been trained for slaughter and unleashed upon the Dicathians.

What then? Would I have returned like Grey, quiet, cold, and often unreadable? Or would I have become more like Kayden, withdrawing into a malaise and acting as if nothing in the world mattered at all anymore?

I forced myself to focus on the canopy of trees and the singing birds around me, pushing any further thoughts of the war away. There was no benefit in thinking about all of this now.

When we finally reached Windcrest Hall, I followed Grey into his room. As he held the door open for me and I saw the inside, I couldn't help but laugh.

He scanned the room, frowning. "What?"

“Sorry, it’s just exactly how I imagined it. Entirely barren of personal belongings or homely comforts. It looks like you’re ready to leave at a moment’s notice.”

Grey regarded me with a raised brow. “That’s kind of rude. What does your room look like then? Did you bring your entire collection of stuffed dolls with you?”

I gaped at him, then narrowed my eyes and crossed my arms defensively. “I’ll have you know I only brought one, and it would be an insult to call him a mere ‘stuffed doll’ considering how ferocious he looks.”

His icy facade cracked momentarily, letting through a brief but bright smile that reminded me of our time in the Relictombs. Things were always easier minus the distractions of “normal” life.

Helping myself to a seat at the Sovereigns Quarrel board, I read the inscription and ran my fingers along one of the red stone pieces. “I like the Hercross red and gray,” I said absentmindedly. “It’s more striking than the plain black and white pieces I have.”

Without preamble, Grey withdrew a couple of items from his dimensional storage. “It’s about time I returned these.”

He held out my brother’s white-bladed dagger, handle first. The Denoir medallion dangled from it, catching the light as it spun slowly.

I had resisted the urge to follow Grey’s location using the medallion after he was released from the High Hall. Even when my parents and mentor insisted I spy for them, I hadn’t activated the tracking function. I wanted to earn the man’s trust, and stalking him with magic seemed like a poor way to do it.

Still, there was a certain comfort in knowing that I could find him if I really needed to. The thought of giving up that capability made me uneasy.

"Keep them," I said, my voice shaking slightly. "Sevren would be glad to know his dagger continues to find use in the Relictombs."

"And you don't want to sacrifice your power to track me down if necessary," he added. The words weren't cruel or angry, just matter-of-fact.

"That's not what I—"

"I already lost your brother's cloak," he interrupted. "If this dagger is all you have to remember him by, then you should keep it. As for the medallion, I won't be needing Highblood Denoir's protection."

My throat constricted as I thought of Sevren. Lenora and Corbett had decided he must be dead and chose to move on even before I received confirmation from Grey, but I had always held out hope. Seeing Grey with that dagger and the teal cloak Sevren favored had dashed that hope, but failed to provide any real closure.

"You're right," I said after taking a steadying breath. "Thank you."

The brushed silver handle was cool to the touch. I pressed my fingers into the grooves, but they were too large for me. Tugging the sheath up to examine the blade, my breath caught in my throat. Inscribed at the base of the blade was a symbol: a hexagon with three parallel lines carved inside it.

"What is it?" Grey asked, studying my expression carefully as he took the seat across from me.

“Nothing, it’s just that…” Sliding the sheath back into place, I stored the dagger and medallion both in my new dimension ring. “Before, in the room of mirrors, while I was still…”

“Haedrig?” Grey asked when I hesitated.

“Yes. I told you I’d studied aether, a little.” Grey nodded as he leaned forward in his chair. “It was mostly Sevren who studied aether. That’s what the insignia is: an ancient rune meaning aether. Three marks for time, space, and life, and the hexagon as a symbol of connection, binding, and building. He used it like a sort of… signature, I suppose. Something he started as a child, marking things with the symbol for aether to give them ‘power.’ It just kind of stuck with him.”

“I see.” Grey’s attention lingered on the ring where the dagger was now stored. “I didn’t realize. I hadn’t seen that particular rune before.”

I twisted the ring around my finger as the animated conversations with Sevren regarding magic and the Relictombs came back to me. “He thought there was more to the Relictombs than what the Sovereigns told us. That by ascending, we could learn how to do what they did… manipulate the fabric of reality through aether.”

Grey began to fiddle with the game board, moving a center shield forward. “Is that what you think?”

I wasn’t sure if he wanted to play or was just fidgeting, but I countered by taking a caster along the right edge to threaten any piece that broke away from the line. “Well, I met you in the Relictombs, and you can wield aether, so…”

Grey was impassive as he moved a second shield to support the first.

I tucked a lock of blue hair behind my ear as I sent another caster along the left of the board to force his sentry down the middle.

The key to true victory in Sovereigns Quarrel was to secure a path through the board. This required forethought, but also creativity. It was a slow and cautious game. Alternatively, by focusing on the destruction of the enemy Sentry alone, it was possible to end the game quickly, but often left both players dissatisfied.

"We both know your being here is no coincidence," Grey said as he made his next move.

"No," I admitted, weighing my move—and my words—carefully. "It is not."

Deciding bold action was required, I moved a striker into the center of the field. "When you didn't throw yourself at my adoptive parents' feet after the trial, they arranged for me to assist Professor Aphelion in order to spy on you and…win you over, if I can. My mentor"—I held Scythe Seris's name back, hesitant to reveal that connection yet—"asked me to keep an eye on you as well, separately."

Grey's focus never left the game board. He didn't flinch, frown, or blink. We exchanged a handful of moves before he spoke again.

"I guess I'm pretty popular."

I pouted my lips and stared at him angrily. "You are an aberration that no one seems to know what to do with, and through my own recklessness, I have been shackled with the responsibility of keeping track of you."

Grey blinked in surprise, to which I responded with a genuine laugh. "I only jest...at least partially. I think forcing me to become an

assistant to Professor Aphelion was also my parents' way of punishing me for sneaking out."

The mysterious ascender scratched uncomfortably at his wheat-blond hair, and his eyes lost focus for an instant.

"Oh, so you choose right now to wake up," he said tartly.

I quirked a brow at him, not following until a moment later when the small, fiery puppy form of Regis leapt out of his side and landed on the ground with a stumble.

"Again?" I asked as he spun around, his fiery little tail wagging. "Is your master abusing you?"

The puppy plopped onto its rear and stared up at Grey, his muzzle scrunched up condescendingly. "My current state was due to his gross negligence, yes."

Smirking, I bent down to pat him on the head. "I'm sorry. You're much grander when you're full size."

Regis's furry chest puffed out. "I know, right?"

I turned back to Grey, who was staring at the shadow wolf pup in that way he had when they were communicating mentally. "It's rude to exclude guests from the conversation, you know?"

Grey grimaced and scratched the back of his neck. "I was just catching him up. He's been out for a while."

I waited for Grey to say something else, to pick back up our previous conversation—ask me questions, tell me to leave, anything—but he stayed silent. Tiring of the game, I decided a true victory wasn't in the cards for the day. Using a caster I had allowed to become isolated near his hold, I killed a stranded shield and stopped a few spaces from his sentry.

“Do you plan on going through with what the Denoirs and this mysterious Scythe mentor have asked?” he said finally, shifting his sentry forward a space.

I felt the blood rush to my face. This is exactly what I had worried about most: that, even after everything we’d been through in the Relictombs together, he still wouldn’t trust me.

“If you think that I would spy on you even after informing you that I have been sent to spy on you, then one of us does not deserve to be molding young Alacryan minds, although I can’t be sure if that someone is you or me.”

“Then why are you really here?” he asked, his steady gaze pinning me to my chair.

The question shouldn’t have caught me off guard, but I still struggled to form an answer.

The truth was that I couldn’t shake the feeling that Grey was somehow the key to unlocking the secrets of the Relictombs. He was an enigma, a person unlike any I had ever met before, and I couldn’t help being drawn to him. Sitting across from him now, feeling the weight of his attention crushing me, I knew it was foolish to call my feelings for him romantic. It was a fascination, and one that I knew would be dangerous for both of us.

I wanted to see what he would accomplish. Not to bask in the reflected glory of his achievements, but to be a part of whatever change he wrought on the world, to have the power to make my voice heard.

Taking my caster piece, I made my final move.

“Because I trust you, Grey. There aren’t many people in this life I can say that about, but I trust you, and I’m still hoping to earn your trust for myself.”

He met my eye then. For a moment, his mask fell away. I saw surprise and doubt in the lines of his brow, appreciation in the curl of his lips, wonder and fear in his eyes… His face carried a world of conflicted emotions, just for that heartbeat, and when the mask went back up on the beat following, I understood.

No one could bear the weight of all those contradictory feelings all the time, and so he buried them.

“Good,” he said firmly, his eyes on the game board instead of me. “Because people worthy of trust are rare, and I would like to be able to trust you too.”

As if we’d been speaking of nothing more pressing than the weather, Grey grabbed a striker piece and slid it across the board, through a gap in my defenses I hadn’t noticed, and clicked it against my sentry. The piece toppled to the table with a clatter.

I gaped at the board. While Grey had beaten me on a fluke when we’d played in the Relictombs, it was only because I’d been greedy, too focused on the true win. This time he had set and baited the trap, then waited for me to fall into it.

Grey leaned back in his chair and crossed his arms. “We’ll keep letting the Denoirs think you’re doing what they want. Send a report, tell them whatever you like.”

I dragged my gaze away from the board, where I was caught up retracing the last several moves. “What? Are you sure?”

The golden-eyed ascender only nodded. “The surest way to lose a war is to a traitorous messenger.”

Regis shook his little head at his master. “He says such scary things with so little emotions…”

“Well, now that we’ve all caught up and have agreed to trust each other…” Grey leaned forward and rested his elbows on the table, a fiery gleam in his honey-gold eyes. “How would you like to help me steal a dead relic?”

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MINIMALLY CATASTROPHIC

"DID YOU GET IT?" I asked as Caera let down the hood of her cloak and closed the door. Her blue hair was clinging wetly to her head, and water dripped from her to pool on the tiles.

"Of course," she said confidently, a mischievous glint in her eye.

With a flourish, she activated her dimension ring and withdrew a pewter-colored orb the size of both my fists held together. The metallic shell was pock-marked and covered in ridges and crevices, making it look like a round metal sponge.

Caera held it out and I carefully plucked it from her grip.

"It's heavy," I commented, shifting it up and down in my hand to feel the heft. "Is that going to matter?"

She unclasped her sopping cloak and hung it by the door. "I certainly hope not. I didn't see any runes that indicated pressure sensitivity engraved on the display pedestal, did you?"

"No, that's true," I replied. "And it seems unlikely the dead relics are removed from their cases often. By the time anyone discovers the switch—"

"Professor Grey and Assistant Professor Denoir will have long since moved on from Central Academy," she finished.

Caera had been surprisingly receptive to my idea. I knew from our adventures in the Relictombs that she had a rebellious and somewhat reckless streak, but I had still expected her to take some convincing. Always perceptive, she understood my intention immediately and was quick to agree. We'd then spent the rest of that afternoon and evening formulating a plan.

Together, we had discussed the strengths of each relic—or at least what we could learn about them from books and Caera's careful questioning of the curator. Personally, I had wanted to take two or three, but Caera had rightly suggested that would add an unnecessary layer of risk. After discussing what the theft would require, we eventually decided on a single dead relic to "liberate" from the Reliquary. Of all the relics available, I didn't see how any single one would give me a sizable boost in power, so we ended up choosing the one that the Alacryans knew the least about, which also happened to be Central Academy's most recent addition.

Although the curator had been quiet on *why* Scythe Dragoth had brought the orb to Central Academy, he had been more than happy to discuss its powers—what little was known about them—with Caera.

According to the old man, the dead relic was unique in that its form provided no hints about its function. The pock-marked surface wasn't by design, but rather wear; when the relic was first discovered, it was unblemished, a perfect silver sphere, but when removed from the Relictombs it decayed quickly. The Instillers had surmised that it was some kind of tool—perhaps something used in the construction of the Relictombs itself—and the sudden degradation was a kind of defense mechanism to prevent the ancient mages' secrets from being discovered. The curator couldn't provide Caera any more information than that, though.

The idea of having a tool of the djinn, something that would let me manipulate the Relictombs directly, was too good to pass up.

"And you're sure the artisan—"

“It’s not unheard of for highbloods to have fake dead relics made in order to impress their friends—and rivals.” Caera indicated the orb with a smirk. “She’ll be quiet about it, as loose lips, in this case, would likely result in her death.”

“Still, if she were to—”

Caera waved my concern away. “I was disguised, as you know, and pretended to be representing a different blood. So even if she did talk, I wouldn’t be implicated.”

Imbuing my extradimensional storage rune with aether, I stashed the fake relic. “What blood did you impersonate?”

The mischievous glint in Caera’s eyes returned. “Oh, I think you know.”

Regis barked with laughter, nearly toppling back in his diminutive form. “Serves those Granbehl jerks right. Almost makes you hope this shady craft-lady does turn over on them—or us, or whatever.”

I threw my own white cloak over my shoulders, giving Caera an amused smile. “If things do go poorly, at least there will be a silver lining.”

Caera pulled out the teardrop pendant she always wore and whispered an incantation. Her features blurred in a way that made my eyes twitch with discomfort, then reformed as the familiar green-haired ascender, Haedrig.

“That is really strange to watch,” I said, scanning the face and body for any hint of Caera beneath.

Haedrig cocked out a hip and batted his eyelashes at me. “What’s wrong, Grey?” he said in his croaky voice. “Don’t you find me attractive anymore?”

Regis walked a slow circle around Haedrig, sniffing at his boots. “I don’t know how to feel about it, to be honest. For one, what happens to your boo—”

“Can we maybe be just a little more serious?” I cut in as I pulled up my hood. “We’re about to commit a major crime.”

Haedrig, who had just conjured a filthy green cloak from his dimension ring, frowned and scratched the stubble on his chin. “Don’t know what you’re going on about. I’m just going for a stroll over to the Reliquary…”

“Don’t mind him,” Regis said. “Just pre-larceny jitters.”

“Let’s get going,” I said, gesturing for Regis to return to my body. “The Reliquary should have just closed.”

Caera—or Haedrig—led the way out into the hallway that connected the many suites in Windcrest. Haedrig went left, taking a more direct route to the exit, while I turned right, following the roundabout path.

The weather was grim. Rain poured from the sky and occasional flashes of lightning revealed a bedraggled campus. The weather was a lucky coincidence; it meant there would be a lot less people moving around in the open.

Pulling the brilliant white cloak more closely around me, I dove into the storm. The rain was punishing, but, whether due to its magical nature or the quality of the craftsmanship, the cloak kept me both warm and relatively dry.

I couldn’t see Haedrig, but I could hear a lilting, drunken tune from somewhere ahead, muffled by the noise of the downpour.

'I never would have expected fair lady Caera to know such a suggestive song…' Regis said, humming the tune himself.

The bright lanterns lighting the Chapel entry slowly became visible through the thick curtains of rain. Haedrig was already stomping up the stairs to the still-open double doors and the guard who stood beside them.

Haedrig paused as the guard addressed him, but they were too far away and the storm was too noisy for me to hear. I assumed the guard was simply informing him that the Reliquary within was closed, but we already knew that. Haedrig nodded and proceeded into the building, stumbling on the threshold.

An exterior hallway ran in a rectangle around a large central space where the dead relics and other more valuable contributions were displayed. While the entry hall was left open—but not unguarded—the Reliquary itself was closed and locked after hours.

The guard was watching Haedrig closely. After a moment of apparent indecision, he abandoned his post to follow the apparent drunk.

Moving quickly, with my back hunched and my cloak still pulled tightly around me, I headed for the Chapel doors. To anyone watching, I would just look like someone caught in the storm and seeking shelter.

Clearing the stone steps three at a time, I paused to listen just outside.

"—told you, it's *fine*," Haedrig was half-shouting from down the hall. "I just want to pop in and get a look at my old"—Haedrig belched loudly—"armor."

A clear, authoritative voice answered. “And, as I told you, it is *not* fine, sir. You will have to come back tomorrow when the Reliquary is open.”

Haedrig replied with a phlegmy snort. “I have friends, you know! Powerful friends. I know damned near *everybody*. I’m sure someone will let me in.”

“Sir!” the guard insisted. “Sir, if you don’t—”

A long peal of thunder cut off the rest of the guard’s threat. I peeked into the hall just in time to see Haedrig turning the far corner with two armed and armored men following closely behind.

I knew there would be two more guards in the outer hallway. Focusing aether into my ears, I listened closely for their footsteps: It sounded like they were on the far side of the building, circling back toward the source of the commotion. I winced as Haedrig began to shout about having them all thrown into the sea before cutting off the flow of aether to my ears, letting my hearing return to normal.

Before entering the building, I let my eyes refocus in order to see the aetheric pathways connecting every point around me. I couldn’t see beyond the far wall and door into the Reliquary, but I took careful note of the paths from the door back out into the rain.

Darting across the hall to the Reliquary door, I examined the black iron handle. As was popular at the academy, the door was locked with a runestone. Unlike my room or office doors, however, there was a glowing rune placed at the base of this handle. It combined symbols for fire-attribute mana and mana transference, suggesting that touching it would result in a bad time.

Go.

Regis, in his shadowy black wisp form, drifted out of my chest and directly through the door.

Although I couldn't see through his eyes, I could feel my companion's emotions and hear his thoughts as he scanned the interior of the room for additional defenses.

In the far hallway, Haedrig began to shout about "respect" and "honor" and "the good ol' days."

'The floor behind each door is marked with another rune. It…' Regis trailed off in thoughtful silence as he attempted to read it. *'Anyone who walks over this thing will have their mana core drained. The rune traps the mana… probably so they can identify who it was.'*

I smirked at the door. *Easy. What about the lock? Can you open it from that side?*

'Less easy,' Regis said, his worry transmitting along with his words. *'There's no handle or way to release the latch from the interior.'*

In our reconnaissance of the Reliquary, Caera and I had spent nearly two full hours inspecting the building and displays as closely as we could without drawing suspicion. Although it had been clear the doors had handles only on the outside, we hadn't been sure if they could be opened some other way from within the room.

I had an idea, but wasn't entirely sure it would work. *Regis, I need you to picture your surroundings as clearly as you can and send me that thought. As clearly as you can, all right?*

'Yeah yeah, I got it.'

I took a step back from the door and focused on the aetheric pathways again, right up to where they stopped at the closed door. When the mental picture of the Reliquary interior began to form in

my mind, I connected it with the purple fractal paths I could see, forming a mental map of where I *thought* they continued to.

Three Steps had taught me not to just *look* for the paths, but to *feel* them and let them guide me along. This made the ability much faster and more efficient to utilize, but it also—theoretically—meant that I could use God Step to move somewhere I couldn't directly see.

Activating the godrune, I vanished with a flash of amethyst light.

And appeared on the other side of the door, crackling with aetheric energy. Aside from the fact that it had worked—*I just teleported through a solid door*, I realized with delight—the more exciting sensation was how little aether the godrune had consumed. Although I hadn't even been able to absorb enough atmospheric aether to fill my newly strengthened core yet, God Step took only a fraction of my aetheric reserves.

The thrill of using the godrune for the first time since forging the second layer of my aether core was interrupted by a tingling sensation all over my body.

Beneath my feet, the rune trap had activated and was attempting to draw out all my mana. I stepped off it, unharmed, my aether core undisturbed by the magic. I had to assume the rune would have drawn some ambient mana from my body—the traces of water or earth mana that would naturally linger near me—but with no mana core to manipulate it, the small traces of mana wouldn't carry any signature of my identity.

I knew I didn't have much more time before the situation between Haedrig and the guards escalated, so I forced my mind back to the mission. Moving quickly to my target, I examined the plinth holding

it, looking for any wards or runes that Caera and I hadn't noticed before.

Unlike the warding runes behind the doors, which hadn't been there during the day, the stone base on which the dead relic was displayed didn't reveal any new protections. But that didn't mean it was unguarded.

A series of complex runes had been engraved around the base of the display to ward off anyone from touching it. A light touch would reward the offender with a shock, and the display would buzz in alarm to warn the curator. Anything beyond a light touch—for example, attempting to lift up the glass and access the dead relic within—would release a paralyzing jolt of electricity before issuing a screeching alarm that half the campus would probably hear.

I had only thought of one way to bypass the runes without triggering the alarm.

Manifesting aether into my hand, I formed a single claw. I also wrapped myself in a barrier of protective aether before kneeling down next to the plinth. Lining the claw up with the runes—starting with those responsible for creating the alarm effect—I slashed at the stone.

As the claw gouged into the marble, a bolt of vibrantly blue lightning leapt to my hand, burning through the layer of aether and scorching my knuckles before I could react. Reinforcing the aether, I focused on redirecting and channeling the lightning, forcing it to skitter and jump across the surface of the barrier.

It travelled up my arm, across my chest, and down my other arm. If I let the super-charged electrical current fly off into the room, I was

likely to blast a hole in the wall or destroy one of the other dead relics. Instead, I pressed my hand firmly over the remainder of the runes so that the lightning bolt travelled in a circle, slamming back into the same runes that conjured it.

The marble split with a loud *crack*.

I froze, my heart racing, listening hard for any indication the noise had been noticed.

Thunder was rolling in the background, and I could hear Haedrig's argument with the guards through the walls.

I hoped it was enough to cover the sound of shattering stone.

"—Vritra's name was that?"

"Go check it out," the same authoritative voice from earlier commanded.

Shit.

'Better hurry it up,' Regis warned, his puppy form watching me with wide eyes.

I ignored the lightning-patterned burn already healing across my arms and torso, focusing instead on the relic before me.

The relic was also protected by a glass case, which was protected by a series of runes that strengthened it and protected it from magical attack, but it didn't react as I lifted it from the plinth and set it carefully on the floor. Before touching the real relic, I withdrew the fake from my dimension rune and held it up next to the original, which was sitting on a square velvet pillow. They were identical.

Well done, Caera, I thought as I picked up the dead relic with my other hand.

It was light as a feather and felt weightless in comparison to the heavy pewter copy.

Taking great care, I slowly settled the replacement onto the pillow. It sank into the soft fabric and immediately looked wrong, but before I could work out anything else to do, I heard the heavy *clunk* of a magical lock being triggered.

'Art, someone's coming!' Regis shouted mentally as he hopped around my feet.

The door closest to where Haedrig was shouting shifted as someone pulled on the handle.

At the same time, there was a hollow *thud* as a body slammed against one of the walls. "Get your hands off me!" Haedrig shouted.

The door paused, hanging open only an inch or two.

I stared at the false relic sinking into the pillow. With some time… but that was one thing I didn't have.

Cursing again, I rushed to pick up the glass casing and fit it carefully over the top of the plinth.

Placing a hand over the lightning-scorched runes, I activated Aroa's Requiem, filling the museum with golden light as the rune lit up beneath my tunic. Sparkling purple motes danced along my arm and across the pedestal, scouring away the cracks, burns, and claw marks and leaving behind unblemished marble. The warding runes along the base glowed dimly in the gloomy light, indicating they were functional once again.

The door began to open again. On the other side was a young guard. One hand was on his sword, the other on the handle of the door, but

his head was turned to look down the hall, his focus still, for that instant, on Haedrig.

I conjured a map of the aetheric pathways in my mind just as Regis leapt up and disappeared into my body. In the space of a single heartbeat I connected the pathways I could see with my mental picture of those on the other side of the door.

Drawing in a shallow breath, I activated God Step.

The first sensation I had was of the cold rain crashing against every part of my body at once. The aetheric lightning that jumped and danced across my skin arced out into the rain, causing the air around me to pop and sizzle.

The second sensation I felt was my heart skipping several beats as I realized a figure was looming out of the darkness, coming straight at me with their head down against the pounding rain.

Aether flowed to clad my body as I prepared to defend myself, but the hunched person stopped so suddenly they nearly fell to the ground when their foot slipped on the wet stones.

Reaching out instinctively, I grabbed them under the arm to keep them from falling.

"Vritra's bloody horns!" a man's voice exclaimed from under his hood.

We stared at one another.

"Professor Aphelion…" I said, still holding his arm.

"Professor Grey, I…"

His eyes were wide and searching, shifting from my face to the hand gripping his arm to the Chapel entry behind me, where I could already hear the noise of the guards struggling with Haedrig.

My mind raced.

I couldn't be sure what the professor had seen, or why he was even there. If he had watched me appear out of thin air wrapped in amethyst lightning, then he was a liability. I considered simply breaking his neck and God Stepping away again, but that would definitely complicate the situation. Besides, I didn't really know what he had seen, and murdering an innocent man—even an Alacryan—didn't sit well with me.

A commotion from the entrance of the Chapel drew both our attention as three guards appeared, half dragging, half pushing a limp Haedrig.

"You two there!" one of the guards shouted. "What are you doing here?"

Haedrig was hanging from the guards' arms, his eyes half-closed, but I caught the surreptitious glance he shot me, and the tightening of his jaw when he noticed Professor Aphelion. Another guard appeared in the open doorway to the Chapel, his lip bleeding and his brows turned down in a thunderous scowl.

The professor tugged his arm out of my grip and limped past me as I channeled aether in my hand and prepared to eliminate all the witnesses if necessary.

"Hello friends," he said amicably, addressing the guards. "I'll forgive your rudeness due to what appears to be a rather tense situation, but you are speaking to two of Central Academy's professors. We simply noticed the absence of a guard at the Chapel's door and were coming to investigate."

“My apology, sirs,” the guard said quickly, snapping into a shallow bow that forced Haedrig down as well. “This drunk was causing a ruckus, and we thought—”

“That we were his accomplices, coming to aid in his mischief?” Professor Aphelion laughed loudly. “No, but the three of you do have the honor of manhandling… uh—”

“Ascender Haedrig,” I whispered in answer to his searching tone.

“—the once-great ascender, Haedrig, who it appears has fallen on hard times. Show a little pity and release him into our care, would you? No need to embarrass his blood over a mild case of public drunkenness, is there?” When the guards frowned and shared an uncertain look, he added, “It wouldn’t exactly look good if his blood made a fuss to the director, would it?”

“No, sir,” the guard answered, but he kept a firm hold on Haedrig’s arm. “However, I would be remiss in my duty if I didn’t report this to campus security. They’ll decide on what to do with—”

While the guard was speaking, Haedrig continued to slouch lower in the guards’ grip. The apparently passed-out ascender suddenly kicked up from the ground, bursting out of the guards’ hands and flipping gracefully through the air to land at the base of the stairs. He snapped a lazy solute before bolting, his mana-enhanced speed carrying him out of sight beyond the veil of rain.

“Go after him!” the head guard exclaimed, causing the other two to burst into a run. Their armored boots slid on the rain-slick pavers, and it was immediately clear they had no chance of catching the quick-footed highblood.

“Well…uh…best of luck,” Professor Aphelion told the remaining guards, who shot us irritated glares.

He nodded to me as he pulled his hood up. “Until later then, Professor Grey.”

I returned the nod, watching his face and eyes carefully for any indication he had seen what had happened or guessed at the reason for my presence near the Chapel, but his face was blank except for the shadow of a sardonic smile.

“Yeah, until later…” I said cautiously, flipping up my own hood and turning away.

I couldn’t help but harbor some lingering unease about Professor Aphelion’s unexpected involvement in the heist, but as far as things that could have gone wrong, it seemed minimally catastrophic.

It was hard to be too worried, considering the prize waiting in my dimension rune.

352
RELIC, REVIVED

CAERA DENOIR

The torrential rain blocked out everything but the wet slapping of my own boots on the cobblestones and the rapid-fire beating of my heart.

"Go after him!"

The shouted order was nearly washed away by the rainfall. Even without the downpour, I knew how to evade unwanted attention and avoid prying eyes, so I wasn't fearful of being caught. No, it was something else that made my pulse thunder in my ears.

Kayden…

What the hell had he been doing there? How much had he seen?

What is Grey going to do to him?

My throat constricted as I remembered the feeling of Grey's powerful hand around my neck, lifting me off the ground. I had no doubt that Grey would kill Kayden if he thought it was necessary.

Depending on what the professor had seen, I wasn't even sure I could disagree. I likely wouldn't be punished in the traditional sense; I was still a Denoir, and knew as well as anyone that Alacryan law worked differently for the highbloods. Still, too much attention could result in the discovery of my Vritra blood's manifestation.

I knew I would do whatever was required to prevent that from happening.

Turning down a wide alley between two academy buildings, I used the windowsill of one to launch myself up into the second story window of the other, then jumped back across the alley onto the

roof of the first. The tiles were slick, but I was able to crawl up over the peak of the roof and slide down the other side. When I reached the edge, I kicked off the roof, soaring a dozen or more feet to land on the ledge of a second story window leading into Windcrest Hall.

The shutters were closed and locked against the storm, but using my brother's white-bladed dagger, I tripped the latch. Before pushing the shutters open, I withdrew my mana from the relic hanging around my neck, letting my appearance return to normal.

Slipping down from the sill, I found myself at the end of one of the many long hallways carving the building up into the various quarters and suites. Grey's suite was a few doors down the hall.

I froze as I realized someone was standing just outside his door, her body swaying nervously. She didn't appear to have noticed the noise of my entry into the building.

Her blonde hair hung straight and damp, and the white battle robes she wore clung to her figure, soaked half through from the storm. I could tell from the puddle that had formed around her that she'd been standing there for at least a few minutes.

"Hi," I said as I carefully closed the shutters behind me.

The woman gave a startled yelp and slipped in the puddle. She threw out a hand and released a gust of wind to keep from tumbling over. "Where in the world did you…"

Trailing off, she took in my appearance and the shuttered window behind me. Her hand raised so that her palm was pointing toward my chest, fingers splayed out, and her expression hardened. "Please note that I am a professor of this academy and more than capable of defending myself and the property of those who live here."

“Glad to hear it, considering *I* live here,” I said, pointing at the hallway ceiling. “Third floor, actually, but the second story window was a cleaner jump.” I gave her a shallow nod, then tucked back the wet strands of hair that had fallen into my face. “Caera of Highblood Denoir. And you are?”

Her hand drifted down to her side as her eyebrows rose up. “Oh. *Oh!* Oh Vritra, I’m so sorry!”

I shrugged, gesturing at myself with a handwave. “I don’t blame you. Looks like we were in the same boat.”

The woman grabbed a handful of her robes and squeezed water onto the floor. “Tell me about it. I was only out there for like two seconds.”

I let a knowing smile play at the corner of my mouth. “So, you and Professor Grey…”

She froze, one hand still wrapped up in her robes, her wide amber eyes lingering on the door to Grey’s rooms. “N-no, I just—the storm, and—thought that…”

The woman paused and forced a smile. “I’m sorry, I’m Abby of Named Blood Redcliff. Can I help you with that?” She gestured to my clothes, which were dripping water onto the floor in a steady stream.

Without waiting for a reply, she waved her hands and conjured up a gust of warm wind that blew through my clothes and hair. I squinted against the draft and grabbed the edges of my cloak to keep it from flapping about. After several seconds, I was dry and warm again.

“Thanks,” I said. “Why didn’t you already do that to yourself?”

“Um…” The woman smoothed her soaking clothes, refusing to meet my eye. “Well, it appears that Professor Grey isn’t home right now anyway. Uh, pleasure to meet you, Lady Caera.”

Swirling so quickly that an arc of water droplets sprayed across the hallway, the woman began a quick march down the hall. As she turned a corner at the far end, she cast a wary glance back in my direction. Her lips tightened when she saw me still watching her, and then she was gone.

It shouldn’t have surprised me. A man as striking and mysterious as Grey would have women flocking around him like birds. Even lacking a blood name, the fact that he had attained the level of professor at such a prestigious academy suggested he had connections and wealth. Many named blood women were expected to marry for political connection and enhancement of their blood, generally by creating a stronger bond between two named bloods of similar status.

The Redcliff blood was well known in the central dominion for their constant efforts to climb the social ladder. However, something told me this Abby wouldn’t be able to keep up with Grey even if she caught him.

In fact, it was exceedingly difficult to picture him with any woman. I couldn’t see how romance or love—even the kind that happened in a single evening—would fit into his “solo-ascender” lifestyle. I found myself trying to picture Grey doing something as simple as walking hand-in-hand with someone through the park, or preparing tea and breakfast for his lover in bed. I couldn’t manage it.

Wet footsteps on the stairs behind me brought me back to myself. I turned just in time to see a very bedraggled Grey appear in the hallway behind me.

He frowned at my clothes. “How’d you get dry so fast?”

“I ran into a friend of yours,” I answered, leaning up against his door. “You just missed her, I’m afraid. Professor Redcliff, I think she said.”

“Oh,” was all he said. He pulled out his runestone and flashed it at the door, which opened with a *click*.

Inside, he immediately unclasped his luxurious white cloak and tossed it into the corner, then began to peel away his wet tunic. Although I knew the polite thing to do was avert my gaze, my attention was drawn to the runes on his spine. Unlike most Alacryans, Grey kept his covered. Even in the depths of the Relictombs, I’d never caught sight of them.

They were strange and untraditional, but only someone who had traveled with him and seen him fight extensively, or perhaps a scholar of Alacryan runes, would question them.

The other runes, those that channeled his powerful aether abilities, weren’t visible.

Realizing I was getting distracted, I looked away. “So? Did you get the dead relic?”

In answer, something tapped my shoulder. Without looking behind me, I took the sphere. It was light, practically weightless. “The weight wasn’t a problem, was it?”

“It sits differently on the pillow, but I don’t think anyone will notice since the relic hasn’t been here long,” Grey’s voice came from his bedroom.

I took a seat and rotated the sphere in my hands as I waited for Grey to return. When he did, he was dressed in black trousers and an azure tunic with black embroidery. It suited him, making his hair and eyes seem even brighter.

I tossed the dead relic to him, and he plucked it out of the air. "Hurry! I'm dying to see what this thing is capable of."

"Yes, ma'am," he muttered, holding the sphere up in one hand.

The puppy form of Regis popped out of Grey's side and then jumped up on the couch next to me. I gave his head a scratch as he leaned against me.

"Go on then, princess," he said, pressing his head into my hand. "Make with the pretty sparkles already."

Grey focused on the sphere. He must have activated his godrune, because a golden glow suffused the room, and brilliant amethyst particles began dancing along his arm toward the relic. When they reached it, the motes skittered across the burnished silver surface and vanished into the crevices and holes.

For a few seconds, it didn't look like anything was happening. I tried to catch Grey's eye, but his attention was entirely on the relic. I drew in a sharp breath as the wear began to vanish, the pockmarks filling in, the wrinkles smoothing, the burnished gray brightening. Then the flow of particles thinned to a trickle and finally stopped, and the last amethyst mote vanished.

Grey held up the perfectly smooth sphere, turning it so it caught the light and shined like a silver moon. As it turned, I noticed a line bisecting the top and bottom halves of the sphere, so thin it was

nearly invisible. Grey must have seen it too, because he took a half in each hand and twisted lightly.

The relic came apart.

"Whoa," Regis said softly.

The inside of the sphere was an organic framework supporting a crystal that cast pinkish light through the room. The crystal was shedding a fine dust that hung in the air, drifting aimlessly around Grey's hand.

"What is it?" I asked, breathless with excitement.

Grey shifted slightly and lowered the empty half of the relic as his focus on the crystal intensified. The subtly glowing crystal immediately blazed with bright purple light.

"What the—" Grey exclaimed as that half of the sphere jerked out of his hand and floated to the ground at his feet.

My hand went involuntarily to my mouth, and we watched, stunned, as the crystal began to disintegrate before our eyes. A cloud of shimmering particles rose up to hover above the half-relic, each grain carrying some of the crystal's light. When the last piece disappeared, the cloud let off a strobing flash of light that made my head spin, and I forced myself to look away.

Puppy Regis winced as he held up a paw to cover his eyes. "I'm pretty sure this is how demon overlords are summoned!"

Glancing from the corner of my eye to make sure the flashing had stopped, I let out an astonished gasp. "Vritra's horns…"

The cloud had coalesced into an opaque oval hovering in the air, which Grey was pacing slow circles around. It had an oily sheen to its surface and was radiating a dim purple light.

“It’s an ascension portal, it has to be,” I said, sinking further back into the couch. “But one you can activate anywhere… That means—”

“I can go to the Relictombs whenever I want,” Grey finished. Facing me, he held up the other half. “What do you think this one is for then?”

I considered the silver half-sphere and the matrix of organic supports within. “Well if the other one takes you in…”

“Then this one might bring me back?” Grey was nodding, and his serious gaze turned back to the portal. “Caera, wait here.”

I shot up from my seat, nearly sending puppy Regis tumbling. “What? You’re going to go now? Without any sort of research or tests?”

“This *will* be the test,” he stated, his eyes still glued to the shimmering gate.

“Then let’s at least go together,” I reasoned. “Even if you do end up inside the Relictombs, what happens if that half of the relic leads you out into one of the main gates? With me there, it’ll be easier to get through any sort of questioning.”

Grey’s brows furrowed in thought before he turned his leveled gaze at me. “I appreciate it, but I’d rather have you here to keep prying eyes away from this room.”

I opened my mouth to argue, but all that came out was a frustrated huff. “Very well. I’ll keep a lookout in case any other woman you’ve managed to seduce decides to pay you a late-night visit.”

He regarded me with obvious amusement. “Come on, Regis.” The diminutive shadow wolf glanced at me and shrugged his little

shoulders before following the command. “And I haven’t forgotten about our promise.”

The mention of our agreement brought a faint smile to my face. I wasn’t expecting any sort of compensation for helping Grey, so it had caught me by surprise when he said he would go on an ascent with me.

“I think you’ll be pleasantly surprised at how much stronger I’ve become since our last ascent,” I said confidently.

“I hope training isn’t your excuse for losing to me in Sovereigns Quarrel,” he smirked just before vanishing through the portal.

I stared, open-mouthed, at the portal suspended in mid-air before letting out a chuckle. “How immature.”

Not long after Grey had left, the gate hovering above the relic half began to fade, the opaque oily surface growing transparent, like fog fading from a mirror. After a few seconds, it was only a ghostly shape in the middle of the room.

I approached the dormant portal and carefully reached toward it. When my fingers brushed the transparent oval, they passed cleanly through and I felt nothing. I waved my hand back and forth, but the movement didn’t disturb the shape.

“At least no one can chase after them,” I muttered.

Too restless to sit around, I began pacing the small suite.

Thoughts of Sevren came to me. I remembered so clearly when he’d left on his preliminary ascent after only his first season at Central Academy. It had felt a lot like this: the excitement tempered by disappointment that I couldn’t follow him or fight alongside him.

Withdrawing the white-bladed dagger from my dimension ring, I unsheathed it to reveal the symbol at the base of the blade. This dagger had been his first accolade. He'd carved the aether rune into it while telling me all about his ascent, still so excited about his adventure that he'd practically been vibrating.

It broke my heart to think of him now, dying alone in the Relictombs, a victim of some hideous monster. I thought he was going to be the one to unlock the secrets of the Relictombs. I'd been wrong.

But I didn't think I was wrong about Grey.

As my thoughts turned to him, I realized that Grey had been gone for a couple minutes already. Considering how time functioned differently in the Relictombs, he should have been able to activate the relic and return already.

"What if it wasn't actually an ascension portal?" I muttered, fidgeting with the tip of the dagger's blade. Bending down, I peered at the half-relic, but it told me nothing.

Even if the portal did take him into a zone, it was possible he was in danger and hadn't been able to activate the other half of the relic…or perhaps we'd been wrong, and he couldn't immediately return. He could be trapped there, forced to clear the zone and find a descension portal before returning. The second half hadn't contained a crystal, which could mean—

I squinted against a bright amethyst light as the portal flared to life again, the ghostly outline solidifying into opaque pearlescence. The figure that appeared from it looked a lot like Grey, but his fine clothes were in tatters and his face was coated with blood and grime.

When he was clear of the portal, it dissolved into a cloud that slowly settled downward, condensing back into a crystal set within the relic.
“What…?”
Grey’s grime-caked face broke into a grin and he held up the black horn of some beast. A glob of dark blood dripped from it to splatter on the floor. “It works.”

353
PARADIGM SHIFT

ARTHUR LEYWIN

I kicked one leg over the rooftop's sheer ledge, leaning back against the crenelated wall and letting my attention wander across the Central Academy campus. Regis, back to his full strength in the form of a large shadow wolf, put his front paws atop the red stone merlon and let the cool breeze fan the flames of his mane.

It was still early morning and the campus was mostly dark, with a spray of pink and orange highlighting the distant horizon. Despite the hour, students were already active around the campus, exercising or working through drills. Flashes of occasional magic lit the campus like fireworks, but it was whisper quiet atop the tower. Perfect for thinking.

"So, you really think we should stay, huh?" Regis said, sniffing at the wind. "With the relic…"

I leaned my head back and stared into the blue-black sky. "The ascension half of the Compass stays in place when we enter the Relictombs. Even though we can come and go at will, we still need a safe place to activate it."

Regis looked back at me curiously, his glowing eyes intelligent. "And is this place really that safe? We could go back to Darrin Ordin, or hell, just find a cave in the mountains somewhere or something."

"That's another set of variables that I can't account for. Here, I know what to expect. We're at risk no matter where we go in Alacrya, but at least we have a story here, an identity."

As a professor, not only did I have a cover story and political protection, but I'd come to realize that the respect inherently offered to my position was its own kind of shield. Whatever curiosity or doubt my students and co-faculty might have about me, it was unlikely that they would ever suspect I was a Dicathian spy. There were a host of simpler explanations for any missteps I might make, and the wealthy and powerful would always assume any mystery somehow fit into their own pet intrigues.

"Besides, we don't fully understand the Compass yet."

Regis stretched before lying down lazily. "Don't we? It seems simple enough to me."

I took out the descension half of the Compass from my storage rune and stared idly at its curved and unblemished surface as if waiting for it to refute Regis.

He was right though. While one half of the relic created a portal into the Relictombs, the other allowed me to return, although not by creating a second portal. It had taken me some time to piece the functionality together, as the second half of the relic had not reacted in any way when I entered the Relictombs, forcing me to clear the zone. However, when I imbued aether into it near the zone's exit portal, the second half of the relic had blazed to life, outlining the portal with a brilliant light. When the glow faded, I could see my rooms on the other side, Caera waiting impatiently for me to return.

Being able to enter and leave the Relictombs at will changed everything. After the original test, Caera, Regis, and I had gone back in together to further explore the relic's capabilities, absorbing a significant amount of aether in the process.

“So, exactly how much grape juice can your core hold now?” Regis asked, obviously reading my thoughts.

Despite exploring the zone for an hour or more, and absorbing aether from both the beasts I killed and the atmosphere, I still hadn’t reached the two-layer core’s limit. “We’re not calling it that,” I said with an amused huff, “and I don’t really know. At least ten times more than before.”

Eager for any excuse to tap into that power, I withdrew the seed-pod toy from my dimension rune. My companion shifted to lie on his side, watching me work with a slightly bored air.

The size of my aether reservoir had never been the primary roadblock keeping me from completing Three Steps’ challenge, but the increased purity of my stored aether and efficiency of my aether channels only made focusing on it easier.

When I channeled aether to my hand to form the claw, I could feel the difference right away. First, the drain on my core wasn’t even noticeable. The form of the claw was steadier and more solid, and it felt inherently easier to focus. And while this claw was simply a step toward my real goal, it felt good to finally be making tangible progress.

Regis let out an exaggerated yawn, drawing my attention. Leaning lazily on his side, he made a show of extending and retracting his own, sharper and longer, claws.

I scoffed. “Show off.”

Taking the hard shell in one hand, I slid a claw into the slot and fished around for the seed within. As it settled into the hole left behind by the stem, I pulled downward, trying to force it out, just as I had done

dozens of times before. The claw held its form, automatically drawing on aether from my core to keep itself stable.

Releasing a slow, steadying breath, I imagined the shape of the claw extending and curving inward more deeply, almost wrapping around the small seed so that it fit perfectly within the curve. The aether responded quickly to my intention.

I grinned.

Then I pulled. Not too hard, but with a steady pressure that I slowly increased until the edges of the hole cracked and bulged outward, and I could feel the seed sliding through.

Then the pressure released.

The dull brown seed popped free and landed in my palm.

I stared down at it, imagining that the Shadow Claws had some ceremony to celebrate when one of their children completed this rite of passage. If I'd had more time in the Relictombs with Three Steps, perhaps she would have had some encouraging memory to share with me to congratulate me, but…

A gust of wind whipped across the tower roof and tugged at the seed, forcing me to close my hand tightly around it. It was a strange and sobering thought to realize that the result of my long efforts with the seed-pod could be blown away in an instant, leaving nothing behind.

I glanced around the barren rooftop and the idle streets below. Snow-capped mountains rose purple in the distance. The unfamiliar stars above were fading away, absorbed by the sunrise.

For a Shadow Claw cub, retrieving the seed would have meant securing a place in their tribe. For me, though, it was simply a reminder that I was without one.

"I mean if you *really* don't want it, I can take it off your hands," Regis said, sniffing eagerly at the small brown sphere.

Following his gaze, I looked more closely at the seed and noticed a nick in the plain brown surface. A subtle purple glimmer was shining through where my claw had dug into the seed. Using an aether claw, I scratched away more of the brown, revealing a solid orb of condensed aether within, it's signature entirely hidden away by the organic exterior.

As I stared at my prize, wondering just how much aether the seed contained, Regis's chin came to rest on my knee. His bright eyes were locked on the seed, and his head inched closer.

Thinking back to the aether-rich fruit that grew in the jungle zone where I'd fought the millipede, I popped the seed into my mouth and swallowed.

It burned going down and settled in my guts like a molten stone as the seed's aetheric core was broken apart and absorbed. My core thrummed as it accepted the rush of energy, and it was full in an instant.

It burned like a star in my solar plexus. I began to glow as a solid barrier of amethyst light shimmered across my skin, the aether threatening to escape. Flexing my intent, I felt the tower groan as its fortified stones and mortar strained against the pressure. The ambient aether buzzed to life, swirling like snowflakes around the rooftop.

“There’s a bit left over if you want it,” I said, snapping Regis out of his baffled daze.

My companion snapped his head away, scrunching his muzzle in a pout. “A god-made weapon of destruction like myself shouldn’t have to settle for second-hand scraps.”

Shaking my head, I closed my eyes and turned my attention inward, exploring my blazing core. “Suit yourself. I’ll take it all then.”

Regis placed a placating paw on my knee as he looked at me deadpan. “Many apologies, sir.”

“Smooth as gravel,” I smirked as the shadow wolf’s immaterial form merged with my body and began absorbing from the ocean of aether.

I stayed on the tower’s roof until mid-morning, watching the campus rouse while Regis was busy siphoning the remaining aether from the seed in me.

Bathing in the warm glow of the sun and my success, I descended the tower and headed toward my classroom. My steps felt light, as if I had been moving underwater all my life until now; the seed had contained significantly more aether than seemed possible, considering its size.

I took my time to cross the campus, reluctant to face a room full of coddled Alacryan teens. Instead, I focused on controlling the power that was straining to burst out of me. The second layer of my core wasn’t an additive growth to my aether reserves, it was exponential.

I could tell it would take time to adjust to the weight of it in my chest.

I had just passed the library when I caught sight of a familiar head of orange hair that faded out to bright yellow.

Briar was standing around with some other girls her age. One of them saw me and must have said something, because Briar turned and gave a small wave, causing her friends to giggle and tease her. Rolling her eyes at them, she broke away and walked quickly toward me.

"Hey, Professor," she said, bouncing on the balls of her feet with her hands clasped behind her back. "I just heard. Congratulations. I am *actually* a little bummed that I've already taken that stupid class, otherwise I'd sign up. Vritra knows you'll need good fighters."

I frowned, caught off guard. "Sorry, what are you…?"

Her face reflected my own confusion. "Wait, have you not…Oh. Sorry, I assumed…" One of her friends called to her, and her frown deepened. "Never mind. I'm sure you'll find out soon enough. Take care. And…good luck."

Just like that, Briar retreated and was folded back into the group of girls. Their heads bent together as they began to whisper, and Briar sent me one last uncertain look before they turned as a group and vanished into one of the many academy buildings I hadn't explored yet.

'What was that about?' Regis asked.

Not sure. I'd seen the serious young Alacryan a few times around campus since she'd first guided me across Cargidan, but she never made a point to have friendly conversation.

Shrugging off Briar's cryptic commentary, I turned toward the Striker complex, where my classroom was. I didn't make it far before I was brought up short by another familiar face, one I would never have expected to see at Central Academy.

Am I seeing things? I asked Regis.

Someone bumped into me from behind. When I turned a sharp eye on the person—a young man wearing darkened steel armor over his uniform—he winced. "Sorry, Professor."

I had to search for her in the crowd, as she was moving quickly, but she seemed to keep herself slightly apart from the stream of students, which made her stand out.

Walking even more quickly to catch up with her, I reached out and set a hand on her shoulder.

The young woman let out a surprised squeal and she spun around, her eyes wide and one hand going to cover her mouth.

"Mayla?"

I almost didn't recognize the young mage from Maerin Town. She had just been a girl, equal parts nervous and excitable, but here, she seemed transformed.

Her surprise bloomed into delight as she recognized me. "Ascender Grey! It's you! When I saw you listed as professor for the Melee Enhancement Tactics class, I had hoped, but then you didn't show up the first couple days, so I thought—I don't know—it was just a mistake or coincidence or something…" She trailed off as her cheeks turned red, reminding of her sister, Loreni, the first time we had met. Tucking a stray lock of auburn hair behind her ear, she said, "Sorry. I'm rambling."

“Mayla, what are you doing here?” I asked. “After the bestowment ceremony—”

“I went through a bunch of testing with the Ascenders Association,” she answered, “and they sent me here to be trained, because of my emblem. At first I was really scared and bummed, because it’s so far from Maerin Town, but it’s actually been okay.” She glanced at a few of the passing students out of the corner of her eye. “Except some of the highblood students aren’t very nice.”

“Wait,” I said as her rushed words wormed their way through my surprise. “Is your blood name Fairweather?”

“Yup, that’s me.” She gave me a small curtsey.

“I didn’t realize when I saw you listed on my class roster… but where were you last session?”

She kicked at the ground and gave me a sheepish smile. “Sorry, some of the other students were picking on the no names, y’know, and a nice boy tried to stick up for us, but then they only made fun of him, too, so I ended up leaving when I saw the professor—you weren’t there. Hoped that it would help the boy, too.” She shrugged. “It’s okay, though, honestly. I’ve learned so much already, it’s hard to believe it’s only been a few months.”

I began moving again, gesturing for her to walk with me as we headed for the class. “You’re a Sentry, right? So why take a non-magic fighting class?”

Her expression brightened again. “I’m taking *everything* I can. I may be a Sentry, but if I’m going to the Relictombs then I want to be able to defend myself. Besides, it’s been totally fascinating so far.”

Mayla kept up a steady dialogue, telling me about her other classes and professors, as well as her sister and the other people of Maerin. Apparently, the town had received an influx in resources as well as interest from academies all over Alacrya after Belmun and she had received such advanced runes.

"The Ascenders Association even voted to expand services at the descension portal in Maerin which will lead to a huge boom in trade and merchants, so my family is—"

I held up a hand, quieting her as we approached the end of the hall in front of my classroom.

A small crowd had gathered there, all trying to peek through the small window in search of something inside.

Caera was the first to notice me, her lips pressed into a stern expression.

My eyes narrowed when I realized that Kayden Aphelion was also there. I had not spoken to him since the night when he nearly caught me teleporting out of the Reliquary. My first thought was that he had told someone after all, and a group of armed guards—or perhaps even a Scythe, like Dragoth or Cadell—was waiting for me, but then I remembered Briar's congratulations.

When I saw the self-satisfied smirk on Professor Graeme's face, however, I was again unsure. "It's been a pleasure, Grey. Bad luck, really. Although, in my humble opinion, I would say that increasing the quality of this institution's faculty is never bad," he prattled before exchanging laughs with his associates nearby.

The rest of the professors broke up and moved away from my door, their expressions varying from pity to curiosity, with one old man

even giving me a hard nod before stepping back. Caera squeezed my shoulder, eyes hard but comforting.

Kayden leaned in close and whispered, "Don't let them take you down without a fight, aye?"

I paused, again picturing Cadell, Dragoth, or even Agrona himself standing in my classroom, waiting for me to arrive. Had the Scythes finally tracked me down?

'As if we'd be so lucky,' Regis said, now wide awake and practically humming with anticipation. *'Do you think we'd even need to break out Destruction to kick Dragoth's ass at this point? I mean, with that new dual-layer core of yours—'*

Like the other professors had done, I glanced through the small window in my door. And while it wasn't a Scythe waiting for me, what I saw didn't exactly settle my nerves.

Four figures were standing at the bottom of the stadium seats, near the training platform. Valen of Highblood Ramseyer was speaking to the director, his grandfather, who shared the same dusky complexion as Valen, but wore his nobility less pompously. The head of the Combat Department, Rafferty, was standing off slightly to the side. I assumed by his stance—still as a statue with his gaze downturned to his shoes—that he was uncomfortable about something.

The fourth man was lean and muscular. His dark hair was pulled into a topknot, and he had come dressed in leather armor dyed the black and azure of Central Academy. He wore a broad smile that showed too much teeth and nodded along with whatever Valen was saying.

"Professor? Should I—"

“Wait out here,” I instructed Mayla, only just remembering that she was still there.

When I entered the classroom, Valen ended his monologue in favor of narrowing his gaze and jutting his chin. The stranger immediately turned his attention to me, his slate-gray eyes crawling across me as they studied me hungrily.

Director Ramseyer broke the silence. “Professor Grey. Come in. We do not mean to ambush you in your classroom, but a runner sent to your private suite this morning was unable to reach you.” Although the words were polite, his tone was clipped and sharp with reproach. “Now that you are here, however, we have a most serious matter to discuss.”

“Which is?” I asked, allowing my concern to come through in my voice.

“It has come to my attention”—Director Ramseyer shot Valen a pointed glance—“that your behavior toward this class has been less than attentive, Professor Grey. This is unacceptable at the best of times, but now more than ever it is essential that a competent teacher is available to guide the Melee Enhancement Tactics students.”

I stood tall, my shoulders loose as my hands clasped together behind me. “And why is that, if you don’t mind my asking?”

The director, who himself stood ramrod straight, inspected me closely before answering. “In different circumstances, I would be here to congratulate you.” He paused, letting the moment linger. “As you likely know, Vechor will host the Victoriad this year. Melee

Enhancement Tactics has been selected as one of the classes to compete."

I opened my mouth to ask why, but Regis growled a quick mental warning to stop me.

'The Victoriad is this huge tournament that brings Alacryans from every dominion to compete, mostly in combat. The type or class of combat is chosen by raffle, so intermediate non-magical combat must have been one of the classes picked.'

"I see," I said out loud. *Piss poor luck for us, though.*

'It's worse than that. The tournament mostly focuses on the Scythes and their retainers,' Regis continued. *'Challenges are sanctioned by the Sovereigns, allowing a sufficiently powerful or connected mage to challenge an old Scythe or retainer for their place. Uto survived a dozen challenges over the years. The Victoriad is the last place we want to be.'*

I met and held Director Ramseyer's eyes, crossing my arms and cocking my head to the side slightly. "I understand why you might want to make a change. Am I to assume that this man"—I bobbed my head in the direction of the stranger—"is to take my place?"

"Indeed," the director confirmed matter-of-factly. "This is Drekker of Highblood Vassere. He has been Valen's private tutor for several years now, and is an excellent fighter. He has offered to lead this class in their preparation for the Victoriad, and I have accepted. He will start immediately, and you will be given—"

"I would like a chance to defend my post," I said evenly.

Regis sighed in resignation. *'My words might as well be a fleeting fart to you.'*

The director squinted at me, frowning slightly. He seemed more intrigued than angry. “Please explain.”

Before I could speak, the door into the classroom banged open and Enola strode in, looking extremely irritated. When she saw the director and department head, however, she froze. Director Augustine held up a hand and said, “Please wait outside a moment, Miss Frost.”

“Let her stay,” I said, gesturing to the door. “In fact, let them come in and watch.”

“Watch what?” Rafferty asked, though his attention was on the director, not me.

“Let’s fight for it,” I said, looking past Valen and the director toward the tutor. “You need someone who has been in actual combat and can show the students how important being able to defend themselves without magic really is.”

“Excuse me?” my would-be replacement snapped, his aloof pompousness falling away. “I’ll have you know that I—”

“Let them watch our duel. It’ll give them confidence in whoever wins.”

Director Ramseyer rubbed his chin, his gaze flicking to the door where the students were starting to gather.

“Grandfather, this is preposterous. You can’t expect Drekker to—”

The director waved for silence, causing Valen’s mouth to practically snap shut.

“Yes, an excellent idea, Professor Grey.” To Drekker, he said, “I am confident in your abilities, but showing them to the students will build excitement for the transition.”

Drekker bowed. "I am at your service, Director Ramseyer."

'You know, being able to read your mind only makes you more *confusing.'*

I gestured for the students waiting outside in the hall to enter. Enola slowly descended the stairs while the rest of the class filtered in, including Mayla. There was some confused chatter as people saw the director and department head, but at my signal, they all found their seats and quieted down.

The director stepped forward and introduced himself for the benefit of any students who had never met him before, then explained what was about to happen. A nervous tension settled over them, but I didn't think it was for my benefit.

Most of their attention was firmly on Valen's tutor as Director Ramseyer motioned him to step forward. "I know it is untraditional for the academy to step in and change a professor mid-season, and for this reason, I would like to more fully introduce Drekker of Highblood Vassere. Hailing from Sehz-Clar, Drekker has spent his entire life perfecting the art of combat as a Striker.

"An ascender, a soldier, a trainer, a tutor… you will find yourselves in very good hands with Professor Vassere."

'But has he had his limbs blown off and regrown, bathed in lava, or been shat out an insect's rectum like we have?' Regis asked in a snippety tone. *'I think not.'*

Well put, I thought, holding back a smile as I watched the students.

Most of them had taken Melee Enhancement Tactics to goof off, not to learn how to fight, and I could tell from the nervous looks that several of them were already thinking about dropping the class.

Those who were most excited—Enola, in particular, seemed about to burst out of her skin—were giving appraising looks to their potential new professor.

'You act like you care what they think of you,' Regis pointed out fairly.

'The real question is… what the hell are you doing?'

I've just found another reason I need to stay as a professor.

I could feel my companion roll his eyes, but no other words were said.

"Now, if our combatants would please enter the ring," the director announced, standing off to the side to allow a clear view for the students. "Let's see who is best fit to prepare this class for the Victoriad."

Drekker and I mounted the raised platform from opposing sides. The man had stopped grinning the moment I walked in the door, but now he was giving me a confident smirk. Making sure I was watching, he quickly shifted between multiple stances, his feet practically dancing across the platform. "Are you a proponent of the Vechorian guard stance or forward basilisk stance?"

Ignoring his question, I take a slow, measured breath, making sure my strength is restrained and I'm in control.

Director Ramseyer's voice rang through the classroom. "Begin."

Drekker's feet flickered as his body swayed. I could see him raise his brows in curiosity behind his raised fists. "I implore you to get into a proper stance. Better yet, I give you the first move."

I nodded as I put strength into my legs. "My apologies, this isn't personal."

The length between us disappeared as my fist slammed into my wide-eyed opponent, who was barely able to guard in time. Pivoting forward, I brought my right foot between Drekker's legs and drove my elbow into the side of his head. Two strikes to the jaw and one to his ear, and Valen's tutor hits the ground. I pinned one knee down under his collarbone as my other foot locked an arm in place.

My eyes flashed up to the director, waiting for him to call the match. Drekker flailed about, but only succeeded in slamming his forehead into my shin.

"I think that is *quite* enough, Professor Grey. It would appear there is more to you than I was told." Director Ramseyer gave his grandson another pointed look. The boy had enough sense to look chagrined.

Releasing Drekker, I got up to my feet and offered him a hand.

Hair disheveled and face already beginning to swell, Valen's tutor gave me a hard stare before accepting my hand and pulling himself up.

"I might've refuted if I thought I had a chance," he acknowledged meekly.

Allowing a faint smile, I let go of his rough, calloused hand. "You have a strong guard."

Hopping down from the training platform, I turned my attention to the students. Most were watching with open-mouthed surprise. Mayla beamed at me, while Enola was looking at me with a newfound flicker of respect. Seth, I noticed, wasn't watching me, but was looking down at his own clenched fists.

Still, it was Valen who surprised me. The highblood boy didn't sneer or scowl like I might have expected. Instead, he calmly took a seat

next to Portrel and Remy, shushing them when they began to whisper frantically, and waited.

I rubbed the back of my neck. “Let’s get started.”

354
SOMEWHAT TEACHING

HOLDING OUT THE HALF-SPHERE RELIC, I imbued a small amount of aether into it. The relic flared to life, burning with a quicksilver glow that coalesced around the zone's exit portal. The opaque field of energy rippled and became clear as glass. It was like looking through a window into my rooms at Central Academy.

I gestured for Caera to go first.

"I'd call you a gentleman but I know you're using me as a test rodent for your new toy," she said with a smirk before disappearing through the portal, immediately becoming visible again on the other side.

Walking through it was as seamless as going through a door. There was no discomfort or sense of vertigo, as people sometimes felt when using the teleportation gates around Dicathen. It felt strange to move so smoothly from the Relictombs into my clean, mostly empty rooms at the academy.

Caera was standing in the middle of the room, her scarlet eyes tracking my every movement as I bent down to deactivate the ascension portal. When both of the pieces were pressed together, they made a faint *click* and reconnected, forming a perfect sphere. I stored the Compass in my dimension rune.

"I'm sorry it didn't work, Grey," she said finally, her gaze softening.

"It's fine," I grunted. "It will, eventually."

Caera gave me a tight-lipped smile and waved a hand across her body, which was covered with spatters of dried blood and black gore. "Anyway, I better go get cleaned up." She glanced out the

window, where light was already creeping across the campus. "Looks like we were in there for most of the night. Class is soon."

"You should probably clean up here," I pointed out, gesturing toward the bathroom connected to my bedroom. "It might raise a few eyebrows if anyone sees you roaming the building covered in blood."

Caera looked at the ceiling as if charting a path from my room to hers. "Good point."

After handing her a fresh towel, I sat down at the Sovereigns Quarrel board and mindlessly prodded the pieces.

'Maybe it didn't work because Sylvie is an asura and we were in the Relictombs?' Regis asked, picking up on my own half-formed thoughts.

No, I thought. *It felt the same as before, just after I'd formed the aether core. Except now, instead of putting buckets of water into a lake, I'm dumping lakes into an ocean.*

With my aetheric reserves having grown ten-fold by fortifying my core with a second layer of binding aether, I had thought for sure I could break the second seal within Sylvie's stone. I was wrong. Instead, I had watched as all the power I had gathered—both from the Relictombs itself and the seed of Three Steps' dried-fruit toy—disappeared into the vast depths of the runic framework, draining away like sand through a sieve.

But you're right, I continued, closing my eyes and letting myself sink into the soft mattress. *We shouldn't try it in the Relictombs again. We don't know what'll happen if a full-blooded asura emerges from inside.*

Caera appeared from the bathing room a few minutes later, scoured clean of the grime and clad in fresh clothing. "It just occurred to me while I was in your shower that my leaving your room in the early hours of the morning, freshly bathed, might start just as many rumors as if I were covered in blood," she said matter-of-factly.

"Less damaging rumors," I said.

She frowned down at me, one brow raised. "For you, perhaps. But then, *you* are not a highblood lady with a reputation to maintain."

I tilted my head, holding her gaze. "Do you want me to open the portal so you can cover yourself in blood again?"

Caera deflated and wearily waved my words away. "Have a good day in class, Grey."

When she was gone, Regis's voice filled my head. *'It's impressive, you know?'*

What? I asked, sensing some trap in his words.

'How you can be so good and so bad with women at the same time.'

It was obvious how much the mood within the Melee Enhancement Tactics class had changed as I walked down the steep stairs of the room.

After it was established that they would be competing at the Victoriad—in front of retainers, Scythes, and Sovereigns—students began to arrive early, even those who had mocked the idea of learning to fight without magic only a few days ago were eagerly waiting with their peers.

Enola and her subservient friend, Laurel of Named Blood Redcliff—Professor Abby's niece, I found out—had taken up most of the training platform, while the rest had paired up with one another and were spread throughout the classroom, sparring awkwardly.

'What… are they doing?' Regis asked, disturbed and unsettled.

My brows furrowed in confusion as I watched the students.

These were mostly highbloods from powerful houses—including several from Vechor, where young men and women were trained to be soldiers from the moment they could walk—but only a couple of them seemed to have any idea of what they were doing.

Their punches and kicks were lacking, like they were play fighting with a toddler. Of the entire class, only Valen, Enola, and Marcus of Highblood Arkwright looked like they were actually sparring.

I let out a scoff in realization. "They're not using mana."

Alacryans awakened as mages earlier than Dicathians, so it made sense that the majority of their training before attending Central Academy relied on mana to fuel their movements and attacks, rather than muscles and technique.

"Professor Grey!"

I turned my gaze to see Mayla scurrying up the stairs toward me, brows lined with sweat.

"You'll be teaching today, right? Seth has been showing me some of the exercises he read about in a book to help us warm up for your lesson!"

"Seth?" I felt a small pinch in my chest at the name, my face involuntarily scrunching into a grimace.

I had kept Seth far back in my mind. It was easier to ignore his existence than continuously trying to convince myself that I was justified in despising him for his sister's actions during the war.
After all, it had led to countless elves being enslaved and eventually the decimation of Elenoir.
Who cares if it wasn't directly his fault.
His family got what they deserved…
'Even if Seth was personally the one that charted the path to Elenoir instead of his sister, let's not forget, you did some terrible things as a soldier in the war. too,' Regis said, his voice tinged with annoyance.
I know that… I know. Just…
I rubbed my temples, walking past Mayla. My eyes shifted away from Seth, who was struggling to do push-ups. I made my way toward the office, ignoring the stares of the students I passed until I was stopped by a figure standing in front of my door.
Enola had her arms crossed, eyes staring icily at me even as sweat rolled down her face.
"Is there a problem?"
She lowered her arms and let out a scoff. "It's been days since it was announced that our class would be in the Victoriad, and you haven't done anything besides tell us to exercise our bodies."
I raised a brow, jerking my head over my shoulder. "It looks like you all are doing more than that already. I don't think sparring was part of the regimen."
Enola clenched her hands tightly as she stepped forward. "Because we'll be fighting in the Victoriad for Vritra's sake! We have to do *something*!"

“And you’re free to do whatever you want,” I responded coolly. “This facility is at your disposal. I’m not holding you back.”

“That’s…that’s not what I meant.” The Frost blood’s heir lowered her head, her shoulders sagging. “Train us. Show us how we can fight like how you did against Valen’s tutor.”

I hesitated, looking away from her pitiful display when my eyes caught sight of Seth once more.

Annoyance and resentment flared as I turned my head back and stepped around Enola. I opened the door when I felt a small tug at my elbow.

“Please,” Enola whispered, her voice quivering faintly.

I waited, silently hoping that Regis would crack a joke or just remind me of the justifications I had made before that were eluding me right now. And for once, he didn’t have anything to say.

I looked back, regretting it immediately. Regretting having to see how the students all looked at me with hopeful eyes, Valen even going as far as bowing slightly along with his friends. Seth stood and peered from the corner of his eye, too afraid to look directly at me, while Mayla smiled meekly.

‘You made the right choice,’ Regis thought.

Who said I made a choice, I replied, gently removing Enola’s hand.

‘That stubborn brain of yours,’ my companion responded with a chuckle.

I shook my head and faced the class. “Everyone on the training platform!”

The kids dropped everything and rushed to the elevated platform, Enola somehow being the first one there despite the fact that she had just been next to me.

I made my way toward the crowd, scratching the back of my head and trying not to think about whether or not I had made the right choice.

Inside the ring, Enola had sat down with Laurel while Valen, Remy, and Portrel were close behind. One by one, my eyes scanned the rest of the students, recalling how they had sparred with each other.

Marcus and Sloane, both Vechorians, had been training together with similar styles, a close-in form of combat utilizing hard-hitting knees and elbows. Another of the students from Vechor, Brion of Named Blood Bloodworth had been sparring with the kid he was sitting next to now, a tanned, blonde boy from Etril named Linden.

Linden looked more like a farmer than a fighter and his swings were messy and wide compared to Brion, who had obviously had some level of training.

Out of all of the students watching me eagerly like baby chicks, only Deacon seemed uninterested sitting next to Yanick in the back, his face hidden behind a book.

I let out a sigh. "What would you get if you injected babies with the muscles of a veteran warrior?"

Raising my right hand, I pointed my finger at the class. "You."

This statement was met with a mixture of responses, ranging from confusion to annoyance and even anger.

'That's one way to get them fired up for class,' Regis responded.

“Simply put, you guys might as well be punching with your wrists,” I said, demonstrating with a flick of my own wrist. “And the only reason why it’s been working is because you have enough mana to make even that hurt.”

Enola bolted up to her feet, her mouth already open, but I cut her off. “I’m not here to stroke your ego or make class fun and exciting,” I said. “I’m going to be teaching one thing today. Whether you choose to listen is up to you.”

“Throwing a punch takes your whole body, starting not from the swing of your arms, but from the ball of your feet.” I swiveled my right foot slowly and pointed to my hips. “Like a tornado, you generate momentum from your leg, rotating your hip and letting power build up as you turn your shoulder and explode your fist forward. Any questions?”

To my surprise, it was Valen’s hand that shot up first. “Can you show us a demonstration using a target?”

“No,” I deadpanned. “Pair up and demonstrate on yourselves.”

Two days later, when I entered my room for the next class, I was surprised to find half the students already waiting for me. Rafferty, head of the Melee Combat Department, was also there, sitting in the row closest to the training platform.

Enola was standing in front of him, throwing the same punch I had shown the class last session.

“—starts in the foot, legs and hips, like this…” I overheard her say as I made my way down the stairs. Her eyes lit up as she made her way to me.

“I’ve been practicing the punch you taught us, and you were right! The force score on my impact gauge artifact more than doubled after reading my punch, and it’s continuing to improve,” she said excitedly while showing me her battered knuckles.

“I-I see,” I responded, caught off guard by her excitement. Turning to Rafferty, I gave him a small bow, only glancing at the stack of parchment in his hand.

“Just here for a standard inspection, nothing to worry about, Professor Grey. Miss Frost here was just filling me in on your last lesson,” the department head said with a cough.

I gave him a hollow smile before heading to the bottom of the bleacher-style seats. While I waited for the rest of the students to arrive, I listened to the din of conversation coming from the class. Mayla was sitting halfway up the bleacher-style seats between Seth and Linden, the only other student in Melee Enhancement Tactics who was from Etril.

“Do you think you’ll get a second rune during the bestowal?” Linden was asking Mayla. “It’s still hard to believe you got an emblem as your first rune…”

Mayla looked down sheepishly. Although she was confident and energetic toward classwork, she seemed to struggle when it came to communicating with the other students.

“I don’t really know,” she finally answered. “Everyone who hears about how I got the…rune is always so surprised. No one has ever heard of it happening like that.”

Linden was shaking his head, his mouth slightly open. “You’re so lucky. On the verge of being unadorned, then *wham!* Emblem.”

Mayla twirled a lock of hair around her finger absentmindedly. “Yeah…”

Marcus leaned back in his chair and looked over his shoulder at the pair. “My first rune was a crest. Personally, I’m hoping for a second one during this bestowal. Not as impressive as an emblem”—he gave a little nod to Mayla, who blushed—“but if I can get a second one early, it’s realistic that I could have a third rune while still at the academy.”

“According to my grandfather,” Valen interjected from several seats away, drawing the attention of nearly everyone in the room, “fewer than ten percent of students manage three runes before graduating, but that’s still higher than nearly any other academy in Alacrya.”

Marcus shrugged nonchalantly, as if he didn’t find these numbers troublesome in the least.

“I already have my second,” Enola said, taking a seat in the front row. “A crest during my first bestowal at the academy.”

Rafferty cleared his throat, and all eyes turned toward him. “Remember, the bestowment ceremony is a time for introspection, and your bestowal is a reflection of your effort to master both mind and mana. Focus less on what you will receive, and more on what you have done to earn it. Professor Grey, please start.”

My eyes swept over the students waiting for me to speak. “Last class, I taught you how to throw a proper punch. This time, you’ll work on how to properly dodge.”

A hand went up. It was Mayla.

“I’m sorry, Professor, but is it possible to review your lesson from the last class? I want to make sure that I’m doing it correctly,” she asked with her hand still up in the air.

“No. Ask your classmates, make some friends,” I replied as Yanick slipped through the door, the last to arrive. Before he could take more than a couple of steps, I waved him down to the floor. “Yanick, good timing. You’re up first.”

He frowned with concern, but made his way down the steps to stand beside me.

“I’m going to throw two punches at you. A straight right at your face, then a left hook at your ribs,” I informed him.

“Huh?”

I raised my fists. “Dodge.”

Stepping forward, I threw my right fist straight at his face. Despite his initial surprise, Yanick was still able to step back away from my reach.

Pivoting on my right foot, I swung my left fist in a wide hook.

Yanick took another step back to dodge.

I turned back to the class, who were watching from the bleachers. “What did Yanick do wrong?”

“He had too much wasted movement,” Valen answered promptly.

“Correct.” I turned to Yanick once more. “Again.”

My little sparring partner nodded seriously, readying himself this time.

I punched again, limiting both my speed and power. This time, the young Alacryan leaned away from the cross rather than jumping back, then parried the hook.

"Faster."

I repeated the exercise, and Yanick's response was the same, lean back before parrying the hook. The third time, his jerking lean back forced him to take an unplanned step, and he only barely got his hand down in time to intercept my hook.

My fist landed solidly in his side on the fourth repetition, just hard enough to knock the wind out of him.

The boy let out a cough as I turned to the rest of the class. "Learning to dodge effectively means that you not only cause your opponent to miss, but also create an opportunity for you to attack at the same time."

The students looked at me with renewed interest; even Deacon had put down his book to pay attention.

"Who would like to go next," I said, waving Yanick away. The boy's braids bobbed as he hopped off the platform before taking a seat.

A couple of hands went up, with Enola practically waving her hand to be picked.

"Valen," I said, turning toward the highblood.

Portrel let out a cheer, but Valen's cool look quieted the larger boy.

"You understand what to do by now?" I asked, adopting my stance.

Valen nodded as he slid back into a stance I recognized as the Vechorian guard stance from my short duel with his tutor, Drekker.

When I threw my cross, he leaned forward, and his elbow fell down to block the hook.

I took a step back. “Take note of how small Valen’s movements are. By leaning into the first punch, Valen is setting himself up to both block the hook with a smaller movement than Yanick’s parry, and to be inside my guard for a counter.”

I raised my fists. “Let’s see if he can do it faster.”

Valen and I went several more rounds, with each combination coming quicker and quicker. Finally, his initial in-step was too shallow, and my cross clipped him on the cheek, nearly knocking him to the floor.

Despite seeing the headmaster’s grandson get hit, Rafferty seemed unaffected as his pen continued to blur across the parchment as he took notes.

“Everyone pair up. Go back and forth, trading off as attacker and defender. Attackers, start at half speed and work your way up.”

“Thank you for the lesson,” Valen said with a bow before walking away.

‘It’s so boring now that the kids are so obedient,’ Regis groused.

Are my lessons too basic for the mighty god weapon of destruction? I asked with a chuckle.

‘Yes, as well as anatomically useless for me. So unless you’re going to start teaching your students to fight on all fours, I’m going to take a nap,’ he answered as his presence faded.

The rest of the session passed quickly, and most of the students seemed genuinely surprised when I announced their dismissal.

“Get out of here,” I shooed impatiently.

“Thanks, Professor,” Marcus said as he led the way up the stairs. A couple of the others nodded. Mayla flashed me a wide grin and waved as she took the broad steps two at a time.

Rafferty was on his feet, his papers tucked beneath his arm. He quickly adjusted his black and azure suit. “Your teachings are…unusual, but effective. It looks like I won’t have to worry too much, Professor Grey.”

“Appreciated,” I said as the head of the Melee Combat Department marched up the stairs and out of my classroom.

I made myself busy putting things away and shutting everything up. I was almost done when I felt someone watching me.

“Were you going to announce yourself, or just stand there acting all creepy?” I mused, closing and locking my office door.

Caera was leaning against the doorframe.

“I was just a bit stunned watching you clean,” she said with a hand over her mouth. “I am unaccustomed to you looking so domestic.”

‘Domestic indeed,’ Regis chortled.

I sighed. “If you’re going to poke fun, at least help while doing it.”

“I’m here for something else,” Caera said, straightening. “With the bestowment ceremony starting tomorrow, classes are suspended for the next few days…”

“I know,” I said, feigning nonchalance. “I’ll finally have time to do those errands that I’ve pushed back, along with some other domestic chores.”

Caera rolled her eyes. “Don’t be a tease. We’re going in, right?”

A smile formed on the corner of my lips. “Of course.”

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JUST HIS NAME

TESSIA ERALITH

Lifting my hand, I reveled in the response of the mana. The red particles jumped and danced, full of energy. The yellow hovered low to the ground, rolling and tumbling like tiny stones. The blue mana washed over me like the incoming tide and clung to my skin like dew. The green ones were my favorite, though. They had a cutting quality, like a sharp blade, whipping and snapping like the wind they represented, but there was also something cool and clean about them. The wind mana was both hard and soft at the same time.

I was standing on a nameless plateau, high in the Basilisk Fang Mountains. Not far from Taegrin Caelum. There was nothing around for miles that I could accidentally destroy…but I wasn't out here because Agrona feared I might lose control. Rather, he knew the extent of my power, and he wanted me to let loose.

Reaching into the sky, I focused on the mana, pulling it to a specific point high above. Water and wind condensed, smashing into each other to build into a huge, black storm cloud that darkened the mountains for miles all around us.

My small audience watched in silence. Nico was there, of course, along with three of the other Scythes. Draneeve, Nico's attendant and a few other ranking figures from the fortress had come as well. Agrona hadn't, but I'd never seen him leave the castle before.

Fire mana drifted up from the sun-warm stones and fused into white, hot bolts of lightning that crashed back down to shatter boulders and cast shrapnel across my training ground. Water condensed into

ice, which began to fall like catapult stones to smash craters into the hard mountain soil.

Even at the height of my strength on Earth, I'd never been able to do anything like this with ki.

My memories had been much more stable in the weeks since Agrona promised I could leave his fortress. He said that I would begin to feel more like myself the longer I was in this body. The runes covering my flesh helped hold me together, helped keep the other voice quiet.

Wind mana coalesced into wide, cutting streams that wove around me like a dragon, separating me from the others. Wind, both soft and hard…

My life—my previous life—had required me to harden myself to endure the constant and torturous training I had received. But there had always been a piece of myself that I kept in my heart, that piece where I had felt loving warmth for the first time in my life, and it was that warmth that maintained me until…

I refocused on the mana, recoiling from the shattered remnants of those memories. I still couldn't remember my death, and Nico had only said I would learn about it in time.

Nico…

I glanced at where he stood, watching me cast spells, his dark hair lashing his face. I couldn't help but notice how he stood well away from the others. Poor Nico, an outsider even here.

Draneeve clapped his hands and shouted into the wind, his mask giving his voice a grating quality that I found uncomfortable to listen to. Nico motioned for Draneeve's silence, and the masked man

stopped shouting, though he continued with a slow, inconsistent applause.

Reaching out, I tugged at the corners of the huge storm and drew it inward and downward until it hovered just above me, hardly the size of an apple tree. The creation, moments ago a deadly manifestation of raw power, was now something entirely different. Tiny, winged creatures made of air wheeled within the clouds, while little watery dolphins jumped and splashed below them.

It was beautiful. *Mana* was beautiful. Ki had been energy, capable of being gathered and unleashed but never really *formed*, not in the same way mana could take shape. This was real magic.

My attention twitched nervously over to the three who stood apart from the rest: the Scythes. Technically, Nico was one of them, but they held him apart, or he kept his distance. Or both.

Their varying shades of gray skin, black horns, and red eyes all served to define them as something firmly *other*. Their gazes held both curiosity and unease, like an audience watching a lion tamer at a circus. It made me believe what Nico kept telling me: they *knew* I'd be stronger than them eventually.

"Very, very well done!" Draneeve piped up in his purposefully grating voice. "You've grown so much more quickly than Lord Nico. Barely weeks in the skinny elf girl's body and you're—"

There was a loud *crack*.

Draneeve straightened his mask—a plain white thing with small holes for eyes and a crudely drawn smile—and rubbed the side of his head where Nico had backhanded him. I frowned at Nico, who had

the good grace to at least look embarrassed. He hated Draneeve, I knew, but he wouldn't tell me why.

Cadell and Dragoth were watching Nico.

Dragoth was enormous, as large as any man I'd ever seen, but he was otherwise cut from a familiar cloth. When I was rising through the ranks in the King's Crown tournament, there were many like him. Cocky, self-absorbed warriors. Quick to laugh at their own jokes, and quick to fight at any perceived insult.

Cadell was stranger, scarier. He had a cold and cruel face, like the sharp side of an axe, but was businesslike in his manners. I didn't like him.

But it was the third Scythe who I found most interesting. I'd only met her once before, and that was brief. Although she looked young—twenty at the most—there was a deep, curious wisdom in her eyes, and a worldly intelligence. I felt like she was dissecting me with her dark eyes, both then and now. Unlike her counterparts, she was still watching me. Not my spell, with it's silly wind-gulls and water-dolphins, but me.

Looking into her eyes, it was almost like I could see the gears behind them turning, trying to figure me out. Did she see me as a threat? A tool? I wasn't sure.

"Nico," Cadell said, his tone full of frost and fire, "be nice to your pet. After all, it is Draneeve who returned you from that awful continent." Draneeve fidgeted, his attitude unreadable behind his ugly mask.. "He'd be a general now, perhaps even a retainer, if he hadn't retreated from Dicathen to save your ungrateful hide."

My spell faded away, the cloud dissolving to mist and then to nothing as I waited for Nico to respond. He clenched his fists and took a step away from Draneeve. “Don’t speak to me like I’m your lesser, Cadell. I’m a Scythe too, remember?”

Dragoth grinned, his teeth shining white as moonlight through his beard. “You are right, little Nico. You are a Scythe. And the name Scythe meant a little less the day we counted you among our number.” He laughed loudly at his own joke, but didn’t stop there. “Perhaps Bivrae should be a Scythe, or even Draneeve!” he said, practically shouting, his grin turning predatory.

Nico sneered. “And where was the mighty Dragoth during the war? Tell me, Titan of Vechor, why was it your retainer went to Dicathen and died while you stayed safe and—”

“Be careful what you say next,” Dragoth growled, his smile dropping quickly. He took a step toward Nico, his huge muscles bulging.

The ground swelled as a twisting, thorn-covered vine erupted between them, quickly expanding into a wicked briar fence. I hadn’t meant to cast a spell at all, but I was agitated by their fighting. My defensive instinct always veered toward plant magic, even when other elements would make more sense.

Dragoth leaned forward, resting both arms on the thorn-covered vines. “You are young and little, yet already at the peak of your power, reincarnate.”

Nico’s head tilted to the side. His eyes were cold as dead coals. “Everyone who might hope to challenge me is already here,” he said softly before turning to me. “It’s clear that you are ready to go.

We've waited long enough—at Lord Agrona's insistence, of course," he added quickly, shooting a sour look at Cadell.

"Your ability to mold mana is impressive," Scythe Seris said, her razorblade gaze cutting me apart bit by bit, "but don't be clouded by what's in front of you. Keep your eyes and ears open and do not reach beyond your grasp."

"She is the Legacy," Nico countered darkly. "The stars themselves are not beyond her grasp."

My first experience of this world was the forest homeland of the elven people. Its strangeness was lost on me. I was too confused and astonished by my own reincarnation to pay much attention to their enchanted forest. Even the appearance of the three-eyed giant—an asura, I reminded myself—had failed to impress upon me the *otherworldliness* of my new home.

It was in Taegrin Caelum when I began to understand how different this place really was from Earth. But there, everything I learned was filtered by Agrona. It wasn't until Nico led me into the Relictombs that I appreciated the full depth of the strange and wonderful differences between the two worlds.

Agrona's private portal could connect to any other in Alacrya, allowing us to teleport much too close to our destination. I would have liked to explore, to spend time taking it all in as we meandered across the second level of the Relictombs. The sky alone nearly took my breath away as I gazed up into the vast blue expanse. I thought my storm had been an impressive piece of magic, but this…

I knew logically that the sky itself was a magical construct, but I couldn't understand it. It seemed incomprehensible that anyone could create such a thing. When I shared this thought with Nico, he ignored me, focused instead on bullying his way through the crowds of armored men and women around us.

"Are you entirely immune to the wonders of this world?" I asked, keeping pace beside him. "You might've gotten accustomed to all of this, but I've only recently arrived here."

"We have someplace to be," he snapped. He must have seen me frown from the corner of his eye, because he slowed down a little. "I'm sorry, Cecil. I'm…a bit agitated. Lord Agrona hinted that what we'll find here might be important to me, but he's left out any sort of details and…" He trailed off, wincing. "I'm sorry, it's not your fault. I'm just impatient to speak to these judges."

"No, I'm sorry," I said, feeling immediately guilty for my choice of words. He'd told me at length about his lives, both what it was like for him after my involuntary induction into the King's Crown tournament and his divided life here. "I didn't mean to make light of what you've been through."

"I know," was all he said.

I followed along silently as Nico led us straight as an arrow toward a large, intimidating building of dark stone and black spines. It looked a little like a huge porcupine with an army of gargoyles clinging to its back.

A woman with a head of hair like a beacon fire was waiting for us in front of the building. She was wrapped in dark robes embroidered

with a golden sword and scales. Her eyes stayed on her shoes as we approached, and even when she began to speak, she did not look up. “It is a great honor to welcome a representative of the High Sovereign.” Her tone was authoritative, even when she tried to be subservient. “Although, I must admit, we expected you sooner.”

Nico marched past her, and she spun around to follow, keeping just slightly farther back from him than I was. “The High Sovereign has little time for such trifling things as a few corrupt judges. I’m still not sure why a Scythe was needed at all,” Nico said briskly.

I wanted to look around, but we were walking too quickly for me to really take the place in. I nearly laughed when I saw a giant fresco of a man I assumed was supposed to be Agrona. It seemed like the artists had never even seen him, but I realized quickly that was a possibility. Then we were past it, with neither Nico nor the red-haired woman taking any notice.

Nico stopped at a black iron door, tapping his fingers impatiently while waiting for the high justice to open it. Waving her mana-swathed hand in front of the door, she motioned us toward a dimly lit stairway made of dark stone and gray tiles. Nico took the lead again, descending the stairs rapidly. By the time we reached the bottom, he was marching at an uncomfortable speed, forcing the high justice and I to practically jog to keep up with him.

A maze of narrow tunnels opened up to our left and right, lined with barred cell doors. In the closest cell to the stairs, a raggedy woman leaned forward into the torchlight, saw Nico, and immediately ducked back into the shadows, her face twisting as if she’d just seen a demon.

Nico ignored the branching tunnels as he led us straight down the middle path.

Then, something clicked.

His standoffishness, the way he was practically ignoring me after spending the last three weeks working tirelessly to prove to Agrona that I was ready, his ill temper… Nico was anxious about this interrogation.

It was hardly a stretch to say that my once-fiancé was always anxious, but he had gone rigid, every movement stiff and awkward, and he wouldn't even look at me. He wasn't merely anxious; he was dreading whatever was to come.

The hallway ended in a pair of wide iron doors, black as night and entirely covered in silvered runes. They looked like they could keep a rampaging rhinoceros inside. Despite their size, though, they swung open all by themselves as the high justice approached, revealing a large, circular room on the other side.

My stomach did a flip.

"What did these people do to deserve this?" I asked, averting my eyes.

Inside the cell, five figures hung spread-eagle from the ceiling by their wrists and ankles. Bronze bands covered their mouths. Although there was mana in the chains and gags, I couldn't sense anything from the prisoners. Either their mana was being suppressed or—I swallowed hard—their mana cores had been destroyed.

"They colluded with a noble house to convict an innocent man of a crime he didn't commit," the high justice said firmly. "Their blatant

abuse of authority for their own personal gain deserves this and worse."

I stepped toward the cell, despite not being entirely sure I even wanted to, but Nico stopped me. He reached out to touch my arm, but stopped. "I think it would be better if you waited out here."

I was almost relieved. Taking a step back, I nodded. Once he and the high justice were inside, the doors began to close. At the last moment, as his eyes turned away from mine, his face changed, hardening like it was carved out of pale marble. Then he was gone, and I watched as yellow mana particles raced along the grooves between the doors, ceiling, and floor.

There was a wooden stool next to the doors, so I sat down. My mind kept fluttering back to the manaless figures in the room. I'd had my own mana core for such a short period of time, but still the idea of losing it terrified me beyond words. To discover that mana exists—and learn how to restructure the physical world with a thought—only to lose that power…

The Alacryans couldn't have understood. Even Agrona, even Nico…

On Earth, I had learned early on that, although I had a relatively large ki center, that power would never be mine to wield. I *was* the weapon. That's what they thought the Legacy was.

Agrona is no different.

I dug a palm into my eye socket, pushing away the irritating thought. Maybe it was true that Agrona hoped I would use my strength for him, but he had reincarnated me knowing it would be *my* power. He knew what I really was. And he wanted to show me what I was capable of.

They're constantly hiding things. Like right now. What is Nico doing that he doesn't want you to see?

Once this thought had invaded my brain, I couldn't escape it. I was just as curious to know what was happening inside that room as I had been hesitant to enter it. I listened closely, but there was a layer of deviant wind mana creating a sound barrier around the cell.

As I focused on the mana, it rippled, and the sound of muffled conversation reached my ears. I remembered swimming at the academy, learning to focus my ki in different environments, and how the water distorted the voices of those outside the pool. It sounded exactly like that. I swam close to the metaphorical surface, and the voice became even clearer. I pushed through the barrier of sound, and suddenly I could hear Nico as if he were standing right next to me.

"—tell me every single damned thing you remember about him. Don't leave out the *smallest detail*." Nico's voice was deep and hollow, like he was speaking from the bottom of a canyon.

A chorus of croaking voices answered, each one more desperate to be heard than the last.

"—cruel cleverness in his eyes as he—"

"—sat like a statue, like he never feared for a—"

"—might be an unadorned, 'cause we never did sense his mana or—"

"—exuded such a terrible pressure—"

"Stop. Stop!" Nico snarled. The cell went quiet. "If you keep shouting over each other, I'll burn out your tongues so only one may speak." I recoiled from his gruesome threat, but told myself he was

only doing what he had to do. “You, tell me how this ascender came to your attention.”

There was some moaning and clearing of throats before a thin, nasally voice answered. “A servant of the Granbehl Blood brought us a strange story… of an ascender without any blood ties, who seemed unaccountably powerful, and who projected no mana signature.” The speaker paused, breathing heavily. “They suspected that Ascender Grey had smuggled a relic—”

The voice choked off as stone and bones both cracked. I could feel the weight of Nico’s rage through the warded doors.

When Nico spoke again, his voice was strained. “Why was I not informed of this ascender’s name?”

“I-it was in the report we sent to Taegrin Caelum,” the high justice said swiftly, her voice shaking.

“It doesn’t make any sense,” Nico snarled under his breath, and I heard soft steps as he began to pace.

Standing, I moved tentatively toward the doors. The steel bolts retracted as I approached, and the doors swung open. Inside, the high justice had shrank back against the curved wall, her head down. Nico paced back and forth in front of the four remaining prisoners. The fifth, a man with a goatee, had been impaled by three black spikes. His blood ran in dark streams down the spikes before seeping into cracks in the floor.

“He’s dead,” Nico said firmly. He spun on his heel, pacing back the other way. “But he’s like a freaking cockroach. If anyone could survive…” He spun again. “Even if he survived, he couldn’t have come to Alacrya without us seeing.”

“Nico, what—”

He snapped his fingers and pointed at me before continuing to speak to himself. “He could have found an ancient portal, still active… but even he wouldn’t be self-absorbed enough to use *that* name… like lighting a signal fire in the dark… ”

Is this the man you love?

I trembled as the vertigo surged through my body, beginning behind my eyes, then jolting down into my guts. I grabbed his wrist with a shaky hand. “Nico, what did you do?”

He wrenched his arm free of my grasp, baring his teeth at me like an animal. “Shut up!”

A monster roared to life inside me. The elderwood guardian’s will was all twisted, boiling rage. It was the trapped beast screaming against the chains that bound it, but it was also the grass and vines and trees that retake the world when humans abandon it. It frightened me, this wild thing sleeping inside me. It was too much like my ki in my last life: uncontrollable, explosive, relentless…

I had learned to touch every kind of mana. Even the so-called deviants, the use of which seemed simple as snowballs in winter… but Agrona had warned me away from the beast will. Perhaps some day I could tame it, but for now…

The light in the room took on the dappled green of the forest beneath a thick canopy, and a single emerald vine curled around my arm, reaching toward Nico.

The fury melted off his face, leaving him pale and green-tinged. He recoiled from me as if he’d been burned.

“Cecil, are you okay? I’m sorry, I’m…” Trailing off, he ran both hands through his limp hair.

The tendril receded, and the light returned to normal. But I could still feel the beast will vibrating with rage. “I’m fine.”

Nico cleared his throat and faced the four prisoners. The old woman had fainted, and the fat man had thrown up on the floor. They had been caught unprotected between the sudden surge of force from Nico and me.

He’ll hurt you.

That didn’t matter. Nico’s spirit was shattered. He wasn’t himself. But that didn’t mean he couldn’t be healed with time.

“What did this ascender look like?” Nico asked, addressing the central prisoner, a frail old man.

“Pale blond hair…” the old man rasped. “Golden eyes, more feline than man. Twenty years of age, perhaps, with sharp and proud features…”

Nico frowned, his eyes losing focus as he tried to picture the mysterious ascender.

“And regal,” the old man added. “He held himself like royalty…like a king.”

Nico scoffed, a vicious sound that clawed the air. “Like a king, you say?” Nico’s body erupted, his sudden swelling rage no longer able to be contained by mere flesh and bone. Black flames engulfed him, leaping from his body like hot ash.

“Who is a king!” he roared. “We have only Sovereigns here!”

I could see the mana, blackened by the basilisks’ decay influence, working itself into a frenzy inside the prisoners’ flesh. All of them

were burning on the inside. On the outside, they writhed in silent torment, the pain too great to even scream.

Nico was panting heavily, and with every exhalation, the air around him seemed to distort. The high justice had already scrambled backwards out of the cell to avoid the black fire. She could only watch, unable to speak out in defense of the justice she claimed to represent.

"Useless old fools!" Nico shouted, his voice cracking. The old man's flesh began to blister and crack, and little black flames leapt out of the wounds as the soulfire devoured them.

It did not take long.

"That wasn't necessary," I said, soft but firm. I didn't want to draw Nico's fury, but I wasn't afraid, either. "They didn't deserve to be burned away by your fear and rage."

Nico closed his eyes. His breathing slowed, and the flames outlining him like a deadly halo receded back into his flesh and faded. "They are nobody. They are entirely insignificant." His voice was utterly devoid of emotion.

"Grey again…" I said, my voice barely a whisper. "Why does this man have such a hold over you that just his name can cause such a strong reaction? Who is Grey?"

Nico, his back to me, seemed to shrink in on himself. "He was our friend…"

He turned, and for just a moment I didn't see the stranger's face that Nico wore. I only saw his eyes, red-rimmed and glistening with tears. I knew the sadness in them. He was looking at me now the same way he used to look at me, helpless. Desperate.

“And he was the one that murdered you, Cecilia.”

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CLOSURE

ARTHUR

The aetheric blade in my hand—no larger than a simple dagger and hazy around the edges—drove into a winged creature made of stone before shattering partway, not yet able to withstand the impact.

My hand wrapped around the creature's throat. It looked like a bat with a petrified squashed face and a huge mouth. Its wide jaws snapped crazily just inches in front of my face as its jagged claws dug into my arms in a desperate effort to pull itself closer.

Holding the gargoyle back with one hand, I conjured the blade again in my other hand and plunged it into the beast's head, which split apart with a resounding *crack*.

The blade broke and faded away, leaving me with empty arms to defend myself as two more gargoyles plummeted toward me.

Twin bolts of dark fire struck the descending gargoyles, and the swooping beasts exploded. Their rubble clattered to the ground like hail and sent up little splashes where it landed in the stream bisecting the zone.

I glanced back to see Caera holding her arm out, revealing the silver bracer she had taken from the Spear Beaks' treasure room. It seemed thin against her wrist, barely more than a decorative cuff covered in intricate engravings.

Two narrow silver shards were revolving defensively around her, blazing with dark light. In the next breath, they began to dim as they drifted back to the bracer and reconnected to it, fitting into the pattern of engravings.

Regis loped toward us, spitting out a chunk of rock from his mouth. Behind him, the zone stretched out far into the distance, covered with the wreckage of our passing.

We were in a canyon with sheer, rocky cliffs to either side. They climbed so high that only a sliver of sky could be seen above us, like a reflection of the thin, clear stream that ran along the canyon floor. Loose rocks and rubble—the remains of the gargoyle creatures—littered the canyon floor.

"That rocked," Regis said, deadpan.

"I admit, it wasn't bad once things got rolling," Caera replied, carefully maintaining a straight face except for the slightest quiver of her lips. "In fact, it was rather… *marbleous.*"

"I guess fun, like beauty, is in the eye of the *boulder…*" Regis answered, his voice trembling as he desperately tried to keep from laughing.

I faced the exit portal with a deep sigh. "I'm so glad I brought you two."

Caera stepped up beside me. "Oh, don't be so stone-faced, Grey."

"Yeah, Princess. You shouldn't take us for *granite.*" Regis broke, barking with laughter.

Ignoring my companions, I focused on the portal, my mind working at a question I'd been carrying with me ever since acquiring the Compass.

It had to be more than just a portal generator that took us in and out of the Relictombs at will. My mind kept going back to the djinn. As difficult as it was to believe, they had designed and built this place.

They must have had a way to travel through it, and I already knew that the Compass could interact with a Relictombs portal.

An image flashed in my mind, the false memory implanted by Sylvia with her last message to me. The clarity of the memory had faded with time, but I knew it was one of the zones leading toward the next djinn ruin.

So far, I had stumbled blindly through the Relictombs, knowing that this place was guiding me toward my goals…or so it seemed, at least. But trusting blindly to the machinations of a long-dead race of aether wielders didn't suit my needs. Not if I was ever going to master Fate.

Sitting down, I focused on the fading memory that Sylvia had left me with as I activated the half-sphere relic. It thrummed with aether as misty gray light engulfed the portal, replacing the oil-slick shimmer that hung like a curtain inside the cut-stone frame with a clear view of my room back at Central Academy.

"Damn it," I cursed, cutting off the flow of aether into the relic, causing the portal to shift back to its original appearance.

"Protein paste for your thoughts?"

I looked up to see Caera holding out nutrient-filled rations stuffed in an insulated tube packaging.

"Just thinking about how to properly use the Compass," I answered, flinching away from the strong smell it emitted. "How do you eat that stuff? It smells horrible."

She shrugged before squeezing the contents from the tube into her mouth. "Unlike you, I actually have to eat to survive. This stuff is easy to carry around in bulk for long ascents."

“I guess I’m glad I don’t need to eat,” I said, wrinkling my nose.
Caera waved the tube around, fanning the smell of jellied meat in my face. I cringed and swatted her hand away, my knuckles ringing against the silver cuff around her wrist. “How does your new artifact feel?” I asked, eager to divert her from torturing me further.
“Ridiculously frustrating,” Caera pouted. “It’s like I’ve grown a new limb that I have to learn to use from the ground up.”
“Eh, he does that all the time,” Regis said, shrugging his lupine shoulders.
I clamped my hand around Regis’s muzzle before responding. “It looked like you had the hang of it by what I saw back there.”
A faint smile tugged at the corner of Caera’s lips before it disappeared just as fast. She held up her silver bracer as she turned toward the portal. “Do you think the Compass works kind of like my artifact?”
“What do you mean?” I asked as I let go of Regis.
“When I first channeled mana into the artifact, I actually thought it was just a defensive item because of the way the shards barely hovered in place around the bracer. It took me days of constant experimentation to realize that the shards were able to be controlled independently,” she explained, tracing the grooves etched into the silver bracelet. “What if the return function of the Compass is the default and for you to do more, it needs further guidance?”
Caera’s expression softened. “It seems unlikely that the ancient mages would let their people traverse these zones aimlessly.

Otherwise, what would have stopped them from being trapped, wandering haphazardly to their deaths?"

I watched as she unconsciously fiddled with the silver bracer around her wrist. Her gaze was empty, focused on a distant memory. She wasn't thinking about djinn, or me, or even herself. Because it wasn't about her.

"You're scared of the possibility that the Relictombs sent your brother somewhere he couldn't escape," I said softly, winning a surprised look from the blue-haired Alacryan noble.

"Is reading minds another of your otherworldly powers?" she asked in horror. "Please tell me you haven't been hiding the fact that you can—"

I let a small smile slip onto my face. "I'm good at reading people, but it's not magic."

"Yes," she confirmed with a sigh of relief. "I've been wondering for a while now…was that zone you found his dagger and cloak in someplace…"

"Someplace only I could escape?"

She nodded hesitantly. "Like the mirror room or the frozen mountains? Even the bridge of faces would not have been escapable without your…"

"We've been calling it God Step," I filled in.

"Without your 'God Step' ability." She gave me an appraising look. "Regis named it that, didn't he?"

I let out a loud laugh that resounded off the canyon walls. "How'd you know?"

She smiled wryly. “Something tells me you wouldn’t be so…grandiose in the naming of your abilities.”

“One, it’s a great name,” Regis replied defensively after pulling his muzzle out of my grip. *‘And two, you used to use a spell called ‘Absolute Zero,’ so…’*

“No,” I said in answer to her original question. “The zone where I found your brother’s dagger wasn’t like those. It was deadly enough to claim the lives of many ascenders before I found it, but it didn’t require the use of aether to escape.”

“That’s something at least. I’m glad he had a fighting chance, even if he didn’t make it out.” Caera forced a smile before turning and walking away.

Regis remained by my side as I returned my focus back on the half-sphere relic in my hand. Like what Caera had said, maybe the Compass needed more guidance. Shutting my eyes, I visualized the zone that had left the biggest impact on me, the one I could recall with utmost clarity.

“It’s actually changing,” Regis said with disbelief before he let out a groan. “You just *had* to pick that one.”

I pried one eye open to see the smooth marble floor, high arched ceiling, and rune-covered doors capping both ends…along with the armed statues lining both sides of the hallway.

“It actually worked,” I huffed, feeling the drain from my core as the Compass continued to siphon aether out of me in order to hold the new destination open.

Deactivating the relic, I began recalling the details of our destination in my head. Once the image was clear in my mind, I patted Regis on his side. “Get Caera. We’re leaving.”

By the time the portal had stabilized to the next zone we would be heading into, Caera had arrived with Regis, wide-eyed in awe.

“I can’t believe you actually figured it out so quickly,” she muttered.

“Your advice helped,” I said, holding out a hand as Regis disappeared back inside me. “Let’s go.”

With a deep breath, the two of us stepped through, immediately greeted by a humid gust of wind. Around us were dense trees growing from both floor and ceiling, speckled with the occasional colors from the aether fruits, while webs of tangled roots spread endlessly beneath our feet.

“Well, this definitely isn’t your room,” Caera observed. “So this is one of the zones you need to visit on this mysterious quest of yours?”

“No,” I said quietly, turning to her. “It’s where your brother died.”

The Alacryan noble’s head whipped toward me, her intelligent red eyes wide and trembling before she turned away, letting her hair fall to shield her face. “Thank you, Grey.”

Ignoring the prickling sensation of Regis’s taunting grin, I stored the Compass back into my rune before stepping forward. “Don’t thank me yet.”

The last time we were here, Regis and I had killed the giant millipede and all but one of its eggs so that we didn’t destroy the delicate ecosystem contained within the zone. But time worked strangely in the Relictombs, so we didn’t know what we would find here.

Scouting the nearby trees, I found one with strong branches and began hoisting myself upwards, avoiding the dangling fruit and the invisible creatures that used them as bait. Once I was seventy feet in the air, I scouted out our surroundings, looking for the millipede's lair.

Although the rough-dug hole that opened up into the millipede den was nondescript, the aetheric glow that emanated from it wasn't, and it didn't take long to find. It was less than a mile away. Before I could drop down to the others, though, movement caught my eye in the distant canopy. Treetops rustled as something moved beneath them.

The two-tailed monkeys weren't big enough to make the trees shake…

Dropping from branch to branch, I was on the ground in seconds. I held a finger up to my lips before speaking to Caera in a bare whisper. "The creature is out of its den. It's a couple of miles away, but we need to move quietly."

Nodding my head in the direction we needed to go, I began to lead the way, taking each step carefully to avoid making unnecessary noise.

'Why are you so tense? We're a lot stronger than we were when we first came here,' Regis noted with a scoff.

I know, but it's hard to let go of the kind of fear that grows in you when you're weak. It grows along with you.

The jungle was quiet. Even the heavy footfalls of the millipede were too far away to hear. The lack of birds chirping or insects buzzing felt unnatural. But, aside from the voracious millipede, the zone was

home only to the two-tailed monkeys, and they had adapted to be completely silent. Even as I listened for them, I couldn't hear a single one.

I paused, scanning the dense trees. Aether-rich fruit hung like fat pears all around us, but there wasn't a single two-tailed monkey in sight. Imbuing aether into my eyes, I focused on the ceiling, where trees grew down like clinging vines. Although I scanned the distant shadows for a minute or more, I saw no movement.

"What's wrong?" Caera whispered, her head swiveling from side to side. "What do you see?"

"Nothing," I admitted. "Nothing at all."

I wasn't sure why the absence of half of the local fauna made me nervous, but it did. I reinforced the layer of aether cladding my body and moved on.

We reached the entrance to the den without seeing any signs of life at all. Caera knelt down and peered into the dim tunnel. She sniffed and wrinkled her nose. "What is that foul stench?"

I copied her and nearly gagged on the smell of rotting flesh. I felt Regis wince inside. *'It's gross enough just by reading your thoughts. I'll just wait this one out.'*

"Maybe it's the millipede's corpse," I whispered, taking a few tentative steps down the steeply descending tunnel.

The tunnel radiated faint purple light, like before, but it felt larger than it had, and the churned dirt of the floor had a red tinge to it below the purple glow.

We moved stealthily along the tunnel until it widened and opened to our left. Aether crystals were scattered across the tunnel floor, some

crushed to gravel and no longer glowing. This eventually opened up into the huge cavern where we'd fought the first millipede.

Caera put a hand over her mouth and nose. We had found the source of the smell, and it wasn't the millipede we'd killed.

Aether crystals carpeted the ground, no longer in piles but spread out and smashed. They were stained red by rotting, half-eaten monkey corpses mixed in among them like grotesque chaff. It was like something out of a nightmare.

"Grey…" Caera looked like she might be sick, but I didn't think it was just from the sight before us.

"It wasn't like this before," I said gently. "Nothing so gruesome."

I began to maneuver through the cavern, trying to avoid the worst of the mess. Cracked and broken aether crystals crunched under my feet, making an uncomfortable amount of noise. I was looking for the bowl-like nest where I'd originally found the millipede eggs and the crystals containing armor and weapons—all that remained of the ascenders devoured by the beast—but it was gone.

Where the nest had been, the ground was dug up and trampled, the only spot devoid of crystals and corpses. As I approached the barren pit, my foot hit something beneath the crystals, and I pulled out a broken sword handle. It was the one I had imbued with aether and smashed, before I found Sevren's dagger and cloak. I tossed it back into the clutter.

"Sorry," I said as Caera came to stand beside me. "I thought this would be more… sentimental."

Caera's hand came to rest momentarily on my shoulder. She didn't say anything, but she didn't need to.

Walking gingerly down into the center of the barren pit where the nest had been, she kneeled. Her fingers combed through the freshly tilled soil. I stayed quiet, letting her work through whatever thoughts she was having. I imagined she wanted to say goodbye, something her adoptive parents had never really given her the opportunity to do.

My mood turned melancholy as I thought of my father. I wished I had done more to memorialize him. Reynolds Leywin had been a great man—a hero—and had deserved more than a sudden death fighting mindless beasts. Then again, Caera probably felt the same way about Sevren.

"Grey?" I looked down into the pit at Caera. She frowned. "Did you hear that?"

I'd let myself become distracted, and so hadn't immediately noticed the growing noise. It sounded like an entire army was approaching, like a thousand armor-plated soldiers sprinting through the jungle above.

"Shit, it's here," I said, giving her my hand to help her out of the pit. "Regis!"

'Do I have to?' he grumbled, but the wolf appeared beside me anyway, his flames flickering in agitation.

We quickly arranged ourselves for battle. I stood near the center of the cavern, prepared to draw its attention. Regis crept around to the left, staying close to the far wall. Caera stayed well back, her sword drawn and the two silver spines orbiting her defensively.

The sound of its hard exoskeleton scraping along the tunnel walls made the entire den shake and sent trails of dust raining down from

the roof. It slowed as it came closer, so that I could hear the mandibles clacking in a measured, steady rhythm. *Clack clack clack*. Again and again. Then it would scrape forward a little more. *Clack clack clack*.

Then its head inched into the cavern.

'Oh. Shit.'

This millipede was easily half again as large as the one we'd killed. Its body had turned a rusty red color, now only slightly translucent. Each mandible was as long and broad as a man and serrated like a bone saw.

It froze. It's head lowered a few feet. The mandibles clacked.

Then it burst forward in a rush of speed that should have been impossible for something of its size. I dodged back as the mandibles snapped shut just ahead of me, then rolled forward beneath it and grabbed the very front leg. With a sharp twist, the leg ripped free of the body, but the giant millipede was moving again, every leg stabbing downward, the body bucking and coiling, every inch of it in motion.

I could just see Regis darting around the back end, biting and snapping at whatever he could. From the other direction, black fire was slamming into the hard carapace like ballista bolts, but the flames only left dark scorch marks. The entire exoskeleton was covered in a thick layer of aether, which was shrugging off even the soulfire.

Imbuing the severed leg with aether, I tried to thrust up into the millipede's belly, but another leg slammed into my shoulder and the blow skated off the aether-coated chitin.

Throwing down the severed appendage, I conjured an aether blade instead and slashed out at the closest leg. My blade chipped it, then broke. Cursing, I willed more power into the aetheric dagger, focusing on its form, forcing it to expand and grow longer. The dagger swelled into the rough size and shape of a spade, then burst apart.

Caera braced herself as the millipede shifted its attention on her. It let out a whistling screech and surged toward her.

Gathering as much aether into my hands as I quickly could, I punched straight up. The chitinous underbelly cracked, and the millipede's body jerked, the legs scrabbling at the crystal-covered dirt. I punched again and again, creating a series of broken craters along the underside of its body, but it wasn't enough to slow it down or reclaim its attention.

The silver shards of Caera's artifact were spinning rapidly in front of her, no longer firing projectiles. Instead, a steady beam of soulfire connected them, forming a thin barrier in front of her. As I prepared to grab the millipede's legs in a last-ditch effort to hold it back, a third satellite broke loose from the bracer, then a forth, and they joined with the others.

The thin barrier bloomed into a wall of black fire an instant before the millipede struck it. Caera's eyes sharpened as she leaned forward, focusing on holding the defensive barrier in place. The impact shook the den, and the millipede's body crumpled up like a derailed train as the front end suddenly stopped, but the back end kept churning forward.

The mandibles opened wide, trying to close around the edges of the soulfire shield. Black-purple sparks flew wherever the aether-clad millipede touched the dark flames, scorching everything they landed on. The dark light reflected off the sweat clinging to Caera's face, highlighting her features. Her teeth were bared in a grimace of concentration, her scarlet eyes blazing like they too had been set aflame.

She was holding it back, but I knew she couldn't hold it for long.

A sudden swelling pressure from the other end of the cave made me spin around, wary of some new threat. Instead, I saw Regis picking himself up out of a pile of aether crystals. His flames grew jagged, his form less obviously wolflike as his features melted into shadow while he transformed. I could see the edges of the hard spikes that were growing out from all over his body and the horns jutting from his head, but I could tell it was going to take time before he could rejoin the fight.

There wasn't time to second guess his use of Destruction. Aetheric lightning flashed around me as I God Stepped onto the millipede's writhing head. Infusing aether into my fists, I slammed them down into the aether-clad exoskeleton again and again, creating a spiderweb of cracks in the thick chitin.

The millipede recoiled from the blows, its head whipping out from under me so fast that I spun in the air before landing on my feet. The head shook back and forth and the mandibles clacked together threateningly. For a single breath, things in the cavern were nearly still.

Caera was breathing hard behind her shield, but when I met her eyes she inclined her head just an inch, assuring me that she was fine.

All our attention—even the giant millipede's—was drawn to Regis. The shadows melted away from him, revealing the full extent of his Destruction form. Just like when we'd fought against the so-called "Wild Things," he was huge. His chest and forelegs grew thick with corded muscles, his back sloping down slightly and afire with jagged, unnatural purple flames. Horns like sharpened battering rams curved forward like a bull's, while his snarling maw was filled with serrated daggers.

When he spoke, his deep voice reverberated through the den, more primal growl than speech. "Try shitting this out, bitch!"

Regis leapt half the length of the den to crash into the coiled millipede, his Destruction-infused jaws rending and tearing. He ripped off legs and tore huge gashes in the carapace, through which a thick, reddish muck spilled out. But the millipede was fighting back. Despite Regis's size, the giant beast was still much larger, and it curled around him like a python, using its bulk to crush him. Legs stabbed like daggers all over his body, deflecting off the hardened fur.

Burning black bolts of soulfire pelted the creature, firing even faster than before. The thick barrier of aether was fading, and for every ten bolts that dissipated against it, one made it through, causing the chitin to pop and hiss as the soulfire burned it away.

Suddenly the millipede went into a death roll, crashing manically through the cavern with Regis pinned against its body. Caera's

artifact flashed back into defensive mode as part of the millipede's body crushed her against the wall.

Taking a deep, steadying breath, I conjured an aether blade in my fist. I guided the formation, keeping a clear picture in my mind: a long, thin blade, translucent purple instead of blue. I had the aether required—I knew I did—it was only the understanding I lacked. Some key insight into how aether could form a solid shape—a weapon—continued to escape me.

Still, I tried. The dagger lengthened, but the edge grew indistinct. The form wavered, coiling like the millipede's enormous body, which was twisting and crashing all around me. I hardened my will, and the blade straightened. The edges shivered and danced, more like forgefire than tempered steel, but the form held.

I tracked the path of the millipede's coiling frame. It was chaotic, mindless…but there was a pattern in all that chaos. Holding the blade with both hands, I split my mind. With one part, I held the sword's form. With the other, I focused aether into every muscle, joint, and tendon. My head ached with the effort, my body screamed as it struggled to hold itself together against the tension.

Burst Step pulled the world beneath my feet, and then I was standing on the other side of the den, nothing left in my hands but a faint wisp of aether. Behind me, there was a steady, continuous crashing noise as the millipede's body slumped to the ground. A deluge of red sludge poured from a gash that ran half the length of its body, turning the ground into a gory soup of crystals, half-eaten remains, and the bloody goo.

You okay? I thought to Regis, who I couldn't see among the folds of the millipede's corpse. The pressure put off by his Destruction form had waned.

'Don't mind me. I'm just going to lie here in this stanky death soup for a minute,' he thought tiredly back.

With a weary chuckle, I turned my attention to Caera, who was leaning against the far wall. I had promised to bring her on these ascents in return for her help in stealing the Compass. However, seeing the Alacryan noble hold her own in these last few zones, having her as a teammate felt less out of commitment and more like a genuine partnership.

"Caera," I called out as I saw her pushing herself back up to her feet. "Nice wo—"

Something about her expression kept me from walking closer to my blue-haired companion as she hobbled toward the center of the den.

Regis appeared around a mound of millipede, shaking off the muck clinging to his fur. He came to stand beside me, and we watched silently as Caera found a relatively clear space near the center of the den. Soulfire suddenly burst out of her, forming a sphere of black flames that faded as quickly as it had appeared.

Now standing at the center of a bare ring of earth, she withdrew something that flashed silver in the dim light, then plunged it into the ground. Her brother's dagger.

Dropping to her knees, she leaned forward and rested her forehead against its pommel. Her shoulders began to tremble as tears traced her cheek before dropping to the ground.

“Come on,” I whispered before turning away. Regis followed, allowing her a moment of privacy to grieve. The half-choked sound of broken sobs resounded in the silence.

357
BLOOD RELIC

AETHER COURSED THROUGH MY BODY, igniting my channels with liquid fire before coalescing into the deep well of my core. Despite my thoughts being elsewhere and the fact that I'd done this countless times before, the feeling was still intoxicating. This profound and elusive power that not even asuras could fully control was inside me, waiting to be unleashed.

'I think we got it,' Regis sent as we finished piecing together our memories. Sylvia's last message hadn't shown the four djinn ruins, but they did show the zones that led to them. Only, it took time for both of us to recall the details clearly enough for the Compass to get us there.

Yeah, I answered simply, visualizing the image of narrow earthen tunnels winding like a maze of giant wormholes in every direction.

I pried my eyes open to be greeted by the chitinous corpse of the giant millipede, which I was sitting on top of while siphoning its aether.

With my core mostly replenished and our destination set, I dropped to the ground just in time to see Caera getting up from her brother's improvised memorial. The whites of her eyes had turned red from crying, but her gaze had hardened, her jaw set firmly with resolve.

No words were exchanged, only a simple nod before we moved on.

The exit portal was hours from the den, and the rest of the journey through the empty zone was uneventful. We moved quickly and in silence. Regis stayed inside my body, regaining his strength after the use of Destruction. His control over the ability had strengthened

significantly since he'd last used it, but I could feel the toll it took on him.

"You should get some rest before we go through," I said as we finally reached the exit. "It's been a while since you slept."

"I'm okay," she replied, casting a glance behind her. Though she didn't say it, I knew that she was ready to get out of this zone.

Focusing on the image of those winding tunnels, I activated the Compass, and Caera stepped through. The zone beyond was thick with dust that hung in the air, making it difficult to see what we were walking into, and all I could make out of Caera was a dark silhouette.

'Arthur,' Regis barked inside me just as two more silhouettes appeared on either side of her.

Stay inside for now, I ordered, focusing on the dull red light glinting off their weapons.

The shining portal evaporated behind me as I stepped through, my eyes immediately searching for Caera and her attackers.

Caera's red blade flashed in the thick dust, ringing against her attacker's weapon. Deep-throated shouts filled the small space, and a glowing spear thrust out of the obscuring dust. I grabbed it just before it would have struck Caera in the back. The mana-reinforced steel haft screeched as I ripped the spearhead from its shaft and hurled it back at the wielder. The jagged tip pierced the attacker's chest, and his dim shadow was lifted off the ground and slammed into the bare dirt wall.

The dust began to settle, revealing another man—large and caked in dirt and clay—hacking and slashing at Ceara with a serrated, frozen

scimitar, and two Strikers flanking a narrow earthen tunnel that led out of the small room we were in.

God Step brought me behind them, amethyst lightning arcing across my skin. The first died instantly as my aether-clad hand struck the back of his neck, breaking his spine despite his chain gorget. I backhanded the second as he began to activate one of the runes displayed along his spine, sending him flying into the tunnel wall. He landed on his own spear, impaling himself through his bare biceps.

He hissed out a curse before rolling over and tugging futilely at the spear, his spell forgotten.

Caera's opponent growled in bestial rage as their blades clashed, a sound that cut off in wet gurgling as her sword plunged through his chest.

I dug my heel into the last mage's bloody wound, ignoring his desperate attempt at defending himself with a shroud of fire.

"Why did you attack us?" I asked evenly, leaning down to meet his eye.

"Kage's o-orders!" the man yelled out, his dirt-caked face contorted in pain. "Please, we're just doing what we were told!"

I tilted my head, raising a brow. "Am I supposed to be familiar with that name?"

"Our leader," he panted, his panicked eyes trained on the blood gushing from his wound. "Any…anyone who steps through that portal belongs to him."

Caera had knelt down to check on the man I'd impaled with his own spearhead, but now she stood up and leveled a fierce glare at the surviving ascender. "Why would any ascender '*belong*' to him?"

My ears picked up the faint sounds of footsteps approaching. Lifting my foot off his bloody arm, I took a step back.

The mage was panting, his eyes losing focus. Gauging by the bloody mud pooled beneath him, he didn't have much longer. "The relic needs blood," he said. "So we… we—"

A stone spike erupted from the floor and impaled him through the chest, spraying blood across Caera's face.

I spun to see a dozen more ascenders huddled together farther down the tunnel. One man stood at the forefront of the group. He was as dirty as the rest of them, but under the layers of filth, I could see a network of scars criss-crossing his face, arms, and hands. His hair was a fine stubble that looked like it had been shaved with a dagger instead of a razor, and a knotted blond beard covered his face. He wore a mismatched suit of armor that looked like it had been scavenged from a dozen different sources.

"Would you care to tell us what the hell is happening in this zone?" Caera asked as she calmly wiped the blood off her face with a handkerchief.

"Hell is the appropriate word," the scarred ascender drawled, grinning. He was missing more than one tooth, and those that remained were filed to sharp points. "You've reached the very bowels of the Relictombs, where ascenders come to die."

Caera took a confident step forward, her dark blue hair fluttering as she leveled her thin blade to the man's throat. The ascender matched it, a small crater forming beneath his feet as he stepped forward and pressed his neck against the tip of Caera's blade.

“There’s no way out of here,” he continued, his dark eyes wide and more than a little mad. “Except by blood. Everyone either gives it or takes it, but no one who stays neutral survives for long.”

I shuffled tentatively in between the two and held up an arm. “We have no desire to fight you if you don’t make us. But can you explain what is happening here? Less cryptically, this time.”

The leader—Kage, I assumed—seemed to dismiss me immediately, instead frowning intensely as he sized up my partner. Caera’s ruby eyes blazed in the dark despite her gaze being frigid. Their standoff ended suddenly when his frown cracked like thin ice and his face shuddered into a forced grin.

Kage tapped his dirty finger against his temple. “I can tell your blood isn’t the letting kind. You’re just the flavor of fresh meat”—his goons chuckled darkly at this—“that we need here. You see, minds, bodies, and spirits go stale in this purgatory.” As Kage spoke, one eye began to twitch. “The longer you stay, the worse it gets, but the only way out is by emptying your friends and comrades of their life’s blood. Cruel, those ancient devils…”

The scarred ascender’s eyes lost focus for a moment.

“I believe we asked you to be *less* cryptic,” Caera said impatiently.

The men behind Kage shuffled, hands tightening around weapons as their glares cut toward my companion. One raised a weapon that crackled with electricity. Kage’s hand flashed out, catching the man in the side of the head. “Don’t go rattling sabers when I’m talking!”

He graced Caera with his gap tooth smile. “I can tell you’re people of means. Wyverns, not wogarts, as the saying goes. And so I’ll level with you. You’ve found yourself trapped in a zone with no exit. The

only way out is to claim a relic held at the center of this maze of tunnels, but that can only be done by blood sacrifice. And so far, no one has managed to spill enough of it to bypass the wards."

I hadn't heard wrong. Kage said it as well…

There was a relic in this zone.

My attention remained on Kage as he spoke: his hands constantly gravitated toward his weapon, his grin would fade only to be forced back on his dirt-caked face, and he swelled up like a fanged musk as he spoke. It all created a subtly threatening image, like an animalistic defensive measure to ward off potential threats.

"We'd like to see this relic," I said gently. "Can you take us to it?"

"Piss off, twig!" one of the men snapped, pointing his sword at me.

Kage let out a craggy laugh and took a backwards step, then spun on his heel like he was in a military procession. A narrow spear of stone burst out of the ground and skewered the offending ascender's hand, sending the sword flying. Kage kicked the man's knee, causing it to crack and bend backwards, then took him by the throat and slammed him to the ground.

"I don't remember telling you to speak!" Kage roared in his face, spittle flying. The runes on his back flared as he raised one hand over his head, and a crust of black and glowing-orange stone formed from his elbow down, radiating a heat so intense that I could feel it from several feet away.

The smoldering gauntlet hit the man's face like a sledgehammer. It fell again and again, filling the cave with the smell of scorched flesh. The rest of the ascenders had backed away. Some watched with a wicked sort of anticipation, but most averted their eyes.

When there was nothing left of the ascender's face but a burnt pulp, Kage straightened. He was panting slightly, and gouts of smoking fire were flashing around the conjured gauntlet. With a crack of his neck and a sigh, he faced Caera. "It takes a firm hand, you know," Kage said, chuckling. "A firm hand, get it?"

Caera's nose wrinkled in disgust, but Kage's men let out scattered laughter. I kept my face blank. "Waste of blood, though. Bah." The molten gauntlet fell away in ashy chunks as Kage released the spell. "Here's the thing, newcomer. Trust earns trust. First, you and your servant boy will come back to camp with us. There, we can decide who gets to see what, aye?"

Caera's mouth opened, and I could tell from the look on her face she was about to dismiss Kage's offer. I grabbed her sleeve and gave it a small tug. "Lady, no good can come from rejecting this man's offer. Look what he did to his own ally. We should go with him and see what he has to say."

"Fine," she answered, searching my eyes questioningly. To Kage, she said, "we'll go with you."

"A wise little sidekick you have there," Kage grunted. "Can't be an unad. Must be a pissy Sentry hiding his mana, eh?" He looked me in the eye and spit on the ground. "Or maybe the lady keeps you around for *other* purposes, eh boy?"

I flinched away from his gaze, which only made him and his men laugh.

"Well then?" Caera asked, maneuvering between us. "Your camp?"

“Guests first,” Kage said, gesturing down the tunnel like a doorman welcoming us into Alacrya’s finest inn. His men split apart, leaving a narrow space for Caera and me to walk through.

‘Is just killing everyone and everything that comes our way starting to bore you?’ Regis asked. *‘What’s with the meek and fragile act?’*

Just stay inside and keep your eyes open, I snapped.

‘Fine,’ he grumbled.

The zone was made up entirely of earthen tunnels, like I had seen in the false memory. They twisted and turned continuously, like some giant worm had eaten through the ground here, leaving a maze of paths behind. Veins of some red-hot stone broke through the dirt in places, shedding rusty light through the tunnels.

Occasionally a thick vine or root would protrude from the tunnel wall, and Kage was quick to direct us around them. “I'd avoid the stranglers. Doubt I need to explain the name.”

As we walked, turning this way and that so regularly that I struggled to maintain a sense of where we were, Kage continued to speak. “It’s a war you’ve found yourself in, friends. Chaos and bloodshed as ascender turns on ascender for a chance at a real, honest-to-Vritra relic. Even if we could leave, most wouldn’t. Not with that kind of prize on the line.”

“There must be more to it than that,” Caera said. “Ascenders are not wild animals.”

“Was worse when I got here,” Kage said proudly. “A total bloodbath, every man set on killing his way to the top.”

“What happened when you arrived?” I asked, carefully moving around another large vine that was blocking half the tunnel.

Kage snorted in delight. “Exerted a little order, of course! Cracked enough skulls to prove my strength, then made the rest of them stop killing each other. Forged a tribe, gave ‘em purpose. We took control of the shrine, and from then on, I decided who lives and who dies.”

I didn’t miss the subtle threat in his tone as he said this.

“If you think about how fewer people have died since I got here, I’m actually a hero. A savior, not some butcher like you might be thinking.”

I shot a glance behind us. Kage was nodding his head, smirking as if pleased with himself.

“How far out do these tunnels go?” Caera asked. “Is there an end?”

“It’s a kind of maze. Roughly a big circle, with the relic shrine dead center,” he answered. “Big enough you could get lost and starve to death before anyone found you.” I could practically hear the cold sneer in his voice as he added, “But the tunnels are still full of mad ascenders just waiting to slit your throat in the dark, and they’d get you before then.”

Knowing the relic was at the center of the maze was something, but I didn’t have any reference for where *we* were yet. But, as interesting as the presence of yet another relic was, my curiosity was focused somewhere else.

“If this place is that big, maybe you just haven’t found the exit portal yet—”

“No!” Kage snapped, his footsteps halting. I turned around to find him scowling at me, his fists clenching and unclenching. Short, burning spikes pressed out of the tunnel walls all around us. “Are you doubting me, boy? Plenty of strong men have withered away in

the tunnels searching for the way out. We *know* where the door is, so only an idiot would keep looking. And the key is"—*'Blood,'* Regis thought sarcastically at the same time Kage said it—"so we just got to figure out how to use it."

I nodded, taking a timid step back. My foot bumped against a vine that slithered along the side of the tunnel, and it struck like a snake. The strangler wrapped around my leg and receded into the dirt, trying to pull me with it.

Caera's blade flashed, severing the root just above the ground. It released its grip, writhing like a dying worm at my feet. I scrambled backwards in the dirt to get away from it as Kage and the others broke into an uproar of wild laughter.

Kage jerked me to my feet and threw his arm around my shoulder, wiping tears and snot from his bright red face as he continued to chuckle. "You know, boy, my court could use a good jester," he said between fits of laughter. "Perhaps there's a reason to keep you around after all."

Regis let out a pleasant sigh. *'This is fun. I get to watch you get bullied while simultaneously looking forward to seeing you crush their gonads.'*

It took another hour to reach Kage's encampment. I wondered how he had arrived at the exit portal so quickly, but the thought was driven from my mind as I entered into a large, smooth-walled tunnel.

Unlike the naturally carved paths that had led us here, the ascenders' encampment bore obvious signs of having been carved out by magic. Whereas the tunnels had been low, barely high enough for me to walk standing straight in most places, the ceiling here was

fifteen feet high. At least a hundred small lighting artifacts were suspended above us, casting a pale, but bright, white light over the men there.

About a dozen men in mud-stained armor occupied the tunnel, which ran nearly seventy feet from end to end and was thirty feet wide. A few were training, but most were sitting around small, red-flamed fires and speaking in hushed and tired voices.

Several more were half-naked and shackled at their wrists, ankles, and throat.

Caera sucked in a surprised breath as she took it in, but had the wherewithal to bite her tongue for the moment.

The shackled men were all skinny and brown with dirt, their beards long and tangled, their hair matted. But I could see the runes on their backs marking them as mages. Two were carrying a large earthenware jug between them—careful to avoid a huge strangler root that grew down one side of the cavern—while a third cast a spell over a similar jug near the far end of the camp. Another was turning a spit over the fire, roasting some kind of meat. I didn't want to know what kind. A couple others stood by open doorways into a series of small caves that had been carved off the main tunnel, their eyes downcast.

Kage's scarred hand clapped my shoulder. "Welcome to my castle. Home of the Kaged Men!"

"There are no women," Caera said softly, like she was speaking to herself.

"Ah, well, anything of value is rare in this pit of despair," Kage grunted humorlessly. "Food, water, entertainment…"

His eyes lingered on my companion, moving slowly up and down her body, as he said this.

“Savages,” she said, matching his gaze.

“Oh come off it!” He howled with laughter. “Once upon a time, I was a highblood, just like you. In here, though, everyone’s blood is red and ripe for tapping.”

He brushed past us, his arms open wide as he entered the encampment. “Your savior has returned!” he shouted, his voice booming. “And I bring new recruits!”

The ascenders all began to gather, with several more coming out of the caves lining the walls, but the men in shackles hardly seemed to notice. They stopped and bowed whenever Kage came close, but otherwise hurried on with their duties.

“Enough gawking!” Kage shouted suddenly, pushing one of the men—a dangerously thin boy who couldn’t have been more than sixteen with the way his facial hair grew in uneven patches—causing him to stumble and fall, nearly landing in the fire. “Get back to work!”

I scanned their faces as we followed, taking in the sunken eyes, gaunt cheeks, and most of all the hard looks they gave us. Every one of them was ready to kill at a word from their leader, despite how he treated them. Men who fell into despair here were likely fed to the relic, so they embraced fury and hatred instead. These were the survivors. I could see the terrible things they’d done to make it this far in their eyes.

Kage led us into the largest of the caves, although to call it a simple cave didn’t do it justice. A talented mage had carved out a space

large enough for a family of four. The floors were hardened into something like marble, while the reddish walls had been carved to look like bricks. Stone furniture was layered with furs and blankets—significantly more than one man could have brought with him into the Relictombs.

A huge bed took up the center of one wall, and was piled high with more furs and bedrolls bound together with silky cords.

"At least you haven't had to give up your lavish highblood lifestyle," Caera said sarcastically as she took in his makeshift home.

Kage threw himself into a lounge chair and kicked one muddy boot up on a stone footrest. "It hasn't been all bad, I'll admit. Out there, I was the fourth son of a failing blood, but here I might as well be a Sovereign."

Caera rolled her eyes. "And what happens when the Ascenders Association learns of what happened in this convergence zone? You'll be executed."

Kage grinned at her like a gap-toothed shark. "That's assuming we ever escape, my lady. And if we do, that means we've claimed the relic. No one will give half a shit what we did to get it." He put his hands behind his head and gazed up at the ceiling. "Imagine it. The first live relic returned in how many years? Two decades? Three? Wealth enough for us all to keep our bloods strong for generations."

I could tell from Ceara's sour expression that she knew Kage was right.

Scuffling steps at the door announced the arrival of a newcomer, who bowed while trying to hold up a cask heavy with some sloshing liquid. He was ghostly pale with muted hair halfway between gray

and brown that hung limp down to his shoulders. His flint black eyes just touched on Caera and me before he stumbled to the table, struggling under the weight of the cask.

“Ah, Rat, perfect timing. Is that the Truacian Stout?” Kage asked, licking his lips. When he saw my questioning look, he winked. “Some fool had half a tavern stuffed in his dimension device. All the better for us.” His face grew sorrowful. “Nearly done now, though, isn’t it, Rat?”

The man called Rat wiped sweat from his brow as he went about tapping the cask. “I’m afraid so, my lord. Only one more cask is all, and it’s the pale from Sehz-Clar.”

Kage snorted. “Might as well be drinking Rat’s piss.” He spat on the ground.

Rat wore a simple linen shirt and trousers, but no armor. He wasn’t outfitted with manacles like the others we’d seen. He avoided looking at Kage, keeping his head averted subserviently, and when he spoke, his words were soft and nonthreatening. He immediately reminded me of his namesake, scurrying around the edge of the room like a rodent trying to avoid being stepped on.

Strangely, he was quite clean. There was hardly a speck of dirt on his clothes or his face, and his hair, although shaggy, was not full of muddy clumps like everyone else's. Only his hands showed any sign of the filth that clung to the rest of them like a second skin.

His darting eyes caught me watching him, but jumped away again instantly.

“Is it possible…” I started, my voice trepid. “To see the relic now?”

Kage took a clay mug from Rat and tipped it back, chugging down several mouthfuls and dribbling at least half of it into his beard and down the neck of his chestplate. “Ah, that *is* good. All the fine wines might come from Etril, but those Truacian bastards know how to make beer.”

He set the mug down and leaned forward, giving me a curious look. When he spoke, though, it was directed to Caera. “You’re in my domain now. You’re strong, I can tell, maybe even almost a match for me, one on one”—he smirked in a way that suggested he didn’t believe this, but was simply being polite—“but I have two dozen hard bastards at my disposal, and you’ve got one timid meat shield.”

Caera crossed her arms, looking unimpressed.

“You want to see the relic. You need to find a place for yourself in this zone, because you’re not leaving anytime soon.” That ugly, predatory grin split his face. “I have wants and needs of my own. So what are you willing to trade for your lives?”

“If you had everything you wanted already, you would’ve just killed us by the portal.” Caera leaned down so she was eye to eye with the scarred ascender. “No, I think you need help, and you’re hoping that we can provide it.”

“You think I need help? I know the way out. I solved it! All I need is more blood.” Kage stood suddenly, knocking over the footrest before jabbing a filthy finger at my unfazed companion. “And I can have you and your man-damsel killed any moment I want.”

“Then there shouldn’t be a problem with showing us the relic,” Caera answered coolly.

Rat was fidgeting while tapping his fingers rapidly on the table, his wide black eyes frozen on Kage. When he saw me watching, he stopped and busied himself preparing another mug of beer.

Kage glared at Caera. “Rat will take your servant to the shrine to see the Relic. But you stay here with me, understood?”

“No, she needs to come with me,” I said quickly, moving a little closer to her.

“Afraid to be without your lady-knight, princess?” Kage asked, fingering the handle of his scimitar.

“Your offer isn’t acceptable,” Caera said flatly. “I would see it with my own eyes, to best judge the situation for myself.”

“You’re confused. This isn’t an offer. It’s an order.” He said with a sharp toothy grin. “He can go, but you’ll stay right here. By my side.”

Both ascenders had their hands on their hilts at this point. I preferred not to leave Caera alone with this murderous lunatic, but I wasn’t quite ready to give up on my ruse, either.

Caera looked at me, searching my eyes for some guidance. I nodded imperceptibly and her hand left her weapon. Kage’s didn’t.

“Fine,” she said, half-resigned, half-annoyed. She stepped up to the warlord, who was only a bare inch taller than her. “Touch me, though, and I’ll cut off the offending body part.”

“Cheers to that.” Kage raised the mug to Caera as he waggled his brows lewdly.

Rat hurriedly escorted me out. Despite the prospects of a new relic and encountering another djinn, my thoughts went errantly to Kage, considering how best to deal with him after all this was over.

358
BLOOD RELIC II

FEIGNING NERVOUSNESS, I crept warily through the tunnels behind the man called Rat, my eyes jumping from shadow to shadow. The way was winding and twisting like a knotted rope. We moved cautiously and stopped often to listen and peek around corners, but the zone was quiet except for the light scraping of Rat's foot as it dragged behind him.

'I kind of feel bad leaving Caera with all those murderous thugs,' Regis said, the warm ethereal ball that was his presence hovering around my core.

I know, I acknowledged. *I can't fathom what she'll do to them without us there to keep her in check.*

We passed a collapsed section of the tunnel, and I noticed a churned, loose patch of wall that made me wonder if some beast—or ascender—could tunnel through the dirt. Thinking back to Kage's rapid appearance at the zone's entry portal, it made sense. The ability to pass through solid earth was fairly common among more powerful earth-attribute mages back in Dicathen.

We took a right turn that reversed sharply back on itself a moment later to dive below the tunnel we had been traversing. There were many more loose patches of wall that suggested someone travelled this way often, and the veins of red rock that lit the passages grew thicker and brighter the longer we traveled.

The aether in the atmosphere grew denser as well, filling the air like a purple mist. I was confident that Rat was leading me the right way,

and that I could find the shrine even without him using the ambient aether.

I expanded my focus in order to feel the aetheric paths connecting each point in space around me. However, with how large these networks of tunnels and caverns were, it was impossible to make sense of the feedback I received.

'As boring as it was getting to watch you act like a pansy woggart, I'll admit it was the right call.'

I know. That's why I so rarely listen to you, I mocked.

"It's unfair, isn't it?"

"Excuse me?" I asked, slightly caught off guard when Rat suddenly started speaking.

"How we are expected to serve like pets, but in the act of doing so, we become reliant on our masters' strength to keep us safe." The pale, quiet man gave me a tight-lipped smile.

"Is that why you serve Kage?" I asked, altering my inflection to sound as if I was afraid to even say the maniac's name.

Rat's hunched shoulders shrugged. "His brutality has made him effective in this place. You may not believe me, but things were worse before he came."

"You… don't think he'll hurt Lady Caera, do you?"

Although I wasn't particularly worried about Caera, knowing her to be more than capable of taking care of herself, I hoped to strike an emotional chord with my guide. If I could get him to open up to me, I could more easily navigate to the truth of what was happening in this zone, including finding out how to escape it.

Rat's back hunched further at my question. When he spoke, it was hardly more than a whisper. "Kage and his men are…not kind to womenfolk. I won't defend it, but…" He paused as I faked a frightened noise from the back of my throat, stopping and turning to face me. His black eyes peered at me searchingly. "We should keep moving. We're still some distance from the shrine."

Rat's ears twitched and he paused for a second before moving on. We travelled in silence for a time, until we reached a tunnel where thick stranglers had grown from floor to ceiling, blocking the way forward. Rat reversed course, finding another tunnel that he said would bypass the overgrown passage.

"How long have you been here?" I asked softly.

"A year…maybe more." His shoulders bobbed up and down in a helpless shrug. "I fought for a while, like the others. Then hid. Then Kage came. At least with him we have some form of order while we figure out how to claim the relic."

"Do you really think it takes a blood sacrifice to get it?" I asked, unsure.

Rat sniffed and spat on the ground as he led us through a crossing of several different tunnels. "I've seen a year of blood drained into the glyph, and it's never been enough. A few months ago, Kage dragged all the ascenders he'd imprisoned to the shrine and had their throats cut at the same time, sure that no one had ever spilled enough blood at once…but even that wasn't enough." Rat halted, listening around before addressing me. "There are some in these tunnels who think it must be something else. That maybe we read the runes wrong…" A

shiver ran down his spine, and I could practically see the weight of those deaths pressing down on him.

"Which is why"--he dragged the thought out, again giving me that searching look—"I have made arrangements for you to see more than just the shrine."

I watched him uncertainly, but said nothing.

"I think we are very much the same," he continued warily, with just a hint of hope tinging his words. "We may not be made for bloodshed and battle, but we are worth more than our masters give us credit for." He hesitated, then shook his head with a nervous smile. "My time here has dulled my manners. I haven't even asked your name."

"Grey," I said, returning his smile awkwardly. "Do you have a name other than…" I trailed off, rubbing the back of my neck.

He frowned sadly, but said, "Amand. But in here…call me Rat. Everyone else does." He straightened. "Grey, I think that together, we can end this awful cycle. I'm ready to go home, to see my…" He paused again, his frown deepening. "I have a mother…and brother…who probably think I'm dead…"

I opened my mouth, then closed it again, not having to feign my emotions as I thought of Ellie and my mother, hidden away under the Darvish desert, with no idea that I was alive.

Clearing his throat, Rat continued. "I hope you can appreciate the risk I am taking by telling you this but…for some time now, I have been passing information about Kage to the other factions in this zone."

Regis chortled. *'So our Rat is actually a mole.'*

“It has been months since anyone but Kage and his people have been allowed to see the relic, or the ward that protects it. Although Kage keeps some semblance of order here, he is not particularly… intelligent.”

“And fresh eyes might find new meaning in old words,” I said, quoting a line from a book on spellcasting I had read while still a student at Xyrus Academy.

“Exactly,” Rat agreed. “So… you will help me?”

I nervously opened my mouth, closed it, then opened it again. “I just want to get my Lady away from this zone safely.”

Nodding in acknowledgement, Rat continued leading me to the shrine, which wasn’t far from where we’d stopped to talk. Several turns later, we found three women standing in the tunnel, their weapons drawn.

I froze, but Rat kept moving toward them.

“Who is this?” a tall woman with tightly-braided hair asked, pointing her golden spear at my chest.

“He’s new,” Rat replied breathlessly. “Not one of Kage’s.”

“Why is he here?” Her liquid brown eyes tracked distrustfully across me, seeming to linger around my sternum. Her frown deepened.

Rat scratched behind his ear. “The same reason you are, T’laya.”

She clicked her tongue, but moved to the side of the tunnel. Rat slunk between the women, each one several inches taller than him, his eyes lingering on their weapons.

I mimicked his wariness as I too passed between them, standing like sentinels to either side, regarding me coldly.

We came to a point where the path split, curving away to the left and right. Rat circled around to the left, then stopped at a bare patch of wall. He closed his eyes and pressed a hand against the wall, and a humming vibration shook the passage.

Like a curtain being drawn to the sides, the wall opened, revealing a chamber completely cut off from the rest of the zone. Three men, all ragged and filthy—obviously part of Kage's gang—brandished weapons, then backed down at the sight of Rat.

An ogre of a man whose beard hung nearly to his belly set the butt of his massive two-handed axe on the ground and rested his hands on the head. He leered at the three women, showing off a mouthful of crooked, stained teeth, but his expression fell when he noticed me.

"You didn't say nothing about another man," he said gruffly. "Does Kage—"

"Would I be here if our master didn't will it?" Rat wheezed. "Kage grows impatient for the relic. This man is a potent Sentry in service to a powerful highblood. Kage has instructed that he be allowed to see the shrine along with T'laya and her womenfolk."

The burly guard didn't seem convinced, eyeing us skeptically.

"Do you ever wish to leave here, you bloodless oaf?" Rat snapped, shoeing the three guards off of a huge carving that took up most of the floor.

The man thought about this for a moment, then deferred to Rat and moved aside. Rat waved us in, gesturing to the floor.

My eyes were drawn past it, however, to what could only be the relic so many had killed and died for.

My immediate reaction was… disappointment.

The garment, which hung suspended within a golden beam of light, was best described as armored robes. They were thick and bulky, the fabric a muted grayish brown, with dark leather pauldrons, vambraces, and a gorget. Runes were embroidered into the seams and carved along the edges of the leather armor pieces.

Putting the dated style aside, the relic armor seemed to have been made for an ogre rather than man.

'Oh, I don't know. It seems rather fitting,' Regis said thoughtfully. *'A macho dress for a macho princess.'*

Something about the way the aether was moving in the room caught my eye, and I looked closer. A subtle amethyst glow of aether infused the armor.

'Is that…?'

I think so, I confirmed, enraptured by the way aether seemed to swirl around the armor, drawn to it from throughout the zone. *That's why the atmospheric aether is so much thicker here.*

T'laya crossed in front of me, breaking the relic's spell. She kneeled down over the glyph, her fingers tracing the deep grooves in the stone floor.

The glyph was a complex series of runes, carefully arranged into concentric circles. It was ingenious, like painting a picture with words, but it was an untraditional design. I couldn't help but think that even a professor of djinn runes would struggle to divine the exact meaning. This was made more complicated because parts had been worn away or damaged over time, and the grooves were stained reddish brown from all the blood that had been spilled here.

At the head of the glyph, it merged into a second, smaller symbol, where the suit of armor hovered within its protective barrier.

I bent down for a closer look, my fingers tracing the carved lines.

"Light guide me…" one of the ascender women breathed in wonder as she took in the shrine.

Rat sniffed. "What do you make of it?"

'No wonder no one has figured out how to get the thing. That glyph is a mess,' Regis said helpfully.

I reread the same section for the third time, struggling with the construction of the runes.

"It begins here," Rat said, pointing to a break in the concentric circles near the golden light and the relic. "Perhaps it would help if you read from beginning to end."

I moved to where he had indicated and began to translate with Regis's aid.

'That's a lot of blood for a race of pacifists,' Regis thought.

He was right. When Kage and Rat had revealed the reason for the violence infesting this zone, I had expected to discover that they were fools and had misread the djinn's instructions, but the glyph was thick with references to blood.

'… the blood of one who… what's that rune say?'

I don't recognize it, I admitted. *Maybe it's been damaged.*

'… of one who something something blood of our blood, may… be burdened? That doesn't make any sense… '

T'laya pointed out the same rune we had struggled with, asking if anyone could read it, but they couldn't.

My attention turned briefly to the three guards pressed against the wall. Each one was bigger—*'and dumber,'* Regis added—than just about any other ascenders I had seen, and I understood why Kage had chosen them to stand guard. Men like that showed no curiosity, and would be unlikely to think too deeply about the puzzle they stood upon, despite it being the key to a fortune they couldn't even comprehend.

"The ancient mages were a people of peace," I said, half to myself. "Their dedication to this ideal was so great that they didn't defend themselves even when another race destroyed them. Instead, they built the Relictombs to keep their knowledge alive. They didn't forge weapons or armor. That's why this relic was locked away." I pointed out a piece of the glyph. "They even call it 'a shrine to futility.'"

"But the relic is also the key to leave," Rat pointed out, picking at the whiskers on his chin. "Are you suggesting this is a dead end?" A sense of nerves settled over him. "That just can't be…"

T'laya spat on the ground. "There is a way. There is always a way in the Relictombs."

I returned my attention to the glyph, muttering to myself as I worked around it in a circle, translating it again from scratch. *"Blood of our blood… burdened by purpose… one who…"*

My brows furrowed as I reread the glyphs a few more times, focusing more on the seemingly contradictory portion of runes and piecing together what they meant.

I held in the urge to sigh at my revelation. Things were never easy.

Letting out a laugh, I got up to my feet. "I-I think I got it."

Rat approached me, his eyes narrowing at the glyphs before giving me a guarded look. “What did you find, Grey?”

My mouth opened on its own in excitement. “The blood isn’t—”

Catching myself, I let out a cough.

I took a deep breath to slow myself. “It’s just that… I… the runes call for a certain lineage’s blood…”

Seeing my reaction, Rat softened, bowing slightly. “I apologize, Grey. Many times over the last year has someone claimed to understand the runes, but it’s never been true. I didn’t mean to discount you, I am just… wary.”

I nodded and let a smile slowly creep over my face. “It needs someone of…” Then I froze, letting my mouth hang open.

“Of what, Grey?” Rat snapped, taking a step closer to me, his expression a mixture of anticipation and frustration.

“Vritra, I’m Alacrya’s worst servant,” I moaned, looking at him in dread. “I’ve nearly forgotten about Lady Caera. Do you think she’s okay? I… I’m willing to tell you how to get the relic, but we need to make sure she is safe first.”

Rat shook his head. T’laya and her companions had stopped what they were doing and were watching me distrustfully. The three guards exchanged confused looks.

“It will be easier to free her from Kage after we’ve claimed the relic. Then we’ll have the upper hand,” Rat insisted. “Once we know how to leave…”

The ogre of an ascender took a heavy step forward and pointed his axe at Rat. “Kage didn’t send you this time, did he, Rat? You lied!”

Rat flinched away from the spittle that flew from the huge ascender's lips. Before the man could come after us, however, a golden spear burst through his neck. The other two fell in the same breath, similarly impaled as T'laya and her companions ran them through.

The tall woman ripped her spear from the dead man's neck and pointed it at me. "Explain."

"The blood has to…to…" I swallowed heavily. "The blood needs to be from someone of asuran descent," I finished in a rush.

T'laya's spear pressed against my throat. "Foolishness. Lies. That is impossible."

"It's not," I hissed. "'Spill the blood of one who has harmed the blood of our blood.' The asuras…the asuras were the enemy of the ancient mages…"

T'laya's hard eyes seemed to bore into mine as she searched them for the truth. After a long few seconds, she cursed and stepped back, lowering her spear. "Then we truly are doomed to rot here forever."

I rubbed at my throat, where a bead of blood was dripping down my skin. The wound was already healed, but no one seemed to notice.

Rat was staring at me intently. I grimaced. His eyes narrowed. "What is it, Grey?"

I hesitated until T'laya let out an angry huff, then said, "Lady Caera…she is of Highblood Denoir, but not by birth. She is Vritra-blooded."

Rat's eyes flashed, his gaze so intense that I could feel it like a physical presence, then realized there *was* some physical sensation,

like kneading fingers working through my brain. Rat's face split into a wide, satisfied grin, and he raised a hand.

My body simply stopped responding. Somewhere deep down in my consciousness I could feel a nearly-imperceptible hum that was more in my bones than my ears. A sound-attribute spell, directly attacking my nervous system to paralyze me. My back was to the others, but I was sure they were affected just the same.

'It's a regalia,' Regis said in realization. *'Some kind of sound-based paralysis spell. It's pretty strong.'*

That was true. The appropriate mana shielding would prevent it from working, but the way it directly attacked the nervous system made it very effective. Physical strength made no difference in my ability to counter it.

Rat's beady black eyes twitched as he watched me, his hands clenched together in front of his chest. "You're dangerously clever," he said, licking his lips. "The ruse with the girl… Kage was a fool to make assumptions so quickly. I knew right away you weren't just some Sentry hiding his mana signature."

He tapped his head. "Another of my many very useful runes. I can hear the flow of your blood, the beating of your heart, the air whooshing through your lungs. I can tell when someone is lying. And since I know you were telling the truth just now, thankfully there is no more need for this charade on either of our parts. It has been an interesting duel—who can pretend to be more weak and pathetic—but I'm tired of it. Thank you, Grey, for your assistance."

'Art, what should I do? I—'

I told Regis what I needed from him, and he lapsed into silence.

With a lazy grin, Rat drew a long curved dagger from his belt and walked up to me. He kept eye contact as he drew the blade across my throat, and I could distantly feel the warmth of my blood spilling down my front.

My body collapsed to the ground, and Rat leaned over me. Although I couldn't move, I could still feel it as the dagger plunged into my side, my back, and finally my heart. My eyes fluttered closed, and my breath stilled.

RAT

Blood pooled under the golden-eyed ascender's body as he slumped lifelessly.

"Looks like you were of use after all." I wiped the blade with the sleeve of Grey's arm before standing up and turning to face T'laya.

The tall, proud ascender stood motionless, her companions flanking her. The rest of her people would fall quickly without these three, I was sure. I waved my dagger in front of T'laya's bloodshot eyes. Although she couldn't move, I could tell from the steady rhythm of her heartbeat that she already knew what was about to happen.

The sonic stasis spell was beginning to wear on me, so I didn't take the time to savor their deaths the way I would have liked. Once she lay dead next to her companions, I released my spell and took a weary, joyful breath.

"One last sacrifice before the end," I said, holding my dagger up to the relic like a toast.

Channeling mana into one of my lesser runes, I pressed my hand to the ground. "Kage. Bring her."

If that degenerate had followed my instructions, he would already be nearby with the highblood. There was no way to be entirely sure that Grey could solve the problem of the relic, but I had sensed the unshakable confidence he held in himself.

It had been a genuine surprise to learn the woman's secret. Although he'd left the most important part unsaid, I had heard the subtle variations of his tone that gave it away. Not only was Lady Caera Vritra-blooded, but her blood had also manifested. Without Grey's assistance, I might have committed the error of piercing her core and giving her to Kage. Knowing that she carried Vritra blood, though… that changed things.

Kage arrived a minute or two later, dragging Lady Caera behind him. Her jaw clenched when she caught sight of her companion's body on the floor. "Was killing him really necessary?"

"Lady Caera of Highblood Denoir," I said, giving her a slight bow. Her mouth snapped shut. "Blood of the Vritra." Her mouth formed into a tight line, and her face paled. I grinned with mirth at the sight. Moving to stand just in front of her, I tweaked the chains that held her wrists. "Do you have any idea how useful mana canceling restraints are on an ascent? And these are particularly high-level variations. You just never know when you'll need to disable an enemy—or ally—when there are accolades to be claimed."

Her chin lifted, emphasizing how she looked down on me. "If you know my blood, then you wouldn't dare lay a finger on me…"

Chuckling, I reached out and fumbled around her neck for the artifact I knew must be there. When my hand wrapped around the thin chain, I gave it a sharp jerk, tearing it off her neck.

Horns appeared from the sides of her head, sweeping forward and up, with secondary prongs pointing back, framing her head like a black laurel. I rang a finger along the hard, smooth surface, momentarily struck by them. She quivered in suppressed rage but didn't pull away. Instead, she spoke with forced calm, her scarlet eyes narrowed into two bloody daggers.

"When we leave here, I will have both a living relic and a Vritra-blood. Imagine it, Lady Caera. I arrive with a tale of discovering you in this convergence zone, half dead, betrayed by your most faithful servant… You wouldn't be the same, of course, not after everything you've seen, but you are alive. And with the wealth acquired from the relic, perhaps the Denoirs would even find me to be a suitable husband for your shattered self?" I gave her a mocking smile. "In a single day, I will become the most famous ascender in Alacrya. I bet I'll even get an audience with the High Sovereign. Perhaps, for the relic-finder, he would deign to marry us himself?" My smile faltered as I had a curious thought. "Why did you do it? Why hide this beautiful gift?"

Those deadly scarlet eyes only glared back at me.

"Well, enough time for such intimate conversation later. For now…"

Tugging on the horn, I dragged the struggling woman across the zone—making sure she had to step over the body of her dead companion on the way—and kicked the back of her leg so she fell to her knees.

Wrenching her hands up by the manacles constraining them, I drew a bloody line across her palm with my dagger, then shoved her to the

ground, where her bleeding hand slammed into the carved stone of the floor, smearing across the glyph.

To my disappointment, she hadn't so much as gasped in pain, but that was a trifling thought compared to what was about to unfold.

Except… nothing happened.

Letting out a put upon sigh, I felt some of my good mood slip away. "I was really hoping I could have both my prizes, but alas. We do not always get everything we hope for, do we, m'lady?"

Once again taking her by the horn, I spun Lady Caera to face me, doing her the honor of not slitting her throat from behind. Her eyes focused on something behind me, widening, and a smile spread over her face instead of the terror I should have seen.

Turning slowly, I found Grey on his feet, his wounds healed, his skin unblemished by my blade. But I knew I had stabbed him… cut his throat, pierced his heart… the blood still soaking his clothes proved I had!

Kage cursed and drew his scimitar, but he did not get the chance to attack. A black shadow burst out of Grey's body, slamming Kage to the ground. I hardly noticed, unable to look away from Grey's golden eyes.

It all made sense now: that impossible confidence the man couldn't hide. Even now I couldn't sense his mana at all. Not because he was some odd little Sentry, capable of masking his presence… no. It was because he was just that much stronger than me… but I'd taken down bigger, stronger, harder bastards than me before.

My core ached as I pushed mana into my regalia again, casting sonic stasis. A low hum of sound vibrated out from me, the exact

frequency required to interrupt the nervous system, preventing all movement.

The shadow wolf froze in place, its jaws hanging over Kage's face, drool dripping off massive teeth. Kage was paralyzed as well, on his back under the creature, his mouth open in a howl more fear than battle-cry. Behind me, I heard Lady Caera's breath stop in her lungs.

The golden-eyed ascender was motionless. I smirked and twirled my dagger for him to see.

"Do I need to sever your head from your neck to ensure you don't get back up again? Perhaps, after I've done that, I'll burn it just to be safe."

Impossibly, he shook his head. "I'd rather you don't."

Although I could see the certainty of my own death blazing within his eyes, I refused to go down without a fight. Spinning, I lunged for Lady Caera. If I could use her as a hostage, then—

Then he was next to me, the handle of a jagged amethyst dagger glowing between his fingers, the blade in my belly. In my core. My magic released with a burst of angry static that made my ears ring. I could hear the woman's steady breathing, and Kage's growling as the beast pinned him to the floor.

The strength left my body as I sank to the ground at Grey's feet. My blood flowed freely, filling the grooves of the glyph.

Above me, the golden light began to flicker. With the last piece of my strength, I stretched to see the relic.

The barrier, so long impenetrable, faded away.

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POTENTIALS

ELEANOR LEYWIN

The long tunnels between the sanctuary cavern and Elder Rinia's little cave were empty and devoid of life. We had already hunted the cave rats to extinction, apparently. There were a few hundred people to feed in the sanctuary now, and even though the mana beasts tasted like a treeskunk smells, they were edible—if you burned the meat black and didn't think too hard about what you were eating.

Although Elder Rinia had said she was too ill for visitors, I couldn't just stay away after what I'd overheard between Virion and Windsom. I *had* to talk to someone, but I was terrified to tell anyone else. Since Rinia would already know—she was a seer after all—at least I wouldn't be endangering her by revealing what I'd learned.

When we reached the mouth of the narrow crevice that served as an entrance to Rinia's home, I scratched Boo under his chin and behind his ear. "You wait here, big guy. I'll be right back."

There was a bitter, earthy smell wafting out of the cave that reminded me of dandelion leaves.

I shimmied through the crack in the solid stone. Before I even poked my head out into the cave, a tired, croaking voice said, "Well, come in, I suppose."

A fire was burning in the far wall, and Rinia was sitting in front of it in her wicker chair, covered in a thick blanket. The cave was sweltering hot and thick with the bitter scent.

“I seem to recall telling you I wasn’t in the mood for visitors,” Rinia rasped, her back to me. “And yet, the curse of the seer is that I can’t even be surprised that you didn’t listen.”

I glanced around the cave before responding. Aside from the natural alcove in which Rinia’s fire blazed, she had a small checker-board table covered in stones, a massive cabinet against one wall, and a low stone table that was covered in cuttings and pulped plants, likely to brew whatever was bubbling away in the pot over her fire. A small alcove contained her bed and a very fine, very out-of-place dresser.

“I’m sorry for disturbing you, Elder Rinia, but I needed to…” I hesitated, taking in her current status, “Are you okay?” As much as I wanted to speak to her about Elenoir, I couldn’t suppress the feeling that something was wrong.

“Fit as a flitter flea,” she japed, pulling the blanket more tightly around her.

I slowly crossed the room and walked around Rinia’s chair so I could get a better look at her. Her skin was withered and dry, and her eye sockets sunken and dark. Thin, white hair draped over her face and loose strands clung to the blanket, having fallen from her head. Most startling, though, were her eyes: they stared at the fire, milky white and sightless.

“Rinia…” I started, but my throat constricted and I had to pause and gather myself. “Why? What have you been—”

“Looking, child,” she said, her voice low and croaking. “Always looking.”

I went to my knees in front of her and took her hand in both of mine, leaning forward to rest my cheek against it. Her skin was dry as

parchment and uncomfortably chilly considering the blazing heat in the cave. “For what? What could possibly be worth this?”

“It’s all in the balance, now. My home…Elenoir…” Rinia trailed off, her hand twitching feebly against my cheek. “It was just the beginning. Dicathian, Alacryan…human, elf, or dwarf…kindling. Our homes—our entire world—will burn unless I see…”

“See what?” I asked after a prolonged pause. “What are you looking for?”

“Everything,” she whispered.

We sat there in silence for a long time, and I thought for a while that she had fallen asleep. My mind felt numb, and I realized that I hadn’t really believed Virion or Rinia when they talked about her being ill. Seeing her now…she was like a ghost of herself, barely clinging to life. I couldn’t help but wonder at how much she must have used her power to decline so rapidly.

Our homes—our entire world—will burn…

A shiver ran through me as those words echoed in my mind. “What can I do?” I asked, my voice escaping my lips as little more than a whisper.

“Be in the right place at the right time,” Rinia answered, making me jump.

I scooted away from the fire and sat on the floor with my legs crossed, gazing up at Rinia’s craggy face. “Where is the right place, and when is the right time?”

“That is always the question,” she answered vaguely.

My heart was hammering in my chest. I hated these games, but felt more pity for the old woman than frustration. It was clearer than

ever that she really was trying to help. “This has something to do with what Virion and Windsom are hiding, doesn’t it?”

She turned, shifting her body under the blanket to a chorus of popping and creaking. “Don’t get involved, child. It is a…delicate situation. Your instincts on this were right: just keep it to yourself. Whatever we think about what was done, fighting against Virion now only leads to catastrophe. We both know you didn’t need to come see me for affirmation of that.”

“Did…” I struggled against the urge to press her on what she’d known and when. It seemed like that always ended up with me feeling bitterly disappointed. But the tension built up inside me until the words just kind of tumbled out. “Did you know what would happen to Tessia—to me—when I asked you about the mission?”

She let out a rattling laugh that quickly turned into a cough. “Every choice, every future, all leading to a single outcome. Always, always.”

“What do you mean?” I asked, insistent.

“It was fate that Tessia would fulfill her role as vessel for Agrona’s weapon,” she said, closing her eyes and sinking back into her chair. “All I could do was attempt to arrange for the most positive circumstances in which that would happen.”

“You could have said. You could have *told me* Tess shouldn’t go. Virion would have stopped her, he—”

“In the future you describe,” she snapped, “the slave caravan is saved, but Curtis Glayder elects not to go on to Eidelholm and rescue the rest of the elves held there. One of those young women, while begging her new master not to desecrate her, offers up a piece of

knowledge, the only thing she has of value: the name of a man who has helped others escape the Alacryans.

"They find him. Then they find us. Many of us die. And Tessia is taken anyway," Rinia finished bitterly.

"Then what about Arthur? Why *tell him* not to let the Alacryans have her?" I asked, my voice cracking a little when I said my brother's name. "Why did he have to…have to…" I choked on the sentence, turning away from the elder to hide my tears.

"Because it wasn't time yet," she sighed.

I stared at her, my tears drying as quickly as they'd appeared when anger quickly took over. "But he *died*!" I hissed. "And they captured her anyway!"

"I know, child." She reached a trembling hand out toward me, but I scooted a few inches farther away, and eventually her hand slowly fell. "I know."

"Was it his fate to die?" I asked quietly. "Did it have to happen?"

Rinia shivered, a slow tremble that seemed to start in her chest and work outward until it had passed through her toes. "Oh, how the hell should I know. A puzzle piece that doesn't fit, that's what your brother was. I could never really see his future, not like everyone else."

"It's always games with you," I muttered angrily, my temper getting the better of me. "Arthur wasn't some piece on a game board. He was my brother!" I shouted, then immediately felt guilty as Rinia's blind eyes slowly fluttered open. "I'm sorry."

She only shook her head. "It's not easy, child. Your entire life is moving a small stick floating in a pond, from one side of the water to

the other. But you can only move the stick by throwing pebbles into the pond and letting it ride the ripples. And the thing is—you're blindfolded. Sometimes the wind kicks up and blows the stick about. I'm no different. One eye open, maybe, and I can see all your little sticks and the ripples that move them, but everyone is always disrupting the flow by throwing their stones in at random, disrupting the whole mess…"

Lifting my knees up to my chest, I curled up around them. My eyes were burning, my throat swollen, but I didn't let any more tears fall. I ground my teeth and pinched myself. The suppressed tears weren't for my brother, or Tessia, or even myself…it was everyone, every*thing*. A deep-rooted sadness had settled over me, cold and somehow comforting, like a blanket of snow. I felt the pressure, the drive to *do* something, to fight back and change things, fading away. The world's problems were so big, there was nothing else I could do to save it.

The realization that I could just let go brought me a kind of peace.

But I didn't want to be hopeless. I didn't want to give up, to let everyone else fight to take back our future while I hid, comfortable in my hopelessness.

Mentally, I called out to Boo, and a moment later his huge bulk *popped* into the cave, just behind me. He filled the small space and could have easily made a wreckage of Rinia's things, but he seemed to sense that I needed comfort instead of protection; he lay down behind me, and I leaned against him, letting my fingers play through his fur.

"Well, that's new," Rinia said, the ghost of a smile on her lips.

A flood of warmth issued from my core, clearing my mind and burning away the cold blanket of apathy.

"Give me hope," I said softly. "Please Rinia. In all your looking, you must have seen some glimmer…"

The old woman pushed the blanket aside, letting it fall to the floor. I would have sworn I could hear her bones creaking as she began to stand, but when I moved to help her, she waved me back down. Once free of the chair, she took a few slow, shuffling steps toward me, until she could rest her hand on Boo's back. Very carefully, the old seer began to lower herself down next to me.

"Rinia, you shouldn't—"

"Don't imagine you can tell me what I should or shouldn't do, child," she snapped.

I helped to guide her as best I could, until she was resting on the ground next to me, her back against Boo's side, just like mine was.

"Hope isn't always a good thing," she said, panting slightly. "When lost, it can break a person's spirit. When false, it may keep people from taking care of themselves."

"Then give me *real* hope," I said, reaching for her hand again and squeezing very gently.

Rinia leaned sideways so that her head was resting on my shoulder. "There is a right place and a right time. And I know when and where that is."

I stayed with Grandma Rinia for a couple more hours, eventually helping her back into her chair, getting her a bowl of soup, and

reminiscing about the time when Mother, Father, and I had hidden with her in a different secret cavern. But eventually she grew tired, so I helped her to her bed and left.

The conversation had worn me out. There was just something about trying to wrap my head around Rinia's seer-talk of potential futures and positive circumstances that exhausted my mind and made me feel small and childish. But then I reminded myself that when Arthur was fourteen he was off in the land of gods, training with deities to fight a war that would change the entire world.

I patted Boo's side as we hiked silently through the winding tunnels. "Mind if I ride, big guy?"

The guardian bear grunted an affirmative and stopped. I sidled up onto his back and leaned forward to rest my head on my forearms, just letting myself float atop his broad frame. "Whatever happens, we'll always take care of each other, right Boo?"

Another grunt.

"Just like Arthur and Sylvie, together until the end."

He huffed at the comparison, making me laugh.

Boo didn't need any guidance from me to find the sanctuary, so I closed my eyes and replayed my conversation with Rinia. It had been long overdue, and I was glad to have left her on positive terms. Seeing her had made me realize just how little time she likely had left. I wished she could have told me more about this "right place and right time" she kept talking about. If she slipped away before the time came… I could only trust that she knew when the end would come.

ELDER RINIA

Once the Leywin child and her beast had finally left, I returned to my work.

Lying in bed, I stared at nothing, my physical eyes now useless. But that hardly mattered. Only my third eye was needed, the one that could see beyond the here and now to what could be.

My core ached when I reached for the mana, and I struggled to build up enough strength to cast the spell. *Damned old body*, I cursed to myself. But I knew that, in truth, my physical body had held together far longer than it ever should have.

It had been my sister who learned of the potion that could strengthen our bodies, even as our life force faded. Too late to do herself much good—but then, even in the midst of her impassioned efforts to save Virion's life, she had never pressed herself the way I did now.

I sent a silent thanks to her, wherever her spirit rested in the afterlife. I couldn't yet be sure if my efforts would make a difference in the end, but I'd gained months of time to look thanks to the potion still bubbling over my little fire.

Casting Sight, I felt myself relax as the third eye opened in my spirit. Through this metaphysical eye, the aetheric world became visible, revealing an infinitely complex web of intertwining threads spreading out into the future. Just seeing them wasn't enough, however.

As my master had taught me, I reached out toward the aevum…slowly, tentatively, like one would approach a half-wild animal. But it was my affinity for aevum that gave me my diviner's powers, and as it had a thousand times before, the aether reacted,

drifting toward my third eye and connecting my mind to the tapestry of possible futures that was laid out before me.

I ignored the way they all cut off at the same point.

Now where was I…

Picking a thread, I plucked on it. It pulled back, drawing my consciousness along the timeline it represented.

When I didn't like what I saw, I found a branching thread and plucked it instead.

It was even worse.

I knew where I needed to be, and when. But there was more to it than just being in the right place at the right time, regardless of what I'd told Ellie. The journey was equally as important as the destination. Which only made it all the more frustrating to know I was running out of time.

Heaving a shuddering sigh, I picked the next thread, then the next, and the next after that.

ELEANOR LEYWIN

I was woken from my doze by the sensation of falling, like stumbling in a dream.

The tunnel was foggy and the air had a heavy, sickly-sweet smell that made my stomach clench up and my head swim.

"Boo?" I asked, my tongue stumbling thickly over the familiar name. "What is it?"

My mind was slow from the nap, and I couldn't shake myself awake, but I was sure something was wrong with Boo. He was walking sluggishly, taking deep, snorting, labored breaths…

My bond let out a nervous whine. I patted his neck and said, “Hey, it’s just fog, Boo, we’re…”

I sniffed at the air again. *The fog…*

Closing my eyes, I focused on the beast will lurking in my mana core, which was now dark orange. Reaching into myself, I prodded the will, igniting it and receiving a burst of smells and sounds from my enhanced senses.

The tunnels were dank and smelled a little like rot. Boo’s heavy musk was everywhere, as was the stinky smell left behind by the cave rats that used to live here, but the rotten scent of the fog overwhelmed everything else. The tunnels were almost entirely silent. Somewhere below me, I could just hear the faint pitter-patter of water dripping from a cave roof to splash into a shallow pool, but the only other sounds were Boo’s uneven, scuffling steps and my own slow heartbeat.

Boo missed another step, sending an uncomfortable jolt through my stomach.

I reached for my bow, but couldn’t fumble it off of my back. One of Boo’s legs gave way, and I tumbled off to land heavily on the ground. I knew that it should have hurt, but all I could feel was the overwhelming desire to shut my eyes.

Boo’s powerful jaws closed on the back of my shirt and he began to drag me, but even through my foggy senses I could hear his labored breathing.

“Boo…?”

I let out a mindless giggle at the sound of my own voice, slurred and silly. I knew I should be scared, but really, I just felt like… going… to… sleep…

Boo released me, letting out a warning growl. I just barely managed to turn my head enough to look down the tunnel, where I could see two silhouettes approaching. Their faces were covered… or maybe that was just my eyes going blurry.

"Easy now, big guy," one of the silhouettes said, their voice muffled by the cloth.

Boo roared and lunged, his massive paw slashing drunkenly at the figures. They dodged back, but I heard a hissing breath and a curse.

"You… get 'em… Boooo," I slurred.

Boo lurched forward and stumbled on the ground while swinging his claws. He let out a low, mewling grunt I thought was fear, then everything went dark.

Through the darkness, I could hear footsteps approaching.

"Don't… mess… with me," I mumbled weakly. "I'm… a…"

Strong arms scooped me up like I was a baby.

"Leywin…"

A voice, soft and sad, echoed out of the black nothing that surrounded me.

"Sorry, Eleanor."

My eyes blinked open, or at least I thought they did. Everything was gray and fuzzy. My head felt like it was full of cobwebs, and my

mouth and throat were so dry they hurt. I blinked again several times, slowly.

"Mama?"

I giggled at the sound of my own voice, which croaked like a fat old toad. The noise died instantly as my breath caught in my chest, and I realized with a spike of clarity that something really bad had happened.

"Mama? Papa?"

A shadow moved across my blurred vision and garbled voices oozed through my cobweb brain. I couldn't understand them.

"B-Brother? Brother!"

The voices were speaking nonsense, and one of the figures came closer. I lifted my hands to ward them off and was shocked by a metallic jingling and the sensation of cold on my wrists.

"Bro—"

Everything came rushing back to me, forcing out a choked gasp. My father and brother were dead. *Rinia, the gas… Boo!*

"Boo!" I shouted, not trying to hide my panic. He should be with me, I knew. He should teleport to me, be right beside me. "What did you do to Boo?" I began to sob.

Strong hands pressed down on my shoulders. A face was right in front of mine, blurry at first, then vaguely familiar, then—

"Albold…?"

"Please calm down, Ellie," he said firmly, releasing my shoulders. "Boo is unharmed, though I can't say the same for us. We left him in the tunnels. I would have preferred to do this a different way, but we *must* know what *you* know."

“We…what?” I shook my head, trying to clear the last of the cobwebs. “You…you attacked me!” I glared at him accusingly.

A second figure moved into view to rest his hand on Albold’s shoulder. The gaunt elf’s hood was still up, but the cloth covering his face had been removed. “We need the truth, Eleanor. We didn’t think you’d tell us unless you had no choice.”

“Feyrith you…you…you jerk!” I snapped. Leaning back, I screamed, “Boo! Boo, help!”

Albold kneeled in front of me and grabbed the manacles chaining my hands together. He gave a sharp jerk that tweaked my shoulders and elbows uncomfortably. His eyes—colorless in the dark cave—pinned me like arrows. “Enough, Ellie. We took steps to ensure that your beast couldn’t follow us. Those mana suppression cuffs should—”

Pop!

A roar like earth and stone being ripped apart exploded from right beside me, and Albold was flung backward across the cave, slamming hard into the jagged stone. A hairy wall moved in front of me, breathing heavily, and snarling with rage and fear.

A thick barrier of water appeared with a *whoosh* and bisected the cave, separating Boo and me from Albold and Feyrith, though I could only just see the edges around Boo’s huge bulk.

Feyrith’s voice was muffled as he shouted, “Eleanor, please listen! We won’t hurt you, we just need to talk.”

“You have a funny way of talking,” I snapped back. Boo turned to look me over, making sure I was okay. I held up the chains. With an irritated snort, he bit down on them, crushing the enchanted metal

links like they were old bones. The suppressive magic vanished, and I felt my core thrumming to life again.

"We…we needed to be sure, "Feyrith said desperately. "With everything that's at stake, we couldn't have you to brush us off or tell us you couldn't discuss it."

I stood and shook out my arms and legs, which still felt half asleep. When I was certain I wouldn't fall over, I stepped around Boo and walked up to the wall of water, glaring at the elves on the other side. Boo moved like a shadow beside me, his teeth bared.

Albold was brushing himself off, and I noticed his pants had been ripped and he had a bandage around his leg, soaked through with blood. Both elves were eyeing my bond warily. I patted Boo's shoulder.

"I can't believe I've been trying to find you for weeks," I grumbled, meeting Albold's eye. He grimaced, but didn't look away. "What do you jerks want? You get one chance. And don't think Boo won't *eat* you if you attack me again."

Boo snarled threateningly.

Feyrith released his spell and the wall of water fell away, draining into the floor and leaving dry rock behind. His hands were up in a gesture of peace as he stepped forward. "We know Virion is lying, Eleanor. His story doesn't make sense. And we know you spoke to the asura, Windsom, and that you have visited the old seer." His hands fell to his sides and gripped the edges of his cloak desperately.

Albold ground his teeth audibly. "I have no idea why a twelve-year-old girl is so involved in all this, but we need to know what you know."

“Fourteen!” I said indignantly, crossing my arms over my chest. “And whatever Virion has told you, it’s for your own good.” I remembered Rinia’s words. “Fighting him will only lead to catastrophe.”

Albold scowled. “That’s not good enough. We—all of the elves—deserve to know the truth. If Virion is working with the enemy—”

I blew a raspberry, acting like the age that they thought I was and drawing shocked looks from both of the elves. “The truth sucks! Knowing it doesn’t help, trust me.”

Albold had a hard, desperate look, but Feyrith seemed to be shrinking in on himself. “You aren’t an elf, Eleanor. You can’t know what this is like.”

I opened my mouth to snap back that I *did* know what it was like to lose people, but the words died in my throat.

What did Rinia say again? I asked myself, trying not to waver while wracking my stressed brain for the details of our conversation. *Don’t get involved. It’s a delicate situation…*

“I know you’ve lost people too, Eleanor…” Feyrith said, taking a half-step forward, but freezing when Boo let out a low growl. “I didn’t know your father, really, but… Arthur Leywin was my greatest rival, and a close friend. His loss affected us all.” Feyrith’s voice was shaking. “But I lost *everyone,* do you understand? My—”

The elf broke, his face twisting into a grimace as tears flooded down his cheeks and sobs wracked his shoulders. He pressed a hand over his eyes, curling in on himself even further. Through his sobs, he said, “My entire family… they… they’re all *gone*.” He sank to the floor, and Albold kneeled awkwardly next to him, his expression unreadable.

Feyrith wiped a sleeve across his face and took a shaky breath. "I tried to save them…but I got caught…never even got close. I left them against their wishes to attend Xyrus Academy…to be more than just the fourth son of a noble family, but I failed them, do you understand? And now they're…just gone…"

Albold was pale as a ghost next to the red-faced Feyrith. His gaze focused into the distance, not looking at his companion or me. "Our king and queen, gone. Our princess, gone. Our home, our culture, gone. Our friends and family, teachers, lovers, rivals…our whole world, gone." Only then did he meet my eye. "And we don't even get to understand why."

I couldn't look away from his piercing eyes. What could I possibly say to ease such complete and bitter loss? If they knew what had really happened in Elenoir, would it actually make them feel better, or just more helpless—hopeless—like me? *Besides*, I reasoned with myself, *Rinia told me to stay out of it.*

But then, she hadn't told me not to tell anyone else. I didn't think the truth would bring the elves any sort of closure, but didn't they deserve it anyway?

I leaned against Boo, running my fingers through his fur and listening to his heart hammering in my ears over the sound of my gnashing teeth. "Okay. I'll tell you."

360
BLOOD RELIC III

CAERA DENOIR

My gaze stayed pinned to Grey's back as we navigated the labyrinthine tunnels, silent except for Kage's constant wheedling. Despite now appearing perfectly healthy, it was difficult to dismiss the image of Grey lying motionless, his throat cut…

I squeezed my eyes shut, blinking away the image and instead focusing on the persistent prattle coming from Kage as he guided us toward the hidden exit portal.

"—not really my fault at all now, see? When Rat saw how people would just leave after a while, after they decided the relic couldn't be claimed, he came up with the idea to close the portal and force people to stay. I just went along with it is all…but what else was I supposed to do?"

"And were you forced to make the female ascenders who found their way into this zone your playthings, as well?"

Kage's hulking form shrunk under my gaze despite the fact that we hadn't bothered to restrain him with mana shackles. Still, the dog had some bite left in him, and I could feel his mana flaring in anger.

"Keep walking, grunt," Regis snapped as he stalked closely behind the scarred ascender.

My eyes found themselves settling on Grey's back again as he moved mutely behind Regis, letting the shadow wolf herd Kage to our destination.

An uncomfortable, writhing frustration was worming its way through my insides as I considered again what Grey had asked me to do.

He knew that Kage wasn't a threat to me, but the truth was that Grey still had silently demanded his complete trust. I was left on my own as collateral, like some damsel in distress—a stereotype of weakness and fragility I'd been fighting against my entire life—and Grey had expected me to put myself in a state of vulnerability without even the opportunity to question or understand what he was doing.

It took every fiber of self-control to keep myself from killing Kage when he had withdrawn a pair of mana suppression cuffs and announced that we would be following after Rat and Grey together.

I rubbed at the faint bruises on my wrist, the dull aches a physical reminder of the danger in trusting too much—something I had never been guilty of before. I chose to let my power be taken away, trusting in Grey that nothing would happen to me.

Nothing too bad anyway, I conceded as I pressed the bandages against the bloody gash on my palm.

Preoccupied by these thoughts, I found myself nearly bumping into Grey, not realizing that Kage had stopped.

"It's right here, just so," he mumbled, giving Regis a gap-toothed grin, like a beaten servant seeking his overbearing master's approval.

"Do you want a cookie or something?" Regis's burning mane flickered with annoyance. "Open it."

Kage blanched before raising his hands to the bare earthen wall. The soil trembled, then melted away to either side, flowing like mud in a

sudden landslide to reveal a hidden tunnel. Regis herded our unwilling guide into the passage, which led to a dead end. Kage repeated the spell, opening up a second hidden tunnel, which led to a third and fourth before finally opening into a round cave.

Veins of glowing red rock grew in a circular pattern on the ceiling, lighting the cave with an eerie glow and bathing the portal in rusty light. The portal itself, which sat at the very center of the room, looked like a scarlet curtain falling through the brick-red stone of the frame.

We all walked around Kage, who had stopped dead at the mouth of the tunnel, nervously watching us. As soon as our attention was off him, he spun and sprinted back in the direction we'd come.

Regis watched him go with a look of faint amusement on his lupine face.

Without even looking back, Grey said, "Get rid of him," and Regis took off at a run.

Grey seemed to have already put Kage out of his mind, his attention entirely on the portal. He walked around it twice, staring into the opaque depth as if he could see what was waiting on the other side.

His clothes were torn where he'd been stabbed, and stained red with blood. I didn't yet fully understand what had happened. Grey hadn't explained how he'd deactivated the shield, only how he'd taken the relic and ordered Kage to lead us to the portal. He'd been silent nearly the entire way.

He stopped suddenly and his gaze fell to my injured palm. "I'm sorry about that."

I flexed my cut hand, which was wrapped in a piece of Grey's torn shirt. The wound burned, but it wasn't particularly deep and would heal quickly. "I'll forgive you if you explain exactly what happened back there."

"Fair enough." He turned thoughtful for a moment. "Rat's demeanor was unnatural for someone being held captive. Little things. But it all really clicked when I saw the glyph and realized they had no idea how to really open it."

"What do you mean?"

Grey bent down and used dirt from the floor to scour away some of the blood staining his hands. When he looked at me, his eyes were cool and calculating. "I thought about what I'd do if I were in their position. How I would motivate the strong, often intellectual, ascenders who arrived in this zone…"

"But if you figured out the glyphs right away, why let yourself be cut to ribbons?"

Grey's fingers unconsciously played with the holes in his tunic where Rat's blade had pierced him. "Because I needed him to. They were right in that it demanded a blood sacrifice, but it had to be from one who had harmed the blood of the djinn."

So you let him stab you? I nearly asked, but I was already putting the pieces together in my mind. Villains were often predictable, after all. All Grey had to do was give Rat a reason to spill his blood, making Rat himself the key to unlocking the relic. But then, that meant…

"So, *you* have ancient mage—djinn—blood?"

Grey shrugged nonchalantly. “I imagine plenty of people do. But the Relictombs called me “descendant” before, and confirmed I had a djinn ancestor…I guess that’s all it took.”

I opened my mouth to ask about this ancient mage ancestry, but slowly let it close again. Although I wanted to know more, I could tell by the way Grey was growing more deadpan and terse that I wouldn’t get the answers I craved. It was beyond frustrating that he continued to live behind this veil of mystery after I’d shown such trust in him, but then…I knew what I had signed up for when we made our agreement.

A brief moment of silence passed before I let out a deep breath. “What drives you to such lengths?”

Grey’s brows rose in surprise. He cleared his throat and stood suddenly. He was silent so long I didn’t think he was going to answer, but then a sad smile crept across his features, an expression that contained so little yet so much emotion. “I owe it to everyone I left behind to come back strong enough to take care of them.”

I tried to fit this answer into the broken mosaic that was my picture of Grey’s life—filled with gaps that represented everything I didn’t know about him—but it did little to resolve the mystery of what drove him to such extremes.

Before I could decide if I wanted to pry further, a scream, followed by a deep, booming voice resounded down the tunnel. “Only I get to call him princess!”

The tunnels trembled, and a light trickle of dust fell on us from above. I met Grey’s wide, golden eyes, and we both broke into a quiet fit of laughter.

Shaking my head, I asked, “So? Are you going to check out the relic or are tattered rags a part of your new image now?”

He rolled his eyes, but activated his dimension rune and withdrew the relic.

I stifled a laugh as he held up the set of ancient heavy battlerobes. The gray-brown robes were much too long for him, and would drag behind him like a wedding gown. “Try it on, Grey,” I said, unable to help myself. “Perhaps a pretty dress for the pretty princess will actually help you stay incognito…”

He ignored me as he investigated the robes, his fingers trailing along the rows of embroidered runes. The touch was gentle, a curious caress, and I could see his lips moving though he did not speak aloud. I knew he must be able to sense something from the robes, although I could feel only a small charge of mana within them, little more than the ring he wore on his finger.

Grey let the robes drape over one arm and pressed his hand down into the fabric. “I think…”

The battlerobes vanished, leaving behind a vague nimbus of purple light that faded away a moment after.

“What happened?” I asked, unsure if he had simply stored the robed away again, or activated some kind of aether-based ability that I couldn’t sense.

The corners of his mouth twitching, Grey did something—a kind of mental flexing that pressed against the air around us and made the hairs stand up on the back of my neck—and the robes reappeared, now draped over his frame. He held his arms out to his sides, examining the effect.

He looked ridiculous. I opened my mouth to tell him so, but froze. The robes were *moving*, the dry fabric rippling like muddy water, shrinking to fit his frame.

The brown-gray coloring darkened to a brilliant black, and the heavy fabric that hung down to drag on the ground separated and reformed into individual legs. The relic—no longer a robe at all—continued to tighten until it fit Grey like a second skin. The material hardened into small, liquid-black scales that clung to his body, highlighting his lithe but muscular frame. Gold glittered between the scales, running along the length of his body like shining tendons.

Scaled sabatons molded around his boots, the overlapping blades held together by a gold mesh, just barely visible when he moved, and ridged pauldrons formed to cover his shoulders. Clawed gauntlets grew over his hands and up his forearms.

The robe's cowl transformed into the same black scales, but shrank to cover Grey's throat, chin, and the sides of his head, leaving his bright hair to hang over the void-black armor and keeping his face visible. Just as I thought the transformation was complete, obsidian horns formed over his ears, growing out of the armor and sweeping forward and down to frame his jaw.

I gasped, sucking in a choked breath as I realized I had forgotten to breathe.

ARTHUR LEYWIN

I flexed my hands, which were entirely encompassed by the clawed gauntlets, and conjured an aetheric blade. The long dagger shivered, its form momentarily jagged, then stabilized. I could feel the pressure of it against my palm, uninhibited by the gauntlets.

Dismissing the blade, I raised my arms and rotated my shoulders, then lashed out at the air with a series of kicks and punches.

The armor moved with me perfectly, leaving my motions unhindered.

A dark shape in the corner of my eye caught my attention, and I raised my hand to touch the horn growing from the half-helm.

"Whoa," Regis's familiar voice said as he loped back into the small cave. "What the hell happened while I was gone?"

Smirking at my companion, I sent a pulse of aether to the armor, and it vanished, melting away in an aetheric nimbus.

His bright eyes bulged, then grew comically wider as I resummoned the armor with only the barest application of aether. It wrapped around me like a shadow, so light and well-fit that I could barely feel it.

"Ayy! Matching horns!" Regis gave a throaty chuckle. "We can be the horny trio."

Caera sputtered as she glowered at my companion. "We're not calling ourselves that."

Regis circled me, sniffing. "It's there, real and physical, but also…"

"A manifestation of aether," I finished for him. "Like energy bound into a physical form." Curious, I held out my arm. "Regis, bite me."

Showing a worrying lack of hesitation, he bit down on my forearm, his teeth grinding against the armor. I felt it as a pressure, obvious but painless. Tilting my head at my companion, I goaded, "Is that all you got?"

Growling, Regis bit down harder, and the pressure increased. Focusing on my forearm, I pushed aether out to my skin in the same

way I would protect myself with an aetheric barrier. The armor seemed to react to it, drawing on the aether to bolster its defensive capabilities and reducing the crushing pressure.

Regis let go and pawed at his tongue. “Yuck. It’s like sticking my tongue on a battery. My mouth’s all tingly now.”

Though I was curious to keep testing the abilities of this new relic, the low hum of the exit portal was drawing me in, and I was eager to move onto the next zone and test the armor properly. “We should go.”

Caera frowned as she glanced at the tunnel into this small cave. “What about the other people in this zone? Should we…?”

“I don’t want to give anyone any more reason to think we were the ones who took the relic than we already have,” I answered. “The tunnel that leads here is obvious enough now, and they’ll inevitably start looking again, now that Rat and Kage are gone. They’ll find it.”

Caera looked uncertain, but moved to stand next to me in front of the portal. “Do your thing with the Compass, then.”

I reached out and took her hand, surprising her. We had matched simulets to keep us together as we navigated the Relictombs, but this time around, I felt certain that the portal’s destination would only be accessible to me and wanted to ensure we weren’t separated. “This portal already leads to where we need to go.”

Once Regis was back inside my body, we stepped into the scarlet curtain together.

And then, we found ourselves in a bizarre dreamscape that my mind struggled to accept. It was like the sterile white hallway Regis and I had navigated to reach the first djinn ruin, except…

Chunks of bright white floor and wall floated over—or under, or within—an endless black void, shattered and pulled apart, each individual section floating free, some spinning, others upside down or sideways…but in the gaps, when viewed from the corner of my eye, I saw a room like a library, except instead of books on the shelves there were rows and rows of rainbow-colored crystals, and in the facets of the crystals, images moved like memories…

"Grey…" Caera's voice came from far away, echoing as it folded over itself, repeating several times, but she wasn't beside me. I wasn't sure when she had left, or even when I had released my grip on her hand.

I took a tentative step forward and my perspective shifted. Caera was there, leaning against an incomplete section of wall. The floor beneath our feet was slowly rotating, bringing into view another part of the disassembled corridor and, far away, a vortex of shattered black crystal, which was pulsating as the pieces recombined to form a gate, then shattered again, repeating this every few seconds in a way that was difficult to look at.

"It's okay," I said, taking her arm. "I'm here."

The library—or the immaterial vision of it that I had seen from the corner of my eye—was gone, replaced by a crumbling ruin similar to the one in which I'd discovered the first djinn projection. Like the library, I could only see it when I didn't look directly at it, and I didn't know how to reach it, because it felt like we were already there.

'The gate,' Regis suggested. *'If we can get to it somehow.'*

Caera's eyes fluttered open, and she slid her arm out of mine and straightened. She was pale and sweating slightly, but steeled herself

against the sickening disorientation of the collapsing zone. “What a horrendous place…”

“I don’t think it is intended to be—” Looking at Caera, I realized with a jolt of panic that her horns were visible.

Afraid that the zone was somehow interfering with the magic, just like in the frozen zone, I checked my new armor, staring at the scales and reaching up to touch a horn…but the armor was intact. However, something in the zone was affecting it, causing it to emit a kind of aura that seemed, somehow, to stabilize the area around me.

When I bent my head to look through the narrow aura—a half-inch wide zone around me where space was bent back into the correct shape—I could see the whole and unbroken corridor wrapping around us.

With Caera at my side—she drew her long blade to help keep her balance as she walked along a corridor she couldn’t fully see—I led the way along the passage, using the image filtered through the hazy aura surrounding my armor to navigate until we stood before the black crystal gate.

In my mind, a broken, garbed voice said, *‘Enter-welcome-descendant-please,’* causing a spike of pain behind my right temple.

The million shards of the crystal gate folded outward, unfurling like a flag and dissolving into an ashy cyclone. I waited to find myself suddenly standing in the library I had seen out of the corner of my eye, but nothing happened. Then the gate was reforming, the crystal shards reappearing and flying back together.

‘Enter-welcome-descendant-please,’ sounded in my head a second time, driving the spike of pain deeper.

Regis's voice sounded fuzzy around the edges when he said, *'We need to do something, chief. I don't think Caera can last long here.'*

Caera wobbled slightly, her eyes shut tight against the painfully unreal vision of the breaking and reforming gate. "What's happening, Grey? I can't bear to open my eyes…"

Blinking hard against the line of blazing agony in my skull, I watched as the crystal gate shattered and started to reform again. Some survival instinct ingrained deep within me warned against stepping into the gate. I imagined being caught in its loop forever, pulled apart and rebuilt over and over until the Relictombs degraded and the zone collapsed…

I saw the circular room of ruined stone again from the corner of my eye. It was so close, like I could just…

In a flash of realization, I unfocused my eyes and searched for the aetheric pathways I could access with God Step, but they were warped and knotted amongst themselves. But if I was right, it wouldn't matter.

I grabbed Caera's arm and activated my godrune.

The zone resolved into a clone of the first ruin I'd visited, made up of bare gray stone, broken and crumbling in many places. At the center of the room was another rune-covered pedestal, around which rotated four stone halos. Or, there should have been four.

Instead, only two halos kept up their slow revolutions. From the shattered mass of stone at the base of the pedestal, it was clear what had happened to the other two.

Like before, a small crystal hovered just over the pedestal, pulsing with an inconsistent lavender light. And like before, something

within the room, something other than the crystal, contained a monstrous amount of aether.

A woman stepped out from behind the pillar. Caera lifted her blade defensively, but I put a reassuring hand on her shoulder. She shot me a probing glance before slowly lowering the weapon.

The woman had ignored Caera entirely. Her glowing purple eyes were locked on me, or more specifically my armor.

She was barely five feet tall, and so thin as to be frail. Her skin was a muted pinkish-lavender color, her short-cropped hair more amethyst, and she wore only white shorts and a chest wrap that displayed the interlocking patterns of spellform runes that covered every inch of her body. Where the first djinn projection I had met was placid in both movement and attitude, this woman's unflinching gaze and noble grace carried a furious intensity that seemed to radiate from her like heat off a bonfire.

She gave me a weak, sad smile. "So someone recovered my creation after all. In truth, I expected its shrine to sit undisturbed until the end of time."

"Your creation?"

She dipped her head, gesturing to the armor I wore. "When it became clear that the Indrath Clan would rather destroy our people than accept we could not give them our insight into aether, I attempted to form a resistance against them. The very few who were willing to fight back helped me to forge that armor, but it was too little, and much too late. Rather than donning it myself and charging alone into a lost battle, I designed the zone where you

found it in the hopes that it might one day be claimed by someone willing to fight against the asura."

Caera gave me an uncertain look. "Grey, what is going on? Is this a…an *ancient mage*?"

I gestured to the crystal, which flickered like a dying light artifact. "No, not exactly. She's a consciousness, contained in that crystal. They're like…some kind of guardians or something." To the djinn woman, I said, "The last projection I met was a lot more confused to see me. Why aren't you?"

"I have some echo of his memory, and I knew you were coming. I only hoped you would arrive before the edifice housing my consciousness failed entirely." She nudged a piece of the broken stone halos with her toe. "My sense of time is…inaccurate, but I know the time I have left is limited. We should begin the test soon."

"Test?" Caera shook her head. "I don't understand."

I quickly explained what had happened last time I found one of these djinn projections, and how I believed each one protected a piece of knowledge—hidden in a keystone—that could help me unlock new powers.

"Will we fight each other?" I asked the djinn woman, who had watched us curiously while I explained.

She smiled wryly. "The irony of my placement here is that I was tasked to administer a different kind of test. Punishment for declaring our inaction against the dragons to be folly and failure as opposed to peace."

She held up a hand to forestall the questions already forming on my lips. "However, it speaks to my compatriots' inability to comprehend

the desire to fight—to defend oneself—that they did not forbid me from passing on the martial techniques I developed in my life. By tasking me with a mental test instead of a physical one, they perhaps assumed that I would simply do as instructed and nothing else."

She lowered her arms to her sides, and an aether blade appeared in her left hand. It was long, thin, and very slightly curved, its form startlingly clear without the degradation my own meager attempts yielded as I forced the aether into shape. The amount of energy contained within that single blade was enough to unleash several aetheric blasts.

"As I said: short-sighted." Then a second blade appeared in her right. She crossed them in front of her, their sharp points searing twin lines in the stone at her feet, and when they touched one another, sparks flew hissing and popping through the air.

"You have shown the strength to fight back, to strike and spill the blood of our enemies. You are exactly who I have been waiting for, and I will train you to wield aether not only as a tool of creation, but as a true weapon of destruction."

361
THE SECOND RUIN

MY EYES REMAINED FIRMLY on the twin aetheric sabers glowing in the djinn woman's hands. Admiration, excitement, and envy swirled in me as I examined her near-perfect creations until I forcefully pried my gaze away. "What about the trial you're supposed to give me?"

"It has already begun," she answered confidently. "I will judge your worthiness as we battle." She spun on her heel and the room vanished, melting away both my armor and everything around us into a blank white nothing-space. "Don't dawdle now."

The djinn flashed toward me, her form becoming a streak of amethyst as her twin sabers swung outward in a broad arc at my throat.

I swiveled on my heel, parrying her blows with a strike to her hands before I forced aether into the shape of a hazy blade. Using the brief window as she brought her swords back up, I lanced at her side with my dagger.

The djinn spun mid-swing, twisting her whole body fiercely to gain the momentum to intercept my strike with her left blade.

Sparks flared upon impact, but the only weapon remaining after the exchange was hers.

The djinn hardly waited for me as she began her assault, her twin blades becoming a barrage of intersecting crescents hell-bent on shredding me apart.

I summoned blade after blade of my own, each time pushing harder to force the shape together, to hold it when deflecting her attacks, but none lasted more than a single strike.

“You’re holding back,” the djinn said tersely, mid-swing of her saber. Just as the amethyst blade whistled past me, it warped into the shape of a long staff. Pivoting on her lead foot, she grabbed her new weapon with both hands and swept at my legs with the butt of the staff.

I fell to one knee from the force, and by the time I looked back up, her staff had become a warhammer.

Jagged bolts of violet lightning arced across my body as God Step took me several dozen feet away just as the giant bludgeon created a shockwave of force upon impact with the white ground.

The short-haired djinn’s expression turned to that of surprise for the first time, her eyes wide and brows furrowed as she took in what had just occurred.

“Again,” she growled, launching herself toward me in a blur.

I stepped forward, concentrating on the aetheric paths converging around her even as I conjured a blade of my own. Using my aether blade to merely redirect her strike was already enough to make it shatter, but it bought me enough time.

Tendrils of violet lightning arced across me once more as I flashed behind the djinn. However, in the time that it took me to form another dagger, the djinn’s own aether blade had already intercepted my attack.

“Had you chosen to attack with your fist, I most likely wouldn’t have been able to block it,” she admitted, her sharp eyes seeming to look through me rather than at me. “Your mind seems to have connected this godrune with the deviant mana element of lightning. It explains much about your tendencies when using aether.”

I furrowed my brows in confusion. “My tendencies?”
The djinn waved my question away, stabbing her aetheric sword into the ground and casually leaning against it. “Before that, I would like to ask first what it is you want from me, Arthur Leywin,” she asked, her tone harsh.
I froze before answering, realizing she had used my real name.
The djinn’s cropped hair bobbed as she cocked her head to the side. “Have you grown uncomfortable with that name already?”
“No,” I answered, caught off guard. I wasn’t sure how I felt. It had been months since anyone except Regis had called me by my real name, and I realized that I had become far too used to hearing myself referred to as Grey. “It’s fine. But I don’t understand your question.”
Her bright eyes roved over me like searchlights. “What do you want, Arthur?”
Is this a part of the test? I wondered, but out loud, I said, “I’m not sure that’s the right question. What I *need* is to learn how to control Fate.”
“If Fate were something that could simply be taught, passed on from person to person, then our universe might as well fit within a snow globe.” She rested her chin on the back of her hand as she continued to devour me with her eyes. “No. What you *want* is power. The power to protect all of your loved ones and defeat your enemies.”
I crossed my arms. “But isn’t that the same thing? Even with all four elements at my disposal, I couldn’t defeat even a single Scythe. I want—*need*—something stronger. From what I’ve been told, that’s Fate.”

She stood tall once more, prying her aether blade out of the ground. “Then you’ll have to open your mind to new ideas. You are blinding yourself by attempting to see aether through the lens of mana, equating one to the other. Only after you understand aether as itself can you begin to understand Fate. Now form your blade. Show me that you understand.”

My dagger formed as I stood up, its edge jagged and lacking substance.

She eyed it with distaste. “Strike me.”

I didn’t hesitate, lunging forward and feinting to the right. When her blade moved to intercept, I conjured a second dagger and thrust up into her ribs from the left.

Her sword came around to deflect both blows, and my aether blades collapsed. I caught her counterattack with my hand, then God Stepped behind her, but she was already rolling forward, her blade sweeping behind her to catch me if I followed after. It was a clean move, and impossibly fast.

She held up a hand before I could attack again. “Focus. You are trying to *win*, and perhaps you even could, but you should be trying to *learn*. Why does your weapon collapse whenever you use it?”

“Because I’m not strong enough to maintain such a complicated form,” I answered honestly.

She frowned at me as though I were a foolish child. “Wrong. You are stronger than you should be. Stronger than me—at least, this remnant of me, contained with the memory crystal. And yet…”

A perfectly formed sword appeared in her right hand. Then a second in her left. Then a third, hovering just over her shoulder. And a fourth floating near her hip.

She glowered at me, and all four blades pointed at my face. "It is not power you lack. It is perspective. As a human, you have always been expected to build on what you already know. Crawl, walk, run, yes? To wield aether, you must forget that there are rules to things. Constraining yourself to a system that already exists around you only holds you back. Do not seek to walk or run. Ignore gravity and simply fly."

I couldn't help but shoot her an amused smirk. "I already learned how to fly—"

One of the flying blades hacked at my neck. I deflected with an aether blade of my own, but it shattered. The second flying sword swept across the side of my knee, while the two she held thrust at my chest and hip. Remembering Kordri's lessons, I fell into a defensive position and used short, rapid movements of both my hands and feet to intercept or avoid each attack, conjuring several aetheric daggers one after the next, each one evaporating under the strain of her attacks.

Her bombardment was relentless, with attacks coming from several directions at once. Although I was fast enough to dodge or block most, I still felt the repeated cuts and piercing thrusts where her blows did land.

Eventually, she simply stopped, dismissed her weapons, and sat once again. I cautiously mirrored her, waiting silently for the lesson to continue. I wanted to think I had learned something, but so far her

guidance had been too esoteric, too vague, to really help me understand how she conjured such powerful aether blades. While she made a fantastic sparring partner, my ability to maintain the form of a pure aether weapon hadn't much improved.

"That is because you're waiting for me to tell you what to do, like we were learning mana manipulation back at that academy of yours," she said shortly. "But I cannot."

I frowned at her. "You claim to want to teach me, but also that I should simply pull this knowledge from the air, manifesting it as if by magic."

"Exactly," she said, giving me a single, sharp nod. "But I can sense your frustration, and I recognize that you are not a djinn, even if you share a drop of our essence. And so I will attempt to explain this in a different way."

She paused, her searching eyes peering deep into my own. "I mentioned your tendencies earlier. You fail to form a true aether weapon because you treat the aether just as you would mana. You feel a constant, ever-burning need to be in control, Arthur Leywin. Of your body, your magic, your life. With mana, this desire coupled with the depth of your confidence allowed you to progress at a remarkable speed. But with aether, you succeed only at building a barrier between yourself and your desire."

Resisting the urge to argue about my apparent need for control, I said only, "Can you elaborate further? If I'm not supposed to control the aether, then what?"

"Do you understand how your heart works, or your lungs?" she asked immediately, pressing a hand to her chest.

“Yes,” I said slowly, unsure where she was going with this.
“Do you control your lungs?” she asked. “Do you force each breath, absorbing just the right amount of oxygen in your body? Without your focus, do you stop breathing?”
“No, of course not. But I *can* control my breath—”
She snapped her fingers and pointed at me. “Yes, you can. But if you focus on every single breath you take over a day, a week, a year, would it somehow make you better at breathing?”
I frowned at this and began tapping my fingers against my ankle. “No, although practicing the control over one’s breathing does help to—”
She reached out and slapped the side of my head. “Don’t be smart. Be focused.”
“Fine,” I said, rubbing my temple. “So if I can’t *control* it, what do I do?”
She smiled as she stood, motioning for me to do the same. “Aether is not mana in the same way water is not a stallion. One may be controlled, the other must be guided. Trusted. A bond formed. But aether is not a stallion, either. It should not be broken. Further, your aether is not my aether. While, through the very careful application of spellforms and decades of practice, I learned to slowly guide aether to assist me, absorbing and directing it, because of your core and your ability to easily absorb and refine aether within your own body, your relationship to aether is more akin to a parent and child.”
I felt inward toward my core, brimming with bright, pure aether. Lady Myre’s first lesson for me regarding aether was to reinforce the idea that it had a kind of “consciousness,” and that it could only be

coaxed, never controlled. When I forged my core and proved her wrong, I assumed my core allowed me to manipulate and control aether in a way the dragon race of the asuras simply couldn't comprehend, and hadn't thought much further than that.

But…

"So you're saying that the aether I absorb and purify within my core… I can exert such a strong influence over it because it's… what? Bonded to me?"

"Exactly!" she exclaimed, focusing on my sternum as if she could see through my flesh and into my core. Then her face fell into a little frown, almost a pout. "While your spatium technique earlier was impressive, I still find myself underwhelmed—disappointed even—that this is all you have managed to accomplish considering the immense potential of your body and core combined. You should be able to form an aether weapon with a thought—no, the aether should react to your intention before you even fully articulate it into a conscious thought."

I scratched the back of my neck, both frustrated and a little stung by her rebuke. "I think I'm beginning to understand."

The djinn woman laughed and shook her head as a single blade appeared in her hands. "No. But with more practice and less conversation, you will." Her face as emotionless as stone, she lunged, her blade aimed at my core.

After what felt like days, our sparring continued unabated. I was forcefully reminded of my time in the aether orb training opposite Kordri as the djinn and I fought each other to a standstill, our battles

raging on for hours at a time. Neither of us held back, nor did we give an inch to the other. The djinn could summon several weapons at once and change their forms with an instant and unpredictable precision, but I was the better swordsman.

And for the first time since Dawn's Ballad had shattered, I had a real sword again.

It had taken time for the djinn's forceful message to sink in, but it wasn't the first time I'd had to relearn something I thought I knew well. Slowly, over the course of hours or days, I had practiced letting my intention shape the aether blade.

In practice, the concept was similar to how Three Steps had trained me to perceive the aetheric pathways of God Step without first having to "see" them. Whereas before it had felt like trying to mold water with my bare hands, it had become as comfortable and natural as closing my hand into a fist, although maintaining the blade still required nearly all my concentration.

I grinned as we fought, reveling in the feel of the aetheric weapon in my hand. The blade itself was both longer and wider than Dawn's Ballad had been, slightly wider at the base and tapering into a razor-sharp point, and glowed a bright amethyst color. A crossguard protected my hand—an addition I'd made after the djinn struck a painful blow against my knuckles and disrupted my focus on the weapon.

Holding the sword revitalized me, giving me back something I hadn't even realized I was missing. Both as King Grey and as Arthur Leywin, mastering the art of swordsmanship had been pivotal to my sense of self, and when Dawn's Ballad was shattered, it was like losing a limb.

Whenever my aether blade crossed with one of the djinn's many weapons, a deep, resonant hum filled the air, and the space around them seemed to warp, flexing outward slightly and causing a visible distortion. It gave the impression that our combat was altering the very fabric of the world around us, and I had to wonder if it was merely due to our being in an entirely mental realm—some representation of my mind growing with the use of the blade—or if this mental simulation was accurately portraying the aether weapons' genuine physical impact.

The djinn threw herself at me with a piercing battle cry. The weapon in her hand shifted to a glaive, while twin blades spun at my head and hip. I leapt into the air, spinning horizontally with the ground so that the flying swords cut only air above and below me. With the glaive, the djinn cut upward in a short, sharp motion meant to catch me midair, but I didn't need to have my feet on the ground to react.

I God Stepped behind her, but couldn't maintain concentration on the summoned aetheric blade in that between-space. The time it took to reform the blade cost me any advantage, giving the djinn time to spin around to find me and then leap over my slash aimed at her waist. I redirected the momentum of my swing into an overhead chop, forcing her to bring up her own weapon—a sword again—to defend.

I leaned into the contact and shoved hard, sending my opponent sliding backwards as I held my sword out to ward off a surprise attack from the weapons that flew unsupported around her.

Triggering God Step, I flashed to her side, then immediately God Stepped again to her opposite side and formed my blade, thrusting it

at her chest, but she was already moving, her many blades swinging around to defend from multiple possible angles.

I repeated this several times, each time trying to catch her off guard, attacking from a different direction, but she matched me step for step, neither of us able to land a solid blow against the other.

Then suddenly her weapons vanished and she blinked—not her eyes, but her entire body, like she'd turned momentarily invisible. I let my own sword fade away.

"Are you okay?"

She nodded, but I couldn't help but think that her form wasn't as bright as it had been. "I'm afraid our time is running short. We should"—the white blankness vanished, and we were once again standing in the dilapidated stone ruins—"return to your companions."

The djinn projection was gone, and the voice was now emanating from the crystal at the center of the room. "You have performed well, descendant."

Caera and Regis stood from where they had both been sitting against one of the crumbling walls. Caera looked relieved, but Regis was giving me an annoyed scowl. I noticed I was back in my armor, or more likely that I had never actually dismissed it, since the fighting had all taken place in my mind.

"You took your sweet time," he said sulkily. "That lasted a lot longer than last time."

"Oh," I said, not having given the passage of time even a second's thought while I was training with the djinn. "How long has it been?"

“Ten minutes, at most,” Caera answered, nudging Regis’s side with her knee. “You were just kind of standing there, staring blankly… It was a bit creepy, really.”

The crystal pulsed as it interjected, saying, “It is unfortunate that I did not have the energy to continue, but manifesting the thought realm is taxing. However, I believe you have made enough progress to continue training your aether blade technique on your own.”

“And the trial?” I asked. Aside from sparring and discussing how I could improve, she hadn’t given me any other test.

“A test of character and will,” the crystal answered, brightening. “You have passed, per my judgement, and will have your reward.”

My dimensional storage rune grew warm, and I hurried to withdraw a plain black cube that had just appeared within. Like the previous one, it felt much heavier than it should have. A part of me wanted to imbue aether into it immediately, entering into the keystone to see what it held, but I resisted the urge.

Caera leaned over, peering at the relic. I handed it to her to examine, trusting that she would care for it, and turned my attention back to the crystal.

“Can you tell me what sort of insight this relic contains?” I asked hopefully.

The crystal dimmed, pulsing unevenly. “I am afraid not. Discovery is essential to learning. By telling you anything at all, I could inadvertently limit or even corrupt your eventual understanding of the godrune.”

I considered for a moment, then asked, “And where do these godrunes come from? Who or what gives them to us? Your compatriot wasn’t able to answer.”
“That information isn’t stored within this remnant.”
I couldn’t exactly be disappointed, since I’d expected this. Besides, I had too many other things to worry about. The mystery of godrunes would have to be resolved some other day.
“I’m sorry, I didn’t think to ask earlier…What is your name?”
The crystal seemed to hum, its light flickering dimly. In a raw, emotional tone, it said, “That information isn’t stored within this remnant, either.”
“Is there anything else you’d like to tell me before we leave?” There were a hundred questions I would have liked for the djinn remnant to answer, but if we were short on time, I didn’t want to waste it by asking things she couldn’t tell me.
The lavender light of the crystal flickered silently for a minute. “Do not try to force the world into a shape to suit your needs, but you should also not accept the limitations of this world as it is. Your path is yours alone, and only you may walk it. I genuinely hope my creation aids you on this path. It will draw aether to you, making it easier for you to then absorb, and will protect you from nearly any attack, but it is not impenetrable. A strong enough opponent, with potent control over mana or aether, will still be able to harm you. Do not let them.”
I nodded to the crystal. “Thank you.”
The ruin shifted around us, only partially becoming the library I had seen out of the corner of my eye while navigating the collapsing

passageway before. It was like looking at two transparent images set over the top of each other, becoming both the library and the ruined room at the same time.

One wall of the library was dominated by a shadowy portal, the frame of which was an arch of shelves full of the crystals. The library was busy with tiny movements as little pictures played across the many facets of the hundreds of crystals, but I found them impossible to focus on, and when I reached for one, my hand passed through as if it wasn't really there.

Facing the portal, I asked, "Will we even be able to use this?" But there was no answer from the crystal.

"This is beyond strange," Caera said, walking directly through a wide table. She moved her hand through the back of a chair. "An illusion?"

"I think *we're* the illusion," Regis said, sniffing around. "There's no smell here. Just a faint hint of something like ozone…like there is nothing here at all. Or like we're not really here."

I withdrew the Compass. "The djinn bound and shaped reality with aether here, but it's beginning to collapse. This place is like three different rooms stacked on top of and within each other…but the boundaries between them aren't stable. We need to leave."

Holding up the half-sphere relic, I imbued aether into it. Misty light settled over the portal, and the frame solidified, becoming more solidly real. Through the portal was my room at the academy, but my attention was drawn to the crystals, which were also solid. The images playing across their many surfaces showed djinn—their race obvious by the variation of pinks and purples in their skin tone, and

the spellforms that often covered most of their bodies—performing any number of mundane activities.

Many of the facets showed only djinn faces, speaking. Most looked tired, and deeply sad.

Tentatively, I reached out to lift a crystal off the shelf. At my touch, a dozen overlapped voices—or rather, the same voice, but saying a dozen different things at the same time—emitted from the crystal, directly into my mind. Instinctively, I touched the crystal with aether, and the voices cut off and the images faded away.

Curiosity won out over caution—and a small twinge of guilt—and I stored the crystal away in my dimensional storage rune for later.

Caera and Regis had watched this silently. Despite her stoicism and unnatural endurance, Caera looked tired. Regis, on the other hand, was unreadable, his emotions hidden from our link even as he disappeared inside me without a word.

With much to think about and even more to be done, I left my partner alone as I recalled the relic armor. The black ethereal suit of scales evaporated, but I could feel it still, waiting for me to call on it again.

Sharing a nod and a weary smile, I gestured toward the portal. “Let’s go see what happened at the bestowment ceremony.”

362
FATE INTERTWINED

NICO SEVER

I marched from Taegrin Caelum's primary tempus warp chamber through the castle's cold halls, moving purposefully toward Agrona's private wing. Servants bowed and pressed themselves to the walls as we passed, and even the many elite soldiers and high-ranking military leaders shrank back in fear of me—as they should. I was in no mood to be disturbed or interrupted; I wanted answers, and wouldn't be dismissed until Agrona himself delivered them to me.

I took the spiraling stairs to Agrona's chambers two at a time, my grip firmly around Cecilia's wrist as she lagged behind me. The stairs opened up on a hallway that connected the main body of the castle with Agrona's private chambers. Unlike the cold stone halls we'd just come from, this chamber blazed with warm light.

The walls were covered in artifacts and souvenirs of Agrona's many victories. Scattered among the dead relics and artifacts of Agrona's favored highblood families were more gruesome keepsakes: a phoenix wing, mounted so that it was spread out, displaying the feathers that still gleamed red and gold; a headdress made of pearlescent dragon feathers over an ornate necklace of claws and fangs; and a pair of dragon horns that sprouted from the wall.

I stopped short. The way forward was barred.

"I am here to speak to Agrona. Move, Melzri."

The other Scythe pressed a hand to her heart and let her mouth hang open mockingly. "Now is that any way to speak to the one who

trained you and took care of you after we got you back from that trashy little island, little brother?"

I scoffed, letting a murderous intent seep out into the fancifully decorated hallway where Melzri stood guard. Though I glared at her, she only smiled back, looking exactly as she always had: perfect silvery-gray skin, pure white hair plaited into a thick braid that ran down her back, and dark lips and eyes that matched the two pairs of shining onyx horns that sprouted from her head and curved sharply back, a smaller pair directly beneath two larger horns.

"I'm not your brother," I said waspishly. "What are you even doing here, anyway?"

She gave me a simpering little giggle, which she knew I hated and did purely to irritate me. "Just some Victoriad business. Viessa was here too, but she left only minutes ago, I'm sorry to say." Her red-black eyes, the color of congealed blood, drifted to focus on Cecilia. "Ah, the famous Legacy. You wear the elven girl's skin well, I must say. That hair is to *die* for."

I growled, stepping between Melzri and Cecilia. "Shut up and leave her out of this."

I felt Cecilia shuffle next to me. "Nico, it's okay. Why don't we just go wait in our rooms?"

Melzri's smile sharpened into a predatory grin. "What's wrong, little brother? Not willing to share your plaything…although, I suppose really she is the High Sovereign's pet, right? Which makes you…what? Her nanny? No…" Melzri put a hand over her mouth as she gave another little laugh. "*You* are *her* plaything, I think…"

“I don’t care what you have to say, Melzri,” I said, trying to sound like I meant it. I thoughtlessly reached for Cecilia’s hand, but she dodged it, and the anger rushed out of me like air knocked from my lungs.

Melzri saw, but instead of mocking me, she gave me a disappointed frown and stepped back to block the way forward. “The High Sovereign is not available to speak with you at this moment. You may wait here or return to your room.”

“This is urgent—”

Melzri sniffed. “I’m just looking out for you, little brother. If you storm in there and interrupt the High Sovereign’s meeting with Dragoth and Sovereign Kiros, you might find yourself with something other than your little feelings hurt.”

This caught my attention.

“The Sovereign of Vechor is here?” It was rare for the Sovereigns to leave their dominions. Although I was paraded around before each of them when I was named a Scythe of the central dominion, I had never met any of them again.

Melzri didn’t bother to answer, and so I turned my back on her and walked to the farthest corner of the room, next to the stairway door, where I stood and glared at a matched pair of ruby blades, crossed over the crest of some long defunct highblood.

Did the members of this ancient blood see the end coming for them? I wondered. *Did they feel safe in their nobility, as if they had carved out a place for themselves in this world, or were they always waiting for someone to put a knife in their back?*

I played through the events at the High Hall again, trying to make sense of it. There wasn't a single doubt in my mind that this blond, golden-eyed Ascender Grey was really *my* Grey, despite the change in appearance. But I didn't understand why Agrona hadn't told me the name beforehand.

Was it some kind of test?

I had been tested often, and experimented on, and pushed to my limit. Sometimes these trials were painful, even cruel, but they had always made me stronger. There was always a *reason*.

I sighed deeply, failing to understand.

Cecilia had followed me, staying by my side but never touching me, never offering comfort…

Needing to look anywhere but Cecilia or Melzri, I let my eyes wander up to the ceiling, where an enormous fresco stretched the length of the hall.

It showed the flight of the Vritra from Epheotus, depicting the dragons of the Indrath clan as monstrous beasts swarming in a blood-red sky, while people—both lessers and the Vritra Clan basilisks—cowered behind Agrona, displayed here in shining platinum armor and radiating a golden light that kept the dragons at bay…

"Nico…?" Cecilia asked from my side. I could feel her gaze on my cheek, but I didn't turn to look at her. I couldn't. If I did, I was worried I might break.

It shouldn't have been like this. I had spent an entire life trying to protect her, first from her own monstrous ki and then from the many people who sought to use her, and this new life had been dedicated

to completing the reincarnation ritual and giving her a second chance, but when I'd finally accomplished it, it seemed like everything had gone wrong for me.

Agrona had once fawned over me the same way he now treated Cecilia…but he had turned dismissive and sarcastic toward me. He had sent me to the High Hall *knowing* who this Ascender Grey really was. He must have, or why else chose me to go, and with so little information? But I didn't understand his motivations. Was it nothing more than a cruel game?

He should have told me what he knew, or suspected.

My mind flinched away from these thoughts, rejecting them, because to linger there meant I would have to acknowledge the creeping fear that was stealing through my mind, corrupting every dark corner of it. Fear was unacceptable. It was weakness. The other Scythes, the Vritra…they could all smell it, and to show fear here meant being devoured alive.

"Nico," Cecilia said again, moving to be in my line of sight.

"What?" I said, more coldly than I'd intended.

"How…" She trailed off, biting her lip. After several long seconds, she took a deep breath and tried again. "I want to know about my death."

My jaw clenched and I ground my teeth together. Although I wanted her to understand—wanted her to hate Grey as much as I did—I couldn't bring myself to speak.

"Experiencing the memory of a death can be quite traumatic," Agrona's rich baritone said from the end of the hallway, announcing his sudden arrival. "But I think you are ready, Cecilia."

Melzri slid aside, putting her back to the wall and keeping her head down. Agrona's red eyes took in everything within the hallway with an easy sweep, a placid movement that almost seemed like laziness, and yet I knew in that instant he had read everything in the room. He moved with an unhurried grace, obviously expecting the world to stand still and wait for him to arrive. As he passed Melzri, he reached out and ran a finger along one of her horns, but his attention was otherwise entirely on Cecilia.

"Do you really—" My mouth snapped shut at a glance from the High Sovereign, my argument dismissed before it could leave my mouth.

I wanted to wrap my arm around Cecilia, draw her close to me so I could comfort and protect her, but instead, I did nothing as Agrona approached. He brushed aside her gunmetal gray hair and placed his fingers against her temples. She closed her eyes as her body went stiff.

Although I couldn't directly experience what the High Sovereign was doing in her mind, I knew well enough. Agrona was a master of direct manipulation of the mind, able to both remove and alter memories, and even able to directly control another person's body to a limited extent. Right now, he was giving Cecilia back the memory of her death…in only a few moments, she would know.

She would remember.

I forced back the nervous, guilty energy tingling through my body. It would have been better if I could have told her all the truth from the beginning…but it was too great a risk. I knew that Agrona had twisted the memories she'd received, highlighting my role in her life while diminishing Grey's. She just had to have someone in this world

she could trust entirely, implicitly. Adjusting those little memories made sure she had that… in me.

This memory, though, the memory of her death… even I didn't want it in my head, and I wished, not for the first time, that Agrona would help me forget it. Cecilia shouldn't have to remember it either, but she had to see, she had to *know* what had happened. With Grey alive, it was only a matter of time until they crossed paths. She needed to know who he really was. It didn't matter how many names he'd taken or lives he'd lived… inside, he was still the same cold, selfish Grey. The man who chose kingship over his only friends—family—in the world.

I wouldn't let him take her from me again.

Cecilia began to tremble. Her eyes stayed shut, but a pained whimper escaped her lips. Her knees threatened to buckle.

"Stop, she's—"

A crushing force wrapped around my throat, choking off my plea. My hands clawed at my neck as I sank to my knees, but Agrona didn't even look at me.

Cecilia was falling, tumbling backwards, but he caught her, scooping her up and holding her in his arms like a child. "Hush, Cecil. I know, and I am sorry to burden you with the truth of your death. Rest now." Agrona lowered his forehead until it touched Cecilia's. There was a spark of magic, and her breathing became even and slow, and the whimpering ended.

Melzri was by their side, and Agrona handed Cecilia—*my* Cecil—to the Scythe. "Take her to her room. Guard her until she wakes, then return to Etril."

“As you command, High Sovereign.” Then she was marching away, and taking Cecilia with her.

Only when they’d gone did the invisible fist around my throat release. I coughed and choked, falling to my hands and knees, gasping for air. I felt the dark aura building within me, angry and eager to burst out, but suppressed it utterly. With angry tears in my eyes, I looked up at Agrona. His face was impassive.

After my coughing had subsided, he said, “You forget yourself. You are so terrified of losing your fiancé for the second time that the fear is ripping you apart from within.”

I stood, finally, and raised my chin to meet Agrona’s eyes. “You were hurting her.” I nearly bit my tongue in half in frustration as I heard my own plaintive, whiny voice. “You swore that you’d—”

“Nico.” My name left his lips like a javelin, and I felt it pierce me somewhere deep within. “Do you understand what Cecilia is? What the Legacy is?” He shook his head, the decorative chains hanging in his horns jingling softly. His large, cold hand brushed the side of my face, but there was no warmth in his gaze. “Of course you don’t. She is the *future*. But you, Nico…there is room in that future—in the world I will build with Cecilia at my side—for warriors, but not for weak lessers who succumb entirely to their own stubborn impulses.”

I tried to swallow. It stuck in my throat, almost as if I were being choked all over again, but it was only my own rage, fear, and disappointment…*My stubborn impulses,* I thought bitterly. It wasn’t fair. My anger and rage had been cultivated since I was an infant, harnessed and turned into a weapon—by Agrona. It was the purity of my fury that made me powerful. Without it…

I knew I had peaked as a mage, that I couldn't continue to grow stronger, and obviously Agrona knew it too.

I hadn't been a powerful warrior or ki user on Earth, not like Grey or Cecilia. When I realized my potential in this new world, before my memories were stripped from me and I was transformed into Elijah and sent away, I was ecstatic. My new life would be nothing like my old one. I would have power, real strength—physical, political, and magical, and all because of Agrona. He had given me everything I needed—training, elixirs, the strongest runes, a body capable of channeling the basilisks' decay-type mana arts—to make sure I would be strong.

But now, those I cared about were still reaching beyond me and leaving me behind. Again.

"Do you know why you were reincarnated?" Agrona asked, turning away from me to look at one of the ornaments hanging from the wall. "You were reincarnated because you were close to her. You and Grey both. To maximize the potential of the reincarnation—to make sure the Legacy was able to fully integrate into this world—a sort of array had to be formed between her lives. I needed anchors to hold and bind the Legacy's spirit. That's all you are."

I couldn't help but shake my head. "No, you said—"

"You see and encourage the lies I tell Cecilia, and yet you don't think I would do the same to you?" Agrona smiled, a nonchalant, disarming expression that showed no guilt or regret. "Utilizing what I learned from the Relictombs, I looked across worlds until I found the Legacy, and next to her, you and King Grey."

I flinched, my anger flaring at the reference to Grey's kingship, won by taking Cecilia's life. "But you *needed* me. You said so yourself. Grey's reincarnation showed you how to bring me here. Without me, you—"

"I attempted the reincarnation on Grey first, that's true, but his soul never arrived in the chosen vessel. A simple miscalculation, I thought. He had been alive still, back in your home world of Earth, while my preparations for the Legacy had assumed a soul passed on from its mortal sheath." Agrona cocked his head to the side slightly, his tongue running over his sharp canines. "None of this matters now, you realize? There is little to no point in discussing it. But…I suppose I can humor you, Nico, if only to watch you struggle to understand."

I glared back at him. His cool words—not cruel or mean spirited, but curious and demeaning, like a disappointed parent humoring their child's foolish ideas—cut sharper than any knife, but I wouldn't show it. I, too, could be cold and dismissive if I wished. "Tell me. I deserve to understand."

Agrona shrugged his large shoulders. "Although I can explain it, I can't make you understand it. Taking what I'd learned from attempting to spark King Grey's reincarnation, I began the process of your own reincarnation next, into the body of a newborn child from a prominent magical family with some lingering Vritra blood. You arrived, as planned."

Keeping my pace empty of emotion, I sat down onto a cushioned bench that ran along one wall of the hall. Leaning back against the wall, I crossed my legs and waited for him to continue.

“But I needed two anchors,” he continued, “and Cecilia had been close to no one else. We tried a few others, but none of their souls were strong enough to be reincarnated, and so eventually I set the experiment aside. Without the appropriate anchors, the Legacy’s reincarnation was too much of a risk; a proper vessel could not be forged.”

I thought back to my childhood in Alacrya, to the endless training and experimentation. The thought of having Cecilia back allowed me to endure any torture. Although I hadn’t known the full truth about my reincarnation and purpose, she had always been the carrot Agrona dangled in front of me, promising that, if I grew strong enough, some day he would be able to reincarnate her as well. That promise kept me from going insane.

“What about me, then? My childhood? Everything you did to me?”

“We didn’t know what benefits your reincarnation might provide, so I kept you here, ordered that you be raised and trained among the Vritra. We tested you, experimented on you, and you proved that a reincarnated soul was indeed extraordinarily potent. It kept my hope up that, some day, I could return to my plan, and the Legacy would be mine to control. And so…”

“Arthur…” I felt a twinge as I said the name, and memories of our time together at Xyrus Academy came rushing unbidden to my mind.

“Yes. Arthur. Somehow born a Leywin, a continent away, outside of my dominion.” Agrona shook his head with apparent amusement, causing his ornaments to jingle again. “Ah, Sylvia. Always the clever one. Hidden away in the wildlands of Dicathen, fatally wounded, and yet still a thorn in my side.

“It wasn’t until Cadell found her that we learned the truth. I’m sure Sylvia thought she had hidden the boy, but in the bare instant before she used her cursed aether art to freeze time, he saw. Who else could it be? What human child could be so important that Sylvia would drain herself of energy and reveal herself to my hunters in order to save them? As soon as I learned what had happened, I knew.”

“And so you took my memories and sent me to Dicathen, to Rahdeas…” My life as Elijah had begun with the dwarves, a blank slate. Even my real powers had been suppressed and hidden from me. I wondered, now, what I might have become if those years spent as Elijah hadn’t been stolen from me.

Would I have still reached the peak of my abilities so soon?

I didn’t think so. Agrona had stolen that potential from me, all just to bring me close to Grey.

“Couldn’t you have sent me as a spy? Why…” I swallowed hard. “Why take my memories? Why take that *time* from me?”

“Do you think you could have kept yourself from attacking Arthur the moment you saw him?” he asked with a taunting smirk. “Could you have forged a true friendship and bond in this life, if you were carrying the prejudice of your old life?”

“For Cecilia, yes. Anything,” I answered, wanting desperately to believe it, for Agrona to be wrong.

“Your anger was an unwanted variable. Why would I take an unnecessary risk just for your sake? By taking your memories—your knowledge of your own reincarnation and birth in Alacrya—I could

more safely bring you together, the two anchors for the Legacy's reincarnation."

I put my head in my hands and pictured ripping Agrona's horns free from his skull and plunging them into his chest, again and again until there was nothing recognizable left of him. "How did you know I would even find him… Arthur?"

A heavy hand rested on the top of my head, and I closed my eyes. "You two were bound by fate. You, Grey, and Cecilia made up the three points of the array. I was certain you would find your way to each other. But I set my spies into motion, regardless, and they expanded our network across Dicathen, and I waited.

"It was years before he resurfaced in Xyrus. But our people were well placed there to find him, and once he'd revealed himself, there was no mistaking the signs: impeccable swordsmanship, a quadra-elemental mage, awakened at only two years of age. And he wore a *dragon feather* around his arm."

"Rahdeas's sudden insistence that I become an adventurer, despite my age…" I muttered, already understanding the rest. "And it was our closeness with the elven princess, Tessia Eralith, that made her the perfect vessel for Cecilia's return. Just like on Earth… a girl who loved Grey first, who only even saw me because I was standing next to him…"

Agrona's strong fingers wove into my hair before suddenly and painfully jerking my head up so I was staring into his scarlet eyes. "What did you expect to happen, Nico? That you and the Legacy would retire to a cabin in the woods and live the rest of your days carefree and peaceful, frolicking and copulating and forgetting

everything that had ever happened to you? After I dedicated such time and resources to her reincarnation? No. You had a purpose, which you dutifully, albeit unknowingly, served."

He released me and began walking away down the hall, but I wasn't finished with him yet.

"What about Grey?"

Agrona stopped and turned, giving me a confused frown, as if he couldn't possibly understand why I would ask about my arch-nemesis. "King Grey… Arthur Leywin… Ascender Grey… his name no longer matters, because *he* no longer matters. His role is complete, just as yours is. I suspect he survived because my daughter somehow sacrificed herself using the aether arts of her dragon mother, which serves me well. Sylvie was always the greater danger than your little quadra-elemental friend."

"But how did you know this ascender was the same Grey? Why…" I took a deep breath, holding onto that image of Agrona desecrated at my feet. "Why send me to the High Hall if you already knew?"

"Seris told me some time ago," Agrona said nonchalantly, as if he were referring to some mundane, unremarkable rumor. "She thought like you—that Arthur was somehow important, that news of his unlikely survival should *matter*. You lessers and your silly grievances. Ever since Dragoth's retainer was slain in Dicathen—what was his name? Uto?—it's been, 'Let me kill him, High Sovereign!' 'Oh no no, please, give me the honor!' There was a time when he could have been a threat, perhaps—when he had the asuras in his pocket, because of my daughter—but that time has passed."

I felt the foundation that had held up my entire new life shift and begin to crumble beneath my feet. In both lives, Grey had been my closest friend and most hated enemy. Even more than Cecilia, his very existence had completely changed the course of my lives. I wouldn't simply allow him to live, knowing what he had done.

And what he still might do, I thought. *As long as Grey lives, Cecilia isn't safe.*

And yet Agrona dismissed him, dismissed us both. Why did he not understand the threat Grey posed?

"You are wrong," I said coldly, standing and slowly approaching the towering Vritra lord. He smiled in amusement. "Please, allow me to hunt Grey down, High Sovereign," I said, trying not to beg, but very aware of how my words were an echo of his own mocking imitation. "I thought he was dead once, but somehow he escaped my revenge. Let me have another chance. After everything you've done to me, you owe me this. You *owe* me Grey."

Agrona's smile twisted into something sour, almost pitying. "You are owed nothing. But if you wish to run off and reenact your revenge, be my guest. Perhaps killing him will do something to quench your eternal inferiority complex. Assuming he doesn't kill you first." Agrona shrugged as if he truly didn't care either way. "First, though, return to the Legacy and relieve Melzri. And do not forget. Cecilia is the future. Make sure she has everything she needs."

Agrona turned on his heel and moved with unnatural swiftness down the hallway, leaving me to stew in my disappointment and anger. *I do not need your approval. I* will *find Grey. I will find him and I will kill him, and this time, he will not come back.*

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RESULTS AND ATTENTION

ARTHUR

The sun had just risen, covering the campus in a blanket of amber and violet. I settled in again atop the flat, crenelated roof of the Hollow Tower, relishing the view and the cool breeze that I couldn't get in my room. While it had been built as a watchtower ages ago and had been kept as a place to meditate, newer and fancier buildings had left this structure all but abandoned.

Letting out a heavy breath, I withdrew the keystone and turned it over, examining the simple black cube. Its surface was plain and matte; its only remarkable physical trait was its weight.

"Who would guess that this homely thing contained insight capable of rewriting the world," I mused. Even knowing everything that I did, I still found it hard to believe that something this small and… tangible held the secrets that could ultimately allow someone to gain insight into Fate itself.

Regis jumped out of my body and sniffed the relic. "It could at least have some ominously glowing runes or something to tell you how important it is." Turning his back to me, he crossed the roof and put his paws up on the parapet. "Anyway, you have fun with that."

His body tensed to jump.

"Hold on," I said quickly. "Where are you going?"

He replied with his back still to me, "I have some training of my own to do."

"Training separate from absorbing aether? Why all of a sudden?" I asked, moving to stand next to him.

Regis stiffened but refused to look at me. “Because. I was brought into this world to be your weapon—your protector—but lately it feels like I’m doing neither. We’re supposed to be partners, but you keep getting stronger by learning new edicts of aether. I don’t want to just watch as the gap between us widens.”

For the first time in a while, I was at a loss for what to say to my companion.

I stood silent, watching the dark wolf, when a four-winged bird settled onto the parapet nearby, clacking its beak and watching us expectantly. I withdrew my packed rations—a habit I kept up despite rarely needing to eat—and pulled out a slice of dried and peppered meat, tossing it to the creature. It hopped down to the stone roof and grabbed its prize before shooting off, its four wings carrying it swiftly out of sight.

“I… didn’t realize that it bothered you so much,” I finally mustered.

“Well, you can thank Sylvie for this infuriating drive to keep your ass alive,” Regis japed.

I let out a small laugh and nudged the shadow wolf. “Fine, just be careful out there. The world is a scary place for a little puppy.”

He turned his bright eyes on me derisively. “Ha. Ha. Hilarious.”

Then, in a maneuver I wasn’t even sure he could pull off, Regis leapt from the side of the tower. I watched as he plummeted toward the ground, purple flames trailing behind him like a flag before he became incorporeal and sank into the ground slightly.

Once he was solid again, Regis took off at a sprint to the north, headed out of the campus toward the mountains. He, of course, took the extra effort to pass by a small crowd of students, causing a

chorus of screams, before he vanished from sight behind another building.

I followed his progress for a while, still able to sense him even as the distance between us grew. He seemed to be heading out into the mountains. I wondered briefly if the energy that tethered us together would allow him to go that far, but we'd both feel it if he began to reach the maximum distance he could be away from me. Since we hadn't tested this aspect of our relationship since the bridge zone I traversed with the Granbehls, I didn't really know how far he could go.

I'm sure he'll be fine, I told myself, turning back to the reason I'd come up to this tower in the first place.

The black cube sat heavily in my hands as I stared at it. A minute passed, and then another as I regarded the keystone.

With a sigh, I stored it back into my dimension rune. I should be diving straight into the keystone—training, absorbing aether, doing something to get stronger. But my mind wasn't there. I couldn't push myself every waking moment, more so after just getting back from one of the djinn ruins.

Instead, I pulled out the far-seeing relic, tracing the sharp-edged facets while thinking of the very people that would motivate me to keep moving forward.

I activated the relic and was transported across the world, zooming in until I found myself in the dim underground cavern of the djinn sanctuary. Ellie was waist-deep in the stream, splashing water at Jasmine, who was holding up an elven child I didn't know as a shield, laughing.

A knot formed in my chest as I then noticed my mother, Helen, and the rest of the Twin Horns sitting around a low-burning campfire at the edge of the stream, watching with weary smiles. Behind them all, Boo was hunkered protectively over a pile of glitterfish.

I dug my nails into my hands, holding back the growing lump in my throat as I forced a smile myself. Afterall, they were all okay, and they were laughing and smiling.

That was enough.

With a shuddered breath and a hollow smile, I pried myself out of the relic and swapped it for the keystone again.

The black, palm-sized cube was much less aether dense than the last one, but otherwise nearly identical. "All right, let's see what you've got for me."

Releasing aether from my core, I channeled it up my arm and into the keystone. My consciousness seemed to follow it as I was drawn out of my own body and inside the djinn relic. First, I was met with a wall of purple clouds, as expected. The wall shivered at my approach, and I passed through easily.

I expected to find another puzzle, something to manipulate or work at like in the last keystone, but instead…

Darkness.

Complete, utter darkness.

Panic overcame me as I was suddenly jolted back to the tower roof, clutching the black cube, sweat pouring down my face and making my palms slick. My breath came quickly, and then I realized why: the inside of the keystone felt exactly like that in-between place after my

body had been destroyed and before I woke in the Relictombs. Like my mind was the only thing that existed in the entire universe.

Hovering in a field of reflectionless black, I remembered. *But it's not the same. I'm still here, this time. Nothing has changed.*

Taking several deep breaths to calm myself, I tried again.

This time the sudden absence of anything except for myself was less startling, but the inside of the keystone was no less eerie. I drifted around for a while, unsure if I was actually moving or only trying to, never striking a wall or any sort of mental object, like the sea of geometric shapes I'd had to manipulate inside the Aroa's Requiem keystone.

It was oblivion.

Even time held no meaning within the keystone, and I had no way of knowing how long I drifted for. At some point, I began to worry I might miss my class, but when I stopped channeling aether and left the black space, only a few minutes had passed. And so I pushed myself back in, and continued to wander the empty depths.

It was like swimming deep down in the ocean, where the light doesn't reach. Up, down, left, right…direction lost meaning, even though I continued to experience the sensation of movement. I tried to push out with aether in random directions, or all around me, but nothing happened. I tried to imbue myself—or whatever of me existed in that space—with aether, but again, this accomplished nothing.

Then I just allowed myself to drift. My thoughts wandered for a while, then stopped, and it was kind of like sleeping.

The darkness rippled suddenly, a visual distortion within the black-on-black void, like something had moved within it. I reached out with aether, trying to interact with the phenomenon, but nothing happened.

The door onto the rooftop creaked open, a vague noise heard just as the edge of my consciousness, and I withdrew from the keystone in irritation. This flash of frustration quickly melted into curiosity as a familiar face peered at me from the doorway.

"Valen?" I said stiffly, looking up at the highblood youth, who was standing framed in the dark doorway, one hand still on the door. His eyes lingered on the keystone as I returned it to the extradimensional storage rune. "Are you lost?"

Valen's eyes swept nervously across the tower roof, but he didn't move away from the door or even let it close. "I…um…" He cleared his throat. "I was looking for you, Professor."

I cocked an eyebrow at the boy, frowning. "How did you even know I was up here?"

Valen shot a quick look back into the door stairwell behind him, took a deep breath, and stepped away from the door, letting it close.

He cleared his throat again before speaking. "I happened to run into Seth on my way to your classroom…I think he was looking for you too, and he mentioned he'd seen you come here a few times, so I thought…" He winced, letting the thought trail off.

"What do you need?" I asked tartly, then remembered that the bestowment ceremony had taken place earlier today. "Is this about the bestowals?"

The tall young man leaned back against the heavy door, letting his head rest against it with a solid *thud.* His dark eyes gazed up into the brightening sky. Just as I was about to repeat my question, he said, "I received an emblem."

An emblem was the second highest tier of rune for an Alacryan mage. From what I understood, receiving such a powerful rune at a young age was life-changing, even for highbloods.

I cocked a brow. "Are you sure? I'd congratulate you, but you don't look very pleased about that."

Valen let out a humorless chortle. "Father is ecstatic, of course. My blood seems to think I'm some kind of prodigy now…"

I let out an impatient sigh while leaning back against the parapet opposite of him. "Well, I'm sure you didn't come all this way just to brag, so out with it."

He scratched the back of his head. "I just didn't have anyone else to talk to. My blood… they don't understand. And my associates—"

"Associates?" I scoffed. "That's an odd way to address your friends."

Valen gave me a hard look, breaking through his awkward hesitancy somewhat. "A Ramseyer does not have 'friends' according to my father. Just servants, acquaintances, associates, and allies." After a brief pause, he added, "And enemies, of course."

I nodded in understanding, thinking back to Trodius Flamesworth and what he was willing to do for the sake of his family name.

"I don't *want* to be a prodigy" Valen blurted, his head down. "Ever since I was an infant, I've been raised as a warrior, scholar, and leader, with the expectation placed on me at birth that I would

become Highlord of the Ramseyer Highblood. Never—not once in my life—has anyone asked me what *I* want to do or become."

"And receiving such a potent rune will only have exaggerated that expectation," I confirmed.

He nodded wordlessly as he turned back around.

"Well then, let me ask," I retorted. "What *do* you want to do?"

Valen deflated, and for the first time, he looked like the kid he was, not someone trying to put on the airs of a highlord. "I don't know, but…I wish I had the chance to find out. That's all I mean. Maybe…maybe what my blood wishes of me *is* exactly what I want to do, in the long run. But it will never feel that way unless I am allowed some kind of choice in the matter.

"I want to explore the world outside of the narrow boundaries my tutors and blood have set for me. But receiving this emblem only seems to have cemented my fate, instead of giving me power over it."

He watched me carefully for a response, good or bad. Perhaps he expected me to rebuke him, to tell him how fortunate he was, to encourage him to do as his family wished, but I kept my silence.

Suddenly he gave me an unexpected smile, and his eyes focused somewhere far into the distance. "You know, my uncle was in the war in Dicathen, and he told me something strange. Over there, teenagers—sometimes as young as thirteen or fourteen—often go off on their own to be adventurers, fighting against monsters and delving into dungeons."

I was taken by surprise by the sudden mention of Dicathen, memories of my time as the masked adventurer, Note, surfacing. It

seemed like another lifetime ago, now. “Mages are less common in Dicathen, and becoming an adventurer is a rite of passage for many of them. But it’s not so different from how Alacrya treats ascenders. Or so I’ve heard,” I added quickly.

Valen’s smile lingered for a moment as he thought about this, but it slowly slid from his face. Eventually he nodded and said, “Thank you, Professor. For listening. I won’t take up any more of your time.”

With a stiff bow, he turned to leave.

“You know, Valen,” I said to his back, my voice soft, “it’s only going to get harder to go against their wishes as you get older. If you really want to live your life without regret, it might be better to disappoint your parents now than later.”

He froze, half turning to look back at me, his face inscrutable. Finally, with a curious smile, he left, and the door closed between us again.

Unwilling and unable to face the many conflicting lines of thought tangling up in my brain, I withdrew the keystone again and activated it, momentarily embracing the void-space it contained. But instead of insulating me against my thoughts, it bared them, leaving me with nothing at all but my own conflicted mind.

I knew that it was unfair in the extreme to blame Valen or his classmates for anything that had happened in Dicathen. They were as much a victim of the war as my friends and family back home, and yet it had been *their* friends and family killing mine. They were Agrona’s subjects, his servants and tools, each one of them a potential weapon against me. Or worse, against my mother or my sister.

But, more and more, I had detected a hesitancy in the Alacryans to follow their overlord, especially among the students. At first, I had assumed Caera's lack of respect for the Vritra was something unique to her—a manifestation of her existence as a Vritra-blooded Alacryan in hiding—but my time at the academy had shown me this wasn't true. Aside from Professor Aphelion's poorly hidden disdain for the war, the students' feelings were plain enough on their faces every time Elenoir was mentioned.

A lot of powerful young Alacryans had lost everything that day. And I don't think all of them blamed the asuras for it.

With a frustrated sigh, I stepped out of the keystone and put it away. It was clear I wasn't going to get anywhere with it while I was so distracted, or while my mind was full of uncertainty.

From the Hollow Tower, I meandered around campus for a short while before making my way to my classroom. I was relatively early, but my thoughts refused to settle and I couldn't focus on anything, so I turned the gravity up by several times in the training ring and started to work out my body. Although I would have enjoyed a chance to summon the aether blade, I didn't want to explain it to anyone who happened into the classroom.

I didn't train for long.

The sound of the door slamming open and hurried footsteps moving down the stairs pulled me out of repeating one of the many forms Kordri had taught me.

"You're here!" Mayla shouted, rushing toward the ring.

Quickly hopping out of the training platform, I pressed a finger against her forehead to keep her outstretched arms from wrapping around me.

Mayla let out a surprised squeak as she hugged the empty air between us.

"Good news?" I asked, crossing my arms nonchalantly while leaning back against the base of the raised training platform.

The girl from Maerin Town was bouncing on her toes as she said, "Yes! It's so crazy. Unbelievable! I've just been added to all these high-level Sentry classes, and apparently the odds are so low that Central Academy has no record of it happening before, and they're offering to waive my attendance fees and send this huge stipend to my family back in Etril if I agree to do some one-on-one study with the head of the Sentry department here, and…"

She trailed off, noticing the look of confusion growing on my face. "I got *another* emblem!" she cheered, her voice raising an octave in her excitement, coming out as a squeak. "Two in a row, and at my first two bestowment ceremonies. The chances are, like, next to zero. They thought about pulling me out of this class to focus on Sentry stuff, but the director apparently really wants me at the Victoriad now."

Her grin faded, and she looked at me with obvious concern. "What's wrong? I…thought you'd be proud of me. Did I say something I shouldn't have, Professor?" Suddenly she stepped back and bowed so low her hair brushed the floor. "I apologize!"

As she was speaking, my mind had jumped from her to Valen, and then back to Maerin Town, where both Mayla and the boy Belmun—

the only two children I'd interacted closely with—received unusually powerful runes. I'd suspected before that my presence had something to do with it, but there had been no reason to think deeply about the bestowal process. I didn't know enough about how the Alacryans allocated magic to make guesses, other than an assumption that aether was involved somehow.

"Professor?"

My attention snapped back to her, and I realized I had been wearing a deep, thoughtful frown. I let my features relax. "I'm sorry, Mayla, I was just thinking…but this is all a big change for you. How are you holding up?"

When Mayla had received her original rune, it had been met with conflicted emotions. Her sister was unadorned, and would likely spend the rest of her life in Maerin Town. Two emblems all but guaranteed Mayla would be drawn into a life of adventure and danger. If she didn't become an ascender, she would certainly end up being drafted into the war.

And the next one won't be fought against Dicathian soldiers, I thought, realizing what the advanced runes might mean for them.

"I was scared, at first," she admitted. "I didn't want to leave home, but now that I've been here for a while…" She turned toward the door, where the sound of several sets of quick footsteps and multiple voices were approaching. "I've never felt special before. I always assumed I'd spend the rest of my life in Maerin Town, like Loreni." Her face fell. "Is it wrong that I don't feel guilty?"

"No," I answered, although I wasn't entirely sure if I believed myself. "As long as you haven't left your family behind in your heart, then

you're not abandoning them. Everything you do now is for them, as long as that is your intention."

Unspilled tears shone in Mayla's eyes, and she nodded vigorously. "I'm…really glad the Relictombs brought you to Maerin Town, Professor Grey."

I waved her to her seat wordlessly. She shuffled, then drew in close. I thought about stopping her again before she could wrap her arms around me, but only sighed instead, returning the hug with one arm while I patted the top of her head awkwardly.

Regis would have made so much fun of me if he were here…

After a couple seconds, I stepped back and turned away to clear my throat as the rest of the class began pouring in, their energy and excitement evident from the overflowing noise they produced.

The students burst into eager explanations of the runes they'd received during the bestowment ceremony. Every single member of the class had received at least a crest, as it turned out, with a handful of emblems as well. Even Deacon turned away from his books for long enough to brag about his new crest.

Sharp footfalls ringing in the outer hallway drew my attention away from the excited chatter just as Professor Irongrove, Head of the Melee Combat Department, pushed in the door. It took a moment for the students to notice, but one by one they hushed suddenly, their attention drawn to the older man. He paused at the door, then stepped aside to allow two familiar figures to enter before him.

Briar's signature hair—orange fading out to bright yellow-blonde at the ends—made her obvious from across campus, much less standing right in front of me, and I immediately wondered what the

hard-shelled young woman was up to. Her hazel eyes met mine defiantly as she descended the shallow steps.

Behind Briar was another familiar face, though it took me longer to place her. A dark-haired girl, similar height and build to Briar. Her eyes tracked over the classroom before settling on me, and then I remembered: Aphene of Blood Mandrick. She was the granddaughter of Elder Cromley, from Stormcove Academy. We had "fought" during the bestowment ceremony in Maerin.

Professor Irongrove stopped halfway down the stairs and opened his arms to encompass the class. "Melee Enhancement Tactics! Our star class. Victoriad competitors as well as the champions of the bestowment ceremony, I must say."

There were a few hoots and a round of applause from the students, to which Irongrove responded with a good-natured smile. When the class quieted, he met my eye. "Professor Grey, I'm sorry to intrude, but I was hoping for a quick conversation before your class begins for the day?"

I nodded and gestured toward my office. Rafferty and the two young women let themselves into the small office, and I followed. The moment the door closed behind me, the classroom burst out into noise again.

"I won't keep you, busy as you are preparing for the Victoriad," Rafferty began, his tone businesslike. "In fact, that's why I'm here. Since you do not have a classroom assistant, the director wanted to ensure you had help. A bit of an oversight that it wasn't seen to earlier, honestly…" He cleared his throat and his gaze dropped to the ground for an instant. "These two very capable young women

have offered to join you as assistant professors leading up to and during the Victoriad. A couple more sets of eyes—and fists—to keep the students on task, if you understand me."

I shot Briar a look, my lips quirking into a wry smile. "Figured out a way to get to the Victoriad after all, huh?"

Rafferty glanced between us. "It was my understanding that you'd trained alongside Briar of Blood Nadir before. She is an excellent student, I assure you—"

I held up my hand. "Only teasing, Professor. She's welcome to be my assistant." My attention turned to Aphene. "I'm more curious about this one."

Aphene lifted her chin, and couldn't help but notice the slight tremor that ran through her. When last we met, I had soundly defeated her and her friend—I couldn't recall his name—in a two-on-one duel.

"Aphene's grandfather sought sponsorship from the Denoirs for her to attend Central Academy," Rafferty informed me. "The Denoirs were quite vocal in their eagerness that she be given a place within our ranks, and Cromley himself reached out to me to provide a recommendation for his granddaughter. I heard the story of your duel in Etril. Based on that alone—two students fighting an accomplished ascender nearly to a standstill!—I'm sure you agree that she would make an excellent assistant."

My eyebrows rose slowly higher as Rafferty talked, and I had to consciously repress a surprised scoff at the mention of our fight. The young woman had some talent, but if the Denoirs were involved, it seemed very likely she would be asked to spy on me, just as Caera

had. Pushing back on the posting had its own set of disadvantages, however, and seemed more trouble than it was worth.

I nodded in affirmation. “Both fine. I’ll be glad to have a couple of babysitters around, while I focus on the important stuff.” I bit back a smirk as Briar and Aphene shot me matching glares. “Now, Professor Irongrove, I’m sure you have things to attend to, because I know I do.”

The void was empty and motionless around me. The darkness no longer rippled, and I sensed nothing else—no presence, no energy—inside the keystone with me.

Intermittent pulses of aether emitted from my body as I drifted through the dark. There was no response. Eventually, my mind strayed away from the emptiness and back to the real world.

The class had responded well to Briar and Aphene’s presence. Although Briar was only in her second season at the academy, she was older than most of the others—and had benefited from Darrin Ordin’s private tutoring—while Aphene was nearing her final season. The two young women had stepped eagerly into their roles, helping me drill the class on a series of new forms, offshoots of Kordri’s training that I thought would challenge them leading up to the Victoriad.

It was then, when I let myself be distracted, that I saw it again: a curtain-in-the-wind movement through the inky black space.

A knock at the door once again interrupted me, but I ignored it, focusing on the ripples disrupting the aetheric realm within the keystone. The knock came again, louder and more insistent this time.

I withdrew from the keystone and stored it away. “Come in,” I said irritably.

The office door opened and Kayden Aphelion poked his head inside. “I’m not interrupting some secret cabal meeting or something, am I?”

“What can I help you with?” I asked, deadpan, not in the mood to exchange pointless witticisms.

Instead of being put off by my attitude, the other professor seemed to take it as a challenge. He limped through the door and eased down in the seat across from me. “In the hopes of convincing you not to take my life for interrupting this secret, undoubtedly high-society meeting—were there masks? I feel like there would be masks. And scantily dressed servants. Anyway, where was I?

“Right,” he said, leaning back in the chair and struggling to cross his legs, an act that required him to physically lift one over the other with his hand. “Straight to business, then. I thought you might be interested to know that you’ve drawn just a tiny bit of attention to yourself, Professor Grey.”

Still leaning back against my seat, I held Kayden’s steady gaze. His eyes were sharp and watchful, not quite matching the wry smirk he wore. “Speak plainly, Kayden.”

He glanced around the office, checking the corners playfully, a mocking pantomime of searching for spies. “Word of your class’s success during the bestowment ceremony has traveled quickly, and far. You know Sulla of Blood Drusus, yes? The head of Cargidan’s Ascenders Association? He’s a friend of mine, and has apparently

received letters from every corner of Alacrya wondering about you, where you came from, et cetera."

He waited, watching me curiously.

"Is there some reason you're telling me this?" I asked.

Kayden shrugged nonchalantly. "Like I said when we first met, you seem like a man who prefers to keep his business private. And yet, it seems like half the highbloods and ascenders from Rosaere to Onaeka now know your name. It's whispered often in Vechor, in particular, according to Sul."

"And why would that be?"

Kayden's smirk sharpened. "You should know as well as I that every instant of the Victoriad—every appointment, every match, hell, every handshake or lack thereof—is closely watched, because the event itself can change the political face of entire dominions. A change of retainer or Scythe can cause bloods to rise and fall…the perfect opportunity for an ascender of unknown blood to make a sudden and violent *ascent* through the ranks of power."

His smile fell away as he spoke. "But I'm not here for answers, or even to share my conjecture. I simply wish to let you know—as your self-proclaimed friend—that you are being watched closely, and from many angles. Whether you seek to challenge for the position of retainer of Vechor or not, you have certainly spawned a whirlwind of rumors."

I couldn't help the surprised laugh that burst out of me, drawing an uncertain smile from Kayden. "Is *that* the rumor?" I said, practically gasping with amusement. "Oh, perfect. *Perfect*."

Kayden must have found my laughter contagious, because he began to chuckle as well. “So you don’t intend to challenge to be Dragoth’s retainer?”

I shook my head and wiped a tear from the corner of my eye. “No, not in the slightest.”

“Ah well, there goes the bet I planned to make. Anyway, I won’t keep you longer, I just thought—”

“It’s fine,” I said, my irritation soothing. “I appreciate the information.”

Kayden limped his way to the door, moving slowly. As he left the office, I said, “Caera mentioned you were in the war. We should… trade stories, one of these days.”

He paused, his eyes widening slightly. “Sure. Maybe invite me to your next cabal meeting, and I’ll tell you all about it.”

I still wasn’t entirely convinced that he hadn’t seen something the night Caera and I stole the Compass, but if he had, he was keeping it close to his chest. It seemed more likely that he hadn’t seen anything at all, considering the dark and the rain, and he hadn’t brought that chance meeting up again, or even asked how “Haedrig” had fared.

I was still considering his words as I left the building for the day. Although any attention was unwanted at this point, at least the nobility had invented their own reasons for my fame, as I’d expected. And if Agrona or his Scythes had caught wind of me yet, they hadn’t made the connection between my two identities. If they had, I was sure they’d have arrived in force already.

Thoughts of conflict with Agrona’s forces were interrupted as I caught sight of a familiar head of navy blue hair just a few dozen

steps ahead of me. I increased my pace in order to catch up to Caera, but slowed when I noticed she was reading a letter as she walked, disregarding the crowd around her. After a moment, she tossed her hair and began to rip the letter to pieces.

"More orders to spy on me?" I asked, making her jump. She spun around, crumpling the ripped pieces of the letter into her fists. Her cheeks were quickly turning red. "I was joking but…it was, wasn't it?"

She glanced around us at the passing students. "Yes and no. It was…an invitation to dinner. Again. I've already refused, but my adoptive parents are persistent…"

The gears in my brain turned as I thought back to Kayden's advice about all the highbloods growing curious about me. With the Victoriad looming, I had to consider what might come after my time as a professor ended. It felt appropriate to start planting a few seeds for the future.

I held out an arm for Caera to take, which she did with a suspicious glance. "I'll need some help picking out my outfit if I'm to be in the presence of such renowned and powerful highbloods as Highlord and Lady Denoir."

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PLANTING SEEDS

A PATH of rich red paver stones led up to the Denoir estate, flanked by thigh-high bushes that were currently blooming with bright blue flowers despite the chill from the mountains. The mansion itself was huge, easily three times the size of the Helstea estate where I had lived in Xyrus, and the grounds around it rivalled the yards of the royal palace from my previous life.

After taking a moment to make sure that Regis was still well within range of me, I strode forward.

Floating light artifacts began to blink to life throughout the gardens as we approached, bathing the grounds in a soft yellow glow. One of the oversized double doors into the estate opened, and a woman in an ash-gray uniform came rushing out, moving quickly to meet us. Her bright orange hair was pulled up in a bun, just as it had been when I'd seen her outside the Relictombs descension portal.

"Lady Caera!" she said warmly, stopping in front of us and bowing. "And Ascender Grey." She bowed again. "Welcome to the Denoir estate."

"Thank you," I said, returning her warm smile. "And you would be Nessa, correct?"

The woman was clearly surprised, but made an effort to hide it, bowing a third time. "You honor me." Although her tone was steady, I could just see a red blush spreading onto her cheeks.

"No need to be so humble," I said, gesturing for her to straighten. "Caera expressed that you are half the reason she stayed sane under the highlord and lady's roof."

Nessa's blush deepened, and she seemed unsure how to reply. Caera saved her by reaching for the woman's arm and continuing toward the house.

After a few steps, Caera shot a glance back over her shoulder, her expression both playful and scolding.

She had prepared me for the evening, telling me everyone's names and explaining the evening's protocol, even outlining the likely topics of conversation should her adoptive parents attempt to wrangle me into some political debate.

Caera most likely viewed me as some sort of unsociable brute who preferred picking fights with mana beasts to being sociable—and I guess she wouldn't be entirely wrong—but she didn't know that I had been a king in my previous life, which had given me years of practice dealing with people like the Denoirs.

More servants were waiting in the entrance hall. Although most kept their eyes down in a respectful bow, a younger woman glanced a peek only to meet my eyes. I flashed her a polite smile, which she responded with a panicked look before averting her eyes back to the floor. From there, we were led to a posh sitting room. Lavish furniture was arrayed in small groupings throughout the large room, which burst with color, and an entire bar ran along the far wall.

Standing at the bar was Lauden Denoir, who I'd met at the culmination of my trial. A woman in a sprawling maroon dress with brilliantly white hair that draped over her shoulders was leaning back in a lounging chair—Caera's adoptive mother, Lenora Denoir. The blond swordsman, Arian, stood in one corner.

Lenora stood gracefully as we entered, practically floating up out of her seat and giving us a well-practiced but welcoming smile. Her eyes took in everything from my boots up to my wheat-blond hair in a single glance, and I could practically see the gears turning behind her perceptive eyes.

Nessa bowed and stepped aside. “Lady Lenora of Highblood Denoir. Lady Caera has returned. She brings with her a guest, Ascender Grey.” Then she straightened and backed up so she was nearly pressed against the wall next to the sitting room door, still as a statue.

“Please,” Lenora said, gesturing to the closest couch. “Join me and my son for a drink while we wait for my husband. He should be down any moment.”

Lauden carried two glasses from the bar, one of which he handed to his mother, then he turned and held out his hand to me. I took it firmly, meeting his eye. “How nice to see you again, Ascender Grey. Or do you prefer professor, now?” His manners were impeccable, but they couldn’t completely shroud the obvious tension that he carried in his shoulders and brows.

“Please, Grey would be more than adequate,” I answered.

Lauden handed the second glass to Caera. As soon as her adoptive brother’s back was to her, she wrinkled her nose and set it down surreptitiously. Lauden didn’t seem to notice as he returned to the bar. “Well then, Grey, what would you like to drink? My father takes no little pride in the quality of our collection. Here you will find only the finest and most potent drinks, specifically tailored to be enjoyed

by those with the elevated metabolism provided by strength in magic."

"It's only proper that I wait for the highlord, as tradition dictates he has the first drink when imbibing with guests," I answered properly before giving him a wink. "But I would enjoy the opportunity to sample your fine collection, of course."

Lauden chuckled. "A man of culture. My father will no doubt appreciate your adherence to the social norm, although I hope you'll forgive me for starting without you."

With this formality out of the way, Lauden continued to make small talk while Lenora questioned Caera about the academy. Lady Denoir and Caera's attitude toward each other was stiff and businesslike, and I caught Caera glancing in my direction more than once.

After a few minutes, the noise of heavy, unhurried footsteps in the hall announced Highlord Corbett Denoir's arrival.

We all stood as the highlord entered the sitting room, appearing from whatever preoccupation he had feigned in order to keep me waiting, a common tactic among these noble types. His clever eyes jumped to each of us in turn, though they lingered on me the longest. His white and navy suit looked like it cost as much as some people's houses, and he wore a golden-hilted saber at his side.

Crossing one arm over my chest with my fist just below my shoulder, and the other behind my back, I bowed slightly, just the gentle inclination of my back. It was the type of bow one gave to show respect, but not subservience. This simple gesture—I had all but shouted that I saw our positions as equal—would set a spark to the

questions in his mind, since the Denoirs already suspected I was secretly a highblood.

"Welcome to our home," he said, unperturbed, before moving around behind where his wife was sitting and resting a hand on her shoulder. "This meeting has been too long in coming, hasn't it my love?"

"Indeed it has," she replied, beaming up at him. To me, she said, "You've given us such a novel experience, as neither of us are accustomed to having our invitations rejected."

Her execution was flawless—politefully teasing with barbs hidden between her words and a blade in her smile.

"You have my apologies," I replied with a weary smile. "It was my selfish desire to express to the other professors at Central Academy that I had rightfully earned a position there."

"Come now, we only jest," Lenora said with a chuckle. "Regardless, Corbett and I are quite curious about you. Why don't we move to the dining room, and you can tell us about yourself over a wonderful dinner our cooks have prepared in your honor?"

Standing, I held out my arm to the Denoir matron, who took it with a curious smile. "Lead the way, Lady Denoir," I said politely.

She did so, with the rest of the Denoirs following after us. Corbett spoke quietly with Lauden about some business dealing while Lenora showed off the mansion, telling me about the many items on display throughout the estate, including several very fine paintings and tapestries, and at least a dozen different accolades returned from the Relictombs.

A long table dominated the dining room, with seating enough for at least thirty people. Three chandeliers hung from a high ceiling, filling the space with a brilliant light. Another small bar ran along one side of the room, while the other was covered up by cabinets and shelves filled with fine dishes and silverware in dozens of different stylings. It was clearly a valuable collection, and likely something Lenora took great pride in, a fact I filed away for our conversations.

The table was already set, and Lenora led me to the far end, gesturing for me to take the seat just left of the head of the table, where Highlord Denoir sat a moment later. Lenora sat across from me, with Caera to my left, and Lauden across from her next to his mother. It was a position of honor, to be sat at the left hand of the highlord, which I assumed was normally reserved for his son.

Lenora continued to chat away while hors d'oeuvres were served, and I grinned and laughed freely between bites of spiced figs topped with crisp bits of meat. The conversation shifted to Corbett over an appetizer of stuffed mushrooms, but he avoided any serious topics, expressing interest in my class at the academy and telling me about his interest in literature as he subtly bragged about the Denoirs' donations to the Central Academy library. Caera kept a cool kind of silence, not interjecting in the conversation unless she was addressed directly.

It wasn't until the salad arrived that the conversation shifted into something more serious.

"So, Grey," Corbett began, stabbing his fork into his bowl, "I was hoping to learn more about your blood. It's no mean feat, securing a

position at Central Academy. It speaks highly of your blood's connections."

I gave the man a wide smile and shrugged nonchalantly. "I'm sorry to disappoint, but there is no mystery to uncover, whatever rumors might be flying around. My parents are from a remote village, and they were both simple people. My father was killed in the war," I said passively, my voice devoid of emotion. "After the war was over, I turned to the Relictombs and became an ascender instead, trying to take care of my mother and sister."

Corbett listened as if he only half believed me, but Lenora's hand had moved to cover her mouth. "Too many were lost fighting those savages in Dicathen."

Lauden grunted unhappily, turning away from the conversation and taking a long drink from his glass.

Seeing an opportunity to take the reins of the conversation, I said, "Indeed, far too many, especially in…what was it called? Dicathen's magic forests?"

"Elenoir," Lauden answered, staring down into his drink, his expression sour.

"That's it," I said, rapping my knuckles on the wooden table. "Poor souls. Although, from what Caera has told me, Highblood Denoir didn't have a presence there."

Corbett and Lenora exchanged a quick glance. "No," Corbett answered after a moment. "I recognized that we already had everything we needed in Alacrya. Maintaining a hold in such a far-off land, and still full of turmoil, seemed an unnecessary complication."

“A fortuitous decision. Many others weren’t so wise.” I turned to Lauden. “You lost people in Elenoir?”

He tipped back his glass, finishing off his drink in one gulp. “A lot of those who went to Elenoir to set up the holds were blood-heirs, or second sons. I knew many of them. Some entire bloods—those who dedicated the most to this effort—were wiped out, depriving Alacrya of many powerful voices and ending many potent bloodlines. And what did we accomplish—”

“Lauden,” Corbett chastised, giving his son a subtle shake of his head. “This isn’t the time for such a conversation. Grey, I hope you’ll retire with me to my study after dinner? A good fire and a Sovereigns Quarrel board make for a better backdrop to politics than the dining room, wouldn’t you agree?”

Although disappointed—I wanted to delve more into this tension Lauden displayed, to see how deep it ran—I only nodded politely, and the conversation turned back to more mundane matters for the remainder of dinner.

After we’d eaten as much roasted meat and fruit tarts as was polite—leaving the last bite on our plates to show that we’d been well fed and weren’t gluttonous—the table was cleared and Lenora whisked Caera away.

Lauden leaned back in his chair and gave me a curious look. “Your star seems to be rising fast, Grey,” he said with just a hint of a slur after several glasses of strong amber liquor. “Best of luck at the Victoriad. It is the place to cement your position amongst the nobility—or to see yourself fall with all speed back to the ground.”

“See to your mother and sister before retiring,” Corbett said firmly, leveling a steady gaze at his son. He held out a hand to a side door out of the dining room. “Grey?”

Wordlessly, I followed Corbett through the house and up into an office. I’d known people whose entire homes would have fit into the two-story study, and there were as many books as the Aramoor City library. The fire was already burning.

“Have a seat,” Corbett said, gesturing to a very fine leather chair resting to one side of a carved marble table, which had a game board etched into the surface and pieces already laid out. “I assume you play?”

I nodded, then gave a helpless sort of shrug. “I should say I *have* played. Caera enjoys reminding me that she has benefited from *significantly* more practice and training than I have.”

Corbett’s expression didn’t change as he poured us both yet another drink and took the seat opposite me. I took a sip from the offered glass. It burned going down, but settled warm and heavy into my stomach. Some of my surprise must have slipped through onto my face because Corbett’s lips twitched in a bare smile.

“Dragon’s Breath,” he announced. “I’m not surprised you’ve never had it. It’s made with a rare spice that only grows along the banks of the Redwater near Aensgar. The warriors of Vechor will often drink it before a battle.”

“And is that what this is?” I asked, resting my glass on the edge of the board. “A battle?”

The brief glint of a humorless smile returned. “That depends on your skill.”

He gave me the first move, and I started the game conservatively, moving a shield up the middle of the game board. “Have the events in Elenoir soured the highbloods’ taste for this war?” I asked conversationally, although I watched Corbett’s face carefully.

He responded more aggressively than I’d expected, drawing a caster along the edge of the board. It was the same opening maneuver Caera often used. “My son is headstrong, and has reason to be frustrated. Several of our friends and allies were lost in the asuras’ attack.”

“Although, to be fair, many more Dicathian lives must have been lost in the attack than those of Alacryans,” I pointed out, continuing to inch forward with my shields.

“All the more reason they should embrace the High Sovereign,” he grunted, his eye on the game. Still, there was something in the lines around his eyes and in his stiff posture that told me he found the topic of Elenoir and all those deaths uncomfortable.

“Perhaps,” I replied, pretending to think about my next move as I took another drink of the fiery liquor. “And yet, I can’t help but wonder…if it meant avoiding further conflict between the asura, would it be worth giving up Dicathen?”

He frowned deeply, which highlighted his wrinkles and made him look about a decade older. “You mean withdraw the forces there and abandon the continent?” He rubbed his chin thoughtfully. “That is a risky proposition. The blow to morale—”

“Let me phrase it another way,” I said, dragging a striker across the board to take out his caster. “If the cost of the war—the cost in

highblood lives—had been made clear up front, would they still have supported it?"

We played a couple moves in thoughtful silence, although Corbett's eyes kept flicking away from the board to me. After a minute or two, he said, "It is common for the lesser bloods to overestimate the power and authority of the highbloods."

I bit back an eager smile at his slip. "Surely if a majority of the highbloods spoke together as one, the Sovereigns—"

"You have climbed far, and too quickly," Corbett said, taking his hands away from the board and leaning back in his chair. "It is evident in the way you speak, like you have no experience with the higher levels of politics in Alacrya. You should be careful, Grey. The wrong word in the wrong ear can get you killed."

As if to emphasize his point, he took a striker through a gap in my shields and killed one of my casters. It left the striker piece open to a counterattack, but it weakened the inner circle of defense around my sentry. "Rushing in, being bold…that is what those bloods who died in Elenoir did. And now many of them are less than the lowest unnamed."

When I responded by killing the striker, I noticed Corbett's knuckles were white as he picked the piece up, squeezing it between his fingers as if he could crush the carved stone to dust.

"Why encourage such heavy investment in Elenoir if there was still such risk?" I asked, my tone innocent and unassuming.

Corbett set the piece down with a sharp *clink* and met my eye. "Perhaps the Sovereigns didn't think the asura had it in them to break the treaty…" But the truth was there, gleaming like a fire in

his eyes. He didn't believe that the Vritra—deities themselves—could be caught so off guard. Which meant…

"You think it was a trap," I said flatly, a statement of fact. "Bait, to make the asuras break the treaty."

Corbett tensed. "You are aware of the relationship between Caera and the Denoirs, correct?"

I nodded.

"Did you know that, should we fail in our duty to the Vritra and to Caera, Highblood Denoir could be stripped of all titles and lands? Lenora and I could be executed."

Again, I nodded in response.

"We are one of the most influential highbloods in the central dominion, even in all of Alacrya," he said, although there was no smugness in the statement. "And yet, a misstep would mean our sudden and violent end. We do not serve kings or queens, as the Dicathians do. Our lords are gods themselves, and we are *all* subject entirely to their will, from the lowest unnamed to the wealthiest highblood. You would do well not to forget this fact, Grey. Do not think yourself untouchable because you have found some success."

Pondering this, I made a series of quick moves to end the game. Although I felt certain I could have ended it in a true win, taking my sentry across the board to Corbett's hold, my taste and patience for the game had faded. Besides, I doubted I would gain anything else from Corbett or his family that evening.

When my caster finally killed his sentry, he gave a resigned sigh and held his glass up to me. "Tell me, Grey, is it generally *after* you've beaten her that Caera reminds you of her tutoring in this game?"

I let a genuine smile show through the stoic calmness that I'd kept up for most of our conversation. "How'd you guess?"

As soon as we returned to the ground level, Caera took me by the arm. "Grey, I'm afraid we *really* should be going. Plenty to do still in preparation for the Victoriad."

"You're right, of course. Highlord Denoir and I—"

"Please, call me Corbett," he said, his tone shifting noticeably toward something approaching friendliness. He patted me on the shoulder and said, "I enjoyed our game, although I'm afraid you distracted me with conversation—by design, I imagine," he said, giving me a sharp look. "You owe me a rematch, which of course means you and Caera will have to return for dinner at a later date."

Caera was watching her adoptive father with unsuppressed surprise, and even Lenora seemed taken aback for a moment before sliding her arm around the highlord. "If anything, I'd say you owe it to us for keeping us waiting so long!" Lenora and Corbett both shared a small laugh.

I gave them another bow, slightly deeper than before. "Thank you, both for the fine food and stimulating conversation."

Caera looked at me like a third eye had just grown in my forehead. "Okay then, we'll see ourselves out, so… bye."

With that, the Denoirs bid us farewell, with Lady Lenora seeing us to the door herself while Nessa stood by. Caera gave a perfunctory farewell before leading us quickly away from the estate and out to the street where we could flag down a carriage to return us to the academy grounds.

“What in the name of the Vritra did you do to Corbett?” she said once we were well away from the doors.
“What?” I asked innocently, my mind already at work sorting through everything Corbett had told me.
“I swear, you’re like a handsome, mysterious onion,” she said wryly. “Every challenge that we face together reveals yet another layer to you. How exactly does a self-proclaimed nobody from the outskirts of Sehz-Clar learn to rub elbows with highbloods like you?” Before I could answer, she kept going. “No, never mind. Honestly, I don’t want to know.”
I laughed quietly as I threw the white cloak Kayden had given me around my shoulders. “I’ve had reason to learn many skills. A dining room can be just as deadly as any battlefield.”
“And your tongue is sharp as a sword,” she scoffed as a carriage pulled by a bright orange lizard stopped for us.

Black void.
Just that, nothing more.
What am I missing? I asked myself as I swam through the keystone realm. *There is something here. I’ve felt it.*
The real problem was context. Djinn had handed down their knowledge in an esoteric way designed to spark insight, not to allow for memorization or the building of a skill. They likely had an instinctive understanding of their own teaching methods, much the same way that I had been able to read encyclopedias and tomes on magic when I was first born in this world. The Dicathian method for

teaching and learning operated on the same principles as those of Earth. But the djinn's keystones did not.

And yet I had gained insight into Aroa's Requiem from the first keystone—

An idea struck me, sending my heart racing. I withdrew from the keystone and held up the black cube. If it was damaged somehow, perhaps…

The golden rune flared to life on my back, glowing through my shirt, and amethyst motes of energy danced and jumped along my arm, flowing to the keystone until they swarmed over it like purple fireflies.

But they didn't appear to be doing anything.

There were no cracks to flow into, no damage to repair. More frustrating still, I didn't know if the godrune wasn't working because there was nothing to fix or because it couldn't repair the damage—like the exit portal in Three Steps' zone.

Cursing my incomplete insight into the godrune, I released it, and the motes flickered and faded away.

Several minutes later, I was still sitting there staring at the black cube when my office door opened suddenly, and Enola marched in and seated herself in the chair on the other side of my desk.

"By all means, come in," I said, setting the heavy cube on my desk and looking at the precocious young woman. She was glaring down at her hands, which were clenched together in her lap. My voice softened slightly as I continued. "You weren't in class after the bestowal. Did you receive such a powerful rune that they've allowed you to skip the rest of your schooling?"

She rubbed at her face then combed her fingers through her short golden hair. “No. My blood matron recalled me to our estate for a couple days,” she said stiffly. “To discuss my future.”

When did I become a teen counselor? I nearly said the words aloud, but bit my tongue.

“I received a regalia,” she said, her voice gravelly with restrained emotion. “The only one in the academy to do so during this ceremony, even among the older students.”

I let out a low whistle. “That’s serious.”

With huff, Enola stood suddenly, nearly knocking over the chair, then winced and set it back in place. She stood behind it, her hands clenching the back. “My blood has already arranged a posting for me in Dicathen after this season. I should have another two and a half years of academy, but they are moving me around like a piece on a Sovereigns Quarrel board, using my regalia to elevate our highblood.”

“And putting you front and center if this conflict with the asura escalates further,” I pointed out carefully. I considered saying more, offering her advice or a calming word, but I couldn’t bring myself to comfort her; she was being sent across the sea to help keep my friends and family in check.

Enola turned her chin up proudly. “I’m not afraid to go or anything. I’m a *warrior*. But…” She swallowed heavily. “Is it really even a war, if we’re battling asura? It seems more like an extermination to me. Regalia or not, how can regular soldiers make a difference in such a conflict?”

They can't, I wanted to say. Aldir had burned an entire nation as if Elenoir had been built on the head of a matchstick.

"My…" She paused and slipped around the chair, taking her seat again. "My brother was killed in Dicathen. In the early days, one of our first assaults. The same battle in which Jagrette, the Truacian retainer was killed." She smiled bitterly, looking past me instead of meeting my eye. "I remember because they announced it like dying alongside a retainer was some kind of honor."

I couldn't help but wince. I had fought and killed the poison witch Jagrette in a swamp near Slore, and a sudden realization hit me. While I was busy being angry about what these students' families had done, I hadn't even stopped to consider the fact that I could have killed their relatives in battle.

"You must hate the Dicathians," I said, feeling somewhat guilty for my deception.

"No," she said immediately, her answer firm. "My brother died in honest battle. War is war. They were our opponent. Although I'll miss him, my brother was lucky to have such a war to fight in."

Enola fell silent, and I knew what she was thinking.

"But fighting asuras…" I probed.

"I want to be a soldier, or maybe a powerful ascender." She crossed her arms and sagged back into the chair. "But I do not wish to be tossed away or burned up as kindling in a battle between greater beings." Her eyes locked onto mine, then, like she was daring me to argue with her.

Resting my elbows on the desk, I sighed. My gaze drifted to the keystone, and Enola's followed. "Any one soldier can change the

course of a battle," I stated. "The strongest warrior can fall unexpectedly, while the weakest and most cowardly might stumble ass-backwards into victory." I picked the keystone up and turned it over in my hand, recalling the djinn projection's words. "But your path is your own, and only you can walk it. You might choose to give up your life, if necessary, but no one gets to throw your life away like it means nothing."

Enola tensed, her jaw visibly tightening as her eyes bore into me. "Do you really believe that?"

I smiled and knocked the cube lightly against the desktop, breaking the tension. "With every fiber of my being."

She gave me a single sharp nod, then looked again at the keystone. "What is that?"

"Oh, this old thing?" I said, flipping it in the air and catching it again. "It's just a tool to help me meditate and channel my…mana."

As I stumbled over the word, very nearly saying aether instead, my mind connected two points of data I hadn't previously considered. Both times I saw the black-on-black movement within the keystone, it was when someone had approached me, interrupting my meditation. I had thought it was just bad luck, with the interruptions coming at exactly the wrong time, but what if…

"Here, let me show you how it works," I said quickly, channeling aether into the keystone.

My mind rushed into the darkness. It was alive with movement. All around me, subtle streams of inky black writhed and ran like oil over water.

The keystone reacted to the presence of mana. Which explained why I couldn't sense anything within.

Like a blind man trying to navigate a labyrinth, I thought, alive with sudden motivation in the face of such a challenge.

I *would* find the insight stored within, and take one step closer to discovering the edict of Fate.

365
UNFINISHED GRUDGES

VALEN'S FIST snapped out in a sharp jab at Seth's nose. Instead of stumbling away as he once would have, the thin boy moved into the blow, sapping it of any strength. His knee came up into Valen's ribs, but Valen blocked with a palm before leaning forward and throwing his shoulder into Seth's chest, sending him reeling backwards.

A spinning sweep at Seth's legs—already poorly positioned for balance—sent Seth crashing hard to the mat.

"Well done you two," Aphene was saying, and I turned my attention back to the papers in front of me with a sigh.

Each attending professor had been provided with documents explaining the Victoriad. Due to the nature of the event, adherence to tradition and protocol was of extreme importance, and so the information provided was thorough to the point of tedium. I knew it was necessary to commit this to memory, but my mind kept wandering back to my own plans for the event.

I was stronger now than I had been as a white core Lance, even if I'd lost some of the weapons in my arsenal. Still, I wanted to use this event to gauge my strength against that of my enemies—without giving away my identity if at all possible.

With the reputation that I'd built here as both a professor and ascender, I wanted to test my strength—if not against a Scythe, then at least against a retainer. Both Caera and Kayden mentioned that it was uncommon for even retainers to receive a challenge, but after reading this document, it became increasingly clear just how rare it was.

Never mind challenging a Scythe, even requesting a duel from a retainer required the consent of their Scythe beforehand. Caera had mentioned that since there were two open retainer positions this time, people speculated there would be many more prospects than normal.

And since both Scythes and retainers could refuse a challenger if they found such a contest to be beneath them, it would be difficult for me to even fight against a retainer.

Worst case, if none of the retainers accepted my challenge, I'd have to watch the duels from afar.

Normally, this is where Regis would have interjected with some blunt but annoyingly accurate assessment of this situation, but no such response came.

It was quiet in my head without the sardonic flaming wolf. Although I could still feel him, connected to me by a thin thread that stretched high up the slope of the closest mountain range, his thoughts were shielded from me, his focus entirely on himself. But brief pulses of excitement or frustration that weren't my own flared up occasionally, and I knew he was growing. I could sense his strength.

I had gotten used to having my mind to myself, but that didn't mean it was peaceful. I had forgotten how much my brain spun without Regis to cut me short.

Realizing I had completely lost the thread of what I had been reading, I set down the parchment to watch the next training bout.

Aphene had brought two more students up to spar while Briar led the rest of the class in a series of exercises. Marcus and Sloane were

exchanging a brutal series of punches and kicks as the classroom doors opened and several armored men stepped inside.

Sloane saw them first and missed a block, taking an elbow into his chin that laid him out flat. This drew the rest of the class's attention, and the students burst into a round of surprised chatter. Briar and Aphene were quick to stamp it out, their eyes turning questioningly in my direction.

"Can I help you?" I said, standing from my seat at the training platform control panel and ascending halfway up the stairs toward the intruders. "We're in the middle of class."

A familiar figure strode forward, scratching his trimmed beard and giving me an awkward smile. "Sorry, Grey, but I'm afraid you're going to have to come with us."

I scowled at Sulla, head of the Ascenders Association in Cargidan. "Can this wait until—"

"I'm afraid not," he said firmly.

My mind began to race as I considered what they could be there for. Sulla's grim expression made it clear his visit wasn't social in nature. But since this was the Ascenders Association and not academy guards or local law enforcement, I wasn't sure what the issue could be. If my identity had been compromised—a possibility I was always conscious of—then it would have been Nico or Cadell knocking down my door.

So what, then?

I turned and met Briar's eye. "You and Aphene finish class. I won't be gone long."

Ascending the stairs, I watched the group's hands and eyes for any sign they were prepared to attack. The men were tense and watchful, maybe even a little nervous, but I also sensed a mutinous kind of frustration in their matching frowns. "Sorry about this," one of them muttered, quieting immediately when Sulla shot him a warning glare.

The head ascender himself had the stiff, awkward look of a man doing something against his will. Whatever was going on, these ascenders weren't thrilled about it.

And so I didn't resist, but let them march me out of the building and across campus. They took up positions around me, but no one drew a weapon or prepared any spells—at least that I could detect. Most of the students were in class, but we still passed many dozens of people on our way out of campus, and I could already sense my name at the heart of a hundred whispered conversations behind me.

Thankfully, the Ascenders Association Hall was close by.

I followed Sulla up into his office, which overlooked the building's main floor. The other ascenders posted up outside the doors, which Sulla closed behind us.

I took a seat without being invited to do so, then waited. Sulla picked up a leather satchel from behind his desk, watching me carefully. Then, with a sudden surge of frustrated anger, he slammed the satchel on his desk and slumped into his chair.

"Damn it, Grey, do you even understand how close to death you've come?"

I turned my head slightly to the side and made a show of looking around the office. “I don’t seem to have a knife to my neck, so no, I really don’t.”

Sulla gave a humorless scoff. “It seems unlikely you worry about little things like knives.” Grabbing the bottom of the satchel, he upended it, spilling a stack of parchment out across his desk. “Do you know what these are?”

Still watching Sulla, I picked up a loose page that had fluttered across the desk toward me. It contained a bracket with each of my own students paired up against an unfamiliar name. *The Victoriad tournament*, I realized.

“I don’t understand the problem,” I said, feigning nonchalance and tossing the page back into the pile on Sulla’s desk.

His left eye twitched. Through gritted teeth, he said, “Then please allow me to educate you, *Professor*.” He had to take a moment before continuing, during which he riffled through the pages. When he found what he was looking for, he held it up for me to see. “This is a report on the Victoriad combatants from Bloodrock Academy in Vechor—or at least, those who will be competing specifically in the non-magical, unarmed duels.” He set it down hard and picked up another page. “This provides some very specific details on one of Bloodrock’s top fighters. Lists of runes, type of mage, preferred combat styles…Vritra’s horns, Grey, it even names which members of her blood could be threatened or bribed to influence her performance.”

He proceeded to go through a handful more pages, which all contained similar details regarding other top performing fighters from a variety of academies.

"Great, this seems like some very thorough research," I said finally, interrupting him as he started explaining yet another page. "But what does it have to do with me? This stuff isn't mine."

Sulla sighed and rubbed the bridge of his nose. "Then why has a reliable witness come forward and asserted that you are attempting to cheat in the Victoriad, using these documents as proof."

I stared at the pile of papers for a moment, then let out a surprised laugh. "You're kidding, right?"

Sulla sat back in his chair and stared at me like a horn had sprouted from the middle of my forehead. "Do you deny that you are leading an effort to give your students unfair advantage in the Victoriad?"

"If my students have an advantage, it'll be because they've worked for it, not because I bullied some teenage girl's mom," I snapped, irritated to have been bothered with this nonsense. "No, I really do have more important things to do—"

Sulla placed both hands on his desk, knocking a few pieces of parchment to the floor, and leaned toward me. "Then someone is trying to get you killed, Grey."

I eyed the veteran ascender curiously, waiting for him to continue.

"Cheating at, tampering with, or otherwise disrupting the events of the Victoriad will result in your execution as part of the Victoriad 'entertainment'," he proclaimed ominously. "So if you didn't order all this information collected—information which makes it clear you intend to threaten harm to several members of important

highbloods—then someone else did, and purely to get you accused of a crime that could end your life."

I was listening more seriously now, but something about what Sulla was saying didn't make sense. "You said you had a witness? Someone who claimed they were working with me or for me or something?"

He squinted thoughtfully before replying. "Yes. They came to us of their own accord, claiming they were forced to make several contacts between you and academy staff all over Alacrya. When they intercepted this satchel of documents—supposedly intended for you—they realized what you were up to and felt compelled to turn in the evidence."

Sulla paused. "You should know, a handful of people are corroborating this statement, confirming that they received threatening letters from you to provide all this." He gestured at the papers. "The best case scenario is that you are banned from attending the Victoriad. The worse, well, I've already told you."

Even from the moment Sulla and his enforcers had arrived in my classroom, he had seemed uncomfortable. Now the reason was clear. "Why are you so certain I didn't do it?"

He scoffed again. "Anyone who'd actually met you would know you wouldn't need to cheat. I've heard about your students' bestowals, too. No, this smelled like a setup from the beginning."

Nodding, I rested my elbows on my knees and leaned forward. "Then tell me who the 'witness' is."

Sulla hesitated, looking uncomfortable. "I could—but if you kill him, this will be out of my hands. Right now, it's only been reported to

the Ascenders Association. If Central Academy or any of these highbloods get involved…”

“I won’t kill him, but I will figure out—”

I was interrupted by a device on Sulla’s desk lighting up and beginning to hum softly.

He stared at it like it was a demon leech for several seconds, then reached out and touched it.

A familiar voice boomed out of the device: “This is Corbett of Highblood Denoir, contacting Sulla of Blood Drusus. Sulla?”

The dark-haired ascender’s eyes went wide at the mention of Corbett’s name, and he looked at me with something akin to panic. “Y-yes, Highlord Denoir, this is—”

“You’ve just apprehended a Central Academy professor named Grey. The foolish charges against him are false, and I have information that will help to prove it.” Corbett’s voice echoed with a slight distortion from the communication artifact, but it still effectively conveyed the weight of his authority. “I demand he be released immediately.”

I couldn’t help the surprised smirk that crept onto my face listening to the highlord speak. Though he maintained a noble air, there was a subtle threat to his words as well.

Did Caera put him up to this? I asked myself. *Or did our conversation make more of an impression than I thought…*

Sulla quickly regained his composure. Although the Denoirs must have outranked Blood Drusus by several times over, he didn’t seem like a man to be cowed by the nobility. “You say you have information pertinent to this investigation?” he asked, his tone all business.

“The Granbehls are behind it,” Corbett said firmly. “They’ve made false claims against Grey before, and they are at it again. I believe a thorough interrogation of Janusz of Blood Graeme, currently a professor at Center Academy, will reveal that he was paid—and very well—to deliver false evidence against Grey. Now, confirm that Grey will be released immediately, or I will be forced to personally visit the Ascenders Association.”

Sulla glowered at the communication artifact, his face reddening slightly. “There will be no need for that, Highlord Denoir. I am equally assured of Grey’s innocence, and will not be charging him. He is here with me now, as a matter of fact, to discuss how best to deal with this situation.”

“Oh,” Corbett said, his noble mannerisms slipping for just an instant. “Very well then. I’ve heard good things about your fairness and wisdom, and it seems these rumors are not unfounded. Grey, meet me at Goldberry’s Throne on High Street in two hours. Good day then.”

“Good day, Highlord…” Sulla said, his expression caught somewhere between frustration and relief.

When the artifact dimmed, his attention turned back to me. “So, you really do have friends in high places…”

“A recent acquaintance,” I said with a shrug. “So, Professor Graeme…”

Sulla winced. “Like I said—”

“Oh, don’t worry. I won’t kill him.” Standing, I gave him a questioning look. “Am I free to leave?”

“For the moment, yes,” he said with a humorless smile. “But this situation will need to be dealt with, Grey.”
I nodded, a certain drunk uncle coming to mind. "Then could you get in contact with someone for me?"

Two hours later, I was walking briskly along High Street, home to many ostentatious businesses that catered to the highbloods.
Various scenarios whirled in my mind like clips from different movies as I thought about what I had learned. If what Professor Graeme had so kindly informed me was true, then it changed everything.
My thoughts were interrupted as I was forced to step out of the way for a pair of young highbloods walking side by side down the middle of the path, but before I could spare them a second thought, I was brought up short by the sight of the place I was supposed to be meeting Corbett, a highblood cafe named Goldberry’s Throne.
The building looked more like a temple than a cafe. Gold-capped marble pillars wrapped around an open-air gallery at the front of the building and around one side, and the carved entablatures that rested atop the pillars gleamed with inlaid gold and a dozen colors of gemstones, making the roof glitter like a crown. Multi-colored flames rose from ever-burning braziers affixed to the pillars, giving the place a distinct mystical quality and giving off a mixture of sweet scents that made my mouth water and stomach rumble.
Several sets of eyes followed me as I entered the cafe, likely because my attire was not up to the standards at Goldberry’s. Inside, the warm aroma of coffee and freshly baked bread mixed with a dozen

different colognes and perfumes to make the air uncomfortably heavy.

A matronly woman dressed in black with a maroon vest was working behind a short bar carved of some kind of opaque crystal. She dipped at her waist into a respectful bow as I approached, her expression flawlessly masked aside from the quick twitch of her eyes as she scanned me from head to toe.

"I'm here to meet Highlord Denoir," I said, feeling the attention of a handful of the cafe's patrons turn in my direction. "Has he arrived yet?"

The woman motioned to her right, her gaze still lowered. "Highlord Denoir's private room is located around the corner there, third door."

I nodded and turned my back on her, just catching it as the patrons—many of whom had been staring at my back only a second before—looked away and pretended to mind their own business.

The indicated door was cracked, and swung slowly open when I knocked lightly on it. Corbett looked up from a leatherbound journal full of cramped writing. "Close the door behind you," he said as he stashed the journal.

I did, and a series of wards that ran along the edge of the door lit up briefly. "Sound proofing?" I mused aloud.

"Among other things. Goldberry's is not successful with the highbloods simply for the pretentious decor," he said, gesturing to a seat across from him.

The room wasn't large, but it's high ceiling gave it a sense of grandeur. A low table made of some dark wood and engraved with a

realistic depiction of the Basilisk Fang Mountains took up the center, with a wraparound couch on one side and two lounge chairs on the other. I sat in one of these, sinking into the soft cushioning.

A low fire burned in a small fireplace in the corner behind me, and a window let in diffused light behind Corbett. I frowned at the window, unsure why it seemed so out of place, then realized there couldn't be a window in this room, which was in the center of the cafe with no outside-facing walls. Looking more closely, I realized it was a pane-shaped light artifact that acted as a faux window.

"Nice place," I commented.

"Good for thinking, or having a conversation that should not be overheard," he said meaningfully. "Were you able to locate Professor Graeme?"

"Graeme is still alive, though I can't say the same for his dignity," I answered nonchalantly. "But that's beside the point."

The highlord nodded. "I figured as much, which is why I wished for us to meet here."

"I need to know what kind of retaliation I can get away with," I said without preamble. "What kind of trouble could I be in if I go after the Granbehls?"

He eyed me critically, clearly weighing his words. "Well, if you were a highblood—or even a named blood equal to the Granbehls in stature—you would be entirely within your right to strike back." He put on a knowing smile. "But as an unblooded, you are without recourse outside of the court, and you already know well how *just* the halls of justice truly are."

A 'feature' implemented by highbloods like yourself, I wanted to say.

“The Granbehls understand and manipulate the system like a true highblood,” he continued. “They have launched an all-out assault on several rival named bloods, but so far have not crossed any lines that would see them stripped of their titles or executed—at least not in broad daylight. Their enemies seem to die under suspicious and convenient circumstances, including a recent fire that killed both the lord and lady of Named Blood Rothkeller.”

“Why do you think these rivals haven’t struck back?”

Corbett tapped the side of his nose. “That is the question, isn’t it? But not every question comes with an answer. In this case, I have only speculation based on rumor. However, it appears that they have somehow acquired the patronage of a powerful benefactor, someone whose protection has allowed them to maneuver more or less uninhibited.”

When a person like Corbett Denoir called someone powerful, it really shortened the list of suspects. Only another ranking highblood could offer that kind of protection—or even someone above the normal constructs of Alacryan society, like a Scythe.

“That doesn’t change what I need to do,” I replied, my expression hidden from Corbett.

“Do you have some plan in mind, then?” he asked. His hand moved to the couch cushion beside him, and I noticed a velvet bag that was half hidden in his shadow.

My lips twitched. “Yes, but it’s not very subtle.”

“I thought as much,” he said, lifting the bag and reaching inside it. He pulled out a metal emblem and set it on the table between us.

The black metal was stained, and when I bent down over it I realized it had been scorched by fire. The emblem itself appeared to be a grapevine set before a rising sun, once brightly colored but now blackened and robbed of the small details.

"Named Blood Rothkeller?" I asked.

Corbett nodded. "If one of the few remaining members of that blood sought retribution for the burning of their estate—"

"No one would bat an eye," I finished, lifting the emblem and turning it over in my hand. With my thumb, I rubbed the soot off the sun, revealing a cracked and faded red coloring. "Would the Rothkeller blood be likely to deny it?"

Corbetts eyes gleamed with cold calculation. "If their emblem was planted like a flag of victory in the wreckage of their enemy's estate? What would you do in their place?"

"Fair point," I conceded before putting the emblem back down on the table. "My only question is why are you willing to do all of this for me?"

They gained nothing from helping me aside from my own compliance in the future, but if things went poorly with the Denoirs, I couldn't exactly kill them all, considering their relation to Caera. Allowing Corbett to have such a dangerous secret was certainly a problem, but with no proof, it would only be his word against mine.

"Curiosity? Intrigue?" Corbett mused. "You're a man with many layers, Grey. And these circumstances allow me to uncover some of them."

"Well, whatever I choose to do, I wouldn't have been able to do it without your help," I said, holding the emblem like I was making a

toast. “So here’s to a lasting bond built from mutually assured destruction, Corbett.”

The highlord sat up a little straighter, but a smile slipped through his guarded demeanor. “Of course. After all, there is still this mysterious benefactor to be concerned about.”

My thoughts cycled through everything Professor Graeme had told me yet again, but I didn’t confirm anything else with Corbett. Instead, I asked, “Is it possible whoever is backing the Granbehls would go after the remaining Rothkellers?”

He nodded, his expression unchanged. “Entirely, but even if they die, they would do so with pride knowing that their blood has been avenged. You offer their blood redemption, while avoiding any personal entanglement, legal or otherwise.”

I didn’t agree with the highblood view on pride over life, but empathizing wasn’t hard. In the face of gods as rulers, sometimes, pride was the only thing left in their control.

With a plan in place and all of the pieces in my head now coming together, I bid him farewell and made my way out onto High Street.

A frigid smile tugged at the corners of my lips as I stretched my neck.

Regis, get back here. It’s time for a little reunion with the Granbehls.

366
UNMERCIFUL PROMISE

TITUS GRANBEHL

"Oh, I nearly forgot to mention," my wife said from across the dinner table. Smiling happily, she set down the skewered chunk of pink meat she had been about to bite into. "The Vale blood has agreed to our terms. A messenger arrived only an hour ago with their letter."

I finished chewing and reached down with my fork and knife to cut another piece. "Yes, I thought seeing what happened to the Rothkeller blood might set a fire under the Vales…"

Karin's cool eyes darted to Ada, but the girl was paying us no mind as she stirred her food around her plate mindlessly.

"Anyway," Karin continued, her eyes widening slightly as if to remind me, like I would need a reminder of our agreement.

My grip tightened around my utensils as I sawed deeper into the scorched white-tailed sambar. *Ada is too frail, too weak to suffer the knowledge of our actions.*

I thought of Kalon and Ezra. My eldest was too proud and self-righteous to have understood what we did now, but had he survived, perhaps such extreme actions wouldn't have been necessary. Ezra though, he was the child who most took after me.

With my appetite leaving me, I pushed my unfinished plate away.

If only Ezra had survived instead, I thought bitterly, casting a dour glance at my scarecrow of a daughter.

"And I've sent out feelers to some likely highblood candidates regarding our proposal," she went on. As she spoke, she reached

over and began to cut up Ada's food, even lifting bites to the girl's mouth.

"Karin, let the girl feed herself, she's—"

She shot me a fierce glare, and I relented, biting back my words.

Her and her obsessive doting.

I watched as Karin spoon-fed my daughter like she had no arms, yet I said no more. As difficult it was to admit, much of what we had accomplished in this short time would have been impossible without my wife.

She was cunning, charismatic, and ruthless. But she was also a mother that had lost two of her children. With Kalon and Ezra gone, Ada had become the woman's entire world. While that had pushed her to lengths I would not previously have imagined possible, in her mind, it was all done for Ada.

"Titus, are you listening?"

"Of course," I said, searching my memory for her half-heard words. "Highbloods Lowe and Arbital. Both fine candidates for Ada."

I pushed away from the table and a servant rushed in to collect my dishes and utensils. "I'm going to make my rounds, then perhaps we can retire together?"

A knowing smile played at the edge of my wife's lips. "Of course, Lord Granbehl."

"It'll be *Highlord* soon," I said before marching out of the dining room and making my way outside.

There was a salty sweetness to the warm breeze blowing from the west, from the sea. When the winds turned, they would bring bitter cold down from the distant mountains. *And yet whichever way the*

wind blows, it is always at our backs. Even our defeats turn into victory.

My failure to secure Ascender Grey's holdings had been a dangerous time for Named Blood Granbehl. When the justices we'd bribed were executed in their cells, I had worried we might soon meet the same fate. With my heir deceased, our entire blood rested on a sword's edge, and any wrong move could spell our end. But fate, as it turned out, was kind.

At least to us.

The sun was just setting as I began my evening rounds to review the estate's enhanced security. We had turned many rivals into bitter enemies, and in a rather short amount of time. Although they had so far been too cowardly to attack us directly—thanks in large part to the rumor of our benefactor's involvement—I had thoroughly prepared for such an eventuality anyway.

Despite my good mood, I affixed a thunderous scowl to my face as I marched slowly past each group of mercenaries, guards, and ascenders I'd hired as security for our Vechor estate. They had to fear me if I expected them to stay in line, after all.

As I passed by the main gates, my head of guards came out of the gatehouse and snapped to attention. "Lord Granbehl."

"At ease, Henrik."

The man bowed, then pulled a rolled parchment from the satchel at his side. "This arrived for you only a few minutes ago."

I suppressed a victorious grin as I held up the rolled parchment, which was marked with the Central Academy seal. "Perfect. The grounds look in order, Henrik."

The man—loyal to a fault and dumb as two rocks, but good with the other guards—bowed again and returned to his post.

I, on the other hand, hurried inside, eager to read Professor Graeme's report. I came up short when I noticed Petras lingering in the entryway. He flinched back at the sight of me.

My lips curled into a sneer. "What are you doing up here? Stop lurking and return to your dungeon."

Petral bowed deeply, his dark hair tumbling over his face like a greasy waterfall. "My apologies, Lord. I wished to tell you that the last of the prisoners has…expired, and the body has been taken away. The dungeons are empty, and—"

"Report received," I said, making a shooing motion with my hand. "Now leave me. You're spoiling a rather long-awaited victory."

The torturer slunk back into the shadows and vanished down the servants' stairs, leaving behind a strong scent of oil. Shaking my head, I returned my attention to the scroll, ripping open the seal and unfurling it, a boyish grin spreading over my face.

My grin darkened and I gnashed my teeth in frustration at the hastily-scribbled words in the letter. The fine parchment crumpled in my fist as I slammed it into the wall.

"Incompetent fool. Perhaps I placed too much trust in Janusz for being a highblood."

With our mutual distaste for Ascender Grey, it seemed obvious at the time to use Janusz, but that sorry excuse for a highblood couldn't even keep Grey detained by the Ascenders Association for a day.

My thoughts carefully skirted around my benefactor, who had left the details of this part of the plan entirely up to me. If I failed to deliver…

"Father?" I spun at the sound of Ada's voice. "Is everything all right? You were muttering to yourself."

Giving her a false smile, I quickly replied, "Nothing to worry about. Why aren't you in your rooms? Study, and then go to bed. You know you need your rest."

The girl's simple, defeated shrug was so pathetic—I didn't know whether to hug her or slap her across the face. With a heavy sigh, I placed a hand on her small shoulder. "Ada, it's time to move past this. You've moped long enough. Now stand up straight and—"

I cocked my head, listening carefully. It had almost sounded like a—

Shouts from outside. A burst of spellfire.

A red glow radiated through the front windows, staining the foyer walls and floor a bloody scarlet. A heartbeat later, the warning bells began to ring.

"Ada, go down to the basement," I said, not looking at my daughter. She whimpered, hesitating, so I snapped, "Vritra's Horns, girl, now!"

I heard her quick steps recede, vanishing down the servants' stairs the same way Petras had gone, but I wasn't thinking about her any longer. Faltering steps took me to one of the front windows, where I confirmed that the estate's shield had been activated, creating a red dome that covered my entire property.

The courtyard flashed with spells as bullets of fire, arcing bolts of lightning, and spears of ice cut through the early evening gloom. All I could see of their target was a shadow that seemed to flicker within

a shroud of purple electricity, appearing and disappearing more quickly than I could follow.

"A rival house?" I muttered, my knuckles grinding down into the windowsill. "But who would dare…?"

My thoughts leapt unbidden to our benefactor, the source of our recent successes…but surely it could not be him. He could not know about our misstep with Grey yet, and even if he did, we had time to correct the mistake, there was no need to—

I froze as a cold sweat began to pour down my face.

Grey…

I crushed the letter in my hand before tossing it to the floor. My face was nearly pressed against the glass as I looked for any sign that I was right.

A bestial form shrouded in purple flames rushed past the window, causing me to gasp and step quickly back.

Men were screaming all around the estate. Screaming and dying.

The front doors—warded to magically lock when the estate's shielding barrier activated—shook under the weight of a heavy blow.

A muffled voice was shouting and cursing incoherently—Henrik, I realized, though I'd never heard such panic in his gravelly voice before—then cut off abruptly as a purple blade of pure light thrust through the door with the cracking shriek of splintering hardwood.

I stared at the blade protruding into my home, not ten feet from me. It was like nothing I had seen before, like liquid crystal amethyst folded over on itself. The color shifted subtly but continuously, growing darker and more deeply purple, then brighter and more

violent. For a heartbeat, I became lost in the otherworldly depths of that blade.

Then it vanished. Blood began to run in a thin stream from the hole in the door.

I backed away slowly, already picturing what was about to happen. The wards shouldn't allow it, but I knew they wouldn't hold.

The warded doors exploded inward, sending a shrapnel of sharp shards of wood and twisted black iron spraying across the entry hall. A shield of bright blue fire roared to life in front of me, evaporating both wood and metal, and I heard the hurried footsteps of more guards running from the interior of the house.

Through the distortion of the blue fire, I could see only a rough silhouette standing where my door had been, Henrik's corpse at his feet.

"Get me out of here," I snarled to the guards approaching from behind me. "And kill that unblooded cur!"

A firm hand grabbed my shoulder and began pulling me away, the fire-shield moving with us. Two heavily-armored Strikers thudded past me, weapons blazing and magical energy suffusing their armor. A spinning wheel of wind and flame cut the air between them, aimed at the intruder, but he was no longer there.

A choking gasp made me spin around. The Caster, one of my elite guards, was already tumbling to the ground, his body bisected at the waist. His legs crumpled to the floor while his torso fell backwards, a look of a surprise etched on his already-dead face.

A dark silhouette flickered next to us, lashing out at my protector. The Shield hurtled backwards with a screech, too quickly to adjust

his spellcasting. His scream cut off as his own blue fire burned away the air in his lungs, and what hit the wall was no longer recognizable as a man.

Both Strikers were staring around in confusion, trying to find their attacker, their weapons ready but useless when he appeared between them, the bright purple blade blurring in the air as it passed through their weapons, armor, flesh, and bones like they were made of silk.

Both men collapsed, dead.

The lingering aspect of the fire shield faded away as the Shield choked out one last, rasping breath.

Grey simply stood there, staring at me, the red barrier defending my estate flickering pointlessly in the background.

My fists clenched, my body shaking—not with fear, I told myself, but fury.

"Y-you overstep," I said, my voice cracking. "The Granbehls are protected. We are being"—I swallowed heavily, my mouth suddenly very dry—"elevated. You have no station, no authority, while we are protected by a Scythe. Do you understand? You'll die for this. You'll—"

"You were told what would happen if you came after me again," he said, his voice devoid of emotion.

I flinched back as a creature—a huge wolf wreathed in black and purple flames—appeared in the doorway, stepping up beside him. "The backside is all clear."

Trying to bolster my courage, I stood straighter and cleared my throat. “I am under the protection of Scythe Nico of Central Dominion. You dare attack me? He’ll—”

Grey took a step forward, and I backed away so quickly I nearly tripped over the dead Caster’s outstretched arm.

“He’ll come after me,” he finished. “I know.”

The blade blazed in his hand, and his summoned wolf growled low in its throat.

“No!”

The yell had come from the top of the stairs.

“Karin!” I shouted, time seeming to stop as I stared wide-eyed up at my wife. Her hair was wet and she was wrapped only in a sheer gown that clung to her body. She must have been in the bath, I realized distantly, my mind rushing to process information while my body remained frozen in place.

She should have run, escaped out one of the back entrances or down into the dungeon to hide, but instead she had come running to defend our blood’s home. And unlike me, she hadn’t frozen. Her hands came up and I sensed the swell of mana from her as wind began to dance between them.

Damn it, woman, you need to—

The wind spell blew through the room like a hurricane, tearing portraits and tapestries from the walls and upending furniture. White cords of wind condensed around the ascender to form an ensnaring web, trapping him. I wished again that she would flee, but Karin tightened the web, clamping down on Grey and pummeling

him from several dozen different directions with her powerful emblem.

I'd seen mages pulled apart by this spell as the gusts ripped and tore at them from every direction. My wife preferred to suppress her power in public, but she had never been shy about getting her hands dirty if it meant assuring the future of our blood. I would have felt a swell of pride in her spellwork, had Grey not simply stood there, the emblem-level Wind Web spell doing nothing more than mussing his hair…

"No, Karin you—"

My words caught in my throat as I turned and met my wife's eyes, already glossy with death. Behind her was Grey, his violet blade sheathed in Karin's blood.

I opened my mouth, trying to say something—say anything—but I could only stare like a fish gulping for air as the light left my wife's eyes.

Then the spell was broken as her lifeless body tumbled forward, rolling grotesquely down the stairs to land at my feet.

I fell to my knees next to her, dragging her limp form up into my lap. My body was trembling, even the breath in my lungs seemed to shake, and I could do nothing but stare down at Karin's corpse as the debris of her dying spell clattered to the ground around me.

Heavy, awkward bootsteps broke the silence, and I saw Petras appear from the servants' stairwell. Grey was standing at the top of the stairs, his distant gaze emotionless, unreadable.

"Petras, kill him," I choked out around an icy fist of raw emotion that seemed to be crushing my throat.

Grey started down the stairs, his brow raised in Petras's direction. "It's been a while, old friend."

Petras, the gangly weasel, dropped his curved blade to clatter on the ground. He turned his back on me—on me!—and stole out through one of the many doors off the entry hall without a word.

"Bastard," I muttered. To Grey, with as much venom as I could muster, I said, "Why couldn't you just die?" I shuddered as a cold emptiness suffused me. "I thought, when Scythe Nico contacted us…" My fist slammed into the floor, and I felt the knuckle bones break. "It should have been easy." I glared up at my killer. "So why couldn't you just fucking *die*?"

Grey approached wordlessly, a thunderous pressure exuding from him.

I spit on the floor. "Do you think you can get away with this? You are the reason my sons are dead. You—"

The man scoffed as he slowly descended the stairs. The wolf was stalking toward me from the door, its mouth hanging open, a dark hunger gleaming in its bright eyes.

"Even now, you try to use your family to justify your greed."

"Who are you to assume my reasons?" I hissed, clutching my wife's cold body tighter. "You are no god to know that, nor do you have any authority to judge me!"

The ascender walked toward me, unhurried as tendrils of violet condensed to form a shimmering blade. "You're right, Granbehl. I'm no god, and I'm not a judge, either. I'm just here to keep my promise."

Primal fear coursed through me like poison in my veins, but I refused to show this bastard any semblance of weakness. I jutted out my chin and chest so that the Granbehl insignia emblazoned on my collar would stare right back at the unblooded. "Go to hell—"

I heard rather than felt the violet blade slide into my chest. Raw coldness spread through me, seeping through every inch of my body as I slumped forward. The ground caught me as I stared up past my killer and at my home.

Everything that we had worked for to rise above everyone else—to become a highblood—had been for naught. Only Ada would remain as my legacy, the weakest of the Granbehls, a poor eulogy by which we would be remembered.

My thoughts blurred, losing all shape and form.

Then, the world went dark.

ARTHUR

The aetheric sword melted away as I released my hold on its form. Lord and Lady Granbehl lay at my feet, their corpses intertwined.

"Well, that's done," Regis sniffed, looking down at Titus Granbehl's corpse before turning to me. "So…you want to grab some shawarma on the way back?"

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath; the smell of scorched flesh hung heavy in the air. "Neither of us need to eat, and I'm pretty sure that dish doesn't exist in this world."

Regis opened his mouth, paused, then slowly lowered his head. "I mean, yeah, sure, I guess you're *technically* right, but it seems appropriate." He wrinkled his nose. "Or maybe the smell is just making me hungry."

“Regis,” I said slowly, “these are the kinds of thoughts you really should keep to yourself.”

The sound of soft steps echoed nearby, drawing my eyes to a narrow alcove in one wall. The familiar young girl who crept out of the servants’ stairwell was even thinner and paler than the last time we had met.

“Hello, Ada.”

Ada wiped a hand down her face, smearing dirt through half-dried tears. “You killed them.” The words weren’t an accusation, merely a statement. “I knew you would.”

“Maybe if your father had known…” I stepped away from her parents’ corpses. “It wouldn’t have come to this.”

She was so silent and pale, she could have been a ghost.

I thought about just leaving, not wanting to burden the poor girl further, but I needed her. “Ada?”

“Hm?” she mumbled, looking past me at the bodies. Although she stared, she made no move to come closer.

I withdrew the Rothkeller emblem. Using a decorative spike protruding from the bottom, I drove the emblem into the banister of the main stairs leading up to the second floor, where it stuck up like a flag of victory.

Ada flinched from the noise, but made no other movement.

“People are going to see this and assume the Rothkeller blood took retribution on your family. Do you understand?”

She took a few tentative steps around so she could see the scorched symbol of her family’s rivals. “I’ll tell everyone I didn’t see anything—”

I shook my head. “No, not everyone.”
Ada tilted her head in confusion.
“You’re going to tell the Scythe that will come find you the truth…”
My eyes watched her for signs of understanding. “And that I’ll be waiting for him at the Victoriad.”

It was an abrupt transition between the second layer of the Relictombs and Darrin Ordin’s country estate in Sehz-Clar. It was still warm in the south of Alacrya, far from the mountains, and a sweet-smelling breeze was tumbling lightly across the rolling hills and rustling the low shrubs in Darrin’s front yard.
From Vechor, I had entered the Relictombs via the local Ascenders Association Hall, then used one of the second level tempus warp chambers to get to Darrin’s, where Sulla had told me my “drunk uncle” would be waiting.
We found Alaric sitting on a bench near the front door, staring down the path. Due to the delay between my appearance and his reaction, which was to belch loudly and lean back on his elbows, sticking his paunchy belly out in front of him, I assumed he was somewhat intoxicated.
‘You know, I’ve missed this old coot,’ Regis said happily.
“So,” Alaric said as I reached him, “I hear you’re once again in need of legal counsel.”
“Not exactly,” I said, sitting on the bench beside him. “What do you already know?”

“I know you’re in trouble,” he said with a scoff. “And that, as usual, you’ve bitten off twice what you can chew.” He peered at me with unsteady eyes. “The Granbehls tried to finish the job, but you finished them instead, aye?”

I filled him in on exactly what happened, but I left one important piece of information for last. “They were backed by a Scythe. Nico, of the central dominion.”

Alaric’s permanently bloodshot eyes went wide, and he heaved himself to his feet and stared disbelievingly down at me. “Sovereign’s sack, boy, why in the hell are we just sitting around talking? The professor identity is right and truly buggered then, and your connection to Darrin and myself compromises most of my usual contacts…”

He began to pace rapidly back and forth, careless as he stepped on one of Darrin’s carefully tended plants. He was speaking rapidly in a low mutter that I couldn’t follow. Instead of stressing him further by interrupting him, I let the old man go on like this for a minute.

‘I think you just knocked the buzz out of the poor drunk,’ Regis noted, a hint of concern in his voice.

Alaric stopped suddenly and glared down at me. “How the hell did you get on the wrong side of a Scythe anyway?”

“We’ve got history,” I said, deadpan. “As for why he’s out to get me now…”

Alaric shook his head and sat back down, resting his head in his hands as though he were utterly exhausted. Voice muffled, he said, “It doesn’t matter, boy. It doesn’t matter *how* you’ve managed to get a Scythe on your ass, only that you *have.*”

“Whatever got you into this,” he said after a minute, “it won’t be easy to go into hiding. Not with so much power sniffing around behind you.”

“That’s fine,” I said, leaning back as well, “because I won’t be hiding. I’m here to secure a couple contingencies in case I might need to escape Vechor.”

“Vechor…? You don’t mean to—”

“I’m still attending the Victoriad,” I answered firmly.

He looked at me with a wry grin. “Now, I know you’re joking, because only a moron would think of doing a thing like that.” His eyes narrowed. “You’re not kidding. You moron. What the hell are you thinking?”

I leaned back, putting my hands behind my head and crossing my legs as I stared up at the blue sky.

“I’m thinking of killing a Scythe.”

367
THE VICTORIAD

SETH MILVIEW

It was freezing! The winds had turned, bringing icy mountain air down to Cargidan and giving us a chilly sendoff as we prepared to leave.

My breath frosted in front of me, rising and intermingling with the icy fog around us. I pursed my lips and blew out, watching it rise up and vanish.

It was such a small and stupid thing to do, but even being capable of this meant so much to me. Just a few years ago, a few cold breaths while playing with Circe—the two of us pretending to be dragons billowing fire instead of steam—was enough to get me bedridden.

I forced my lips to smile, tricking myself into thinking of these memories as happy ones, before turning my attention back to the scene around me.

It was early in the morning on the first day of the Victoriad, and we were all lined up outside of the tempus warp chamber, a small octagonal building at the heart of campus. A lot of other students, both those who would be competing in other events and those who had come to wish us good luck, hung around the courtyard, huddled into groups and wrapped in heavy cloaks. I even noticed a few who had dragged their bed blankets out here to stay warm.

There were a lot of students going to Vechor, too many to use the tempus warp at once, and our class was last in line to be teleported. Inside, Professor Abby of the Redcliff blood was in charge of teleporting each class in turn.

I looked around and noticed a figure hurrying through the crowd. The person was bound up in a furry parka with a hood so deep and padded that it completely hid their face. They got in line behind us and adjusted the hood slightly.

"Oh, hey Laurel," Mayla said, giving the other girl a cheery wave. "Chilly, isn't it?"

Laurel peeked out through the fur lining of the hood and her eyes squinted around in an apologetic smile until she found Professor Grey, who was standing off to the side with the two assistants. Her voice was slightly muffled as she said, "S-sorry, Professor. I had to find my coat. I h-hate the cold…"

"Now that we're all here"—the professor dismissed Laurel with a wave—"I have a couple of things you each need to have."

"Oh, presents!" Laurel said, bouncing on the balls of her feet.

"Not exactly," Professor Grey answered as he withdrew a bundle of items from his dimension ring and split them with Assistant Aphene and Assistant Briar.

Each student received two items. The first was a cloak made of velvet in the azure and black of Central Academy. The second was a white half-mask that covered my face from my hairline down to below my nose. A pattern of dark blue lines was painted over it, sharp and angular like runes, although more artsy. Small horns protruded from the top of each mask.

Mayla held hers up to her face. It was identical to mine except for the patterns, which were more natural and smooth, like gusts of wind or flowing waves. She stuck out her tongue and made a silly growling noise.

“I shouldn’t have to remind you,” Briar said disapprovingly, her focus on Mayla, “that Sovereign Kiros Vritra will be in attendance at the Victoriad. Since this is likely a first for all of us—being in the presence of a Sovereign—you need to understand a few things.

“While these items identify us as representatives of Central Academy, the mask in particular should be worn whenever you are within sight of Sovereign Kiros Vritra—which, for us, means at *all times*. Our behavior at the Victoriad represents not only the Academy, but, since we are from Central Dominion, the High Sovereign himself.

“Your victories are not *yours*, but his. You do not do this for your own glory, but for the High Sovereign’s. Any insult you may make, purposeful or inadvertent—such as going without your mask or looking Sovereign Kiros in the eye, will also reflect on the High Sovereign, and will be punished severely.”

The class was quiet as the rest of the attire was handed out. Laurel took hers and left us to join Enola at the front of the line.

Marcus, who was standing just in front of us, was staring down at his own mask with a strange, kind of distant expression. His fingers traced along the heavy, angular blue lines painted on it.

Mayla must have noticed his expression too. “What do you think your markings represent?”

He glanced up at her, his face tightening nervously for just a second before smoothing out into his usual at-the-ready sort of expression. “I can’t imagine the patterns are matched to us personally in any way, can you? After all, they’re to limit our personal identity before the Sovereign, not make us stand out as individuals.”

“Oh,” Mayla said, frowning. “I hadn’t really thought about it.”

Yannick, usually quiet, scooted a little closer to Marcus and leaned toward us. “The Vritra care about your utility, that is all. It is foolish to think otherwise.” He slipped on his mask—a pattern of jagged, wild cuts that looked kind of like claws—and tied it around the back of his head before moving away again.

The line began to move again as the class in front of us entered the tempus warp chamber, and the crowd broke up as people headed back to their rooms. A few people waved in the direction of our class, but I knew no one was waving at me.

I didn’t let this fact bother me, though. The truth was, even though I’d lost a lot, this season at the academy had been better than I ever could have imagined, and mostly due to Melee Enhancement Tactics. I was stronger physically than I’d ever been, even before I got an emblem. The sickness I’d lived with my entire life, which I had always expected to kill me, was almost entirely gone.

Never in my wildest dreams had I imagined I would be an emblem-bearer. Even Circe had hoped only that I wouldn’t end up an unad with a sickness likely to kill me before my twentieth birthday.

And I was good at something. Maybe I wasn’t as strong as Marcus, as fast as Yannick, or as powerful as Enola, but after training under Professor Grey, I knew I could get in the ring with *any* of them and give them a fair fight. But more than that, my classmates all showed me respect, even Valen… maybe not Remy or Portrel as much, but at least Valen kept them from beating me up anymore.

If they even could, I reminded myself, unable to suppress a silly grin.

I glanced at the professor, who had turned away from us to watch a blue-haired woman approach.

I really didn't understand him. Even though he always seemed reluctant, he taught all of us how to be passable fighters. I knew he didn't really like us, especially me. Actually, that's a pretty huge understatement. Sometimes, the way he looked at me, I thought he must *hate* me. But I had no idea why.

Mayla elbowed me sharply in the ribs. "Ooh, do you have a crush?"

I flinched and stared at her in confusion. "What?"

"You're totally staring at Lady Caera," she teased, and I realized I must have been looking at Professor Grey for a while, lost in thought. "She is awfully pretty, but she's a little old for you, isn't she?"

I opened my mouth, no idea how to respond to Mayla's teasing, but Professor Grey started speaking and I kept quiet to hear.

"You're late."

Assistant Professor Caera looked behind her, then back at him, one hand on her chest. "Excuse me? Have you already arrived in Vechor, Professor Grey? Because if not, it seems I am perfectly on time."

"Besides," Mayla murmured, leaning in toward me, "I think she's already taken."

I blushed and turned away, super uncomfortable even thinking about the stern professor's love life. I was saved from any more teasing as the line started moving again, and we were all invited into the warmth of the tempus warp chamber.

Once we were all inside, Professor Abby arranged us in a circle around the device, which was humming gently and putting off a

warm radiance. A few of the students shuffled closer, putting their hands out to warm them.

A breeze kicked up out of nowhere, and I realized that someone was casting wind magic. Mayla giggled and pointed: Professor Abby's hair was dancing lightly around her as she led Professor Grey by the arm to an open place in the circle. "I'm really looking forward to this, aren't you, Grey?" she asked, her bright voice carrying in the small chamber. "The Victoriad is so exciting, and there is so much to do! We should get a drink while we're there."

Some of the other students burst out into muffled snickers so that I couldn't hear the professor's answer.

Whatever it was, Professor Abby pouted as she moved to the anvil-like tempus warp artifact and began to activate it.

I took a deep breath to steady myself, feeling my nerves start to flare. Not so long ago, I would have come up with any reason to keep from doing this, but now…I was ready. I was *excited* even. I was going to have fun and do my best, and even if I got knocked out in the first round, it didn't matter, because I got to go to the *Victoriad*.

There was a feeling of warmth and the sudden smell of the sea.

Thousands of voices came together in a chaotic roar, and I realized we were standing on a massive stone walkway in the middle of a ring of black iron posts topped with lighting artifacts. A dozen identical platforms lined the walkway.

Before I could take even a second to look around, a man in a blood-red mask that was made to look like some kind of monstrous demon swept into the center of our group. "Welcome to Vechor and the city

of Victorious. Professor Grey of Central Academy and the Melee Enhancement Tactics class, correct?"

"Right," Professor Grey answered, not looking at the man but staring around at the streams of students in different styles and colors of masks that were moving steadily by.

"Please make your way to the staging area," the man said, pointing after the trail of students from all over Alacrya. "Staging area forty-one, on the south side of the coliseum. From there you'll be able to watch the other competitions as well as prepare for your own."

The professor thanked the man and gestured to Assistants Briar and Aphene. "Don't let anyone wander off."

Reminding me of the veteran drill sergeants I'd read about in stories, the two assistants herded us into two lines and guided us into the river of students and teachers coming from the other platforms. I was separated from Mayla and found myself walking between Valen and Enola instead.

High steps led down from the stone path and into a sea of brightly colored tents and canopies. Aside from the noise of the students and their teachers, there were also the shouts of dozens of merchants all fighting each other for attention through the chaos, the braying of mana beasts, ringing of forge hammers, and the random *pop* of distant magical explosions.

Looming over all of this was a massive coliseum. The curving walls rose high above us, casting a long shadow over the merchant stalls. From where we were, I could see a dozen different entrances, each with a long line of well-dressed Alacryans slowly filtering through. At

the closest, a large, armored mage was waving some kind of wand over each attendee before allowing them in.

"Wow, it's so… big," I said, stumbling over my tongue.

Behind me, Valen snorted. "All that reading and 'wow, it's big' is the best you can come up with?"

Enola chuckled at this, her neck craning to see the top of the coliseum walls. "Something like this… it can steal the words from any of us."

I tried to think of something witty to shoot back at Valen, but it took far too long and the moment passed.

Our line split into two, one group heading left while our class followed the right-most stream, which took us down a wide boulevard between two rows of merchant stalls. Everyone was immediately distracted by the huge variety of goods and souvenirs on display.

The entire thing seemed like a carnival, with well-dressed and masked attendees wandering everywhere while a hundred merchants and gamesmen tried to get their attention.

We all gasped when we passed by a lumbering, six-legged beast with a flat head like a boulder and pockets of glowing crystals growing all over its body. It reared its awkward head at us and let out a grinding bellow, nearly sending Linden toppling over backwards.

A mage who swallowed fire from a stick and then made it come out his ears danced alongside our group for the length of several stalls before Assistant Briar shooed him off, getting a good laugh out of the class.

Shortly after that, we were all forced to stop short as a procession of highbloods from Sehz-Clar passed ahead of us wearing dazzling battlerobes and jeweled masks. One in particular caught my eye, or rather the silver medallion that hung from his belt did.

"What does 'In blood, remembrance,' mean?" I asked to no one in particular. Something about the phrase was familiar, but I couldn't place it.

"It's worn by fools that are too stubborn to forget the last war between Vechor and Sehz-Clar," someone said under their breath.

Looking around, I saw Pascal staring at me, scowling. The right side of his face was wrinkled from a bad burn when he was younger, giving him a mean look even though he was generally a pretty nice guy.

"Oh," I said, realizing I must have read it in one of the many books on inter-dominion conflicts I'd read. "You're from Sehz-Clar, right?"

Pascal grunted and slowed down, looking at a bunch of jeweled daggers spread out on a booth next to the path. Assistant Briar was quick to snap at him to get back in line, but he was now several people back, too far away to talk to.

The winding route to the coliseum took us past clothiers and woodcarvers, blacksmiths and glassblowers, bakers and beast breeders. I couldn't help but lick my lips at the smell of roasting meat drifting away from a butcher who specialized in the flesh of exotic mana beasts.

Each new sight was something I had never seen before, and the more I saw, the more excited I was. My eyes grew wider and wider as we marched along, and I saw a hundred things I wished I could

stop and buy: quills that used sound magic to translate your voice and write down whatever you said; elixirs that sharpened your mind and made it so you could memorize large amounts of information in just a short time; a dagger that contained its own wind spell and would return to your hand when thrown…

Actually, I decided that last one probably wasn't such a great idea…

Eventually, we were directed to a separate entrance just for participants. As the many students from other schools made their way down a long slope that led into a tunnel below the coliseum itself, our group was forced to pause. A few dozen onlookers were gathered here, cheering and waving at the Victoriad competitors as we marched by.

"It's a little overwhelming, isn't it?" Enola said as she looked around and gave a little wave to several small children pressed against the short wall near the start of the descending tunnel.

"Yeah, a little," I admitted.

She turned around, her surprise obvious even behind her mask. "A little? Seth, I've trained my whole life for this moment, and I'm still terrified."

Portrel laughed, having snuck up through the line to stand next to Valen. "At least if you shit yourself, your cloak will hide the worst of it, Enola."

Everyone within earshot groaned, and a hand came out of nowhere and scuffed the back of Portrel's head, making him yelp with pain.

"Mind your manners," Professor Grey said firmly. "And keep the inane chatter to a minimum."

Portrel rubbed his head and gave a smirking Enola a sour look, but then the line began to move again and our class started descending the ramp.

More than a couple of the others cast longing glances back toward the merchants as we dipped down into the entrance tunnel, where solid stone cut out much of the noise from above. The huge structure above seemed to press down on us, making everyone go quiet.

"I'm sure there'll be time to spend your parents' money later," Professor Grey said into the heavy silence, adjusting his mask and glancing around the dim tunnel. Thick wooden doors and intersecting tunnels opened to the left and right at irregular intervals, hinting at a large underground network beneath the coliseum floor. "For now, remember what you're here for."

I stared at the professor's back as he moved to the front of our class. Here, in the middle of so many students my own level, his ability to entirely suppress his mana made him stand out even more. It was so perfect, I would've guessed he was an unad if I hadn't known better.

We all slowly wound through the coliseum underworks until another sloping path led up onto the edge of the combat field, and we all got our first look at just how massive the structure really was.

According to The Wonders of Vechor, Volume Two by the historian and ascender Tovorin of Highblood Karsten, the oval combat field was six hundred feet long and five hundred feet across, capable of seating fifty thousand people in the open-air seats and with fifty private viewing boxes.

Still, the book didn't even come close to doing the place justice. There was no way the numbers could express how truly *enormous* the Victorious coliseum was.

Tens of thousands of spectators had already taken their seats, blurring into a sea of color as each blood displayed their own emblems as well as masks that represented their dominions and Sovereigns. A few cheered at our appearance, but most of the crowd seemed oblivious to our presence.

Many of the younger named and highblood men and women in the audience were sending up bursts of magic to create sparks of lightning or bolts of colorful flame that exploded in midair. Under this display, several dozen warriors and mages were already on the combat field, training and preparing for the upcoming tournaments, and their shouting and spellwork added to the cacophony and gave the impression of a huge battle.

The tunnel entrance had come up in front of staging area thirty-nine, and once again the groups of students broke left or right. We found the section labeled forty-one easily, and Assistant Briar led the way into what was part private viewing chamber, part training room.

"This is so *cool*," Remy gushed, receiving a round of agreement from several others as everyone stared around.

Dark-stained walls separated each staging area from the next one, while the rear wall was made of stone with a single door that opened into a bunch of tunnels that led up into the stands. The front, facing the combat field, was open, although a series of portal emitters generated a shield that would keep anyone inside safe from the magical battles happening just outside.

The room itself was spacious enough for five times as many students as there were in our class, but none of us complained as we spread out and eagerly began to explore.

"Normally we'd have to share a staging area with the entire delegation from Central Academy," Valen was explaining to Sloane, "but I saw the rest of the students from our school being led in the opposite direction. My grandfather's doing, I'm sure, giving us a private space."

The rest of the class settled in, but I was drawn to the front of the staging area so I could look out onto the combat field. It was nearly all set up, and the first events would begin in only a couple of hours, including ours.

I rested my hands on the balcony, suddenly finding myself wishing Circe was here to see this with me.

Everything my sister had done, she had done for me. She went to war for me. She died for me. But she'd never be able to see the results of her efforts. *The war, won. Her brother, completely healed.*

If Circe hadn't done these things, she would have been alive. Mother and Father might have been alive. But I wouldn't, at least, not in any way that mattered.

I wouldn't be *here.*

Letting out a sigh, I looked dumbly into the distance, staring at the combat field without truly seeing it.

I liked to think that Mother and Father were with Circe now somewhere in the beyond, waiting for me to join them someday.

My thoughts wandered to maybe one day traveling to Dicathen myself. Afterall, if I could do *this,* then I could do just about anything.

I could make her a tombstone…no, a statue! There would be—

I grimaced, my mood souring. *Assuming we don't all get ground to dust between the Vritra and the asuras.*

"Don't tell me you're already feeling sick," Professor Grey said, appearing beside me.

I flinched, stumbled over my reply, then finally said, "N-no sir, not sick. Just…" I trailed off, swallowing down the urge to tell him everything I was feeling, knowing without a doubt that he didn't want to hear any of it. "I'm fine, sir." Then, as if some outside force had suddenly taken control of my mouth, I blurted out, "What if I'm not good enough?"

Professor Grey watched me for a few seconds, his face impassive. "Good enough for who? The crowd of pompous highbloods? Your classmates?" He lifted one eyebrow. "Yourself?"

"I…" Whatever I'd been about to say, the thought died on my lips. I didn't know how to answer him. *To make her sacrifice worthwhile*, I thought, but couldn't bring myself to say it out loud, because I wasn't sure it was even true.

A horn blared, making me jump. The combat field was empty. Four huge fireballs flew into the air and exploded, sending multi-colored sparks showering down across the coliseum.

"It's starting!" someone shouted, and the rest of the class crowded up to the front around me and the professor.

There was a low rumbling noise, so deep I felt it more than heard it, and a huge ramp in the center of the arena began to lower. Four guards appeared, marching up the ramps into the sunlight and dragging heavy chains behind them. Attached to the other end of

the chains, by manacles at their wrists and ankles, were a crowd of people.

The prisoners were dressed in loincloths and chest wraps, their bodies painted with runes. Some marched up the ramp, but others were practically dragged. Many had roughly shorn hair that had been shaved at the sides to show off pointed ears, while others were shorter and stouter…

Just like the elves and dwarves of Dicathen.

The crowd began to boo the Dicathians, shouting out jeering insults and taunts as the guards gathered the prisoners into a group at the very center of the combat field. The prisoners huddled there, staring around in obvious dread as the ramp closed behind them.

The guards hurried off the combat field and the stadium grew quiet again as everyone waited to see what was going to happen. This quiet lasted the space of a few breaths, then the grinding noise came again as two smaller ramps lowered to either side of the prisoners.

Four dark-furred beasts stalked up ramps. Each one looked like a wolf, except long-legged and with burning orange eyes. Their teeth were shaped like arrowheads and shone black in the sunlight.

"Black-fanged wolves," Deacon said. "Rated as B-class monsters on the Dicathian scale. They have fire-resistant fur and can eat rocks! Isn't that insane?"

"I don't think they'll need rocks tonight," someone else muttered.

The chains fell with a clang to the ground, magically separating from the prisoners' manacles and causing the black-fanged wolves to scurry away momentarily.

The Dicathians began to move as the stronger, healthier-looking people pushed the weaker and frailer ones into the center of the group. I didn't sense any mana or see spells being cast.

The black-fanged wolves' wariness didn't last long. Once they realized their prey was entirely defenseless…

The first of the beasts launched itself into the ring of defenders, its dark fangs closing around a man's head. The other three followed, and although the prisoners fought back, kicking and punching wildly, there was nothing they could do.

The stands exploded in noise at the bloodshed.

A sudden shiver ran down my spine and made my skin break out in goosebumps. I jerked, staring around for the source of the sharp, bitter cold aura raking at me like claws.

Professor Grey…

Standing right next to me, he seemed—just for an instant—like an entirely different person. He was as still as a statue, and his normally inexpressive face was sharp as a blade. His golden eyes, dark and ruthless, gazed down at the combat field with such ferocity that it burned even to me.

Only Lady Caera seemed to have noticed. When she reached out and curled her fingers around his wrist, I flinched away, instinctively afraid that the killing intent I felt would lash out at her.

Then the spell was broken, and I was left with an empty feeling, like someone had scooped out my insides with a frozen shovel.

Why did seeing the Dicathians make him so distraught?

Did his family die over there too? I wanted to ask.

Before I could work up the courage to say anything at all, an even more overwhelming presence settled over the staging area. I immediately felt like I was back in the training room, the increased gravity crushing me into the ground.

Brion and Linden both kneeled immediately and pressed their faces to the floor while the rest of the class looked around in bewilderment, the "battle" outside completely forgotten.

As one, we turned to face the figure that had just appeared in our staging area. Laurel let out a whimper and fell to her knees, and soon the rest of the students had followed suit. I realized with a stabbing panic that only Professor Grey, Lady Caera, and I were still on our feet, but my legs were locked straight, and I couldn't move.

She met my eyes, held me there, and I felt like I was sitting in the palm of her hand as she inspected me. I tried again to kneel, but couldn't look away from her face, the only one in the room not covered by a mask.

Purple paint flecked with gold stained her lips, and her cheeks glowed with silver stardust. Dusky pearl hair rose up in braids and curls atop her head, resting between two narrow, spiraling horns. She wore a battle dress crafted from scales that glittered like black diamonds and a fur-lined cloak that was so dark it seemed to absorb the light.

I wanted to look away, to close my eyes, to do *anything*. But I couldn't.

Then a heavy hand was on my shoulder, forcing me out of my stupor. I let myself fall, dropping immediately to my knees with a grunt of pain.

“Scythe Seris,” Professor Grey said from above me. “How nice to see you again.”

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THE VICTORIAD II

ARTHUR

Clamping down on my emotions with a cold iron grip, I refused to let myself be overtaken by rage at the sight of mana beasts ripping apart unarmed and magicless people… my people.

My stomach turned at the sight while the rest of me wanted nothing more than to God Step onto the field and kill the beasts.

The power to defy reality in my grasp, yet I couldn't even save those people.

I reasoned that restraining myself now was for the greater good, that it was the price we all had to pay for losing the war.

But that didn't make it any easier to sit and watch my fellow Dicathians be slaughtered. And then there were the cheers that rolled like hateful thunder down from the tens of thousands of onlookers as they gorged on the sight just like the wolves gorged on the innocents…

For a single, dark moment, I hated them all.

I imagined Destruction leaping from my hands to burn the entire stadium and everyone inside it to less than ash… but there were no cheers or laughter coming from our staging area. Though I couldn't bring myself to look away from these Dicathians' last moments, I could hear the shallow, labored breathing of my students, the crack of their knuckles as they gripped the rails, the quiet whimpers of disgust as the wolves feasted…

Then the hair on the back of my neck stood up as a familiar force filled the room, breaking the spell of the slaughter.

The students began dropping to their knees as they followed the source of the pressure to the back wall of the staging area, where a horned figure dressed all in black stood watching us.

Regis bristled, the mental equivalent of putting his hackles up.

Seris Vritra looked much different than she had that day on the battlefield, when Uto nearly killed Sylvie and me. Instead of a wartime general, she looked regal as an empress draped in a black scale battledress, though she wore the same midnight-black cloak she had when I first saw her arrive in Darv.

Next to me, Seth remained on his feet, slack-jawed and staring. While the rest of the class had the good sense to go down on their knees, Seth seemed frozen in place. The Scythe's sudden appearance cemented one piece of information I had only guessed at so far: Nico wasn't the only one who knew my real identity.

Seris was watching Seth like he was some amusing little critter. Whatever her reason for coming here, I didn't need the students involved in it, and so I placed a hand on Seth's shoulder and pushed him to his knees.

"Scythe Seris," I said. "How nice to see you again."

"Professor Grey of Central Academy. Lady Caera of Highblood Denoir." A tremor ran through the kneeling students at the sound of Seris's silvery voice. "With me."

She spun, her cloak flowing like liquid around her, and vanished through the single door set into the stone wall at the back of the staging area. Caera jumped to follow her, but I stayed where I was.

'Yes, because what this whole ordeal really needed was another layer of complication,' Regis thought, our link clearly transmitting his hesitant resignation.

The fact that Seris had also discovered my identity wasn't exactly a surprise since Nico obviously knew, but I had to wonder why she would contact me now, and so openly.

Even with Seris gone, the students were still petrified. Their shock and awe were tangible, floating in the viscous silence that the Scythe's sudden appearance and departure had created. Even the noise of the crowd had been muffled, as if unwelcome in this place.

"Briar, Aphene."

Both young women flinched as my voice broke the silence, their heads snapping up to stare wide-eyed and searching around the room. Briar's eyes blinked several times behind her mask as if she were waking from a long, uncertain dream.

"You're in charge until I get back," I said quickly, then marched out after Caera and Seris.

The Scythe was silent as she led us through the bowels of the coliseum. She walked with purpose, and yet her movements maintained a fluid grace and elegance that hinted at a flawless control over her physical form. Her confident rhythm never broke, not even to look back and make sure we were following. As we strode after her, we saw no one else despite the constant bustle of officials, workers, and slaves that must have filled the underworks.

After a minute or two, I noticed Caera watching me from the corner of her eye. She opened her mouth, but closed it again without speaking.

“What is it?” I asked, my voice sounding hollow in the underground tunnels, but she only shook her head in response.

Seris’s head turned a fraction of an inch as I spoke. I wondered what unspoken tension was weighing down Caera’s shoulders, but kept my silence.

I was wary, but not afraid. Although Seris was too distant and mysterious to consider an ally, I didn’t count her among my enemies, either. If she wanted to harm me, there had been plenty of opportunities to do so before the Victoriad.

When we arrived in a private viewing box overlooking the combat field, I immediately scanned the room for any threats—as if there could be anything more dangerous than the Scythe within—but found only a plush lounge from which to watch the games below. The decor didn’t interest me, and my attention turned immediately back to Seris.

“Make yourselves comfortable,” Seris said, her light tone at odds with her dominating presence. When I made no move to do so, she waved a hand as if to brush away my wariness. “I didn’t bring you here to harm you, *Grey*, but you already know that. You look well, by the way. Golden eyes… *very* subtle. Why don’t you remove that mask so I can see your face properly?”

“Thank you for the hospitality,” I replied, doing as she asked. “Nice place, if a bit lonely. Where’s Cylrit? Lurking in the closet, waiting to jump out and give me some dire warning?”

Seris laughed happily. “My retainer is seeing to something else for me at the moment. No dire warnings today, but that doesn’t mean we don’t have business to discuss. I’m sure it won’t surprise you to

learn that I've been keeping close tabs on you ever since you so conveniently appeared in the Relictombs."

Caera flinched, looking slightly past me, not quite meeting my eye. "I'm sorry, Grey. Scythe Seris, she is my guide—my mentor, as I've mentioned before—and at first of course I had no idea you might know each other, but only told her about you because you were so…" She paused, biting the side of her cheek. "So curious and interesting, and then she wanted to know more about you, and she asked me to keep an eye on you—but I told you, so I hope you know I—"

As she spoke, I had noticed Seris searching my eyes from behind her and giving me a coy, knowing smile. When I returned the expression, Caera faltered, her worry giving way to a confused frown.

"It's fine, Caera. I mean, you have a powerful female Scythe mentor with an unusual interest in me?" I gestured to Seris, unable to suppress a guilty smirk. "I never pressed you for more details because I didn't need to. It wasn't all that hard to figure out."

Caera let out a deep breath and ran a lock of blue hair between her fingers. "Thank you for understanding. You two can stop making silly eyes at each other now."

"Caera of Highblood Denoir, is that any way to speak to your mentor?" Seris asked with only a slight mocking air. "Your adoptive mother would be appalled."

'Pretty classy, the way you handled that. But then, I guess it'd be pretty childish of you to get all pissy at her for not telling you, considering the uncountable number of lies you've told about your own identity,' Regis scoffed.

Fair point, I thought back. *And also, shut up.*

Seris reclined against the warded glass that fronted the chamber. "You've grown predictable, Grey."

"Oh," I asked, quirking an eyebrow at the Scythe. "How much of what I've accomplished have you predicted, exactly?"

Her lips parted to respond, but I saw her eyes flick to Caera, and she seemed to rethink whatever she had been about to say. Finally, she said only, "Enough."

I met the Scythe's piercing eyes, no longer smiling. "What do you want with me now, Seris?"

"The same thing I have always wanted." She turned to face the window. Below, a dozen slaves were cleaning up the last of the mess left by the black-fanged wolves. "To see your potential grow."

The Scythe drifted to a chaise lounge and eased into it while indicating we should take the couch across from her. Caera didn't hesitate to comply with her mentor's unspoken request. I moved to stand behind the couch, but did not sit, instead resting my hands on the cushioned back.

"Speaking of potential," Seris said, her focus on my sternum, "Caera tells me you have exchanged your ability to manipulate mana for mysterious aether arts that even she does not understand." Caera shifted uncomfortably at Seris's words. "How did this come to be? I hope my last gift to you wasn't entirely wasted, was it?"

'Uto's mana wasn't wasted at all, if you ask me,' Regis thought with the mental equivalent of letting his tongue loll contentedly from his mouth.

“My injuries in the war were catastrophic,” I answered, my body tingling as I remembered the feel of it breaking down due to prolonged use of the third stage of Sylvia’s beast will. “I had to adjust.”

“Yes, well, *that* is certainly something I couldn’t have predicted,” she said in a low voice, more to herself than Caera or me.

“What do you want with me?” I asked again, more firmly this time. A sudden suspicion dawned on me, and I added, “Did you bring me here? To the Victoriad?”

Seris’s painted lips quirked up. “I’ll admit, it has pained me to see you sit on your hands at that university for so long. A professor, really?” She gave me a disapproving look, as if I cared what she thought about my actions in Alacrya. “As I said, predictable. But you are also right, I did arrange for your class to be here.”

“Why?” I asked, trying to piece this new information into everything else I already knew.

“Because I wanted to remind you who you are, and what is at stake,” she said, her voice heavy with authority, a sharp change in tone from the rest of our conversation. “To that end, I have arranged for your presence here to ask something of you. Think of it as calling in the debt you owe me.”

“Debt?” I asked, not sure I liked where this was going. “So you didn’t simply help me out of the goodness of your heart? Shocking…”

Caera turned slowly, staring at me with eyes the size of full moons. Her jaw was clenched so tightly I thought she might crack a tooth.

Seris, though, only adjusted herself to be more comfortable. “I want you to challenge Cylrit to be my retainer.”

This seemed to be too much for Caera, whose mouth fell open in surprise. She ripped off her mask, snapping the cord, and let it fall to the couch beside her. "What is happening right now?"

I disguised my own surprise beneath a wry smirk. "And what do I have to gain by doing that?"

"I will assume that is a rhetorical question, because we both know why you're really here," she said, her tone that of a judge delivering her verdict.

'Tell her Scythe or nothing,' Regis japed. *'We aren't playing second fiddle to anybody.'*

"You don't want me to be your retainer," I guessed, rapidly considering the various goals she could be pursuing with this course of action. "You want me to draw attention to myself."

She nodded, just a minute dipping of her horned head. "By defeating Cylrit and then *refusing* the role of retainer, you will be sending a very clear message."

Agrona knows I'm here, I realized with absolutely certainty, wondering if Seris might even have told him herself. After all, who else would she need to send a message to. *But he already has what he wants, and he doesn't care about me anymore.*

This realization struck me like a thunderclap. All this time in Alacrya, I had always assumed he would make me a priority if he discovered that I had survived my battle with Nico and Cadell. I had worried that the Scythes would kick in my classroom door or rain fire and black iron down on Windcrest Hall while I slept.

But to find out Agrona had discovered that I had not only survived but was living in his own lands, and he didn't care…

I was conflicted, to say the least.

'If Agrona doesn't think we're a threat, that's his own dumbass miscalculation,' Regis thought with a snarl. *'But if the horned goddess over there wants us to expose ourselves…'*

This knowledge threw my entire plan into question. While Agrona knowing I was alive—and where I was—wasn't exactly great, Regis had a point. Dismissing me was a mistake on his part, one I was happy to capitalize on. But if I drew his attention now, showed him my power before I was ready…

"That plan seems bad for me, and I'm not sure how it benefits you either," I hedged, curious how much of her plan Seris would give up before she made me confirm my intentions.

"Oh, come now, put that clever mind of yours to work," she insisted, the crushing authority gone from her voice, which was once again light and teasing. "How long do you plan to run and hide?"

Sitting in front of me, Caera remained quiet, although she still wore a confused frown, and I could see the gears in her head turning as she struggled to make sense of the conversation.

Standing straight, I looked down at the Scythe. "I'm not going to challenge Cylrit."

Seris's mouth thinned into a hard line.

"But I'll still send your message," I went on, making my decisions only as I said the words out loud. "It'll be loud, and abundantly clear."

Seris straightened, then stood. Even though she was quite a bit shorter than me, when she looked into my eyes it felt like *she* was

looking down on *me*. “I would prefer it if you’d tell me exactly what you’re up to. I might be able to help.”

“Come on, Seris,” I said, mimicking the same teasing expression she’d worn only a moment ago, “put that clever mind of yours to work.”

Hearing Caera’s footsteps halt, I stopped and turned to face her. We were deep in the underworks, and the stone around us vibrated with the noise of cheering and battle from above.

Caera’s gaze was on the ground at my feet, what little of her features I could see behind her mask subdued.

“Trilby tie your tongue?” I asked, not trying to guess which part of my conversation with Seris had her head spinning. I couldn’t begin to imagine what kind of wild story she was creating in her mind.

Caera hummed nervously as she looked up to meet my eye. “I want you to know that you can trust me. Obviously there are a great many things I don’t know about you, and based on what I just witnessed between you and a *Scythe*, whatever fanciful notions I’d had up until now are woefully inaccurate.”

I scanned the dim tunnel where we’d stopped. It ended at a junction just ahead, where turning left would take us back toward the combat field and staging area, while the rightmost path would lead us back outside.

Doing some quick calculations about how much time we had before the tournament started, I smiled and held out my arm. Caera looked at me uncertainly before letting her hand rest in the crook of my elbow.

“Let’s take a walk and clear our heads for a bit before subjecting ourselves to the millions of questions likely brewing in my students’ heads,” I said with a soft chuckle.

“I’m not sure I, a humble Vritra-born highblood, deserve to be seen walking arm-in-arm with such a well-connected and mysterious figure as yourself,” she teased.

“Perhaps not, but I’ll extend you this honor just this once,” I shot back, leading her toward the exit.

The noise outside was deafening after the muffled quiet of the underworks. Merchant’s hollered, mana beasts squalled, and thousands of excited Alacryans shouted over one another to be heard.

We turned out of the crowd, moving down less densely packed alleys, although this had the drawback of making us easier targets for the many venders and gamesmen.

“Ho, sir with the golden eyes, stop here to win your beautiful lady a fine prize,” a man in a sparkly silver mask sang, waving us toward his cart.

A fat man bowed as he walked past, then practically shouted in our faces. “Gemstones! Gemstones here! Finest cut, finest color! Sapphires to match the lady’s lovely hair, or perhaps rubies for her enchanting eyes.”

For the first time in a while, I really missed being a quadra-elemental mage. A simple wind barrier spell would have made the walk a lot more peaceful.

“What are you smiling about?” Caera asked.

I fixed my face. “Nothing, just…wondering how you came to be under the tutelage of Seris.”

“Oh really?” she asked, her gaze following the line of colorful carts, tarps, and tents. “You already know more about me than perhaps anyone else in the world, while you are a locked book with pages of which are out of order, encoded, and probably written in invisible ink…” She trailed off, shooting me a wry look, then sighed. “But by all means, let’s talk about me.

“Vritra-blooded children, those of us with pure enough blood to potentially manifest Vritra magic, are not common, but we’re not so rare that each of us gets our own Scythe, either.” A woman who recognized Caera, a vendor selling extremely expensive leather goods, shouted out, and Caera gave her a small wave as we continued on. “She claimed to have chosen me because of Highblood Denoir’s standing, which of course only grew after being assigned a Vritra-blooded foster daughter, but I’ve always wondered…”

“If she knew somehow? That you’d…” I gestured at her head, where her horns were kept invisible by the teardrop pendant she wore around her neck.

“Right,” she answered. “I was…eight, maybe nine when she started training me, making me not only a Vritra-blood and adopted highblood, but also protege to a Scythe. It made for a…conflicted childhood.”

“Why do you think she has helped to keep you hidden?” I asked, lowering my voice as a group of highbloods sauntered past, dressed

so brightly they could have been mistaken for peacocks. “What does she want with you?”

Caera eyed me curiously. “Are you asking for my benefit, or your own? Perhaps trying to figure out what she wants with *you* in the long run?” She shook her head. “I still can’t believe she asked you to be her retainer.”

“But she didn’t, really. She only wants me to fight him, remember?” I pointed out.

“Which only makes it more confusing, at least for me,” Caera said, sounding exasperated. “I won’t pressure you to explain anything—though I’ll happily listen when you decide to do so—and promise not to hold it against you if you chose to hold some things back”—Regis let out a mental snort—“but why would she want you to draw attention to yourself? From who? For what purpose?”

Caera chewed on her own tongue for a second before continuing, obviously giving voice to some thought that had been bothering here. “Are you… Scythe Seris’s concubine?”

I nearly choked on my surprise, the question catching me entirely off guard.

‘Talk about a whole new level of “keeping your enemies closer”,’ Regis thought with a barking laugh.

“No,” I finally answered, rubbing the back of my neck. “Nothing remotely like that.”

She gave me a frustrated shake of her head. “Then I just don’t understand.”

“I know,” I said, sounding suddenly tired even to my own ears, “but you will someday.”

“That’ll have to be good enough then, I suppose,” she said with a chagrined smirk. “Anyway, we best get back to your class. Their bouts should begin soon.”

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THE VICTORIAD III

SETH MILVIEW

"They've been gone for so long," Pascal muttered to Deacon, who was standing next to him. We were all lined up in rows as Assistant Aphene led us through a series of movements and forms to warm up our muscles. "What in the name of the High Sovereign could the Scythe of Sehz-Clar want with our professor, anyway?"

"Maybe he offended or angered her in some way?" Deacon suggested, fidgeting nervously with his mask.

Like me, Deacon usually wore glasses, but they didn't fit with the masks. Luckily my sight had been slowly improving since my debilitating sickness went away, but Deacon kept having to pause and squint up at Assistant Aphene to see what stance she had twisted her athletic frame into.

"Don't be stupid," Valen scoffed. "A Scythe wouldn't come personally for that. She'd send her retainer, or maybe just a bunch of soldiers. With almost all the Scythes present at the Victoriad, it's to be expected that they would appear in person at some point."

"Maybe the professor is Scythe Seris Vritra's secret lover!" Laurel giggled, hiding her mouth behind one of her long braids.

Mayla leaned toward me and whispered, "Someone needs to lay off the cheesy romance stories."

"Or he's been training to replace her retainer," Marcus suggested. "We've all seen how scary he can be when he wants to. Have you known anyone else, even professors, who can train so easily at max

gravity in the fighting platform at school? He doesn't even break a sweat."

Valen shrugged, breaking form for an instant.

Assistant Briar was walking around offering small corrections on the form of our movements. Her orange and yellow hair was pulled back, which for some reason made her look kind of scary. Like she was getting ready to kick someone's butt. "Less chatter, more following along," she scolded.

"Interesting theories," Valen went on, his voice lower, "but it could be more mundane than that. I've personally met Scythes Cadell Vritra, Dragoth Vritra, and Viessa Vritra already myself. It's—"

"And I've kissed Scythe Melzri Vritra," Yanick said, cutting into the conversation and getting a surprised laugh out of everyone, even Valen. Assistant Aphene cleared her throat and brushed the dark bangs from her eyes as she moved into a new stance.

"What I was *trying* to say," Valen said as the noise petered off, "is that it isn't unheard of for the Scythes to make social calls to high-ranking bloods."

"Except that Professor Grey isn't a high-ranking highblood, as far as we know," Deacon pointed out, huffing slightly from talking and stretching at the same time. "And besides, Scythe Seris Vritra is known to be a recluse. She doesn't *make* social visits."

I stayed out of the conversation, too embarrassed by freezing up in front of the Scythe to say anything or draw attention to myself.

And so of course Mayla chose that moment to lean toward me again and ask, "Hey, you all right? You seem a little shaken up."

“More like frozen stiff,” Pascal said, starting another round of poorly suppressed laughter. Mayla pinned him with a warning glare, and he held his hands up, wobbling slightly. “Just kidding, sheesh.”

Assistant Aphene cleared her throat again, but before she could scold anyone for talking, all eyes turned toward the front of the staging area, where an event official wearing a red demon mask had just appeared, marching into our space and staring around.

At nearly the same moment, the door in the back wall of the staging area opened and the professor stepped through, Lady Caera just behind him. The professor raised a hand and seemed about to say something to the class when he noticed the official.

“Professor Grey of Central Academy?” the official asked in a clipped tone.

“Are you here about the tournament?” the professor asked. “I hope I haven’t kept you waiting long.”

The official’s eyes narrowed behind his mask as he marched across the room and held out his hand, which the professor shook perfunctorily. “You haven’t, which is good as I have four more team leads to meet with.”

He sniffed indignantly and began what sounded like a very rehearsed speech. “The unarmed nonmagical duels begin in twenty minutes, Professor. Multiple matches run concurrently, but your students will be placed at these platforms closest when possible. Students should be at the ready at their assigned ring no later than five minutes before their bout begins. This is a single-elimination tournament. Loss occurs by knockout, forfeit, or by being forced from the ring.

“I’m sure I don’t need to remind you, but magic is *not* allowed under *any* circumstances. Any use of mana beyond latent body-strengthening caused by the presence of runes will result in immediate forfeiture of the match and expulsion from the Victoriad. In addition, attacking with intent to maim or kill is also forbidden.”

He took a breath as he unrolled the next length of his scroll. “The first competitors from Central Academy are: Enola, blood Frost, at ring six. Deacon, blood Favager, ring seven. Portrel, blood Gladwyn, ring nine. Sloane, blood Lowe, ring eleven.”

I let out a sigh of relief. At least I wasn’t one of the first to fight, so I wouldn’t be the first one knocked out of the tournament. Probably.

Professor Grey checked with the four named students to ensure they had their ring numbers, then thanked the official.

He nodded curtly back. “We also ask that the team lead—in this case, you, Professor—remain present in case any issues arise.” Spinning on his heel, the man then rushed out of our staging area and on to the next.

“Well, you all heard him. Let’s—”

The professor paused, his gaze sweeping over the students.

“You look like a flock of little chicks waiting to be fed,” he said with a sigh. “I suppose none of you are going to focus until I’ve explained, correct?”

“What did the Scythe want with you?” Assistant Briar asked in a hushed tone.

The professor shrugged. “We drank tea and had a casual chat. Nothing special.”

Assistant Briar snorted and rolled her eyes as Assistant Aphene wrapped an arm around her shoulder, grinning. “My grandfather won’t believe I was standing so close to a Scythe, not even at the Victoriad!”

Laurel leaned in close to Mayla. In a singsong voice, she whispered, “Secret lover.”

Everyone burst out with questions and excited comments, but the professor waved away the commotion. “Enola, Deacon, Portrel, Sloane… get to your rings. Everyone else, pay attention.”

Enola and the others hurried out to the rows of combat rings and waited. Just like the official had said, they were fairly close by, near enough to see all four fights at once. I jogged to the front to get a good view, the rest of the class right behind me, and ended up sandwiched between Mayla and Brion.

Enola was the first into her ring, striding confidently up the stairs right on the heels of the official who was leading her, her golden hair gleaming in the sunlight.

Deacon, on the other hand, walked like he was being sent to the director’s office, his feet dragging on the ground, his head constantly swiveling to look back at us.

When Portrel did the same, I snorted in amusement. After all his trash-talking about me being nervous, there he was, constantly checking back over his shoulder to look at Valen, even when he was in the ring across from his opponent.

The combatants were introduced one by one, drawing a few excited cheers from the audience, but mostly from their own classmates at each staging area. Next, an organizer and referee shouted out the

instructions, their voices all mixing up and growing muddy competing with each other and the crowd.

According to what I'd read about the Victoriad, the student tournaments were mostly just a warm-up event—incredibly important to the students and our bloods, but not really attended otherwise.

The fact that the stands were only half-full yet proved this, but didn't bother me. *A smaller crowd means fewer people to see me get my butt kicked…*

The officials each raised their right hand, and all at once, they shouted out to begin.

It was chaotic trying to keep track of all four fights at once, not to mention all the other battles going on in front of us that weren't from Central Academy. I saw Deacon barely dodge as a dark-skinned girl with a mossy green mohawk jumped up and tried to knee him in the chest, but then Sloane landed a punch that dropped his opponent to the floor, and my attention turned to his fight instead.

Sloane jumped on his opponent, a broad-shouldered boy in a green and gold uniform, throwing knees and elbows, but Deacon let out a yelped and so I turned back to his fight just in time to see him stumble backwards through the shielding barrier to fall hard to the dirt.

Next to me, Brion hid his face in his hand, and there was a chorus of groans from the rest of the class.

Mayla grabbed my elbow and pointed to Portrel, and I felt a distinct pang of jealousy watching the larger boy grab his opponent's fist out of the air. "He's so strong," I muttered.

“Yeah, it’s crazy. Oh, ouch!” Mayla winced as Portrel slammed the boy he was fighting to the floor before knocking him out cold with three quick punches to the face.

“That’s right! Knock his ass out!” Remy shouted, his fists raised in the air over his head.

Another cheer went up, and I realized with a jolt of excitement that Sloane won his match as well. “Way to go, Sloane!” I shouted, laughing when Brion threw his arm around my neck and jumped with excitement, cheering along with me.

Several other fights had also already ended, making it easier to see past the empty rings to where Enola was still going toe to toe with a girl who was at least four inches taller and thirty pounds heavier than her.

But that didn’t even matter. Enola fought like a crazy demon. She was so talented, it was hard to believe I was competing in the same tournament she was. Even though the other girl was bigger than her, Enola was a way better fighter.

Hearing chanting coming from several staging areas down, I leaned over the rail and pointed the other school’s students out to Mayla. “Do you know what academy they’re from?”

“Not sure,” she said with a shrug, not taking her wide eyes off Enola’s fight.

“Bloodrock Academy,” Marcus said, shifting over between me and Brion. “They tried pretty hard to recruit me, but my parents were set on sending me to the central dominion for training.”

“They seem pretty intense,” I said, watching the rows of students shouting and stomping in unison. There were a lot more of them

than us, since we'd been given a private staging area away from the rest of the Central Academy students.

Laurel started chanting, "Enola! Enola!" and waving her arms around at everyone else, encouraging us to pick it up. The name rang through the stadium with the beat of a drum.

Our chant continued for as long as the fight went on, which was several minutes longer than any others. I got so into it that I found myself dipping and ducking, shadowing Enola's movements without really meaning to.

"Hey, watch it, Seth," Marcus grumbled when I accidentally stepped on his foot.

I stopped and gave him a tight-lipped smile. "Uh, sorry."

Mayla laughed, poking me in the ribs. "You're like, a fight nerd, Seth."

I stuck my tongue out at her, but then turned my attention back to the fight.

It was pretty clear when the larger girl started to get tired, and when she did, Enola moved in to finish it with one of the special combinations Professor Grey had taught us.

She threw several punches and kicks in quick succession, each one timed to take advantage of her opponent's most likely defensive action, pushing to make the girl desperate, each dodge or block wilder and more out of place, and ending with a spinning elbow to the girl's undefended temple. Or at least, that's how the professor explained it.

Our staging area exploded. Mayla jumped on my back, surprising me and nearly knocking me over, but we only laughed and cheered even louder.

Enola, Sloane, Deacon, and Portrel entered the staging area shortly after to raucous applause.

I slapped Deacon on the arm. "Don't look so glum. You didn't do too bad, considering you couldn't even see."

"Whatever, at least now I can just sit back and relax," he mumbled, giving me an appreciative smile. "And watch the rest of you get your butt's kicked, of course."

I wanted to congratulate Enola too but hung back with Deacon, Mayla, and Linden when I realized she was beelining for the professor. "So… how'd I do?" she asked, almost too quiet for me to hear with Remy and Portrel wrestling around and shouting at each other.

"Your execution was a little sloppy. You'd have won in half the time if you'd…" He paused, then seemed to relax slightly. "You did well."

Enola beamed as she spun away, catching my eye for an instant. I gave her a thumbs up and mouthed, "Great job," then she was absorbed into the group as Brion, Linden, Marcus, and Pascal started peppering her with questions and reliving their favorite moments of her fight.

It seemed like only a few seconds passed before the masked official was back, bringing the celebration in our staging area to a sudden halt. He repeated the part of his previous speech about where to go and not using magic, blah blah blah, and I felt my body tightening up as he prepared to announce the next round of fights.

“Remy, blood Seabrook, ring seven; Laurel, blood Redcliff, ring eight; Mayla, blood Fairweather, ring nine; Seth, blood Milview, ring eleven.”

A hand grabbed mine and squeezed. “Good luck, Seth!” Mayla said excitedly. “Let’s show everyone just how much we’ve learned, okay?”

“Yeah,” I said, my voice coming out hoarse.

Then we were all marching out onto the combat field along with a dozen other students from other schools. I immediately blanked and forgot which ring I was supposed to go to, and ended up walking around in a circle before an official took me by the arm and dragged me to ring eleven. My face burned as I heard laughter from the closest staging area, but I didn’t turn to look at which academy it was.

I blinked and suddenly the official was urging me up onto the combat platform opposite my opponent.

He wasn’t much taller than me, but he was athletic, very much unlike me. Where I had pale, stick-thin arms, his were tan and muscular. My legs were trembling, but his were stout and tree trunks. His uniform was red and gray, and he wore a black mask with scarlet runes painted on it.

“Not fair!” someone shouted from nearby. This time I did turn to look and realized I was right next to the Bloodrock Academy staging area. A huge boy—if he even was a boy, and not a mountain ogre in disguise—was leaning on the rail and shaking his head. “How’d you get so lucky, Adi? I didn’t know little kids could compete in this event.”

His classmates all hooted with appreciative laughter and cheered for my opponent, who was smirking now beneath his black mask.

The official said something that I didn't catch, then a heavy gong announced the beginning of the fight.

My opponent didn't even adopt a form, just sauntered across the ring toward me. With a casual air, he threw a forward kick at my stomach, looking at me with a frustrating mix of pity and disdain.

My training kicked in. I stepped to the side and forward while aiming a low kick at his ankle, knocking his foot out from under him. He crashed straight down with a pained grunt, his legs going in opposite directions, but I had already reversed my stance and kicked straight backwards with the other leg, my heel connecting solidly with my opponent's temple.

He collapsed sideways, mask askew and eyes rolling back in his skull.

And it was over. Pairs of students were still fighting all around me, but the official judging my match hopped up into the ring and shouted out my victory above the din, then instructed me to wait next to the ring until all matches had finished. The stunned boy shifted so I paused to offer him my hand to help him up, but he swatted it away and struggled to right himself.

Moving down the steps to the dirt of the combat field, I stared around at the other fights without really seeing them, not quite sure yet what had even happened.

"Lucky move, woggart," the big boy said from behind me, crossing his arms as he stood to his full height. He was as tall as Remy but beefy as Portrel. His eyes were a dark, bloody red behind his mask.

“You better hope you don’t end up in the ring with me. I’ll break your scrawny ass in two.”

Doing my best not to look as scared as I felt—any joy at my victory forgotten—I tried to watch Mayla, but my head felt like it was full of tar, and I kept thinking about the big, angry ogre glaring at me from the Bloodrock staging area and wondering if he was going to jump on me like a wild animal.

Several minutes passed by in a daze before I was instructed to return to the staging area with Mayla, Laurel, and Remy. With a pang of guilt, I realized I hadn’t even seen if Mayla won.

By the way she was grinning, though, I thought she had. “I missed your whole fight!” she said excitedly as we walked side by side. “Like, I blinked and it was over. What happened?”

“He won!” Yannick shouted, jumping over the rail and rushing out to us, followed by Marcus. Before I knew what was happening, I was sitting on their shoulders being bounced around as they began to chant, “Seth! Seth! Seth! Seth!”

I had to duck to avoid knocking my head when we entered the staging area, which was in an uproar.

“Hell of a move!” someone shouted.

“Fastest victory yet,” someone else said, and it went on like this for a minute or more with everyone cheering and congratulating me.

I wished I could have taken more of it in, but my mind was buzzing and I had a hard time following what was happening. My thoughts jumped from the surreal feeling of being cheered for back to the fight—which now felt like a half-remembered dream—to the Bloodrock boy’s threat…

Professor Grey caught my eye, and my mood evened out. He didn't utter a word, but gave me a nod before turning to welcome the event official, who was back yet again.

When the first round of battles was over and everyone had fought, only Deacon, Remy, and Linden had lost. The fights lasted longer in the second round, but with only half of the combatants remaining, it went quickly.

The highlight was definitely when Laurel let out a squeal of panic as she narrowly missed catching her opponent's knee in the mouth, tumbled backwards, then fell out of the ring on her own, which of course was met with lots of groans and embarrassed silence from the rest of the class. But she wasn't the only student to go down in the second round; Sloane, Pascal, and Brion all joined her pretty soon after.

As much as I'd like to say my second fight was as cool as the first… it wasn't. I was matched with a girl from some academy in Etril, and she stayed back and bounced around the ring like we were at a formal dance instead of a combat tournament. Our fight actually took the longest, and only ended when I managed to bull-rush her and push her out of the ring.

Still, I was glad not to have drawn the big ogre from Bloodrock, at least until Mayla was called out to ring eleven…

I groaned, feeling slightly sick as he hopped up onto the platform across from her, cracking his knuckles and leering like a common street thug.

“Mayla, blood Fairweather versus Gregor, blood Volkunruh,” the official announced, his voice lost in a tangle of others, and then the gong sounded.

Gregor thundered across the ring and took a huge backhand swipe at Mayla. She rolled beneath it and kicked out at the back of his knee, but he pivoted with frightening speed and attempted to stomp on her. She only barely tossed herself out of the way, but it had been a trap. Pushing off using the leg he had stomped with, he lunged in the other direction, following her.

When his knee connected with her chest, Mayla was lifted off her feet and thrown through the air. My own chest and stomach contracted like I was the one who’d been kicked, but my first thought was that at least the fight was over, and he couldn’t have hurt her too badly.

I choked on this thought when his massive fist wrapped around her ankle, jerking her flailing body to a halt and bringing it crashing back down onto the platform instead of outside the ring.

“Hey!” I shouted, my voice cracking slightly. It seemed crystal clear to me that Gregor had every intention of hurting Mayla, not just beating her, but the official refereeing their fight didn’t react.

Mayla was dazed on the floor and didn’t even try to block or dodge when Gregor’s boot slammed into her ribs, sending her tumbling across the dueling platform. Somehow, she used the momentum of the roll to push up to her feet, but she was too winded to attack back effectively.

Inside, I was begging her to just forfeit, but I couldn’t even bring myself to shout, only to watch in horrified fascination as Gregor

slapped aside her defenses and grabbed her by the throat. Mayla was lifted up off the ground until she was eye to eye with him. Gregor paused there, Mayla's hands wrapped around his wrist, scrabbling feebly to free herself.

"What the hell is that guy doing?" Marcus spat.

"Oh, shit," someone else cursed, and I realized most of my classmates had been watching Enola's fight instead and hadn't seen what happened.

"He's going to—"

Gregor turned toward our staging area, grinning beneath his mask. Then his hand came up like a battering ram into Mayla's stomach, the sound of it audible even from where I stood. He punched her again, then again, then let her drop. Bile rose up in the back of my throat as she curled in on herself, obviously still conscious but badly hurt.

I wanted to rush out and help, or to punch Gregor in his big, stupid face, but instead I just stood there while Assistants Briar and Aphene went out and helped Mayla back to the staging area. I stood aside while they laid her on one of the couches and checked for broken ribs. I didn't say anything even after they'd rubbed her down with pain-relieving ointment and wrapped her in half-frozen towels.

It wasn't until the professor came over that I snapped out of it, moving to sit by her feet and the end of the couch.

"You alive?" he asked.

Mayla's response was muffled from beneath a towel.

The professor met my eye, his face impassive…except for a tightness around his eyes and the corner of his mouth. My hands

balled into fists, which the professor must have noticed, because he asked, “Are you angry, Seth?”
“Yes,” I said, my voice raw.
“Good. Use that.” Then he moved away again as the rest of the fights ended.
“He’s so good at pep talks, isn’t he?” I said.
Mayla chuckled, then groaned from beneath her wrappings. “Don’t make me laugh,” she grumbled, her words barely discernible. “But… don’t leave, okay?”
There was an awkward fluttering in my stomach and chest at her words. “Yeah, sure. I’m right here. You just rest.”

I don’t know if it was fate, or luck, or perhaps just that the event organizers had a cruel sense of humor, but in the next round I, of course, found myself standing opposite “Gregor, blood Volkunruh.”
When I saw the giant Striker from Bloodrock Academy approaching ring eleven from the other direction, the bottom fell out of my stomach. I suddenly wanted to scream at the official that I forfeit and flee.
But I was afraid to even do that.
There was something else, though, beneath the fear. The image of Mayla bruised and bloodied beneath a wrapping of iced towels fed it like kindling. Even though I couldn’t put a name to the feeling, I knew I needed it if I was going to make myself get into the ring with Gregor, much less actually *fight* the monster.
And so I embraced it, picturing my friend, watching her fight against Gregor in my mind as I waited for the official to wave us up onto the

fighting platform. I thought about how he had purposely prolonged the fight, how he had tried not just to win, but to *hurt* her. How he had succeeded.

I heard Professor Grey's voice in my head: *Are you angry, Seth?*

Yes, I was pretty freaking angry, but it was a more layered emotion than that. And it ran deep. Desperation, motivation, eagerness…it was all burning beneath the fog of fear in my mind and spirit.

And so I didn't run. I stepped into the ring and glared up at Gregor. He smirked back down. Everything else blurred into the background.

Then the gong was ringing.

My body started moving before I had any kind of plan or thought about what to do. I felt like just another onlooker as I quick-stepped forward and dipped right, just beneath the opening haymaker I knew Gregor would throw. I hit him with two quick punches in the kidney then retreated out of reach of the back kick that followed.

Gregor was stronger than me. He was faster than me, too, and had better form. I'd never had to fight anyone with the raw power behind their attacks he had. But Professor Grey hadn't tried to make me as strong as Enola or as clean as Valen. He knew I couldn't win on talent alone. Instead, he'd taught me to develop my own style, to lean into my natural talents.

Analyze my opponent. Anticipate their movements. Plan my counterattacks.

It was almost like a puzzle: see what the opponent does, consider the forms and combinations the professor had taught me, and then put the right one in the right place. It was a fighting style I could excel at.

Anticipating Gregor's attacks, I ducked and dodged, throwing a few punches and kicks of my own when he left himself open, but retreating away from any concerted effort to corner me. The few times his blows landed, they slammed aside my inadequate defenses and nearly crushed me. Still, it was working.

"You hop around like a scared little toad," Gregor grunted after a couple of minutes. His wide, ugly face was red and his knuckles were white. "You're embarrassing yourself. Fight back or get out of the ring, toad."

He launched a series of punches, elbows, and knee strikes that I only barely managed to slide away from, although I landed a strong kick to the inside of his thigh in return. Every time I scored a blow, he swelled up and grew even more red, like an overwatered tomato about to burst.

But the real problem was that I wasn't *hurting* him. My kicks and punches just bounced off his heavily muscled body like he was wearing armor.

Eventually, my strategy failed.

Gregor engaged in a prolonged combination of quick kicks and sweeps, trying to put me on the ground. Several moves in, I lifted my foot to avoid a low kick at my ankle, responding with a kick of my own to the side of his knee. I overextended and couldn't get my feet back under me in time to avoid his big elbow crashing into my shoulder and driving me painfully to the ground at his feet.

With a roar of victory, Gregor fell down on top of me, slamming his knee into my stomach.

The sound of my ribs breaking cut through my mind like a dagger, shredding my focus. My entire torso lit up with hot pain. The air in my lungs exploded out in a dull grunt, and I couldn't catch my breath again.

Gregor's fist fell, hammerlike, on the side of my head, making it bounce off the combat platform and filling my ears with ringing. Stunned, unable to defend myself at all, I just stared up at him and waited to get pummeled into unconsciousness. Only, the next punch didn't come.

Instead, Gregor stood and turned his back on me, arms out wide as he yelled something at his classmates. Their response was a meaningless roar in my malfunctioning ears.

I focused on trying to breathe until my lungs finally inflated again and my head cleared a little, just in time for Gregor to grasp the front of my uniform and pull me bodily to my feet.

"I hope you enjoyed that while it lasted," he said, his breath hot on my ear. "It's my turn to have some fun now."

My head snapped back as he drove his forehead into the bridge of my nose with enough force to crack my mask, which tumbled to my feet. The world jumped, shifting out of position as my eyes lost focus.

Three Gregor's all laughed in my face. "Going maskless in front of the Sovereign? You worm. You should be punished!"

Huge, hard hands wrapped around my throat and lifted me off the ground. Somewhere, so distant it could have come from another dominion, or even the other continent, someone shouted my name.

My fingers clawed at Gregor's wrists uselessly. I flailed, kicking his legs and kneeing his sides, but I might as well have been fighting back against a marble statue.

The wild, irrational thought that this ogre of a boy was going to kill me right then and there overtook me, and the desperation burned away some of the fog clouding my mind. I focused on my pulse, following the drumbeat in my skull back to awareness.

Releasing his wrists, I pushed my arms between his, forcing them as far up as I could. It wasn't enough to break his grip, but it gave me just enough room to tuck my legs up into my chest. The pain of my broken ribs tried to steal my breath again, but I focused on that pulse, timing my breath to the heavy *thumps*.

I wedged one foot up between his outstretched arms and kicked hard, my heel striking his nose with a wet crunch. I kicked again, then again, then braced myself.

With an animalistic battle cry, Gregor swung me down toward the ground.

I lurched forward, just getting my hands around the back of his neck and pulling him down with me. When we hit the ground, my knee was just under his solar plexus, and the full weight of his own attack combined with his body weight to drive my knee into his sternum and the mana core beneath it.

I felt something move and break in my leg or maybe my hip. Everything hurt as I was crushed beneath Gregor, so it was hard to tell. The arena flashed black, then slowly faded back in, blurry around the edges but still there. It was quiet. Almost peaceful, like a fine place to just lay back and die.

Gregor rolled off me, lying on his side just next to me. His mouth was opening and closing rapidly, his eyes bulging. Then he gagged and a stream of vomit splashed onto the platform between us.

A sufficiently hard strike to the mana core was a lot like getting kicked between the legs. And I'd just delivered enough force to his sternum to break my hip, I was pretty sure.

The official was on the platform with us now, shouting, but everything sounded like I had my head in a vat of tar. Still, I got the gist.

Rolling through Gregor's sick, I pushed him over on his back and forced myself up on one knee, sending lightning bolts of pain through my entire body. I raised my clenched fist and tried to meet Gregor's eyes, though neither one of us seemed to be able to focus.

"Do you… forfeit?"

He coughed, shaking his head. I gathered as much strength as I could manage and punched him in the solar plexus, sending his body into convulsions of sickness and pain.

"Forfeit?" I asked again, struggling to even get the word out.

Gregor coughed up vomity drool and spit on the floor. A single, shallow nod, and then his eyes closed.

A firm but careful hand pulled me away from Gregor. I screamed as something shifted in my hip, and the hand released me, letting me fall onto my back. The official was speaking quickly, but the words were meaningless.

The blurriness around the edges of my vision grew more intense, going black and slowly swallowing everything I could see. One last thought tumbled through my tired brain before I lost consciousness.

I won.

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A BRIEF REPRIEVE

ARTHUR

I knocked lightly at the door before pushing it open and peering inside. A round-cheeked woman glanced up at me, nodded, then returned to caring for her patient.

Seth lay in a bed, wrapped in bandages, every inch of exposed skin shiny with healing ointments. The woman was passing some kind of rod-shaped device over his torso, treating his multiple broken ribs, fractured pelvis, and dislocated hip.

'Tough kid,' Regis said. *'I thought he was done for.'*

Yeah, well, that kind of grit probably runs in his blood, I sent back. *His sister probably showed the same.*

'Sure, sure, let's blame these kids for what Agrona made their friends and family do. Totally fair, because they definitely *could have resisted his will, right? What a bunch of pussies.'*

I sighed. *We've had this conversation already, Regis. I was just being petty, and I recognize that.*

'Don't sweet talk me like one of your princesses, Princess,' Regis said with a snort.

There wasn't anything I could do for Seth, and so I returned to the staging area, where I'd left Briar and Aphene in charge. As I opened the door, I was met with Briar's bellowing over the cacophony of my overexcited class.

"Would you all *be quiet*! We have a guest—oh, Professor Grey…"

Briar looked from me to Director Ramseyer, who had just entered from the combat field, looking unusually relaxed, even bemused.

“Don’t be too hard on our championship team,” he said. “It’s only natural they’re excited, considering. Which is why I’m here, of course, to say a few words. If you don’t mind, Professor Grey?”
I motioned for him to continue.
The director waited for the last few chatting students to quiet. “What a treat that was to watch,” he said, beaming around at the students. “Congratulations to each and every one of you for such an impressive performance during the tournament, and of course an *exceptional* job done by our tournament champion, Lady Enola of Highblood Frost.”
Cheers and applause burst out of the students, but it tapered off quickly as the director looked on expectantly.
“Additionally, I’d like to recognize Marcus of Highblood Arkwright and Valen of Highblood Ramseyer, who both performed up to the high standards of their bloods, going farthest in this tournament aside from our champion!”
Another round of applause, though I also caught a few exasperated looks at the director’s unsubtle calling out of his own grandson. Valen seemed oblivious, practically radiating pleasure at his grandfather’s compliment.
“And of course,” Director Ramseyer went on, “we can’t forget your injured classmates, Seth of Highblood Milview and Yanick of Blood Farshore. I hope you will pass along both my sympathy and my pride when you see them later.”
Shortly after Seth’s barely-won victory against the club-fisted kid from Bloodrock Academy, Yanick’s leg was broken by a careless opponent, but they were the only major injuries. Central Academy

became a standout in the tournament after that, putting up a better win percentage than any other academy present.

The students had grown more wild and boisterous with each passing round, and had rushed out onto the combat field in a frenzy when Enola ultimately won the championship. I found myself in a strange position, unable to ignore my part in their success. It was my training that brought them to this point, after all. And knowing that instilled me with pride, but also guilt.

And so, instead of giving these kids the positive reinforcement they needed, I had stepped back, steering my thoughts toward my plan for the Victoriad, eventually excusing myself entirely, using Seth's injury as an excuse to get a few minutes alone in the relative quiet of the underworks while my mixed emotions cooled.

"Now," Director Ramseyer said, clapping his hands together, "with today's events wrapping up, I'm sure you are all eager for a moment to rest your bodies and relax your minds, and so I'll leave you in the capable hands of Professor Grey and his assistants. Again, well done everyone, well done!"

The director made a point to shake my hand as he left, the students buzzing with tired conversation in the background. "To you, Professor Grey, I must also extend my congratulations. Melee Enhancement Tactics has never exactly been our school's priority, I'm afraid, but look at what you've accomplished with them." His normally severe expression gave way to a wide grin. "And to think I nearly had you replaced. Hah!"

Shaking his head, he made his way out of the staging area, and I clearly heard him mutter, "Oh, I can't *wait* to rub this in the other directors' noses at supper this evening."

Briar and Aphene were watching me, waiting. I gave them a nod.

"Listen up!" Briar shouted. "We're headed to our rooms. No dallying, no straying. You all look like you've had sixteen shades of shit kicked out of you already, but don't think for a *second* that I won't kick sixteen more out of anyone who feels like screwing around."

Biting back a smirk, I followed behind, only half keeping an eye on the group.

"Everyone should have your room numbers already," Aphene said when we reached the hall where we'd been provided rooms. "If you forgot your number, then I guess you'll have to sleep in the hallway."

"I know most of you are eager to sneak out of your rooms and hang out with friends," I added. "All I have to say is…just don't get caught."

There were a few appreciative chuckles at this, and even Aphene cracked a smile, but Briar only rolled her eyes and shot me an exasperated look. The line then broke apart as students began hunting for their rooms.

With my professorial duties absolved, I entered into the quiet confines of my little chamber and closed the door behind me.

Regis immediately hopped out of my body and sniffed around. "Not exactly a castle, is it?"

The accommodations provided for visiting students and professors were sufficient, if somewhat spartan. We were given rooms in the coliseum itself, and had been invited to stay for the rest of the event,

which consisted of another day of wargames and duels between high-ranking ascenders.

It wasn't until the third and final day of the Victoriad that the retainers and Scythes would accept challenges for their positions. If Nico was going to take my bait, it would be on the third day. Until then…

Reaching into my extradimensional storage rune, I conjured out the last keystone I had received. It had been a long and mentally taxing day, and what I really needed was to meditate and focus my mind.

Sitting cross-legged on the bed with the keystone between my knees, I closed my eyes, but didn't imbue the relic with aether. Instead, I waited. My brief training session with Enola and the keystone had shown me that what I really needed to make progress with the relic's insight was help.

A couple of minutes passed before the knock at my door came.

"Come in."

The door opened and Caera entered, looking frazzled around the edges. She'd spend the last couple rounds of the student tournament with her blood in their private box at Corbett's request.

"Sorry," she muttered. "Lenora trapped me in a very uncomfortable conversation with a young Vritra-blooded man who has been fostered out to some highblood in Sehz-Clar."

"Ah," I said, adjusting my position and gesturing to my room's single chair sitting at the foot of the bed. "Is there a potential betrothal in your future, Lady Caera?"

"No, *Professor* Grey, but that won't stop Lenora from trying." Caera fell into the chair with a huff, then gave me a more serious look. "So

what did you want to discuss? Finally planning on telling me what this mysterious plan is?"

"No," I admitted, giving her an apologetic smile. "Actually, I need your help with something."

She leaned back in her chair and crossed her arms, giving me a suspicious look. "Oh really?" Her focus moved to the keystone. "Something to do with that thing, I assume?"

I spent a couple minutes explaining what I wanted her to do, after which she adjusted her chair and got a little more comfortable.

"So, just…?"

"Exactly," I answered.

She closed her eyes. Warmth radiated from her body, and although I couldn't sense her mana, I could still feel the physical effects it caused. A faint movement in the air dislodged a lock of her hair, which fell in front of her face. Her lips pressed into a thin line as she focused. Her eyes flicked around beneath her closed lids, which were lightly painted a smoky gray color for the Victoriad.

"Thank you, Caera," I said, closing my own eyes and pushing aether into the keystone, letting my consciousness follow. As before, beyond the wall of purple energy I found only the empty black nothing of the keystone realm.

The darkness was alive in the presence of Caera's mana, shifting and moving. Drifting through the dark, I watched the rhythmic dance happening inside the inky blackness carefully, taking note of every aspect I could think of.

For some time—fifteen minutes, assuming Caera followed my instructions, but the time seemed to last much longer inside the

relic—the movement took on vertical striations that jumped and writhed like flames on a log.

Then the movements shifted, gaining a jagged, cutting edge, their movements erratic and difficult to quantify, like the many disparate shapes—each still a part of the whole—were waging a sudden and violent war on each other.

This didn't last as long before the shape of the motion changed again, now subtle streams, both flowing and radiating outward, like a river of lava and the intense heat it gave off.

At each step, I practiced forming aether in a variety of ways, attempting to cause some kind of reaction in the colorless motion of the keystone realm. Lashing whips, cutting arcs, shaped bursts, and even a rough spade-shaped aetheric form that I dragged through the blackness, but nothing affected my surroundings.

Nothing worked.

Whatever this puzzle was, I lacked something essential—whether understanding or ability—to navigate it…

Cold sweat dampened my forehead at a sudden, chilling realization, and I backed out of the keystone, my eyes snapping open.

Caera was sitting in the chair, currently channeling mana throughout her body to enhance her physical abilities. Her eyes were open, and she'd been staring at me. She jumped slightly and cut off channeling her mana. "I wasn't expecting—"

"Here," I said, handing over the keystone.

She hesitated, looking at it as though it might explode.

I unfolded from my sitting position and moved to the end of the bed. Taking her hand in my own, I set the keystone in her palm, then

wrapped both my hands around hers, cupping the keystone in the middle.

"I'm going to channel aether into the keystone," I explained. "I need you to tell me what you see… assuming this works."

"Um, okay, are you—" Her words cut off in a surprised gasp as I started.

Caera's eyes snapped shut and her body stiffened. "I see… a huge, ethereal wall… like I'm approaching the edge of the world."

Maneuvering by practice and instinct, I guided her consciousness deeper into the keystone realm.

"I'm moving through, it's all purple, a hundred different shades… and it's warm. It feels like—" She gasped again, this time even louder. "Light guide me… it's *mana*. I can see it! All the colors… the whole *world* in here is made up of mana, shaped by it. What is this, Grey? What am I seeing?"

I jumped out of the bed, swiftly pacing the short distance to the wall and back, my stomach clenching uncomfortably.

The keystone has something to do with mana, we'd already learned as much. Only, Caera can see mana particles within the keystone, but it looks like a black void to me, which means… what?

I don't have a mana core, but the presence of a mana core doesn't allow a mage to see mana particles. Sense them, yes, but I needed to activate Sylvia's beast will and the power of Realmheart to see the mana directly, even before my core was destroyed.

'So why is it all endless darkness and creepy ink-monster ripples when you go in there?' Regis asked from where he had curled up in the corner.

My lack of a mana core must be preventing me from properly sensing whatever it is the keystone is trying to show me, I answered, looking down at the cuboid relic resting in Caera's hand, still drawing on my aether to keep it open and her mind submerged within. *The ripples in the dark, they're obviously caused by the mana itself moving, but that doesn't make sense… unless it's a manifestation of the mana's effects, like the heat coming off Caera's body as she channeled fire mana.*

'Maybe it's sort of like when you see a heat haze rising off a sun-baked stone. The mana is moving, causing a change in the environment, and, you know, interrupting the sensory information you receive.' Regis rolled over, burying his face in the pillow from my bed, which he must have stolen when I wasn't looking. *'But the fact that you can sense something in there, anything at all, is a good sign, right?'*

I leaned against the wall as I considered this, wondering what mechanism of the keystone and whatever insight it contained allowed me to sense the movement of mana, even if I wasn't seeing it. The realm within the relic was aetheric in nature, and there wasn't any natural light, so Regis's comparison to a hot stone didn't quite fit the picture I had in my head. It was more like…

… the reflection of water seen from the outside of the glass. My mind reached far back to before the war, when Lady Myre had first explained aether to me. *"Aether makes up the building blocks the world is made of, while mana is what fills it with life and sustenance." She compared aether to a cup, and mana to the water that fills it. But if water changes shape, it doesn't alter the cup in any way. Or… does it?*

'Okay, you're losing me. Aren't the dragons a little behind the times on aether art stuff?' The wolf let out a rumbling chuckle. *'Aether "Art" stuff. Haha, get it?'*

The keystone realm itself is aetheric in nature, only housing mana within. I can't see the mana, but somehow my connection with the aether is letting me sense its movement. At least when it is reacting to outside stimulus, which must cause stronger fluctuations.

"Grey?" Caera's voice was a quiet, nervous whisper, making me realize I'd been quiet for some time.

"Sorry," I said immediately, "I was just thinking. Do you mind staying in there for a bit? There are a few more things I'd like to try."

"Are you kidding me?" Caera grinned. "This is amazing. It's…beautiful. Imagine seeing the world like this all the time?"

I smiled sadly, but pushed thoughts of Realmheart and Sylvia's beast will away.

There was work to do.

TESSIA ERALITH

Cold wind caressed my cheek and brushed a stray strand of my gunmetal gray hair behind my ear. It danced around me, carrying a little flurry of snow that spun outward with every twist and dip to drift down toward the fortress of Taegrin Caelum below.

"Weak."

I rubbed hard at the point on my chest where Grey's blade had pierced me…in a different life, a different body, and yet now that I had the memory of it, it was like I could feel the scar of the old wound.

"I had expected more from you."

The wind swirled inward, tugging at my blouse like it wanted me to dance too. So high above Agrona's fortress, the air was frigid and clear, and eager to feel the touch of mana.

Mountains stretched as far as I could see in every direction. Clouds gathered on the horizon—fluffy-gray and full of snow—but otherwise the huge sky was crystal blue. Cold but inviting.

"I'm the better contender."

I squeezed my eyes shut, trying to push away those last moments of my life, which had now replayed over and over in my mind for days…weeks? Time moved strangely in Taegrin Caelum, like the turning of the world meant little to the fortress or its ruler.

"If I have to leave you and Nico behind to achieve my goal, I will."

Those had been his last real words to me, this person who was supposed to be my friend. Before he had plunged his sword through my chest. And Nico had watched it happen.

That was my last memory. Turning my head to see Nico, ringed in a halo of light, half-obscured by clouds of dust, his face frozen in a tortured mask as he arrived too late to help…

I let out a shuddering sigh.

No wonder he is the way he is.

I shook away the thought. It wasn't Nico's fault. All I had to do was die and wake up, but Nico…his path had been much longer, much more painful.

Being forced to remember my own death had put me into a fugue for days, and even after that it took days more to return to myself. After taking so long to adjust to my new body—*my body*—being trapped in my rooms again had felt like prison, like torture. I'd

already lived one life of imprisonment, in which I'd never been allowed to be myself, to live for myself, make choices for myself.

But how is serving Agrona any different?

"I will make it different," I told the dancing wind. "I will control my own fate."

I released my hold on the magic that made me fly.

My body twisted in the air until I was staring down at the fortress. The air thinned ahead of me while blowing hard from behind, sending me hurtling at a break-neck pace downward. Taegrin Caelum, small as a child's toy only an instant ago, rushed toward me, expanding to engulf my vision.

I turned suddenly, my body aching from the force, and flew through my open balcony doors with enough speed that they slammed shut behind me. The door into the maze of hallways jumped open just before I would have smashed through it, responding to my will, and I hurtled along the castle corridors with dangerous speed.

When I stopped, the sudden burst of wind my passage created sent a stuffed mana beast tumbling off it's wide plinth to crash down the hallway. I winced, not having meant to cause any damage, but there was also a small part of me that felt vindictive pleasure in the act.

I knocked on Nico's door, but there was no answer. Earth mana lingered in the heavy metal lock, and it jumped to the side at my command, allowing the door to swing open.

My feet drifted up off the floor and I flew into the room. It was dark, empty, and absent of warmth…

Nico wasn't there.

There was only one other person in Taegrin Caelum I could talk to, really, and so I left Nico's room, flying off his balcony and around the edge of the fortress. I stopped, hovering in the air as a set of balcony doors high in the wall of Agrona's private wing pushed outward as if to welcome me.

Each time we met, it was like I was seeing Agrona for the first time.

His horns were empty of ornamentation, his usual fine clothes replaced by dark leather pants and a simple white tunic that hung casually off his lithe form, the top buttons undone to expose his chest and allow the runic tattoos that covered it to peek through. His marble skin shimmered in the cold mid-morning light, or perhaps that was the strength of his mana shining through his body from his core, which burned like a miniature sun within his sternum.

"Feeling better?" he asked, feigning a casual air. "I was just thinking of you. Draneeve said you missed your last assessment. I…" His head cocked slightly to the side, his tongue darting out to wet his lips. "What is weighing so heavily on your mind, Cecil?"

I met his brilliantly scarlet eyes—this being who was closer to god than man—and lifted my chin. "I've had a lot of time to consider everything you've shown me, Agrona, and I need to tell you something."

His smile was kindly, but carried the confidence of a conqueror. Whatever I had to say, I knew he would listen, but he wouldn't be bent or broken by it.

"I won't be your weapon," I continued, my voice carrying on the wind. "Or your tool. I want to be able to make my own choices, to have a *life*, not just to be alive."

Agrona's shrug was perfectly casual. "Of course, Cecil. Your life is your own." He gave me a charming, warm-hearted, understanding smile that made it difficult to remember what I wanted to say. "I would ask you inside to discuss this further, but honestly I love the drama of you flying there, face like carved ice, ready to make demands."

He's lying, of course.

I drew in a deep breath and the mana all around us swelled outward like it was a part of me. The air warmed, water vapor solidified and began to fall as wet flakes of snow, even the stones of Taegrin Caelum groaned.

"Tell me the truth."

Agrona stepped farther out onto the balcony. His eyes closed and he sniffed at the wind, filling his lungs with it. "Power," he said, his voice a booming whisper. "Raw and impossible."

Opening his eyes, he held out a hand to catch some of the snowflakes. "Would I repeat the mistakes of those fools who caged you in your last life? Suppressing your potential by constraining you, trying to control you? I hope I do not strike you as foolish."

"But you did something similar to Nico," I pointed out, holding in the tremor that would have wracked my body at Agrona's casual mention of the many years of imprisonment and torture—in the guise of training—I went through in my last life. "He—"

"Isn't the Legacy," Agrona said easily. "Although… what he endured for you, just for the chance to stand by you again… Nico was weak and powerless as he watched Grey take your life. Unable to do

anything, anything at all. He was willing to endure any pain to bring you back and keep you safe, no matter the cost to himself."

Agrona inspected me closely. "But Nico is not what you're here to talk about, is he? I'm not lying when I say your choices are your own, but there is something you need to know."

He paused when a bird flew right past me to settle on the balcony rail. It tapped its beak on the metal, issuing a hollow *clang*, and ruffled its shiny black and red feathers. Agrona held out his hand, which was suddenly full of seeds. The creature hopped from the rail into his palm and began to eat, fanning its four wings.

"It's… beautiful," I said, momentarily distracted.

"You won't find them anywhere else in Alacrya," Agrona mused, watching the bird peck at the seeds. "They come from Epheotus, native only to the precipitous cliff sides of Mount Geolus. I had some brought here, long ago, when…"

Agrona's features grew intense as he trailed off. Suddenly his fingers closed like a cage around the bird. It gave a frightened squawk and began to flap around in his hand and peck futilely at his fingers.

"They are out of place here, just like you," he said, his intense gaze on the bird. "You are in danger, Cecil, and you will be until the war is won and the Indrath Clan is thrown from their mountain."

"Why?" I asked, unable to take my eyes from the bird, a strong sense of foreboding making my stomach lurch.

"Unlike the Vritra, who pride ourselves on exploring the unknown, the rest of the asura clans are terrified of it. If they were ever to get their hands on you…"

His eyes drifted away from the bird to meet my own, and I felt myself drawn into them, like staring down the caldera of an active volcano. I could *feel* him riffling around in my mind like he was flipping the pages of a book. But instead of feeling like a violation, there was a warmth and comfort to it, like having him in there with me meant I wasn't alone.

But you aren't alone, Cecilia.

His hand closed. The bird gave a muffled shriek, which was immediately replaced by the crunching of small, hollow bones. When Agrona's hand opened again, the beautiful creature was little more than bent feathers and broken wings.

With a flick of his wrist, the little corpse tumbled over the edge of the balcony and down to the sharp stones far below.

"But I am not going to war with the other asura for your sake," Agrona said, his voice heavy with intent. "They are not just a danger to you, but to all lessers. And the people of both Alacrya and Dicathen deserve an existence without fear of their tyranny. I may rule the lessers, guide their evolution, but I have no interest in building them up only to break them and start over again as Kezess has done."

He held out his hand toward me, palm up, as if expecting me to take it. "If you fight with me in the war to come, you can protect yourself and the people of two continents from the danger that the asura pose. After all, they've already shown the depth of their disregard for lesser lives in Elenoir when they committed genocide just for the *chance* to stop you growing into your full power."

At the mention of Elenoir, an emerald haze leaked from my core, filling my vision and making me wobble in the air. Agrona tensed, but I regained control immediately and pushed the sensation down deep, back into my core where the alien presence of the elderwood guardian remained, its power still shuttered from me.

Agrona was tracing my body with his eyes, inspecting every inch of me. "The beast will riles at the mention of the attack," he noted. "Most interesting. Should you ever gain control over it, adding its formidable power to your own freeform control over mana will be a boon, but not strictly necessary for you to attain your full potential."

I rubbed my sternum over my mana core, uncomfortable.

"But I understand that this world will never be your home," Agrona continued, like he was pulling thoughts straight from my head. "And so I promise you this. When we defeat the asuras and topple the Indrath Clan, I will use the knowledge I have gained from the Relictombs to give you back your old life, your old world—but as they should have been."

My breath caught in my chest.

"Imagine it, Cecil. Picture exactly what that life would be like, whatever you want. Now, what would you do to claim it?"

It's a trick, or a trap, or—

But already his treatment of me was changing. His tone was respectful, even cautious. The way he looked up at me, I could see it in his eyes, like he saw me as a partner, not a tool, and that was exactly what I'd come here to demand. There was both a confidence and a question in that gaze, and I knew with utter certainty that he could do what he said.

But what *would* I do in this life for a chance to return to the life I should have had?

"Anything, Agrona."

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THE VICTORIAD IV

SETH MILVIEW

Standing at the bottom of a long stretch of stairs leading up into the stadium seats, I nearly turned around and gave up. I was *so* tired…but then, having your bones and musculature stitched back together by magic wasn't exactly what I'd call restful.

I'd stayed in bed for the entire second day of the Victoriad, which sucked. While everyone else was cheering on the wargames or spending their allowance at the market, I was curled up under about four blankets, shaking and sweating as my body worked overtime to heal.

Still, the doctor had been optimistic as she explained that a fractured pelvis was relatively easy to fuse, and how I'd have been looking at a much longer, more painful recovery if my hip had been broken and not just dislocated. And most of the class stopped by in groups to see me, with Mayla coming back several times throughout the day to check in and drop off cakes and candies to make me feel better.

I thought of that fluttery moment where she'd asked me to stay with her every time she walked in the door, and through the pain-induced haze, I realized something.

I liked her. Like, *like* liked her. I'd never had a crush before. I'd never been close enough to a girl to have a crush before…

"Seth?"

I flinched, feeling my face grow hot as I peeked at her out of the corner of my eye. Mayla was holding my arm while helping me walk, and I'd just frozen for about thirty seconds. "Sorry, I, uh…"

“We could sit lower if—”

“No, it’s okay,” I assured her, starting up the stairs. “I’ll be fine.”

A hot poker jammed into my side with each step as we ascended about halfway up the stadium to where Brion, Pascal, Yanick, Linden, and Deacon were seated. Most of our other classmates were in private viewing boxes with their bloods as everyone prepared for the main event, the real reason for the Victoriad: the challenges.

“Hail, Seth the Undefeated, Slayer of Giants!” Linden cheered as we shuffled in to sit next to the others.

“We are both honored and humbled by your presence,” Pascal added, a genuine smile creasing the burned side of his face.

I laughed, then winced.

Yanick leaned back and stuck his heavily wrapped leg in the air. “I feel your pain, man. At least you still *won* your fight.”

With an appreciative smile at my friends, I scooted past a few other people—the stands were almost entirely full now—and slid onto the bench next to Linden. “So, have they announced the challenges yet?”

“No,” Yanick said, pouting down at the empty combat field, which had been cleared of all the smaller fighting platforms. Then he brightened. “But, the rumor back home is that Ssanyu the Stone Eater is challenging to replace Bilal as Scythe Viessa Vritra’s retainer.”

Pascal grunted. “Ssanyu may be a legendary ascender, but everyone knows Scythe Viessa Vritra prefers a certain type of retainer.”

“That’s true,” I said, nodding along with what they were saying. “Have you read *The Forging of Scythes* by Tenebrous?”

“Oh, I have!” Deacon said brightly, getting a laugh out of everyone else. He looked affronted, pressing his hand to his chest as he said, “Well excuse me for being well-read, you barbarians.”

“In the newest version, Tenebrous mentions that Scythe Viessa Vritra prefers to train up her retainers personally,” I continued, adjusting myself on the hard bench to try and get comfortable. “Her last retainer, Bilal, was a wartime appointment, but he’d been her ward since he was a kid.”

“Right!” Deacon said. “Him and his siblings. Bilal, Bivran, and… Bivrae, right? The Dead Three?”

“Dead Three?” Mayla echoed, looking confused.

I winced as I turned toward her. The sun gleamed off her auburn hair, which framed her face and accentuated the slight roundness of her cheeks. She was…

Clearing my throat, I said, “Three little kids, eight or nine years old, who were found alone in their home. The building had been completely destroyed by some kind of explosion, and everyone else inside was killed. But somehow the triplets survived.”

“Whoa,” Brion said. “I’ve never heard that story.”

Linden leaned forward, chiming in for the first time. “I wonder if—”

But he was immediately interrupted by a series of magical gong noises echoing throughout the stadium. It was like someone had created a sound barrier as the audience suddenly went completely silent.

Into that silence marched a Vritra-born man in dark plated armor, a purple cape trailing behind him, striding purposefully toward the center of the combat field. Horns jutted out of his short-cropped

black hair. He had a serious face, and wherever his red eyes focused, the crowd seemed to tremble

There was no announcement to tell us his name or list his accomplishments. Everyone already knew who he was: Cylrit, retainer of Sehz-Clar.

When he reached the middle of the field, he turned toward the high box, his posture straight as a sword, and then bowed deeply. I could just make out Scythe Seris Vritra move to the front of the balcony, and I was glad I was already sitting down. The sight of her—her hair glowing like liquid pearl in the sunlight, her battlerobes shining like black diamonds—made my knees tremble.

She stepped back into the shadows of the high box just before a second figure appeared, marching toward Cylrit.

Although completely focused on the woman, I found it really hard, almost painful, to look at her. My gaze kept wanting to slip off, like turnshoes on an icy path. Her figure was indistinct, sort of ethereal…shadow made real. Plain black robes hung from her thin frame, but they seemed to drift and move, collapsing back into nothing around her ankles, like they stopped being robes and just became darkness.

She seemed to float over the ground, carried on a wind of black mist. No horns sprouted from her head, but her short white hair, which practically glowed in contrast with her midnight black skin and robes, was styled up into straight, sharp spikes.

Mawar, the Black Rose of Etril…

Stopping beside Cylrit, Mawar also bowed to the high box.

Another woman stepped out onto the balcony, raising her hand toward her retainer. She was a lot like Scythe Seris Vritra, and, at the same time, almost her opposite. The woman's silvery-gray skin wasn't painted, and she wore no ornamentation in her bright white hair. Unlike Seris's delicate horns, this woman had two pairs of thick black horns that curved away from her scalp, dark and heavy.

She wasn't wearing a dress or battlerobes, but was clad in armor made of white scales: larger, slightly darker plates at her shoulders, neck, and hips had an organic look to them, almost like bone, while smaller, arrow-shaped scales meshed together over the rest of her body.

Scythe Melzri Vritra…

She stepped back, and retainer Mawar straightened.

The ringing of gongs made the entire audience jump. Yanick cursed as Linden slipped out of his seat. I let out a groan of pain, having flinched so hard it felt like I'd cracked a rib again.

A deep voice spoke, coming from the air all around us. "No challengers have stepped forward to face Cylrit of Sehz-Clar. Would any prospects now offer challenge?"

As one, the entire audience, several tens of thousands of people, all focused on the combat field, waiting breathlessly. But no one stepped forward.

"Cylrit goes unchallenged," the voice boomed.

Bowing again to the high box, retainer Cylrit marched stiffly from the field.

"No challengers have stepped forward to face Mawar of Etril. Would any prospects now offer challenge?"

Again, the call for challengers went unanswered.
“Mawar goes unchallenged,” the voice boomed.
Following Cylrit’s lead, Mawar bent into a fluid bow, then floated from the combat field.
When she was gone, the voice spoke again. “Scythe Cadell Vritra of Central Dominion has elected to refuse any and all challengers to retainer Lyra of Highblood Dreide, who remains in the land of Dicathen, helping to settle our new sister continent and bring peace to its citizens.”
There was some muttering from the crowd at this, but it quieted immediately when the voice continued to speak.
“In times of war, even the strongest soldier may fall pursuing the will of the High Sovereign. The world is vast, and its perils are many, which is why Alacrya needs the High Sovereign to watch over us, protect us, and make us strong. We honor the dead for their sacrifice. Retainers Uto of Vechor, Jaegrette of Truacia, and Bilal of Truacia. Their names, like their deeds, will be remembered so long as a single Alacryan heart still beats.
“But where one falls, another rises. Four of Alacrya’s champions have stepped forward to challenge for the position of retainer of Truacia under Scythe Viessa Vritra. Sovereign Kiros Vritra welcomes and invites to the field: Ssanyu the Stone Eater—”
“Hah, told you!” Yanick whispered, grinning ear to ear.
“—Aadaan of Named Blood Rusaek, Kagiso of Highblood Gwethe, and Bivrae of the Dead Three.”
As their names were spoken, the four challengers appeared from one of the many entrances and marched toward the center of the

field to the spot that Cylrit and Mawar had only just vacated. They stood side by side in a line—Bivrae standing well away from the others, her face an ugly mask of disdain—and bowed as one to the high box.

"Would any other prospects offer challenge?" the voice said.

A moment passed. No one moved.

The voice boomed again, deeper and more grandiose. "Then bow before Sovereign Kiros of Vechor, and let the challenges commence."

A suffocating presence washed over the coliseum. It felt as though someone had flipped the world upside down and I was standing under the weight of the entire continent, waiting for it to fall and crush me to nothing.

The shadow of a large being appeared at the edge of the high box balcony. All around me, people were already looking down, staring at their feet or their laps.

Clasping my hands together, I kept my eyes on my interlocked fingers, not daring to look anywhere else. From the top of my vision, I could just see the four challengers, each facedown in the dirt, prostrate before the Sovereign.

When he spoke, the Sovereign's voice boomed with blood-stained thunder and white-hot power, scorching my ears and stealing my breath. "Prove yourselves, challengers. Show the depth of your mettle and the range of your desire. Bring pride to your bloods and your Sovereigns. Let no weakness creep in upon you, but claim every eager ounce of strength from your bodies."

Then the force of his presence was gone. I waited, afraid to look up and accidentally meet the Sovereign's eye. But the crowd began to shuffle, and I could hear a few whispered conversations, and finally, Mayla's hand was resting on my forearm.

"Seth, you can—"

I glanced up, meeting her eyes. "That was…" But I trailed off, unsure how to describe what I'd just felt.

"I know."

The projected voice of the unseen announcer came again, this time grating on my frayed nerves, making it feel like someone was standing right behind me, shouting into my ear. "Challengers Kagiso and Aadaan, please remain on the field. All others, return to your staging area."

Ssanyu and Bivrae left in opposite directions, the former striding proudly, the latter slinking along in a way that reminded me of the creatures in horror stories my mother read to me as a child.

The two men remaining on the field bowed again to the high box, then to each other.

Aadaan was tall and lean, with arms and legs that looked like they'd been stretched on a rack. He was clad in rune-inscribed leather armor, the dark brown nearly the same color as his skin. He wore a clever grin, and his eyes never left Kagiso.

Kagiso made a show of stretching, his mane of tawny hair bouncing around his shoulders with each movement. The tips of his black horns were just visible through his hair, and he had one blazing red eye and one jet black one. His armor was a mesh of leather and chain

in a deep red that matched his eye, with silver runes glowing from the pauldrons, chest, and down either side of his exposed back.

"Dang, that's a lot of runes," Linden muttered, but I could tell he wasn't talking about the armor. The man's spine was marked with at least a dozen emblems, and even a couple of regalia. "Does anyone know anything about him?"

"Only that he was fostered by Highblood Gwethe and he's a solo ascender," Deacon answered. "He fell out of the public eye when he manifested his Vritra blood."

Pascal grunted and scratched at his scarred cheek. "I heard they do all kinds of crazy experiments on any of the Vritra-blooded that manifest.. That's why there are so few of them."

"Don't be stupid," Brion said, earning a glare from Pascal. "There are so few of them because it's super rare for even someone with even a lot of Vritra blood to be able to use their asuran mana arts. For the few that do, the High Sovereign takes them all to Taegrin Caelum and has them trained to fight the other asuras."

Linden laughed. "Man, even total badasses can't fight asuras. Scythes maybe, but only after they've been strengthened with elixirs and stuff. I bet the High Sovereign has some secret weapon against the other asura. That's why he's never been afraid of them. I mean, think about it. They decided to blow up half the other continent instead of attacking us here. Why would they do that if they weren't afraid of Alacrya?"

Pascal rolled his eyes. "Linden, bud, you've been watching too many broadcasts…"

The conversation was interrupted by the ringing of gongs, announcing the start of the fight.

Except the combatants didn't move. Kagiso and Aadaan were standing thirty feet apart, weapons summoned to their hands. Aadaan wielded a long, thin silver spear, while black iron gauntlets formed around Kagiso's hands, sharp claws extending from the knuckles.

"What are they doing?" Mayla asked, her voice barely a whisper.

"Gauging each other," Deacon muttered, his eyes wide behind his mask. "At this level, a careless move could mean instant loss."

Aadaan moved first.

Cocking back his arm, he let his spear fly toward Kagiso. The air distorted around the spear, moving like melting ice as it coalesced into a huge wind-spear with the silver sliver at its center. At the same time, several dust devils sprang to life, circling Aadaan and spinning protectively around him.

Kagiso raised a hand. The gauntlet melted away into dozens of small, black dots, which moved to intercept the attack. Like a swarm of attacking hornets, they completely covered the spear, and when they broke apart an instant later, it was gone, and the wind around them had dissipated.

"What just happened?" Brion asked breathlessly. "I've never seen magic like that."

"Because it's Vritra magic," I answered, keeping my eyes on the battle. "Decay type. Erosion, probably wind-attribute." The others all looked at me with a mixture of surprise and curiosity. "I—"

"Read about it in a book," Linden, Brion, and Pascal all said in unison.

We all laughed for a moment, but the stadium was so quiet, it sounded unnatural, and we quickly turned our attention back to the combat field.

With a flick of his wrist, Kagiso had already sent the swarm of black dots flitting through the air toward Aadaan. They didn't even slow as they cut through his defensive cyclones like hot iron through parchment, but Aadaan just stood there grinning. There was a silver flash, and he was standing twenty feet away, his grin sharpening into a dangerous smirk.

The crowd, silent since the first introduction of the retainers, finally woke up, and the arena exploded with the noise of cheering and shouting.

"Wind Runner," Yanick breathed. "His signature regalia…"

The swarm of black dots changed direction to follow Aadaan, but, in another flash of silver, he stood fifty feet away, *behind* Kagiso.

But Kagiso hadn't been just standing around sucking his thumb while Aadaan ran. Instead, the Vritra-blooded ascender had been channeling mana into another rune, sending out tendrils of earth mana all over the combat field. I couldn't tell what he was doing, but—

Aadaan vanished in a flash as the swarm bore down on him, but a huge column of stone laced with veins of black metal burst from the combat field. There was a crack, and the column broke and fell to the ground with a crash that I felt shake the bench beneath me.

Aadaan, moving at the speed of wind, had slammed into the stone with enough force to break bones, but he didn't even look stunned. Instead, a condensed field of shimmering energy had surrounded

him. Kicking off the broken stump of the column, he hurtled toward Kagiso, exploding in a nova of pure force.

The battlefield was momentarily hidden in a cloud of dust.

"What the heck was that?" Linden asked, squinting as he tried to see through the brown cloud below.

"Some kind of force redistribution spell," Deacon answered, following the fight by holding his glasses up over his mask so he could see. "But strong. Emblem, maybe even regalia level."

A torrent of wind pushed the dust cloud out of the stadium. In the few seconds we hadn't been able to see what was happening, the arena floor had become a minefield of Kagiso's little black motes. Aadaan was stuck. There was no way he could use Wind Runner to get around in such tight quarters.

Kagiso was standing on top of the shattered stump of the column he'd conjured, basically switching places with Aadaan. His red eye gleamed.

It seemed like he had the Truacian pinned.

Then something *pulled* at the air mana all around us, everywhere. I could sense the rush of it pouring down into the arena, bombarding Kagiso's spell, the sheer amount of mana overpowering the motes' ability to erode it.

Mayla gasped and grabbed my hand, squeezing it hard, and my stomach fluttered. I peeked at her from the corner of my eye, but her gaze was on the arena, and her expression gave no sign that she was even thinking about holding my hands. Linden elbowed me from the other side, his brows bouncing up and down as he gave me a thumbs up.

Embarrassed, I thought about pulling my hand away, but…I realized that I didn't want to. It felt…nice. Really weird, but comforting, too.

When I managed to focus back on the fight, the battlefield was clear of the black motes—the overwhelming rush of mana had exhausted them, burning them out—and a slowly-revolving cyclone was beginning to spin around Aadaan. Kagiso held out his bare hand, and the clawed gauntlet reformed around it. The two eyed each other for a long moment, both warriors wary and confident in a way I found difficult to understand.

Then Aadaan grinned and pushed outward with the gathering storm.

And that was just the beginning.

The noise of the crowd ebbed and flowed as the fight stretched on, five minutes, ten, twenty. My friends and I laughed, gasped, and shouted at one another as the pace of the fight continued to build, awed by every new spell cast or rune activated, jeering when one of the fighters got the upper hand only to have the tables turned a moment later by some unexpected reversal by their opponent.

I'd never seen anything like it. And I'd never had more fun.

Mayla didn't let go of my hand until the final moments. Kagiso's defensive capabilities—his power to erode his opponent's mana and turn away even the deadliest attacks—outmatched Aadaan's mana pool. Once Aadaan could no longer use Wind Runner to flit around the arena, it was over.

Kagiso closed the distance, smashing through Aadaan's defensive wind barriers with those heavy gauntlets and crushing him to the ground. With his claws to Aadaan's throat, Kagiso looked to the high box for direction.

The crowd, which had grown quiet again, sucked in a collective, hissing breath, and Mayla turned away, pressing her face to my shoulder.

A gong sounded. Kagiso dismissed his gauntlets, and Aadaan rolled over and pushed himself up onto his knees. Sand clung to his sweat-soaked skin, and even from the stands I could see that he was shaking.

The crowd burst like a dam, flooding the arena with ecstatic cheers. Even Yanick jumped up, hopping on one leg while supporting himself on Brion's shoulder, shouting along with everyone else. "Kagiso! Kagiso! Kagiso!"

I felt a moment's disappointment when Mayla let go of my hand as she jumped up and down, her face flushed, her hair bouncing in a way I found kind of hypnotic. "That was crazy!" she yelled over the cacophonous cheers.

I leaned closer to speak without shouting. "I know, they're really on another level. I—"

"Well fought," the unseen announcer's voice said, cutting through the audience's excitement and silencing everyone in the arena. "Well fought to the prospects, Kagiso of Highblood Gwethe and Aadaan of Named Blood Rusaek. Victory goes to Kagiso!"

The two combatants bowed again to the high box where the Sovereign and Scythes were, veiled beneath thick shadows, then left the combat field, Kagiso striding confidently away, Aadaan slinking after him, his eyes downcast.

"Ssanyu the Stone Eater and Bivrae of the Dead Three, return to the field and prepare yourselves."

Ssanyu entered the arena first. He was tall with bulging muscles. He wore a chest plate that left his abs and the ridge of his runed spine exposed, along with steel plates covering most of his lower body. A kind of iron crown ringed his shaved head.

After Ssanyu reached the center, a green mist began to boil out of the ground, forming into a woman with thin, sharp limbs and a grotesque, twisted stance, like her bones were put together in the wrong shape. As if to accentuate the grossness of her figure, the black robes she wore were sheer and cut in places to reveal her ribs and spine, which stuck out of gray, sickly skin.

She snarled at Ssanyu, revealing teeth filed down to points.

Both combatants bowed to the high box, then faced each other. Vomit-colored green mist was floating around Bivrae's inhuman body,

The sound of gongs announced the beginning of the fight.

"Wait, what's he doing?" Mayla asked, standing and shielding her eyes from the sun with one hand.

"He's… surrendering…" I muttered, taken aback.

Ssanyu had gone down on one knee, his head lowered to stare at the ground under Bivrae's clawed feet. Her lips pulled back like an animal's, bearing her sharp teeth. The mists fluttered in an agitated sort of way before being drawn back into her body.

She turned to the high box, straightening as best as her twisted frame allowed.

"Ssanyu the Stone Eater yields," the voice said, it's tone perfectly flat. If the announcer was surprised, they hid it pretty well. "Victory goes to Bivrae!"

There was some grumbling from the audience, and no cheering for Bivrae as there had been for Kagiso, but the adults around us kept their complaints and conversation quiet, and I knew why. Below, Bivrae cast a challenging stare around at the audience, almost like she was daring anyone to voice their displeasure at the result loud enough for her to hear.

After a few seconds, she stalked out of the arena to a smattering of half-hearted applause.

"Un-freaking-believable," Yanick said grumpily. "And I was so excited to see Ssanyu fight. That was stupid. Is Kagiso just going to roll over and show Bivrae his belly, too?"

Deacon snorted. "We'll have to wait a bit to find out. He'll get a break to rest and recuperate, so we'll see the battles to replace Dragoth's retainer next."

Brion clapped Yanick on the back. "Everyone knows Scythe Dragoth Vritra is the most popular Scythe. I'm sure there will be a—*ooph*!" Brion grabbed his stomach as Yanick elbowed him, and everyone else laughed.

But before anything else could be said, the announcer began speaking again. "Twelve more of Alacrya's champions have challenged for the position of retainer of Vechor under Scythe Dragoth Vritra. Sovereign Kiros Vritra welcomes and invites to the field…"

The announcer began listing off the challengers, all powerful ascenders or war heroes. As each name was spoken, the prospect stepped onto the combat field and joined the growing line facing the

high box. As the last of the challengers stopped, the line bowed in unison.

"Challengers Echeron and Lancel, please remain on…"

The voice paused. I glanced at Linden, then at Mayla. She looked as confused as I felt. Something was… wrong.

"Hey, what's that?" Pascal asked, pointing into the air. "Do you feel it?"

A black speck in the sky was quickly growing in size. Other members of the audience were starting to notice it now, and thousands of voices echoed Pascal's question. A few even conjured shields, others shouting, leaving their seats, or channeling magic into runes in preparation to face what they obviously thought was a threat.

For the umpteenth time since the Victoriad started, my breath was crushed from my chest by the sudden presence of a powerful aura.

The prospects on the field scattered, activating their powers and preparing to defend themselves. A jet black comet landed in the center of the arena an instant later with an explosion of dark energy then sent them all flying like bugs. Tens of thousands of people screamed, but no one was running now. The entire audience seemed frozen, unable to do anything except watch.

The arena below was completely obscured in a cloud of dust yet again. In the high box, all four Scythes moved forward onto the balcony. Although they made no move to cast defensive magic, the sight of them—all together at once like that—made my head swim, and I worried for a second I might pass out.

Mayla's hand on my arm brought me back to myself. I put my own hand over hers and squeezed.

A nova of black flames cleared the dust, revealing a slender man—a boy, really, not so much older than most of us—with short black hair and sharp features, almost unassuming except for the untamed, hate-filled rage in his eyes…

He stepped up out of the crater he had made in the arena floor, his dark eyes sweeping the coliseum around him. Spikes of black iron thrust up from the ground with every step, and dark flames wreathed his body. The sight of that black Decay magic—so much stronger than Kagiso's—filled me with dread.

Scythe Viessa Vritra spoke first, her voice carrying effortlessly through the dead-silent stands. "Nico. Explain yourself! What in the High Sovereign's name do you think—"

"Grey!" the newcomer—Scythe Nico Vritra of the central dominion, I realized with a tremor—screamed, his voice cracking. "I know you're here! I accept your challenge, you bastard! So face me!"

Mayla's eyes went wide as dinner plates, her lips trembling. "Did h-he—"

"Grey?" Linden choked out. "Like… *Professor* Grey?"

My mind raced as every wild theory about the professor's weird meeting with Scythe Seris Vritra tumbled through it, scattered like leaves on the wind. I'd thought my classmates were completely nuts, the way they'd come up with more and more unlikely explanations for what we'd seen. But this…

Who *was* Professor Grey, really?

Scythe Dragoth Vritra smirked down at the other Scythe. "You're out of line, little Nico. This isn't how we—" His head suddenly snapped

to one of the many entrances into the combat field, his smirk turning down into an angry frown.

Someone was walking toward Scythe Nico. A man in a fur-lined white cloak and Central Academy uniform. Wheat blond hair tousled by the Scythe's raging aura, golden eyes shining from behind his mask. He walked with such confidence and purpose, his mere presence a shield against the hateful aura radiating like a sickness from Scythe Nico.

I knew him, but something in my brain wouldn't quite accept that this could be the same person I knew, who I had first met in the library before the season started, who had spent so much of his time turning a thin, weak, sickly kid into a half-decent fighter, despite looking at me like he wanted to wring my neck…

Because how could my grumpy, mysterious, emotionally distant Melee Enhancement Tactics professor be the same person now approaching Scythe Nico on the field of battle as if he weren't stepping toward death itself? I couldn't make sense of it.

But it *was* him.

Even the other Scythes didn't intervene further as Professor Grey and Scythe Nico came to stand nearly toe to toe.

"Nico," Professor Grey said with a smile that didn't quite reach his eyes. "You look like garbage, *old friend*."

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UNSANCTIONED

ARTHUR

Nico took a half step toward me, jaw tensed and a vein pulsing visibly at his temple. Black spikes thrust up out of the ground at his slightest movement, his skin tinged with faint wisps of soulfire flames. "Even after two lifetimes, you haven't changed."

The false smile fell from my face at his words, and I bit back more goading words. Any pride I'd felt at my own ingenuity in drawing Nico into this fight—one where he couldn't run away or call for backup—vanished now that he stood in front of me. His face, on which only a mere shadow of Elijah's features now remained, filled me with conflicting emotions.

He'd been my best friend in two lives, after all. First as Nico, then as Elijah. And I had failed him in both. It was those failures, in part, that had led him to become who he was now.

Hateful. Desperate. An inhuman shell of a man.

Still…I didn't blame him for hating me.

I couldn't.

I couldn't even blame him for what he'd done in this life…no matter how easy it would be to do so. He was reincarnated here only to be manipulated and used as a tool by Agrona. Fate hadn't given him the opportunity to learn from his past life's mistakes. Instead of a second chance, Nico's fear, insecurity, and rage had been manipulated into a tool and weapon from the first moments of his life.

But, regardless of how we'd both arrived at this point, we'd come much too far for apologies, for reconciliation.

Despite knowing what Tessia meant to me, Nico had aided Agrona in Cecilia's reincarnation, using Tess's body as a vessel—the ramifications of which I still didn't understand. Cecilia, who had wanted to avoid being someone else's weapon so badly she fell on my sword to do it…

And he, in his infinite selfishness and ignorance, had handed her to Agrona.

"Say something!" Nico growled, almost shouting. A burst of soulfire ate away the ground beneath him, leaving him hovering in the air.

"Like what?" I snapped, his petulant whining working at my nerves like an old wound. "That I didn't kill Cecilia? That I never meant to abandon the two of you? Would you even listen if I told you the truth? And what would it change, Nico? Certainly not the fact that you've killed thousands of innocents, that you took Tessia out of pure selfishness—"

"I just took back what was mine!" he yelled, his eyes full of dark, hateful fire. "What I was supposed to have. *That's* fate. Just as much as it is for you to die. Again."

I don't know why, but the finality of Nico's statement caused a sharp ache deep within me. I wished, in that moment, that I could undo everything that had happened. That Cecilia could have survived, and they could have run away together just like they were planning. That I wouldn't have shut them out so I could train with Lady Vera, and would have tried harder to help Nico find Cecilia when she disappeared.

There was so much I could have done differently.

But I hadn't. And although I could look backwards at the path I'd taken, I couldn't change its shape. Nor could I change where that path had brought me. But I could look forward, and make new choices—different ones—to change the direction I was headed.

Ever since waking up in the Relictombs, I'd been cold and detached. I'd had to be, I knew that. I didn't fault myself for it.

The persona of Grey was like a shield, one I wrapped around my mind, keeping out thoughts of those I couldn't help right now: Tessia, Ellie, my mother, everyone back in Dicathen…Instead, I focused on the Relictombs and pursuing the ruins as Sylvia's last message had instructed, and on understanding my new abilities and the new world I found myself in.

But it was time to go a different direction. And that started with Nico.

I couldn't help the softening of my expression, knowing the full weight of my sadness and pity was plain on my face.

"Don't. Don't look at me like that," Nico said, shaking his head in defiance. "I don't want your pity."

My body relaxed as I accepted what was about to happen. "I wish things could have turned out differently."

SERIS VRITRA

I clicked my nails together, a nervous habit from my childhood that I'd long since cured myself of, or so I thought.

Arthur's machinations had sped past my own, yet again, it seemed.

I found myself off guard, vacillating between a rushed attempt to put the pieces into place and a mute acceptance that I didn't fully understand what was happening.

Still, I had not arrived at my current station by being dense, and after giving myself a moment to ponder, I realized that Arthur's plan had really been quite simple, although effective.

Nico's stumbling and impatient alliance with the Granbehl's, who shared his hatred for Arthur. Arthur's less-than-cautious reprisal and bare attempt at a cover-up.

It would have taken more restraint than Nico could muster to build up his allies' strength enough to be a threat toward Arthur, the subterfuge working contrary to his impulsive, wrathful nature. When his ill-planned scheme failed, Arthur knew it would lead to a tantrum.

Nico had always been a temperamental boy. He embodied a weak man's concept of power, a fool's idea of intellect, and a child's view of maturity. And yet I had never discounted him. The other Scythes didn't yet see it, but none of the reincarnates were what they seemed. They were each a force of change—of chaos—in their own way.

Seeing Nico and Arthur—or Grey, who was in many ways an entirely different person than the boy I'd saved in Dicathen—standing across from each other on the battlefield, I felt a sudden thrill.

"An unscheduled interruption, but perhaps this will be an opportunity for little Nico to prove himself," Dragoth mused with a carefree laugh.

"Prove himself?" Viessa asked, her voice a low hiss. "Merely by fighting this—what is he, some kind of school teacher?—Nico embarrasses himself, and us by extension."

Sovereign Kiros let out a huff of irritation, his bored eyes traveling aimlessly around the high box, which had been appointed with every

comfort imaginable. “So long as this doesn’t slow things down too much,” he grumbled. His gaze lingered in the darkest corner of the room. “Perhaps you should go chastise your brother-in-arms.”

Cadell stepped out of the shadows and bowed to Kiros. “Forgive Scythe Nico’s impudence, Sovereign. The High Sovereign has let him off his leash too long and too often, I’m afraid.”

Kiros’s lips twisted in a wry half-smile. “Do you question the High Sovereign’s actions or judgment, Scythe?”

Cadell sank to one knee, resting both arms across the other. “No, Sovereign Kiros, of course not.”

“They’re saying something,” Melzri said, leaning against the balcony rail and turning her head slightly. “Pointless, prattling banter.” She exchanged a dark look with Viessa. “We should have beaten Nico more during his training.”

“Who is this Grey, anyway?” Dragoth asked, looking around at the rest of us. “He seems somewhat familiar.”

Cadell, once again on his feet, was watching from the shadows instead of stepping out onto the balcony with the rest of us. “A dead man,” he said simply, meeting my gaze as he spoke.

So Agrona did not confirm Arthur’s presence in Alacrya with the rest of the Scythes, but he has told Cadell. Interesting.

I wasn’t sure how much I believed Agrona’s insistence that Arthur no longer mattered to him. The High Sovereign often played his own games, some with purpose, some purely for entertainment. There were times where he worked at cross purposes to himself, perhaps simply to confuse anyone who was keeping track, including his allies,

or maybe because he enjoyed the thrill of not knowing exactly how things would unfold.

Below, Arthur pulled the white cloak from his shoulders and made it vanish with a flourish. No hint of mana or intent leaked from him, a fact the others were quick to notice as well.

"His control over mana is perfect," Viessa said, her black-on-black eyes squinting as she peered at Arthur.

I didn't try to hide my amusement at this statement, and she turned her gaze on me. It had been quite some time since I'd spoken with the Scythe from Truacia. As we matched gazes, I took in her stance, expression, and features.

Her skin was as pale as her eyes were dark, and a sea of purple hair spilled down over her shoulders and back. She was taller than me, made even taller by the heeled leather boots she wore, their teal coloring matching the runes stitched into her fine white and gray battlerobes. The black voids of her eyes were always unreadable, and emotion rarely interrupted the porcelain coldness of her face.

Of all the Scythes, Viessa was the one I was most unsure of.

But I didn't spare her any additional thought just then. There were more interesting things to focus on. "They're going to fight."

In the arena, Arthur and Nico had separated, putting twenty feet of distance between them. Nico was an inferno of black fire. Arthur could have been carved of ice.

With an angry scream, Nico hurtled forward. The ground came apart beneath him, collapsing in on itself as black spikes grew like weeds wherever his shadow touched. A vortex of black flames coiled

around and extended in front of him as he prepared to bathe Arthur in hellfire.

But Arthur did not flinch in the face of Nico's rage. I might have thought him as mad as Nico if I didn't know better.

My eyes widened and I leaned over the rail next to Melzri, well past ready to finally see for myself the power that Caera had described.

With a hungry roar, Nico's soul flames burst forward. Arthur's hand rose, and a cone of amethyst energy spilled out to meet the fire.

Where the two powers touched, they intertwined and ate away at one another, each perfectly canceling the other out.

"Impossible," Cadell grunted from behind us.

"Oh, now that's interesting," Kiros said, leaning forward on his throne. "You there, Melzri, scoot aside, you're blocking my view."

Black spikes punched out of the ground all around Arthur, but they shattered against a layer of glowing aether that tightly clad his skin.

Nico burst through the crackling cloud that remained behind after the aether and soulfire collided, a dozen more blades of black metal orbiting around him. With a shove, he sent them flying like missiles at Arthur.

A sword shimmered to life in Arthur's hand. A blade of pure aether, glowing vibrantly amethyst. The air around it warped in a way that made my eyes ache, like the blade was pressing away the fabric of the world to make room for itself. In movements so quick that most wouldn't have been able to follow, Arthur cut through spike after spike, letting the pieces careen past or ricochet harmlessly off the protective barrier over his skin.

Then Nico was on him.

Their collision sent tremors through the foundations of the stadium, and for a moment I lost sight of the action as it was happening. Arthur's weapon was a line of vibrant purple light glowing through a screen of dust. Nico was a silhouette, highlighted by the nimbus of black fire that still surrounded him.

The line of purple light intersected the dark silhouette…

Then… Nico was hurtling past Arthur, tumbling through the air like a tossed ragdoll.

Nico's body struck the arena floor with a crash, digging a deep furrow half the length of the coliseum behind Arthur.

"Wait, what happened?" Dragoth asked, his deep voice thick with confusion.

Viessa let out a slow breath. "Nico's core…"

She was right. Already, the mana was abandoning Nico. I could sense it flooding from his ruined core and disbursing into the atmosphere around him.

"Oh," Dragoth grunted. "I guess I was wrong about him proving himself."

"Shut up, you oaf," Melzri said, leaping off the railing and striking the ground below with enough force to crack it.

Finally, Arthur turned. His golden eyes followed the line of Nico's crashing descent to where the broken Scythe lay in a tangle. They fixed on Melzri, but when she stopped to kneel next to Nico's prone form, they traced a line up to the high box.

Time, which had been crawling slowly by, suddenly caught up with itself.

I heard the gasps and frightened screams of the crowd, the shouted questions of the guards and event officials seeking direction, the tumbling of stones and broken timber as tunnels beneath the combat field collapsed.

I took in Melzri's worry, Viessa's frustration, Dragoth's curiosity, Cadell's cold detachment.

I was already considering the ways in which I could get Arthur out of this, but I stopped myself. This had been a part of his plan. He would already have prepared his own method of escape, if escape was even necessary. What were my fellow Scythes going to do, after all? Nico challenged Arthur—or accepted his challenge, based on his own words. And it had been Nico who interrupted the Victoriad. Arthur had done nothing wrong… but had still sent a message.

Loud and abundantly clear, indeed.

I thought—hoped, even—that Arthur would simply walk away, ending the confrontation there before it escalated. Instead, he strode purposefully toward the high box, walking right past Melzri as she inspected Nico's wound.

"I apologize for the delay this duel has caused in today's events, but I'm afraid a further interruption is necessary," he shouted, making sure his voice carried not just up to the high box but throughout all of the coliseum.

"This *duel* was an unsanctioned challenge," Viessa answered coolly, her voice effortlessly projecting across the stadium. "Whatever the reason for your assault on our fellow Scythe, know that defeating him has earned you nothing from Sovereign Kiros or the High

Sovereign, and gives you no right to claim Scythe Nico's position, or to ask us for anything at all."

Arthur met Viessa's black eyes unflinchingly. The sharp line of his jaw was relaxed, his lips firm and straight, his stance attentive but composed. He looked for all the world like *he* was the one in charge here.

"I respect the rules you've put in place," Arthur continued, shifting so his hands were clasped behind his back, his legs in a wider, more aggressive stance. "Nevertheless, it was your own Scythe that instigated and forced me to make this challenge out of order."

Dragoth's form expanded, growing by a foot, then two. With both hands on the rail, he looked down on Arthur, his reserved curiosity clear in the set of his jaw and subtle cocking of his brow. "Fine then. What is it you want? Maybe if you beg for it, we will be—"

"No," Arthur said, his voice cutting across Dragoth's pomp like the crack of a whip.

Dragoth, always more relaxed than the other Scythes, only chuckled at this offense, a crime punishable by death in any other circumstance.

When Arthur continued, he met my eyes for a bare instant, then shifted his gaze past me to Cadell, speaking with a calm surety that belied the extraordinary nature of his request: "I only ask for what I've earned. To challenge Scythe Cadell of Central Dominion."

Viessa's lips twitched in what I thought almost might have been a frown.

Beside her, Dragoth waved dismissively toward the battlefield. "We don't have to entertain challenges from schoolteachers."

Below, Melzri was holding a vial of elixir, her hand frozen halfway to Nico's mouth, her eyes wide and mouth partially agape.

Just five minutes before, I would have assumed any conflict between Arthur and Cadell would be a one-sided victory. If Arthur would have confided his full plan to me—to not only draw Nico into a fight where no one would intervene on his behalf, but also to challenge Cadell before the entire Victoriad—I would have either dissuaded or discarded him from the tournament, if necessary.

Which, of course, is why he didn't.

Now, any recourse I may have used to remove him—or help him escape—was gone. With my gaze lingering on Melzri and Nico, I realized I could no longer be confident of Arthur's abilities. Though Nico was no Cadell, he was still a Scythe… but he had let himself be baited into an unknown situation, fallen right into Arthur's trap. Cadell would not be as foolish.

I met Cadell's eye. His frown turned down into a deep scowl. My eyebrows rose. His furrowed.

"No," he said finally, loud enough for only those of us in the high box to hear. "Scythes cannot start entertaining every challenge that comes along. To do so would demean us and give a platform to every self-important fool who—"

"Who just defeated one of us with a single blow," I cut in.

"Yeah," Dragoth said with a throaty chuckle. "Don't tell me that Cadell, the slayer of dragons, is afraid of a schoolteacher?"

"The people must be shown that we are not as weak as Nico has made us appear," Viessa added.

Cadell's eyes flashed. "This challenge is beneath me. He is not—"

Sovereign Kiros shifted. It was a small movement, but it silenced the building argument. We all turned to face him.

Kiros was as tall and broad as Dragoth, though he was softer around the middle. Thick horns grew from the sides of his head, curving up and then forward, ending in sharp points. Golden rings of varying thickness ornamented the horns, some studded with gems, others engraved with glowing runes. His golden hair was shorn close on the sides around his horns, then pulled back into a tail. Shiny red robes draped from his frame.

He popped a fat, purple fruit into his mouth, then began to speak as he chewed, dribbling juice down his chin. "Go. This strange little man has caught my interest. I'd like to see more of what he can do, so don't end things too quickly."

Cadell stood ramrod straight, then bowed deeply before turning and stepping off the balcony. Regardless of his own desire, he couldn't refuse Kiros's order.

It was with a deepening sense of apprehension that I watched Cadell float out over the battlefield, looking down on Arthur. He waited as Melzri scooped up Nico—or the boy's body, I couldn't tell, there was no mana circulating within him—and withdrew from sight.

"I accept." Cadell's voice was strained and bitter. "But this battle"—he paused, letting the words hang in the air with him—"will be to the death."

The held breath of the rattled audience was audible.

"Yeah," Arthur answered, taking several steps back toward the center of the half-ruined combat field. "It certainly will be."

Cadell wasted no time, gave no warning. An aura of black flames ignited the air, both surrounding Cadell and billowing out and down in a wide cone. The arena floor where Arthur stood was obliterated, the earth blackened and burned away, leaving a widening crater the length of the battlefield, Arthur vanishing within it.

The crowd gasped as the inferno dissipated.

Arthur had not moved, except he was now standing at the bottom of a deep crater. His body was undamaged, and no soulfire mana burned within him, eating away his life force as it should have.

I had to bite back a chagrined smile at the sight.

It had been a good trick. From where Cadell was, with his vision obscured by his own attack, he probably hadn't even seen, and the movement had been much too fast for anyone in the audience to follow, even with strong magic enhancing their vision. For a blink, just long enough for the wave of fire to pass, Arthur had vanished with a flash of purple lightning.

Caera had mentioned this ability, but the incredible speed and control Arthur exerted astonished even me.

This growing feeling of ignorance gnawed at me from the inside. What exactly was it that Arthur had done? How could he do what even the dragons could not? What more had he hidden from everyone?

The soulfire aura around Cadell flared as he dove, expanding behind him like giant wings. Fiery claws extended outward from his hands. His figure, flames and all, dimmed, turning to shadow as the Decay-based fire ate away at the light itself.

Arthur shifted, his legs separating, his hands clenching into fists. Again, the bright blade of aether shimmered into existence.

The two vanished in a nebulous cloud of black-purple fire and lightning.

The crowds screamed as the shields keeping them from being vaporized by the aftershock trembled and flickered.

Behind me, I heard the rustling of Kiros's robes as he inched forward on his throne.

Arthur reappeared first.

My jaw clenched and my fingers sank into the decorative railing, twisting the metal until it sheared in my grip.

His uniform had been ripped from his stomach up to his ribs. Soulfire danced along the wound, burning into him. It would keep going, igniting his blood and scorching his mana channels until it reached his core. Eventually, it would consume his life force, killing him from the inside out.

As the combusting cloud of mana and aether fizzled out, I caught sight of Cadell on the other side of the arena, hovering thirty feet in the air. One hand was pressed to his neck, and blood was oozing from between his fingers. He grimaced with pain, but there was a vindictive gleam in his eyes. Already, I could see the purple-tinged black flames licking at his wound, healing it.

But Cadell wasn't the only one healing. The soulfire burning in Arthur's side dimmed as waves of purple light washed over it, dousing it bit by bit until the flames were quenched. Then, as if the wound had been nothing but a line drawn in sand, the same waves wiped it away, leaving Arthur's flesh clean and unblemished.

“Fascinating,” Kiros mumbled. “Some surprise of the High Sovereign’s, perhaps? A staged fight to highlight some new magic he has unlocked?” I glanced at the Sovereign. His eyes were alight with curiosity and wonder, his lips curved into a silly smile. “What a wonderful surprise,” he added, drumming his palms against his knees with excitement.

Everything was a game to the Sovereigns. That’s what came of a life lived completely disconnected from real consequences. Especially to the basilisks of the Vritra Clan, who looked at the world like one big laboratory, everything inside of it an experiment. War, disease, natural disasters…little more than opportunities for the Vritra to dissect the aftereffects.

My mind tried to turn back to the last war between Vechor and Sehz-Clar, as it often did when I pondered both past and future, but I pushed the thoughts away, focusing instead on the scene unfolding before me.

Arthur had turned to face Cadell, who was slowly drifting toward him, his nose wrinkled in a sour expression as he tried and failed to hide his surprise at Arthur’s survival.

Arthur’s form shimmered, a transformation akin to how the asura were able to shift matter and take on pure, mana-empowered forms. I sucked in a breath, momentarily taken aback as black scales grew over his skin and onyx horns jutted from the sides of his head, pointing forward and down to frame his jaw.

Then he moved, gold shimmering between the black scales, and I felt off my guard again—a sensation I was not accustomed to, and yet seemed to happen with aggravating frequency in relation to Arthur.

His armor was magnificent, its manifestation a wonder to behold, carrying the same elegance and prestige as the asuras themselves.

Arthur adjusted his stance and conjured a sword, which cast its purple light over the blackened and battle-scarred ground. “I’ve learned a few tricks since we last met,” Arthur said, his voice resonant in the ethereal silence. “I hope you have as well, otherwise this will be over far too soon.”

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THE VICTORIAD ENDS

ARTHUR

Cadell stiffened at the sight of the relic armor, taken aback by my transformation. I could see his jaw working as his teeth ground together, the frustration he felt emanating from him like heat from a flame.

"Your tricks are a mockery to the asura, boy," he said scornfully as his form crackled with energy.

But his voice was muffled, smothered by the sound of blood rushing to my head. The world blurred and my eyes locked onto Cadell—the first true monster that I had laid eyes upon in this world.

I hurled myself into the air to meet him as Cadell fell from the sky like a bolt of dark lightning.

A wave of black fire roiled out from his hand. I countered it with an aetheric blast before slashing at his throat with my aether blade. However, Cadell's body dissipated like smoke, vanishing into the flames still filling the sky.

My arms blurred as I slashed around me, shredding the flames like silk curtains.

But when Cadell reappeared, it was from behind me. His hand, wreathed in fiery claws, plunged into my side, through the armor and aether, and curled up into my ribs. Ignoring the pain, I reversed the aether blade and stabbed back and down, barely missing his chest as he flew away from me.

I willed myself to follow, to fly, to simply *ignore* the restraints of this world as the djinn manifestation had instructed, but gravity pulled me back down.

With a roar of frustration, I flung the aether blade after him, which immediately began to dissolve after leaving my grip.

I hit the ground with another weapon already conjured, and threw myself after the Scythe, swinging with abandon, carving through the cloud of soulfire. But my weapon never found purchase, and again Cadell coalesced from the blaze to strike, this time raking fiery claws across my arm, nearly severing it at the elbow.

Dismissing the aether blade from my injured arm and conjuring it again in the other, I thrust at Cadell's chest with the full force of my momentum as I careened like a catapult stone through the air, but he burst into black flames and vanished back into the burning cloud.

I landed in the midst of the ruined arena floor fifty feet away, cursing loudly.

Cadell's form warped in my vision—the afterimages of how he had looked before he massacred the people in the castle, before he killed Buhnd, before he killed Sylvia all overlapping. He was responsible for so many deaths, including what was supposed to be mine had Sylvie not sacrificed herself for me.

Death wouldn't be enough for him. I needed to crush him, to make him feel weak and helpless, just as I had felt. Here, In front of all of Alacrya, Cadell would suffer.

Blood and aether rushed through my limbs as the emotions I had been suppressing all this time threatened to overwhelm me. It

wasn't Destruction this time trying to overtake my sense of self. It was me.

The cloud of fire dissipated, revealing Cadell hovering over the battlefield, a blade in each hand. One was the same black iron that Uto and Nico favored, but the other was void-black, like a piece of night sky carved into the shape of a longsword.

"You are a *lesser* to the end," Cadell spat.

Letting loose an aetheric blast for cover, I burst across the ground before leaping at him, my blade poised.

We crashed together.

Black and purple sparks flew as aether impacted against his soulfire-sheathed weapons. I slashed and stabbed, but each furious blow was deflected. A dozen new wounds opened up across my body, but they hardly mattered.

Then I was hurtling away in the air.

The tip of the void-black weapon was embedded in my chest, and it was growing, carrying me along with it. Ten feet, twenty, fifty, a hundred, until I slammed high against one of the huge shield walls that protected the crowd of onlookers.

But the lance continued to expand, growing through me, pressing into the shield so hard that it began to quiver. My armor was peeled away as the lance grew wider, ripping a hole in my chest.

My aether blade lashed out, but the void-black material shifted, moving and reforming around my sword. I hacked at it wildly, like an untrained boy trying to split a log. My head began to pound, my pulse racing, each beat of my heart sending blood pumping out around the edges of the lance.

Then an icy coldness was pouring from my core, washing over the hot rage, dousing it in a focused kind of detachment.
A shadow loomed over me.
Regis, in his pure Destruction form. Huge wings of black shadow kept him effortlessly aloft. His massive, fang-filled maw opened and a gout of Destruction blazed across the lance. The violet flames raced in both directions, devouring the lance. I felt, for an instant, the hunger of those flames dancing in my open chest cavity, licking the inside of my wound, reaching downward toward my core.
Then I was falling.
I hit the ground on my back, collapsing in a heap.
Regis floated above me protectively, and I could see his clash with Cadell, holding off another attack with a blast of Destruction.
'After patronizing Nico… look at you.' His voice was an inferno in my head. *'Get a hold of yourself.'*
I spit up a mouthful of blood as the hole in my chest slowly grew back together, bones fusing, organs reseating themselves. Finally, I was able to take a deep, heady breath. And through each breath after, I realized, through these last reckless exchanges, I had channeled too much of my aether into my attacks, ignoring my wounds and neglecting my armor.
Despite where I was and how the situation was unfolding, I laid in the ash and rubble for a moment more and let the rage that had overtaken me fizzle into frustration and embarrassment.
What had been the point of growing stronger, learning aether arts, obtaining relics, if all I was going to do was hack blindly in rage?
Yeah. I'm good now, I sent Regis with a sobering sigh.

Clearheaded but still incapacitated, I continued to draw in aether from the atmosphere while studying the battle above.

Purple flames erupted from Regis's jaws as a barrage of void-black missiles swarmed like a flock of corrupted ravens, spinning and darting around the purple flames, but not fast enough.

Destruction leapt from one to the next, burning Cadell's Decay-attribute magic to nothing, then chasing Cadell up into the sky, forcing him to retreat. Patches of purple flame burned in the arena and over the shields, but they were quickly doused by my companion.

I'd faced both soulfire and the black metal before, but the changeable, gusting black magic was a different attribute, likely wind, which meant Cadell could control at least three different elements. And he could combine them, like his ability to fuse soulfire and wind to meld into the atmosphere.

His power was more versatile than mine, but mana didn't offer strong protection against aether. All it would take was a single decisive blow to defeat Cadell, just as I had Nico.

The sky above grew dark. Cadell flew at the center of a hurricane of blustering Decay-infused wind, which coalesced like an impenetrable cloud.

He jerked his hand downward, and a rain of black spikes and soulfire was launched from the cloud like a downpour of ballista bolts. Coal-black lines of infernal wind chased the burning spikes, pushing them faster and faster as they fell.

The coliseum trembled as the black spikes slammed into the ground around the edges of the ruined stadium floor, some glancing off the

walls or punching through the shield protecting the closest seats. A black sphere momentarily wrapped around the high box, and any spikes that struck it dissolved, the soulfire flickering out like expired candles.

But over Regis and me, a shield of Destruction devoured everything that came in contact with it, keeping us both safe.

'I know you've got your deep physical and psychological injuries to sort out, but I have a limit you know,' Regis thought with a mental grunt of exhaustion.

I noticed the shimmering, smokey apparition before Regis did.

Cadell solidified from the gloom still cast by the clouds overhead, swinging down with a burning black blade. Activating God Step, I appeared just before him, catching the attack with an aetheric sword.

I was just waiting for you to tap out, I answered, straining under the force of Cadell's blow.

The shadow wolf dissolved, becoming immaterial and drifting into my body. *'Since you're back to making crappy jokes, I assume you've got it from here?'* Despite his banter, I could sense the fatigue setting into my companion. He was near the end of his strength.

Black metal spikes burst out of the ground between us. My sword swept cleanly through them, but it gave Cadell time to step back and bring up his own sword. "Your new bond is a rather crude excuse of a beast."

"I think the word you're looking for is 'majestic'," I quipped, hurtling forward and unleashing a flurry of cuts and jabs, pressing him further back. He tried to fly up into the air, but God Step allowed me to cut

him off, pushing him back toward the ground where we were on more even footing.

Cadell may have been more versatile, but I was the better swordsman.

Driving the aether blade into his ribs, I tried to slash sideways and cut him in half, but his hands closed around my arm, holding me there.

Our eyes locked, and I took in the snide, cruel expression that seemed permanently affixed to his pale gray face. His chin jutted out proudly between the serrated horns that curled around below his ears. But the air of absolute confidence he usually exuded was long gone. He was worried.

And he was afraid.

I noticed the shadow almost too late.

God Stepping away just as a spike several times the size of my body would have struck me, I watched from above as, instead, it crashed into the arena floor, dragging Cadell down into a huge crater.

Cracks snaked out from the crater, running beneath the stands and making the entire coliseum shift and tremble. Somewhere, metal sheared and wood snapped, and two sections of the stadium seating began to separate.

The forgotten audience screamed as the shield protecting them flickered and vanished, only to be replaced by dozens of smaller shields as the mages leaped into action.

The underworks collapsed, opening fissures in the coliseum walls and causing large portions of the seating to sag. A few people had the wits to run for the exits, but most were still frozen where they sat or stood. I noticed Seth, Mayla, and some of my other students

hunkering together beneath a clear panel of mana being cast by an older mage, their mouths agape, awe etched on their distant faces.
Something shifted in the shadows as I caught myself along the edge of one of the hundreds of black spikes sticking up from the floor. A creature, more shadow than man, crawled out into the light and stretched long, thin limbs tipped with jagged claws.
The shadows around Cadell twisted and bit at the air like flames. "Enough." His voice grated like teeth shearing through bone. "There are no dragons around to save you this time, boy."
Cadell's shadow-clad arms spread wide, and black fire began to boil out of him. His corrupted magic spilled like burning tar into what was left of the arena and splashed against the shields protecting the staging areas, the light of which crackled inconsistently as the shields reached the end of their capabilities.
I felt an icy claw clutch at my insides as I remembered the last desperate moments of my battle against Nico and Cadell, racing away from this same hellfire conflagration with Tessia, desperately exhausting the last of my strength. Only this time, Cadell wasn't holding back.
Regis emerged beside me, fiery hackles raised but only barely able to hold his normal form.
My brows furrowed as I glanced down at my companion. *Regis. You shouldn't—*
'Relax, Princess. I'm no martyr; I'm your weapon, remember?'
Flashes of instructions blazed in my mind like a branding iron, showing me glimpses of Regis in a dark forest clearing.
This is… How did—

My vision darkened as Cadell's shadowy form barreled toward us.
'It's not perfected, but it'll probably still work. Just do it!'
As the flood of hellfire was almost on us, Regis closed his eyes, his lupine body growing shadowy and see-through as it became incorporeal. I raised the aetheric blade in my hand, but rather than attacking, I reeled back and…
I plunged the aetheric blade into my companion.
His body flared before enveloping my sword until the aetheric blade grew larger and was sheathed in dark violet flames.
"It doesn't matter how many more tricks you pull out, lesser!" Cadell roared as his shadowy, demonic form neared.
My grip tightened around the Destruction-clad sword and a shared sense of a cold, emotionless void wiped my senses clear of anything other than Cadell. His long, taut limbs of flickering obsidian, his jagged horns that had grown twice in size, and the aura of soulfire wrapped around him like wings—I took it all in.
Cadell unleashed his arsenal of spells with abandon—a volley of blood iron, a maelstrom of void wind, a barrage of soulfire—but it was useless.
The dark violet sword in my hand arced in jagged flames as my body blurred. Concise, wasteless movements carried behind the small openings carved out by my new sword.
Arcs of violet tore through every spell spat out by the Scythe, and his gleaming red eyes widened in fear more each time.
Ignoring the icy grip around my core, I let God Step carry me right in front of Cadell's distorted visage. I raised my sword over my head, Destruction blooming in a blaze of violet. His ghoulish black arms

crossed in front of him, wreathed in soulfire, black metal spikes materializing like shields.

The blade came down, passing through the black spikes as if they were nothing but mist. I struck him with the full force of my strengthened body, flooding every muscle with aether. He was crushed to the ground, and a shockwave rippled outward from us, toppling the thirty-foot-tall spike that jutted up just behind Cadell.

Screams filled the stadium as part of the coliseum collapsed, dragging down the thousands of people seated there, swallowing several private boxes, and filling the coliseum with a thick cloud of dust.

Cadell struggled to regain his feet. His arms were flickering with soulfire and Destruction. He flailed desperately, like he could shake the purple flames away. His body flickered in and out of incorporeality, but the Destruction clung to him, his own outpouring of mana the only thing keeping him from being consumed.

The Scythe's face was pale as he shivered, and the shadows clinging to him melted away as he returned to his normal form. His scarlet eyes were full of fear, his usual snide face a mask of desperation. Turning away, he stared up at the high box, perhaps hoping the other Scythes or even the Sovereign would appear to save him.

As I looked down on him, I felt only the cold acceptance of justice finally fulfilled. "This is for Sylvia."

The violet flames flickering jerkily around the aether blade grew even more agitated as I thrust forward. It plunged through his chest and burst out of his back. Destruction leapt across him, devouring Cadell from the chest outward. There was no blood, no gore of internal

organs spilling out, just the cleansing flames of Destruction wiping him away as if he had never existed.

No, I thought, *not quite like that*. The stain of Cadell's existence would always be on this world, visible by the holes he had left in it.

"Sorry it took so long," I said, watching in my mind's eye as Sylvia's draconic eyes shined with tears as a portal drew me in, her last words echoing in my mind: "Thank you, my child." My guilt for what I couldn't do then lessened, but I knew it would never leave me entirely.

I pulled the sword from Cadell's chest and swept it over his head, shearing off both horns. Regis, sensing my intention, withheld Destruction, leaving them whole.

Then he was gone, nothing but the severed horns remaining.

Regis drifted out of the sword as it disappeared, moving back into my body near my core, his aether exhausted, no words necessary to express how either of us felt in this moment.

I bent down to retrieve the horns and stowed them in my dimension rune. A deep, crushing fatigue settled over me as my gaze swept across the broken coliseum.

Dozens of mages swarmed over the collapsed section, working to pull survivors from the rubble. The shields, those still functional at all, were flickering in and out. The rest of the audience was in shock, their eyes either following me or boring into the place where Cadell had been.

There was movement in the high box—one of the only untouched spaces in the entire coliseum—and my attention settled there.

A huge man with ornamented horns thrusting forward from the sides of his head moved into the dust-filled light. He was wearing a loose-fitting robe and a hungry smile. Though suppressed, his aura was heavy enough to bend the heads and shoulders of every Alacryan in the stadium. This was a Sovereign, Kiros Vritra of Vechor.

He was underwhelming, compared to the likes of Aldir, Kordri, and Lord Indrath.

I kept my eyes just slightly averted, not downcast or in a bow like the tens of thousands of Alacryans around me, but I didn't meet his eyes.

The slow, resounding clap that came from the high box caught me by surprise.

Kiros was *applauding*. His smile widened to a grin as his hands came together faster and faster. A confused and mistimed smattering of applause followed from the audience.

"Amazing!" Kiros said, his voice projecting effortlessly through the coliseum and silencing the weak applause. "A beautiful display of power. Such unexpected death! And delivered with—"

A pearlescent oval opened over the arena floor, twenty feet in front of the high box.

Kiros frowned.

Two figures stepped through.

The first was someone I had never seen in person before, but I knew him instantly, and the mere sight of him was enough to sober me from my fatigue.

Agrona's horns splayed out from his head like an elk's, the dozens of sharp black points ornamented with chains and rings. He had strong, sharp features that reminded me uncomfortably of Sylvie.

The second, I was less prepared for.

Tessia looked exactly as she had when I'd last seen her, speaking to her people from a balcony in Elenoir. She wore form-fitting battlerobes, similar to the dress worn by Seris, except the individual "scales" were emerald green and shaped like little leaves. The battlerobes left her arms bare, showing off the faintly glowing runes I'd noticed in my vision.

Although she looked the same—gunmetal gray hair draped down her back and over her shoulders, braids tucked behind her pointed ears, shining teal eyes—she was immediately and unequivocally *not* Tessia.

Tessia…

Tessia was a princess. She'd grown up in the royal palace in Zestier, been tutored in the manners of customs of elven, dwarven, and human nobility. That grace extended to the way she held herself, the resting expression of her face, the cadence of her walk…

But all that was gone now.

Instead, this person masquerading as my oldest friend moved with aggressive confidence—not the Cecilia of my youth, but not far removed from the young woman I had battled in the King's Tournament. Whatever harm that experience had done to her mentally, clearly it had carried through into this life, no doubt fostered by Agrona, just as Nico's misplaced rage had been.

Logically, I understood what I was looking at.

But the cold, distrustful look Cecilia gave me from Tessia's eyes still drove a knife through my chest.

Agrona's appearance wasn't unexpected, necessarily, but Tessia—Cecilia…

I had buried her too deep, labeled her a problem that could only be resolved in the future when I'd had more time to consider…

Could Tessia even *be* saved? Was she still in there, somewhere? And if she could…was protecting her more important than depriving Agrona of the Legacy?

I hadn't been ready to face these questions.

I still wasn't.

Regis tugged at my core. *'This is dangerous, Art. If we push ourselves much farther…'*

I should have been afraid. There was no way I could fight Agrona. I wasn't even sure that I could fight Cecilia, knowing nothing about her powers in this world. But I wasn't frightened. If anything, Agrona's willingness to appear here in person simplified things greatly for me.

It meant there was only one path forward, that I was free of the burden of deciding what to do after the Victoriad.

Kiros's voice boomed, shaking the already unstable stadium. "Vechor welcomes the High Sovereign. All hail Agrona Vritra!"

People fell on their faces to properly bow throughout the stands, their voices echoing back: "All hail Agrona Vritra!"

"I guess I finally got your attention," I said into the silence that followed.

Agrona smirked. He rested one hand on the small of Cecilia's back, and her arms came up in a complicated gesture.

Something happened in my core. It felt like a pinprick of light, burning right in the middle of me. Cecilia's hands went wide, and that pinprick expanded into an orb of white light that completely surrounded and encapsulated me, pushing away the dust and dirt. Little eddies of wind and bursts of flame manifested around the outside of the sphere, with moisture condensing against it to drip down, like the outside of a window on a dewy morning.

Clear crystal bars thrust up out of the ground in a square with me at the center. The crystal had a liquid smoothness to it, turning just above my head so the bars all ran together, forming a cage.

Uncertain, I took hold of the bars. They were cold as ice and vibrating with energy. I pulled. They didn't break.

'It's some kind of mana nullification,' Regis thought with a sense of exhausted wonder.

Though I couldn't sense the mana she'd just displaced, I was pretty sure Regis was right. Cecilia had pulled all the mana out of the atmosphere, even out of my body… If I still relied on a mana core, this single spell would have left me powerless. I couldn't even begin to wrap my mind around how such a thing was even possible.

Agrona's smirk sharpened. "Was this all done just for me? I'm flattered, *Grey*. For a lesser, your over-inflated sense of self-importance is astounding. But you seem to have tried very hard to get my attention. And, well, now you have it." Agrona's head cocked to the side a fraction of an inch, sending the tinkling of golden chains rustling through the deadly-silent coliseum. "I find myself quite eager to see how your new abilities function. I'll take great pleasure in dismantling you piece by piece to find out."

'We should go,' Regis thought.

I glanced around the stadium. First, my gaze landed on Mayla, Seth, Deacon, and the others. Though still bowing, Seth was staring at me, his eyes wide with confusion and fear. I wished suddenly that I had been kinder to him. He had a warrior's heart, and didn't deserve the hand life had dealt him.

I found Valen and Enola, their bloods' private boxes close to one another. Though kneeling to their High Sovereign, both students were practically pressed against the transparent shields protecting them, staring down at me just like Seth.

I was surprised to see Caera with one foot on the scorched dirt of the combat field, fallen into a kneel at Agrona's appearance, which must have interrupted her rushing out to check on me. She, too, risked lifting her head just enough to watch me. There was genuine terror in her scarlet gaze as her lips moved in some silent prayer.

Hopefully, she wouldn't hate me for what I had to do. I regretted not telling her who I was, but even now I couldn't say what her reaction would have been. It could be that she would have turned against me, and I would have ended up regretting telling her instead.

She had been a good friend to me, if a true friend could be based on a foundation of lies. I could only hope my gaze properly expressed that sentiment.

While I'd been gazing around the coliseum, the Scythes had flown out of the high box and maneuvered around the arena floor to box me in.

Seris's face was unreadable, her thoughts carefully hidden. Melzri had left Nico's side, and was staring at me with open hatred. Dark

energy writhed like wet tentacles around Viessa, though her gaze was on Agrona instead of me, waiting patiently for his command. Last was Dragoth, frowning down at the dark stain that had once been Cadell.

One thing was consistent through all of their expressions, even Seris's—an edge of uncertainty undercutting their usually unshakable confidence.

Before following Regis's advice, I again met Cecilia's eyes, searching within them for something. Some sign. I had made a promise. But I didn't even know if the woman to whom I'd promised myself was alive in her own body.

Agrona waved for the Scythes to take me. "I'll admit, I'm ever so slightly disappointed. I expected you'd have yet another trick up your sleeve. Still, even if what I've witnessed from you so far is the extent of your abilities, I'm sure I'll find dissecting you a useful distraction."

I had to decide. It was time to leave. I could go without her, turning my back on the question entirely, trusting that there would still be a chance to answer it in the future.

Or I could try to take her with me, try and find some way to pull Cecilia out of Tess's body, bring her back…

Or…

I grew slightly sick at the thought.

But it was the clearest path forward, the most decisive measure. I could assure that Agrona couldn't use Tessia *or* Cecilia, that whatever power the Legacy had couldn't be controlled.

I felt my eyes grow wet, but I hardened my heart.

Forgive me, Tessia.

Bracing myself, I channeled aether throughout my exhausted body. Every muscle and joint protested angrily, and I struggled to focus on the complex interweaving of aether and physical form required to use the Burst Step technique.

Remembering what it had been like struggling to teach myself in the forests of Epheotus, I knew what might happen if I wasn't precise, or if my strength failed…

The cage bars were unnaturally strong. But my armor and asuran physique protected me as I crashed through them, sending crystalline shards spraying in every direction. Mid-step, I conjured the aether blade, drew it back, aimed for her core.

Her teal eyes followed me every inch of the way, as if she were able to trace my progress even when using Burst Step. When the tip of my sword was pressed against her sternum, her eyes widened and flashed green. Mossy green veins spread out across her face beneath her skin and, for an instant, she looked… resigned as a strained smile graced her painted lips.

Her body trembled, her hand rising not for the blade—not in defense—but toward my face. A caress. "Art, please…"

It was Tessia's voice.

I released the aether blade. She held my eyes for a heartbeat, two, then…

The green veins receded, her eyes returned to their natural color, one hand went to the tear in her battlerobes where my sword had nearly pierced her. Tess—Cecilia took a step back, giving me a look of deepest loathing.

“Oh, that *was* close, wasn’t it?” Agrona said, amused. “You really thought for a second you could do it, didn’t you?” Agrona’s arm snaked around Cecilia’s shoulder and pulled her to his side. “You’re only cold-hearted and calculating when it’s easy, Grey. In reality, you’re weak, emotional, and rather prone to attachment.”

I looked down at my empty hand, my mind blank except for Agrona’s words.

What should have been a moment of victory instead rang hollow and empty, filling my mouth with the taste of cold ashes.

“Take him,” Agrona ordered. The Scythes closed in.

Agrona’s confident smirk finally slipped away as I activated God Step. He reached for me, his power suddenly unleashed, the weight of his intent making even Kordri’s King’s Force feel amateurish in comparison.

His look of astonishment was the last thing I saw as the aetheric pathways took me far away from the coliseum and the Victoriad.

374
AFTERWARDS

TESSIA ERALITH

I stood lifelessly, unmoving as if paralyzed, my eyes unseeing as my thoughts turned inward.

Agrona was shouting, but through the blood rushing through my head, his words were muffled like thunder in the distant mountains.

This man who'd supposedly been my friend once—I ignored the nagging sense that almost every memory of him continued to elude me—had tried to kill me. Again. But more disturbing than that, I had lost control of my own body.

I had almost let him run me through. But no, that wasn't entirely true—*she* had almost let him run me through.

Choppy and full of turmoil, my thoughts raced back along the short span of my new life, and I realized she'd always been there, hidden inside this body, tangled up within the elderwood guardian's will. Rooted inside me.

And she'd taken over. Just for a second, but long enough to show me she was more than her memories.

But that was wrong. This body…Nico and Agrona said it had belonged to an enemy combatant, a princess, but she'd been wounded in the fighting, her body living on but her mind gone…

Lies, always lie—

Now that I could fully sense her, knew what she was, I recognized this thought as hers, not my own, and silenced it. I thought about how it had felt for Agrona to muffle the memories, which had constantly plagued me in the first days after my reincarnation.

Reaching for this feeling again, I instinctively wrapped the beast will in mana, creating a dampening barrier between her mind and mine.
My thoughts are my own, no one else's, I thought angrily.
There was no reply.
I drew in a deep breath. The stadium smelled like tar and cold ash, overwhelming the subtle fragrances of ambient mana still in a disarray after the battle.
Agrona glanced in my direction, frowning slightly. Beyond him, I saw, in the stands, rows and rows of bystanders, still kneeling, some slumped over, clearly passed out from Agrona's intent. Those faces I could see—the ones brave enough to raise their head in the presence of the High Sovereign—were tired masks of fear and wonder.
"What did you sense from him, Cecil?"
I shook my head and a loose strand of gunmetal gray hair tumbled into my vision. *Maybe I should have it dyed?* I thought to myself, before remembering that Agrona was waiting on me. "Nothing. I sensed no mana from him at all, even when he was clearly using magic." I paused, searching Agrona's blazing scarlet eyes. "Would you have let him kill me?"
His gaze went back to the sky, searching. "You were never in danger. I knew he would try, and I knew he would fail."
Nodding, I turned away. My breath caught as I noticed Nico's prone and battered form lying just within one of the many staging areas surrounding the combat field. I took a step toward him, but Agrona took hold of my elbow.

Without looking at me, he said, “Leave him. The boy is no longer of any value to either of us.”

Scowling, I shook free of Agrona’s hold. “He matters to me, Agrona, and so he should matter to you.”

Floating up from the ground, I flew over the field of spikes and charred earth, then drifted to a knee at Nico’s side. His breath was halting and ragged, and his dark hair stuck out wildly. Sweat beaded across his pale, dirty face

There was a blood-stained hole in his armor, just above his sternum. The wound was no longer bleeding, already healing around the edges, but whatever elixir he’d been given couldn’t save his core. The mana ignored him. A few particles of earth mana clung to his skin, some blue water mana trailed the flow of blood in his veins, but his core was empty. Broken and useless.

“I’m sorry, Nico,” I said, wiping a spot of grime from his cheek. “I should have protected you. You get so…*angry*…I should have realized you were going to do something like this.”

Nico’s chest was rising and falling. His eyelids fluttered. All around him, mana lay heavy in the ground, blew on the breeze, basked in little fires left burning from Cadell and Grey’s fight…

But none of it was drawn into his mana veins or fueled his body via his channels. The runes etched into his flesh sat empty and manaless as well, no different from the plain ink tattoos of my previous world.

That wasn’t fair. That wasn’t *right*.

I felt Agrona’s oppressive power approaching from behind, could sense his curiosity even without looking at him. His gaze was like a spotlight, lighting up the world wherever it turned. “After all his

work and pain to grow stronger, Nico will never use magic again." Agrona didn't sound sad, made no attempt to affect emotion at all, merely commenting on the fact.

His words rang hollow in my ears. A wound that didn't even kill the body shouldn't be able to steal a mage's magic. To give someone this gift only to snatch it away from them? It was a fate worse than death.

Agrona was speaking again, but I couldn't process his words through the spiraling of my thoughts. My vision tunneled on the motes of mana lingering around Nico. There was something *here*, some potential, something only I could do.

My body began to move as if in a trance, drawn by some deeper instinct. My hand drifted to Nico's sternum, then my fingers pushed down into the still-healing wound. They moved down through his warm insides until they bumped against something hard: his core.

Blue, red, green, and yellow motes swirled around us, floating like glowing pollen in the air, then began flowing into his mana veins, winding their way through his body and back into his broken core. With the mana, I could feel the black scar marring his core and the roughness within it, filled with clotted and hardened blood.

The core itself—this strange organ found in this world but not in my last—didn't react to the presence of the mana. It was as if the core were dead, despite Nico's other organs continuing to function. Normally, a failed organ would cause a cascade of other failures, eventually resulting in death. But humans were capable of surviving without a mana core…

I had been reincarnated into a body with a fully formed, beautifully silver core, and so had never needed to form my own. The reincarnation process itself—or perhaps my status as the Legacy—had near-instantly purified the body's silver core to white. But the lingering mana surrounding Nico's core felt like a blueprint for what it used to be… for what it could *still* be.

Using the mana like steel wool, I scoured the dried blood from the inside while burning away the residue with careful ignition of fire-attribute mana.

Nico let out a low moan and twitched, but remained unconscious, which I was glad for. This process wasn't quick. My ability to master new techniques, however, was, and within a couple of minutes I had cleansed the inside of the core.

The core itself was harder. Like one that had just been newly formed, the hard walls of the organ were contaminated with blood.

Taking hold just of the water mana, I pulled them *through* the core walls. Each individual particle leeched out some of the trapped blood, and the more I repeated the process, the cleaner and clearer Nico's core grew.

This was a slower process, and so I stopped when his core was still a murky yellow color. For now, I just needed to know it would work.

But the presence of the cleaned core and mana alone did not seem to spark anything within him. He rested uneasily, his brows pinched and mouth curved downward in an uncomfortable frown.

Alacryans, unlike the humans in Dicathen, were born with their mana cores in place: One of the many mutations caused by Agrona's experimentation and crossbreeding. The bestowals did the work of

activating the natural core, harnessing mana for the mage so they could tap into the runes' powers. In Dicathen, however, I knew that young mages meditated to collect and purify mana until they "awakened," using the mana itself to manifest the core.

Reaching outward, I called to the mana filling the stadium, drawing it to me in swirling streams. I again siphoned it through Nico's mana veins, into his core, and then out again through his channels and into his runes until his body was glowing with it, his dark features alight from the inside.

I heard the Scythes returning, but Agrona waved off their excuses and conjectures. He was focused entirely on me, his mind probing mine curiously.

I ignored it.

The shields—those that had survived the battle—dimmed as I stole the mana from them. Mana powered lighting artifacts flickered and went out. Imbued artifacts failed. I stopped only at drawing mana directly from the cores of the shivering, frightened people in the stands, otherwise taking every particle of mana I could reach and pouring it into Nico.

His eyes flickered open. "Cecilia?"

He began to cough. I released his core and slowly pulled my hand from his chest, carelessly wiping his blood off on my battlerobes. "I've done my part, Nico. I need your help now. Draw in mana, take control of it. Can… can you do that?"

Nico took a deep breath, choked, and coughed some more. "I can't feel it."

Taking his hand, I squeezed hard enough for it to hurt. “Children on the other continent can manipulate the mana in their bodies before they form a core. Surely, you can too.” Seeing the confidence leave his gaze, I spat the last words, trying to spark a fire in Nico. “Grey accomplished it in the body of a three-year-old, didn’t he?”

By the way he tensed, I was sure it had worked. Nico glared at me, then closed his eyes. A heartbeat passed, then two, then… the mana I had condensed into his body rippled. A small movement at first, like a light breeze over the surface of a pond, but it was enough to bring a smile to my face.

“What exactly did you do?” Agrona asked as he leaned down next to me and rested his hand between my shoulder blades.

I explained the process as best I could, keeping my voice low so Nico could focus. “But I’m not exactly sure if it’s working yet.”

“Once again, your reign over mana surprises even me,” Agrona said, his rumbling baritone warm with praise. “I truly believe there is no limit to your ability, Cecil. And I apologize for what I said earlier. I was too quick to give up on Nico.”

“It’s fine,” I answered coolly. “Because I won’t ever give up on him. And I won’t let you forget your promise, either.”

The mana particles within Nico’s core began to change, growing brighter and purer. His channels woke up, too, pulling the newly purified mana out into his body to help him recover. His runes activated in brief flashes, one by one, like muscles being stretched.

Nico’s eyes fluttered open. The smile he gave me was full of softness and wonder and the tentative kindness I saw in my memories of him from the orphanage.

“How?”

I squeezed his hand again and realized the vertigo and nausea I’d previously felt at his touch—some abstract remnant of the feelings Tessia Eralith had for him—was gone. I considered leaning down to kiss him, but then remembered Agrona’s promise.

Someday, Nico and I could have our lives back. Our real lives—including our relationship with each other. But for now, in this body…intimacy felt like a desecration. I nearly laughed at the childishness of this thought. What a silly line to draw, I told myself. Was it ethical to fight a war in the body of another, but not to share a kiss?

But the truth was something else. Something more complex, and much stranger.

This would not be like a life at all, I decided. More like…purgatory. Though I wasn’t going to be merely a weapon in Agrona’s arsenal, neither could I be *myself*, not really, not as long as I wore this skin. Nico couldn’t either. But we would work together, changing the face of this world to Agrona’s design, and when the war was won, we could leave. Together. Be ourselves again.

Together.

Standing, I pulled Nico up with me. He grimaced, rolling his shoulders and stretching his neck. His eyes flicked to Agrona before jumping away again, focusing into the distance. “What happened to…”

“Grey?” Agrona said, raising an eyebrow over an otherwise impassive face. “After your spectacular failure, he vanished again.”

Nico’s face fell, but I took him by the chin and forced him to meet my eyes.

“Don’t lose yourself to the despair and anger,” I said, softly chiding. “I need you. If we’re going to kill Grey, we need to do it together.”

ARTHUR

My core groaned in protest as I completed the God Step.

Stomach lurching, I plummeted to the ground, my body crashing into a thick carpet of dry needles.

For a couple of seconds, I just stared up from my back. A thick canopy of tall evergreens blocked out the sky. Gray-brown trunks rose high in the air, thick limbs spreading out until they wove into those of their neighbors.

My hand clawed at the ground beneath, clenching the dirt into my palms. I slammed the fist down, and again as a frustrated shout tore free from my throat.

I knew I had made a mistake. But I wasn’t sure yet if the mistake was in trying and failing to kill Cecilia, or in trying at all.

It was painfully clear that she was not the person who had died on my sword in the King’s Tournament. Agrona had done something to her, either during or after her reincarnation. The look of loathing she’d given me…it wasn’t the look of a tortured girl who threw herself on a friend’s weapon to end her life.

But there was something else. I just didn’t know yet if it was good or bad.

Tessia was still in there. She had taken over her body, just for an instant, long enough to tell me.

I could have grabbed her, God Stepped away with her…

But I also knew that Agrona wouldn’t have let that happen.

A light weight suddenly pressed down on my chest as Regis appeared in his puppy form. The small shadow wolf pounced off me and began to patrol the perimeter of the small clearing we had just appeared within.

Thanks, I thought to him, unable to muster up the energy to say it out loud quite yet.

'For what, saving your ass?' Regis paused, cocking a tiny lupine brow. *'Not the first time. Won't be the last.'*

I paused to gather my thoughts. *That too, but for letting me have my battle against Cadell. It was selfish, dangerous even, but it was something I needed to do.*

Regis gave a small, sniffling scoff. *'You're telling me.'*

So, that power you used…

'I've said it before…my strength hasn't kept up with yours,' Regis thought matter-of-factly. *'I trained, sure, but I also spent a lot of time thinking. Meditating.'*

A vision of Regis sitting on a rock, eyes closed, paws resting on his knees, bathed in cool mountain sunshine made my lips twitch. *Meditating, huh?*

'Hey, don't be fooled by my gorgeous set of teeth. I'm an intellectual. But the point is, I gave a lot of thought to how I could better keep us sane while you utilize your insights into aether…'

So, by restricting the application of Destruction to a specific spell… I considered, recalling the jagged violet flames sheathing the aetheric sword.

'Exactly,' Regis thought, then stiffened.

I heard the crunching of soft steps a moment later, and turned my head to look more closely around the forest.

A heavy blanket of orange and gold needles covered the forest floor, interrupted by dark green bushes that grew around the base of the trees, making it difficult to see more than a few dozen feet in any direction.

Just behind me, a weathered arch interrupted the natural landscape. It was carved of white marble, but the detailed engravings had long been worn away, and the stone had been stained yellow. Crawling vines crept up the sides, gripping it as if they would pull it down and drag it back into the ground where it belonged.

A wizened old man, portly around the middle but with broad shoulders that hadn't yet lost all their definition, stepped around one of the huge trees, his bushy brows raised. "I thought you said this was a quiet operation, boy. Crashing out of the sky and shouting like a madman isn't exactly that, is it?"

I pushed myself to my feet and gave him a tired nod. "All the more reason for me to get moving."

Alaric stuck his thumbs into his belt and looked me over. "Well, considering the hints you gave me, I expected you to look a lot worse if you ended up here. Things otherwise went to plan then?"

"More or less." I grimaced and rubbed at my aching sternum. "Did you get everything?"

Alaric harrumphed. "Straight to business then, eh?" Drawing out a plain ring of polished black stone, he tossed it to me. "Everything is there."

“Thanks,” I said, slipping the ring on my middle finger. “They’ll be looking for me. I think they’ll keep things quiet, but I expect they’ll check up on anyone I’ve had contact with.”

Alaric looked right into my eyes and let out a loud belch. “Piss on ‘em all. I’m just a washed-up ascender, anyway. Too dumb and drunk to turn down easy coin when a stranger offers to pay me to guide him around, pretend to be his uncle.”

I snorted, watching the old man warily, feeling a crack run through the icy coldness that was creeping like frost through my insides. “Thanks, Alaric. I hope I haven’t made your life any harder.”

He kicked the ground lightly, scattering dead needles. “Indeed you have, but then, I imagine you meant those words as a half-assed apology, because you already know that.” Alaric’s eyes followed Regis as the shadow wolf pup continued his circuit. “I wasn’t exactly living the Sovereign’s life when you met me, after all.”

I stayed quiet, my thoughts only half on his words, turning instead toward what came next for me.

“I, uh…” Alaric cleared his throat, his bloodshot eyes darting to me, then away again. “I had a son, you know. Vritra-born.”

Caught by surprise, I looked up with knitted brows as he continued.

“He was taken, of course, the moment he was identified. Plucked away from us and fostered with some highblood.” Alaric leaned back against one of the nearby trees and closed his eyes. “Didn’t find out ‘til years later what they did, but apparently they were of a mind that for his blood to manifest, they had to push him. *Hard*.

“They… killed him.”

Alaric let the words hang in the dense forest air. “His mom had pissed off years before. Never saw her again. We weren’t allowed any contact, not even to know which highblood had him, and I guess she just didn’t see the value of continuing on together. I don’t know.”

Regis had come to join us, apparently satisfied that we were, for the moment, safe.

“Dug around in the Ascenders Association records with the help of some friends years later, when he’d have been old enough to go on ascents. No match at all for my boy, so I kept going. Don’t know why, really.” Alaric scratched his beard, below which a pained smile was hidden. “But it became a kind of obsession. One connection led to another, and eventually I figured out which highblood he’d been sent to.

“Got myself signed up to go on an ascent with some of their folk. Brought plenty of drink, got ‘em talking. Wouldn’t have even needed the drink.” Alaric’s eyes were far away now, staring into the abyss of his memories. “Proud to talk about how they’d pushed him. Pushed and pushed. They’d fostered three manifested Vritra-born already, he would have been the fourth. But…”

Alaric paused to clear his throat again. “He broke. Died when he was only eight. Got carted off to Taegrin Caelum to be dissected and researched. Quite a blow for the blood, they said. Stripped down to a named blood. For killing my son.”

A cool breeze blew through the trees, and a mana beast howled in the distance… yet, a heavy silence clung in the air as words of solace failed to form.

After all, I had *been* that boy. Taken from my family, raised first by Sylvia, then the Eraliths, my parents having no idea what had happened to me…

"I'm sorry, Alaric," I said finally.

He swatted the words out of the air with one hand while fumbling for his flask with the other. "Don't be. I'm telling you this so you don't leave here worrying about me, thinking you've made some big mess of my life. Besides…" Alaric mustered a grin. "Where better to release some of my inner demons than onto a boy I might not see again."

"Right," I smiled back, holding out my hand. "Regardless. Thank you for everything you've done for me."

Alaric took it. "You paid well and offered me some kind of…hell, I don't know, purpose or something, in my old age." His gravelly voice grew hoarse. "Well get going then, Grey, before a Scythe crashes down on our heads and makes this whole sad story for naught."

I nodded, giving his hand a firm shake. "Arthur. Call me Arthur."

"Arthur," he repeated slowly. His brows furrowed in thought, and his eyes darted to me before going wide. "As in—"

"I better get going," I said with an amused smirk.

"Right." Alaric let out a stiff laugh, fumbling with the runic token in his hand before touching it to the marble. With a soft hum, an opalescent portal appeared in the frame. "You be coming back from…wherever it is you're going?"

"I'm not sure," I admitted. "But I expect I will eventually."

"Well, when you do, look your old uncle Al up." He leaned against the portal frame and crossed his arms over his belly. "Unless I've

already drank myself to death, in which case, you took too bloody long."

Regis trotted along beside me as we approached the portal, and Alaric bent down to give him a pat on the head. "Take good care of the boy, got it?"

Regis turned in a circle, nipped at Alaric's finger, then jumped back into me.

'I'm going to miss that old codger,' he said, a hint of a whimper in his voice.

I gave the old drunk one last smile. "Goodbye, Alaric."

He winked. "See you later, Arty boy."

Shaking my head, I braced myself for what was to come and stepped into the portal.

374.5
IN THE WAKE OF

SETH MILVIEW

Everyone was screaming as the stadium shook.

A translucent bubble of mana covered our group. Mayla was clinging to my arm. I was dimly aware of blood dripping around her fingernails where they'd dug into my skin, but I couldn't feel it.

Deacon was on the ground, holding his head. Yannick had slumped back in his seat, unconscious. At least, I hoped he was just unconscious.

Brion and Linden were screaming at them both, half their attention still on the fight that was tearing the coliseum apart.

Only Pascal didn't seem to be completely losing it, but then I followed his line of sight…

The first several rows of our section were full of corpses. Spikes that were the size of crossbow bolts stuck out of stonework and flesh alike, having broken the shield that was supposed to protect us from combat even between retainers and Scythes. Some of them must have used their own magic to conjure shields, but, against the full might of a Scythe…

There was a crashing *boom* and an entire section of the coliseum crumbled, directly across from us. I watched as thousands of people were swallowed up by a cloud of brown dust. Gone, just like that…

The arena was a blackened and broken field of rubble. Blood iron spikes stuck up like gravestones everywhere. The cloud of void wind was breaking up and fading away. Soulfire burned in dark patches,

just like the wisp-flames they always mentioned in stories. The ones that would lead the hero astray, into the swamp or the beast's lair…

At the very heart of the battlefield, Professor Grey stood over Scythe Cadell Vritra of Central Dominion. They could not have looked more different. Professor Grey… *Can I even call him that still?* I wondered. *It seems like such an insufficient title now.*

Professor Grey stood straight and tall, his strength an undeniable, inescapable… *physical* presence. Clad in black-scale armor, with onyx horns like a Vritra's curving out from his head, he might have been a deity himself.

I struggled to understand what I was even seeing. I'd studied magic and runes since I was just a little kid. My illness meant I couldn't begin training like Circe, and so I'd stayed inside and read. All the time. But I'd never heard of mana arts like these.

He had flitted around the arena with *impossible* speed. His weapon came and went instantly and with no apparent effort. His summons changed from an already intimidating wolf-creature to a *huge, flying* monster that could destroy every kind of Decay-attribute mana attack just by breathing!

It didn't even make sense. I'd never felt any mana come from him, none at all. Scythe Cadell Vritra's was overwhelming, stifling, but the professor's power was… something else entirely.

And so it was with a certain amount of detachment that I watched Professor Grey's weapon plunge through the Scythe and devour him. It felt… inevitable. The way the weird purple fire curled across the Scythe's skin, unmaking him, made me feel deeply uncomfortable. As

if I were watching the rules that bound my world together unravel before my eyes.

"H-he—but… what?" Mayla stammered.

"No *freaking* way," Linden said, forgetting the unresponsive Yannick as our collective attention was pulled to the sight of Scythe Cadell Vritra burning to ash.

"What even was that?" Pascal muttered, his head shaking like he couldn't believe what he was seeing. "I've never seen magic like that."

"The way he just stabbed his summons…" Mayla's voice was full of horror.

"I think he absorbed it into his weapon," I pointed out, remembering how the wolf had dissolved and the blade had come alive with violet flames. "Some kind of crazy combo attack."

It was all pretty hard to make sense of, honestly.

Professor Grey had defeated a *Scythe*. But no, that wasn't quite right. I had nearly forgotten about Scythe Nico already, my mind and memory both sluggish from trying to process everything that had just happened.

The professor had just defeated *two* Scythes. And he killed one!

"He must be freaking *covered* in regalias," Linden said. "That's why he doesn't show them off like most mages."

Pascal's eyes went wide. "Dude, maybe that's why everyone in the class ended up with such strong runes at the last bestowal…"

Doubt suddenly smothered my wonder. And with it came… dread.

This wasn't right. It was way, way outside the bounds of what usually happened at the Victoriad. A challenge alone was rare, but to have killed a Scythe, maybe even two… this could be a declaration of war.

I swiftly became uncomfortably aware of just how little we knew about Professor Grey. If Pascal's guess was accurate, what would this mean for all of his students? Was the professor some kind of enemy of the Vritra? We'd all benefited from his training, maybe even somehow from his mere presence. Did that make us… accomplices, somehow?

I leaned my head against Mayla's.

Her eyes rolled up to look at me askance. "I'm scared, Seth. What's going on?"

"I don't know," I answered, my chest tightening. "But I am too."

SERIS VRITRA

The wave of relief I had felt at Sovereign Kiros's joyful acceptance of Cadell's death collapsed into disappointment as the portal appeared below us, cutting off the Sovereign's words.

Immediately, I set to work planning how I might get Arthur out of this situation alive.

I was now more certain than ever that this human boy was the key to everything, and I absolutely could not allow him to fall into Agrona's hands.

It was quite frustrating, really. If he would have simply done as I requested, dueling and defeating Cylrit then declining the position of retainer… it would have made things much simpler. I still could have used his victory to put him on a pedestal, holding him up as a leader

among the "lessers," but without drawing Agrona's attention. At least not yet.

This victory though…it was much too large, and too soon. Agrona had banished all thought of the boy, focusing entirely on the Legacy instead, no longer concerned with the anchors that brought her here. That was useful. It couldn't last forever, of course, but if I'd only had a few more months to work with…

If I didn't get him away, somehow, then Agrona would strip him down to his base components to figure out how Arthur's aetheric powers functioned. I'd seen enough of the dungeons and laboratories beneath Taegrin Caelum to know exactly what fate awaited him. More frightening perhaps than losing Arthur was the prospect of Agrona somehow divining a way to control aether from Arthur's dissected corpse.

Given the situation at hand, even giving myself away would be worth it. I'd prepared thoroughly enough that my plans could be put into motion from hiding if necessary, despite not being ideal. Arthur, or rather Grey, would be a household name in Alacrya within days. No one of any stature wouldn't know of his victory. In the event we actually could manage some miraculous escape from the Victoriad, utilizing him as a figurehead would be a simple task.

I resigned myself to simply watching and listening as I waited for the right moment. But when the Legacy cast her spell an instant later, the bottom fell out of my stomach.

Despite charting her progress, I hadn't seen this ability before. Such a spell could, theoretically, defeat even a Scythe, if her control over it were strong enough. No, not just a Scythe. Considering that asura

relied on mana simply to exist, with it infusing their very bodies, such a spell might be able to neuter even the strongest beings in this world, dividing them from their own power.

Dragoth and Viessa drifted into the sky, moving to circle Arthur's trap. I had no choice but to follow, letting the situation play out.

Watching Arthur's face, though… somehow, he did not seem afraid. If anything, he was calculating.

Even a little… sad?

I listened to Agrona speak, heedless of the words until the others moved in to capture Arthur. Perhaps I could make my move while transporting him back to Taegrin Caelum, offer to escort him into the dungeons myself…

Suddenly, Arthur shifted, smashing out of the trap and streaking toward Agrona and the Legacy, a blade of vibrant purple aether humming to life in his grip.

I stopped breathing, so intently did I have to focus to see what was happening.

Fool, I thought only an instant later, mouthing the word but knowing better than to speak out loud.

He had stopped. He could have struck a killing blow, his blade was so close he'd seared a hole in the Legacy's battledress, but he'd stopped himself. Because of his relationship with Tessia Eralith, he didn't have the stomach to do what needed to be done.

The idea of killing her myself flashed through my mind for the dozenth time, but I couldn't risk alienating both Agrona and Arthur in a single move. If Arthur struck the blow himself however…

But I knew there was no hope for that as Agrona began to jeer, insulting Arthur. Then, his eyes never leaving the boy, Agrona gave the order. “Take him.”

I knew that it was now or never, but I hesitated. Although stricken, his face pale, fingers trembling at his sides, Arthur did not yet look defeated. I flew toward him, keeping pace with the others, at a loss for how to proceed.

And then he was gone. Just like that, so fast that even Agrona, face twisted in rage, could only grasp at the afterimage of purple lightning left hanging in the air, all that remained of Arthur.

I began to laugh.

CAERA DENOIR

“What the actual fuck.”

The words left my mouth as if they’d been spoken by a stranger, but I couldn’t have more eloquently described my feelings if I’d been given a month to think the words through.

Grey was… gone. Just gone.

As the High Sovereign began to shout out instructions to all the Scythes, I slipped back into the shadows of an empty staging area, stumbling over rubble before leaning back against the wall and closing my eyes.

The first thing I saw was the memory of Grey, caged and wrapped in some kind of anti-mana bubble, looking directly into my eyes. A plethora of emotions and thoughts had flashed across his face in that single instant, but one was clear above the rest.

Regret.

Which could only mean one thing. He was leaving.

He hadn't just used his aether arts to escape the stadium, I was sure of that. He intended to disappear.

I felt like I should've been mad—should've felt betrayed. But I wasn't. Grey had always warned me of getting too close…of knowing too much. This had confirmed it. What he had sought to do was beyond the scale of my imagination.

I remember first seeing him in the Relictombs, manaless and seemingly at death's door, taking pity on what I thought was a young woman whose core had been destroyed. Against all odds, we then crossed paths again in the convergence zone, where he carried my own brother's weapon into battle. This alone was too much to write off as mere coincidence, and yet I then later learned of a mysterious connection between him and my own lifelong mentor, Scythe Seris…

So, while whatever force had brought us together—aether, or fate, or the will of some divinity beyond the asuras—I knew the next steps were up to me. Whether or not Grey intended to involve me further in his adventures, I had to choose what to do from here.

"Whatever that is," I muttered aloud, pressing myself into the wall, which was trembling subtly.

Separately and simultaneously to these considerations, Grey's fight with Cadell was rapidly replaying in my mind. Despite having fought side by side with him, Grey's powers seemed as much an enigma to me now as they ever had.

It was well known in Alacrya that Scythe Cadell was not *just* a Scythe—he was Agrona's private enforcer, dealing with issues that required the High Sovereign's personal attention. According to

Scythe Seris, he had only been named a Scythe when Agrona began ramping up for the war with Dicathen nearly fifteen years ago, but even before that had been more powerful and dangerous than the other Scythes.

And yet, Grey had defeated him in single combat, killing him where every important person on the continent would get to see.

My throat grew constricted as questions tumbled haphazardly through my mind. There was so much more to this than a single, stunning defeat. Because the Victoriad had revealed that Grey not only knew Scythe Seris, but Cadell and Nico as well. And even Agrona, judging by the way he had spoken.

But what was their relationship? Why did Grey make these challenges? Who *was* Grey, really? And what was he trying to accomplish?

Could I have been right when I suggested to Scythe Seris that he was asura born? Perhaps some descendant of the dragons sworn to take vengeance against Agrona? If I hadn't adventured at his side within the Relictombs, I would almost believe him to be a full-blooded asura. It would at least explain his control over aether.

Or—I felt a thrill as I considered this—could he be one of the ancient mages? A djinn, surviving within the Relictombs and hidden among us since the dragons exterminated them. It was true that he had a way with the Relictombs, far beyond any ascender I had ever seen. To my knowledge, no ascender in history had ever discovered one of these ancient ruins before, much less spoken to a djinn remnant.

And he *did* have these spontaneously manifested runes—godrunes—one of which even allowed him to revive relics from that ancient culture…

My cheeks grew warm. Even thinking these things made me feel like a silly little girl. But the truth was, I couldn't think of a simpler, more reasonable explanation for how Grey would be at the heart of all this power. To have drawn the attention of the High Sovereign himself, who rarely if ever left the confines of Taegrin Caelum, high in the Basilisk Fang Mountains…

I realized with sudden and absolute certainty that Grey could be one of the most powerful beings in the world. If not yet, eventually. I knew with equal certainty that I would not be content to return to my old life, knowing he was out there, somewhere.

My coddled noble life, my efforts to live up to my brother's legacy as an ascender, even the reality of my being a hidden Virtra-born whose blood has manifested, it all seemed entirely unimportant in the face of whatever breakthroughs Grey had made and would continue to make.

That was real power, the kind that could reshape the face of our world.

A small smile came to my lips as I remembered a conversation with Sevren, a very long time ago. We were play-fighting in the gardens with wooden swords—each one carved with the symbol for aether, of course—and the duel grew heated, until I accidentally rapped his knuckles with my "weapon" hard enough to make him yelp in pain.

In my embarrassment, I'd teased him about yielding to the power of my aether magic, but instead of being mad, he'd simply sat down in the grass and thoughtfully flexed his bruised hand.

"One day, I'm going to be an ascender, sis. I'm going to go into the Relictombs and learn all about this stuff for real." I still remembered so clearly how his eyes shined as he looked up at me from the ground, his face much too serious for a boy not yet twelve years old. "Then nobody will have to fight at all, not anymore. We could make the world whatever we want it to be."

I had laughed at him. "Can you make it rain toffee for us, then? Lenora told the cooks not to make anymore after I snuck some last time."

But Sevren hadn't even cracked a smile. "The first thing I would do is make it so no one ever takes you away from our family. I'd create a world where you were safe from the Vritra Clan."

The torrent of conflicting thoughts and emotions overwhelmed me, and I realized that there were tears streaming down my cheeks. Outside the safety of the empty staging area, I could hear the noise of thousands of footsteps hurrying from the arena, of people shouting, the bones of the coliseum shifting, magic humming…so much life being lived, pain and fear and awe all wrapped up into one, no one fully understanding what they'd just seen.

I considered Grey's students, likely awestruck and terrified, lacking any context to help them make sense of what they'd just witnessed.

My adoptive parents were out there somewhere as well, likely scrambling to arrange a tempus warp back to the central dominion in order to avoid being caught up in any fallout, already establishing

their story for when Grey's connections to Highblood Denoir came clear.

Perhaps the right thing to do would have been to go help. Dozens of mages still swarmed over the collapsed section of the coliseum, searching for survivors in the rubble. The officials would need all the help they could get to manage the churning herds rushing toward the tempus warp platforms.

But when I finally pushed myself away from the wall and wiped my tears, there was only one thing I could think to do. I needed to know what came next. And to do so, I needed my mentor.

I couldn't help but feel it was quite past time for me to get some real answers.

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VOICES

ELEANOR LEYWIN

I rocked side to side as Boo's broad back swayed with each slow step. His breath was heavy and even, almost sleepy after gorging himself on glitterfish. We were taking our time, moving slowly as we returned from Boo's favorite fishing spot and headed toward the square outside Town Hall.

I could already hear the low rumble of many voices combining. It sounded like dozens, maybe even a hundred or more…

It was weird. Growing up in Xyrus, a day at the market meant crossing paths with hundreds, even thousands of people. I never thought twice about the noise of a crowd back then. All those people just kind of blended into the background, *there* but…not important.

Now, the idea of so many people—each one having suffered such horrible loss, surviving the nightmare of these last several months—made me feel uncomfortable. Constricted. Even as this feeling took root in me, though, a golden light issued from my core, infusing me with confidence and bravery.

Smiling, I patted Boo's neck. "Thanks. I can always count on you, can't I, Boo?"

The crowds' volume inched higher and higher as I approached the gathered refugees, almost all elves. Several sent wary looks in my direction as I rode by, and I was surprised by how uncomfortable and agitated the crowd seemed. I wasn't completely sure what was happening, only that Albold had sent me a message to be here.

My mother was waiting for me in the mouth of an alley that led toward one of the community gardens, outside of the dense pack of elves filling the square.

Staying mounted atop Boo, I reached down and gave her hand a gentle squeeze. “What’s going on?”

“I thought maybe you would tell me,” she said, her eyes darting nervously around the crowd.

Following her line of sight, I realized why. More of the elves were looking at me now. Some stared openly, while others shot me poorly hidden glances as they talked quietly to their friends and family. And while some seemed just curious or even—I hoped—friendly, others were much less so.

Then I realized why Albold had asked for me.

I wondered exactly what he and Feyrith had told these elves. Everything I had shared with them about Virion and Windsom’s conversation? That seemed foolhardy, but then, I wasn’t exactly sure what I expected them to do with the information. By the way people were looking at me, though, that must have been it.

I found myself wishing they would have at least not mentioned where they got their information…

Not that I felt frightened. Sitting on Boo’s back, with my mother’s hand wrapped comfortingly around my calf, I had the same warm feeling I did as a little kid when Art would fall asleep next to me while putting me to bed. Like I was protected.

But I couldn’t help but feel like all this unhappiness and frustration I saw around me was my fault.

It had been a couple weeks since I told Albold and Feyrith about Virion and Windsom's lies. Rinia had warned me to stay out of it, but I still thought they deserved to know. I knew a bit too well what it felt like to be lied to, to have things hidden from me to "protect" me. Mom and Dad were always keeping things about Arthur from me. Even when the Lances took him away, they made all kinds of excuses so I didn't worry.

Like I was too stupid to understand that when Mom locked herself away and cried, something was wrong.

But I wanted to be told the truth so I could grow from it, react to the world as it was, not through the rosy lenses of what my parents wanted to show me.

Still…I knew that the elves might not feel the same. Maybe in scary times like these, some people would prefer to stay ignorant, unaware and clenching onto the hopeful, filtered words of our leaders.

And so I waited, expecting for something to happen since my conversation with Feyrith and Albold, almost hoping for it just to get it over with.

Because, if something bad happened, I knew it would be because of me.

"Thank you for coming, Ellie," someone said from behind me. I spun around so I was sitting backwards on Boo. Feyrith and Albold had just come out of a narrow alley.

"What exactly is happening here?" Mom asked, moving so she was between Boo and the pair of elves.

They both bowed to her before Feyrith said, “Thanks to your daughter, we elves were finally told the truth of what happened to our homeland, something our leaders have lied about to protect an alliance with false friends.”

“We’re going to make Virion explain himself and his actions,” Albold said forcefully.

Feyrith gave me a tight-lipped smile. “We wanted you to be here, Ellie, to hear what Virion has to say and… offer some perspective, if necessary.” He quickly held up a hand when Mom started to object. “You have been guided by the seer Rinia herself. You were in Elenoir when the destruction occurred… the only survivor of that attack. You heard for yourself the lies shared between Virion and the asura. We need you here, Ellie.”

So I wasn’t brought here to be questioned, I thought in relief. But what’ll Virion say—or deny—when they ask him for an explanation? Either way, it was because of me and the information I chose to share that this gathering of elves happened in the first place.

Mom sighed, stepping back and looking up at me. Boo was twisted around so he could watch the elves, his heavy brows low over his small eyes, and his huge teeth bared.

“It’s fine,” I said to no one in particular. “We’re already here. I just… did you have to tell everyone it was me?”

A light flush appeared on Feyrith’s cheeks and he looked down at the ground. “People took convincing just to show up. We had to tell them exactly how we’d discovered the truth.”

“Oh,” I said. I wanted to be upset, but I couldn’t blame them. If I didn’t want to be involved, after all, I could have just kept my big mouth shut.

I guess I won’t know if what I did was right or wrong until I see how it all turns out. Hopefully, most people are glad to learn the truth, but I bet a bunch of them think I’m lying, or blame me for causing problems.

I glanced around again. More eyes had turned my way now that I was speaking with Feyrith and Albold. An old elf with a cane—one of the council, I thought—was making her way toward us, but behind her, I caught sight of a genuinely friendly face.

Riding above the crowd on Jasmine Flamesworth’s shoulders, my friend Camellia beamed and waved at me. Her pale blonde hair was tied back in thin braids, and there was a sprig of holly tucked behind her ear. She tapped the top of Jasmine’s head and pointed in my direction, drawing a sour frown from her mount.

The rest of the Twin Horns were with them, and when they turned in our direction, the crowd parted to allow them through.

Helen gave me a warm smile and patted Boo’s side. “Ellie. I should have known they’d drag you into this.” She gave Feyrith and Albold a sharp look, her smile quickly dropping.

Durden, who stood out from the crowd due to being at least a head taller than everyone else, frowned in an exaggerated kind of way, highlighting the scars over half of his face. “Ellie, you do know you’re riding your bear backwards, right?”

Camellia rewarded his joke with an appreciative laugh, but it faltered quickly. She looked down, letting a loose braid of pale hair fall over her face. “Sorry, I suppose this isn’t the time for laughter.”

“There’s always time to remind ourselves we’re still here kicking,” Angela Rose responded as she wrapped her arms around my mother, pulling her into a tight hug.

The old elf woman finally made her way through the crowd. She hesitated, looking around at the Twin Horns and me. “I’m sorry to interrupt, but…” Her gaze shifted to Feyrith. “I was hoping for a word before we began.”

Feyrith nodded, looking gaunt and serious. But when he looked at me, there was a softness in his features that seemed to undo some of the damage his time spent as a captive of the Alacryans had done. “Thank you again for being here, Ellie.”

And then they were gone.

I turned around so I was sitting properly on Boo, and Camellia clambered off Jasmine’s shoulders and onto Boo’s back behind me. Her arms wrapped around my waist and she rested her head on my back, squeezing me slightly.

“Things are going to get pretty rough,” Angela Rose mumbled, one arm still wrapped around my mother.

“Let’s hope not,” Helen said. “But if it does, remember that our role here is to keep people from hurting each other.”

Durden pulsed with mana, and a stone arm coalesced in place of the one he’d lost fighting at the Wall. “We’re with you as always, Helen.”

Our strange little family fell into a tense silence as we waited.

It wasn’t long.

Albold and Feyrith eased through the crowd until they could climb the stairs that led into the Town Hall. The usual guards that would have stood there were absent, and the doors were closed.

Albold tried to shout something, but his voice was lost in the din. Feyrith fired a kind of water burst up into the air, where it exploded with a popping, hissing noise, silencing the crowd.

"Most of you already know why we're here," he said when the last of the chatter had died down. "Some of you had already seen through the lies of our commander and are here to support this effort, but I know many of you are still skeptical. And I don't blame you for that."

He paused, letting his words settle over the crowd. "My fellow elves, we have lost much." His voice cracked, and he paused again. "No one can heal the hole that has been torn in our hearts and souls at the destruction of our home, the careless genocide of our people. But I, Feyrith Ivsaar III, am telling you now that you deserve to understand why this was done to us."

Feyrith's voice rose as he spoke, becoming a shout that filled the cavern. "We have been lied to. Treated like children. Asked to align ourselves with our destroyers. Betrayed by our own leaders!"

This was met with supporting cheers from several elves, but most remained quiet. A few were obviously hostile to Feyrith's message, glaring fiercely up at him. Beside me, I could see Helen clocking everyone who seemed like a potential threat, regardless of which side of the argument they were on.

"Proof!" a gray-haired elven man yelled, cutting over the cheers. He had a brand burned into the side of his neck, still shiny and scabbed. "How *dare* you accuse *Virion Eralith*, a man who has fought for us all his life, of betraying us without proof!"

There were a few cries of support, but more boos as Feyrith's supporters tried to shout the man down.

"Are we supposed to take the word of a human girl over our own commander!" another elf shouted, a woman this time, her bright green eyes so full of bitterness and disdain that I felt bile rise up in the back of my throat.

The crowd fell into bickering, shouting across each other so their words were lost. All I could see was the division that was being caused, the fracturing of our fragile resistance, and how my words had brought us here.

"I hope you're not taking their words personally, El," a worried voice said as Emily Watsken appeared out of the crowd. Curly hair framed Emily's soot-stained face, and there was a crack around the edge of one of her lenses.

"Em!" Slipping off Boo, I gave her a big hug. "What happened to you?"

She rubbed her cheek, further smudging the soot clinging to her skin. "An explosion at the lab, one of Gideon's new projects…but never mind that. What did I miss?"

I sighed, leaning back against Boo. "Nothing but a bunch of shouting and dirty looks so far."

Everyone else said their hellos, although the Twin Horns were mostly focused on the still seething crowd. I crawled back up on Boo, leaning into Camellia, who rested her chin on my shoulder.

"No one really blames you for anything, you know," she said in a whisper. "They're just scared."

“Aren’t we all?” I grumbled, then blew out an unnecessarily loud sigh. “I just…”

Mom squeezed my leg and gave me an apologetic smile. “Being caught in the middle of world-altering events is apparently the curse of my children.”

I took my mom’s hand and laughed a little. “We’re just lucky, I guess.”

In front of the Town Hall, Albold had turned away from the crowd and was now hammering on the doors. “Virion! Virion, your people need to hear your voice. Address these accusations, or be named a—”

The doors flung open, nearly knocking Albold over backwards.

The Lance, Bairon Wykes, now personal guard to Commander Virion and member of the council, stood framed in the doorway, his gleaming armor alive with crackling lightning. His eyes blazed as little lightning bolts jumped from him to the walls and floor, burning scorch marks into the stonework.

“Clear off,” he ordered, his voice thrumming with the kind of power I’d rarely witnessed up close. Even fifty feet away, I felt the static discharge tingling across my skin, and tiny arcs of electricity jumped between the fine hairs on my forearms. “The commander won’t be dragged from his home by an unruly mob. If you want to talk, make an appointment.”

Feyrith and Albold were quick to recover. “Our own commander, once king of Elenoir, sends his attack dog to run us off. What is your plan, Lance? Will you—”

“Enough, Bairon, enough,” a rugged voice sounded from inside the Town Hall. The crowd—nearly driven into a frenzy by the Lance’s threats—went still and silent as a field of standing stones. “I will speak to my people.”

The Lance glared fiercely around before stepping out into the open and moving to the side. Virion came up behind him.

Although the old elf stood tall, each step firm and confident, I felt immediately like something was off. He was dressed in forest-green battlerobes embroidered with golden leaves and vines, his hair pulled back into a tail, making him look regal and powerful… but that alone wasn’t enough to hide the deep tiredness that hung about him like a black cloud.

He didn’t immediately speak, but let his sharp old eyes track across the gathered refugees. Wherever they fell, the elves looked down. A few even wept, their soft snuffling the only sound.

“My brothers and sisters,” he began, his voice both firm and soft, somehow. Still the practiced tone of command, but also the grandfatherly projection of understanding. “You have asked for me, so here I am.”

I didn’t know what to make of Virion’s expression when his eyes scanned the crowd. “It pains me to see us like this—the last dregs of our civilization, hidden underneath the earth instead of flourishing in the forests of our birth… but more so that we are being pulled apart, and at a time when we need to come together more than ever.”

“No one is questioning anything you’ve said,” Feyrith responded from the bottom of the steps, looking up at Virion. He gestured to the onlookers with one hand. “But it’s hard to reconcile your

message of unity with the reality of our situation, at least for me. Our home is *gone*, Virion… and the asura of Epheotus took it from us. Not the Alacryans. Do you deny it?"

Virion nodded along with Feyrith's words. Before he answered, he took a deep, shuddering breath. "No, I don't deny it."

The crowd burst as people cried out in dismay or disbelief, some demanding to know why, others shouting that it couldn't be true, that Virion was being manipulated somehow.

"Then why lie?" Albold shouted above the din.

"It was a necessary lie, told to keep the ragged tatters of our civilization from collapsing into despair." As Virion spoke, he held his head up, facing the accusing gazes without flinching. "I may regret its necessity, but, given the chance, I would make the same decision again."

"You would protect the asura over your own people?" Feyrith asked in disbelief.

Virion stood straighter, and when he glared down at the younger elf, his eyes were full of fire. "Do you see an asura before you, or are these ears not proof of my heritage!"

His sudden outburst smothered all other noise.

"Do you really think I have lived so long and fought so hard for Elenoir that I do not mourn its destruction just as deeply as any of you? Did the asura destroy Elenoir? Yes! And in the act, they eliminated an enemy foothold in this continent and cut the heads from many of the highest-ranking families of Alacrya. They burned the enemy's war camps and magical laboratories. They cut off many

of the long-range teleportation devices that connected Dicathen to Alacrya."

From where I stood in the crowd, I could see the very moment when the crack in Virion's disciplined, royal demeanor formed—the empathy and the emotion winning out as Virion's eyes grew wet with barely suppressed tears.

"But they did not take our *home.*" Virion pressed one hand against his chest, gesturing to the crowd with the other. "Wherever we go, whatever becomes of the elven people, we carry our homes with us. Trees can be replanted. Houses rebuilt. Magic reclaimed. No one can take that from us."

"But the people they killed can't be reborn!" someone shouted, their voice choked with emotion.

"This is *war*!" Virion's gravel-filled voice cracked, the word "war" crashing like a fallen tree among the crowd. "Sacrifice is necessary, even when the price seems beyond paying."

The fire, momentarily so bright it seemed to glow out of him, died, leaving behind a very old, very tired elf. "Don't let this tragedy push us into an even worse situation. We can't properly mourn those we've lost until we save everyone who remains…"

The crowd was silent, watching Virion, Feyrith, and Albold with wide, wet eyes.

I didn't agree with Virion. But… I understood him. His people were so fragile, had already been through so much. He was just trying to save them from whatever pain he could.

After a long pause, Virion motioned behind him for something. "It was the Alacryans who attacked our continent, invaded our homes,

murdered our friends and family…executed our kings and queens…" A single tear fell from Virion's eye, traveling in a zigzagging pattern down his craggy face. "This war ends when they are thrown from our shores."

He turned to take something from the head guard, Lenna Aemaris, who then bowed and retreated back into the Town Hall. When he again faced us, he was holding a long, ornate box. It was made of a deep, richly black wood and bound with luminescent silver metal. With one hand, he opened the lid, revealing the contents to the crowd.

It was a rod, around two and a half feet long, with a gleaming red handle wrapped with golden rings every few inches. At the head of the rod, a crystal glowed with diffused lavender light. It was beautiful, but the sight of it sent a shiver down my spine.

"You all now know of the artifacts used to empower the Lances, which were long kept secret from the population, used to guarantee the safety of our kings and queens by both creating and binding the continent's most powerful mages in their service," Virion said to the enraptured audience.

"Those artifacts no longer serve a purpose," Virion continued, his voice soft, almost reverent. "And so, to keep them out of the enemy's hands, our asuran allies have ensured they can't be used again."

Several onlookers shouted in dismay, but Bairon waved for silence, lightning crackling between his fingers.

"Instead, they have given us *new* artifacts," Virion said, his voice rising, growing less tired and more powerful. He held up the box,

making the rod's lavender gem glint in the soft light of the underground cavern. "This is one of three artifacts capable of raising a mage to white core or even beyond, which could be our best chance to fight back against the Alacryans. Each artifact is specifically attuned to one of the three races of Dicathen, and can't be used by anyone with Vritra blood, making them useless to the Alacryans."

I couldn't help but be surprised by the number of cheers that rose from the crowd. Glancing around, I realized that most of these people had been drawn here out of fear, not a search for truth, and Virion had just shown them what hope might look like. It suddenly mattered a lot less who had caused the disaster in Elenoir if we had had weapons like this to fight back against the Alacryans with.

"That's… pretty good, isn't it?" Camellia asked, still sitting behind me on Boo.

People were shouting out questions or words of praise, but one cut through the rest. "Who will be granted this gift, Commander Virion?"

Virion frowned, his brows coming together sharply as he closed the box and handed it back to Lenna. It grew quiet again as we all waited for an answer.

"Much remains to be decided," he admitted, taking the first step down toward the people. "The old way—selecting just two warriors from each race—will no longer be sufficient. With these new relics, we could create an entire Lance Corps, and—"

" —cause untold devastation while shackling our most powerful defenders to the Indrath Clan," a croaky old voice cut in from somewhere in the audience.

I rapidly scanned the surprised faces until I found her. A hunched form, wrapped in both a cloak and a blanket, shuffled out from the doorway of one of the houses surrounding this square, pulling her hood back as she did so.

The crowd shuffled to give her room. A few of the elves bowed respectfully, but more gave her wary or even outright hostile looks.

She paid them no mind, moving shakily toward Virion. "These artifacts are designed to trap us in power. Ensure our subservience. I know what will happen if we make use of them."

Virion's frown etched deep wrinkles into his face. But instead of anger, I thought his expression showed more sadness and regret. "Rinia. Please, come inside and we can discuss this further."

Ignoring Virion, Elder Rinia turned her head left and right, meeting the eyes of those closest to her. "If used, these relics will indeed help our mages grow strong, strong enough to fight the Alacryan Scythes. Together, in number, strong enough even to fight the asuras of the Vritra Clan."

The audience was briefly filled with whispering, but it died out quickly. "Our enemy will respond by escalating his efforts on this continent—a distraction put in play by the Indrath Clan. The battles that follow will leave the continent in ruin. Xyrus will be ripped from the sky. Etistin, shattered and taken in by the ocean. The Wall, crumbled back into the earth. Dicathen, our home, will be in ruins, with titans still battling in the rubble."

Virion was quiet when he asked, "And what will happen if we refuse Lord Indrath's hand of friendship and break our alliance with the

asura? With no allies, and no hope, I don't need visions of the future to understand the fate of our continent then."

Rinia scoffed derisively. "Your *allies* will use our people as fertilizer, from which they'll grow a new nation after their war with the Vritra is settled." Rinia's demeanor softened somewhat as she looked at her old friend. "There are so few of us left, Virion. Don't march the last of the elves to their own extinction."

"Then what should we do?"

"The gods have turned against us—"

"—die fighting, at least!"

"—accept the asuras gift—"

"—destroy the artifacts—"

And so it went for a while. Helen and the Twin Horns stayed sharp and watchful, just in case things escalated, but no one took it beyond shouting or the occasional shove. Camellia stayed with me, her cheek resting against my back, her body tight as a bowstring. Mother wrapped her arm around my leg and leaned against Boo, her face unreadable.

"I wonder how they work?" I just barely heard Emily mutter under her breath. "I'll have to ask Gideon…"

After a couple minutes of this, a heavy pressure, like before a coming thunderstorm, filled the chamber and made my ears pop.

Everyone went still as Lance Bairon took a step forward. "Silence," he said firmly.

Virion gave Rinia a searching look. "We have a choice before us, then. But…"

Virion's gaze tracked across the cavern, landing on Albold and Feyrith, and a few other leaders among the elves, before coming to rest meeting my own eyes. "If you all want to be heard—if you wish to shoulder the weight of not only your lives, but others' as well—then that's exactly what we'll do." Lance Bairon shot him a concerned frown, but wiped it away almost immediately. "Speak to your kin. Spread this information to everyone in this sanctuary, so that each and every one of us—displaced as we have been by the Alacryans—may express our desires. In three days, every human, dwarf, and elf in this sanctuary will be given the chance to vote on the matter, and determine the direction of our people. For better or worse."

Mother pulled away, turning to leave, but I stayed, watching Virion as he took the steps down from the Town Hall slowly.

The crowd was breaking up, starting to disperse, some lingering to speak to Feyrith and Albold, others gathered around Rinia as if she were a candle in a dark room, but through the noise of it all I could just barely hear Virion's words as he approached Elder Rinia.

"Rinia. Come inside. Let us speak, like we used to."

The old seer pulled her blanket close around her shoulders. "Can't," she answered gruffly. "You don't listen to me like you used to."

She shuffled off, several elves trailing after her, and Virion caught me watching them. He inclined his head slightly in my direction, his emotions unreadable behind the fatigue and resignation clear in his every little movement.

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CHOICES

VIRION ERALITH

My boots felt as if they were covered in thick mud, each step through the empty halls heavy and dragging. The weight of confrontation bowed my shoulders and made my temples ache. The impromptu rally, or rather my response to it, was already chasing in circles through my mind as I reconsidered each word and phrase, fearing that I hadn't articulated my thoughts well enough.

When I reached my private chambers, I turned to close the door only to find that Bairon had shadowed me from the rally, and was now standing in the hall and watching me carefully. His presence was a comfort, and I couldn't help but consider the path our relationship had taken. I had never liked the human Lance, considering him selfish and egotistical. There were many times I would have dismissed him if I'd had the power, or perhaps consigned him to a purgatory of some demeaning, inglorious task.

At some point, however, in our long days within the ancient mages' hidden sanctuary, it had occurred to me that these traits were perhaps not intrinsic to Bairon himself, but were fostered by both his family and the Glayders. Whether due to their absence, his own near-death, or the failure of the Council and Lances to protect Dicathen, Bairon had changed.

Now, he was a level head and steady hand at my side on the council. Still prideful, perhaps, but not vainglorious as he had once been.

"Commander?"

I started, realizing I had just been gazing at him like an old dotard for several seconds. “Bairon. Have I expressed my appreciation to you for your assistance these last long months?”
He eyed me, uncertain. “Sir?”
“Things like a simple ‘thank you’ are so often let slip in dire times,” I mused. “As I likely haven't said it enough, thank you for your service to Dicathen.”
He swept aside the blond hair that fell down across his bright green eyes—features of the Wykes family. “Such things don’t need to be said between men like us, Commander.”
I scoffed. “Perhaps once I would have thought the same, but I’m too old and tired for masculine pride.” Bairon’s lips twitched, but he didn’t reply. “Now leave an old elf to rest.”
The Lance hesitated, grimacing, then blurted out, “Are you sure about this, Commander?”
I could only offer the young human an uncertain shrug. “We haven’t had a king or queen who didn’t try to throw their people to the mana beasts for their own gain. Not in this war. Maybe…maybe the time of rulers is past. The people need to choose for themselves how they’re going to die.”
Bairon’s face fell as he bowed, turned sharply on his heel, and marched away. As I watched his broad back recede, I considered just how separate—even lonely—our positions had left us.
Bairon had gone to what remained of his family soon after regaining his strength, hoping to help them flee Xyrus for the sanctuary. With his level of power, it would have been an easy matter, but he hadn’t been prepared for what he found in Xyrus.

It wasn't the Alacryans, who had quickly arrived in force after taking control of the teleportation gates at the flying castle, that stymied his efforts, but his own family members.

The Wykes were a powerful and renowned house. They could have rallied the other houses and organized a defense of the city. Instead, they were one of the first to swear service to Agrona, likely in some short-sighted effort to ingratiate themselves with the invaders. Bairon went to help his family escape, but instead found them actively working alongside the Alacryans to suppress whatever small pockets of resistance had survived so long.

It had nearly broken him again to return empty handed. I had to wonder if the old Bairon—the person he was before our defeat at the hands of the Scythe—would have come back at all. I shuddered to think what would have happened to us if he'd followed his family instead of me.

Once he had turned a corner and left my sight, I eased the door closed and moved to my desk, taking a seat. With my elbows rested on the stone desktop, I let my face sink into my hands.

Learning that the asura, our allies, had destroyed Elenoir was a blow to our morale. I knew when I accepted Windsom's proposal that it was a risk, but I agreed with him that the truth could have broken our spirit entirely. And I stood by that assessment, though I couldn't help but second guess my decision, now that the truth had been revealed through gossip and whispered conversation.

Through my splayed fingers, I looked at the three long boxes resting on my desk. Gingerly, I reached out and flicked the latch on the first box, then opened the lid. The rod's lavender gem flashed in the light,

and I ran my fingers along the richly red leather of the handle. There was a crackle of energy, and the hairs on my arm stood on end.

These artifacts had given me hope, and I'd expected my people—both *my* people, the elves, and all those under my care within the sanctuary—to share this feeling. Windsom's timing couldn't have been better. With the artifacts in hand, I had the tools necessary to dampen the shock and despair we all felt, show them a future where we had the strength to be victorious.

Perhaps it was shortsighted of me that I hadn't foreseen Rinia's involvement. But then, *I* wasn't the seer.

Chuckling darkly, I pressed my palms hard into my eyes to relieve the pressure building there. I was already wondering whether my offer to allow a vote on the artifacts' use had been an act of wisdom or weakness.

This was a question I had asked myself many times before, and it was almost comforting to think that I would never know the answer.

Judging the correctness of my actions would be left to future generations. If there *were* any future generations. If what Rinia had said was true, if she'd foreseen catastrophe and destruction across the continent, perhaps there wouldn't be. But then, what was the alternative? It seemed the choice was that we either grew strong enough to destroy ourselves in the fighting or be destroyed because we were too weak to fight back at all.

And that, I suppose, is exactly why I called for the vote.

Should these people not be allowed to choose their own end? I had grown too old, commanded too long, sent too many to their deaths to bear the weight of this decision on my own.

Taking a key from my belt, I unlocked the single drawer in the desk and slid it open with the rough grinding of stone on stone. Pushing items out of the way until I found what I was looking for, I carefully withdrew a crystal orb about eight inches in diameter.

The artifact was a dear possession, but something I used sparingly, trying to move on from my past. But I found myself growing more and more dependent on it, using it to escape to a better time in my life.

The orb swirled with misty light, which seemed to grow agitated as I set it on the desk, holding it with one hand to ensure it didn't roll off and shatter.

"Lania…" I whispered, staring deep into the swirling light.

At the sound of my voice, it began to coalesce into a bright image…a face, molded of liquid light. It was the single most beautiful face I had ever laid eyes on, one I hadn't seen in person in many, many years.

My wife smiled out at me from within the memory orb. *"The king of the elves shouldn't look so glum. What weight is it that drags the corners of your lovely lips down so?"*

The voice in the orb was hers, but there was a subtle echo to it, like it had been resounding through the years and was reaching me from far away and a long time ago.

My own voice, though many decades younger, sounded from the orb in response. *"I'm sorry. The war…it's gone on too long. Far too long. I've started to question the price we've paid. I'm afraid, Lania. Afraid that this makes me weak."*

"No, my love. You are not weak. You are brave and beautiful."

"Beautiful, huh?" my younger self replied with a snort. Though the memory was from my own point of view, I could picture the elf who spoke, a younger man, face not yet creased with wrinkles, shoulders unbent by the burdens of command. A tear trailed along the path of the laugh lines she'd given me. *"That's not exactly the kind of compliment kings hope to hear."*

"But it's true, now and always. Inside and out, you are a beautiful man, and you have lived a beautiful life. And I will always protect you."

Another snort issued from my past self, but I remembered the way my face had softened as I gazed lovingly at her. *"Don't you mean* I'll *always protect* you?*"*

"No, my love." Her hand rose up to caress my cheek, and I could practically feel the softness of her fingertips against my skin.

The image faded back to a swirl of misty light.

I sat hunched over the crystal orb, staring at my wrinkled hands through its transparent surface.

Would these same hands be here had it not been for my wife's gifts?

Would Dicathen's fate have been better without me in it?

Feeling emptier now than I had before using it, I shoved the memory orb back into my desk before pushing away.

"Damned future-sight," I cursed, bitter that my whole life seemed almost entirely defined by the visions of seers.

Whether it was a gift or a curse, I thought, as I had many times before, that we were better left to our own devices, navigating our lives as best we could within the range of our own vision and forethought instead of relying on pictures of futures that may or may not come to pass. Even the wisest of us could drive themselves mad

attempting to decipher the impossible branching pathways that lay ahead of each and every elf, human, or dwarf.

But I had seen firsthand how heavy such foresight weighed on those who possessed it. The responsibility of knowledge is, in many ways, even heavier than that of command. No matter how many times I begged my wife to stop looking forward, to stop trying to protect me at the expense of her own life, she could not. If something had happened to me when she was in a position to prevent it, it would have broken her.

But had she ever considered what my life without her would be like?

Rinia had always understood my bitterness towards her gift. When the war between humans and elves finally ended, she did not offer to use her abilities to help me lead. After what happened in the flying castle, though…it was difficult to forgive her for not sharing what she'd foreseen sooner.

"You old hypocrite," I mumbled to myself, standing and beginning to pace around the small square room.

Regret prickled in my chest. Seeing Rinia, who looked even older and more worn than I felt, drove home how much of herself she had sacrificed over the last months. She was following my wife's—her sister's—path, but I wouldn't thank her for that. Still, I had to believe that she had done so with purpose, and had chosen to step back into the light for a purpose as well.

I would be a fool to discount everything she'd said.

I moved to the window and leaned against the sill with a shaky sigh. Below, a family of elves was working in the mushroom garden next to Town Hall. Three little elves ran and skipped through the garden,

pointing out mushrooms to their father. At each one, he would stoop to see if the mushroom was ready, then either pick it or explain to the children why it wasn't ready…

I wondered what he had done before coming to this sanctuary. Had he been a soldier? Or a woodsman? Perhaps he'd been a cook. I was curious what he thought about the artifacts, and even more so about whether or not he *wanted* to be responsible for the decision that would be made in three days' time.

Because, regardless of his own desires, this man would be expected to lend his voice to the decision. I had put that pressure on him.

Had it been an act of wisdom that had led me to do so?

I was afraid that, deep within me, I had made that decision because I was just tired. I didn't want to shoulder this burden alone, not when the future of my entire race was in the balance.

Not when we stood alone between the great powers of the Vritra and Indrath Clans.

WINDSOM

Far below, the sanctuary village swarmed with lessers. A few hundred, by my estimation, all crammed together at the center of the underground town. If I closed my eyes and pushed mana to my ears, I could hear their muddled banter, like a field of mooing aurochs.

It was with some disappointment that I had learned of Virion's recusal in the matter of the artifacts he'd been so eager to take ownership of. From an outside perspective, it seemed like he folded the moment his people discovered the reality of Elenoir's destruction by the World Eater technique.

The lie was never meant to last forever, but simply to buy time for the next stage of Lord Indrath's plan to commence. A hopeless Dicathen was of no use to my lord. I had even offered Virion several suggestions about which of his people here should be the first to be anointed by the new artifacts. He could have begun this process at any point over the last three days, and mages like the Glayders, Earthborns, or even Lance Bairon Wykes would already be parading in front of these people as beacons of hope.

In a way, this made the immediate collapse of his judgment almost personal. All our long conversations—all my advice and guidance—were abandoned in an instant.

It had been Aldir's decision to cast Virion as commander of Dicathen's joint forces, back when the war began in earnest. Aldir saw him as a man worthy of time and training, but this failure was a stark reminder that all lessers had limits, and it appeared Virion was reaching his. Short-lived and even shorter in foresight, lessers had no concept of time's true passage or what was at stake beyond their own lives.

So much time wasted, I thought, irritation clinging to me like road dust after a long journey.

As envoy to Dicathen, too much of my life had been spent tending to the continent, assuring that the lessers' civilization didn't implode before it was fully established. Though I hadn't voiced the thought to my master, I was eager for this war to finally end so that I might seek a higher role in the court.

Of course, depending on what Virion and his people decided, my service to them could be over sooner than I'd imagined.

My body melted into inky blackness, reforming into the shape of a black cat, and I leapt off the ledge I'd been watching from, springing from stone to stone until I reached the path leading toward town.

Perhaps I should have dealt with the seer years ago, I mused, frustrated by Rinia Darcassan's intervention. She alone among the lessers understood Lord Indrath's purpose clearly, although she was blinded by the sacrifice asked of Dicathen as opposed to seeing the *good* they would do by fulfilling their given role.

I reached the outskirts of the congregation before the meeting began. The garbled susurrus of the crowd congealed into individual voices as I grew closer. Each voice expressed an opinion, each opinion contrary to every other, creating an incomprehensible, directionless quagmire. How decisions could be made in such a way was beyond me.

As the lessers became more densely packed, I slipped between their legs and hopped up on a small ledge protruding from the side of a molded-stone building. I immediately regretted my seat of choice when the child below attempted to make a grab for my tail. There was no time to relocate before I sensed a shift in the crowd.

Across the square, the doors of the Town Hall opened and Virion appeared, carrying one of the rod-shaped artifacts Lord Indrath had gifted him. The human Lance walked just behind him, holding a second, its gem blue and handle silver, while a blond dwarf grasped the third, which was forged in gold and set with a red gem, as if it were a venomous serpent.

The crowd's noise quieted in waves as they realized a few at a time that their commander was now present. He simply watched the

milling people, which filled the square and all the nearby alleys, some even leaning out of windows or gathering on the low rooftops. When the entire cavern was silent, he began to speak.

"Dicathians. Thank you for being here today. The matter in front of us is one of dire importance for every soul within this refuge, and it is essential that every voice be heard as we determine how to move forward as a collective." Virion paused, allowing a smattering of conversation to peter out. "I hold in my hand an artifact capable of advancing a mage to or even beyond the white core. This power is being given to us so that we may finally be on even footing with our enemies."

There was some cheering and shouted questions at this. I found the lack of discipline and respect appalling, but Virion only waited for the noise to subside before continuing.

"These artifacts have been crafted by the asuras of Epheotus and gifted to us by Lord Indrath. But, as I'm sure you are all aware by now, it is true that Lord Indrath also issued the order for the asura known as General Aldir to attack the Alacryans in Elenoir, resulting in the elven homeland's destruction."

"Murderers!" shouted a pot-bellied human.

"We won't accept help from those devils!" an elf woman screeched. She was missing an eye, the ghastly hole where it had once been uncovered for all to see. "You're just as bad as them! Traitor!"

"Beyond white core, fools!" hollered a deep voice I couldn't locate. "We could take back our homes, your pride be damned!"

From a rooftop, a young human male cracked his warhammer against the stone. “Why vote? Commander, just let those of us who want to grow strong use the artifacts!”

A dozen voices rang out in a confused muddle of support and condemnation, and the crowd seemed ready to collapse into violence. Before it could progress further, however, the sound of a thunderclap shook the cave. The child that had been accosting me whirled toward its parent, wailing in surprise and fear.

I examined the Lance. Bairon Wykes could have been a firm hand to direct the Dicathians under different circumstances, but he was too closely aligned with Virion.

There were still the rest of the Lances, of course. Varay Aurae, in particular, would have been a potent figurehead. She had shown herself to be entirely loyal to Dicathen, however, and was unlikely to side with us over Virion and the lesser council.

“There is ample time to discuss how we will respond to the asuras, or indeed what the people wish to do with me,” Virion went on, his voice ringing through the cavern. “But today, we are here for a specific purpose, one of dire import that will change the face of this resistance. The choice is this: do we accept the gift of power, which we have been warned could lead us down a path of destruction, or will we refuse, spurning the Indrath Clan and perhaps setting the meager remnants of our nation against the asura themselves?”

Although I would have liked to close my eyes and ears to the circus that followed, I had no choice but to listen intently as, one by one, people began to speak their mind.

Some spoke of survival, others of right and wrong. Many tearfully mourned for the loss of their forest home, while others preached pragmatism. For all their words, it didn't seem to me as if anything was accomplished. Still, I took note of what was said as I gazed around at them all, attentive to both their words and actions.

Eleanor Leywin watched with her mother and guardian bear from a porch to my left, but I didn't let my gaze linger in case the perceptive young human noticed my eyes and connected this form with my normal appearance.

The inventor Gideon was present as well, his arms crossed, a sour look pinching his face. It wasn't often that the asura took note of Dicathen's artificers, but Gideon had an unusual mind. It would have been most unfortunate if the Vritra Clan had gotten their claws on him.

There were few enough other lessers in the sanctuary that had been of any real note.

An hour or more passed as they went back and forth like children playing boulder toss. More than long enough for me to consider the irony of feeling the minutes of my life ticking uselessly away, despite being older than even the most ancient of the elves. Just as I decided they must have forgotten the reason for this conversation, Virion called for silence.

"We will now vote. Friends, I would ask that anyone who is in favor of using these artifacts raise their hand."

Hands all through the village raised, but there were too many people to be sure if it was more or less than half. Next to Virion, a mage raised her hands and sent out a pulse of wind-attribute mana that

spread through the crowd like a ripple in a pond, pulling at my fur as it sped past. She bent to Virion and whispered a number in Virion's ear.

He nodded. "Would anyone opposed to using the relics please raise their hand?"

Hands went up again. I noticed very clearly that Eleanor was among them, as was Gideon. I was surprised to see that Virion hadn't raised his hand either time, and neither had the Lance.

Again, a pulse of wind fluttered through the cavern. The mage leaned into Virion's ear. He did not immediately address the crowd, but when he did, it was with a clear tone of resignation.

"The people have spoken. We will refuse the artifacts, and in doing so refuse Lord Indrath's hand of friendship. Our mages will not be bound to the asura, and we will continue to search for a way to resist the Alacryan occupation of our continent."

"But those of us who *want to* should—"

"Wisdom prevails!"

"—demand a recount—"

"—made enemies of the deities!"

"—should stand trial as a traitor—"

I couldn't help but sigh, my small shoulders rising and falling in disappointment as the lessers boiled over, the crowd immediately turning to screaming and shoving now that the niceties had failed. Guards and some of the stronger mages waded in, breaking apart quarreling groups and shouting for people to disperse and return to their homes. Wives clung to their husbands, parents enfolded shaking children into their arms, friends shared uncertain looks.

So foolish, I thought, hopping down from my perch and weaving through the stomping feet.

For so long they'd regarded us asura as deities. They should have been more grateful for what we'd done, held us in higher regard.

Or, barring that, they should have remembered to be afraid.

Perhaps history is destined to repeat itself after all, I considered, already mentally preparing my report for Lord Indrath.

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TIME TO GO

ALDIR

The familiar shape of Dicathen's flying castle slowly came into view through the dark clouds looming high over the Beast Glades. The castle seemed cold and dead, no longer the vibrant hub of Dicathen's Council.

One of the large bays that allowed flight in and out had been smashed open. I banked in that direction, passing through the thin layer of mana that contained the castle's atmosphere before coming to a stop just outside of the castle itself. The door had been crushed inward, and the floor beyond was littered with corpses.

Landing among them, I kicked the body of an armored man over to reveal the cut-away portion of his cuirass. Runes marked the skin along his spine, which was slightly bluish and clad in a layer of frost.

The castle was quiet. No noise of battle echoed through the halls, no shouted orders or death yells. Distantly, I could detect only three mana signatures within the structure. Everyone else, it seemed, was dead.

Just as well. There would be fewer distractions for what was to come.

A line of corpses guarded the hallway I took as I followed the mana signatures. Their bodies had been crushed into the floor as if by an enormous weight.

In the stairwell leading up to the next floor, several more Alacryans were draped over the steps, their own weapons embedded in each other's bodies, their faces frozen in masks of utter terror.

It was much the same as I continued moving through the castle toward the three mana signatures, my own carefully suppressed. Instead of investigating corpse after corpse, however, I was considering my purpose here. Despite having an entire day to think as I flew over the Beast Glades searching, I was no closer to a decision.

Would I act as a soldier, doing as my lord had commanded me? To do anything else would place the entire Thyestes Clan in danger, but then, I knew that Indrath had sent *me* for exactly that reason.

A test. Of loyalty, not of skill. It would be another member of my clan who received *that* trial.

My steps grew soft as I approached my quarry. Their voices drifted out of the Council chambers, still breathy with the exhilaration of battle.

"—could, but I'm not sure it is worth holding."

"I still say we should destroy the portal controls and just leave."

"Perhaps, but that could not be undone, Aya. We may do more harm to Dicathen's future than to the Alacryan forces."

"Mica has always liked it here! Why don't the Lances set up shop in the castle? If the Scythe returns, we will just kick his ass."

I stepped into the doorway, examining the women. Aside from looking battle-worn and rugged from their time in hiding, they did not appear injured. Varay Aurae's white hair had been cut short, cropped in a military style, only highlighting her severity. She was leaning against the far wall of the chamber, her eyes downcast.

Mica Earthborn seemed entirely unchanged since her time in my service, grinning like a child even while covered in the blood of her enemies. Her needlessly large hammer rested beside her.

The elf, Aya, on the other hand, seemed like a ghost of her past self. Her eyes were dark and sunken, her skin pale, and every muscle in her body seemed to be held taut. Her gaze lingered on a body slumped in a chair in the corner. From the look of the man, he had been tortured severely before his death.

"That won't be necessary," I said before any of them noticed me.

The three Lances jumped up, weapons in hand and magic swirling around them. Color drained from their faces, and their spells writhed and nearly slipped away as panic broke their focus. Despite being Dicathen's most powerful warriors, they were no match for me, and they knew it.

"General Aldir," Varay said, the tip of her ice-sword trembling only slightly as it pointed at my chest. "What are you doing here?"

"The Scythe, Cadell, won't be returning," I said, standing straight, one hand raised non-threateningly in front of me.

"What?" Mica asked, frowning in confusion, her hammer lowering slightly.

I gave her a slight nod. "He was killed in a duel with an unknown Alacryan."

Mica and Varay exchanged a glance, but Aya's eyes never left me.

"How do you know this?" Varay asked. "In fact, how did you know we were here?"

I kept my eye on Aya as I answered. "Alacrya is momentarily distracted, a fact which certainly aided in your assault on this

fortress. Our spies are still attempting to sort out truth from exaggeration. But… that is not why I am here."

Aya's eyes fell to the ground. Her voice was cold as frostbite when she spoke. "Was it you?"

Both Varay and Mica turned in her direction, but before they could intercede, Aya looked up to meet my eye and took a step forward, a gust of wind whipping her dark hair around her face. "Did you destroy my home? I felt it… your power… "

Opening my other two eyes, I held her gaze with the full force of my attention. "I did, Aya Grephin. And now I've been sent here to kill you and your sisters-in-arms as well."

Varay stepped toward the elven Lance, but Aya was already moving. Her hands raised toward me, fingers spread wide, and visible tendrils of wind coalesced around her, knocking the others back. Her mouth opened, unleashing a banshee screech of frustration and fury, a wind lance firing from each tendril.

I didn't move as dozens upon dozens of semi-transparent spears of condensed wind-attribute mana crashed into and around me. The stone wall splintered, cracked, and crashed down, spraying debris across the room. The floor beneath my feet gave way, a foot of solid stone shattering and falling into the space below, but I continued to hover in place.

Eventually, the barrage brought down the ceiling, and stones tumbled past me like rain. When I determined that the Lances were in danger as the room's stability quickly degraded, I decided to move.

Utilizing the Thyestes Clan's technique, Mirage Walk, I empowered my body with mana and moved in a single near-instant burst to Aya's side. My hand wrapped around one of her wrists, and I pushed outward with my mana in a rippling wave that slammed into every cell in her body all at once.

Aya stiffened as the mana feedback overwhelmed her senses, her eyes rolling back in her head. She went limp and began to fall, but I caught her and eased her to the ground.

A stone hammer crashed into my shoulder with enough force to shatter it, the impact shaking the dilapidated floor beneath our feet.

I met Mica's gaze. She gave me a sheepish smile. Then the gravity in the room swelled several times over, and the floor gave way. Furniture and stone all crashed into the void below, along with Aya's unconscious body, falling much faster and harder due to the gravity field.

The two Lances and I, on the other hand, remained flying. I shook my head slightly. "We've been through this before, Mica Earthborn. Have you forgotten that lesson already?"

"Mica isn't going down without a fight, three eyes!" she shouted, sweat beading her brow as she attempted to amplify the force of gravity even further. The three walls still standing began to shake.

"You're going to collapse this entire section of the castle," I pointed out, keeping my voice steady. "This would damage several important substructures while doing nothing to me."

"You sure, asura?" Mica shouted. "Mica thinks dropping the entire castle on you might do *something*."

Though trembling, her flight unsteady, the human Lance was able to shift position so she was next to Mica. “If he was going to kill us, we’d already be dead!” She had to shout to be heard over the groaning of the castle. “Let’s hear what he has to say!”

Mica stared at her fellow Lance for a long moment before releasing her spell. A few more stones fell down into the room below, clattering amongst the rubble, then all was quiet. Suddenly her eyes went wide and began hurriedly scanning the dusty space below. “Aya!”

“She’ll live,” I noted as the dwarf plunged downward in search of her friend.

Varay was inspecting me carefully, her own face a cool mask of impassivity. “Why are you here if not to do as you’ve been commanded? I always had the sense that your loyalty was to your master, not us *lessers*.”

I considered my words as Mica reappeared, Aya draped across her arms.

“If my life were represented by a tapestry, yours would be but a single thread,” I said. “And while your world may change suddenly, and often, like a hades serpent shedding its skin, mine remains as static as that same tapestry. Epheotus is like a place trapped in time, unchanging, unevolving.”

I paused, unsure of the words, or even of my intent. I was a soldier, and had never been good at this. But then, I’d never had reason to doubt the path my lord took us on.

Lord Indrath had sent me to kill these Lances as a test of my loyalty, knowing how the use of the World Eater technique had strained it.

Meanwhile, across Dicathen, a boy of my clan would face a much different kind of trial. If I failed and he succeeded, there was no doubt the World Eater technique would be passed on to him instead. Knowing this should have solidified my purpose, or made it easier to follow through with this task, and yet, I found myself unwilling to submit to these games. It was a kind of stubbornness I had not seen in myself before. No matter how many stories of our history I explored, though, I hadn't been able to convince myself that Lord Indrath's way was the right one.

Mica scoffed, shooting Varay a disbelieving look. "Mica thinks the asura intends to bore us to death."

Varay hissed for the dwarf to be silent, then nodded for me to continue.

"Instead of bringing you death, I have brought opportunity," I said finally, still hovering in the air over the collapsed floor. "Your Commander Virion and Lance Bairon live, guarding over hundreds of refugees."

Varay's eyes narrowed, but before she could speak, Aya's eyes fluttered open, her body stiffening. "W-what did you just say?"

Crossing my arms over my chest, I bowed at the waist. "Hundreds of your kin are there, evacuated from Elenoir only shortly before…"

"Before you destroyed it," she choked out, pushing free of Mica's arms and flying unsteadily until she was just in front of me. "Where? Where are they?"

"I will tell you," I answered, straightening. "But I must also tell you something else. Virion has upset Lord Indrath, stinging his pride. All those in the sanctuary are in danger. They need their Lances."

“Then we will—”

I held up a hand to forestall Varay’s comment. “But know that, in sending you there, I may still be killing you.”

Cold wind cut through the room, buffeting the rising dust. “Will we have a chance to save those people if we go?” Aya’s voice shook loose more stones, sending tremors down to the castle’s foundations.

“You will.”

The elf waited impatiently as I explained how to reach the hidden sanctuary, then turned her back on me, flying down through the collapsed floor and out a doorway with a gust of wind.

Mica only glanced at me before taking off after her companion, leaving Varay and I alone in the ruined conference chamber.

“If Virion and Bairon are still out there, why didn’t we find them sooner?” she asked. “We’ve watched for signs, and left those of our own.”

Flying down into the lower room, I pulled an unbroken chair from the wreckage and set it upright, taking a seat. Though my gaze was to the ground, truly I was seeing the distant mountains and valleys of my home. “The Lances were kept separate on purpose, to build desperation among your people. Lord Indrath thought perhaps he could use you, but recent events have changed his mind.”

Varay only nodded. “Farewell, General Aldir.”

I closed my eye and rested my chin on my knuckles. “We aren’t generals anymore, are we, human?”

I followed the three mana signatures as they left the empty castle and sped over the Beast Glades toward Darv, but eventually, they moved beyond the reach of my senses.

I wondered if I should have told them about Arthur Leywin's unlikely survival in Alacrya, but I wasn't sure what it would mean to them, even if they survived the coming battle. If they didn't, then Lord Indrath's will had still been done, if not in the way he wished. If they did, and Arthur Leywin was somehow able to return to Dicathen…

In no hurry to return to Epheotus, I let my mind wander back to my conversation with Seris. What was it that she had said?

"Indrath, Agrona. Agrona, Indrath. You speak as if they are the only two beings in the world, as if there is no choice but to serve one or the other."

"No," I said, my breath roiling the dust still thick in the air. "Neither of you are worthy of service, in the end."

VIRION ERALITH

"It's time," Lania was saying, her voice both old and young. Her eyes shone like aquamarines in the sunlight, her pale lips trembling as they curved into a gentle smile. *"Virion, it's time to go."*

"No," I begged her. *"Not yet. Please, not—"*

"Virion," she said again, her voice like cartwheels on gravel. *"Virion, you old fool, wake up!"*

I felt myself frown in the dream, the hardness of my bed pressing against me, and realized I was asleep. My eyes blinked open, struggling to focus in the dark room.

"It's time, Virion," a different voice said, older and rougher. "The evacuation has already begun."

“W-what?” I pushed myself up on my elbows, struggling to pull free of the dream. “What do you mean? What evacuation?”

Finally, my vision settled on Rinia. She was wrapped in a blanket, hunkering in the chair in the corner of my chambers. Steam rose from a mug that she held in front of her face. She blew on it, sending a trail of misty gray swirls outward.

“Tell me what’s going on,” I said more firmly, sliding off my bed to stand.

Rinia’s milky eyes trailed past me, her brows furrowing slightly. “I can’t see everything. What is coming, yes…where we must go, that too, but then…”

“There is something coming? What do you mean?” Frustration was beginning to burn away the fog of sleep. “How did you get in here, Rinia? What are you—”

My old friend scowled up at me with such ferocity that I went silent, my mouth slowly closing.

“If you want to save your people—not all of them, no, that’s impossible, but many of them—then please shut up and listen to me.”

We glared at each other, her sightless eyes none-the-less digging into me from across the dark room. My teeth ground together, and for a moment I considered shouting for the guards. But then my dream drifted back into my thoughts, and I sighed. “Go on.”

Rinia sipped from her mug, which made her cough. She drank again, then said, “Albold and the others are ushering people into the tunnels as we speak. Some are resistant, waiting to hear from you. I

have seen a place, deep below us, and can lead us there. If we reach it in time, some of us may yet survive what is coming."

"But *what* is coming, Rinia?"

"Our death, if things go poorly,," she said simply.

My stomach fell. I knew, of course, that denying Lord Indrath's gift would have consequences, but I never thought…

What could the asura lord possibly gain by sending one of his own after us, destroying us? We were no threat to him, likely wouldn't even survive the Alacryans without his assistance. "So why?" I said, voicing this last thought out loud.

"Why does the storm-tossed sea sink a ship?"

Rinia, shaking, pushed herself up out of the chair, letting the blanket fall to the floor. She set her mug on the desk, then straightened, her old joints popping audibly. "And no, before you ask, the artifacts won't help. To use them now would only ensure our immediate destruction."

I knew she didn't want to answer any more questions, but my mind was brimming over with them. "What will happen at this place? How will reaching it save us?"

"Sometimes you just need to be in the right place at the right time," she said with infuriating nonchalance.

The last months and weeks flashed through my mind's eye in an instant. It had been difficult to trust Rinia—no, not to trust her, to *listen* to her—after she failed to stop me from sending Tessia into Elenoir, and failed to forewarn me about the destruction that would follow. But, though she hadn't always told me what I wanted to hear, she had never led me astray, either.

Especially in moments like these.

“I will follow your leadership, Rinia. Let’s save our—”

The door to my chambers flew open, cracking against the wall, and I reached instinctively for my beast will, sinking down into the second phase, the darkness oozing over my skin, every sense coming to life so that I could hear the shouting from across the cavern and smell my own fear lingering in the air.

A flash of lightning lit up the room as Bairon, already armed and armored, stared around the dark room. “Commander? There is…” He trailed off, his sight missing me entirely and focusing on Rinia instead. “What?”

I slipped free of my beast will. “Bairon, we need to organize the people. Everyone has to leave the sanctuary, flee into the tunnels.”

The only sign of Bairon’s surprise was a slight twitch of his eye. He considered me for half a second before snapping to attention. “Of course, Commander!”

He turned to rush away, but Rinia stopped him, gesturing to her trembling legs. “Actually, you had better carry me, or we’re all going to die.”

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LAST STAND

BAIRON WYKES

The ancient elf was weightless in my arms as we rushed between houses toward the edge of the cavern. The streets were still filled with people, some standing idly, confusion etched across their faces, but most were hurrying in the same direction as us.

A cascade of voices rose up and then faded away as we rushed past. Virion addressed each and every one without stopping, directing them toward the deeper tunnels. Those who were most loyal to Virion had hesitated to flee, but at his words, they quickly followed with whatever family or friends they still had.

The tunnel entrance was overwhelmed by a crowd of people. At least half the sanctuary was there, already packing into the narrow hole that led out unto the network of caves and tunnels.

"Remember, stick with the appointed leaders!" the elven refugee, Feyrith Ivsaar, was shouting from atop an earthen platform that had been summoned next to the tunnel mouth. "They'll lead you somewhere safe! We'll send a message to them when the danger has passed!"

Rinia wriggled out of my arms, patting my elbow once her feet were back on the ground. "Thank you for your service to Dicathen, General Wykes. I need you to organize a group of guards and search the village. We must make sure everyone escapes this cavern. Virion and I will take the lead while you cover the rear."

I looked to Virion for confirmation, and he nodded. “I’m relying on you to make sure these people have time to get away from the cavern.”

I snapped a salute. “Of course, Commander.”

Turning on my heel to leave, a strong hand grabbed my arm. Virion met my eye and said, “Don’t linger. I expect you back when this is over, understand?”

I nodded sharply, and Virion let go.

Those on the fringe had noticed Virion and Rinia, and in moments the pair was swallowed up by the frightened crowd, dozens of voices all shouting out at once.

I turned away from them, scanning the scene for any of our guards. A few had gathered above the path on one of the many rocky outcroppings, while others were intermingled within the crowd, helping Albold and Feyrith in their efforts. I took careful note of who had been quick to join with the pair of troublemakers, then started toward the rest of the guards.

“You, head back out into the village and look for any stragglers. Everyone needs to evacuate.” The men cast uncertain glances toward the clogged exit into the tunnels. “Now!” I snapped, making them jump.

“Yes, sir!” they said in unison before rushing off.

I flew upwards, watching them sprint back into the underground town from forty feet in the air. The chaos below reminded me uncomfortably of the castle’s fall. I tried to press the flashes of memory to the back of my mind, but images of lightning ricocheting off gray skin kept intruding into my thoughts.

Nothing I had thrown at the Scythe had hurt him. And now, something even stronger and more dangerous was coming.

My gaze swept across the crowd as the fear grew. I *hated* it, the impulse to flee, the questions that came unbidden to my mind. Should I have stayed with my family, abandoning Virion and all these people to their fates? Should I leave now, to save myself? Did I owe these people my life?

Lightning jumped from my skin and ran across the surface of my armor. It crackled between my fingertips, eager for direction.

I focused on that sensation. That urge to strike. I let its brightness blind me to my own weaker impulses. Like Virion, despite everything he had faced and the losses he had suffered, I would make myself a beacon for everyone to draw strength from.

With an efficiency born of desperation, the refugees under our care continued to funnel out of the cavern. Virion and Rinia had already gone on ahead, leading the main group toward some unknown destination. My soldiers had swept the village twice; the only people who remained now crowded around the tunnel entrance, awaiting their chance to escape.

I was the first to sense the shift in the mana. Just beyond the last building at the edge of town, a tremor ran through the air, and light began to coalesce into a hovering oval. Someone shouted.

I dropped to the ground between the portal and the remainder of the people still trying to flee. The guards were hollering directions, urging them to move faster.

Two figures appeared. The first was clad in the same immaculate uniform he always wore, his inhuman eyes taking in everything in a blink.

The second was younger, fiercer. He was lean and clean-shaven, a head shorter than Windsom, with angry black eyes that reflected no light. Instead of a fancy uniform or armor, he wore loose red training clothes as if he were here for a simple sparring match.

The crushing weight of his intent was a sharp counterpoint to his appearance.

"Asuras!" I shouted, my voice crashing over the stone like a thunderclap. "You are no longer welcome in this place. Leave now, or—" An intense pressure squeezed my chest, cutting the words off.

"Silence, human," Windsom said. There was no hint in his expression or tone that we were or ever had been on the same side of this war, entirely empty of empathy or regret. "I have come with a proclamation from Lord Kezess Indrath of the Indrath Clan of dragons, chief among the asuras of Epheotus.

"Our alliance has failed." These words vibrated through stone and air, seeming to come from every direction at once, even echoing back out at us from the tunnel mouth. Fearful shouts followed. "You have shown yourselves to be lacking in judgment and weak in faith. You are a danger to your own nation, to the future of your own races. For this, Lord Indrath has deemed it necessary to eliminate this sanctuary and all that reside within."

I strode forward, chin raised, a longspear of molded lightning crackling into my hand. "Your lord has no authority here. Go back to your home and leave us to ours. We'll win this war without you."

The younger asura scowled, his nose wrinkling as if he'd just stepped in something foul. It was Windsom who spoke, however. "You know what to do, Taci. Lord Indrath has high expectations of you."

The galaxy-eyed dragon turned and vanished back into the portal, which faded away.

Behind me, the last few refugees were shoving and pushing to get into the tunnel, the mouth of which was clogged with scrambling, screaming, frightened people. The guards encircled them, their weapons turned toward the young asura.

Gathering my power, I thrust forward with my spear, which extended outward in an arc of lightning, but the asura, Taci, flashed to the side several feet, and the bolt blasted a crater in the stone floor.

The world seemed to slow as electricity coursed along my nerves, heightening my reflexes and perception—something I had learned from the Leywin boy before his death. Thin tendrils of lightning arced out from me like extensions of my nervous system, allowing me to sense attacks from any direction, and before they even reached me.

The noise of the explosion was still resounding off the walls—dull and muffled to my sped-up senses—when Taci moved. Even under the effects of Thunderclap Impulse, I could barely follow along. He took a single step, and the ground seemed to pull me toward him. I only just managed to dodge sideways to avoid his scything hand, the tendrils of electricity helping to disburse and redirect the force of his attack, but even as he flashed past, I could see his black eyes tracking me.

The asura's momentum changed mid-strike, his form blurring and leaping inhumanly, too fast for me to react.

Suddenly I was hurtling toward the closest building. My breath left me as I crashed into and through it. Dust and debris blinded me, and I heard the groan of stone shifting, then felt the weight of an entire building crash down on top of me.

Even through the dense rubble, though, I could hear the death screams of the guards.

Thunder exploded outward from me, and the weight pinning and blinding me was blown away. I wrapped myself in a cloak of lightning and flew with all speed toward the tunnel entrance. Stones from the rubble pile I'd just blasted were raining down all throughout the cavern.

The mutilated corpses of my soldiers littered the ground, their blood staining the gray stones red. It looked like an army had charged over them, butchering them where they stood.

Taci stood over the prone form of Lenna Aemaris, head of Virion's guards since we first escaped to the sanctuary. She turned in my direction, coughing up blood, her eyes wide and disbelieving. Then his foot came down, crushing out the last of her life.

Though he could move faster than the eye could follow, Taci took his time as he began walking toward the huddled mass of people just inside the tunnel mouth, each step leaving behind a bloody footprint.

Lightning crackled between my fingers, condensing into a vibrant blue-white orb, then arced through the air. It flew several feet over the asura's head, hovering in the air between him and the people, then flashed. A bolt of lightning crashed into the wall above the

tunnel, and a section of the wall collapsed, heavy stones tumbling down over the tunnel mouth, muffling the screams from within.

At the same time, the orb began to spin, shedding sparks that coalesced into long javelins of lightning and launched themselves at the asura. As he batted each javelin aside, they embedded into the ground all around him.

Lightning jumped from the end of each javelin, sticking up all around him like pilons, and formed chains and manacles that wrapped around Taci's wrists and ankles. My entire body radiated mana as I flew across the cavern and crashed into him.

There was an explosion of bright white-blue energy, followed by a thunderclap that shook the cavern, resounding off walls and buildings to build into a deafening shockwave.

My head spun as I pulled back, readying a lightning spear and again charging my nervous system with electricity, my eyes dilating as they jumped around in search of my opponent, who should have been right in front of me but wasn't.

Too late, I heard the near-silent swish of his clothes cutting air. Even with my enhanced reflexes, I couldn't get my arms up in time, and his blow took me in the chest as he appeared right in front of me, sending me tumbling across the ground. I thrust downward with my spear, impaling it into the stone, which cracked and screeched in protest as I jerked to a sudden halt, my muscles screaming in complaint.

A dull, throbbing ache deep inside me immediately pushed this lesser pain out of my mind. Looking down, I realized the front of my armor was caved in and pressing painfully on my sternum.

Soft steps drew my attention back to Taci, who was watching me curiously as he approached. “I thought Lord Indrath said this was supposed to be a test of my strength…”

I snorted and pulled my spear free from the stone. “Indrath should have waited until you were out of your swaddling clothes before sending you here, boy.”

Taci’s black eyes narrowed, then his body blurred around the edges, and he repeated the single-step maneuver. My spear swung around to intercept him, but he shifted his momentum, taking a near-instant step to the side and around the spear before closing the rest of the way. The point of his elbow came down on my shoulder to the sound of metal shearing and bones breaking.

My vision darkened, then I was looking up at him from the ground, my entire body numb, all of my spells fizzling out as I lost focus.

He held out a hand. There was a rush of mana, and then he was holding a long, blood-red spear. The spear lifted over his head, but instead of thrusting down into me, it kept raising up into the air, taking Taci with it. I blinked. Taci was *below* me, falling toward the cavern ceiling, and I was plummeting after him.

The world seemed to have turned upside down. I caught a flash of Taci’s face as he scanned the cavern thoughtfully before something hit me hard from the side, jarring the broken bones in my shoulder.

The sounds of spells—shattering ice, rushing wind, crashing stones—exploded from nowhere and everywhere at once.

I blinked, trying to see what had hit me. A pixy-ish face looked at me and winked, then we were swerving violently to avoid something—a streak of red—and somewhere stone collapsed on stone.

“Mica?” I said, my thoughts sluggish with pain and exertion.
“Always the show-off, aren’t you? Fighting an asura one on one without waiting for the rest of us.” Mica hummed as we touched down, the impact again jarring my whole body. She set me on my feet, her gaze turning back to the Taci. “How long since the population fled?”
“Not long enough,” I ground out, shifting my arm as I attempted to assess how bad the injury was. “We have to hold him here.”
She studied me for a moment, the air exploding with frozen missiles in the distance behind her. “Well then, you better pull yourself together quick.” She flashed me a jaunty grin, then flew off to support Aya and Varay, who I could see flitting like flies around Taci, their spells cutting colorful lines through the air.
I turned my attention inward, trying to get some sense of what was wrong with me. The asura had only struck me twice and hadn’t even used any spells, but the entire area around my core was tender, swollen, and bruised. My clavicle was broken at least, perhaps more bones, and there was a grating ache that went up my neck and into the base of my skull that suggested my neck was fractured as well.
I stood and pushed mana into the injured sections of my body, supporting the broken and fractured bones. Without an emitter, there was nothing I could do to speed the healing. I would simply have to fight on as I was.
The air above the village had become pure chaos.
Even from where I stood, I could feel the chill of Varay’s spells as she froze the very air, causing heavy flakes of snow to fall down on the ancient buildings. Ice formed over Taci’s arms and legs, and though it

shattered when he launched himself at Varay, it slowed him just enough that she was able to avoid the attack, conjuring a wall of opaque ice between them and hurtling away at full speed.

As soon as he slowed down the ice began forming again, clinging heavily to him. His dark eyes seemed to lose focus for a moment, staring into the distance instead of scanning the sky for the other Lances.

A shiver ran down my spine at his passive, slightly curious expression. His mouth was a straight, dark slash across his face, one brow slightly raised in consideration. It wasn't the look of a man fighting a life and death battle, but closer to that of a young mana beast testing its limits as it played with its prey…

Despite his lack of focus, Taci easily batted aside a series of spells before fixing his attention once again on the battle. Wherever he looked, however, pillars of ice appeared to interrupt his line of sight, and a strong headwind blew in his face to distract him no matter which direction he turned.

Several cyclones carrying chunks of ice and jagged stones were whirling in between all the ice, constantly attempting to pull the asura in and pummel him. As I watched, still focused on preparing my body, one of the cyclones swept over him. Instead of trapping him, however, it seemed to shatter against his defenses, the wind-attribute mana dissipating and the cyclone fading, its contents raining to the cavern floor far below.

In the same instant, though, he bucked backwards. Only a foot or two, but enough to prevent him from launching another attack. Then

gravity shifted again, and he dropped a foot toward the floor, and again a few inches toward the ceiling, keeping him off balance.

Gritting my teeth, I took off into the air, already gathering mana in my hand.

Taci stopped attempting to resist the maelstrom of spells hitting him, his chest rising as he took a deep breath. One hand slowly came up, the fingers curling together. The mana all around him shivered, then he twisted his wrist sharply. There was a booming *crack*, and I felt the mana break.

Mica screamed, and from the corner of my eye, I saw her tumble out of the air like a bird struck by an arrow.

At the same time, Taci kicked off a pillar of ice and vanished. Instinctively, I turned toward Aya just as he appeared at her side. She was surrounded by a barrier of quickly changing gusts of wind, but Taci's spear punched through it without effort.

I released the lightning held in my hand in the form of a flash of blinding light between Aya and Taci.

At the same time, the air around the asura froze solid.

For a moment, I couldn't see what had happened. Then the block of ice shattered, and I watched as Aya slid from the end of the red spear and fell.

With a roar, Mica appeared like a catapult stone to crash against the asura. Her hammer shattered against his upraised arm, reformed, then broke again as he swatted it aside.

A jolt of electrical force leapt from my fingers to her hammer, and when the next blow fell, an explosion of lightning rocked Taci to the

side. Just behind him, an orb of pitch-black nothing—a dark sphere that light couldn't escape—appeared, and he lurched back into it.

But I had to turn away as I aimed for Aya's falling body. There was a low *boom* as I reached my top speed, scooping her out of the air just before she would have crashed into the rubble of one of the many buildings destroyed in the fighting.

She was breathing heavily, her eyes wide, his teeth bared like an animal. "Damned he's strong. That spear…"

I flew behind the cover of a house, hoping against hope that Varay and Mica could hold him for a moment so I could inspect Aya's wound. But as I set her down and began looking her over, she pushed me aside.

"I'm fine, Bairon. That spear did something, interrupted my mana, but I'm not badly hurt," she said, gesturing to a bloody wound in her side.

As she spoke, I took Aya in with fresh eyes. It had been months since I'd seen the other Lances. Aya was gaunt, her eyes dark. Gone was the mana vibrating alluringly in her voice, the pouted lips, the pretense of seductiveness that she used to wear like a suit of armor.

There was no time to wonder what the others had been through since the battle at Etistin and the fall of the castle, but I also knew we all might die here. "Aya, are you sure you're all right?"

She shoved me aside. "There's no time. Let's—"

"We can't fight him toe to toe. Even these delaying tactics will work for only so long. This isn't a fight for him, it's some kind of damned wargame," I pointed out, drawing a glare from Aya at the interruption. "What about your illusions? Perhaps—"

She scoffed, floating off the ground and staring fiercely up toward Taci, her eyes full of hatred, the desperate need for vengeance carved in every hard line of her face. "Maybe—*maybe*—something like that would work once before the asura realized what I was doing, and what difference could it possibly make? No, I'm not playing games with this *deity*."

Wind whipped around her as she bulleted back toward the fight, and all I could do was follow.

The black hole Mica had conjured was gone. Varay had closed in as well, her body encased in gleaming ice-armor, but the two Lances were on the defensive and couldn't break away from Taci's barrage of attacks.

Aya was screaming straight toward him. The air warped, twisting and condensing into curving missiles that fired in rapid succession, pelting the asura's back.

I followed close behind her, sending arcs of lightning into Aya's wind missiles, twisting the lightning into something more subtle as I cast Nerve Fracture. When the lightning-infused bolts landed, the electrical impulses spider-webbed across Taci's skin, vibrating through his mana barrier and into his nervous system to paralyze him.

He barely twitched.

Aya closed on Taci, a dozen transparent blades scything toward him from every direction.

Taci's form seemed almost to stutter and skip around, moving with such instant precision that it was like he was teleporting an inch at a time, only utilizing as much movement and effort as was absolutely

necessary to avoid an attack or let it shatter against an arm or shoulder. With each movement, his red spear lashed out, slashing and thrusting in every direction at once, cutting through the spells he couldn't dodge, breaking apart our spells and then reabsorbing the mana to fuel his own strength.

The others needed to fall back, but they were locked in place.

Scanning the ceiling, I found what I needed. There was a large chunk of iron-rich stone above where the others were fighting. I hurled a bolt of lightning-attribute mana into it, but instead of destroying the stone I infused it with the mana, then manipulated it to spin in a looping arc through the iron.

Taci kicked backwards, sending Mica spinning away, then whirled his spear around him in a circle. As he shifted his hold on it, I *pulled*. The iron became an enormous magnet, ripping the spear out of Taci's unexpecting hands. It flew straight up into the air and hit the ceiling with a clang.

I immediately struck out with so much lightning that the stone melted, fusing the spear to the ceiling.

Varay took the opportunity, falling back, conjuring several barriers of ice as she did.

But Aya kept fighting. The sphere of blades encircling her expanded and condensed, so many moving so fast that Taci could no longer dodge them. Instead, he turned cold black eyes on her, letting the wind blades strike at him from every direction, but they did nothing.

"Do you know the purpose of this trial?" the asura said, looking Aya right in the eye. "To prove that I have the strength to learn the World Eater technique… the same one that destroyed your home."

The battlefield seemed frozen. As if in slow motion, Taci reached out and grabbed the mana swirling in the air, as he had before. But the instant before he broke Aya's spell, she released it. Her body became as the wind, which coiled around Taci and reformed, Aya now right behind him, her blade across his throat.

They moved simultaneously. Her blade flashed to the side as he spun, his hand pointed like the tip of a spear to strike her in the stomach, shattering her mana barrier.

With horrible clarity, I watched as his arm plunged through her stomach and burst out of her lower back. It was dripping with her life's blood, and had a section of what I thought must be her broken spine clutched in a tight fist.

Even from where I flew sixty feet away, I saw the light leave her eyes. As her body fell, so did my stomach.

My eyes tracked her downward motion until she vanished, then snapped back to the battle just as Taci blurred away before smashing Mica into the wall with the back of his bloody hand.

A thick layer of glittering black crystal formed around Mica, but when the asura struck there was a sound like shattering glass, and cracks webbed across the surface. He struck again, and pieces of black crystal flew glittering into the air. On his third strike, the Black Diamond Vault spell broke, his arm sinking in up to the elbow.

When it ripped out an instant later, blood sprayed from between the jagged shards of black crystal.

A solid beam of white-hot lightning warped the air between us with the smell of burning ozone, and Taci rocked to the side.

Varay appeared from the frigid, misty air right beside me, a slight breeze feathering her short hair. Her icy cold hand wrapped around my wrist, and the lightning beam became a crackling ray of cold white energy. She met my eyes, her own full of determination. "Don't save anything for later."

I could have laughed. "Back ten minutes and already giving orders."

Under the combined weight of our mana beam, Taci was being pushed back, a layer of electrically-infused frost building up over his skin. For an instant, I felt a flicker of hope.

There was a flash of red as the spear reappeared in Taci's hand like a shield, splitting the beam in half so that it fired off to either side of him with a crash where it impacted the walls. An avalanche of stone collapsed onto the buildings below, crushing them and burying half the village in the rubble.

I pushed and pushed, concentrating everything I had into that singular attack, Varay's grip getting tighter and colder on my arm as she did the same.

Taci's spear swept through the mana beam, carving it in two.

I lurched sideways as the cavern exploded. An invisible blade of mana split open the roof and carved a deep ravine into the wall behind us with a deafening blast.

The air around me was clouded with red mist. With dawning horror, I slowly turned toward Varay. Her left arm, with which she had pushed me to safety, had been vaporized, leaving only a smoldering red-black gash at her shoulder.

Then Taci was on us. A shield-shaped panel of blue-white lightning appeared in front of me with the crack of thunder, but Taci's red

spear cut effortlessly through it, striking me across the chest. Blood gushed through the rent in my armor, and everything went black for a second before reality lurched back in.

I was falling. Above, Varay had grabbed onto the red spear with an arm of semi-transparent ice. Taci spun the spear, shattering the arm, the long blade slashing through Varay.

My vision dimmed and my eyes lost focus. I blinked, then she was falling.

Varay's head drifted in one direction, the rest of her body in the other.

I tried to stand, but my entire body howled in pain. Looking down, I saw that I had been cut from shoulder to hip, through both armor and mana. It was difficult to tell if I was already dead and my mind just hadn't realized it yet, or if the blood spilling out between the jagged edges of my armor would be what finished me off.

But I was the only one left.

I drew in a trembling breath as my eyes shifted to where each of my companions had fallen. My chest tightened. An intense pressure built up behind my eyes. Growling low in my throat, I rolled onto my side and forced my way onto my feet, only vaguely acknowledging that my guts didn't immediately spill out.

Taci was already moving toward the collapsed tunnel to begin his hunt.

"Asura!" I shouted, my voice hoarse, my vision blurry with welling tears.

He stopped and glanced back at me, his black eyes heavy-lidded and disinterested. A single drop of bright blood was smeared over the

side of his neck where Aya had cut him, even though the wound itself had already healed.

My fists clenched, the stone beneath me quaking, a raging blaze of fury roaring to life inside me. The tears dried as my spirit hardened. I was prepared for death, but knowing that the Lances—the greatest mages of Dicathen—had all died to draw only a single drop of blood from this asura was unbearable.

I knew that ensuring the others escaped was the true goal of this battle, but that didn't mean I had abandoned my pride. I was a Wykes, even if the rest of my family had proven unworthy of the name.

"Thunderlord's Wrath," I uttered. The spell took all my focus, every ounce of my anger and mana.

My blood turned to lightning in my veins. White light began to spill out of the wound across my torso, burning from my eyes and inside my skin. Deviant mana infused every particle of my body.

The asura shifted his spear into a defensive position, his matte black eyes burrowing into me.

My battle cry was a thunderclap as I screamed out my rage. A trail of lightning followed when I flew up into the air, aiming myself like a weapon at Taci. I moved like the lightning I channeled, jagged and unpredictable, and I was on him in an instant. The lightning bursting out of me stabbed at him from every direction, a thousand jolting, burning daggers plunging into every square inch of him.

His spear pierced my side, but lightning ran up the shaft and into his hand. When he ripped the weapon free, a thunderbolt struck him in the chest.

I smiled, lightning-infused blood between my teeth. “Burn, little deity.”

Shockwaves began to burst out of the long gash on my torso, each one slamming into the asura, scouring away his defenses. I wrapped a hand around the back of his neck to ensure he couldn’t flee, and when his spear pierced me again, it only let more of my power flow through.

A cool breeze caressed my cheek, and I closed my eyes. I was ready. I had held out as long as I could. This was a death I could be proud of.

Just before I erupted, a small, familiar voice whispered in my ear. “You’ve done enough, Bairon. It isn’t your time.”

My eyes bolted open, and I searched wildly for the voice, unsure how it could be real, afraid it was my own dying mind playing tricks on me.

As I lost concentration, the light spilling out of me dimmed. Taci’s spear came up, breaking my hold on him, then down again on my already shattered shoulder. I barely noticed when I cratered into the ground.

Taci brushed soot from his red uniform. Even the fabric he wore was unscathed, I noticed with detached bitterness.

I fought to get my elbows underneath me, to push myself back up, set on finishing my spell, doing whatever damage I could to the asura, but the voice came again, breathy and very real in my ear. “Don’t move. No matter what you see. Don’t move.”

Taci landed beside me. He did not grin at his victory, or offer me any meaningless platitudes about our battle. There was a thoughtful frown on his face as he raised the red spear one last time.

I let my body relax, finally setting down the burden I'd carried since the Council's fall. I'd done everything I could. Though I hoped Virion and Rinia would reach their destination in time, there was a kind of peace in submitting to the softly spoken orders of this strangely familiar voice.

The spear fell, plunging into my chest and through my core.

As darkness overtook me and I let my eyes close for the last time, a fleeting thought settled into the cold drowsiness.

I expected death to hurt more.

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RIGHT PLACE, RIGHT TIME

ELDER RINIA

The ancient bedrock trembled beneath my feet. I felt how the atmospheric mana quivered at the release of such enormous power. It wouldn't be long now.

Someone laid a hand on my shoulder. "Do we have enough time?" It was Albold's voice. "Should we set up an ambush somewhere, slow the asura further?"

I scoffed. "Our hope now is in haste and good luck, not by force of arms. Do not be so ready to die a meaningless death, any of you."

Another voice, from farther back in the line. "You could join me on the beast." It was Madam Astera, who Eleanor Leywin had allowed to ride her bond, seeing as though she was missing a leg. It was a kind offer coming from someone who hated my guts.

"I know the way by foot and feel, not by bear. I'll walk." I squeezed Virion's arm as he guided me along. "We need to go faster."

I felt his concerned look, despite not being able to see it, but he did as I asked. I pushed my old body to keep up.

This was the point where paths of potential diverged, and my ability to influence a specific potential future was limited. Our group was sixty, perhaps seventy people: some council members, the adventurers known as the Twin Horns, the artificer Gideon and his assistant, and those among the refugees who had shown the most faith in me.

They would need it.

Smaller groups had broken off to head down dozens of different tunnels, led by the Glayders, Earthborns, or other strong mages. If the Lances fell too quickly, or fought too long, preventing the asura from reaching us at the right time, we would all die. If Taci hunted us down too quickly or spent too much time prowling the tunnels, again, we would all die. The timing was crucial.

My right foot brushed a sharp outcropping of stone. "Take the next branch right and downward," I told Virion, and after another fifty steps he guided me to the right, and the path sloped under my feet.

An explosion from somewhere far behind and above us shook loose dust from the tunnel ceiling. Someone muffled a scream.

At the bottom of the decline, the tunnel curved sharply left. "You're all going to feel a strong disinclination to continue onward. This is a trick of the ancient mages to prevent this place from being discovered. You *must* push past it."

We wound along through another handful of turns before the creeping sensation of unease set in. It was mild at first, just a twinge in the back of our minds that said, "Something is wrong here. Be wary." The sensation increased rapidly as we pressed forward, becoming a near-overwhelming sense of dread.

Those we guided began to whimper and complain, and our pace slowed despite my encouragement and the *thudding* of spells breaking stone in the distance. Even the bear was panting, each breath sharp and desperate.

"Albold, take all the guards to the rear. Keep these people moving forward. Don't let anyone turn around," I said.

“Y-you can’t force us on!” someone choked out. “You’re leading us to our deaths!”

Several sets of footsteps ceased, and I heard people pushing and shoving. Guards moved to intervene, but there was a sharp pulse of intent from right beside me, and everyone grew still.

“You can all sense the danger behind us. It is very real, while this magic works against only your imagination. If Rinia says that salvation lies ahead, then we will press on.”

Virion’s confidence and command settled the riled crowd, at least for a moment. When he turned and began marching again, his body stiff at my side, everyone else followed.

Thrum, the mana responded to the distant battle. *Thrum. Thrum.*

It was almost enough to keep even the most frightened of the refugees moving forward against the magical dread that sought to push us away.

But not entirely.

After only fifty more steps, some were halting again. After a hundred, I heard weeping. After five hundred, the guards in the rear were dragging the weakest forward. After a thousand, the guards lacked the strength, and the first of those too weak to face the fear broke away, sprinting back along the tunnel, their cries echoing throughout the dark depths.

“Let them go,” I demanded, hearing Albold’s light steps start to follow. “Anyone who turns back now is doomed, including you.”

Our pace slowed to a crawl. Each step felt like moving deeper into a tar pit, waiting for the blackness to close over my head and choke the life out of me.

I had known we would have to cross this barrier. I thought I was ready.

I was wrong.

My feet stopped moving. Virion tugged at me, his frown audible. He was saying something, but I couldn't hear through the roaring of my own blood in my ears.

It had all been for naught. I'd pushed my body too far, and now it didn't have the strength to continue on.

The earth seemed to tremble, then go silent. The mana stilled. The asura's battle against the Lances was over. Our last line of defense had fallen. There was no *time*. Not for doubt, not for fear.

A thin arm wrapped through mine, and Virion released my other arm, stepping away. Someone else, shorter and even thinner than the first, replaced him.

Cool, soothing mana flowed through me. Most of my body had become one interconnected ache, so ever-present that I had almost forgotten it was there, but at the mana's touch, this pain faded. My breath came easier. I stood straighter.

From the other side, a golden light was moving through me, warming my core and pushing away the darkness and despair.

"Thank you, Leywins…" I muttered once I was capable of speech. "Now, get moving. We're wasting valuable time."

Alice chuckled to my right, but Ellie only held on more firmly. "We're going to make it. Right place, right time?"

I cleared my throat as it suddenly constricted with an upwell of emotion. "We're nearly there."

The two held my arms and helped me forward, Virion walking just ahead of us. The zone of dread seemed to go on and on, pushing against our bodies and wills with a mounting desperation to break us. Then, like plunging through an icy waterfall, we were free of it, every nerve in my body coming to life as the repelling aura vanished. My mind cleared, immediately calculating the approximate amount of time we'd lost.

Wordlessly, I set the pace, my body refreshed by Alice's healing magic and feeling light as a feather without the ancient mage's wards pulling me down.

A virulent intent entered the tunnels somewhere behind us, moving faster than I could imagine.

We began to run.

The rough stone floor grew smooth, and relieved exclamations from behind me echoed along a finished hall. I knew what they were seeing: gem-studded carvings, telling the story of a place called the Relictombs, made by the ancient mages before their fall.

But there was no time. Not to explain them, not even to spare the breath I needed to run, and so I pushed the others onward.

Virion's light steps halted ahead of us, but I shooed him on. "Go, we must get everyone inside."

The oncoming aura was like a red haze on the mana now, agitating it. Though my blind eyes couldn't see the room, I knew well from my visions. An arched door frame opened into a large hexagonal-shaped space a hundred feet wide. Steep stone benches led like steps down to a dais in the middle, where a rectangular stone frame stood.

“Take me down to the center,” I said, desperately focusing on the carved stone frame. There wasn’t long now. If it didn’t happen soon…

When we reached the dais, I pulled free of them and rested my hand on the stone frame, my fingers tracing intricate carvings.

It was cold. No mana or aether hummed within it.

“What is this?” Madam Astera asked as she was helped down off Ellie’s bond. “You’ve led us into a dead end!”

Others joined her, pleading for there to be more to this place, something else, *anything* that could save them. Someone knocked against the frame as if it were a door, hoping someone might let them through. Most rushed to the back of the chamber, getting as far from the approaching aura as possible.

“I have led you to where you need to be in order to survive,” I said, letting my tiredness and frustration bleed into the words. “If I planned on allowing you all to die, it would have been much easier to simply stay where we were.”

“Move away from the door,” Virion was ordering elsewhere. “Everyone to the back of the room!”

I nodded in his direction. “These people will need capable leaders when this is over. Do as he said, Astera. Survive this.”

A scream scythed through the cold air, and I heard flesh tear and bones break.

A figure so rich with mana that the outline of him glowed in my senses stepped into the archway above. His killing intent was like a murderous fist around my heart, squeezing the life from me.

The world seemed to jerk to a halt, the only sound a half-muffled cry of abject terror, the only movement the slow turning of the figure's head as he scanned the room.

"People of Dicathen, followers of Commander Virion Eralith, I am Taci of the Thyestes Clan." His voice was lilting and arrogant, the words echoing out of him and through the chamber stained with his disgust for us. "For your failure to see the way forward, your inability to understand the necessary evils of this war, Lord Indrath has proclaimed that you all must die to make way for a more sensible future."

Virion stepped forward. *Brave fool*, I thought, though I didn't try to stop him. We needed every last second now.

Mana surged from Virion as he activated his beast will. His voice was a low growl as he said, "False allies and betrayers. The Indraths are no better than the Vritra."

He dashed forward, his movement lightning quick. I heard his sword slide from its sheath and cut the air, watched the radiant outline of Taci move to defend, then the chamber lit up with magic as a dozen other mages hurled whatever spells they could to support Virion.

I held my breath.

The asura moved with the liquid grace of a lifetime of dedication and practice. Against it, Virion's animalistic speed and ferocity were impotent. Taci blocked several rapid strikes and shrugged off a dozen other spells. Virion lunged from side to side, always moving and slashing, a dark whirlwind, but his blows never pierced the asura's mana.

Then Virion lurched to a stop. Several people screamed or shouted. His body slammed against the stone benches with a painful *crunch*.

Boo gave a mighty roar that cracked, becoming a tortured yelp, and a heavy weight crashed down the stairs. Behind me, Ellie shouted out in despair.

The asura flashed across the room, his mana signature melding into the atmosphere for the blink of an eye, and when he reappeared there was the sharp, wet sound of a blade cutting flesh. Then he flashed again, and again, and everywhere he went, a mana signature winked out.

But the portal frame stayed cold and lifeless, empty of magic.

"Stop!" I shouted over the screaming. I stepped forward, yanking myself free of grasping arms that attempted to hold me back. "Taci of the Thyestes Clan, I, Elder Rinia Darcassan of Elenoir, command you to stop!"

The asura stopped, and I had to listen as his blade slid out of a body, which then crumpled to the floor.

"Would you willingly, eagerly let them make a weapon of you?" I asked, taking another step forward. "You would be no more important to your lord than we are. A tool, to be sharpened, used, and replaced as necessary."

He laughed. A simple, disbelieving, cruel sound. "I have been trained since I was a child, spending decades in the aether orb, to be my lord's weapon. It is my purpose, seer."

Throughout the chamber, people were whimpering, crying. Someone was choking on their own blood. *You can't save them all*, I told myself for the hundredth time.

“I’ve *never* understood why we bothered with you lessers at all,” Taci went on, his aura focusing around the room, taking in the terrified, helpless people he was about to murder. “Epheotus doesn’t, has never, needed *anything* from you. So why—*why?*—was one of your own, a boy, a stupid child, trained among us?”

Someone broke and ran for the door. Taci’s spear whistled, and blood splashed against the ground.

“It dishonored Elder Kordri. It dishonored me, and everyone else who had to spar with the brat. I—”

He paused, and I felt the full force of his consideration rest on me. Then he was standing directly in front of me, his intent a bonfire that threatened to consume me.

“You think I'm a fool,” he said, his breath like hot summer wind in my face. “I was warned about you, student of the lost prince. Now, though, I don’t understand why. Whatever stolen aether arts you have, you’ve burned yourself up with them. You are nothing but a leaf on the wind.”

His hand rested against my shoulder, and then pushed.

ELEANOR LEYWIN

Like some horrible nightmare, I watched, paralyzed, as Rinia lifted off her feet and flew backwards until she struck the stone frame. Back in Xyrus city, I’d once seen a boy throw a sack over a rat and then stomp on it. It sounded just like this.

Her body slumped to the ground, motionless. I was screaming. Mom was clutching at me, trying to pull me away, shield me with her body, but I fought to get free, to pull my bow up. It was like I was watching everything happen from above, not in control of myself at all.

Several of the guards were already dead. Boo lay in a heap, unmoving except for the shallow rise and fall of his sides. Durden was bleeding from a wound to his head, though I thought—hoped, maybe—that I could still sense his mana. Jasmine and Angela Rose were shielding Camellia and Emily against the back wall. I couldn't see Helen, wasn't sure if she was okay, but it didn't seem like a good sign that her bow wasn't firing.

The asura's black eyes scanned the room, settled on me, focused on my screams. An arrow formed against my string and flew. He moved an inch, the arrow hissing past his ear. A second jumped from my bow, and this one he caught, the mana breaking and fading away at his touch. The third came faster still, but he wasn't there anymore.

A flash of red, and my bow fell to pieces in my hand, the arrow on its string fizzling to nothing.

I heard my mother's screams over my own as the red spear lifted like a manticore's tail. I wasn't afraid, not really. I'd always known I was going to die fighting, like Dad, like Arthur. I wanted to be strong and brave, just like them. But in this world, the strong and brave people always died fighting.

The asura hesitated. Mom grabbed me, pulling me tight, the destroyed pieces of my bow pinned painfully between us. "Please!" she screamed, her voice ragged and choked with tears.

His frown deepened. "You must be Arthur's sister." His pure black eyes flicked to Mom. "And his mother?" The spear lowered. "It's too bad that Arthur isn't here now. It has been an honor to undertake this task for my lord, but I would have really enjoyed facing your

brother again, to show him how small his potential really is compared to one of the pantheon race."

Slowly, the asura grabbed Mom's arm, pulling her away.

"No! Let me go! Don't *touch* her! Ellie!"

My mother's pleading screams fell on deaf ears as the tip of the red spear rose, slipping into my side beneath my ribs. My knees began to shake as I felt it pushing up through my body, as easy as cutting birthday cake.

Birthday cake? I wondered, watching my pale face reflected in the asura's eyes. *That's a funny thing to think about when dying.* But it made a silly kind of sense, too. I thought about the last birthday party I'd had before the war a lot. When we were all together, even Brother, when the world wasn't ending…

I made sure not to scream. I decided, in the midst of my delusional, swirling thoughts, that I wouldn't die screaming.

The spear slid out of me just as easily as it had gone in. My shaking legs failed and I collapsed to the ground.

Mom was on top of me, tears streaming off her face, splashing all over me. My back was warm and wet, but I could feel a coldness inside, spreading slowly outward. Mom's hands were flashing with a pale light. "It's okay, baby, it's okay. I'm right here. I've got you, and I'm going to take away the pain, sweetheart, Ellie. I'm going to take care of you."

Above her, Taci's spear was poised to strike at the back of her neck, but all her focus was just for me.

No, run Mom. Get away, I wanted to shout, but couldn't seem to get any air into my lungs.

Taci hesitated again. His gaze shifted to where the stone frame stood in the center of the dais, and I realized there was light coming from it. I had to struggle just to turn my head, but inside what had been a blank stone rectangle, now there was a brilliantly glowing purple portal, swirling with ethereal patterns.

Beneath my mother's frantic chanting and the sobs of those waiting their turn to die, a gentle, rhythmic humming was issuing from the portal.

The liquid-purple curtain rippled as if a breeze had blown through it, and two silhouettes appeared.

The features were hidden, but there was something about the shape and stance that was so familiar. Almost like…

A smile crept across my face as my eyes drifted shut. I felt safe for the first time in a very, very long time.

ELDER RINIA

The sound of sobbing came from nearby, working their way through the ringing and buzzing in my aching skull. It was a familiar noise. *Alice*. I sensed for Ellie. She was near, but fading. The asura was standing over them, but his focus was elsewhere…

I followed it to the aetheric glow of a portal, visible even without my sight. But it was a pale thing in comparison to the figure standing within it.

My heart thrummed.

What I sensed was beyond the scope of my understanding, but I knew it wasn't my mind failing me. My body was broken, my life slipping away. This was the moment I had foreseen, where all the

threads ended, but I could never make sense of how we might be saved, only the when and where. But now I knew why.

"Arthur…"

He'd been absent from my visions of the future since his disappearance, his future never very clear to me even as a child. I hadn't fully believed him to be dead, but couldn't scry him, or find any future in which he reappeared. Even though I had seen this moment, it had been like watching it through the bottom of a thick glass bottle: unclear, colored by my own lack of knowledge and understanding.

Now I could see him just as clearly as I could Taci, a radiant nimbus of amethyst light, the warmth of him spilling through the chamber like the noon-time summer sun.

"Regis, help my sister."

A wisp of purple light—a living spark of aether—dove into Ellie's fading mana signature, and life bloomed within her.

Taci stepped back, shifting the burning brand that was his weapon into a defensive position. "Who… Arthur Leywin?" His confusion and uncertainty was palpable, laced within his tone, woven into his stance.

Arthur's aura grew darker, hints of deep, bloody red in the purple. A beam of pure aether in the shape of a sword rippled into existence, warping the fabric of reality.

Lightning-like tendrils of aether swallowed Arthur, and space seemed to bend to his will as he reappeared just behind Taci. Purple light clashed against red as Taci spun the spear behind him, catching the attack.

“I’m glad you’re here,” Taci snarled, his voice grating against my ears.
“You shouldn’t be,” Arthur replied, his voice a cold white flame of anger.
The aether sword winked out of existence then back in the same breath, now thrust up and under the spear. Mana and aether screeched against one another and the sword slashed across the asura’s ribs.
With a growl of pain, Taci stepped back, again disappearing and reappearing, using what could only be the Thyestes Clan’s Mirage Walk technique.
I sensed aether swelling within Arthur, and he burst toward his foe, the aether sword carving an amethyst arc through the air. Taci’s spear again came up to deflect.
The clash sent out a shockwave that rolled me over, nearly toppling me off the dais. My body screamed at me that I was dying, as if I didn’t already know.
Arthur paused, glanced around. Alice had been thrown backwards off her feet. Ellie had been sent tumbling. Screams filled the chamber as many others had been knocked flat by the collision of these two titans.
Taci whirled his spear around in a wide arc, and I felt a wave of cutting mana fly overhead. Some of the screams stopped, cut suddenly short, and several mana signatures were extinguished.
Arthur was back on him in an instant, his purple blade moving faster than should have been possible in the hand of a human, but Taci

matched him strike for strike. And with each clash, the chamber quaked.

They will bring the roof down on us if Arthur doesn't do something.

I tried to shout, but my lungs could no longer make more than a muted whisper. Instead, I reached for the last dregs of my power. It wasn't much. Mana flared within me, and I tried to reform it, shape it into a message, a vision, and send it directly into Arthur's mind, but… there wasn't enough of me left.

For the first time, the possibility of failure, despite everything I had done to reach this point, seemed horribly real. So often the world had asked more of me than I could afford to give, and yet I gave it anyway, and now, at the end of it all, I lacked the strength to see my visions through.

A section of the chamber roof fell.

The aetheric wisp I had sensed earlier emerged from Ellie's prone form, throwing itself under the stones to shield a huddled group of survivors.

The two combatant's forms became a muddle of color and power, white light fusing with purple, aether clashing against mana, their weapons humming against one another. Several times I sensed Arthur take wounds, and felt rifts of mana left behind where the spear struck, but he seemed tireless and inexorable as he pressed the asura.

Taci's spear suddenly smote the ground. The earth shook and the dais cracked. More stones tumbled free from the ceiling, and the chamber was filled with the rush of mana forming into spells to deflect or destroy debris.

Arthur's weapons vanished and he grabbed Taci's spear. The two strained as they wrestled for control of the weapon. Taci lashed out with knees and elbows, mana surging into his strikes, each one creating another shockwave.

Arthur looked in my direction. I *had* to make him understand. Again, I gathered up all my remaining mana and formed the message. The room was full of aether, spilling out of the open portal like a ruptured dam. I reached for it, pleading, begging it to help me.

I felt Arthur's mind connect with mine.

Arthur, use the portal! Take Taci away from here. I stared with wide and urgent eyes, unsure if he could really hear and understand me.

'Asuras can't go into the Relictombs.'

I felt the granite-hard coldness of his mind through our tentative connection. This wasn't the boy I had known. He had sacrificed so much to return to us, leaving something of himself behind wherever he had been.

Just trust me.

Aether flared around Arthur, and he spun the spear up over his head, turning so that he and Taci were back to back, each holding the spear aloft. The two struggled, neither one able to gain leverage over the other, then Arthur blinked away in a flash of aetheric lightning, reappearing in the same spot only facing the other direction.

Taci stumbled forward from the force of his own strength. Arthur's arms wrapped around him from behind, tackling him forward.

Into the portal.

And then… they were gone. The chamber was hauntingly silent, and the air seemed lighter and easier to breathe. I took a shaky breath, feeling a great weight on my chest.

Something shifted at my side, and a warm hand clasped my own, our fingers weaving together. Under the smell of sweat and blood, there was sunshine and maple leaves and sword oil. I wondered how long it had been since Virion's skin saw the sun that the smell of it still clung to him.

I opened my mouth to speak, but nothing came out.

"Don't talk. You're hurt. But… we have—where is…?" His gravelly voice cut off, and I could tell from how he strained that he was gravely injured. "I need an emitter! Alice?"

His voice was fading, and I felt something wet drip onto my skin. The pain suffusing my body began to ease… and then it vanished, leaving me only the warmth of his hand around mine.

A shame. I wanted to tell him…

I was glad he was at my side here at the end.

380
A VOID BEYOND

ARTHUR

'Just trust me.'

Rinia's words echoed in my mind as Taci and I collided with the portal. It bulged out and away from us like the surface of a bubble, fighting back against the asura, refusing to allow him entry.

Anger burned through the fear I should've felt facing an asura. The only thing keeping it in check was the presence of my friends and family. Even within the cloud of raging emotions, I knew Rinia was right. It would be impossible to defeat Taci while keeping everyone around me safe.

The portal's surface warped to wrap around us, rippling dangerously. I could *sense* the aether struggling to maintain its form as we pressed against it, simultaneously attempting to accept me and reject Taci.

It's going to break. I hesitated, my mind racing for another solution. *Regis, we—*

The world *fractured*.

Purple shards of portal-stuff sprayed across an empty-nothing limitless expanse of aetheric twilight, refracting the everywhere-from-nowhere light like shattered mirrors.

A hungry omnipresent *something* devoured each shining shard, disintegrating them back into pure aether, then into nothing at all.

There was a sharp pang of something missing, like I'd lost a limb, though I couldn't make sense of it.

I was drifting, afloat or maybe falling, but where and in what, I wasn't sure.

What had I been doing just now?

I knew I was angry. Or that I *had* been angry. Now I was just… out of place.

No, not hungry, I considered, my derailed train of thought leaping back to the *something* in which I was drifting. *Just there, but what…*

I squinted, peering through the hazy amethyst light at a ghostly shadow below me. Drifting in the twilight purple sea was a rolling landscape of dunes, their shape discernible. Familiar.

Instinctively, my head tilted forward as I tried to fly toward the dunes, but there was no sense of movement, and the familiar-but-not landscape didn't come any closer.

"W-where are we?" a strained voice said from somewhere above and behind me.

Turning without thinking, my body started to spin, bringing the figure of a bald young man into my vision.

My memories collided with my current dazed state of mind like two icebergs crashing together in an open sea.

The elation I had felt at finally finding a portal that was already linked to Dicathen, waiting at the bottom of a ravine under a dune-filled zone, washed over me, as did the fury and terror of activating the portal only to watch a spear plunge through my little sister…

Zone after zone had come and gone as I searched, focusing on Dicathen each time I used the Compass, finding nothing but dead portals that were no longer connected anywhere waiting at the end of each one.

But I knew there had to be at least one Relictombs portal in Dicathen somewhere. I just didn't understand how to even look without a memory map like the ones Sylvia had left for me.

My head splintered in pain as the memories came together in a muddled, half-senseless mess.

Alaric had helped with the preparations. Acquired the portal rune key. Bought or stole a collection of items I wanted in case I couldn't return to Alacrya.

When I learned of the Victoriad, I knew attending could mean exposing my real identity, which would mean going into hiding. There was only one place to go: back to Dicathen. Home. To my family. Finally.

And I had made it. I had made it only seconds too late…

I had fought Taci, heard Rinia's voice in my head…

'*Just trust me,*' her voice sounded again, bringing my spiraling thoughts full circle.

I searched the pink-stained shadow of the dunes, my attention sticking on it, confusion entangling me like a giant spider's web. This was the last zone I'd gone through before arriving in Dicathen. A huge canyon split the ground. The remnants of the zone's guardian, a hydra made of living glass and liquid fire, still lay shattered next to it.

The Relictombs were somehow programmed to prevent asuras from entering, but this aether realm was separate—more, maybe—than the Relictombs themselves, which seemed only contained within the greater expanse.

We must have bounced off the Relictombs and ended up in this between-space.

As I stared down on the dim landscape, a gust of wind kicked up the sand, whipping across the dunes with impossible speed and wiping them away. When the windstorm faded, the zone seemed to…reset. Back exactly to the way I'd found it. I could see the hydra's form writhing just below the canyon's edge, lying in wait for the next ascender to challenge it.

What is—

The cutting pain, the sense of something missing, came back, drawing my attention to a void within myself.

Regis! I shouted mentally, searching for my companion's mind. He was nowhere to be felt.

Our connection had been severed.

I followed this thread back to those moments—a few seconds—I'd stayed in Dicathen. Regis was still there, I had sent him into Ellie to…I didn't know what. Help. Somehow. I saw again her thin frame lying on cold stone, bleeding out, my mother—her hands had been so red—struggling to heal her.

I'd needed to hold back my anger. Losing control risked killing everyone there, including Ellie and Mom. All the rage I'd felt in that moment rushed back into me as the shock wore off.

I wouldn't have to hold back here.

Before I had even fully formed the thought, aether coalesced into a sword in my right hand.

Gnashing my teeth, my entire body going tense, I leaned toward Taci. But I didn't move.

The bewildered frown on Taci's face had slowly morphed into a furious grimace that mirrored my own. "Where are we, Leywin? What did you do!"

Then he was on me, his crimson spear—stained yet redder with the blood of my friends and family—knocking aside my weapon and driving through my shoulder. I grabbed the spear's shaft with my free hand and used it as leverage to kick Taci in the chest, sending him spinning away.

His spear ripped free of the wound, leaving a bloody gash just below my collarbone. Blood drifted out in little globules, and despite the danger Taci posed, I couldn't help but watch them float through the aetheric nothing-space.

The red was quickly infused with purple as particles of aether clung to them. The sharp pain in my shoulder lessened, and I realized aether was flowing *into* the wound from the atmosphere, not out from my core. The wound was healed in an instant.

Drawing on the atmosphere for the first time since appearing here, aether rushed into my core. The atmosphere wasn't just thick with aether—it *was* aether. All of it. Everything. That devouring presence I had sensed was an endless ocean of aether eager to reabsorb the tiny fraction of it that had been shaped into the Relictombs portal.

Taci was watching me warily, his eyes focused on my shoulder where the wound had vanished. "What have you become, Arthur Leywin?"

Letting out a scoff, I called on the relic armor. Waves of obsidian scales coalesced around my body, practically quivering against my skin as it reacted to the ocean of pure aether.

My left hand thrust forward, palm outward, and a cone of blazing violet energy scorched the space between us. Taci flew backwards, hacking at the aether with his spear, but the blast followed him, writhing like a snake as it grew and grew, a living torrent of aether eager to devour him whole.

With no ground to shove off of, he could fly but couldn't use the Mirage Walk technique to reposition. Still, his mobility far outstripped my own, which seemed limited to spinning in place as I very slowly drifted away from where we'd appeared. If I had any hope against him, I needed to figure out how to move.

Dismissing the aether blade—but still concentrating on the coiling stream of aether flooding from my hand—I mentally felt around me. Flying would be optimal, but even if I just had something to stand on…

My feet came to rest against something solid. Caught off guard, I lost focus on the aetheric torrent as I looked down at a small platform of purple-gray, slightly luminous energy. It was perfectly smooth and radiated a gentle warmth.

This is aether…

My head snapped up at a flash of movement in my peripheral vision. The amethyst sword hummed to life in my grip just in time to deflect a sweeping cut aimed at my neck. Taci used his momentum to slam into me, hurtling me off the platform toward the dunes below. I spun out of control, flying wildly through empty space, but was quickly jarred to a stop as my back struck a solid, vibrating surface.

Taci was on top of me, his spear leaping and thrusting so fast it was nothing but a red blur. Each strike was a near-instant burst of

movement, as Mirage Walk sped not only his movement, but his attacks as well.

Getting my feet under me, I matched the asura move for move. We fell into the patterns taught to us long ago by Kordri, but it quickly became clear that Taci's training had gone far beyond my own, his every strike countering mine with brutal efficiency. If not for my asuran physique, he would have outpaced me in moments.

Taci vanished. I let my senses unfocus, searching for the aetheric pathways with the God Step rune, but… there were no paths here.

Something hit me like a battering ram between my shoulder blades, the relic armor only just withstanding the blow, and I was knocked forward. Taci appeared in front of me, and the long, winged blade of his spear plunged through my armor just above my stomach, the black scales bending and shearing apart.

I felt it as the spear impacted off the twice-hardened shell of my aether core. A sickening ripple went through me, every atom of my being recoiling in horror. I jolted painfully when the spear's point wracked against the armor over my back, lacking the force to puncture completely through.

Panic rising like bile in my throat, I turned my senses inward, focusing on my core.

It was intact.

Despite the pain of my wound, the fear drained from me, replaced with a cold fury as I slashed at his throat with the blade of my hand.

The spear disintegrated as Taci moved to catch my arm. I twisted, breaking his hold, then snapped a jab into his chin, letting off an aetheric blast directly into his face. His arm coiled around mine as he

reeled back, using the momentum to pull me up off the ground, spin, and send me flying.

Through the pain haze, I realized where we were; we'd been fighting on the side of some kind of barrier encasing the dune zone. It was a rough, transparent shell that separated the zone from the aetheric expanse. In the half-second I had to consider this, my mind rebelled against the idea. The dunes had seemed endless from within the zone, with no walls or ceiling, and yet…

Taci landed on my back, smashing me into the shell. I felt the aether pushed aside as he raised his spear, heard the creak of his teeth and jaw as he snarled down at me, poised to drive the weapon through my skull.

Aether was rushing into me. My core was brimming with it, the wound in my chest already healed.

I shoved away from the "ground" as hard as I could while conjuring the aether blade in a reverse grip, sweeping it behind me.

The spear glanced off the armor around my neck, and Taci howled in agony.

I spun, the aether blade automatically shifting to a forward grip as I brought it up defensively, but Taci was fifty feet away, one hand pressed against a bloody wound in his side, half his face scorched a dark, sooty gray. His chest was rising and falling rapidly, his breath hissing between gritted teeth, eyes bulging.

I stretched my neck as aether healed the bruise Taci's blow had momentarily caused. "First time you've had to bleed for Lord Indrath's ambitions?"

With an angry shout, Taci reared back and hurled his spear at me. It streaked like red lightning out of the purple sky. I took one shallow step, letting it cut through the air less than an inch from my face.

It struck the zone's shell like a hammer striking a gong, sinking into it. A series of cracks raced out from the impact, and purple motes began to leak out and vanish into the atmosphere.

Instinctively, I took the spear in my hands and jerked it free of the shell. The shaft bowed in my grip as I flexed, intending to break it in two, but it was heavily reinforced with mana. The next second, I was holding nothing. The spear had dematerialized and reappeared in Taci's hand.

A thick stream of aether particles was now leaking out of the hole it had left in the shell at my feet.

Spear in hand, Taci flew farther away, only coming to a stop when there was a hundred feet or more between us. "Whatever half-breed mongrel beast you've made of yourself, Arthur Leywin, know that it is my honor to unmake you," he shouted through the void.

Then he began to transform.

Broad, black horns burst through the skin above his ears, growing out and forward until they crossed over one another in front of his eyes, then melding together into a flat plate that masked the upper half of his face. Two additional pairs of arms pushed out of his sides, ripping off his shirt and stretching inhumanly. His tanned skin hardened and feathered outward into golden scales that shone dully in the defused purple light. The wound just above his hip closed, the skin melting back together as scales grew over it.

Finally, four eyes, two on each side of his head, opened, their brilliantly white irises seeming to stare outward in every direction. "See what a pantheon—what *I*—am truly capable of, lesser."

Held in four hands, the red spear swept from the side as air hissed like pistons from between the scales that lined his arms. I felt the distortion in the aether as the attack was projected, and dark aetheric sparks flew from the zone's shell.

Activating Burst Step, I dodged just under the force attack. Behind me, there was a series of sharp, sudden *crack*s, and the gash in the shell began to cave inward, the barrier itself shattering like an eggshell.

A small aether platform appeared beneath my foot, and I charged my body with aether before pushing off it with Burst Step again, aiming for Taci. But he moved just as fast. Deflecting the strike at his heart with one hand, the asura grabbed my wrist with another and caught the full force of my momentum with his knee into my stomach.

My armor flexed, and the ribs beneath it cracked. I started flying backwards, but Taci still had my wrist. He jerked me to a halt, rearing back with his spear.

Using him as an anchor, I spun around and planted my feet against his chest, then pushed outward, again activating Burst Step.

His grip broke, but my leg screamed in pain at the thigh as his spear punched through my armor and cracked my femur. At the end of Burst Step, I was left floating in the void, spinning around and shedding a thick trail of blood from my shredded leg.

It hurt like hell, but aether was already flooding to the wound, pulling the flesh back together, the armor sealing over it just as quickly. As I spun, I caught sight of Taci struggling to regain control of his flight, as he'd been catapulted away from me by the force of Burst Step.

Then my rotation brought the dune zone back into my eyeline.

Aether was spilling out of a thousand cracks across the surface of its shell, a significant part of which had collapsed. The dunes within were dissolving, solid matter breaking apart into aether particles before being blasted out into the void.

My skin was suddenly damp with a cold sweat as I watched the violet plumes be reabsorbed into the atmosphere. I sucked in a surprised, delighted breath, my heart beating like a drum at the realization.

Sylvie's stone…

I nearly reached for it before the reality of my situation came crashing down on me—an instant before Taci himself did the same.

Our limbs intertwined as we hurtled like a meteor toward the collapsing zone below, four hands struggling to grapple me while the other two slammed the spear into my ribs. The wide-tipped blade slid over black scales with a metallic shriek.

I summoned the aether blade into one of my pinned wrists and twisted.

The violently purple light swept across one of Taci's wrists. The fine golden scales shifted, changing angles to deflect the blow; my strike lacked the force to pierce through.

The asura scoffed and pulled me in close, the spear wrapped around my back to pin me to him, my arms trapped between us.

Taci's head pulled back, then the horn-plate over his eyes slammed into the bridge of my nose with a *crunch*. Stars exploded in my vision, then winked into black-purple striations of pain as Taci headbutted me again. I felt more than saw him pull back for a third blow, but something collided with us from the side, sending both of us spinning away from each other.

Before I could make sense of what was happening, I crashed into the side of a dune, the coarse golden sands swallowing me.

All around me, I could feel the matter breaking down, whatever magic the djinn used to bind and shape reality failing.

Still reeling from Taci's last strike, it took real effort to push outward with a nova of aether, destroying the dune I had sunk into. I found Taci waiting for me, floating at the border where the still-collapsing zone met the void.

The once endless sand sea now seemed little more than an island in the purple void. The shell was visible from inside the zone now, the sky no longer vibrant blue by a dusky blue-purple with bright cracks running through it. The canyon containing the hydra and exit portal had already dissolved, leaving only this patch of dunes and the frame of the zone's entrance portal, which stood in a valley at the very center.

Damn it, I thought, feeling myself grow pale.

That portal seemed like the only way out of this place. And the zone was rapidly collapsing around it. I wasn't sure what would happen when the entire zone was gone, but I knew it wouldn't be good.

Small platforms appeared at will as I stepped up into the air toward Taci.

There wasn't much time, but I couldn't activate the portal and risk him coming through it with me.

"You must have really hated me back then to bring us to this point," I said, buying myself a second to think.

Taci scoffed, a sound like stones shattering. "You have nothing to do with my current mission. Although this has been an interesting encounter, and killing you will bring a certain redemption for the insult of being forced to train alongside you as a child, you have not stopped me from doing as my lord commanded."

"Haven't I?" I quirked a brow at him, smiling wryly. "You don't know where you are, or how to leave. Kill me or not, my family and friends are safe from you. You're trapped here, Taci. Forever."

Taci's mouth bent down into a deep frown. "That's a lie. You're just trying to save yourself, because you know you can't defeat me."

I snorted derisively. "I'll admit, I really bought into the asuras' mystique, still thinking of you as gods. But the truth is, you're just a frightened child, and Lord Indrath is a short-sighted coward."

Taci's spear flashed, and I Burst Stepped to the top of a neighboring dune. The hill I'd left behind burst in a shower of sand, cut completely in two. The spear flashed again, and I dodged, then again and again, each strike carving away at what little was left of the zone.

I activated God Step.

Inside the zone, my senses lit up as all the amethyst pathways connecting every point to every other burned bright to my senses. But they were unstable, collapsing alongside the zone, the points shifting and fading as I held them in my mind.

I stepped into them anyway.
And appeared right in front of Taci.
His inhuman eyes widened in surprise, but he managed to bring his spear up to defend as a blade appeared in my hand. I swung toward him, baiting him to move his spear to catch the blow, but let the blade dissolve at the last moment, using the force of my swing to strike him in the chest.
The spear came up and around, but God Step took me behind him. The golden scales shifted again, seeming to follow me, his four eyes offering him a clear line of sight in every direction.
My knee drove into his lower back, my elbow coming down on the base of his neck, and I God Stepped again, appearing just behind the arc of his spear. Aether rushed into my fist, releasing in a burst as I struck him just below the ribs, the force of it pushing me away.
But I appeared again at Taci's side, grabbing two of his arms as I drove my elbow up into his chin and pushed off the back of his knee with one foot. Using the momentum of my own perpetual fall along with the subtle shifts my strikes and kicks created, I spun through the air, conjuring an aether blade and swinging it up under his arms.
Two fists hit me at the same time, sending me tumbling out of the zone's limited atmosphere and into the aetheric space that surrounded it.
A vertical wall formed to catch me, and I slammed into it with enough force to crack it.
I jerked around, looking for Taci. He was staring at his right side, where all three of his arms drifted beside him, connected to his body

only by the streams of blood spilling out of the severed joints and limbs.

But past him, I saw what was left of the zone. The portal frame stood at the center of an island only thirty feet across, golden sand spilling from the broken edges and transforming into purple aether particles.

Pushing against the cracked platform, I Burst Stepped again, aiming for the island, my entire mind bent on reaching it before it collapsed completely. The djinn projection's words returned to me, and the aether reacted to my thought, seeming to wrap itself around me, lifting me, pushing me up and then speeding me toward my goal.

Strong hands grabbed my ankle, and I jerked to a near halt. Looking over my shoulder, I realized I was towing Taci behind me, two of his remaining hands holding onto me while the third jabbed with the spear. It glanced off my hip, then again off my back, my armor flaring with aether as it absorbed the impacts and turned the blade aside.

I slashed at his wrists, and he flailed backwards to avoid losing any more limbs. Turning back toward the portal, I rushed forward again, flying through the aether like I had wings.

The island shrank before my eyes. Fifteen feet wide, ten feet. Aether rushed into my storage rune, the Compass appearing in my hand. Eight feet. Infusing the Compass with both aether and will, I twisted it into two. Five feet of land remained beneath the portal frame, which was growing distorted around the edges, the aether struggling to hold its form.

Focusing on the Compass and the chamber where I'd found Ellie and Mom, I slowed despite every impulse to move faster, faster. Purple

light began to glow within the sandstone frame, sharpening into a view through the portal.

I saw Virion kneeling beside Rinia, tears on his face. Mother was casting spells over my sister, her eyes dry, her face determined. My heart skipped a beat as I took in the redness of Ellie's cheeks, the rising and falling of her chest. She was alive.

And sitting directly in front of the portal was Regis, concern etched into his lupine features, the fire of his mane waving in agitation.

There was only a foot of ground left on either side of the portal as I hurtled toward it.

A streak of red pierced the portal frame. Sandstone exploded outward, and the purple-tinted window rippled, faded, and popped with a sound like boiling tar. I landed in the wreckage an instant later. Around me, the last of the island dissolved, then the remains of the portal frame, and finally the last few shards of hard aether shell that had contained the zone.

We were stranded in the void, nothing but the two of us as far as I could see.

"You're staying here with me, lesser," Taci said, his three remaining hands holding the severed stumps across his body.

As I watched, the horns receded back into Taci's head, the rest of his body reverting to his original shape an instant later. He looked pale and weak as he listed to the side, missing an arm, the bloody hole in his shoulder shining with mana to bind the wound. And still, somehow, he maintained his frustrating arrogance.

His lip curled up into a sneer, his eyes searching, digging into my own. “Shall we be two immortals, battling for eternity in this outer realm?”

I shook my head, willing the aether to move me up to his level so I could look him in the eye. “There is no mana here, is there? And you’ve expended all yours maintaining that form. I don’t have to fight you forever, Taci. In fact, I don’t have to do anything at all.” I looked him up and down pointedly. “With no way to replenish your mana, your body will consume itself. You’re already dead, and you know it.”

The facade of his overbearing confidence cracked, and for an instant he was just a boy—a terrified kid who wasn’t ready to die.

Then the spear appeared in a scarlet shimmer, and he pointed it at my core. “Then I won’t hold anything back.”

A large aether platform formed underneath us. I settled my feet on it. Seeing my intention, Taci did the same, his spear held down and out to his left. I conjured a blade into my right hand and set my feet.

“For Lord Indrath, may he reign forever under the golden sun,” Taci said proudly.

“Not if I can help it.”

Aether flooded to every point in my body, preparing it for Burst Step. Taci’s eyes narrowed. Then I was moving.

Taci hadn’t flashed forward to meet me. Instead, he settled back, his eyes tracking me even in the midst of Burst Step, his spear moving to catch me.

I let go of my aether blade and activated God Step. There were no paths, and no time to sense for them even if there had been, but the

space around me warped, pulling me into and through the distortion, and I appeared behind Taci, aetheric lightning wreathing my limbs.

Infusing the blade of my hand with aether, I spun around and struck Taci at the base of his neck, just where it met his shoulder. There was a loud *crack* as his body folded inward.

The aether blade, which I had released while still moving forward, flew past Taci. I caught it in my free hand and plunged it between his shoulder blades. His body was turning, the spear spinning around to thrust backwards, but it slipped from his fingers as he instead stumbled down to a knee, his jet-black eyes staring up at me in despair.

"You want to know what I've become?" I asked, driving my blade through his neck. "Godkiller should be appropriate."

Taci coughed, spraying blood over the platform, then collapsed and went still.

I dismissed my armor and then the platform, releasing Taci's body to drift in the void. I watched it float for a few seconds until Taci's face turned in my direction and I met his wide, dead eyes, frozen in this last moment of surprise.

Then I turned away, refusing to take joy in his death. For all Taci had done, he was still just a tool for Kezess.

The crimson spear, its winged blade outlined in a shimmering haze as the aether in my blood was reabsorbed into the atmosphere, floated nearby. I plucked it out of the void and sent it into my dimension rune, knowing a proper inspection would have to wait.

After that, I spared Taci and his weapon no further thought, turning away from his body to examine the endless void around me.

Immediately, I noticed a deviation in the atmosphere's coloration just where the exit portal had been, like a stain on the dark sky. The aether there fluctuated, rippling like water.

I rushed to it, reaching out and just letting the tips of my fingers brush the surface. A tingling sensation like static electricity ran up my arm and made my teeth itch.

Something was forcing it open, holding it there for me. I pushed my palm against the distortion, but it resisted. There was a connection back to Dicathen, I could feel it, but the portal itself was gone. This was more like… a scar.

'*—thur. You… shit, you better not be dead or I'll kill you myself.*'

A tired grin spread across my face as I heard the sound of Regis's voice in my head, echoing along the scar.

Regis. You kept the portal open. How?

I practically heard him scoff. '*Yeah, I'm amazing, details don't really matter right now though, because*'—his mental voice was strained, like he was holding up a great weight—'*I can't keep this here much longer. You need—*'

Regis's thoughts fizzled out, and I felt the distortion waver as it faded perceptibly before my eyes.

Almost without meaning to, I conjured Sylvie's iridescent egg from my dimension rune. It was warm to the touch, and practically vibrated in the presence of so much aether. There was more than enough here to bring her back, I knew it. But—

A spike of panic surged through me. Not my own, but Regis's. He couldn't hold the portal scar in place any longer.

I squeezed the egg. "I'll come back, I promise."

The egg went back into my rune as I faced the scar, reaching for it with both hands, pressing on it with all my mental and physical strength, willing Regis to hear me.

Seconds past. I pushed harder, feeling the fabric of reality quake under my hands. Golden light suffused me as Aroa's Requiem activated, the golden motes flowing down my arms and into the scar.

Regis's thoughts came to me clearly as the dying connection suddenly strengthened.

There were no words, but a mental projection of what he was seeing: a dozen mages working to pull others from rubble, dozens more only staring at Regis, mouths open and tears streaming down their faces.

I focused on Ellie and Mom. I saw the space from me to them, pictured the web of interconnected aetheric pathways linking each point between us.

I activated God Step.

Walls of amethyst mist and violet lightning sped past. My core lurched as reality warped around me.

Then my feet touched solid ground.

Slowly, like waking from a long, deep dream, I opened my eyes.

The portal chamber had largely collapsed. Dust was heavy in the air, tinged with the copper smell of spilled blood.

A warm presence drifted into my back and settled near my core. *'Welcome back. You can take things from here, yeah?'*

My sister was staring up at me from the edge of the dais supporting the portal frame. Her blood and dust stained face twitched from one emotion to another, confusion pushing away lingering pain and a distraught sadness. Under it all, though, there was a hopeful glimmer.

"B-brother? Is that really you?"

I felt my expression soften and my body relax. "Hey, El. It's been a while."

Tears burst from her eyes as she jumped up and slammed into me, wrapping me into a desperate hug.

I hugged Ellie back, squeezing her tightly and picking her off her feet. When I set her down, she looked up at me, her cheeks streaked with tear trails. She had grown so much. There was a depth and maturity to her almond-shaped brown eyes I didn't remember from before, and she was lean and athletic, like my father in his youth.

She frowned slightly and plucked at a strand of my pale hair.

Then she punched me in the arm as hard as she could. "I thought you were dead!"

My smile faltered, and I pulled her back into a hug, one hand patting the back of her head. I looked over her to where my mom had half stood. She was pale and shaking, her eyes wide, mouth hanging open. She seemed thin and weak, like she'd shriveled away in the months since I'd seen her. But she was still my beautiful mother.

I smiled at her the way Dad used to. "Hi Mom. I'm back."

As if the words had stolen the last of her strength, she fell to her knees, her hands going to her face as she sobbed into them.

Dozens of other people stood or sat around us, all dusty and covered in blood. But my eyes settled on Virion, who gave me a faint nod before looking down to the person in his arms.

Elder Rinia, her body stiff and obviously devoid of life. She had exhausted the last of her lifeforce to bring these people here, where I could protect them.

My gaze fell back to Ellie, shaking in my arms.

"I'm back."

EPILOGUE

A DRY COUGH wracked my body, and I jerked awake to *pain*. A thick cloud of dust obscured everything but the blood-stained stone floor I had expected to be my funeral bed.

My last thought before falling unconscious floated back into my mind. *This* was how I expected death to feel. Every part of me screamed in anguish, the pain of each wound crowding against the rest, one overriding another in my mind until it felt as if my entire body had been cut to pieces by—

The asura!

Despite a strong desire to never move again, I turned my head, jostling my broken bones and creating a fresh chorus of agonies.

I couldn't see anything through the heavy blanket of dust. But neither could I sense the asura's unbearable presence.

Taking a deep, steadying breath, I rolled onto my side and *heaved*, pushing myself up to my feet. Rocks and debris clattered off me, and the gash in my chest pulled painfully, partially sealed by dust clotting in the wound.

My legs wobbled, the tattered scraps of my armor clanging together like empty tin cans. I tried to push mana out into my body to give myself strength, but was met only with a dull, squeezing pain from my core, which was all but empty.

The backlash made my stomach turn and bile rise in the back of my throat.

Flashes of the battle started coming back to me through the waves of nausea and pain, and my breath seized in my lungs.

Varay, Mica, Aya…

They were all—

I spun around as stone clattered from the wall or ceiling somewhere in the distance. My senses were dulled, my thoughts crawling along like slugs in my skull, and there was a low roar in my ears like I was underwater. Only my sense of smell seemed to be functioning properly; the cavern stank of brimstone and scorched soil.

Dim, murky light cut through the obscuring cloud, a few quick flashes, and I sensed mana moving.

My mouth opened of its own accord, but I stopped myself from shouting. I didn't know who or what was out there. It could be the asura, or survivors returned from the tunnels—or Alacryans, alerted by the disturbance our battle had no doubt caused in the desert above. And I was in no fit shape to defend myself if they turned out to be hostile.

The image of blood gushing out of shattered black crystals overlayed the last memories of my own "death," and I felt a brief glimmer of hope, but just as quickly tamped it down.

I shouldn't have survived that battle, and I couldn't find it in myself to harbor even the smallest hope that any of the others had as well. I'd seen what Taci did to Aya and Varay, and despite the voice that had sounded in my head in those last moments of consciousness, I knew that not even a Lance could survive those wounds.

Still, I couldn't simply ignore the presence of another here, and began limping in the direction of the light, moving as quietly as my battered body and ruined armor would allow.

The cavern floor was in ruins. The rubble of lightning-blasted and cold-shattered rock made footing treacherous, and I had to navigate around several deep gouges scored in the earth by Taci's strikes. A partially intact wall from one of the many demolished buildings had been flung several dozen feet and was now resting at an angle against a huge boulder dislodged from the ceiling.

Carefully, I crept up the side of this wall, then from the bolder to a higher shelf of rock that curved around toward where I'd seen the light. The dust thinned as I moved toward the far edge of the cavern and I squinted through it for any sign of who or what had used mana. It was difficult to believe what I saw.

"M-Mica?" The words clawed reluctantly out of my throat, the effort of speaking setting fire to my many other wounds.

The dwarven Lance glanced up at me from where she kneeled beside a second figure. The right side of her face was stained with tear streaks through caked-on dirt. Dozens of long, straight slash marks crisscrossed over the left side of her face, and a black, bloody hole was all that remained of her left eye. Her entire left side was soaked red-brown with dried blood and some kind of wet mud that she had compacted over her ribs.

There was blood dripping from her palms where she'd dug her fingernails into them, and her normally playful gaze met mine with a hollow emptiness that made me question if she was truly alive or just some dark aspect of my own subconscious.

When she turned her unsteady gaze back on the second figure, my eyes reluctantly followed.

Aya's face was pale, her dark eyes staring sightlessly up to the cavern ceiling high above. Her stomach was a gory ruin where Taci had dealt her fatal blow.

"I…" I had to stop and clear my throat, then went on. "I thought I heard her, just before the end. She… she said…"

But I had to stop again, unable to speak around the lump in my throat.

Mica's shoulders sagged, but she didn't reply.

Sliding awkwardly, painfully, down the ledge, I moved to Aya's other side and gingerly sat.

Once, it would have been impossible to imagine myself on the verge of tears over the death of another soldier—especially another one of the Lances. It was with little guilt that I remembered my callousness after Lance Alea's unexpected death. She deserved better, and so did Aya. There was no shame in shedding tears for a friend taken far too early.

The Six Lances had become only two, and—I glanced at Mica—there wasn't much left even of us. That, too, was something to mourn. We should have been Dicathen's greatest defenders, and yet, this is what had become of us.

The noise of a boot scuffing against hard stone made me jump up. My legs immediately gave way, and I stumbled painfully to one knee, grunting through gritted teeth. Mica wobbled as she stood, but kept her feet, and even managed to conjure a small stone hammer as her remaining eye glared into the darkness.

"Announce yourself!" she snapped, her voice raw.

A lopsided silhouette limped toward us, veiled behind the dust, one hand pressed against the side of its neck. It looked like a ghost.
The ghost of…
Varay coalesced before our very eyes, as if she'd just stepped back out from the land of the dead.
Her left arm was missing, cut away at the shoulder, the wound frosted over. A patch of crimson ice also clung to her neck beneath her hand, but blood was running freely from several cracks.
Her eyes were dull, jumping between Mica and me in a bleary, unfocused way. She hurried toward us, her right leg dragging slightly with each step, but when she reached the edge of the rocky shelf, she missed her footing and sprawled down the side face first with a muted groan.
Mica rushed stiffly to her, rolling her over and dragging her up into Mica's lap.
The ice around her neck had shattered and melted away, revealing a grisly cut that opened her neck almost to the throat. Blood poured out like a fountain, drenching Mica.
"Shit!"
Mica scrambled to scoop up a fistful of loose dirt. She focused on it, closing her eyes, her face scrunching up with effort, and I watched it soften and boil into a thick muck, which she hurriedly spread all over the wound. When this was done, there was another flash of mana, and the claylike soil hardened, stopping the bleeding.
I settled back, staring at Varay.
I had *seen* her die, seen Taci strike her head from her shoulders. "An illusion," I muttered, turning to Aya's body. Her wound was certainly

no illusion, though. "She…she said the illusions wouldn't fool an asura more than once…and used the last moments of her life to save us. Layering illusions of our deaths over our real bodies."

I was stunned by her final show of strength, and her words suddenly made sense.

"You've done enough, Bairon. It isn't your time."

She was using the last of her strength, sacrificing herself to save the rest of us, even stopping me from burning myself out with Thunderlord's Wrath.

"Don't move. No matter what you see. Don't move."

I had been lying on the ground at Taci's feet, his spear poised above me.

I probed at a deep wound in my right shoulder, then my fingers trailed across to my sternum. Though aching and bruised, there was no wound there. My core was intact.

A disbelieving snort burst out of me, which drew a tired, vaguely irritated look from Mica. "What?"

Varay's eyelids dragged slowly open at the sound of Mica's voice. They meandered sluggishly past me until they came to rest on Aya. Her lips parted, her throat bobbing as she attempted to speak, but nothing came out. She only sighed and sank even deeper into Mica's blood-stained lap.

Mica petted Varay's hair, but her gaze was drawn back to Aya's body. "I felt the mana rush from her core. I thought…I thought she'd died instantly, but—" A choked sob cut Mica off, and she gnashed her teeth in frustration.

Varay shifted and tried again to speak. “She… emptied her… core… on purpose.” Her voice was thin and weak, scraping out of her. “To… make the… illusion… more realistic.”

“She needed the asura to believe what he saw and felt,” I added, regarding each of our wounds, considering how close to the edge of our power we’d been pushed. Our mana signatures must have faded to almost nothing in those final moments. “It was the only way he wouldn’t see through it.”

“But was it enough?” Mica asked, her voice scraping and raw. “For the people down in the tunnels?”

“Those lives are out of our hands now…” I answered. We lacked the strength even to walk, much less to chase after the asura. “Aya’s life, though. We can remember and mourn our friend. While we wait for whatever end to come.”

Mica broke into cracked, half-choked sobs. Varay forced trembling lids to stay open, letting fresh tears flow down her cheeks, but never looking away from our fallen teammate.

Turning, I reached shaking fingers out to Aya and gently closed her eyes. “I’m sorry,” I said, my voice a hoarse rasp. Normally, Varay would have been the one to handle things like this, but I knew what I wanted to say. “And thank you, Lance Aya Grephin of Elenoir. Your long battle is at an end, but those who you leave behind won’t stop fighting until it is our time to join you. Rest now.”

AFTERWORD

Hello! TurtleMe here, author of this little novel that you've just finished reading. I hope you've enjoyed the story and you're looking forward to the next installment of Arthur's journey! While waiting, please consider taking the time to leave an honest review of this novel. **Ratings and reviews are tremendously important** and since this is what I live off of, I would greatly appreciate your thoughts on this book so others can make sure that this is the book they want to read! Whether you loved it or hated it, I hope you can spare the time to write your two cents.

Kindest regards, TurtleMe

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